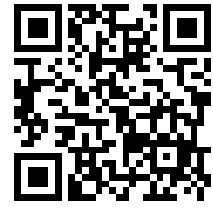
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STUDIA PATRISTICA

VOL. XLI

Papers presented at the Fourteenth International Conference
on Patristic Studies held
in Oxford 2003

Orientalia
Clement, Origen, Athanasius
The Cappadocians
Chrysostom

Edited by
F. YOUNG, M. EDWARDS and P. PARVIS

Index Auctorum and Table of Contents of Vols. XXXIX-XLIII in Vol. XLIII



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LEUVEN - PARIS - DUDLEY, MA
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VOL. XLI

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Abbreviations

AA.SS	see ASS.
AAWG.PH	Abhandlungen der Akademie der Wissenschaften in Göttingen Philologische-historische Klasse, Göttingen.
AB	Analecta Bollandiana, Brussels.
AC	Antike und Christentum, ed. F.J. Dölger, Münster.
ACL	Antiquité classique, Louvain.
ACO	Acta conciliorum oecumenicorum, ed. E. Schwartz, Berlin.
ACW	Ancient Christian Writers, ed. J. Quasten and J.C. Plumpe, Westminster (Md.)/London.
AHDLMA	Archives d'histoire doctrinale et littéraire du moyen âge, Paris.
AJAH	American Journal of Ancient History, Cambridge, Mass.
AJP	American Journal of Philology, Baltimore.
AKK	Archiv für katholisches Kirchenrecht, Mainz.
AKPAW	Abhandlungen der königlichen Preußischen Akademie der Wissenschaften, Berlin.
ALMA	Archivum Latinitatis Medii Aevi (Bulletin du Cange), Paris/Brussels.
ALW	Archiv für Liturgiewissenschaft, Regensburg.
AnalBoll	Analecta Bollandiana, Brussels.
ANCL	Ante-Nicene Christian Library, Edinburgh.
ANF	Ante-Nicene Fathers, Buffalo/New York.
ANRW	Aufstieg und Niedergang der römischen Welt, ed H. Temporini *et al.*, Berlin.
AnSt	Anatolian Studies, London.
AnThA	Année théologique augustinienne, Paris.
APOT	Apocrypha and Pseudepigrapha of the Old Testament in English, ed. R.E. Charles, Oxford.
AR	Archivum Romanicum, Florence.
ARW	Archiv für Religionswissenschaft, Berlin/Leipzig.
ASS	Acta Sanctorum, ed. the Bollandists, Brussels.
AThANT	Abhandlungen zur Theologie des Alten und Neuen Testaments, Zürich.
Aug	Augustinianum, Rome.
AugSt	Augustinian Studies, Villanova (USA).
AW	Athanasius Werke, ed. H.-G. Opitz et al., Berlin.
AZ	Archäologische Zeitung, Berlin.
BA	Bibliothèque augustinienne, Paris.
BAC	Biblioteca de Autores Cristianos, Madrid.
BASOR	Bulletin of the American Schools of Oriental Research, New Haven, Conn.
BDAG	A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament and Other Early Christian Literature, 3rd edn F.W. Danker, Chicago.
BEHE	Bibliothèque de l'École des Hautes Études, Paris.
BETL	Bibliotheca Ephemeridum Theologicarum Lovaniensium, Louvain.
BGL	Benedictinisches Geistesleben, St. Ottilien.
BHG	Bibliotheca Hagiographica Graeca, Brussels.
BHL	Bibliotheca Hagiographica Latina Antiquae et Mediae Aetatis, Brussels.

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BHO	Bibliotheca Hagiographica Orientalis, Brussels.
BHTh	Beiträge zur historischen Theologie, Tübingen.
BJ	Bursians Jahresbericht über die Fortschritte der klassischen Altertumswissenschaft, Leipzig.
BJRULM	Bulletin of the John Rylands Library, Manchester.
BKV	Bibliothek der Kirchenväter, ed. F.X. Reithmayr and V. Thalhofer, Kempten.
BKV²	Bibliothek der Kirchenväter, ed. O. Bardenhewer, Th. Schermann, and C. Weyman, Kempten/Munich.
BKV³	Bibliothek der Kirchenväter. Zweite Reihe, ed. O. Bardenhewer, J. Zellinger, and J. Martin, Munich.
BLE	Bulletin de littérature ecclésiastique, Toulouse.
BoJ	Bonner Jahrbücher, Bonn.
BS	Bibliotheca sacra, London.
BSL	Bolletino di studi latini, Naples.
BWAT	Beiträge zur Wissenschaft vom Alten Testament, Leipzig/Stuttgart.
Byz	Byzantion, Brussels.
BZ	Byzantinische Zeitschrift, Leipzig.
BZNW	Beihefte zur Zeitschrift für die neutestamentlische Wissenschaft, Berlin.
CAr	Cahiers Archéologique, Paris.
CBQ	Catholic Biblical Quarterly, Washington.
CCCM	Corpus Christianorum, Continuatio Mediaevalis, Turnhout/Paris.
CCG	Corpus Christianorum, Series Graeca, Turnhout/Paris.
CCL	Corpus Christianorum, Series Latina, Turnhout/Paris.
CCSA	Corpus Christianorum, Series Apocryphorum, Turnhout/Paris.
CH	Church History, Chicago.
CIL	Corpus Inscriptionum Latinarum, Berlin.
CP(h)	Classical Philology, Chicago.
CPG	Clavis Patrum Graecorum, ed. M. Geerard, vols. I-VI, Turnhout.
CPL	Clavis Patrum Latinorum (SE 3), ed. E. Dekkers and A. Gaar, Turnhout.
CQ	Classical Quarterly, London/Oxford.
CR	The Classical Review, London/Oxford.
CSCO	Corpus Scriptorum Christianorum Orientalium, Louvain. Aeth = Scriptores Aethiopici Ar = Scriptores Arabici Arm = Scriptores Armeniaci Copt = Scriptores Coptici Iber = Scriptores Iberici Syr = Scriptores Syri Subs = Subsidia
CSEL	Corpus Scriptorum Ecclesiasticorum Latinorum, Vienna.
CSHB	Corpus Scriptorum Historiae Byzantinae, Bonn.
CTh	Collectanea Theologica, Lvov.
CUF	Collection des Universités de France publiée sous le patronage de l'Association Guillaume Budé, Paris.
CW	Catholic World, New York.
DAC	Dictionary of the Apostolic Church, ed. J. Hastings, Edinburgh.

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DACL	see DAL
DAL	Dictionnaire d'archéologie chrétienne et de liturgie, ed. F. Cabrol, H. Leclercq, Paris.
DB	Dictionnaire de la Bible, Paris.
DBS	Dictionnaire de la Bible, Supplément, Paris.
DCB	Dictionary of Christian Biography, Literature, Sects, and Doctrines, ed. W. Smith and H. Wace, 4 vols, London.
DHGE	Dictionnaire d'histoire et de géographie ecclésiastique, ed. A. Baudrillart, Paris.
Did	Didaskalia, Lisbon.
DOP	Dumbarton Oaks Papers, Cambridge, Mass., subsequently Washington, D.C.
DOS	Dumbarton Oaks Studies, Cambridge, Mass., subsequently Washington, D.C.
DR	Downside Review, Stratton on the Fosse, Bath.
DS	H.J. Denzinger and A. Schönmetzer, ed., Enchiridion Symbolorum, Barcelona/Freiburg i.B./Rome.
DSp	Dictionnaire de Spiritualité, ed. M. Viller, S.J., and others, Paris.
DTC	Dictionnaire de théologie catholique, ed. A. Vacant, E. Mangenot, and E. Amann, Paris.
EA	Études augustiniennes, Paris.
ECatt	Enciclopedia Cattolica, Rome.
ECQ	Eastern Churches Quarterly, Ramsgate.
EE	Estudios eclesiásticos, Madrid.
EECh	Encyclopedia of the Early Church, ed. A. Di Berardino, Cambridge.
EKK	Evangelisch-Katholischen Kommentar zum Neuen Testament, Neukirchen.
EH	Enchiridion Fontium Historiae Ecclesiasticae Antiquae, ed. Ueding-Kirch, 6th ed., Barcelona.
EO	Échos d'Orient, Paris.
EtByz	Études Byzantines, Paris.
ETL	Ephemerides Theologicae Lovanienses, Louvain.
EWNT	Exegetisches Wörterbuch zum NT, ed. H.R. Balz *et al.*, Stuttgart.
ExpT	The Expository Times, Edinburgh.
FC	The Fathers of the Church, New York.
FGH	Fragmente der griechischen Historiker, Berlin.
FKDG	Forschungen zur Kirchen- und Dogmengeschichte, Göttingen.
FRL	Forschungen zur Religion und Literatur des Alten und Neuen Testaments, Göttingen.
FS	Festschrift.
FThSt	Freiburger theologische Studien, Freiburg i.B.
FTS	Frankfurter theologische Studien, Frankfurt a.M.
FZThPh	Freiburger Zeitschrift für Theologie und Philosophie, Freiburg/Switzerland.
GCS	Die griechischen christlichen Schriftsteller, Leipzig/Berlin.
GDV	Geschichtsschreiber der deutschen Vorzeit, Stuttgart.
GLNT	Grande Lessico del Nuovo Testamento, Genoa.
GNO	Gregorii Nysseni Opera, Leiden.
GRBS	Greek, Roman and Byzantine Studies, Cambridge, Mass.
GWV	Geschichte in Wissenschaft und Unterricht, Offenburg.

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HbNT	Handbuch zum Neuen Testament. Tübingen.
HDR	Harvard Dissertations in Religion, Missoula.
HJG	Historisches Jahrbuch der Görresgesellschaft, successively Munich, Cologne and Munich/Freiburg i.B.
HKG	Handbuch der Kirchengeschichte, Tübingen.
HNT	Handbuch zum Neuen Testament, Tübingen.
HO	Handbuch der Orientalistik, Leiden.
HSCP	Harvard Studies in Classical Philology, Cambridge, Mass.
HThR	Harvard Theological Review, Cambridge, Mass.
HTS	Harvard Theological Studies, Cambridge, Mass.
HZ	Historische Zeitschrift, Munich/Berlin.
ICC	The International Critical Commentary of the Holy Scriptures of the Old and New Testaments, Edinburgh.
ILCV	Inscriptiones Latinae Christianae Veteres, ed. E. Diehl, Berlin.
ILS	Inscriptiones Latinae Selectae, ed. H. Dessau, Berlin.
J(b)AC	Jahrbuch für Antike und Christentum, Münster.
JBL	Journal of Biblical Literature, Philadelphia, Pa., then various places.
JdI	Jahrbuch des Deutschen Archäologischen Instituts, Berlin.
JECS	Journal of Early Christian Studies, Baltimore.
JEH	The Journal of Ecclesiastical History, London.
JJS	Journal of Jewish Studies, London.
JLH	Jahrbuch für Liturgik und Hymnologie, Kassel.
JPTh	Jahrbücher für protestantische Theologie, Leipzig/Freiburg i.B.
JQR	Jewish Quarterly Review, Philadelphia.
JRS	Journal of Roman Studies, London.
JSJ	Journal for the Study of Judaism in the Persian, Hellenistic and Roman Period, Leiden.
JSOR	Journal of the Society of Oriental Research, Chicago.
JThSt	Journal of Theological Studies, Oxford.
KAV	Kommentar zu den apostolischen Vätern, Göttingen.
KeTh	Kerk en Theologie, 's Gravenhage.
KJ(b)	Kirchliches Jahrbuch für die evangelische Kirche in Deutschland, Gütersloh.
LCL	The Loeb Classical Library, London/Cambridge, Mass.
LNPF	A Select Library of Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers of the Christian Church, ed. P. Schaff and H. Wace, Buffalo/New York.
L(O)F	Library of Fathers of the Holy Catholic Church, Oxford.
LSJ	H.G. Liddell and R. Scott, A Greek-English Lexicon, new (9th) edn H.S. Jones, Oxford.
LThK	Lexikon für Theologie und Kirche, Freiburg i.B.
MA	Moyen-Âge, Brussels.
MAMA	Monumenta Asiae Minoris Antiqua, London.
Mansi	J.D. Mansi, Sacrorum conciliorum nova et amplissima collectio, Florence, 1759-1798. Reprint and continuation: Paris/Leipzig, 1901-1927.
MBTh	Münsterische Beiträge zur Theologie, Münster.
MCom	Miscelánea Comillas, Comillas/Santander.
MGH	Monumenta germaniae historica. Hanover/Berlin.

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ML	Mediaevalia Lovaniensia, Louvain.
MPG	See PG.
MSR	Mélanges de science religieuse, Lille.
MThZ	Münchener theologische Zeitschrift, Munich.
Mus	Le Muséon, Louvain.
NGWG	Nachrichten der Gesellschaft der Wissenschaften zu Göttingen.
NH(M)S	Nag Hammadi (and Manichaean) Studies, Leiden.
NovTest	Novum Testamentum, Leiden.
NPNF	See LNPF.
NRSV	New Revised Standard Version.
NRTh	Nouvelle Revue Théologique, Tournai/Louvain/Paris.
NTA	Neutestamentliche Abhandlungen, Münster.
NT.S	Novum Testamentum Supplements, Leiden.
NTS	New Testament Studies, Cambridge/Washington.
OBO	Orbis biblicus et orientalis, Freiburg, Switz.
OCA	Orientalia Christiana Analecta, Rome.
OCP	Orientalia Christiana Periodica, Rome.
OECS	Oxford Early Christian Studies, Oxford.
OLA	Orientalia Lovaniensia Analecta, Louvain.
OLP	Orientalia Lovaniensia Periodica, Louvain.
Or	Orientalia. Commentarii editi a Pontificio Instituto Biblico, Rome.
OrChr	Oriens Christianus, Leipzig, then Wiesbaden.
OrSyr	L'Orient Syrien, Paris.
PG	Migne, Patrologia, series graeca.
PGL	A Patristic Greek Lexicon, ed. G.L. Lampe, Oxford.
PL	Migne, Patrologia, series latina.
PLRE	The Prosopography of the Later Roman Empire, ed. A.H.M. Jones et al., Cambridge.
PLS	Migne, Patrologia, series latina. Supplementum ed. A. Hamman.
PO	Patrologia Orientalis, Paris.
PRE	Paulys Realenzyklopädie der classischen Alterthumswissenschaft, Stuttgart.
PS	Patrologia Syriaca, Paris.
PTA	Papyrologische Texte und Abhandlungen, Bonn.
PThR	Princeton Theological Review, Princeton.
PTS	Patristische Texte und Studien, Berlin.
PW	Paulys Realencyclopädie der classischen Altertumswissenschaft, ed. G. Wissowa, Stuttgart.
QLP	Questions liturgiques et paroissiales, Louvain.
QuLi	Questions liturgiques, Louvain
RAC	Rivista di Archeologia Cristiana, Rome.
RACh	Reallexikon für Antike und Christentum, Stuttgart.
RAM	Revue d'ascétique et de mystique, Paris.
RAug	Recherches Augustiniennes, Paris.
RBen	Revue Bénédictine, Maredsous.
RB(ibl)	Revue biblique, Paris.
RE	Realencyklopädie für protestantische Theologie und Kirche, founded by J.J. Herzog, 3e ed. A. Hauck, Leipzig.

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REA(ug)	Revue des études Augustiniennes, Paris.
REB	Revue des études byzantines, Paris.
RED	Rerum ecclesiasticarum documenta, Rome.
RÉL	Revue des études latines, Paris.
REG	Revue des études grecques, Paris.
RevSR	Revue des sciences religieuses, Strasbourg.
RevThom	Revue thomiste, Toulouse.
RFIC	Rivista di filologia e d'istruzione classica, Turin.
RGG	Religion in Geschichte und Gegenwart, ed. Gunkel-Zscharnack, Tübingen
RHE	Revue d'histoire ecclésiastique, Louvain.
RhMus	Rheinisches Museum für Philologie, Bonn.
RHR	Revue de l'histoire des religions, Paris.
RHT	Revue d'Histoire des Textes, Paris.
RMAL	Revue du Moyen-Âge Latin, Paris.
ROC	Revue de l'Orient chrétien, Paris.
RPh	Revue de philologie, Paris.
RQ	Römische Quartalschrift, Freiburg i.B.
RQH	Revue des questions historiques, Paris.
RSLR	Rivista di storia e letteratura religiosa, Florence.
RSPT, RSPh	Revue des sciences philosophiques et théologiques, Paris.
RSR	Recherches de science religieuse, Paris.
RTAM	Recherches de théologie ancienne et médiévale, Louvain.
RthL	Revue théologique de Louvain, Louvain.
RTM	Rivista di teologia morale, Bologna.
Sal	Salesianum, Roma.
SBA	Schweizerisches Beiträge zur Altertumswissenschaft, Basel.
SBS	Stuttgarter Bibelstudien, Stuttgart.
ScEc	Sciences ecclésiastiques, Bruges.
SCh, SC	Sources chrétiennes, Paris.
SD	Studies and Documents, ed. K. Lake and S. Lake. London/Philadelphia.
SE	Sacris Erudiri. Bruges.
SDHI	Studia et documenta historiae et iuris, Roma.
SH	Subsidia Hagiographica, Brussels.
SHA	Scriptores Historiae Augustae, .
SJMS	Speculum. Journal of Mediaeval Studies. Cambridge, Mass.
SM	Studien und Mitteilungen zur Geschichte des Benediktinerorderns und seiner Zweige, Munich.
SO	Symbolae Osloenses, Oslo.
SP	Studia Patristica. Papers presented to the International Conference on Patristic Studies held in Oxford, successively Berlin, Kalamazoo, Louvain.
SPM	Stromata Patristica et Mediaevalia, ed. C. Mohrman and J. Quasten, Utrecht.
SQ	Sammlung ausgewählter Quellenschriften zur Kirchen- und Dogmengeschichte, Tübingen.
SQAW	Schriften und Quellen der Alten Welt, Berlin.
SSL	Spicilegium Sacrum Lovaniense, Louvain.
StudMed	Studi Medievali, Turin.

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SVF	Stoicorum Veterum Fragmenta, ed. J. von Arnim, Leipzig.
TDNT	Theological Dictionary of the New Testament, Grand Rapids, Mich.
TE	Teologia espiritual, Valencia.
ThGl	Theologie und Glaube, Paderborn.
ThJ	Theologische Jahrbücher, Leipzig.
ThLZ	Theologische Literaturzeitung, Leipzig.
ThPh	Theologie und Philosophie, Freiburg i.B.
ThQ	Theologische Quartalschrift, Tübingen.
ThR	Theologische Rundschau, Tübingen.
ThWAT	Theologisches Wörterbuch zum Alten Testament, Stuttgart.
ThWNT	Theologisches Wörterbuch zum Neuen Testament, Stuttgart.
ThZ	Theologische Zeitschrift, Basle.
TLG	Thesaurus Linguae Graecae.
TP	Transactions and Proceedings of the American Philological Association, Lancaster, Pa.
TRE	Theologische Realenzyklopädie, Berlin.
TS	Theological Studies, New York and various places; now Washington, D.C.
TThZ	Trierer theologische Zeitschrift, Trier.
TU	Texte und Untersuchungen, Leipzig/Berlin.
USQR	Union Seminary Quarterly Review, New York.
VC	Vigiliae Christianae, Amsterdam.
VetChr	Vetera Christianorum, Bari (Italy).
VT	Vetus Testamentum, Leiden.
WBC	Word Biblical Commentary, Waco.
WUNT	Wissenschaftliche Untersuchungen zum Neuen Testament, Tübingen.
WZKM	Wiener Zeitschrift für die Kunde des Morgenlandes, Vienna.
YUP	Yale University Press, New Haven.
ZAC	Zeitschrift für Antikes Christentum, Berlin.
ZAM	Zeitschrift für Aszese und Mystik, Innsbruck, then Würzburg.
ZAW	Zeitschrift für die alttestamentliche Wissenschaft, Giessen, then Berlin.
ZDPV	Zeitschrift des Deutschen Palästina-Vereins, Leipzig.
ZKG	Zeitschrift für Kirchengeschichte, Gotha, then Stuttgart.
ZKTh	Zeitschrift für katholische Theologie, Vienna.
ZN(T)W	Zeitschrift für die neutestamentliche Wissenschaft und die Kunde der älteren Kirche, Giessen, then Berlin.
ZRG	Zeitschrift für Rechtsgeschichte, Weimar.
ZThK	Zeitschrift für Theologie und Kirche, Tübingen.

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IX. ORIENTALIA

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An Archaic Syriac Prayer over Baptismal Oil

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Prayers sanctifying the oil used in the baptismal rite are to be found in a number of different Syriac texts, both literary and liturgical. In the extant Syriac liturgical texts, such prayers feature in the baptismal ordines of the Church of the East[1], the Maronite Church[2], and the old Syriac rite of the Melkite Church (Byzantine Orthodox Patriarchate of Antioch)[3]; none, however, is present in any of the Syrian Orthodox Church baptismal services[4]. Two very much older prayers over oil for baptism are preserved in the *Acts of Thomas* (§§ 121, 157), a work usually dated to the third century[5]. It is to another archaic prayer over baptismal oil, preserved in a late eighth-century Syriac chronicle, that the present paper seeks to draw attention. When, in 1895, J.-B. Chabot published the last part of the chronicle in question he was under the impression that he had recovered the lost Chronicle by the Syrian Orthodox Patriarch Dionysius of Telmahre (who died in 845)[6]; as was subsequently pointed out, this was incorrect, and when Chabot came to publish the entire Chronicle in CSCO (1927), he gave it the cumbersome title *Chronicon anonymum pseudo-Dionysianum vulgo dictum* – not, of course, the more fa-

[1] Urmia edition, p. 68. English translation in K.A. Paul and G. Mooken, *The Liturgy of the Holy Apostles Adai and Mari together with the Liturgies of Mar Theodorus and Mar Nestorius and the Order of Baptism* (Trichur, 1967), pp. 149-51.

[2] Text and Latin translation in J.A. Assemani, *Codex Liturgicus Universae Ecclesiae*, II (Rome, 1749; repr. Farnbrough, 1968), p. 330; a different prayer is found in Paris syr. 116, edited photographically by A. Mouhanna, *Les rites de l'initiation dans l'église maronite*, OCA 212 (Rome, 1980), Plates LVIII-LIX.

[3] Text and Latin translation in Assemani, *Codex Liturgicus*, III (Rome, 1750; repr. Farnbrough, 1968), p. 213.

[4] Although no prayer for sanctifying the oil is found in any of the extant ordines, a prayer for use if no oil is left over from that sanctified on Thursday of the Mysteries is given in Mingana Syriac 127, ff. 182b-184a.

[5] Syriac text, ed. W. Wright, *Apocryphal Acts of the Apostles edited from Syriac Manuscripts in the British Museum and other Libraries* (London, 1871), I, pp. 172-333; Greek, ed. M. Bonnet, in R.A. Lipsius and M. Bonnet, *Acta Apostolorum Apocrypha* II.2 (Leipzig, 1903; repr. Darmstadt, 1959), pp. 99-291. English translation, A.F.J. Klijn, *The Acts of Thomas*, Supplement to NovTest 5 (Leiden, 1962). The *Acts of Thomas* (*ATh*) are quoted both by page of Wright's edition and by Bonnet's sections of the Greek text (adopted in Klijn's translation of the Syriac). On these prayers, seee especially B. Varghese, *Les onctions baptismales dans la tradition syriaque*, CSCO 512, Subs 82 (Louvain, 1989), ch. 1.

[6] J.-B. Chabot, *Chronique de Denys de Tell-Mahre, quatrième partie* (Paris, 1895).

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mous Pseudo-Dionysius, but Pseudo-Dionysius of Telmahre[7]. In more recent years this Chronicle has less cumbersomely been designated the 'Zuqnin Chronicle', after the locality, near Amid/Diyarbakir, where the chronicler, a monk, was writing[8].

The Zuqnin Chronicle (as I shall call it) is a world chronicle, covering from Creation to AD 775/6[9]; within it are a number of incorporated sources, mostly taken over wholesale, such as the detailed section covering AD 497-506/7, usually known as 'the Chronicle of Joshua the Stylite'[10], and that covering 489-578 which is very largely based on the lost Part II of John of Ephesus' *Ecclesiastical History*[11]. An earlier self-contained work incorporated into the Zuqnin Chronicle is entitled 'The Revelation of the Magi'[12]. The work describes how Adam revealed to Seth his former glory, prior to the Fall, and foretold the future appearance of 'the Son of Perfect Mercy'; all this was written down by Seth for the benefit of future generations. This 'Book of Hidden Mysteries' (as it is called) survived the Flood, having been taken into the Ark by Noah; subsequently it was transmitted to the Magians, who kept and cared for it in 'the Cave of Treasures of the Mysteries of the Life of Silence' on 'the Mountain of Victories' (*ṭurā d-neṣḥānē*). In the due course of time, a heavenly sign, in the form of a star and a column of light, is observed, and twelve (named) Magians set off with gifts taken from the Cave of Treasures; led by the guiding star to Bethlehem, they eventually find the infant and present their gifts. They are greeted by Christ with a long address, opening with 'Welcome, sharers in my hidden mysteries'. Christ tells them 'You have become worthy

[7] J.-B. Chabot, *Incerti auctoris Chronicon Pseudo-Dionysianum vulgo dictum*, CSCO Syr 43 text, 66 Latin tr. (Louvain, 1927, 1949).

[8] Thus, for example, the translation of the last two parts by A. Harrak, *The Chronicle of Zuqnin, Parts III and IV, AD 488-775*, Mediaeval Sources in Translation 36 (Toronto, 1999).

[9] On the Chronicle, see especially W. Witakowski, *The Syriac Chronicle of Pseudo-Dionysius of Tel-Mahre* (Uppsala, 1987); in several subsequent articles he has studied the sources of different sections of the Chronicle.

[10] This was separately edited and translated by W. Wright, *The Chronicle of Joshua the Stylite* (Cambridge, 1882). There is a recent English translation by F.R. Trombley and J.W. Watt, *The Chronicle of Pseudo-Joshua the Stylite*, Translated Texts for Historians 32 (Liverpool, 2000), and a German translation by A. Luther, *Die syrische Chronik des Josua Stylites* (Berlin, 1997).

[11] There are recent English translations of this section by W. Witakowski, *Pseudo-Dionysius of Tel-Mahre, Chronicle (Known Also as the Chronicle of Zuqnin), Part III*, Translated Texts for Historians 22 (Liverpool, 1996) and by A. Harrak (see note 8).

[12] Ed. Chabot, I, pp. 57-91; Latin tr., pp. 45-70; Italian translation by U. Monneret de Villard, *Le leggende orientali sui Magi evangelici*, Studi e Testi 163 (Vatican City, 1952), pp. 27-49. There is a Polish translation and commentary by W. Witakowski, in M. Starowieyski (ed.), *Apokryfy Nowego Testamentu*, I (Krakow, 2003), pp. 352-83; Witakowski plans an English translation of this contribution; his survey, 'The Magi in Syriac tradition', is forthcoming in *Vox Patrum* (Lublin).

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to be my witnesses in the East, along with my disciples' (p. 78), and he promises to send some of his 'chosen ones' after his ascension. On their return home, many noble Magians gather to hear their 'new teaching', and subsequently (presumably some three or so decades later), Judas Thomas (or just Judas) arrives in the East (p. 86) where many people who have believed in the 'new teaching' request 'the seal of our Lord', that is, baptism. It is at this point, near the end of the narrative, that the text of the prayer used by Judas for sanctifying the baptismal oil occurs.

Before quoting the relevant passage, a few brief observations concerning the background of the Revelation of the Magi should be made. Mention of the Cave of Treasures on the Mountain of Victories at once points to some sort of link with the Syriac work known as the Cave of Treasures, which also mentions the Mountain of Victories[13], and to a considerably closer association with a *Liber apocryphus nomine Seth* containing a passage concerning the Magi, quoted in a summarized form in the Latin *Opus Imperfectum in Matthaeum*[14]. All three works draw on what must once have been an extensive literature associated with the name of Seth[15], and in both the Revelation of the Magi and the *Opus Imperfectum* this material has been brought together with legends concerning the Gospel Magi that presumably grew up in Sasanian Iran in order to provide a foundation legend for the Iranian Christian community, many of whom would, by the late fifth and the sixth century, have had Zoroastrian ancestors[16]. In the Revelation of the Magi, this local tradition has been neatly combined with the widespread early tradition that Thomas evangelized Parthia (so Eusebius, *H.E.* III.1.1), or Persia (so Rufinus, *H.E.* IX.2), and for this purpose the compiler has drawn upon materials that must derive from the kind of milieu that produced the literature associated with the name Judas, or Judas Thomas. Thus, not surprisingly, by far the closest parallels to the – often distinctive – phraseology of the prayer over the oil that features in the Revelation of the Magi are to be found in the Syriac *Acts of Judas Thomas*.

With these preliminaries, it is time to turn to the prayer itself, along with the brief narrative introducing and following it.

[13] Cave of Treasures (ed. Su-Min Ri, CSCO Syr 207-8 (Louvain, 1987)) XIV.1; cf. VI.23; see also his *Commentaire de la Caverne des Trésors*, CSCO Subs 103 (Louvain, 2000). p. 207. There is, however, no direct literary relationship between these two texts.

[14] PG 56, 637. This includes a reference at the end to the arrival in the East of Thomas. According to J. van Banning, *Opus Imperfectum in Matthaeum*, CCL 87B (Turnhout, 1988), p. v, the work dates from the second half of the fifth century.

[15] A.F.J. Klijn, *Seth in Jewish, Christian and Gnostic Literature* (Leiden, 1977), esp. pp. 74-80, and G. Stroumsa, *Another Seed: Studies in Gnostic Mythology* (Leiden, 1984), esp. ch. 6.

[16] For Iranian elements in the Revelation of the Magi, see G. Widengren, *Iranisch-semitische Kulturbegegnungen in parthischer Zeit* (Cologne, 1960), pp. 71-83.

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(Syriac text, ed. Chabot, I, p.88)

ܗܘ ܕܠܝܠܝܐ ܕܐܬܝܗܒ ܠܢ ܒܙܝܬܐ ܒܨܠܘ ܠܡܫܝܚܘܬܐ ܕܝܠܢ ܒܙܝܬܐ ܒܚܒܐ ܕܡܫܝܚܘܬܐ ܕܐܬܝܗܒ ܠܢ ܒܙܝܬܐ ܒܚܒܐ ܕܡܫܝܚܘܬܐ ܕܐܬܓܠܝ

3. to you be praise, Hidden Mystery that has been given us in the oil for Life/Salvation and for forgiveness.
4. By it (sc. the oil) he illumines us and chases away from us darkness and error,
5. and in its Mystery, again, athletes in the contest overcome their enemies.
6. To you be praise, Mystery of the oil, who were worthy to have participation with Christ,
7. and with it the victorious are crowned in the contest.
8. You are twinned with the Spirit
9. and it (sc. the oil) too floats over the water like its mate (fem.), the Holy Spirit,
10. the mingler of the soul with the mind,
11. and the renewer of the body in the rebirth to Life/Salvation.
12. Come (fem.), Companion of the Firstborn,
13. come (fem.), Renewer of human beings in her giving birth to eternal life,
14. reside in these believers, who are the beloved of our Lord Jesus Christ,
15. and purify them and sanctify them from all the scars of their bodies;
16. and may they become for you (fem.) temples for your dwelling,
17. and a resting (place) for the perfect Son of Mercy;
18. and may you sanctify them in rebirth to Life/Salvation completely.

And he baptized them in the name of the Father, Son, and Holy Spirit.

The prayer falls into two main parts: 1-11 are addressed to the Hidden Mystery (*rāzā kasyā*), represented by the visible oil, while in 12-18 the Holy Spirit is invoked directly, and asked to sanctify those participating in the rite of initiation. Within the first section there are two phrases where there is a shift from 2nd person to 3rd person (4-5;7).

The various parallels with the *Acts of Thomas* (*ATh*) are best indicated in the form of a running commentary. References are to the page numbers of Wright's edition of the Syriac text and, in brackets, the section numbers of Klijn's English translation (taken over from Bonnet's edition of the Greek translation). Not surprisingly, most of the parallels are concentrated in passages where the *Acts of Thomas* describe rites of baptism and eucharist (§§ 25, 27; 49, 50; 121; 132, 133; 156, 157, 158)[17].

Introductory narrative

'receive the seal (*ḥātmā*) of our Lord': cf. *ATh*, p. 192 (§ 26), 'to receive the mark (*rušma*)'. Rusma is the standard term in *ATh* and early Syriac literature for the baptismal anointing; 'seal' here will represent later terminology (already present in the Greek translation of *ATh* here (*sphragis*); likewise at §§ 120, 150, etc.

[17] For these, see especially G. Winkler, 'Weitere Beobachtungen zur frühen Epiklese', *OrChr* 80 (1996), 177-200, esp. 181-92.

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'spring of water': so too *ATh* § 121 in the Greek (but not the Syriac, p. 291), at Mygdonia's baptism.

'he took oil and gave praise over it and said': exactly the same wording, including the unusual 'give praise over', occurs in *ATh* p. 323 (§ 157).

1. 'Mystery (*rāzā*) of Life/Salvation (*ḥayye*)': the phrase appears not to be found in *ATh*, though is occasionally found elsewhere: Athanasius, *Life of Antony* 125 (Syriac tr., ed. R. Draguet); Narsai (ed. A. Mingana), I, p. 351. In early Syriac texts *ḥayye* 'life', also regularly corresponds to Greek *sōtēria*.

2. 'Hidden Mystery (*rāzā kasyā*)': in *ATh*, p. 216 (§ 47) a prayer of Judas begins, 'O Jesus, Hidden Mystery who has been revealed to me'. In our passage too, Jesus will be the *rāzā* hidden in the oil. In *ATh*, p. 193 (§ 27), the Holy Spirit is the revealer of 'hidden mysteries', while at p. 179 (§ 10) it is Christ.

3. 'for Life/Salvation and for forgiveness': cf. *ATh*, p. 301 (§ 132), where baptism is 'of forgiveness of sins' and it 'gives birth to new human beings'.

4. 'illumines us': Christ, the Hidden Mystery represented by the oil, will be the subject. For Christ as illuminator (*manhrānā*) of those in the darkness of error, see *ATh* p. 320 (§ 153).

'darkness (*ḥešōkā*) and error (*ṭu'yay*)': Christ is the chaser away (*rādōpeh*) of darkness and destroyer of error in *ATh*, p. 250 (§ 80), while in *ATh*, p. 322 (§ 156), he is the haven for those who go out from 'the place of darkness'. The term 'error' occurs several times elsewhere in our text, as well as in *ATh* (e.g., pp. 221, 292); it perhaps reflects the influence of Zoroastrian terminology.

5. 'athletes in (literally of) the contest': by contrast, *ATh* only has the Greek loanword *atlīṭā* as a title of Christ: p. 209 (§ 39) 'our true Athlete', and p. 218 (§ 49) 'our victorious Athlete' (on this title, see my 'Greek words in Ephrem and Narsai: a comparative sampling', *Aram* 11/12 (1999/2000), 439-49, esp. 444-6). Closer to the idea behind the present passage is *ATh*, p. 209 (§ 39), where Christ is an 'aid to his servants in the contest, throwing down the enemy before them'.

6. 'who were worthy': though *dšwyt* could in theory be taken as *d-šawwit*, 'which I have placed', in the light of *ATh* it is much preferable to read it as *da-šwayt*, 'who were worthy' (thus both Chabot and Monneret de Villard): a similar phrase is found at *ATh*, p. 323 (§ 157), in Judas' prayer over the baptismal oil, where the oil is addressed, 'O fair fruit who were worthy to become fervent with the words of holiness, so that human beings might put you on and vanquish, by you, their enemies' (the imagery will be of athletes and wrestlers oiling themselves before a contest, as is found, for example in Narsai, *Homily* 22)[18].

[18] Ed. A. Mingana, I, p. 368; English translation by R.H. Connolly, *The Liturgical Homilies of Narsai*, Texts and Studies VIII.1 (London, 1909), p. 45.

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8. 'you are twinned (*mat'mat*)': though the theme of twinning is a notable feature of *ATh*, there is no exact parallel to the present use of the term. The subject of the verb must be either the oil itself, or (more likely) the Mystery (*rāzā*) hidden in the oil.

9. 'floats (*ṭā'es*) over the water like its mate (*bat zawgeh*; (fem.)), the Holy Spirit': although *ṭās* normally means 'fly', it is also occasionally used of ships on the sea; here the imagery is that of oil spreading over water, and the comparison with the Holy Spirit will be an allusion to Gen. 1:2 (where the Peshitta has *mraḥḥpā*); cf. *ATh*, p. 209 (§ 39), 'we praise you... and the Holy Spirit who hovers (*mraḥḥpat*) over all created things'. For the disputed exegesis of Gen. 1:2, whether the *ruḥa* of God refers to the Holy Spirit or not, see my 'The *ruaḥ elohim* of Gen 1,2 and its reception history in the Syriac tradition', in J.-M. Auwers and A. Wenin (eds), *Lectures et relectures de la Bible. Festschrift F.-M. Bogaert*, BETL 144 (Leuven, 1999), pp. 327-49.

The fact that the oil is associated with the water, and not those being baptized, perhaps suggests that the oil being sanctified is not just for anointing them (implied by *mšiḥūtā* in 1), but also to be poured on the baptismal water as part of the sanctification of the font[19]. The pouring of oil on the water in the course of the sanctification of the water is in fact a feature of most early Syriac baptismal rites (subsequently, in the Syrian Orthodox rite, it is myron that is used instead).

The Holy Spirit is grammatically feminine throughought the text, following normal early Syriac usage[20]; the term used here is *ruḥa d-qudšā*, whereas below (Epilogue, q.v.), and elsewhere in the text (p. 79), the much rarer *ruḥā qaddīštā*, with the feminine form of the adjective, is employed.

10. 'the mingler (*māzgat*) of the soul': the following fem. construct of the participle, *mḥaddtat* in 11, indicates that *mzgt* should also be taken as a fem. construct of the participle, and possibly the pa'el *<m>mazzgat* should be read, in conformity with *ATh*, p. 301 (§ 132), where Baptism is 'the mingler (*mmazzgat*) of souls and bodies' (in the light of Klijn's note (p. 288) on the passage, it is possible that *mad'a* refers to the Mind of Christ).

11. 'and renewer of the body': in the passage of *ATh* just quoted, Baptism is 'the renewer of minds' (*mḥaddtat re'yane*).

'rebirth to (literally, of) Life (*mawlādā d-ḥayyē*)': the phrase, also found below in 18, does not feature in *ATh*.

[19] This may also apply to the prayer over the oil in the Byzantine rite, for which see M. Arranz, 'Les sacrements de l'ancien Euchologe constantinopolitain (7)', *OCP* 52 (1986), 145-78, esp. 176-7.

[20] For the Holy Spirit (*ruḥā*) as grammatically feminine in early Syriac literature, see my 'The Holy Spirit as feminine in early Syriac literature', in J. Martin Soskice (ed.), *After Eve: Women, Theology and the Christian Tradition* (London, 1990), pp. 73-88, and 'Come, compassionate Mother ..., come, Holy Spirit. A forgotten aspect of early Eastern Christian imagery', *Aram* 3 (1991), 249-57.

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12. 'Come, (*tāy*)': the Holy Spirit is addressed. The imperative 'come', addressed either to Christ or (as here) the Holy Spirit/Spirit of Christ, is found in several early epicleses (in *ATh*, p. 193 (§ 27), p. 218 (§ 50), and p. 323 (§ 157)), and will go back ultimately to the phrase *māranā tā* in 1 Cor. 16:22; in later epicleses where the verb 'come', rather than 'send', is used, the jussive 'May there come' is employed, rather than the imperative[21].

'Companion of the Firstborn (*šawtāptā d-bukrā*)': since the imperative is feminine, it is the Holy Spirit who is being addressed. The term 'companion' (or, 'sharer', 'participator') was probably also used of the Holy Spirit in *ATh*, p. 193 (§ 27), where the text has 'Come (fem.), sharing (*šawtāpūtā*) of the blessing (*d-burktā*)': in the light of the present text it seems quite likely, not only that the abstract *šawtāpūtā* is a corruption of *šawtāptā*, but also that *d-burktā* is a corruption of *d-bukrā*[22]. The verb *eštawtap*, in the imperative or jussive, is a characteristic feature of several epicleses in *ATh*, addressed either to the Holy Spirit (pp. 193, 218, 219 = §§ 27, 50 bis), or to Christ (p. 218 = § 49).

13. 'Renewer of human beings': cf. *ATh*, p. 217 (§ 48), quoted below, under 14.

14. 'Reside upon (*šrāy 'al*)': cf. *ATh*, p. 217 (§ 48), 'May your grace come and faith in you reside upon them and renew them'. Elsewhere in *ATh*, p. 323 (§ 157), Christ is invoked, 'Come, reside (*šrī*) on this oil as you resided on the Wood'; earlier in this prayer (end of § 156), however, we find 'and may the Holy Spirit dwell (*te'mar*) in them'.

15. 'purify them ... sanctify them': both verbs, but in reverse order, are found in *ATh*, p. 323 (§ 156), 'sanctify them in the unclear region and purify them from corruption in the region of the enemy'.

'scars (*kutmātā*)': cf. *ATh*, p. 291 (§ 121), 'heal her from her former sores (*šumātā*)'.

16. 'shrines (*nawse*) for your dwelling': based on 1 Cor. 3:16, 6:19, 2 Cor. 6:16 (where, however, the Peshitta has *hayklā*, not *nawsā*, corresponding to Greek *naos*). In *ATh*, cf. p. 323 (§ 156), 'and make them shrines and holy temples, and may your Holy Spirit dwell in them'.

17. 'resting place (*nyāḥā*)': in early Syriac literature this term usually has reference to Christ[23], and not to those being baptized. The basis for the present usage might be Isaiah 28:12, 'This is my rest (*nyāḥt(y)*), give rest (*'aniḥ(w)*)

[21] On this, see my 'The epiklesis in the Antiochene baptismal ordines', in I. Ortiz de Urbina (ed.), *Symposium Syriacum 1972*, OCA 197 (Rome, 1974), pp. 183-218, esp. 199-200, and Winkler, 'Weitere Beobachtungen'.

[22] The Greek text of *ATh* § 27, however, has *hē koinōnia tou arrenos*, supporting the Syriac *šawtāpūtā*; on this, see further Klijn's note, p. 289.

[23] Thus in *ATh*, p. 209 (§ 39). See especially G. Winkler, 'Ein bedeutsamer Zusammenhang zwischen Erkenntnis und Ruhe in Mat 11,27-29 und dem Ruhen des Geistes auf Jesus am Jordan', Mus 96 (1983), 267-326.

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to the afflicted': Aphrahat, *Dem.* IV.14, quotes the opening of this (with *nyāḥt(y)*), but goes on to paraphrase, 'Perform the rest (*nyāḥeh*) of God, ... give rest (*anīḥ*) to the afflicted', and to identify this as constituting prayer. A further possible biblical starting point could be Isaiah 66:1-2, 'What is the house you are building for me, or what is the place of my rest (*da-nyāḥt(y)*)?... On whom shall I look and (in whom) shall I dwell (*e'mar*), apart from the tranquil (*nīḥā*) and humble in spirit?'[24] If the latter passage lies behind the text here, perhaps one should simply add *syame* and read *nyḥ'* as a plural, *nīḥē*.

'Son of Perfect Mercy': the clear presence of *syame* on the same phrase at p. 59, and the occurrence of the separate term 'Perfect Mercy' at p. 80, indicate that both here in our prayer, and at p. 84 (where the presence or absence of *syame* is unclear), one should read *brā d-raḥmē mšallmānē*, rather than *brā d-raḥmē mšallmānā*, 'Perfect Son of Mercy'. The same very distinctive title for Christ also occurs in *ATh* several times (pp. 208, 282, 322 (§ 39, – (i.e., absent from Greek), 156), while at *ATh*, p. 179 (§ 10) Jesus is 'Perfect Son of Perfect Mercy'; likewise, 'Perfect Mercy' alone occurs at *ATh*, pp. 193, 216, 218 (§§ 27, 48, 50), and 'Perfect Son' at p. 280 (-). At the epicleses on pp. 193 and 218, 'Perfect Mercy' is addressed directly, 'Come, Perfect Mercy'; at p. 218 the term must be a title for the Holy Spirit, and this probably also applies at p. 193, *pace* Klijn (p. 214).

Epilogue

'Holy Spirit (*ruḥā qaddištā*)': the preservation of the archaic feminine in the adjective is rare; in *ATh* it features at pp. 209 and 218 (§§ 39, 50). In Wright's text it has been altered to *ruḥā d-qudšā* at pp. 192 and 324 (§§ 27 and 157), though corresponding to p. 324, the original reading, *ruḥā qaddīštā*, has been preserved in the early palimpsest in Sinai Syr. 30[25].

Outside Judas' prayer over the baptismal oil there are a number of further parallels between the Revelation of the Magi and the *Acts of Thomas*. Particularly striking is the appearance, immediately after the baptism, of 'a child of

[24] For this, see Winkler, 'Ein bedeutsamer Zusammenhang', p. 289, who draws attention to the paraphrase in *Liber Graduum* XXI.12; there, interestingly, *nyāḥ(y)* is again used instead of the Peshitta's *nyāḥt(y)*: 'My rest (*nyāḥ(y)*) is the tranquil (*nīḥā*) and humble in spirit, upon whom I look and in whom I dwell, and he (will) ascend in me when I ascend to the place of my rest (*da-nyāḥ(y)*)'.

[25] These palimpsest fragments were originally edited by F.C. Burkitt in A.S. Lewis, *Select Narratives of Holy Women. Syriac Text*, Studia Sinaitica IX (London, 1900), pp. 23-44, but a fuller reading was later provided by A.S. Lewis herself in her *Acta Mythologica Apostolorum*, Horae Semiticae 3 (London, 1904), Appendix, pp. 192-228, and translated in her accompanying volume, *The Mythological Acts of the Apostles*, Horae Semiticae 4 (London, 1904), pp. 223-41.

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supernal light' (p. 88 end): in *ATh*, p. 193 (§ 27), it is 'a youth with a lighted candle' who is momentarily seen. Among the parallels in distinctive terms and phrases, the following might be noted:

	Revelation of the Magi	*Acts of Thomas*
Christ as 'Voice (*qālā*)':	pp. 59, 70, 71, 75	pp. 216, 282, 322
Christ as 'Saviour of the Worlds (*maḥyānā d-'ālmē*)':	p. 74	p. 179
Christ as 'Beloved Fruit (*pī'rā rḥīmā*)':	p. 77	p. 301
'region of life (*atrā d-ḥayyē*)':	pp. 77, 84	p. 176

On the other hand, there are quite a number of characteristic terms in the Revelation of the Magi which are completely absent from the *Acts of Thomas* (for example, the frequent phrase 'Supernal Majesty (*rabbūtā 'elāytā*)', (pp. 57, 59, 61, 62, 64-7, 73-7, 83, 87, and 'Father of Majesty (*Abbā d-rabbūtā*)', (pp. 60-2, 65-7, 71, 75, 76, 78, 79, 83, 84. The second of these happens also to be one that is favoured in Manichaean texts[26]; the wider implications of this and other features, however, lie beyond the scope of this article and cannot be explored further here.

[26] Thus, for example, it occurs several times in Theodore bar Koni's account of Manichaean doctrine in his *Liber Scholiorum* XI (ed. A. Scher, CSCO 55 (Louvain, 1910)), pp. 313-6; see also *Corpus Fontium Manichaeorum: Dictionary of Manichaean Terms*, I, *Texts from the Roman Empire* (Turnhout, 1998), pp.43 (Greek), 101 (Coptic). The other frequent phrase, *rabbūtā 'elāytā*, however, does not seem to feature in the main Manichaean texts.

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'Humility Begets Wisdom and Discernment': Character and True Knowledge in Aphrahat

J.W. CHILDERS, Abilene

In mid-fourth-century Persia, the Syriac-speaking scholar Aphrahat stated that 'humility begets wisdom and discernment' (*Demonstration* 9.2)[1]. Connecting knowledge and sound cognitive processes to the presence of moral virtues and praiseworthy dispositions is commonplace among ancient writers. However, the modern epistemology of the last 300 years or so has displayed more interest in the propositional content of beliefs, rather than in the agency through which beliefs are formed and sustained. Indeed, practitioners of modern positivistic methods, having rejected the allegedly primitive cosmologies and anthropologies of ancient thinkers and writers, have tended to view with suspicion the patristic conviction that, in addition to careful methods of intellectual enquiry, the diligent practice of inner virtues and their attendant moral behaviours will play a beneficial and even decisive role in the quest for genuine knowledge.

Modern epistemological theory has tended to treat beliefs as propositional objects, focusing its inquiries on the question, 'What is knowledge?', and attempting to establish the properties that knowledge must have in order to be justified as true belief. Both epistemological foundationalism[2] and coherentism[3] are basically deontological and belief-based, focusing on the properties of particular claims and the processes by which one evaluates their truth or falsehood. Due to the complex problems that have arisen in the epistemological discussions of the last quarter of the twentieth century, many epistemologists have chosen to abandon these perspectives and develop theories akin to ancient virtue approaches instead[4].

[1] 1, 409, 10-11. References are to volume, column, and line numbers of J. Parisot's edition, *Aphraatis Sapientis Persae Demonstrationes*, PS 1, 2 (Paris, 1894, 1907).

[2] See the explanations of contemporary forms of foundationalism in Paul K. Moser, Dwayne H. Mulder, and J.D. Trout, *The Theory of Knowledge: A Thematic Introduction* (New York, 1998); Robert Audi, *Epistemology: A Contemporary Introduction to the Theory of Knowledge* (London, 1998).

[3] For explanations of coherentism, see Keith Lehrer, *Theory of Knowledge* (Boulder, 1990); Michael Williams, *Problems of Knowledge: A Critical Introduction* (Oxford, 2001).

[4] See Guy Axtell (ed.), *Knowledge, Belief, and Character. Readings in Virtue Epistemology* (Lanham, Maryland, 2000), pp. xi-xxix; Abrol Fairweather and Linda Zagzebski (eds.), *Virtue Epistemology. Essays on Epistemic Virtue and Responsibility* (New York, 2001), pp. 3-14.

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Virtue epistemologists prescribe a change in the direction of analysis, from properties of beliefs to properties of persons, so that epistemic justification is explained in terms of a belief's source in an intellectual virtue[5]. Some follow reliabilist proposals[6], focusing attention on the reliability and successful outcomes of the cognitive processes; others follow responsibilist proposals[7], emphasizing the agent's virtues and motivation. Some attempt to combine the two, holding that a success component must be accompanied by a motivational one[8].

Virtue epistemologists commonly notice parallels between their own assumptions and those of ancient authors[9], yet relatively few attempts have been made to explore the ancient texts of specific authors and intellectual traditions with this in mind[10]. One ancient tradition for which it may be said that notions of virtue play a prominent role in shaping epistemological assumptions is that of early Syrian Christian thought. In particular, the works of Aphrahat provide abundant evidence for the pervasiveness in early Syriac thought of what may be called a virtue approach to knowledge. This essay will conduct a preliminary overview of some of the epistemological assumptions at work in Aphrahat, showing that he illustrates many of the assumptions and practices that are of particular interest to virtue epistemologists today.

Aphrahat: "Humility Begets Wisdom and Discernment"

Aphrahat composed twenty-three *Demonstrations* (*Dem.*) in Syriac on various topics of theological and spiritual interest, between the years 336 and 345.[11]

[5] The accounts of knowledge offered by virtue epistemologists differ in various ways, and the field enjoys lively discussion. See the survey in Axtell, 'Recent Work on Virtue Epistemology', *American Philosophical Quarterly* 34 (January 1997), pp. 1-26.

[6] Ernest Sosa, *Knowledge in Perspective* (Cambridge, 1991); Alvin Goldman, *Epistemology and Cognition* (Cambridge, Massachusetts, 1986); John Greco, 'Virtue Epistemology', in Jonathan Dancy and Ernest Sosa (eds.), *A Companion to Epistemology* (Oxford, 1992), pp. 520-2; Jonathan Kvanvig, *The Intellectual Virtues and the Life of the Mind* (Lanham, Maryland, 1992).

[7] Linda Zagzebski, *Virtues of the Mind. An Inquiry into the Nature of Virtue and the Ethical Foundations of Knowledge* (Cambridge, 1996); Lorraine Code, *Epistemic Responsibility* (Hanover, 1987); James A. Montmarquet, *Epistemic Virtue and Doxastic Responsibility* (Lanham, Maryland, 1993).

[8] See Roderick M. Chisholm, *The Problem of the Criterion* (Milwaukee, 1973); W. Jay Wood, *Epistemology: Becoming Intellectually Virtuous* (Downers Grove, Illinois, 1998).

[9] An oft-cited example is Aristotle, who assigns a prominent place to moral and intellectual virtues in his *Nicomachean Ethics*.

[10] One noteworthy example is Frederick D. Aquino's study of the *Philokalia*: 'Epistemic Virtues of a Theologian in the *Philokalia*', in William J. Abraham (ed.), *Canonical Theism*, forthcoming.

[11] For a fine recent introduction to Aphrahat, see Marie-Joseph Pierre, *Aphraate le sage persian. Les exposés*, 2 vols, SC 349 and 359 (Paris, 1988-89), 1, 13-202.

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In these treatises, Aphrahat's ethical emphasis is clear; nearly every passage rings with the force of his moral exhortations. For example, though he upholds literal understandings of spiritual disciplines, he prefers to probe them for deeper, moral meanings – true prayer expresses itself in aid for the needy (*Dem.* 4.14, 15), genuine fasting involves avoiding evil practices (*Dem.* 3.1), and proper Sabbath-keeping is a matter of giving rest to those who are burdened in life (*Dem.* 13.13). True children of Abraham are distinguished by their right behaviour (*Dem.* 11.1). For Aphrahat, moral behaviour is fundamental to the Christian life.

Aphrahat also ties moral character to the performance of the intellect. He finds within humanity a tension between its potential to share in the divine nature and its arrogant tendency to usurp the divine glory and power[12]. The tension between these two aspects of the human experience has a direct bearing on the quest for knowledge. According to Aphrahat, 'the man was conceived and dwelt in the mind of God'[13], prior to his birth (*Dem.* 17.7). Once humanity was born into full existence, it had the 'knowledge of discernment'[14], the capacity to distinguish good from evil and to know that God was its creator. The proper exercise of this original knowledge perpetuates the mental connection inherent in the primal relationship between human and Creator. Aphrahat explains, 'inasmuch as he knew his maker, God was formed and conceived within the man's thought, so that he became a temple for God his maker'[15].

One implication of this notion of reciprocal conception is that people are meant to experience a natural mental harmony with their Maker, a sharing of minds that is linked to full human existence and is associated with knowledge. Aphrahat indicates that if a person does not know the Creator, then God does not dwell within that person's mind – he or she is therefore 'like the beasts, like the other creatures'[16]. Fundamentally, Aphrahat assumes that God is the ultimate ground and source of knowledge, and that truly human intelligence exists only in a mind that is structured as a temple for God, because otherwise it lacks the ennobling vital component of the divine presence.

When Adam seized the fruit of the Tree of Knowledge, he was seeking not simply a share in the divine nature, but was pridefully seeking 'that he should be equal with its Maker'[17]. Furthermore, because of the wilful way in which Adam and Eve acquired the fruit, and because of their arrogant motives, the knowledge they got was 'confused and harmful knowledge, which they had

[12] See Peter Bruns, *Aphrahat Demonstrationes. Unterweisungen*, 2 vols, Fontes Christiani 5.1-2 (Freiburg, 1991), 1, 67-8; Pierre, *Aphraate le sage persian*, 1, 157-8.

[13] 1, 797, 3-4.

[14] 1, 800, 4-5.

[15] 1, 800, 6-9.

[16] 1, 800, 15-16.

[17] 2, 5, 17-19.

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taken prematurely'[18]. It brought them discrimination and differentiation, an important function of knowledge, but it was differentiation in the form of a barrier separating them from the Tree of Life. Their reward was the curse and a life full of torments (*Dem.* 23.3). This is the situation that Jesus Christ came to remedy. A major achievement of the incarnation is the recovery of the divine nature on behalf of humanity (*Dem.* 6.10). The Christian salvation-history tradition provides Aphrahat with a narrative framework[19] for understanding the predicament of the human intellect – situated between its lofty potentiality to ascertain divine knowledge and its baser impulses prompting it to seek that knowledge in proud and selfish ways, humanity is invited to rediscover, in Christ, the role that practical virtues play in the mind's proper orientation and functioning.

Sincere Truth-Seeking

One implication for epistemic virtue is the importance of truth-seeking. Those who do not crave knowledge like food and drink do not find it; whereas those who genuinely desire it and are willing to engage in the requisite practices to find it will be satisfied (*Dem.* 10.8). For Aphrahat, genuineness in truth-seeking is marked by personal integration and pure sincerity. The consonance of the inner person and the outer person is basic to the proper functioning of human faculties.[20] Any learned scholar can make observations based on clear evidence, for example that death comes to every person; but responding to these observations with appropriate behaviour indicates the operation of a deeper quality, that of wisdom (see *Dem.* 22.11). Also, inner attitudes like love must express themselves in physical practices, such as the care of the poor (see especially *Dem.* 20), and mental practices, such as trying to keep one's cognitive processes open to receive instruction from others. For their part, external practices lose their vigour unless the beliefs and attitudes of the inner person match up; for example external circumcision is meaningless without genuine circumcision of the heart, in the form of sincere and accurate faith (*Dem.* 11.5, 10-11).

The inevitable connection between the inner and outer life means, first of all, that a person must attend to the cultivation of the inner life. For Aphrahat,

[18] 2, 8, 8-10.

[19] In his first *Demonstration*, 'On Faith' (1.19), Aphrahat rehearses the basic items of the Christian faith. For a discussion of this creedal statement, see Pierre, *Aphraate le sage persian*, 1, 144-56.

[20] Aphrahat uses various terms to describe the human person (e.g., body, soul, spirit, heart, flesh), but these do not refer to separate components out of which the person is constructed. Rather, 'ce sont des modalités du vivant unifié qui désignent son activité, sa production – et même ses potentialités et ses infirmités' (ibid., p. 181).

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prayer is an important integrative practice, since it provides an environment in which to check and refine one's inner motivations and the extent to which one's dispositions translate into attendant behaviours (*Dem.* 4.1, 13). Hence, regular self-examination is an important cognitive habit. Other integrative practices include asceticism and celebrating the sacraments. The sacraments (see *Dem.* 11, 12) are formative of cognitive processes because they involve the practitioners in the specific content of Christian truth, over time forming the structures of their thought and behaviours according to the contours of that knowledge and the priorities of its values. Also the sacraments, like the ascetic lifestyle (see *Dem.* 6), are a means of conforming a person to Jesus Christ, the virtuous exemplar, involving them in his work of reclaiming the human person (including the intellect) for its intended destiny of sharing abundantly in the divine nature. These practices are epistemic virtues because they assist one in achieving coherence between the inner and outer person; they integrate a person's cognitive practices with their behaviour according to the normative contours of their beliefs.

Disciplined Enquiry and Discourse

Another epistemic virtue Aphrahat values is the practice of intellectual enquiry and discourse. He likens the careful and diligent student of scripture to the well-tilled field, ready to receive the good seed and to enjoy the rewards of abundant produce in knowledge (*Dem.* 1.20). Aphrahat models scholarship, constructing his arguments carefully, taking up pieces of evidence in scripture and meticulously treating them in a disciplined fashion.[21] He entertains questions about the evidence and treats objections to his interpretations as he articulates the logic by which he understands the evidence to lend its support to his argument, exhorting his audience to 'read, learn, know, and perceive' (*Dem.* 7.27)[22]. Aphrahat's quest for truth furthermore obligates him to communicate what he has discovered, in ways that recreate for the reader the compelling adventure of discovery, illuminating (as he sees it) the beauty and logic of what he has found. Having received out of the boundless treasury of divine knowledge, Aphrahat is compelled to imitate God's generosity by sharing his knowledge openly – and persuasively – with others (*Dem.* 10.8).

Although Aphrahat advocates and models sophisticated methods of enquiry and argumentation, he insists they cannot substitute for purity of heart and the desire to follow the truth. For example, when discussing the issue of the

[21] Jacob Neusner, *Aphrahat and Judaism: The Christian-Jewish Argument in Fourth-Century Iran*, Studia Part-Biblica 19 (Leiden, 1971), pp. 6, 7.

[22] 1, 360, 15-16.

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appropriate timing of paschal observance, Aphrahat carefully examines the complex issues associated with biblical Passover prescriptions and the relative chronology of the Gospel texts (*Dem.* 12.1-12). Yet he concludes his investigations by encouraging the reader not 'to be vexed with bickering over words ... but (to have) a pure heart that keeps the commandment' (*Dem.* 12.13)[23]. After painstakingly weighing the evidence, at the end he admonishes the reader not to become exasperated by the complexity of it all, but instead to 'be diligent, but not concerning a season .... Instead, let us delight in keeping the fourteenth of every month .... All the days of the week we should do what is pleasing before the Lord our God'[24]. Although Aphrahat clearly believes diligent research on the paschal mystery to be important, it must cohere with the essential practices of keeping a pure heart, maintaining genuine paschal praxis, and doing right each day.

Humility

For Aphrahat, perhaps the most prominent disposition for the truth-seeker is humility. 'Humility begets wisdom and discernment'[25], he says (*Dem.* 9.2). Ancient ascetics prized humility as an ethical virtue and Aphrahat composes an entire Demonstration (*Dem.* 9) on the subject. The epistemic importance accorded to humility is not surprising; humility presents itself as the obvious cure for the pride that Adam displayed in his attempt to usurp God's place by seizing 'premature knowledge'. In contrast to the wilful presumptuousness of Adam, the humble welcome instruction; they drink it like water, so that the fruit of knowledge flourishes (see *Dem.* 9.1, 2). Lowering oneself in humility elevates one's heart and mind, so that one is perceptive of heavenly things (*Dem.* 9.4).

For Aphrahat, humility is not just an ethical virtue-it is also an intellectual virtue, because it helps the truth-seeking mind retain a receptive and flexible posture. The sense of wonder that a person experiences in an authentic encounter with God's infinite wisdom brings not only delight, but also a keener awareness of one's own limitations (*Dem.*10.8). The experience affects behaviour. Having worked through a learned text, the wise person realizes there is no shame in acknowledging, 'Whatsoever is written is written well, but I have not attained the understanding of it', since no human is capable of comprehending all truth, even if he or she had 'all the days of the world from Adam to the end of the ages'[26] to study it (*Dem.* 22.26). Humility

[23] 1, 540, 3-5.
[24] 1, 537, 22-1, 540, 1.
[25] 1, 409, 10-11.
[26] 1, 1045, 24-25; 1, 1048, 13-14.

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also helps a person guard against the presumption that he or she has exhausted every possible interpretation of the object of enquiry. Since God is the ground of all knowledge, and since God's riches cannot be counted or depleted (*Dem.* 5.25), only a fool would presume to have spoken the last word. 'The treasure fails not, for it is the wisdom of God'[27]; it is inexhaustible (*Dem.* 10.8). The virtuous intellect realizes that the goal of finally exhausting the search for truth is beyond human reach, and behaves accordingly.

The latter observation leads to a more detailed consideration of the way in which humility conditions a person's treatment of others who are engaged in the process of intellectual discovery and discourse. Humility is incompatible with envy or contentiousness (*Dem.* 9.4, 7, 8). Arrogant behaviour towards others signals intellectual pride and pride impairs the intellect. In *Dem.* 5.25 Aphrahat warns the reader to beware of anyone who mocks the views of another while maintaining, 'Mine are wise'[28]. The arrogance of such a person shows that their thinking is suspect, since a refusal to listen to others hinders the search for knowledge. Aphrahat's priorities in this area are most clear in his conclusion to *Dem.* 22:

> As for me, even if some of the words I have written do not agree with those of other speakers, I will say that these wise men have spoken well, yet I think that I ought to speak like this. And if anyone wants to lecture me and teach me about anything, I will take it from him without a quarrel. Everyone who reads the sacred books ... and reads for instruction, is a [true] learner and teacher. But if anyone raises disputes about questions he does not understand, his mind is not patient of discipline[29].

According to Aphrahat, the best teachers are also humble learners. Aphrahat desires to remain open to other insights, entertaining divergent points of view and acknowledging that there may be more than one legitimate way to see or explain the truth. He warns against the opposing vices of contentiousness and pride, since they harden one's intellect against the reception of sound teaching.

The Jews as Intellectual Opponents

Despite Aphrahat's explicit commitment to open-mindedness, he confidently rejects the opinions of the Jews[30]. This might seem like just another instance of the prejudiced anti-Semitic polemic that is so common among

[27] 1, 464, 4-6.

[28] 1, 237, 9.

[29] 1, 1045, 11-22. Translation of 1, 1045, 13-22 by Robert Murray, in *Symbols of Church and Kingdom. A Study in Early Syriac Tradition* (Cambridge, 1975), p. 29.

[30] Aphrahat's polemic is probably intended for a Christian readership, not a Jewish one. Several of his *Demonstrations* attempt to strengthen Christian self-understanding by putting Christian convictions into dialogue with Judaism, particularly as he perceives it in scripture.

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Christian authors of the period[31] – and indeed Aphrahat does apply strongly negative rhetoric from time to time, characterizing Jews who might disagree with him as foolish and unlearned (*Dem.* 13.11; 15.1, 8). He does not neglect to emphasize that much of Israel's history was conditioned by their penchant for wickedness, a point he develops at some length in order to explicate the origins of various, outmoded laws (*Dem.* 15-16).

Yet in his polemical treatment of Jews Aphrahat actually compares favourably to most other patristic writers[32]. His use of pejorative language is sparing, nor does he resort to the easy device of slander and *ad hominem* argumentation. Instead, even in his pretended dialogues with Jewish opponents, he prefers to face evidence openly and honestly, arguing his points carefully. Not only does he appeal consistently to a source of evidence universally acknowledged by Jews and Christians, the Old Testament, but he employs a plain-sense approach to the text that bears many similarities to rabbinic reading strategies and does not require the enigmatic, in-house methods used by many Christian allegorizers in their polemics against Jewish interpretations of scripture[33]. With characteristic enthusiasm, Jacob Neusner remarks,

> Of all parties to the argument between Judaism and Christianity in late antiquity, Aphrahat therefore is most impressive for his reasonable arguments, his careful attention to materials held in common by both sides, and the articulated and wholly lucid, worldly character of his argumentation. On the Christian side, he stands practically alone for his interest in the opinions of actual, not imaginary Jewish opponents[34].

In Robert Murray's words, 'Aphrahat hits hard, but it is a clean fight; in general, he lets Scripture speak for him'[35]. Aphrahat is confident that he can slay his opponent through diligent argumentation and a trust in God's revelation, without resorting to mere character assassination. Yet he cannot avoid surmising that moral defects are partly responsible for his opponents' faulty thinking.

[31] On the subject of patristic anti-Semitism, see Marcel Simon, *Verus Israel. A Study of the Relations between Christians and Jews in the Roman Empire (AD 135-425)*, tr. H. McKeating (Oxford, 1986). Also, see the earlier studies, G. Richter, 'Über die älteste Auseinandersetzung der syrischen Christen mit den Juden', *ZNW* 35 (1936), 101-14; Frank Gavin, 'Aphraates and the Jews', *JSOR* 7 (1923), 96-166.

[32] Neusner, *Aphrahat and Judaism*, pp. 214-44; L. Ginzberg, 'Aphraates, the Persian Sage', in *Jewish Encyclopedia*, ed. Isidore Singer, vol. 1 (New York, 1901), pp. 664-5. Cf. J.E. Seaver, who describes Aphrahat as 'violently anti-Semitic', in *Persecution of the Jews in the Roman Empire (300-434)* (Lawrence, 1952), p. 38, but Simon notices that Seaver's view is based on a very limited reading of two *Demonstrations* and suffers from a superficial understanding of Aphrahat's thought and polemical purposes (*Verus Israel*, p. 401).

[33] Neusner, *Aphrahat and Judaism*, pp. 6, 7, 144.

[34] *Ibid.*, 244.

[35] Murray, *Symbols of Church and Kingdom*, p. 41. Simon maintains, 'When Aphraates takes issue with the Jews, he fights...with their own weapons and on ground they themselves have chosen' (*Verus Israel*, p. 320).

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For his part, Aphrahat believes himself to be open to instruction, even by Jewish scholars – provided they exhibit the virtues of honesty and careful handling of evidence: 'If you make argument against me from the scriptures regarding any of these things I will accept it from you. But I will not listen to anything you have invented out of your own mind' (*Dem.*18.7)[36]. He suspects his 'opponents' of wilfully inventing counter-arguments rather than genuinely and humbly seeking truth.

Conclusion: Combining Virtue and Process

Like other ancient authors, Aphrahat exhibits the assumption that cultivating the virtues greatly impacts the quality of human life and the functioning of the mind. Though Aphrahat is no epistemologist, beneath the surface of his rhetoric and behind the logic of his argumentation it is not difficult to detect epistemological assumptions that resonate with those of contemporary virtue theory. In Aphrahat, virtuous inner dispositions – such as a genuine desire for truth, humility, and an awareness of one's limitations – must cohere with virtuous practices, such as frequent self-examination, the careful and disciplined handling of evidence, participation in discourse, open-mindedness and an openness to correction. Certain other practices support these virtues, conforming them to the specific contours of Christian thought structure – practices such as the sacraments, the ascetic lifestyle, and the disciplines of fasting, prayer, and helping the poor. Epistemic vices are as injurious to the mind's functioning as the virtues are healthy for it.

It would be inappropriate to impose contemporary categories and questions on Aphrahat, yet it is clear that he presumes a vital connection exists between virtue and proper cognitive functioning. Moreover, his reliance on virtue language is not merely a rhetorical device employed to sharpen the edge of his polemic against those who disagree (though at times this may be so). Instead, notions regarding the connection between virtue and cognition function as deeply held epistemological assumptions for Aphrahat.

The purpose of this study has been to shed a modest amount of light on the illustrative value that texts like these have in current discussions of virtue epistemology. For example, the reliabilist/responsibilist debate is probably the most pressing issue in contemporary discussions. Without forcing the contemporary question onto Aphrahat, we have seen that he presumes a combination of sorts. For him, both virtue and process – motivation and consequence – are interrelated. Both play an evaluative and constitutive role with respect to proper cognitive function. Whether his particular manner of

[36] 1, 836, 14-18.

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combining the two would be judged satisfactory by contemporary virtue epistemologists is another question, yet Aphrahat undeniably shows that it is possible to combine some form of reliabilism and some form of responsibilism, to potent effect.

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Interior Decorating: Jacob of Serug on Mary's Preparation for the Incarnation

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The image of the body as a temple for the Lord's indwelling was a favourite of ancient Jewish and Christian writers, who found ample biblical resources by which to explore its thematic possibilities[1]. Syriac writers, too, were enarmored of such building imagery from an early date. The *Acts of Judas Thomas* and the *Manichaean Psalms* in the third century[2], Aphrahat the Persian's *First Demonstration* and the *Book of Steps* in the fourth[3], were all texts in which the body, individual and/or collective is built anew into a house of faith, a building to be adorned by the virtues of practised devotion. Indeed, Syriac writers by the fifth century would present the ascetic life as a liturgical celebration enacted in the temple of the body, upon the altar of the heart[4].

It comes as no surprise, then, to find that late antique Syriac writers are glad to image Mary and the incarnation of Christ in precisely these terms: seeing Mary's body as the temple in which, at the moment of Christ's conception, the divine indwelling is supremely accomplished – a motif that is widely used in the Christological debates leading up to the Council of Chalcedon, and perhaps most notably by the Antiochene theologians[5]. The image of Christ as the king who prepares Mary to be his palace, or sanctuary, or temple, recurs in Syriac hymns and homilies of Mary as a familiar, yet elegant refrain[6]. Jacob of Serug,

[1] Particularly important were Jn 2.13-22; 1 Cor 3.9, 16-17; 6.19-20; 2 Cor 6.16-7.1; 1 Pet 2.4-8, quoting Ps 118.22.

[2] *Acts of Thomas*, 6-7; see H.J.W. Drijvers, 'The Acts of Thomas', in *New Testament Apocrypha*, ed. W. Schneemelcher, trans. R. McL. Wilson, rev. edn, 2 vols (Louisville, KY: Westminster/John Knox Press, 1991-92), 2, 329-30, 341-2; A.F.J. Klijn, *The Acts of Thomas*, Supplement to NovTest 5 (Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1962), pp. 67-8, 177-9.

[3] C.R.C. Allberry (ed.), *A Manichaean Psalm-Book, Part II* (Stuttgart: W. Kohlhammer, 1938), pp. 188-9. Aphrahat, *Demonstration* 1.8.25-9.2, tr. J. Gwynn, LNPF, sec. ser., 13, pp. 345-6. *The Book of Steps* 12.2, tr. S.P. Brock, *The Syriac Fathers on Prayer and the Spiritual Life*, Cistercian Studies Series 101 (Kalamazoo: Cistercian Publications, 1987), pp. 45-53.

[4] 'On Hermits and Desert Dwellers', especially lines 97-108, 485-96; tr. Joseph P. Amar, in *Ascetic Behavior in Greco-Roman Antiquity: A Sourcebook*, ed. Vincent Wimbush (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1990), pp. 66-80.

[5] For the overview, see, e.g., Aloys Grillmeier, *Christ in Christian Tradition*, vol. 1, *from the Apostolic Age to Chalcedon (AD 451)*, revised edn, tr. John Bowden (Atlanta: John Knox Press, 1975), 184, 299-301, 304-5, 312, 327, 359, 428-37, 417, 477, 492, 513-6.

[6] E.g., Hymn 25.5-6 (anonymous), in S.P. Brock, *Bride of Light: Hymns on Mary from the Syriac Churches* (Kerala, India: SEERI, 1994), p. 87; Jacob of Serug, Hom. 1, in M. Hansbury,

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d. 521, arguably the most prolific Syriac homilist of late antiquity, was no exception in this regard.

However, in one of Jacob's homilies on the Nativity (Hom. 6 in Bedjan's edition of Jacob's Marian *memre*)[7], Jacob presents this familiar motif in slightly changed terms. The passage at issue follows immediately upon Mary's dialogue with the archangel Gabriel concerning her conception of the divine Son, at lines 387-418. After fervent exchange with the divine messenger, Mary turns to the task of preparation for this monumental event.

Mary begins by 'refining' and 'cleansing' her senses, mouth, and words, and 'gathering and removing' all inappropriate thoughts from her mind. After this initial 'clear-out', she sets to work cleaning the dwelling of her body. Jacob uses a series of verbs referring to cleaning, cleansing, purifying, or straining or filtering out impurities (dirt). As cleansing agents, he has Mary employ several of the classic Syriac ascetic virtues: purity (*dakyutho*), holiness (*qaddishutho*), reverence (*iaqirutho*), perfection (*gmirutho*).

> She swept her house with the holiness that was within her,
> And she embellished its inner walls with all kinds of reverence.
> Again in it she set in order the good signets of perfection.

Next, Jacob's Mary undertakes redecorating: replenishing, refilling, repairing, sewing, hanging and adorning, again with the favored practices of Syriac ascetic tradition as the objects of decor: modesty (*knikutho*), virginity (*btulutho*), vigilance (*zhirutho*), chastity (*nakputho*).

> She replenished it with blossoms of all manners of modesty.
> She leveled its land with the choice implements of virginity.
> She hung up ornaments, crowns of praises of watchful care.
> She took up and laced together veils out of chastity;
> She spread out and stretched out spacious garments of watchfulness.

With a deft touch, Jacob's vocabulary for Mary's work carries allusions to the biblical language of God's glory (*iqara*, as the equivalent for Greek *doxa*, Hebrew *kavod*), the radiance (Syr. *zahra*) of the divine presence that will soon fill her house[8]. Lastly, Mary adorns her house with actions of ornamentation that render her body into a sanctuary for liturgical celebration:

Jacob of Serug on the Mother of God (Crestwood, NY: St Vladimir's Seminay Press, 1998), at pp. 24, 41; Jacob of Serug, Festal Hom. 1, in Thomas Kollamparampil, *Jacob of Serugh, Select Festal Homilies* (Rome: CIIS, 1997) at pp. 61-3.

[7] Ed. P. Bedjan, *S. Martyrii qui et Sahdona quae supersunt omnia* (Leipzig: Harrassowitz, 1902), pp. 720-74, here at pp. 738-9; trans. as Festal Homily 1, in Kollamparampil, *Jacob of Serugh*, pp. 41-93, here at pp. 59-60. I use Kollamparampil's translation for this discussion.

[8] On this point I am indebted to Alexander Golitzin, 'The Place of the Presence of God: Aphrahat of Persia's Portrait of the Christian Holy Man', in *Synaxis Eucharistias: Charisteria eis Timen tou Gerontos Aimilianou*, ed. Simonas Petras Monastery (Athens: Indiktos Press, 2003), pp. 391-447.

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She poured out as oil, good deeds in her lamp
And her great flame has been inflamed in the temple of her body.
She burned the fragrance of her prayers warmly
So that the pure fire of her faith should serve as incense.
She threw, as sweet spices, the sounds of praise into the fire of her love
And from her thanksgiving breathed the fragrance of choice incense.

Finally, Mary is ready:

And while the house was made radiant by these things in a holy manner,
The Son of the King entered and dwelt in the shrine of virginity[9].

In this richly evocative passage, we are not shown Mary's preparations as those of building a temple. Instead, we are shown a very different set of activities necessarily related to buildings: those of building maintenance. Jacob shows us Mary engaged in the tasks of cleaning, repairing, and redecorating (a 'spring overhaul', so to speak). While based on the imagery of the body as a temple, the motif of building maintenance is, I suggest, of a different ilk than the familiar pattern noted above. While Jacob's homily presents the event as transpiring at the culminating moment of sacred time (the incarnation itself), the imagery of building maintenance locates this homily at a particular point of ecclesiastical, and hence historical, time. Two characteristics of that temporal point are especially relevant here.

First, Jacob presents Mary as an exemplary housecleaner. She cleans thoroughly and carefully, sweeping up dirt, refuse, and extraneous or inappropriate matter. Sweeping is followed by the standard methods widely practised in the ancient Mediterranean for 'deep cleaning' or disinfecting: fumigation with medicinal herbs, and the use of aromatic incense to sweeten the air to a wholesome and health-giving quality[10]. In other words, the language of cleansing as purification that Jacob uses in this passage is not, I think, primarily evocative of ritual states of purity and pollution, although it carries such a traditional sense, but rather is referencing the mundane tasks of thorough house cleaning, with the most effective cleansing agents of the ancient world.

There is an interesting social shift evidenced by such description. The vast bulk of our ancient literature, in any language of the Mediterranean, was written by men. When ancient writers described the work of housewives, they did so in detail on those aspects of domestic activity they themselves witnessed (Xenophon's *Oeconomicus* is an example). As a result, detailed descriptions of cleaning are often lacking, since those were the chores of women (or slaves)[11]. But prescription recipes for cleansing agents and disinfectants turn up in texts dealing with herbs and spices (such as Pliny's *Natural History*) – the *materia*

[9] Kollamparampil, *Jacob*, pp. 59-60.

[10] A practice advocated, e.g., by Tertullian, *On the Crown* 10.

[11] See Gillian Clark, *Women in Late Antiquity: Pagan and Christian Lifestyles* (New York: Oxford University Press, 1993), pp. 94-118.

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medica of antiquity, and the pragmatic ingredients for maintenance of healthy households. In late antiquity, however, as monasticism becomes established in Christian communities, metaphors and imagery drawn from the mundane work of housekeeping and house cleaning begin to appear, with surprising detail, in ascetic literature. While not an overbearing theme, texts such as the *memre* of Ephrem Syrus, the Pseudo-Macarian homilies, the *Life of St Syncletica*, and the *Divine Ladder* of John Climacus all utilize imagistic language referring to basic house maintenance, particularly cleaning[12]. Dirt, trash, bugs, vermin, smoke, stains, rot, and stench of various kinds are all referenced in metaphors and similes for different mental problems attendant on long-term ascetic practice. Solutions to the problems are then presented through imagery of the different cleansing, disinfecting, and sweetening methods of the ancient cleaning repertoire – a sort of alternative to the philosophical tradition of medical imagery and therapeutic discourse for moral guidance. This ascetic imagery of filth and cleansing corresponds to categories in Graeco-Roman moral psychology taken from philosophical tradition, of correcting and ordering the passions. I have argued elsewhere that the emergence of such imagery in late antiquity marks a change in social history, to the establishment and maintenance of single-sex households (monasteries, episcopal households, hermits' caves), in which men themselves had to take up cleaning tasks that would previously have been handled by women. Hence their seemingly 'new' ability to deploy such descriptions accurately[13]. As in the case of Jacob's passage here, such imagery attends to issues concerned with long-term maintenance, rather than construction or establishment.

It should be noted that Jacob also differs in this instance from the housekeeping pattern of ascetic literature, in that he is not presenting Mary's efforts as the heavy duty cleaning needed for serious filth. Hers is the extra work of the splendidly competent housekeeper, the scrupulous attention appropriate for a royal visitor. In terms of his larger purpose in the homily, Jacob's use of cleaning imagery in no way intimates that Mary is unclean according to ancient purity and pollution codes. Rather, his emphasis is decidedly on her efforts as a measure of free will. Jacob presents no passivity in Mary. Having decided to accept the divine request for use of her womb after lengthy interrogation of Gabriel, Mary also decides when she is ready for the event. The cleaning and redecorating are her choice. When she deems herself adequately prepared, Jacob has her declare firmly at the end of our passage, '"Let your

[12] Ephrem, *Memra* 2. 93-123, ed. E. Beck, *Des Heiligen Ephraem des Syrers Sermones* I, CSCO 305, Syr 130 (Louvain: Secrétariat du CorpusSCO, 1970), pp. 12-49; Pseudo-Macarius, *Homilies*, 1, 15, 16, 27, 28, 33, 43; pseudo-Athanasius, *The Life and Activity of the Holy and Blessed Teacher Syncletica*, passim; John Climacus, *Ladder of Divine Ascent*, Step 5, Step 8.

[13] S.A. Harvey, 'Housework: An Ascetic Theme in Late Antiquity', in *'To Train His Spirit with Books': Studies in Syrian Asceticism in Honor of Sidney H. Griffith*, ed. Robin A. Darling Young and Monica Blanchard (Washington: Catholic University of America Press, 2007).

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Lord come./ Behold, I am prepared so that according to His will He might dwell in me."... She by her will opened the door and then the King entered'[14]. The cleaning interlude, inserted by Jacob into the elastic narrative of sacred time, allows him to underscore the significance of human free will in the salvation drama.

However, in Jacob's passage, a further set of cleaning associations is apparent, resonating with matters appearing in Syriac canon law collections of the fifth through seventh centuries. Previously, church canons of the third, fourth, and much of the fifth centuries had focused heavily on matters of ecclesiastical order: establishing church offices; defining their authorities, duties and domains; prescribing appropriate social and religious demarcations. In the course of the fifth century, a different set of concerns begins to appear. What should be done with worn or faded altar cloths or church linens? With broken or cracked Eucharistic vessels? What about urns for holy oil that have gone rancid with age? Or liturgical vessels that have gone mouldy? Rotted pieces of Eucharistic bread? What about worn-out chalice sponges? What should be done with the cleaning water afterwards? Can priests sanctify holy oil into which insects have fallen? What should be done with broken liturgical utensils or instruments?[15]

When Jacob describes Mary's preparations, the actions he attributes to her are reminiscent of the regulations prescribed in response to just such questions. The use of special cleaning implements and procedures, of water specially scented, of particular disposal methods for refuse and dirtied water afterwards, as well as instructions for disposal or repair of damaged or malodorous sacred vessels – all such regulations enumerated in the canon collections seem to find echo in the actions Jacob ascribes to Mary. Maintenance, repair, upkeep, replacement are the underlying themes.

But Jacob's text does not stop there. When Mary has completed her cleaning chores, she turns to overhauling the interior decoration of the building. More than simply refurnishing, she undertakes a series of acts of adornment that in fact mirror the liturgy itself: incense, hymns of praise, lighted lamps, and prayers of thanksgiving – all to prepare the body to receive the indwelling of the divine person. The textual recounting of Mary's singular cleaning and preparation of her house for holy visitation becomes, in Jacob's rendering, an account of the preparation of the Church for the divine liturgy to be celebrated

[14] Kollamparampil, *Jacob*, p. 60.

[15] A few such matters are raised in the 'Rabbula Canons for Clergy and Members of the Covenant', ed. and tr. A. Vööbus, *Syriac and Arabic Documents Regarding Legislation Relative to Syrian Asceticism* (Stockholm: Estonian Theological Society in Exile, 1960), pp. 34-50. But more detailed discussion appears in canons attributed to Severus of Antioch and John of Tella – contemporaries of Jacob of Serug – and again in canons by Jacob of Edessa. See A. Vööbus, *The Synodicon in the West Syrian Tradition I*, CSCO 367-8, Syr 161-2 (Louvain: Secrétariat du CorpusSCO, 1975).

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by the church body as a whole each week. Cleaning, furnishing, adorning, beautifying: the sequence becomes both the unique moment of salvation effected at the incarnation and its repeated representation in the collective activity of the ecclesial community.

Jacob's text on Mary's preparation for the incarnation moves beyond the inherited image of the body as temple or sanctuary in which the Lord dwells, and engages more than the traditional language of cultic purity and pollution as ritual conditions. Refracted through Jacob's verses is the daily life of late antique Syriac churches, particularly those of small towns and villages. Dirt, disrepair, long-term wear, cracks, and rot crept into any and every building over time. When Jacob describes Mary's preparations, he reminds us of the humble challenges involved in maintenance and upkeep. Cleaning, repair, and renewal are the needs of the long haul. And the long haul was where the late antique Christian stood.

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Ezekiel's Vision and the Hekhalot Mysteries: Pre-Kabbalistic Philosophy in the Age of Augustine[1]

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'In the thirtieth year, on the fifth day of the fourth month ... the heavens opened and I saw visions of God ... a flashing fire, surrounded by a radiance; and in the center of it ... a gleam as of amber.' (Ezek. 1:1, 4)

Ezekiel's vision and the rabbis who studied it are important building blocks in the growth of what was to become Kabbalah. The earliest period which truly can be termed Kabbalistic is that between the emergence of *Sefer Bahir* in Provence[2] (*c.* 1176 CE) and the emergence of the *Zohar* in Spain[3] (*c.* 1295 CE)[4]. This does not mean that Judaism was bereft of mystical writings and practices prior to that time, nor that these practices grew in a vacuum. For centuries, Judaism had a deep and abiding mystical tradition, as can be seen in numerous passages from the Mishnah (redacted *c.* 200 CE) and Talmud (Babylonian Talmud, redacted *c.* 400 CE). After the fall of the Second Temple (70 CE), numerous academies were founded in Babylonia, and during the next few centuries the rich mystical traditions of Babylonia influenced Jewish culture, especially in the area of demonology[5]. Bowls from as early as the fourth century have been discovered, buried upside down, inscribed with spells to protect Babylonian Jews from demons which may have been living beneath the ground. These spells contain words and phrases which are nearly identical to those found in the *Kol Nidrei* prayer, recited by Jews the world over on Yom Kippur[6].

The *Bahir* was passed down orally prior to its written transmission, and all of the rabbis mentioned and quoted within its 200 verses lived prior to the fifth century. The last of these include Rava, who was known, according to Talmud,

[1] 354-430 CE.

[2] Including rabbis Abraham ben David (1120-1198) and his son, Isaac the Blind (1165-1235), the 'father of Kabbalah'.

[3] Rabbi Moses deLeon (1240-1305) 'discovered' the *Zohar*, attributing it to Yochanan ben Zakkai and his followers. Most scholars accept that deLeon wrote the *Zohar* himself.

[4] Joseph Dan (ed.), *The Early Kabbalah* (Mahwah, NJ: Paulist Press, 1986), p. 1.

[5] Stuart Weinberg Gershon, *Kol Nidrei, Its Origin, Development, and Significance* (Northvale, NJ: Jason Aaronson, 1994), p. 51.

[6] *Kol Nidrei*, pp. 53-4; prayer to nullify the previous year's vows between man and God; 'all vows', 'cancels', 'annuls', and 'divorced' common in both.

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to have engaged in mystical practices[7]. Another early text, the *Sefer Yetzirah*, with its concept of the 'ten sefirot of nothingness'[8] is mentioned in the Talmud[9]. Although verse 6:7 indicates that the text was written or given to Abraham[10], giving the *Sefer Yetzirah* a more ancient provenance, it was probably written during the early part of the second century, perhaps by Rabbi Akiba[11].

The type of meditation Akiba and his peers engaged in is part of the earliest mysteries to be expounded upon with any frequency. They are contained under the general heading of *merkavah*, and are based upon the first chapter of Ezekiel, his being the only vision a prophet attempted to transcribe for future generations[12].

As is the case with any aspect of Jewish mysticism, there is no text which can be held up as the prime example of *merkavah* philosophy. There are, instead, numerous texts, all of which were well known during the fifth century, although none of them is currently dated past the late second or early third centuries[13]. The major personalities whose words are recorded therein are well-respected second-century mystics and sages such as Rabbis Akiba, Ishmael, and Nehuniah ben HaKana, himself one of the main figures of the *Bahir*[14].

Of the main texts, five stand out as the most important in the study of *merkavah* mysticism. While they are attributed to the rabbis who appear within, it is unclear as to who the authors actually are or when, precisely, any were written. The word *hekhalot* appears in three of the titles[15] and means 'chambers' or 'palaces'. This refers to the mystical realms which must be navigated before reaching the throne of the King, which is to say, God. In some texts these *hekhalot* are seen as representing chambers within a perfected Temple contained in a heavenly Jerusalem, similar to Augustine's view of the City of God, where 'the holy angels ... invite us to their society ... to join them in worshipping their God'[16].

[7] *Talmud Sanhedrin* 65b

[8] *Sefer Yetzirah* 1:1; tr. Aryeh Kaplan (York Beach, Maine: Samuel Weiser, 1990), p. 5.

[9] *Sanhedrin* 65b and 67b especially.

[10] 'And when Abraham our father ... understood ... he was successful in creation ...' (*Sefer Yetzirah*, p. 255).

[11] The text gives authorship to Abraham; Kaplan asserts that Akiba wrote the book or, at the very least, assembled oral traditions into a written form (p. xvii).

[12] Isaiah 6 records a vision as well, but it is not as detailed nor as intense as Ezekiel's.

[13] Dates vary from the first to as late as the eighth centuries; Kaplan, Patai, and Idel date them to the second century.

[14] Nehuniah ben HaKana: the first rabbi in the *Bahir* (vs. 1): 'Rabbi Nehunia ben HaKana said ...'; see Aryeh Kaplan, *The Bahir Illumination* (York Beach, Maine: Samuel Weiser, Inc., 1979), p. 1.

[15] *Hekhalot Rabbatai*, *Hekhalot Zutratei*, and *Sefer Hekhalot*, better known as *Hanoch*, or, in English, Enoch.

[16] Augustine, *City of God* X.25; tr. Marens Dods, LNPF 2 (Buffalo, 1887), p. 196.

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In most cases, there are seven chambers[17]. With proper knowledge, the mystic can reach a level at which he will be deemed worthy to enter the chariot. Along the way there are specific perils which must be dealt with, and a mystic deemed, for whatever reason, to be unworthy by the angelic hosts he encounters will suffer grave punishments. For example, 'Lightning flashes ... exploding and blinding all who are not worthy'; 'They throw him into burning lava'; and 'They immediately cast thousands of steel axes at him'[18].

Unlike the spontaneous nature of Ezekiel's visions, the rabbis' visions were gained deliberately, through various meditative techniques, including the recitation of Divine names, especially the Tetragrammaton, YHVH. Yet so intense are the details of Ezekiel's experience that the Mishnah warns, 'Do not expound upon ... the Chariot before [any person], unless he [is] a sage ...'[19] The *Bahir* states that 'when a person accustoms himself to study the ... Mystery of the Chariot, it is impossible that he not stumble.' Even so, such study should still be pursued because it ultimately leads to the 'way of life' (*Bahir* 150; p. 55).

The *hekhalot* texts provide a hierarchical description of the Divine realm and the practical means by which to achieve the highest levels, brought back by rabbis such as Akiba[20], acting as part how-to manual, part travelogue, and part commentary, showing the various ways in which the rabbis went about explaining their experiences[21]. The *Hekhalot Rabbatai* states that mystics should 'be careful [to] choose [as their followers in the mysteries] proper individuals, and they should be members of the society who have been screened'[22], and also states that the only ones who are allowed to take part in these meditations are 'the proper, the meek, the humble, the wise, the upright, the pious, the chosen, the ascetics, the righteous, and the perfected ones'[23].

The nature of the palaces and the progression through them vary, as well. Some texts indicate that the progression is linear, but others, such as *Hekhalot Zutratei*, say that the palaces are contained one within the other, nested, so that the journey is not through a series of chambers so much as it is a journey which progresses from outer to inner. In *Hekhalot Zutratei*, Rabbi Akiba ultimately

[17] The seven chambers connect to the concept of the seven heavens.

[18] *Hekhalot Rabbatai*, Chapters 20, 26; see Aryeh Kaplan, *Meditation and Kabbalah* (York Beach, Maine: S. Weiser, 1982), pp. 50, 54.

[19] *Mishnah Hagigah*, 2:1: Jacob Neusner, *The Mishnah: A New Translation* (New Haven and London: Yale University Press, 1988), p. 330.

[20] Akiba (d. 135 CE) was known for his scholarship and knowledge of the mysteries, taught by a student of the scholar/mystic Rabbi Yochanan ben Zakkai.

[21] In some cases, the followers are assumed to be accompanying elders, who yet are not able to follow all the way to the last revelations. In others, the rabbi seems to be meditating while his words are noted by scribes. Thus, even the unworthy may learn, assuming that their motivations are correct.

[22] *Hekhalot Rabbatai*, Chapter 28; see Kaplan, *Meditation and Kabbalah*, p. 48.

[23] *Hekhalot Rabbatai*, Chapter 2; see Kaplan, *Meditation and Kabbalah*, p. 43.

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reaches the seventh *hekhal*, in which is the throne of God himself. Here he learns God's holy and secret name, which is 'The great and mighty and revered God, the strong and the heroic and the powerful and the gallant, my beloved is white and ruddy ... hosts, his head is as the most fine gold ... hosts, his eyes are as the eyes of doves ... hosts ...', each of seven verses from Song of Songs (5:10-16) containing part of the name[24]. In similar fashion, the Talmud recounts Akiba's journey into 'the Orchard'[25]. With him on this shared meditation were three of his colleagues, Ben Azzai, Ben Zoma, and the Other[26]. Akiba warned the three of sensory mirages or synaesthesia: 'When you enter near the stones of pure marble, do not say "water, water".' Of the four, Ben Azzai died, Ben Zoma went insane, and the Other became a heretic. Only of Akiba does the Talmud say that he 'entered in peace and left in peace' (*Chagigah* 14b). As with the Talmudic story of Akiba and his colleagues, Akiba is the only one worthy of achieving the innermost of the palaces in *Hekhalot Zutratei*.

The reference to the Song of Songs is of great importance in *Hekhalot Zutratei* and in other *merkavah* texts. It is seen in both rabbinic and mystical circles as an intense love poem, with God and his people Israel as the main characters. It is Akiba himself – believing that it is akin to the Holy of Holies –, who is responsible for the Song's inclusion in the canon (*Mishna Yadayim* 3:5). Furthermore, the gematria[27], or numerical equivalent, of the phrase from Song of Songs 6:11, 'I went down into the garden of nuts,' is identical to that of the phrase 'This is the depth of the Chariot,' leading some of the *merkavah* literature to be known as *Sod Egoz*, 'the secret of the nut'[28]. This is the reason that the texts speak of individuals going down or descending into the Chariot, after ascending to the heights of the heavens (*Bahir* 88).

Hekhalot Zutratei also mentions a specific danger which lurks at the sixth *hekhal*, which shines with the light of the marble with which it is paved. The radiance is such that it looks as though it is 'engulfed by a hundred thousand thousands of thousands and ten thousands of ten thousands of sea waves'. Those who attain this level, but believe that the marble is actually water, are stoned and then, 'before he can move from there, [the servants] split his head with metal cutters'[29]. Hence, Akiba's warning.

[24] Joseph Dan, *The Ancient Jewish Mysticism*, (Tel Aviv: IMOD Books, 1993), p. 36.

[25] Used in Talmud and later writings as a euphemism for the Paradise of God's innermost chambers.

[26] A reference to Elisha ben Abuya, who, due to his meditative experiences with Akiba, became a heretic.

[27] Gematria is studying a word, phrase, or paragraph via its numeric equivalent. Hebrew letters have a direct numeric value, thus facilitating such connections. One-to-one correspondence is the simplest variety.

[28] Dan, *The Ancient Jewish Mysticism*, p. 79.

[29] *Hekhalot Zutratei*; see Dan, *The Ancient Jewish Mysticism*, p. 98. Again, this relates back to Akiba and 'do not say "water, water"'.

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Hekhalot Rabbatai contains the names of the angels which guard the doors to the *hekhalot* and explains exactly what needs to be done in order to pass by in peace. Each of the doors to the chambers is guarded by eight angels, four to one side and four to the other. Taking as an example the journey from the third *hekhal* to the fourth,

> Show them two seals, one of TzURTK the Lord, and one of Dahavyoron, the Prince of the Face ... Immediately they will grasp you, one to your right, and one to your left, and two angels will precede you and two will follow you. Perfecting and illuminating you, they will bring you to Pachdiel, the chief guardian of the door of the Fourth Chamber ... and to Geburathiel, the angel who stands to the left of the lintel with him[30].

This continues until the last *hekhal* is reached, at which point the mystic is compelled to enter the Chariot. Those who enter the Chariot immediately, without hesitation or pause, are deemed to be unworthy due to their lack of humility and are immediately killed and thrown into burning lava[31]. Those who refuse are compelled by the angels again and then allowed to enter in safety. Few ever complete the journey successfully.

Once again, the example of Rabbi Akiba as the exemplary individual, worthy of all secrets, is given. He alone is able to hear all six voices of those who sing God's praises. Of lesser individuals, it is said that he who hears the first voice becomes insane. 'With the second voice, whoever hears it immediately becomes lost and never returns.' This is most likely a reference to apostasy.

> With the third voice – whoever hears it is seized by convulsions and dies immediately. With the fourth voice – who overhears it has his skull broken immediately and most of his ribs uprooted. With the fifth voice – whoever hears it is immediately spilled out like a flagon, and turns entirely into blood. With the sixth voice – whoever hears it is immediately seized by a stabbing in the heart; his heart makes a noise and turns his bowels upside down, turning his innards into water[32].

The *merkavah* texts continued to be studied well into the twelfth century and even into the thirteenth, with numerous commentaries connecting Rabbi Akiba's ascent as described in the Talmud to the *hekhalot* texts[33]. With the beginning of the Kabbalistic period, focus began to shift away from the *merkavah* mysteries to the details of what became known as the sefirotic Tree of Life. Although the *merkavah* mysteries were still seen as important, the

[30] *Hekhalot Rabbatai*, Chapter 19; see Kaplan, *Meditation and Kabbalah*, pp. 46-7.

[31] *Hekhalot Zutratei*; see Dan, *Ancient Jewish Mysticism*, p. 97.

[32] *Hekhalot Rabatai*; see Dan, *Ancient Jewish Mysticism*, p. 95.

[33] Chaim Vital (sixteenth century): *merkavah* practices ended about the fifth century. In his *Shaaray Kedushah*, he writes that those who desired to attain the levels necessary had to first undergo purification using the ashes of the Red Heifer (Num. 19:1-10). Ashes from the second Temple sacrifices remained and were used until just past the time of Rava. See Kaplan, *Meditation and Kabbalah*, p. 40.

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belief that such levels could no longer be attained meant that kabbalists needed to turn to new approaches. After the acceptance of the *Zohar* as an authentic work and, especially after the Expulsion from Spain in 1492, the *merkavah* mysteries began to attract less attention. Study of the *Zohar* and, later, of the writings of Rabbi Moses Cordovero and the teachings of Rabbi Isaac Luria gave rise to a new era of mysticism. The rabbis of the Talmud were not forgotten, but followers were able to learn at the feet of great scholars and kabbalists instead of by only studying texts written centuries before, opening the door for new innovations in ritual practice and mystical techniques. Yet the fourth and fifth centuries were the foundation and remain as texts worthy of modern study and practice. It is good to remember that the worthy few who ascended all the way were seated with the creatures of Ezekiel's vision – the Cherubim, the Ophanim, and the Chayot were shown 'wonders and powers, majesty and greatness, holiness, purity, terror, humility, and uprightness'[34].

[34] *Hekhalot Rabbatai*, Chapter 22; see Kaplan, *Meditation and Kabbalah*, p. 50.

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Dadisho Qatraya's *Commentary on Abba Isaiah*: The *Apophthegmata Patrum* Connection

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Dadisho of Qatar is a literary figure in the history of the Syriac-speaking church, but that is all. We do not know what we would like to know about the life and ministry of this spiritual writer of the Church of the East. It is certain that he wrote, and in particular commented upon other texts, and his comments were neither insignificant, nor brief[1].

The Life, As We Know It

Addai Scher first identified Dadisho as a unique personality, concluding by his citation of authors that he probably wrote in the last part of the seventh century[2]. The title of the *Commentary on the Book of Abba Isaiah* identifies him as a native of Qatar, part of the province of Bet Qatraye[3]. Nothing is indicated regarding his particular status in the church – whether he is a monk, abbot, teacher – although it is obvious he has had considerable experience in and commitment to the monastic life in the Church of the East. In his *Commentary on Abba Isaiah* (DQI), he notes that he wrote the first six discourses at the monasteries of Rabkennare, and discourses 7-13 at the monastery of the Holy Apostles, both situated in the mountains of Beth Huzzaye[4]. Dadisho lived last of all in the monastery of Rabban Shabbur, near the city of Shushtar[5].

Considering the depth of learning and scholarship in his *Commentary*, Dadisho must have been a teacher in the monastic setting. The tenor of his comments regarding the status quo of the monastic vocation demonstrate some disappointment at its deterioration from its former rigour.

[1] This paper originates as one part of a workshop conducted at the 14th International Conference on Patristics Studies entitled 'The Commentaries of Dadisho Qatraya (7th century) on the Desert Fathers'. The other papers were by David Phillips and Witold Witakowski.

[2] A. Scher, 'Notice sur la vie et les oeuvres de Dadiso Qatraya', *Journal asiatique* Series X, 7 (1906), 103-18, esp. 111.

[3] *Commentaire du Livre d'Abba Isaie (logoi I-XV) par Dadisho Qatraya (VIIIe s.)* ed. and tr. by René Draguet, CSCO 326-327, Syr 144-145 (Louvain, 1972), 1.1, p. 1 v(ersio) and t(extus) (abbreviation, DQI).

[4] DQI, 6.1, 80v (103t).

[5] Scher, 'Notice', 109, note 1.

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Literary Works

What we do know about Dadisho is that he wrote four books or treatises, all centring on the monastic and ascetic way of life.

The first work published was *A Treatise on Solitude*, from the manuscript Mingana 601, a series of short essays in which he deals with the development of stillness or *hesychia* (*shelyā*, ܫܠܝܐ) during the solitary's retreat lasting seven-days, eventually working up to a seven-week retreat[6]. These essays provide the background and theory, the manual perhaps, for Dadisho's principle concern in DQI – the revival of *shelyā*. Rhetorically he asks why Mar Babai the Great, the Church of the East theologian *par excellence*, did not press this issue himself? The answer is familiar: because back in Babai's day, things were more disciplined, not like they are now! Sure, monks try to pray, but they are always coming out of their cells, seeing who they can talk to, getting something special to eat – in other words, interrupting the continuity and efficacy of their retreat[7].

A monk begins with a seven-day retreat in which one does not emerge out of the cell until the following Sunday. Three essential things are necessary for proper *shelyā*, according to Dadisho[8]: (1) good intentions, or a sincere desire and commitment to make progress in this communion with God for its own sake with no thought of reward; (2) the performance of the various ascetical routines in one's cell in undisturbed silence; (3) perhaps the most important – one engaged in *shelyā* of seven days, and especially of seven weeks, needs a leader/teacher/spiritual director. No one else is allowed to speak to the solitary during his retreat.

Writing DQI at the request of a Mar Ahub, Dadisho mentions that he had written another book for a mutual friend, Mar Abkosh[9]. This is the 'Letter to Mar Abkosh on hesychia', a shorter work on the practical aspects of the life of prayer also found in Mingana 601, but omitted from the Woodbrooke Studies edition.

In the letter, Dadisho responds to the request of his friend Abkosh for spiritual direction by asking that he not visit him, lest Dadisho's own practice of *shelyā* be undermined. Assuring his friend that he has competent and eminent spiritual masters where he is living, Dadisho proceeds to outline the detriments to *shelyā* inherent in monks talking and listening to other people 'through the window [of one's cell]'. The theme of distraction from the practice of *shelyā* surfaces regularly in Dadisho's writing.

[6] Alphonse Mingana (ed.), *A Treatise on Solitude* by Dadisho Katraya, Woodbrooke Studies 7 (Cambridge, 1934), 70-143 (201-47 text) – Mingana Syriac 601.

[7] *A Treatise on Solitude*, 79 (ff. 5a-b, 202-3).

[8] *ibid.*, 83 (f. 8a, 205).

[9] DQI, 1.1, 1v (1t). Cf. 'Lettre de Dadisho Qatraya à Abkosh sur l'hésychia', tr. Antoine Guillaumont and Micheline Albert, in *Mémorial André-Jean Festugière: Antiquité païenne et chrétienne*, ed. E. Lucchesi and H.D. Saffrey, Cahiers d'Orientalisme 10, (Geneva, 1984), 235-45.

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Dadisho wrote two long commentaries on other ascetical texts. The first is the previously noted *Commentary on the Book or Asceticon of Abba Isaiah.* Isaiah was one of the legendary Egyptian desert fathers, learning his trade in the cells of Skete, but later migrating to Gaza in Palestine. The original *Asceticon* of Abba Isaiah was composed in Greek – recently translated into English by John Chryssavgis and Pachomios Penkett[10] – but would be translated in several stages into Syriac, Coptic, Arabic, Armenian, and Ge'ez[11]. Dadisho offers no evidence that he knew any other language than Syriac, for all the references and citations of earlier authors were available in Syriac, even if the source of every citation is not locatable.

It is not hard to understand why Dadisho chose to examine Abba Isaiah. The latter addresses monks under his care on a variety of topics, being especially concerned about the relationship between monks living in community – a situation analogous to Dadisho. An individual monk needs to be humble, kind, and hospitable to others, yet careful to maintain the integrity of his solitude. Dadisho's concerns did not dwell as much upon issues of living in community, but upon the preservation of solitude or stillness as the central attribute and activity of the solitaries[12].

The second major work, another commentary of a different order, is the focus of this workshop. The previously unedited *Commentary on the Paradise of the Fathers*[13] apparently marches through the text of the Syriac *Paradise of the Fathers* (which contains the *Lausiac History* of Palladius, the *Historia Monachorum in Aegypto*, and the *Apophthegmata Patrum*)[14]. The commentary is structured as a series of questions and answers generally directed by a group of monks or brothers to an old man or elder (*saba*). A wide range of issues are treated, from trivia regarding personalities in the collection to extended expositions of why did Abba so-and-so say such and such, and what did he really mean. The apophthegmata themselves consist of short stories and aphorisms by and about famous ascetics in fourth- and fifth-century Egypt. The shape and order of the collections of the *Apophthegmata Patrum* is quite varied, and the lack of a critical edition is felt keenly here[15]. Which version Dadisho utilized as the basis for his commentary is beyond us at this point and must be delayed

[10] *Abba Isaiah of Scetis: Ascetic Discourses*, ed. and tr. John Chryssavgis and Pachomios (Robert) Penkett (Kalamazoo, 2002).

[11] *Ibid.*, 33-4.

[12] By the late seventh century, *īḥīdāyā/īḥīdāyūtā* (ܝܚܝܕܝܐ/ܝܚܝܕܝܘܬܐ) are the terms used to designate people committed to a celibate religious life living in community – monks, monasteries.

[13] Paul Bedjan did publish a non-critical edition of an abbreviated form of this work in *Acta Martyrum et Sanctorum. Tomus septimus vel Paradisus Patrum* (Paris, 1897).

[14] Cf. Nicholas Sims-Williams, 'Dadisho Qatraya's Commentary on the Paradise of the Fathers', *AB* 112 (1994), 33-64. This excellent article has provided the impetus and road markers for our venture.

[15] Cf. Chiara Farragiana di Sarzana, 'Apophthegmata Patrum: Some Crucial Points of these Textual Transmissions and the Problem of a Critical Edition', *SP* XXIX (1997), 455-67.

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to another day. It is probable that he was so well versed in the stories that a specific edition of the text was not always necessary for him.

Principles of Commentary

The first thing necessary for a commentary is a consensus that a specific text is worthy of canonical status in a community, along with the recognition that this text is not plainly understandable to all who wish and need to read it – for example, the bible! The consensus does not have to be great. Only Dadisho commented upon the *Paradise of the Fathers* and there was only one other anonymous commentary on the Book of Abba Isaiah[16].

Commentaries have provided one incalculably valuable service for numerous ancient texts: citations of works that are otherwise lost to posterity. A prime example for Syriac studies is Ephrem's *Commentary on the Diatessaron* that is an important source for the actual lost text of the Diatessaron[17]. A significant number of the patristic citations Dadisho supplies in the DQI cannot be attested among the respective authors' known works.

Dadisho reveres the position of Abba Isaiah as one of the original mentors of the spiritual and monastic life, and so attempts to restrict himself to explaining the sense and meaning of Isaiah's counsel. But occasionally he overwhelms Abba Isaiah's agenda with his own by means of copious patristic citations, as well as many tales and parables from the *Paradise of the Fathers* and *Apophthegmata Patrum*.

Dadisho's purpose in his commentary is to reinforce and advocate a style of monastic life he believes is the most effective for the solitaries or monks. Like Abba Isaiah, his intended audience appears to be the rank and file of the monasteries. Sometimes Abba Isaiah says exactly the right thing and Dadisho simply affirms it; other times, Abba Isaiah is set off to the side while Dadisho addresses his contemporary concerns.

Initially, Dadisho examines and explains Abba Isaiah's Discourses 1-5 'phrase by phrase'. At the beginning of Discourse 6, Dadisho announces that he assumes the reader has now perceived the sense of Abba Isaiah's teaching, so he will focus henceforth on explaining only obscure and difficult passages[18].

Dadisho's hermeneutic principle is to look for the sense[19] in the passage, that is, its general meaning that can be translated into another situation. He

[16] R. Draguet (ed. and tr.) *Commentaire anonyme du Livre d'abba Isaie (fragments)*, CSCO 336-337, Syr 150-151 (Louvain, 1973).

[17] Louis Leloir, *St. Ephrem: commentaire de l'Évangile Concordant: text syriaque (Manuscrit Chester Beatty 709)*, Chester Beatty Monographs 8a, b (Dublin, 1963-1990).

[18] DQI, 6.1, 80v (103t).

[19] *sūkālā* (ܣܘܟܠܐ).

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does not appreciate the approach of the *eskōlāyē*, 'the school people', who spend their time mulling and arguing over words, often ignoring the meaning and edifying nature of the text[20].

Still, Dadisho likes words and will fuss over them in full view of his reader. An instance is his discussion of the difference between 'Abba' or father in the natural sense and 'Abba' in the spiritual sense as spiritual father and director of souls, a 'desert father'. The difference in Syriac is a matter of the placement of the diacritical point and therefore the pronunciation. The natural father has the soft *rūkkākhā* point below the letter *bēth* with the resulting aspirated 'Awa'/'Ava' pronunciation. The spiritual desert Father has the hard *qūshshāyā* point above the letter, so '*Abba*'[21]. The latter is meant to be a sign of the humility of a small child, of one's utter devotion and affection for his teacher.

Dadisho holds in tension two approaches to scripture. The first is the historical interpretation of scripture, by which he characterizes most of the biblical interpretation of Theodore of Mopsuestia that emphasizes the literal sense of the text in Antiochene tradition. The second is the spiritual interpretation of scripture[22]. By spiritual interpretation, Dadisho is not leaning towards the Alexandrine allegorical method of exegesis. It is an ascetically directed hermeneutic that understands the crux of the gospel to be fulfilled in the monastic/solitary way of life. The proper interpretation of scripture illuminates the pursuit of the way of perfection, so therefore, this hermeneutic applies only to the solitaries who pursue perfection. The practice and nurture of *shelyā* is maintained by Dadisho as the focus of spiritual interpretation, the living experience of the fullness of the kingdom and the presence of God.

Nevertheless, Dadisho did not believe solitaries and others should spend much time exegeting passages of scripture because such activity leads to debates, arguments, and disharmony in the community. Besides the acrimony created, these debates inhibit the development of stillness (*shelyā*) in the individual solitary. The safer way to approach problematic scriptural passages is to consult an elder and heed his conclusions. In the interim, Dadisho suggests that the solitaries would benefit more by discussing what the Fathers say[23]. We do agree.

Of course, Dadisho cites the bible continually throughout his commentary, often achieved through the citation of scripture by a Father or inclusion in an apophthegm.

And of these patristic citations there is no end. The erudition of Dadisho is immense, and it pours out page after page, providing a vast compendium of

[20] Cf. DQI, 10.2, 108v (140t) ܠܐ ܡܫܡܥ ܠܗ.

[21] DQI, 5.2, 80v (103t).

[22] DQI, 7.14, 99v (129t); Luise Abramowski, 'Dadisho Qatraya and his Commentary on the Book of the Abba Isaiah', *The Harp* 4 (1991) 67-83, esp. 77. Historical interpretation (ܦܫܛܐ ܕܬܐܘܪܝܐ); 'he does not exegete according to the Spirit' (ܠܐ ܡܦܫܪ ܠܐ ܒܪܘܚܐ).

[23] DQI, 6.4, 82v (106t).

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patristic citations on a range of topics. Evagrius, Theodore of Mopsuestia, and the Pseudo-Macarian author arguably could all be the most frequent and influential for his work. Mark the Solitary, John Chrysostom, Babai the Great, and Athanasius are not given short shrift by any means.

Almost as numerous are the tales from the *Apophthegmata Patrum*[24] and the Syriac *Paradise of the Fathers*[25] to which Dadisho resorts liberally. The particular focus of this workshop is upon his use of these stories to illustrate his contentions about the nature and discipline of the monastic and ascetic life. The narrative structure of the apophthegmata demonstrates in living colour the sense and meaning of what Abba Isaiah and Dadisho are talking about[26]. The stories typically rest, not upon a word or maxim, but upon a physical action of one or several of the characters. Solitaries may have had too many words bombarding their brains and spirits; what they need are examples of God-filled actions.

The Book of Abba Isaiah[27]

The textual history of the *Book of Abba Isaiah* is complex. The Greek text is accepted as the original, but it made its way into Syriac in the sixth century. Since the origin and reference point for Abba Isaiah is Skete, one might hope for a Coptic recension, but only fragments have been discovered[28]. There are also fragments in Ge'ez[29], as well as an Arabic fragment[30].

René Draguet has produced critical editions and French translations of both the Syriac *Asceticon of Abba Isaiah*[31] and Dadisho's *Commentary on the Book of Abba Isaiah*. He has identified five recensions of the former in the Syriac

[24] *The Sayings of the Desert Fathers: The Alphabetical Collection*, tr. Benedicta Ward (Kalamazoo, 1975). Abbreviation, Alph.

[25] *The Book of Paradise*, 2 vols., Lady Meux Manuscripts 6 (London, 1904), Syriac text; *The Paradise or Garden of the Holy Fathers*, tr. E.A. Wallis Budge, 2 vols (London, 1907), revised English translation.

[26] 'Narrative preaching' attempts the same thing by engaging listeners in congregations in a story, in which the listeners appropriate roles, rather than working their way through propositions.

[27] Cf. Derwas J. Chitty, *The Desert a City* (Crestwood, NY: St. Vladimir's Seminary Press, 1966) 73-7; and *idem*, 'Abba Isaiah', *JThSt* n.s. 22 (1971), 47-72.

[28] Antoine Guillaumont, *L'Asceticon copte de l'abbé Isaïe*, (Bibliothèque d'Études coptes 5 (Cairo, 1956); cf. also Youhanna Nessim Youssef, 'Un Complément de l'Asceticon Copte de l'Abbé *Isaïe*', *VC* 55 (2001), 187-90.

[29] Victor Arras, (ed. and tr.), *Asceticon*, CSCO 458-459, Aeth 77-78 (Louvain, 1984).

[30] J.-M. Sauget, 'Les fragments de l'Asceticon de l'abbé Isaïe de Scete du Vatican arabe 71', *OrChr* 48 (1964), 235-59. Also important is J.-M. Sauget, *Une traduction arabe de la collection d'Apophthegmata Patrum de 'Enānīšō': Étude du ms. Paris arabe 253 et des témoins parallèles*, (CSCO 495, Subs 78 (Louvain, 1987).

[31] R. Draguet, *Les cinq recensions de l'Ascéticon syriaque d'abba Isaïe*, CSCO 289-90 (syriac), 293-4 (tr.) = Syr 120-123 (Louvain, 1968).

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translations that demonstrate a gradual accretion of materials to the original Greek text[32]. What Dadisho probably accepted as the very words of Abba Isaiah was not exactly the case in every instance.

There is also the problem of the availability of the full text of the work. The Greek recension includes twenty-nine discourses or *logoi*[33]. The forty-four witnesses to the primary Syriac recension (S) generally have twenty-six discourses, with a few manuscripts adding *logoi* 27-29, attributing these sometimes to Evagrius, sometimes to Isaiah[34]. Draguet's Syriac edition of the *Asceticon* only goes as far as Discourse 13, while Dadisho's *Commentary* reaches the 15th Discourse.

Dadisho apologizes for his tardiness in delivering the manuscript because of personal illness[35]. Draguet wonders out loud whether Dadisho's admitted health problems finally caught up with him and prematurely ended his commentary at fifteen discourses. If this hunch is correct, then one can assume DQI was Dadisho's last written work. In several places, Dadisho did make mention of his aim to finish the full project of twenty-six discourses[36]. While we do not have the complete Syriac Abba Isaiah or the full extent of Dadisho's commentary, we still have plenty of material from which to work.

The *Paradise of the Fathers* in the *Commentary on the Book of Abba Isaiah, Vita Isaiah*

Draguet's edition does not begin with the text, but with the author. A short vita is included that is more concerned to demonstrate what kind of soul Abba Isaiah possessed than to detail the usual historical and biographical items[37]. In this way, Dadisho's readers would be convinced that Isaiah's words were validated by his humility, ascetical rigour, and wisdom.

In true desert father tradition, one never becomes a saint completely on one's own merits. No one becomes an abba without an abba, for the master–disciple relationship is necessary to learn the vocation and maintain humility. Therefore, no life of a desert father can properly be described without reference to his own abba. In Isaiah's case, his master was Achila, and Dadisho intertwines their stories as if the character traits of one are shared by the other – which is the point.

[32] *Les cinq recensions*, CSCO 289, Syr 120, especially 10*-70*.
[33] *Abba Isaiah of Scetis*, 31-5.
[34] *Les cinq recensions*, 28*-30*.
[35] DQI, 14.2.
[36] Draguet, in CSCO 327/145, 6*.
[37] DQI, 1.2-5, 2-8v (3-10t). However, the question of whether this Vita was really edited by Dadisho is left open by Draguet (CSCO 327/145, 14*-15*). The Vita in his CSCO edition is from an isolated folio in BL Add. 17213 (10th-11th c. (=L)). The editor appears to have assembled Isaiah materials from the Apophthegmata.

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Dadisho first wants to emphasize that this author Isaiah, who is writing about the monastic, ascetical life, was himself a gifted and disciplined ascetic. One day Isaiah, was visited by Abba Achila and caught in the act of eating. Asked just what it was he was eating, Isaiah showed that it was dry bread and salt, but so dried out he had to add a little water. 'Oh, come and see Isaiah,' laughed Achila, 'who eats the "soup of Skete"!'[38]

Food again is the context when Isaiah is visited by a monk while he is cooking lentils. The water has just started to boil when Isaiah takes out the lentils. The visitor expresses alarm that the lentils have not been properly cooked. Isaiah retorted, 'Haven't you seen the fire? Isn't that enough?'[39] Food is treated ambivalently in the ascetic traditions of the desert. It is intended to meet minimum nutritional requirements, not comfort or pleasure.

An Egyptian sent out a brother to distribute apples to the Fathers of Skete. This brother knocked at the cell of Achila. Achila remonstrated with him, 'Were these apples of gold, I would not want you to knock at my cell or at those of any of the other brothers'[40]. The theme of sitting in one's cell engaged in *shelyā*, undisturbed by the distractions of the world, is established here and will be returned to countless times in the commentary.

Apples are food, by the way. So it is not surprising that the next apophthegm finds Isaiah sitting at table eating with a group of brothers who carry on an animated conversation. Isaiah admonishes them to maintain their interior prayer[41] and exercise of the Spirit. He adds an encouraging example: 'I know a brother sitting with us at table whose interior prayer went up to God like a flame'[42].

Food in a monastery is serious business, especially at the common meal – where such apophthegmata might be read. Dadisho intends that meals will be more than consumption, but alive with the admonitions to holy living of the Abba Isaiahs.

The last episode has nothing to do with food. Three men are travelling together to visit a holy man. Suddenly, each of the three receives divine revelations or visions, which the first two men relate to the others. Isaiah is the third of these men, and according to the editor, it is obvious that Isaiah's revelation is the most sublime, but he humbled himself and did not mention his vision, simply sharing in the joy of the others[43]. Humility is the beginning and end of all things for the solitaries.

[38] DQI, 1.3, 4v (5t); Alph Achila 3. Also Budge, *Paradise*, II, 686 #243. *zawmā dEsqītā* (ܙܰܘܡܳܐ ܕܐܣܩܺܝܛܳܐ).

[39] DQI, 1.3, 5v (6t); Alph Isaiah 6; *Paradise*, II, 449 #65.

[40] DQI, 1.3, 3v (5t); Alph Achila 2; *Paradise*, II, 437 #14.

[41] *ṣalūtā kasyūtā* (ܨܠܘܬܳܐ ܟܣܝܘܬܳܐ).

[42] DQI, 1.4, 6v (8t); Alph Isaiah 4; *Paradise*, II, 417.

[43] DQI, 1.5, 6-7v (8-9t); *The Lives of the Desert Fathers: The Historia Monachorum in Aegypto*, tr. Norman Russell, introd. Benedicta Ward (Kalamazoo, 1980), Sourous. The Syriac text offers a different interpretation of the Greek text, rendering Isaiah as the hero rather than Anouph/Nouf, the monk whom the three solitaries visit.

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Antony, First of the Solitaries

Antony the Great occupies a position of honour and authority in Dadisho's ascetical hierarchy. He is 'the first of the solitaries'[44], his practices and ideas being the fundamentals of the monastic life towards which Dadisho persistently directs beginning solitaries. Antony's words and exploits are drawn upon by Dadisho throughout the Commentary, usually from the long opening section of the Alphabetical Collection of the *Apophthegmata Patrum*[45], but also from the Syriac *Life of Antony*[46]. The latter was not included by 'Enanisho in his *Paradise of the Fathers*, although E.A.W. Budge did add the book to his huge volume of the *Paradise of the Fathers*[47].

On several occasions, Dadisho recalls the saying attributed to Antony, 'The cell of the solitary is the furnace of Babylon ... It is the column of luminous cloud that led the Israelites into the Promised Land'[48]. It all happens in the cell – one of the most reiterated principles of the desert. Here and there in the Commentary, one can hear Dadisho complain how new innovations and situations consistently work against this principle of monastic life. Luise Abramowski caught Dadisho's impatience with the influx of new hymns into community worship that would compromise the solitary's time of *shelyā* in his cell[49].

Antony is the exemplar of all that a monk should be aspiring towards. Dadisho observed that when those who are perfect and righteous leave this world, their faith being evident both to angels and devils, the angels will say to the devils – as they said regarding Antony – 'by his ways of life you are despised'[50].

For Beginners

Discourse 10 of the *Asceticon* of Abba Isaiah deals with rules for beginning monks, a list of eighty aphorisms and case situations to enable the fledgling solitary to avoid problems in his vocation[51]. This should be Dadisho's territory, but in his first sentence he declares that it is all plainly understandable. Nevertheless, he has a page or two to fill out, so he begins by denouncing the efforts of some *eskolaye* – highly educated men with plenty of words, but no

[44] *rīšā īḥīdāyē* (ܪܝܫܐ ܝܚܝܕܝܐ).

[45] *The Sayings of the Desert Fathers*, Antony 1-38.

[46] R. Draguet (ed. and tr.), *La vie primitive de s. Antoine conservée en syriaque*, CSCO 417 (Louvain, 1980). Cf. Fumihiko F. Takeda, 'The Syriac Version of the *Life of Antony*: A Meeting Point of Egyptian Monasticism with Syriac Native Asceticism', *OCA* 256 (1998), 185-94.

[47] Budge, *The Paradise of the Fathers*.

[48] DQI, 13.3, 136v (176-7t); *Paradise*, II, 446 #54. Anonymous, attributed to Antony.

[49] Abramowski, 'Dadisho Qatraya' 69-71. DQI, 13.6, 143-4v (185-6t).

[50] DQI, 15.13, 205v (266t); *Life of Antony* 65.

[51] *Les cinq recensions* Logoi 10 (184-120t).

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actions. Dadisho has heard some of them openly mock Abba Isaiah as a mere teacher of young students. Dadisho does not think much of their discernment, stating that this discourse was quite sophisticated and obviously intended for bishops, professors, and sages when they begin teaching the monastic arts[52].

Dadisho lifts up three notable monks as exemplars: John Chrysostom[53], Evagrius, and Abba Arsenius.

Chrysostom, of course, did not make it into the *Paradise of the Fathers*. Dadisho praises his early education in the monastic life, but laments that he largely did it in solitary fashion, rather than in a larger community of monks. Chrysostom had an aversion to eating[54] from that early period which might have been checked if he had lived among other monks. Dadisho advocates the corrective measures of community living, for physically solitary endeavour is only for the most mature, not for the beginner.

For Evagrius, Dadisho narrates the famous apophthegm of the former's visit to an elder to ask for a 'word' of salvation. The old man responded that if one wants to be saved, don't speak before being spoken to. Evagrius was struck to the heart and answered, 'I have read many books, but never have I received such a teaching before'[55]. Wisdom is not all written down in a book, but comes out of the heart and experience.

Dadisho completes the trilogy with a couple of stories regarding Arsenius that complement the first two. Arsenius was heard consulting an old Egyptian monk regarding his own ascetic discipline. Overhearing, Evagrius questioned Arsenius, 'How come you who have been educated in Greek and Latin ask this old peasant about your way of life?' 'That's true,' Arsenius replied, 'I do know Greek and Latin, but I have not yet learned the alphabet of this old peasant'[56].

On another occasion, someone asked Arsenius why with all their wonderful secular education they accomplish nothing (in the spiritual life), but these old Egyptians gain so many virtues. 'That's because these old peasants acquire their virtues through hard labour'[57].

Dadisho concludes this supposed commentary on Abba Isaiah's rules for beginning monks by observing that this famous trinity all received or should have received proper discipline and education at the beginning of their vocations[58]. A persistent theme is Dadisho's insistence on learning and develop-

[52] DQI, 10.2, 108v (140t).

[53] *pūmā ddahbā* (ܦܘܡܐ ܕܕܗܒܐ).

[54] *senyat mal'ās* (ܣܢܝܬ ܡܠܥܐ).

[55] DQI, 10.4, 109v (141t); Alph Euprepius 7 – but Evagrius in Syriac; also *Paradise*, II, 447 #58.

[56] DQI, 10.5, 109-10v (142t); Alph Arsenius 6 – Greek and Syriac have an anonymous elder question Arsenius, not Evagrius. *Paradise*, II, 676 #218.

[57] DQI, 10.6, 110v (142t); Alph Arsenius 5 – in this place the questioner is anonymous, while in Syriac it is Evagrius. *Paradise*, II, 676 #217.

[58] DQI, 10.6, 110v (142t).

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ment in the midst of the community of elders and peers, abbas and brothers. Affirming Abba Isaiah's directives, Dadisho simply supplied his own narrative examples, rather than referring to a list of imperative statements and propositions.

Interpreting Scripture

If even the great saints and abbas require elementary instruction regarding the solitary life at the beginning of their pilgrimages, just as necessary is a humble and careful development in the mysteries of holy scripture. As noted above, Dadisho is wary of novices getting disoriented in the ambiguities of the bible with resulting interpersonal conflict, the building up of pride in one's own intellectual abilities, as well as the genesis of heresy. In his commentary on the 13th Discourse, Dadisho illustrates his perspective with three tales.

Dadisho cites Abba Poemen:

'When a brother is sitting in his cell in *shelyā* (and) wishes to understand some sense of the Scriptures, while he has not yet attained the level of that phrase, instead of the grace of the Holy Spirit, it is the working of an evil spirit that instructs him'[59].

Dadisho explains that the brother had not bothered to humble himself to go enquire of the meaning from someone more schooled in the Bible. As well, he had not wanted to wait for the maturity and purity of heart through which the Holy Spirit might eventually grant him the light of grace to understand the sense of the text. Being too self-assured in the beginning of his vocation, he pretended to be enlightened by his *shelyā*, ascetical labours, and prayer, and to understand the passage by the grace of the Spirit. It is not the right spirit that helps this young solitary to read scripture.

So it is not wise that a young solitary attempt to delve the depths of scripture before he has been granted the grace of the Spirit. Dadisho offers the story of a monk coming to see Antony in order to be instructed regarding a phrase in the Book of Leviticus. This is the way it is supposed to be done. However, Antony did not know the answer, really did not have a clue, 'because the scriptures and their interpretations were not read to him.' However, he did not want the brother to have to go elsewhere, and it was too far anyway to travel to the nearest brothers. Up the mountain he climbed and prayed to God that Moses be sent to instruct him in the phrase[60]. And so it happened.

[59] DQI, 13.6, 144v (187t); cf. J.C. Guy, *Recherches sur la tradition grecque des Apophthegmata Patrum* (Brussels: 1963), 95 #677 – anonymous. Dadisho apparently knows an otherwise unknown tradition attributing the logia to Poemen. *Paradise*, II, 639 #699.

[60] DQI, 13.6, 145v (187-8t); Alph Antony 26; *Paradise*, II, 565 #468.

[61] Cf. Mingana, *A Treatise on Solitude*.

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Finally, a tale about an anonymous brother who wanted to know the sense of a phrase in scripture. He did not want to travel the long distance to another monk for instruction, so he decided to fast and pray and embark on a retreat of seven weeks[61]. His hope was that such herculean asceticism would entice either an angel to come to reveal the meaning to him, or that God would reveal it to him through an inner illumination. Nothing happened, no insight. Finally, he had to relent and at the very instant he stepped outside his cell to go seek advice from another Father, an angel appeared and enlightened him. The angel delivered the message from God that only when he demonstrated his humility by asking for help did he receive help[62].

Dadisho's conclusion is that if a monk underwent such rigorous asceticism in search of the sense of scripture and was not rewarded, how can we much lesser athletes of the Spirit learn anything without humility?[63] At the very end of the Commentary – as we have it – Dadisho refers to Abba Sisoes the Theban for what appears to be the final word. Abba Sisoes, when being asked what entails the perfection of the solitary, answered, 'Humility'[64].

The broad strokes of Dadisho's ascetical hermeneutic in DQI are apparent. The necessary discipline at the centre of monastic life is the devoted practice of *shelyā* or *hesychia*. All other activities and ideas are judged as to whether they build up or distract from the practice of *shelyā*.

Shelyā, however, is physically and spiritually exhausting and requires the support of and accountability to the community. Dadisho is not loathe to reveal the errors of those who attempt to be true solitaries. Even the greatest of the hermits needed an abba to help them understand the vagaries of the scriptures and the pitfalls of the ascetic way of perfection. As Dadisho interprets the path of Abba Isaiah, he makes it clear that none of these qualities can develop without genuine humility.

Commentary on the *Paradise of the Fathers* (DQC)

Dadisho Qatraya wrote one more commentary on a text of monastic and ascetic spirituality, the Syriac *Paradise of the Fathers* compiled by 'Enanisho[65]. Having examined the commentary on Abba Isaiah, we are in a better position to understand Dadisho's method of interpretation as well as his favourite literary resources. However, the *Commentary on the Paradise of the Fathers* (DQC) assumes a quite different shape than that of DQI.

In DQI, Dadisho follows the text more or less in order, sometimes phrase by phrase, at other times simply noting obscurities or his own interests and pro-

[62] DQI, 13.6, 145v (188t); *Paradise*, II, 565 #468.

[63] DQI 13.6, 145-6v (188t).

[64] DQI, 15.40, 237v (306t); Alph Sisoes 13, 42; *Paradise*, II, 569 #477.

[65] Cf. David Phillips' paper for details regarding the nature of the text and the development of a critical edition.

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pensities. In DQC, Dadisho also follows the parent text, but fits his commentary into a formulaic series of questions and answers. In DQI, the tales of the Desert Fathers were employed as illustrative material for Dadisho's explication of spiritual discipline; in DQC, the tales are no longer illustrations per se, but the direct object of Dadisho's commentary.

Usually, 'the brothers' ask a question of 'an old man/elder' (*saba*). One instance, however, has the *saba* identified as Philoxenus of Mabbug[66] (to whom the Ge'ez/Ethiopic version attributes the work[67]). That the Jacobite/henophysite champion was identified as an elder worthy of explaining topics dear to the heart of a Church of the East theologian is evidence of the transconfessional sharing of spiritual theology in the Syriac-speaking churches[68].

Types of Questions and Answers

In DQC, Dadisho deals with some of the same themes and illustrations as he treated and used in DQI, but moves in different directions. There appear to be several types of question and answer configurations in the segments of the text we currently have available.

First, there are the 'trivia' questions, as in DQC 1.19: 'How many Fathers were there who were named Ammonius?' The teacher (*malpānā*) responds that there are six and lists each with a brief identifying characteristic or anecdote[69].

Second are the questions that ask for an explanation of an apophthegm's story that is unclear to them. Often it is a particular report, as in DQC 1.34: 'Explain what Macarius meant, "I never gave the eucharist to Mark the Mourner (*abīlā*), but an angel used to give it to him from the altar ...."' Dadisho discusses the custom of the abbot alone acting as the priest even if there are others available. James the Lame performed the duties for sixty years, he recalls. However, Dadisho never answers the direct question about the angelic appearance.

In DQC 1.33, the brothers ask about Eustathius, who dried up his body so much through ascetical disciplines that the sun shone through his ribs. The Elder responds that he had seen someone like this himself, so he can believe it about Eustathius. Dadisho concludes that we can and should believe these amazing things about holy people if the reports come from a reliable source.

[66] DQC 1.78; BL Add. 17264, ff. 44r-45r.

[67] British Library Oriental 759, 760, 761; Uppsala Ethiopic 7; also 10 MSS on microfilm in the Hill Monastic Manuscript Library, St John's University, Collegeville, Minnesota: EMML 15.3, 418, 1387.1, 1836.2, 1848.1, 2100.3, 2127.3, 2157, 2197, 2837.2.

[68] Or, as David Phillips notes, at DQC 1.32 that the inclusion of Philoxenus' name was a Jacobite revision. Therefore, the reverse situation to the above may apply: the Jacobites were willing to receive and read a work known to have been written by a theologian of the Church of the East.

[69] Cf. also DQC 1.23 on Macarius.

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'Why did Abba Macarius not spit for sixty years?' (DQC 1.27) is a serious question. Dadisho answers equally seriously that Macarius never wanted to spit on the ground after he had eaten and drunk the body and blood of Christ. No one of you, Dadisho admonishes, should be so inconsiderate and careless. What you do with your body matters.

Third, the brothers question a particular phrase or word used in a story. DQC 1.29 finds the brothers asking about the conversation between Paphnutius, Jacob the Lame, and Evagrius regarding offences 'by the senses' and 'by the whole body'. Dadisho answers with short anecdotes of everyday experience to explain each type.

DQC 1.30 asks how it is possible to have the human mind continually, unceasingly, with God. What are the 'thought' and 'deed' of the fear of God upon which the mind meditates? Dadisho responds with his theology and practice of prayer and asceticism. In other answers, Dadisho treats at some length the characteristics and attainment of purity of heart (1.31), the nature of Paradise (1.21), the role of monasticism in supporting and caring for the weak as well as the strong (1.24), and explains why a certain abba Elijah founded and administered a convent of 300 sisters despite many temptations and indiscretions against which he had to battle (1.28).

We must return to the larger question of who asked and answered all these questions and why. Were these questions handed down by tradition, or were they questions Dadisho had garnered from the younger solitaries he taught and lived with? Some questions are rather simplistic, others very complex and astute. There is no immediate solution, but after reviewing the strategies of DQI, I believe generally Dadisho heard similar questions from within his community or even thought up the questions at first hand. His purpose was to bolster rigorous asceticism in contemporary monasteries, and he taught with examples from the *Apophthegmata Patrum* to demonstrate just how to live out one's life in holy fulfilment. In the case of DQC, all the brothers probably knew the *Paradise of the Fathers* reasonably well, so the purpose of the Commentary is to help the beginning solitaries to comprehend the depth and practicality of what the Fathers did and said. Such a diverse range of questions suggests a diverse community asking these questions, for monasteries were no more homogeneous than the rest of society.

Where to Go and What Else to Do

'The perfection of the ways of life [of the solitaries] is the love of God and of people' is Draguet's choice for the epitome of Dadisho's dominant theme[70].

[70] DQI, 12.2, 125v (162.5-6t). ܗܕܐ ܣܘܟܠܐ ܕܚܝܐ ܕܡܢ ܫܘܪܝ ܕܐܠܗܐ ܘܕܒܢܝ ܐܢܫܐ.

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This is accomplished in the first place through the monk's persistent engagement in *shelyā* (*hesychia* retreat, solitude, stillness). He is very anxious to bolster and retain vigorous practice of this life of prayer as the essential activity of the solitary. It occupies the first place: all else must wait for its appropriate time.

Our English translation of solitary – though literal – sends us off in the wrong direction. Dadisho lives in the midst of a community of brothers who are attempting to live the perfect life in this world, and that means with a bunch of imperfect people, not to mention the monastery of some almost perfect spiritual directors and abbas. We are not allowed to be alone!

The frequent use of apophthegmata illustrates how various holy men embodied these principles through their actions, and usually that meant with other people. Graham Gould's monograph *The Desert Fathers in Monastic Community*[71], poses the tension held between solitude and interaction, between relationships and prayer that remains alive here with Dadisho, as it does with all contemplative and religious communities.

Gould relates the tale of a brother asking Abba Sisoes about what he should do when he comes to an *agapè* meal and 'they detain me' – that is, involve him in conversation and personal relationships that prevent him from returning to the solitary life of prayer. Sisoes begins to answer, 'It is a difficult business ...,' but is interrupted by another person questioning him, and never gets back to the brother[72]. It is a difficult business, not a terribly original answer, but one to which I would like to hear Dadisho's response.

There is a lot more to be done. Our principal conundrum is the nature of the *Apophthegmata Patrum* and *Paradise of the Fathers* that Dadisho knows and loves so well, and has used in an enlightening way for illustration and instruction. Just what is the authentic shape of the Syriac and the Greek *Apophthegmata Patrum* is being worked on by a number of scholars.

The general trajectory for Syriac translation was to move from Syriac to Arabic to Ge'ez. Dr Kate Leeming is starting to work on one of the principal witnesses of the Arabic translation of DQC[73] for this project.

DQC was eventually translated into Ge'ez, and there are a number of manuscripts, varying widely in the order and number of the questions and answers[74]. Getachew Haile, the cataloguer of the Ethiopian Monastic Manuscript Library at St John's University, Collegeville, Minnesota, showed me a

[71] Cf. Graham Gould, *The Desert Fathers in Monastic Community* (Oxford, 1993), 139-66 and 167-82.

[72] Gould, 142. Alph Sisoes 2.

[73] We are focusing on St Petersburg Asiatic Museum Arab. 8; cf. V. Rosen, *Notice sommaires des manuscrites arabes du Musée Asiatique*, I (St Petersburg, 1881), 6-12.

[74] W. Witakowski's contribution to this workshop focuses several selected MSS (BL Or. 760, BL Or. 759, Upps. Et. 7) to establish the nature of these versions.

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printed Amharic edition of our text published in Addis Ababa, but it is not a critical edition – no manuscripts behind the edition are listed. Dr Haile thought it was printed from memory.

Yet Ge'ez is important for BL Add. 17263 and 17264 because both contain significant lacunae for which Ge'ez manuscripts might supply the missing material. We have a few more holes to fill.

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Ephrem's Theology of Humour*

Thomas KOONAMMAKKAL, Kottayam

Humour is 'that quality of action speech, or writing, which excites amusement. It is the faculty of perceiving what is ludicrous or amusing, or of expressing it; jucase imagination or treatment of a subject'[1]. Theological speculations are not always fond of this quality, especially in the patristic period. Ephrem (*c.* 306-373) is one of the exceptions in this area. He is fond of explaining theological topics in an amusing manner; with an element of unexpectedness he combines amusement, delight, surprise, ridicule, liveliness, sarcasm, irony, satire, cutting remarks, sharp criticism, taunting and provoking reproaches, challenging scorn, and so forth. He relishes his arguments and invites his audience and readers to enjoy a smile or even a laugh. Ephrem is often a smiling poet, though his later Syriac and Greek biographers prefer a bleak, ascetic depiction. The lively arguments, personal warmth, and persuading words depict a very cheerful personality behind the authentic Ephremic corpus. This is only an introduction to the theology of humour in Ephremic works.

J.B. Segal writes about Ephremic poetry, 'His poems are turgid, humourless, and repetitive ...'[2]. But one need not necessarily agree with this grim verdict.

> If one thing is true about Ephrem's poetry, it is that it has occasionally a penetrating sense of humour and depth of thought ... He is full of wit, humour and personal warmth ... [with an] inborn sense of humour occasionally directed at himself as well as at his theological adversaries ...[3].

* Abbreviations:

C Diat	Commentary on Diatessaron
C Nis	Carmina Nisibena
HcH	Hymns against Heresies
HcJ	Hymns against Julian
HdE	Hymns on Church
HdF	Hymns on Faith
HdN	Hymns on Nativity
HdV	Hymns on Virginity
Pr Ref	Prose Refutations
SdF	Discourses on Faith

[1] *The Shorter Oxford English Dictionary*, third edn revides (Oxford, 1973), I, 996.

[2] J.B. Segal, *Edessa, The Blessed City* (Oxford, 1970), p. 89.

[3] T. Koonnammakkal, 'Changing Views on Ephrem', *Christian Orient* 14.3 (1993), 116, 117, 122.

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Jacob of Serugh (d. 521) depicted Ephrem as the watchdog of the flock of Christ[4]. This is an image which Ephrem is happy to apply to himself as well as to his theological adversaries[5]. The sick dogs (ܟܠܒܐ ܚܠܝܡܐ) of Mani attack everyone though they are unable to break bread[6]. Mani taught that the souls of dogs are from God[7]. Marcion became rabid and went astray, and Mani followed suit[8].

I have heard that dog loves the door of its master;
It is also governed by its belly, for it is bribed and perverted.
There are many dumb watchdogs barking against the very household.
They helped the wolves while plundering.
Sheepdogs disfigured the flock.
And they attacked, dragged away the sheep, lambs, and ewes[9].

In contrast with heretics who tore away the sheep, Ephrem is a diligent and faithful sheepdog[10]. Heretics are those who steal the sheep of Christ. Valentinos stole sheep; so too Quq. With cunning Bardaisan stole them. Marcion sifted them, leaving them desolate. Mani fell upon them and plundered what he could. Ephrem concludes, 'One mad dog bit another'[11], and the rabies of heresy spread like wildfire. Heretics are like false teachers and weeds; these are seeds of disputes[12]. The river Daisan brings flood, and after the flood Edessa is full of thirstles and tares. So too the Church of Edessa, because of the son of Daisan (ܒܪ ܕܝܣܢ), the Daisanite weed (ܣܝܢܐ ܕܕܝܣܢ)[13]. Marcion stole sheep's clothing to conceal himself, at least externally[14].

Ephrem is keen to play on the name of heretics who masquerade as monks and torment themselves.

One demon among the Greeks,
As he began to commit fornication,
Likened himself to every (bride of Christ)
In that which was proper to her.
And today, habit with a habit,
He led them astray, the simple ones.

[4] P. Bedian, *Acta Martyrum et Sanctorum* 3 (Leipzig, 1892), p. 679.
[5] HeH 2.12; 22.15; 24.16; 52.2-3; C Diat 12.13; HdF 10.1-3, 22.
[6] HcH 2.2.
[7] HcH 22.15.
[8] HcH 52.3.
[9] HcH 52.2; Beck translates ܟܠܒܐ ܕܒ ܚܠܝܡܐ as 'Hunde, Glieder der Herde'; cf. E. Beck, CSCO 170 Syr 77 (Louvain, 1957), p. 178.
[10] HcH 56.9.
[11] HcH 23.3; 2.2.
[12] HcH 23.1, 7; HdF 64.1-2; 87.5-12; HdV 28.11; HcH 22.17.
[13] HcH 2.1; 1.10; 23.9.
[14] HcH 1.10.

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It is with fasting he hunts her,
And it is with sackcloth and dry vegetables,
And it is with speech he captivates her.
Blessed is he who shatters his snares[15].

Heretics try to steal and hide a mountain that cannot be stolen or hidden:

Come let us (wonder) at the weaklings
Who pound on the apex of truth,
To hide from sight great mountains
That cannot be stolen or hidden[16].

Mani is like a highwayman who plunders from everyone else. In fact, Ephrem is explaining Mani's syncretism. Mani stole from Marcion and Bardaisan. He is a crafty thief. Marcion and Bardaisan live through their disciples. It is a single weed (ܐܝܪܟܐ) which has grown into different branches (ܥܢܦܐ) full of leaves (ܦܐܐ) and fruits (ܦܝܪܐ)[17]. Heretics steal words of scripture and the leaven of life from Christians and hide it to build a tower on sand[18]. Ephrem would be at peace if no one were going to Gehenna![19] Through Bardaisan, the error of Greeks (ܛܥܝܘܬܐ ܕܝܘܢܝܐ) spread, like a Daisanite flood bringing Daisanite weeds. Heretics are children of error (ܒܢܝ ܛܥܝܘܬܐ) and thieves. Marcion wore sackcloth, that is, an ascetical garment. In HdF 87.4 Ephrem speaks of the hidden flea from the Greeks (ܦܫܐ ܓܢܝܒܐ ܕܝܘܢܝܐ). It is Greek wisdom (ܚܟܡܬ ܝܘܢܝܐ) and venom of 'the children of the serpent'[20].

The lion takes rest in the open;
Snake lies restless in a cave[21].

The contrast between the restful lion in the open and the restless snake in the cave cannot escape unnoticed in the context of Ephrem's apologetic argument against all kinds of heresies.

The dispute between Satan and Death contains passages full of humour.

Accursed is your name, O Satan!
You cannot make it beautiful.
All curse it;
Hide your shame!

[15] HcH 23.7; cf. HcH 38.10.
[16] HcH 27.4; cf. 27.3.
[17] HcH 41.9; 56.6; 3.1; 4.6-8.
[18] HcH 2.9-12; cf. 2.19-21.
[19] HcH 2.5.
[20] HcH 23.9; 3.7-8; HdF 68.3-4; HcH 1.11-13; HdF 2.23-24; HcJ 1.5; HdN 28.8; HcH 14.7; HdF 48.7; cf. T. Koonammakkal, 'St. Ephrem and Greek Wisdom', Symposium Syriacum, IV, 1992, ed. R. Lavenant OCA 247 (Rome 1994), pp. 170-3.
[21] HcH 1.5.

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O death, they hate
Both your name and your deed.
My name is hated,
But my delights are much loved![22]

Ephrem criticized young heretics who grow up suddenly like Jonah's gourd (Jon 4:6) and carry on the doctrinal strife on behalf of their teachers. ܕܝܘܢ ܡܪܝܐ ܒܪ ܐ is a comparison full of imagination and humour[23]. There may be hope even for those in Gehenna, but not for scrutinizers of God, argues Ephrem[24]. He is only making clear his aversion to a wrong method in theology and not advocating hope for those in Gehenna. He makes a reference to Jonah's silent prayers (Jon 2:2). Through this prophetic call he was a preacher. But the preacher was silent in the belly of a fish[25]. Ephrem's harp is Ephrem himself; it is a harp endowed with life, speech, and wisdom[26]. Another image is of a group of blind people standing in bright light seeking light! They examine gold, comparing it with a star; they touch a jewel and imagine that it is the colour of light; they scrutinize everything and touch everything. The fools imagine that they have touched the star, and each begins to explain his own illusion about the appearance of the star. Instead, they should have believed someone having sight[27]. HcH 14.11-15 speaks of an assembly of animals, worms, reptiles, serpents, and birds against Christ. In HdF 81.14-16 the fishes of the sea are quoted by Ephrem! He is putting his words in their mouths, and they in turn speak against Arian heretics. In HdF 82.1 Ephrem asks the pearl to speak to us. In HdF 84.4-6 we hear,

As Balaam became a fool, through an ass,
A foolish animal, He spoke to him;
For he had despised God, who spoke to him.
Let the pearl reprove you, instead of the ass.

The long dialogue between Satan and Death contains a substantial number of texts exhibiting a sense of humour. In C Nis 35.4 Satan describes how he tempted Jesus with excellent bread while Jesus was fasting. Satan even learned a psalm with great effort to conquer Jesus. When he failed, he improved his armoury with a second psalm. Satan remembers that in the days of Adam, it was far better for him because Adam could easily be taught by Satan! In C Nis 36.3-9 all-conquering Death boasts of its single-handed conquest. Death is beyond the influence of bribery. Only Enoch and Elijah escaped Death. Death calls them two lost grains and two grapes lost while

[22] C Nis 52.15, 20.
[23] SdF 6.217-24.
[24] SdF 6.311ff.
[25] HdF 20.9.
[26] HdF 21.9; 23.1, 5-7, 9-10; 51.5.
[27] HdF 27.4-6; cf. SdF I.157f.; HdF 65.8-13.

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harvesting. In C Nis 38.3-4 Death is called a blessing for humanity, a minister of Gods's plan, a liberation for the old from all their sufferings and a liberation for the young from all sins! Death, like Ephrem, fell among the waves of symbols, ܕܡܝܢ ܒܣܝܡܐ, as we hear in C Nis 39.17. The Evil One claims in C Nis 40.1 that he is a self-taught master who is proud of his learning:

Who is more foolish than men
Who care for their dwelling more than for themselves!
He examines his garment everyday,
But a worm is lurking in his body.
He repairs the rents of his clothes,
But his soul is split apart.
His house is full of light,
But his heart is darkened.
He closes his senses and opens windows.
He closes his door, but guards his money;
His mouth is wide open,
And the treasure of his thought is stolen.

The fool cares for his animals more than for himself;
He cares for his possessions, but not for himself.
He sows good seed in his land,
But he sows weeds in his heart.
His mind is wide open and cast out,
But he toils to make fences for his vineyard.
He selects and plants vines.
But his mind is a vine of Sodom.
He drives away the wild ass from his garden,
But the wild boar eats up his thoughts[28].

Satan is thousands of years old; but never has he taken any rest. He is ever alert and active. Whenever he finds something established he never turns away until he overthrows it. He even raised up a mountain, a tower reaching up to heaven. Though he is very old, he takes care of every infant. He teaches them evil from the very start. As they grow, the evil grows with them. Satan scolds foolish parents who do not uptoot the seed sown by Satan. He appreciates those parents who, like good farmers, uproot the evil seeds from the minds of their children. He complains that among men there are many Satans; but what a pity that he alone is cursed by all. He set his traps, sat, and waited. He challenges whether anyone is more patient than he is in catching his prey. After conquering Adam, Satan became unemployed until Adam had children. But Satan does not like to be idle. So he began counting the sands of the sea to increase his memory. When humanity multiplied like the sands of the sea,

[28] C Nis 40.5-6.

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Satan's memory became sufficient to seduce each and everyone! But now Satan is in great peril. He finds no place of refuge. Whither should he flee from Thomas the Apostle? Satan went to India, where he saw Thomas. Thomas is equally present in Edessa, and Satan began to weep bitterly. He longs for the purse of Judas Iscariot to gain strength, because the chest of Thomas tortures Satan always[29].

The sinful woman compares herself to a bow in war; she has killed the good and the wicked alike. She was a storm in the sea which sank the ships of many merchants. She has corrupted the whole town and is still unsatisfied. She is a gulf that swallowed up the merchandise of those attracted by her. The perfume-seller gives her ironic advice to seek a husband for herself. But how his own business can then prosper is a mystery! Satan followed her as a robber follows a merchant: Satan's anxiety and worry is understandable. His tender sympathy for her is depicted in amusing terms. Perhaps one of her lovers is dead, and she is going for the funeral, and it is natural for Satan to accompany her. Indeed, she is going to bury the sin of her thoughts, which is dead. Satan claims to be her first lover. She admits that she had been a bridge for Satan, who used to reach thousands of men through her! Satan is planning to go to Jesus to warn him about the arrival of this harlot. If Jesus receives her, the whole of mankind would flee from Jesus, and how ready is Satan to help Jesus! But as an afterthought, Satan goes to Simon's house and sows seeds of doubt in Simon's mind. Simon's hypocritical efforts, apparently to protect the good name of Jesus, fail, and he equates the harlot and Jesus. Jesus forgives the woman and reveals that Simon is a greater sinner than the repentant woman[30].

Ephrem saw a temple engulfed in fire. He is very confused, and he runs back and forth as he knows that he is unable to quench the fire. But he cannot be idle, and he becomes a firefighter amidst the heretical disputation engulfing the Church[31].

[29] C Nis 41.1-2, 4, 6, 8, 9; 42.1-2.

[30] E. Beck, *Des heiligen Ephraem des Syrers Sermones* II, CSCO 311 Syr 134 (Louvain, 1970), pp. 78-87.

[31] Pr Ref II.iv.

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The Gospel of Truth's Interpretation of the Delusion of the Demiurge

J. Woodrow McCree, New York

The extent to which the Nag Hammadi *Gospel of Truth* expresses Valentinian teaching – especially whether or not it is hiding something like Ptolemy's 'Great Account' in its vaguely gnostic and biblical language – is widely disputed[1]. I suggest that *GTr* offers us a conflation, or rather a demythologization, of Ptolemy's Valentinian myth. More specifically, the figures of Sophia and the Demiurge himself have been compressed into one figure, the Error of the totality, who personifies a collective state of being. The arrogant assertion of independent existence attributed to the Creator God in classical gnostic myth is no longer attributed to a single mythological figure, but to the aeons who compose the totality, that is, the noetic cosmos. As the aeons turn toward ego in their confusion regarding the unthinkable, incomprehensible Father, they inadvertently create the material world.

One of the most crucial passages in *GTr*'s theology of creation is, of course, *GTr* 17.5-20:

When the totality went about searching for the one from whom they had come forth – and the totality was inside of him, the incomprehensible, inconceivable one who is superior to every thought – ignorance of the Father brought about anguish and terror; and the anguish grew solid like a fog, so that no one was able to see. For this reason, error grew powerful. It worked on its own matter in emptiness (ϩN̄N ⲟⲩⲡⲉⲧⲱⲟⲩⲉⲓⲧ)[2], not having known the truth. It set about with a molded creation (ⲁⲥⲱⲱⲡⲉ ϩNN ⲟⲩⲡⲗⲁⲥⲙⲁ), preparing with power and beauty the substitute for truth.

[1] In 1986, Harold Attridge proposed that the *GTr* was a Valentinian document written to convert ordinary Christians to a gnostic way of seeing the Gospel. *GTr*'s use of biblical allusions and gnostic motifs was designed to 'render familiar the unfamiliar' and vice versa. While Attridge notes a number of ways in which the *Gospel of Truth*'s myth seems to differ from that of Ptolemy, he does seem to affirm that the main characters from the traditional Ptolemaean myth are to be found hidden within the *Gospel of Truth*'s evasive and allusive depths. See 'The *Gospel of Truth* as an Exoteric Text', in *Nag Hammadi, Gnosticism and Early Christianity*, ed. C. Hedrick and R. Hodgeson (Peabody, Mass.: Hendrickson Publishers, 1986), 339-55, and also his 'Introduction' and 'Notes' in *Nag Hammadi Codex 1 (The Jung Codex)*, ed. Harold W. Attridge, 2 vols, NHS 22-23 (Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1985).

[2] ⲱⲟⲩⲉⲓⲧ is used consistently to translate the Hebrew bible's terms for vanity and emptiness (LXX: μάταιος, κένος), see W.E. Crum, *A Coptic Dictionary* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1939), 602-3.

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There is little reason to doubt that this passage is a variant on Ptolemy's myth of the creation of the material world as a result of the thirtieth aeon, Sophia's excessive longing to know the 'immeasurable greatness of the Father' (Trenaeus, *Adv. Haer.* I.2). At the 1979 Yale conference on Gnosticism, William Schoedel pointed out that when *GTr* tells us that 'ignorance of the father' resulted in anguish and terror, allowing error to grow powerful and matter to be fashioned in the void, 'we are not told that material creation was thrust out of the Pleroma' as we might expect if we were to assume that Irenaeus' account of Ptolemy's thought were determinitive here. Schoedel went on to note that on the whole, 'the line between the world below' and the world above is quite 'fluid'[3]. Indeed, a wide range of scholars have emphasized that the 'blurring of distinctions', with a tendency to conflate several levels of reality in very brief and evocative references, is one of the most defining features of the text[4]. In a text where boundaries are blurred so easily, we should not be surprised to find that even the most central characters from the full-blown Ptolemaean myth have been conflated into an abstract principle.

Most significant is the fact that this errant longing no longer designates the hubris of one aeon alone out of all the paired aeons, who acted without her partner; rather, the totality as a collective is characterized by this problem (17.5-20). Likewise, when *GTr* 22.24-33 reaffirms that the aeons received error on account of the depth of the Father, language drawn from the account of Sophia's journey outside the pleroma is used to describe the experience of the aeons as a collective:

> It was a great wonder that they were in the Father, not knowing him, and that they were able to come forth by themselves, since they were unable to comprehend or know the one in whom they were (ⲛⲉⲩⲛⲁⲃ ⲙ̄ⲙⲁⲉⲓϩⲉ ⲧⲉ· ⲁⲉ ⲛⲉⲩϩⲛ̄ ⲡⲓⲱⲧ· ⲉⲩⲥⲁⲩⲛⲉ ⲙ̄ⲙⲁϥ ⲉⲛ ⲁⲩⲱ ⲛⲉⲩⲃⲙⲃⲁⲙ ⲛ̄ⲉⲓ ⲁⲃⲁⲗ· ⲟⲩⲁⲉⲉⲧⲟⲩ ⲡⲉ· ⲉⲡⲓⲁⲏ ⲛⲉⲩⲱ ⲃⲙⲃⲁⲙ ⲉⲛ ⲁⲱⲱⲡ ⲁⲣⲁⲩ ⲁⲩⲱ ⲁⲥⲁⲩⲛⲉ· ⲙ̄ⲡⲉⲧⲛⲉⲩⲛ̄ϩⲏⲧⲟ̄).

This statement captures one of the greatest mysteries of human existence – how it is possible to 'live and move and have our being in God' (Acts 17:28)

[3] William Schoedel, 'Monism and the Gospel of Truth', in *The Rediscovery of Gnosticism*, ed. Bentley Layton, vol. I, *The School of Valentinus*, Proceedings of the Yale Conference on Gnosticism, 379-90, at 384, 387. Schoedel also pointed out that in *Adv. Haer.* II.5.3, 17.10, and 24.6, Irenaeus himself seems to have encountered a monist gnosticism with emphases very similar to those of *GTr*; Schoedel saw this as evidence that *GTr* might well be representative of a movement within gnosticism to address orthodox objections to classic gnostic myth leading up to the time of Irenaeus.The question of the fluidity of *GTr*'s language was also explored at the same Yale conference by Joel Fineman, who gave attention to the shifting range of meanings in the *GTr*'s theology of the divine Name; see 'Gnosis and the Piety of Metaphor: The Gospel of Truth', in Layton, *Rediscovery*, 289-418.

[4] See especially Pheme Perkins, *Gnosticism and the New Testament* (Mineapolis: Fortress Press, 1993), 152-56.

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and yet be alienated from God in sin and ignorance[5]. The aeons come forth from God into an unhealthy state of autonomy, falling from unity: 'They come forth by themselves.' This description would seem to echo the account of Sophia's movement outside of the pleroma by herself, and yet instead of presenting us with the literal crossing of a limit as in Ptolemy's account, a paradox is invoked. The mystery of human existence is that we both subsist in God and yet stand apart from God out on our own. The fact that both can be true simultaneously is a 'great wonder'. Such a paradox is akin to Heracleon's claim that the Samaritan woman of John 4 can be both spiritual and lost in the deep error of matter simultaneously[6].

With this collectivization of Sophia's sin and the author's invocation of a paradox, the elaborate picture of the Christ and Spirit emerging from the aeons to restore Sophia to the pleroma and leave her separated desire outside the limit also drops out of the picture. The hierarchical picture of aeons in descending order, which had probably been created to put several developmental stages between the transcendent depth and the aeon who fell, seems irrelevant, since every member of the totality is equally characterized by the ignorance and autonomy which gives rise to and defines the sin of Error.

GTr's description of this fall as the solidifying of a fog, and its subsequent claim that Error substituted a powerful for the truth a powerful and beautiful image (17.10-20) draws upon the description in Romans 1:21-27 of the emptiness of human reasonings and the darkening of the human heart as it exchanges the glory of God for an image and the truth of God for a lie[7]. This biblical allusion suggests that Error is not so much a person as the state of consciousness which characterized the totality in its longing. Thus, while the language of this account of the fall does echo Ptolemy's account of Sophia, it simultaneously points back in the direction of the Pauline conception of the resistance of human consciousness to the purposes of God. Although *GTr*'s simplified version of the Ptolemaean myth clearly retains the classically gnostic idea that the material creation is the result of a noetic fall, the extent to which it pulls that gnostic teaching in a direction closer to the teaching of Romans 1:21-27 is notable.

When the author of *GTr* says that the entire material cosmos is a beautiful substitute for truth, she is saying that the very existence of the material cosmos

[5] Van Unnik has pointed out that the central theme of *GTr* seems to be 'an elaboration of the thoughts contained in Acts 17.25-30: We live in God and know him not': 'The Recently Discovered "Gospel of Truth" and the New Testament', in *The Jung Codex*, ed. F.L. Cross (London: Mowbray, 1955), 106. The pervasive 'in him' language of our text seems to refer primarily to the Father, and not to Christ as in the Pauline and Johannine literature.

[6] Yvonne Janssens, 'L' Épisode de la Samaritaine chez Héracléon', in *Sacra Pagina*, ed. J. Coppens *et al.*, vol. 2, BETL 13 (Paris: Librairie Lecoffre, 1959), 75-85.

[7] J. Williams, *Biblical Interpretation in the Gnostic Gospel of Truth from Nag Hammadi* (Atlanta: Scholars Press, 1988), 16-20. Elaine Pagels has also drawn attention to possible Valentinian uses of Romans 1: see 'The Valentinian Claim to Esoteric Exegesis of Romans as Basis for Anthropological Theory', *VC* 26 (1972), 241-58.

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is an idol[8]. While the characterization of Error as nothingness or a vanishing mist is partly based on traditions found in the *Odes of Solomon*[9], *GTr*'s language of 'nothingness' may also be partly drawn from Deutero-Isaiah's discourse on the powerlessness and nothingness of idols, which is concentrated most forcefully in chapters 40-45. The nations, their rulers, and the idols themselves are all described in similar terms as utterly insignificant in comparison with the transcendent sovereign majesty of God: 'All the nations are as nothing before him; they are accounted by him as less than nothing and emptiness (LXX: καὶ πάντα τὰ ἔθνη ὡς οὐδέν εἰσι καὶ εἰς οὐδεν ἐλογίσθησαν) (40:17). God challenges the idols themselves as if in court, 'Do good, or do harm, that we may be afraid and terrified. You indeed are nothing and your work is nothing' (41:24). 'No, they are all a delusion; their works are nothing; their images are empty wind' (41:29; *ruach wetohu* = the wind and chaos of Genesis 1). *GTr* 26.26-27 uses similar language in the parable of the jars, 'error is empty, having nothing inside (†ⲡⲗⲁⲛⲏ ⲥⲱⲟⲩⲉⲓⲧ· ⲉⲙⲛ̄ ⲗⲁⲩⲉ ⲛ̄ⲭⲏⲧⲥ̄)'. The nothingness of the material world is likewise emphasized in *GTr* 28.31 (cited below).

Isaiah 44:9 continues, 'All who make idols are nothing, and the things they delight in are vain/empty/do not profit'. Isaiah 44:13 mentions the beauty of the idol, and 45:15-16 seems even closer to the concerns of *GTr*: 'Truly you are a God who hides himself, O God of Israel, the Saviour; all of them are put to shame and confounded, the makers of idols go into confusion together.' The totality, as one, characterized by Error, go into confusion together and out of their confusion they forge the ultimate idol, a beautiful world that substitutes for the hidden God they cannot grasp.

GTr's creation account, in which the totality itself in a state of Error generates the material world, is rooted in the picture of the Old Testament Creator God as ignorant and egocentric as seen in the *Apocryphon of John* and Ptolemy's account, where the creator himself speaks in the words of Isaiah 45:5-6, 'I am the Lord, there is no other; besides me there is no God.' The curiosity of this classic gnostic myth is that it conflates the Creator God of Israel with the very idolmakers that the Hebrew God critiques. *GTr* continues this conflation process by fusing the Demiurge with Sophia under the figure of Error, who is really the collective state of the totality in its anxiety-ridden turn to self-delusion.

[8] Valentinus expressed some concern for the phenomenon of idolatry in Fragment 1 (Clement, *Strom.* II.36.2-4); however, *GTr*'s view of the material world seems considerably harsher than that of Valentinus himself. Valentinus saw an idolatrous potential in the process of creation, yet recognized that in spite of the inferiority of the lower realm, the divine Name condescends to fill up what is lacking in the image below (Frag. 5: *Strom.* IV.89.6 - 90.1). Thus, while Valentinus recognized with mainstream Platonists that the beauty of the world above shines in the world below, the author of *GTr* simply sees the whole material creation as an idol generated by delusion.

[9] e.g. *Ode* 31.1-2, 34.4-5.

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That the totality has committed a sin similar to that of the Demiurge is seen most vividly in the passage preceding the famous description of the nightmare from which the true gnostics will wake. *GTr* 27.23-28.31 affirms,

> Thus also, every aeon (MAEIT) which is itself in the Father is from the one who exists, who established it from what does not exist. For he who has no root has no fruit either, and though he thinks to himself, 'I have come into being', yet he will perish by himself. For this reason, he who did not exist at all will never come into existence. What then did the Father wish him to think of himself? This: 'I have come into being like the shadows and phantoms of the night.' When the light shines on the terror which that person experienced he knows that it is nothing.

In *GTr* 17.30-31, Error fell into a fog because it had no root. Here 'having no root' is defined as having a self-reliant attitude; though 'the one who has no root ... thinks to himself, "I have come into being", yet he will perish by himself.' Such an attitude may be easily summarized in the words of the Demiurge drawn from Isaiah 45:5-6: 'I am and there is no other'[10].

Clearly Error's sin is understood in some sense as going off on one's own; we can hear the echo of a myth in which both Sophia and the Demiurge turn toward ego. However, as it is presented in *GTr*, this sin also strikingly echoes Isaiah 53:6a: 'We all, like sheep, have gone astray; each of us has turned to his own way (πάντες ὡς πρόβατα ἐπλανήθημεν, ἄνθρωπος τῇ ὁδῷ αὐτοῦ ἐπλανήθη).' The focus in *GTr* is not on the crossing of a limit, or even the desire to produce by oneself; it is rather on a delusion regarding one's own existence. Error thinks it has existence 'on its own'. If it continues in this attitude, it will also 'perish on its own'.

This attitude of self-sufficiency, supposing that one has in oneself the root and ground of one's own being, is contrasted with the attitude that the Father wants the aeons to have: 'I have come into being like the shadows and phantoms of the night' (28.26-28). In order for the aeons to have true existence, they have to understand their ontological situation. They have to wander in a fog of ignorance for a time so that they can sense the groundlessness of their own being. Philo himself spoke of the need for the creature to despair of its own being before God:

> This is nature's law; he who has thoroughly comprehended himself, thoroughly despairs of himself, having as a step to this ascertained the nothingness in all respects of created being. And the man who has despaired of himself is beginning to know him that IS (*Somn.* I.60)[11].

[10] H. Attridge has noted that the general tenor of this passage sounds like a description of the sin of the Demiurge: *Jung Codex*, vol.2, p. 83.

[11] Cited in B. Pearson, 'Philo, Gnosis and the New Testament', in Pearson, *Gnosticism, Judaism and Egyptian Christianity*, Studies in Antiquity and Christianity (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1990) 180, n. 63. Pearson emphasizes that for Philo 'self-knowledge is not the same as knowledge of God'. However, as *GTr*'s use of the themes indicates, it is possible for true self-

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The aeons of the totality must first experience confusion and need, they must become aware of the ultimate non-reality of their being apart from the Father of Truth. Once the fallen aeons recognize the groundlessness of their own being, they have received the turning of repentance that is required, and immediately the dream world of matter dissolves as one wakes from a nightmare: They 'know that it is nothing'[12].

The primary collective sin of the totality in its error is to say to itself, 'I AM', as if each aeon were the source of its own being, as if it stood on its own as a reality in itself. This is, in fact, the sin of the Demiurge, described in more abstract terms and stripped of dependence on an elaborate mythological framework. Of course, in asserting its independence from God, the collective splits apart into the multiplicity of individual identities. Indeed, in the process of this fall into multiplicity, the aeons themselves create the material world as their confusion thickens into a solid mass.

One possible source of inspiration for this theology of sin as self-grounding hubris is found in the *Odes of Solomon* 7. The crucial verse is 7:12:

> The Father of knowledge is the Word of knowledge ...
> For he it is who is incorruptible ...
> He has allowed him to appear to them that are his own,
> in order that they may recognize him who made them,
> and not think that they came of themselves.

This Ode offers a number of parallels to *GTr*; H.-M. Schenke[13] has rightly emphasized that 7:21[14] seems to offers a basis for the infamous Valentinian syllogism. I suggest that 7:14 provides a basis for *GTr*'s claim that Error's rootlessness and nothingness lie in the fact that it says so boldly, 'I have come

knowledge to be grounded in the knowledge of God, and specifically in the awareness of one's dependence on God for true being. Knowledge of God is knowledge of the self, but the two are not necessarily identical. The one has its being in the other.

[12] There seem to be two phases in the dissolution of the world. The first is found in *GTr* 24.20b-25.6: 'Having filled the deficiency, he abolished the form (*schema*) the form is the world (1 Cor. 7:31), that in which he served. For the place where there is envy and strife is deficient ... ignorance vanishes of itself ... So from that moment on the form is not apparent, but it will vanish in the fusion of Unity." This first dissolution seems to be one of perception. When one abandons self-grounding hubris that defines error, envy and strife are no longer the governing structure of the world, though matter presumably continues. The second stage of dissolution is at the very end, when all the elect have woken up, and matter, along with those who have not yet woken up, utterly dissolves into the nothingness that it and they are have always been: 'For he who is ignorant to the end is a creature (*ouplasma*) of oblivion, and he will vanish along with it' (*GTr* 21.34b-37). '*Plasma*' is, of course, the material formation that solidified from the fog of ignorance.

[13] *Die Herkunft des sogenannten Evangelium Veritatis* (Göttingen: Vandenhoeck and Ruprecht, 1959).

[14] 'For ignorance was destroyed upon it (the earth), because the knowledge of the Lord came upon it.'

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into being.' *Ode* 7:14 itself depends on Psalm 100:3 (both MT and LXX)[15], which reads, 'Know that the Lord himself is God; he himself has made us, and not we ourselves (γνῶτε ὅτι κύριος, αὐτός ἐστιν ὁ θεός, αὐτὸς ἐποίησεν ἡμᾶς καὶ οὐχ ἡμεῖς).'

Psalm 100 was apparently used regularly with the thank-offering on weekdays in temple times[16]; it seems to have been used as a replacement for the thank-offering once the temple was destroyed, and it came to hold a special place in the thinking of the Rabbis who compiled the Talmud and the Midrash[17]. It is not surprising that a liturgically prominent Psalm should shape Jewish-Christian texts such as *OdesSol* and *GTr*. In *Ode* 7, Jesus saves his own by helping them 'recognize him that made them, and not think that they came of themselves'; the author of *GTr* then used this insight as she transferred the arrogant sin of the Demiurge to the totality itself.

In the end, by identifying the essence of Error as the tendency to suppose that we 'came from ourselves', the author of *GTr* develops a kind of creature/Creator distinction that was only hinted at in Ptolemy's picture of a limit between the Father and all other aeons[18]. The interpretation of gnostic myth it provides truly points in the direction of the central assertion of Romans 1:21-27: the Maker and ones made must not be confused – the source of true existence and those who are dependent on that source must be understood as distinct. Such a theological manoeuvre would seem to distinguish the author of *GTr* from Valentinus himself, who in Fragment 4 (*Stromateis* II.89.2-3) pressed the identity of the gnostic with the divine to an unacceptable extreme.

[15] Recent translations have followed later Rabbinic oral tradition and minority textual variants which read 'and we are his' rather than 'and not we ourselves'.

[16] See the superscription, 'Mizmor l'Todah' and Lev. 7:12-13.

[17] Leviticus Rabbah 9 (a fifth-century C.E. Midrash) claimed that in the messianic age, 'All songs will be annulled except this one'. All other sacrifices will be unnecessary, but the offering of thankful acknowledgement will remain. See A.Z. Idelson, *Jewish Liturgy and Its Development* (New York: Dover, 1995; original 1932), 81-2.

[18] *GTr* 19.7b-10a: 'It is he (the Father) who fashioned the totality, and within him is the totality, and the totality was in need of him'. God made the aeons; they exist in him and in dependence on him.

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Christi Seele und die Seelen der Gerechten
Zum fünften Fragment aus dem Johanneskommentar des Philoxenus von Mabbug

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Nachdem Apolinaris von Laodicea die Existenz einer menschlichen Seele in Christus geleugnet hatte, war es – im Gegenzug dazu – in der Theologie des 5. Jh.s zu einem vertieften Verständnis der soteriologischen Bedeutung der Seele Christi gekommen. Das entscheidende Dokument auf Seiten der alexandrinischen Tradition ist dafür Kyrills zweiter Succensus-Brief. Für die weitere Diskussion wurde die Seele Christi zu einer festen theologischen Größe. Das gilt auch für Philoxenus von Mabbug, der sich die Auffassung zu eigen machte, wonach der Sohn den ganzen Menschen (einschließlich einer menschlichen Seele) angenommen habe, um ihn als ganzen zu retten[1].

I.

Im folgenden soll auf ein bislang unediertes Philoxenus-Fragment hingewiesen werden, das der Seele Christi eine besondere Funktion im Hinblick auf die „Gerechten" zuweist. Es ist das fünfte von 13 Fragmenten, die André de Halleux mit der Vermutung zusammengestellt hatte, sie entstammten einem verloren gegangenen Kommentar zum Johannesevangelium[2].

[1] Die wichtigsten Stellen, an denen Philoxenus von der Seele Christi handelt, wurden zuletzt besprochen von T. Bou Mansour, 'Die Christologie des Philoxenus von Mabbug', in A. Grillmeier, *Jesus der Christus im Glauben der Kirche*, Bd. 2/3: *Die Kirchen von Jerusalem und Antiochien nach 451 bis 600*, hg. von Th. Hainthaler (Freiburg i. Br., 2002), 500–569, zur menschlichen Seele Christi siehe bes. 531–534.

[2] A. de Halleux, *Philoxène de Mabbog. Sa vie, ses écrits, sa théologie* (Louvain, 1963), 150–162. Sechs Fragmente finden sich als Zitate im Johanneskommentar von Dionysius Bar Salibi, weitere drei in der armenischen Florilegiensammlung „Siegel des Glaubens". Vier Fragmente erscheinen in syrischen Väterflorilegien in Handschriften der British Library. Zu dieser Gruppe gehört unser Fragment Nr. 5 aus BL Add. 14,538 (10 Jh.). Das mit Abstand umfangreichste Fragment Nr. 2 (zum Johannesprolog) liegt ediert vor in: Philoxène de Mabbog, *Commentaire du prologue johannique (Ms. Br. Mus. Add. 14,534)*, ed./trans. par A. de Halleux, CSCO 380/381, syr. 165/166 (Louvain, 1977). – Die Annahme, diese Fragmente seien sämtlich Teile eines Kommentars zum Johannesevangelium, ist nicht unwidersprochen geblieben. Douglas Fox bezweifelte, daß es überhaupt einen Johanneskommentar gegeben habe; vgl. D. J. Fox, *The*

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Das Fragment[3] beginnt mit der geläufigen anthropologischen Vorstellung, wonach der Tod als Trennung von Seele und Leib aufzufassen ist. Im Leib eingeschlossen, vermag die Seele die Gegenstände dieser Welt lediglich durch Vermittlung der fünf körperlichen Sinne wahrzunehmen. Charakterisiert wird der ontische Zustand der Körperwelt mit dem Stichwort des „Zusammengesetzt-Seins". Doch besitzt die (ihrem Wesen nach geistige, d.h. „unzusammengesetzte") Seele auch die Fähigkeit, die geistige Welt jenseits der irdischen Elemente zu erkennen. Dafür muß sich der Intellekt (*hawnā*) allerdings im Zustand der Reinheit befinden. In eine fatale Situation gerät diejenige Seele, die ihre geistigen Sinne durch sündhaftes Begehren befleckt hat. Verläßt sie ihren Leib, so kann sie weder in der materiellen noch in der geistigen Welt irgend etwas wahrnehmen.

Diese Epistemologie wird nun mit dem Heilswerk Christi in eine enge Verbindung gebracht. Röm 3,23f. wird – charakteristisch erweitert – so verstanden, daß die Schau der geistigen Welt ohne Christus von vorne herein ausgeschlossen ist: „Alle haben gesündigt und haben die Herrlichkeit Gottes *und die Schau der geistigen Welt (ḥzāṯeh d-ʿalmā rūḥānā)* verloren. Gerecht gemacht werden sie umsonst aus Gnade durch die Gerechtigkeit Christi"[4]. Christus führt die Seelen aus dem Zustand der geistigen Wahrnehmungslosigkeit. An dieser Stelle bringt Philoxenus die Existenz der menschlichen Seele Christi ins Spiel:

Deswegen ließ er [Christus] es in dem Moment, als er das menschliche Leben beendete, zu, daß seine Seele aus seinem Körper wich. Dies nämlich tat er kund, als er ausrief: „Es ist vollbracht" (Joh 19,30). Jede einzelne von all den [Seelen], die er anführte und die seiner Seele wie die Glieder dem Haupt anhingen, ließ er [dabei] zurück in ihrer Wohnstatt und dem Ort, der ihr angemessen war, indem er ihre Sinne heilte und ihre Augen öffnete. Was er an den Körpern öffentlich durch seinen Körper getan hatte, das sorgte er verborgen für die Seelen durch seine Seele. Wie er also jeden einzelnen von denjenigen, die er in der Welt geheilt hatte, je in seine Stadt und seinen Ort

„Matthew-Luke Commentary" of Philoxenus (British Museum Ms. Add. 17,126). Text, Translation and Critical Analysis, SBL Dissertation Series 43 (Missoula, 1979), 26ff. Die fraglichen Stücke trügen keinen exegetischen, sondern eher homiletisch-polemischen Charakter. Über ihre Herkunft seien sichere Angaben nicht zu treffen. In seiner gegen Fox gerichteten Replik bemühte sich de Halleux darum, die Einwände zu widerlegen; vgl. A. de Halleux, 'Le commentaire de Philoxène sur Matthieu et Luc. Deux éditions récentes', *Mus* 93 (1980) 5–35, bes. 17ff. Daß die bisher bekannten Teile des Johanneskommentars in der Tat kaum den Charakter eines Kommentars tragen, wird man gleichwohl zugeben müssen; so etwa auch B. Aland, 'Monophysitismus und Schriftauslegung. Der Kommentar zum Matthäus- und Lukasevangelium des Philoxenus von Mabbug', in P. Hauptmann (Hrsg.), *Unser ganzes Leben Christus unserm Gott überantworten. Studien zur ostkirchlichen Spiritualität; Fairy v. Lilienfeld zum 65 Geb.*, Kirche im Osten. Monographienreihe 17 (Göttingen, 1982), 142–166, hier 143f. Über die ursprüngliche Zusammengehörigkeit der Stücke zu einem Werk und über ihre Authentizität wird erst dann ein Urteil gefällt werden können, wenn alle Fragmente publiziert vorliegen.

[3] BL Add. 14,538, fol. 23v, lin. 32 – 24r, lin. 37.

[4] BL Add. 14,538, fol. 24r, lin. 26–27.

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zurückgeschickt hatte, die Apostel aber zurückbehielt, so sorgt er auch durch seine Seele für die Seelen, die er von den übrigen heilt: Er läßt sie an ihren Orten und Wohnstätten, die Seelen der Gerechten aber führt er mit sich. Indem sie ihm folgen und ihn begleiten, wenn er eingeht in die geistige Welt, und zwar nach dem Vorbild der Apostel in diesem Körper. Und er übergibt sie durch seine Seele in die Hände seines Vaters. Denn es steht geschrieben: „Die Seelen der Gerechten sind in der Hand des Herrn" (Weish 3,1). Dort aber läßt er sie alles erkennen, was sein ist; denn es wurde dort niedergelegt in diesen drei Tagen, weil er gesagt hat: „Vater, in deine Hände übergebe ich meinen Geist." (Lk 23,46)[5].

Wenn es heißt, Christus habe zugelassen, daß sich seine Seele vom Körper trennte, so bedeutet das: Christus starb am Kreuz – freiwillig – unseren menschlichen, natürlichen Tod. Sein Erlösungswerk vollzieht der menschgewordene Gottessohn mit Leib *und* Seele. Das konstruiert Philoxenus streng parallel: Mit seinem Leib heilte Christus leibliche Gebrechen. Auf verborgene Weise heilt Christus aber auch die Seelen durch seine Seele. Die Analogie von Leib und Seele wird unter Anspielung auf Wundergeschichten wie Mt 9,6 so weitergeführt: Christus schickte die körperlich Geheilten wieder zurück nach Hause und behielt nur die Apostel bei sich. Ebenso verhält es sich mit den seelisch Geheilten. Auch von ihnen behält Christus nur einige bei sich, nämlich die „Gerechten" (*zaddīqē*). Diese führt er mit sich in die geistige Welt, wohin seine Seele uns am Karfreitag vorausgegangen ist. Die Schriftstelle Weisheit 3,1 („Die Seelen der Gerechten sind in der Hand des Herrn") kombiniert Philoxenus dabei mit Christi Worten am Kreuz (Lukas 23,46): „Vater, in deine Hände befehle ich meinen Geist." Am Kreuz habe Christus die Seelen der Gerechten in die Hände des Vaters übergeben. Wie bei den Aposteln würden auch die Seelen der Gerechten schon „in diesem Körper" (*b-hānā pāḡrā*) dem Vater übergeben.

II.

Bei einem Vergleich mit den übrigen Schriften des Philoxenus fallen zahlreiche Parallelen ins Auge. Das gilt in besonderer Weise von den erkenntnistheoretischen Aussagen über das Wahrnehmungsvermögen der Seele und ihre geistigen Sinne. Anstelle einzelner Nachweise soll in diesem Rahmen nur summarisch auf die Grundgedanken des Kommentars zum Johannesprolog verwiesen werden. Nach André de Halleux zeigt sich darin ein „Intellektualismus platonischen Typs, der das geistige Verstehen dem reinen Intellekt vorbehält"[6]. Die geistige Erkenntnis, stets im ontologischen Status „unzusammengesetzter"

[5] BL Add. 14,538, fol. 24r, lin. 28–37. Mit dieser Passage endet das Fragment.

[6] A. de Halleux, 'Monophysitismus und Spiritualität nach dem Johanneskommentar des Philoxenus von Mabbug', *ThPh* 53 (1978), 353–366; das Zitat 357.

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Einsicht vorgestellt, kann der Seele nie von außen, durch die körperlichen Sinne zukommen, sondern ihr nur von innen her, durch den Heiligen Geist offenbart werden. Zweifelsohne sei dieser Typ geistiger Erkenntnis Philoxenus durch Evagrius Ponticus vermittelt worden. De Halleux weist zu Recht darauf hin, daß Evagrius die einzige im Johanneskommentar wörtlich angeführte Autorität ist[7]. Wie John Watt zeigen konnte, hatte Philoxenus wohl schon als Student an der Schule von Nisibis mit den Werken des Evagrius Bekanntschaft gemacht, besonders auch mit der von radikal-origenistischen Aussagen purgierten Version der *Kephalaia Gnostica*[8]. Gerade aus den Kephalaia ließen sich zahlreiche Parallelen zu unserem Text anführen[9].

In unserem Zusammenhang ist ein weiterer Aspekt zu beachten, den de Halleux für den Kommentar zum Johannesprolog herausgearbeitet hat: Philoxenus verbinde die evagrianischen Theologumena mit einer (in Harnacks Begrifflichkeit) „physischen" Art der Erlösung. Gnade und geistige Erkenntnis seien bei Philoxenus letztlich durch die Inkarnation des Logos grundgelegt und würden durch ihn vermittelt; Philoxenus vertrete (im Unterschied zu Evagrius) eine christozentrische Mystik[10].

Auch unser Text ließe sich mit diesem Ausdruck – „christozentrische Mystik" – zutreffend charakterisieren. Denn das Geschick der menschlichen Seele Christi am Karfreitag ermöglicht hier den Aufstieg der Seelen der Gerechten in die geistige Welt.

Daß Seele und Leib Christi am Heilswerk auf je eigene Weise beteiligt waren, drückt Philoxenus im Kommentar zum Johannesprolog unter Aufnahme der *Descensus-ad-inferos*-Vorstellung so aus: „Und mit seiner Seele, mit der er alle in der Scheol eingeschlossenen Seelen besuchte, besiegte er die Macht des Todes. Mit seinem Körper aber vernichtete er, als er im Grab niedergelegt war, das Reich der Vergänglichkeit"[11].

Daß Leib und Seele Christi auch noch nach ihrem Tod erlösende Funktionen ausüben können, liegt für Philoxenus an ihrer untrennbaren Einheit mit dem menschgewordenen Logos[12]. Das Herrenwort Lukas 23,46 (mit dem unser Text endet) klingt bei Philoxenus andernorts an, wenn er sagt, Christus

[7] Ebd., 357; es handelt sich um ein Zitat aus dem Prolog zum Praktikos: CSCO 380, 174,6–12; CSCO 381, 172,2–8 de Halleux.

[8] J. W. Watt, 'Philoxenus and the Old Syriac Version of Evagrius' Centuries', *OrChr* 64 (1980), 65–81.

[9] Vgl. etwa für die zugrunde liegende Erkenntnislehre *Kephalaia* 4.86 (PO 28 (1958), 172 Guillaumont S_1); besitze der Intellekt einen Leib, könne er das Unkörperliche nicht schauen, während er ohne Leib das Körperliche nicht sehen könne.

[10] Vgl. bes. de Halleux, 'Monophysitismus' (wie Anm. 6), 360f.

[11] CSCO 380, 231,20–22; CSCO 381, 229,13–16 de Halleux.

[12] Die miaphysitische Christologie führt bei Philoxenus zu der Annahme, der Leib Christi sei im Tode nicht dem Verwesungsprozeß unterworfen gewesen. Dank der Verbindung mit der Gottheit sei Christi Leib auch nach dem Tod (der Trennung von Leib und Seele) noch immer belebt und lebendig-machend gewesen; vgl. de Halleux, *Philoxène* (wie Anm. 2), 503f.

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habe am Kreuz die Sünde getötet und sodann unser (nun von der Sünde gereinigtes) Leben in die Hände des Vaters übergeben[13]. Auch habe Christus für die menschlichen Intellekte einen vertrauten Umgang mit Gott erworben, als er seinen Geist in die Hände des Vaters übergeben hatte[14]. Fragment 44 des Lukaskommentars beschreibt gleichfalls, wie Leib und Seele Christi während des *triduum sacrum* wirkten. Hier ist es (anders als im Kommentar zum Johannesprolog) der Leib, der in die Scheol hinabsteigt, um den Toten zu predigen und die Auferstehung der Leiber zu verkünden. Der Leib Christi konnte das, weil er auch nach seinem Tod noch lebendig und lebensspendend war[15]. Der vorausgehende Abschnitt über die Seele Christi ist leider nicht ganz erhalten. Immerhin ist eine Passage mit Weisheit 3,1 vorhanden, mit einem Bibelwort, das auch in unserem Text von Bedeutung ist: „Die Seelen der Gerechten sind in der Hand Gottes." An das Bibelzitat schließt Philoxenus hier den Satz an: „...dort, wohin er ihr Leben im voraus (*da-qdām*) übergab, als sie (noch) im Körper (*b-pāḡrā*) waren"[16]. Wie in unserem Fragment begegnet also auch hier die Vorstellung, Christus habe am Kreuz die Seelen der Gerechten dem Vater übergeben, als sie noch „im Körper" waren.

Für unser Fragment wäre zu überlegen, ob Philoxenus ausschließlich von der postmortalen Existenz- und Erkenntnisweise der menschlichen Seelen sprechen will. Ob die Angabe „in diesem Körper" nicht andeuten soll, daß die Seelen der Gerechten *schon jetzt*, in ihrem irdischen Leben, dank der Selbsthingabe Christi am Kreuz in die geistige Welt aufsteigen können? Könnte das mit dem Hinweis auf das „Vorbild der Apostel" gemeint sein (man denke etwa an 2 Kor 12,2)?[17] Gerade in diesem Falle wäre es wichtig, sich darüber klar zu werden, daß Philoxenus v.a. in seinen Homilien unter den „Gerechten" die „normalen" Getauften im Gegenüber zu den „Vollkommenen" (den Mönchen) versteht[18]. Sollte diese Terminologie auch in unserem Text vorauszusetzen sein, würde hier von den spirituellen Erfahrungen der Getauften gesprochen werden; diese Erfahrungen würden am Kreuz Christi ihre heilsgeschichtliche Verankerung finden.

[13] De Halleux, *Philoxène* (wie Anm. 2), 500, Anm. 56 (aus dem ersten Brief an die Mönche von Telada; eine analoge Stelle daraus bei de Halleux, 492, Anm. 32).

[14] Ebd., 493, Anm. 35.

[15] Philoxenus of Mabbug, *Fragments of the Commentary on Matthew and Luke*, ed./trans. J.W. Watt, CSCO 392/393, syr. 171/172 (Louvain, 1978): 392, 48,14f.; 393, 41,30 Watt.

[16] CSCO 392, 48,3f.; CSCO 393, 41,19f. Watt.

[17] Gelegentlich kann es Philoxenus als das Ziel des Kommens Gottes in die Welt beschreiben, daß der Intellekt des Getauften zur Erkenntnis der geistigen Welt erneuert werde; Belege, v.a. aus dem Brief an Patricius, bei de Halleux, *Philoxène* (wie Anm. 2), 437–445.

[18] Philoxenus übernimmt hier die Terminologie des *Liber graduum*; vgl. dazu Robert A. Kitchen, '*The Development of the Status of Perfection in Early Syriac Asceticism with Special Reference to the Liber Graduum and Philoxenus of Mabbug*', (DPhil Diss. Oxford, 1998).

[19] BL Add. 14,538, fol. 23v, lin. 31.

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III.

Es dürfte deutlich geworden sein, daß sich unser Text in die eben skizzierte Gedankenwelt des Philoxenus gut einfügt; seine Verfasserschaft wird man kaum bezweifeln wollen. Der Kompilator unseres Fragmentes gibt an, es stamme aus dem zweiten „Memra" des Johanneskommentars[19]. Das Stück steht in engem inhaltlichen Zusammenhang mit dem Kommentar zum Johannesprolog. Auch stilistisch paßt es zur elliptischen Syntax des Kommentars zum Johannesprolog. Daß die beiden Fragmente einmal zusammengehört haben, ist also durchaus vorstellbar. Schwierigkeiten bereitet die Zuordnung unseres Fragments zu einem bestimmten Vers aus dem Johannesevangelium. Schon de Halleux hatte die Angabe Joh 2,19, wo Christus seinen Tod vorhersagt, nur als Notbehelf betrachtet[20]. Unser Fragment belegt damit die Einschätzung, daß das zugrundeliegende Werk wohl keine exegetische Abhandlung im strengen Sinn gewesen ist.

[20] De Halleux, *Philoxène* (wie Anm. 2), 159: Die Angabe „Jean, II, 19" ist mit Fragezeichen zu versehen.

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Avoiding the Lure of Edessa: A Plea for Caution in Dating the Works of Ephraem the Syrian

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There are many reasons for wanting to date the production of particular documents written by an author of a large corpus. A chronology of an author's works allows for a whole new level of interpretation. Background events can illuminate the works, and vice versa. One can trace the development of thought and the changes of positions supported in the author's works, if these can be dated. Think how different our picture of Augustine would be if we could not date any of his works! What a confusing ocean of writings would confront us. And yet, I have been told that more writings pass under Ephraem's name than even come to us with Augustine's name attached.

Ephraem is an unusual figure in the ancient world. He is an individual who wrote a whole library, whose putative works are not yet fully sifted for authenticity and who speaks in a clear and characteristic voice. Yet, he comes to us, essentially, out of a void.

Ephraem was a native of, and product of, Nisibis. He lived almost sixty years before he left that city, if our usual accounting of his life is a good guide[1]. His ideas were formed there, his prejudices established, his education (whatever it was)[2] completed, and his reputation fixed before he came to live in Edessa. Yet it is with *Edessa* that he is linked in our minds. Why is that the case? I think it is because we know Edessa in a way that we, probably, can never hope to know Nisibis.

One of the peculiarities of Ephraem's works is that the great majority are single pieces that survive without a known context or identifiable companions. The collections in which they have come down to us seem to reflect the

[1] The author's fullest attempt to sketch out our knowledge of Ephraem's life is found in Paul S. Russell, 'St. Ephraem, the Syrian Theologian' *Pro Ecclesia* 7.1 (1998), 79-90.

[2] Ephraem's education has been an area of some discussion, since it directly affects our idea of how much he was influenced by Hellenistic culture and the pagan culture of his locale. Ute Possekel, *Evidence of Greek Philosophical Concepts in the Writings of Ephrem the Syrian*, CSCO Subs 102 (Leuven: Peeters, 1999) has shown good reasons for thinking that he had a greater and deeper acquaintance with Greek thought than has often been credited to him. What is important for our purposes is to realize that even so basic an element of his background and upbringing must be approached obliquely, through the careful study of his works. We have very little dependable historical information about him to guide our endeavous.

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sensibilities of later compilers rather than of Ephraem himself. Because of this, the shape of these collections is misleading if they are used, as they often are, though sometimes perhaps only subconsciously, as guides to the context or meaning of the writings they contain[3].

There are, of course, some works that seem to survive in intact sets: the Hymns on Paradise, the Hymns on the Pearl at the end of the Hymns on Faith, the three hymns on Mark 13:32 in the Hymns on Faith, 77-79, are three examples that come readily to my mind. Though more examples could be mentioned, it is important to realize that these works are not the norm. Andrew Palmer has begun the work of trying to argue that some of the collections we have do, indeed, stem from Ephraem himself, but this point cannot be considered sufficiently settled to form a secure basis for further steps of reasoning[4]. The stand-alone hymn or prose homily is the representative, typical work of Ephraem, as we now know his works, and very few of these can be dated or placed with any precision at all.

What makes this situation particularly perilous is the fact that we know that Ephraem moved from Nisibis to Edessa for the last decade of his life: out of the darkness into the light, as far as we are concerned. From a place that offers us almost nothing except the Persian sieges to use in our study of his works[5], Ephraem moves to the centre of the Syriac-speaking Church. Now, all at once, we can use our knowledge of the art and inscriptions[6] and culture of Edessa[7] and even its Christian history (or legend) in the form of the Edessene documents. (Every student of Syriac knows Cureton's volume *Ancient Syriac Documents relative to the establishment of Christianity in Edessa and the neighbouring countries*[8]. The use of that volume is a standard part of a student's initiation into the field. It is unimaginable, in our present state of knowledge, that someone would try to produce a comparable work centred on Nisibis.) If we imagine that a particular piece by Ephraem stems from after his move to

[3] The two articles of de Halleux, 'Une Cle pour les Hymnes d'Ephrem dans les MS. Sinai Syr. 10', *Mus* 85.1-2 (1972), 171-99, and 'La Transmission des Hymnes d'Ephrem d'apres le MS. Sinai Syr. 10, F. 165v-178r', in *Symposium Syriacum 1972*, OCA 197 (Rome: Pont. Institutum Orientalium Studiorum, 1974), 21-63, argue from manuscript evidence that the collections of Ephraem's works in which they come down to us were the creation of later compilers rather than of the author himself, in most cases.

[4] Andrew Palmer, 'Mind the gap! or, A Church Father with a sense of fun', *Gouden Hoorn* 4.2 (Winter 1996-1997). To my knowledge, scholars of Ephraem have not responded to Dr Palmer's suggestions.

[5] These are quite properly put to use for dating purposes, especially in the case of those of the *Carmina Nisibena* that reflect them.

[6] Han J.W. Drijvers and John F. Healey, *The Old Syriac Inscriptions of Edessa and Osrhoene, Texts, Translations and Commentary* (Leiden: Brill, 1999).

[7] H.J.W. Drijvers, *Cults and Beliefs at Edessa* (Leiden: Brill, 1980).

[8] London and Edinburgh: Williams and Norgate, 1864; repr. Amsterdam: Oriental Press, 1967.

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Edessa, then, when we study it, we can use Eusebius and his intriguing passages on the early Church in Edessa[9] (or not, as we choose) and we can discuss our decision. We can argue with Bauer's picture of Christianity in Edessa[10] or support it. We can turn to Segal's *Edessa*[11] and we can speak of Quq and Bardaisan[12]. Very useful and interesting works on Edessa continue to appear, like that by Steven Ross[13], and the urge to run after what we know grows ever stronger. Few scholars can keep their heads with such temptation before them.

The best of us seem to falter in our judgement at this point. I think always, in this regard, of the great Dom Edmund Beck's assignment of the Sermons on Faith to Nisibis and the Hymns on Faith to Edessa on the basis of the appearance of explicit mentions of the Holy Spirit in Trinitarian contexts in the Hymns, but not in the Sermons[14]. That suggestion contains, all at once, almost every one of the mistakes I am trying to argue against.

1. It requires the assumption that these are two integral collections, each of which was produced at one period and each of which therefore represents one stage of Ephraem's theological development. (This assumption allows for them to be compared and dated against each other, en masse.)

2. It assumes that we can compare what Christians in Edessa and Nisibis talked and thought about during Ephraem's lifetime, when we know very little of the theological *causes célébres* of one of those places (Edessa) and virtually nothing of those in the other (Nisibis).

3. It assumes that Edessa held a centrality in this Syriac cultural world that we can never demonstrate.

The logic of Dom Beck's argument depends on the assumption that the weightiest theological work was being done in Edessa and that a move from Nisibis to Edessa was a move from the backwaters into the main currents of Christian thought in the Syriac-speaking Church of the time. In other words, this contention of Dom Beck's takes the peculiar limitations of our knowledge of early Syriac Christianity, especially its focus on Edessa, and projects them onto the past as if they were correct characterizations of it.

[9] Eusebius, *The History of the Church* I.13. The Abgar legend forms the final section of the first book of Eusebius' work.

[10] Walter Bauer, *Orthodoxy and Heresy in Earliest Christianity*, ed. Robert Kraft and Gerhard Krobel (Philadelphia: Fortress Press, 1971).

[11] J.B. Segal, *Edessa 'The Blessed City'* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1970).

[12] Han J.W. Drijvers, 'Quq and the Quqites. An Unknown Sect in Edessa in the Second Century A.D.', *Numen* 14.2 (1967), 104-29. Han J.W. Drijvers, *Bardaisan of Edessa* Assen: Van Gorcum, 1966. Javier Teixidor, *Bardesane d'Édesse: la première philosophie syriaque* (Paris: Éditions du Cerf, 1992).

[13] Steven K. Ross, *Roman Edessa* (London and New York: Routledge, 2001).

[14] *Des Heiligen Ephraem des Syrers Hymnen de Fide*, tr. Edmund Beck, CSCO 155 (Louvain: Peeters, 1955), ii, and *Des Heiligen Ephraem des Syrers Sermones de Fide*, tr. Edmund Beck, CSCO 213 (Louvain: Peeters, 1961), i.

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In the famous illustration, the blind men trying to describe the elephant each speak of the part of the beast they feel – trunk, tusk, tail, or leg – and each man thinks he knows what the beast is like. Modern scholarship is in that case of blindness in our study of early Syriac Christianity, but all of us can feel only the same part of the animal – the part that was based in Edessa. How can we claim to see Syriac Christianity whole? How can we pronounce judgements that require a rounded knowledge of it? We cannot, I think.

I would like to suggest that modern scholarship must proceed in its study of fourth-century Syriac Christianity, the great library of St Ephraem's works included, with the real and constant awareness of the limitations of our knowledge and the limitations of our ability to make use of the materials that do survive for us to study. The study of the ancient world, whether Christian or not, must always be conducted with a sense of the distance that separates us from the lives of those we study and the knowledge they had, and assumed their readers had, of the world around them.

Our knowledge of St Ephraem the Syrian, and the world he lived in and the works he wrote, will be held captive by our ignorance as long as we refuse to recognize how great that ignorance really is. If we take a step back from the materials we have to study in order to see them more clearly against as much of the background that produced them as we have the tools to see, we may yet be able to identify all the pieces that survive for us to study. As long as we continue to try to see further than our separation from the material allows us to see clearly, we will continue to run the risk of misleading ourselves and each other by attempting to construct more complete pictures of the past than our knowledge really allows for.

I have great hopes for the future of the study of ancient Syriac Christianity, and of the works of St Ephraem in particular. However, I do not think that we will achieve all that we might achieve until we begin to proceed more cautiously in our reconstructions of the past.

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A Peculiar Version of the *Inventio Crucis* in the Early Syriac Dormition Traditions

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The Syriac narratives of the Virgin Mary's Dormition and Assumption are among our most important sources for understanding the earliest history of Dormition traditions, particularly since they preserve the earliest exemplars of several different narrative types[1]. Strangely enough, however, this same corpus may also have something important to add to our understanding of the late ancient traditions of the discovery of the True Cross. Certain of the earliest Dormition narratives, preserved in Syriac manuscripts of the fifth and sixth centuries, preserve an unusual account of the invention of the Cross, one that is quite distinct from the three known versions of this story but also shares a number of their key features. Given the nature of the Dormition narratives in which this tale of the True Cross is embedded, it seems that they have preserved at least the outline or part of a fourth tradition of the Cross's discovery that circulated in the late ancient Near East.

This new account of the *inventio crucis* is presered within the so-called 'Six Books' narratives of Mary's Dormition and Assumption, although the story does not appear in every version of the Six Books[2]. The Six Books narrative is one of the earliest extant Dormition traditions, and it is known from a number of Syriac manuscripts, as well as in Arabic and Ethiopic versions. All of these versions relate essentially the same story, although they can vary considerably in details, and one of the main points on which they differ is the inclusion of the True Cross's discovery. Consequently, we have no way of knowing if this episode was included in the original version of the 'Six Books', but in the end this is not particularly important: the antiquity of certain manuscripts allows us to be certain that this version of the Cross's discovery circulated in the Near East by the early fifth century at the latest.

These Dormition traditions introduce the relics of the True Cross within a broader context of sustained conflict between Jews and Christians that pervades the narratives[3]. When the Jewish leaders see Mary going to pray at her

[1] See, e.g., Stephen J. Shoemaker, *Ancient Traditions of the Virgin Mary's Dormition and Assumption*, Oxford Early Christian Studies (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2002), esp. 32-57; 62-4.

[2] For more on the Six Books narrative and its versions, see ibid., 45-57.

[3] On the anti-Judaism of the Dormition traditions, see Stephen J. Shoemaker, '«Let Us Go and Burn Her Body». The Image of the Jews in the Early Dormition Traditions', *Church History* 68.4 (1999), 775-823, and on the traditions of the Cross' discovery in particular, see 801-3.

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son's tomb as the Six Books narrative begins, they persuade the Roman governor to banish her from Jerusalem to Bethlehem; after she begins working miracles, they repeatedly complain to the governor, asking him to intervene[4]. In each instance, the governor accedes to the Jewish demands, until a miraculous fire consumes many of the Jews during their attempt to burn Mary alive in her house. Following this, the governor suddenly begins to reconsider his position, and near the middle of the narrative, he organizes a great debate between those Jews who did not believe in Christ and the 'lovers of Christ', who also seem to be ethnically Jewish. Somewhat unsurprisingly, given that this is a Christian text, the Christians triumph in the debate, and they demand of their defeated opponents that they reveal to them

where is the wood hidden, on which Christ was crucified, and where are the nails that were fixed in his hands and in his feet, and where was the sponge placed, with which we offered him vinegar, and where is the spear that wounded him, and where is the crown of thorns that we placed on his head, and the garments of disgrace, with which we clothed him? Where are they hidden?[5]

The governor orders the defeated non-Christian Jews to reveal where the implements of crucifixion are hidden. They explain that after the crucifixion, the crosses of Jesus and the two thieves were buried in a pit, along with the other items, and were covered with stones so that they could not be seen. Nevertheless, a small opening was left in the mound

so that a person's hand could reach our Lord's cross, so that whenever an affliction comes upon one of us, he goes and stretches out his hand to the head of the wood of our Lord's cross, and he immediately receives help, and the one who is sick is healed[6].

'And not only is he healed,' they explain, 'but if there is a sick person in his house, he takes some dust from that opening on his finger and goes and rubs it on the limbs of the one who is sick, and immediately he is healed'[7]. Those

[4] The following editions of Syriac version of the Six Books have been published: William Wright, 'The Departure of My Lady Mary from This World', *The Journal of Sacred Literature and Biblical Record* 6-7 (1865), 417-48 and 108-60; William Wright, *Contributions to the Apocryphas Literature of the New Testament* (London: Williams and Norgate, 1865), حـ-ىـ and 18-41; Agnes Smith Lewis, *Apocrypha Syriaca*, Studia Sinaitica 11 (London: C.J. Clay and Sons, 1902), ص-صنه (Syr) and 12-69 (Eng). The version edited in E.A. Wallis Budge, *The History of the Blessed Virgin Mary and The History of the Likeness of Christ which the Jews of Tiberias Made to Mock at*, 2 vols., Luzac's Semitic Text and Translation Series 4-5 (London: Luzac and Co., 1899) is much later and is rather corrupt. I am presently working toward a republication of all these texts with new translations, together with a new edition of Wright's version on the basis of an unpublished sixth-century manuscript in the Göttingen collection to be published as Stephen J. Shoemaker, *The Early Syriac Dormition Narratives: Texts and Translations.*

[5] Smith Lewis, *Apocrypha Syriaca*, ﻫ. I have consistently referred to this version, since its manuscript is the earliest, dating to the late fifth century.

[6] Ibid., ﻫ.

[7] Ibid.

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who possessed the Cross maintain that over 5,500 people from Jerusalem and its environs had been cured in this way, noting also that each one paid a fee for the therapy. They further confess that they formed a conspiracy among themselves, agreeing that anyone who revealed the true nature of their healing shrine would be slain with his wife, and the rest of his family would be cast out from the people. In order to maintain their secret, they also agreed that

if someone should ask us, 'What is in that opening, by which the world is healed', let us say to him, 'The pot of manna is there, and the water of trial, and the staff of Aaron, and these things give healing to all who go there'[8].

The keepers of the Cross further inform the governor that he should be sure to arrest a certain Jonadab, because he is in possession of one of the nails used to crucify Christ. With this nail he has saved 500 people from death and become quite rich in the process, all the while not knowing exactly what it was that he possessed.

The governor is naturally rather impressed by these powerful relics that the Jews have carefully hidden among themselves. When he demands that they take him to the location of the Cross, they bring him there. He then asks the Christians what they would have him do. They suggest that he should

order that they raise up the cross on which our Lord was crucified, and let the two crosses of the two thieves be burned with fire. And let the cross of Jesus be placed in the temple of Jerusalem, and let it be worshipped by all people[9].

The governor refuses, however, explaing,

I have not been ordered by the emperor to do this, but I will put you to great shame before all creation. For I will not go near the cross of Christ: for the Christ who was crucified on it will raise it up from the earth in which it is burried[10].

Then the governor immediately orders that the crosses be buried with the other items under 'earth and large stones' up to the height of ten men, and he says, 'You used to come to this place and receive help from it. I have piled up earth and stones on it, so that help from the cross of Christ will no longer go forth to the children of Israel'[11]. Immediately after this the governor's son becomes gravely ill, and when he goes to Mary for a healing, it is clear that he has already become a Christian. Nevertheless, this apparently did not inspire him to exhume the Cross and its related relics; these remain buried without further comment, possibly so that they may be rediscovered roughly

[8] Ibid., ܚܕ-ܚܗ.
[9] Ibid., ܚܗ-ܛ.
[10] Ibid., ܚ.
[11] Ibid.

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three centuries later by Constantine's mother, Helen, although this is not indicated.

This story of the Cross's discovery differs considerably from each of the three late ancient versions that Jan Willem Drijvers identifies in his excellent monograph on these traditions[12]. Consequently, it is not possible to explain this account as either a derivation from or combination of any of these more well-known narratives, in the way that, for instance, Drijvers has shown that the Protonike version retells the story of Helen's discovery of the Cross in a first-century setting[13]. Instead, the version of the finding of the Cross preserved in the early Syriac Dormition narratives appears to be a fourth, independent tradition that was current in the late ancient Near East. Although this story of the Cross's discovery and subsequent reburial is not present in every version of the Six Books narrative, it is preserved in its fullest form by a somewhat fragmentary palimpsest codex that was written in the late fifth century, most likely at the monastery of Mount Sinai[14]. As I have explained elsewhere, the Syriac versions of this narrative depend on an earlier Greek source, which probably had been composed by the early fifth century at the latest[15]. A somewhat abbreviated version of this episode is also included in a soon-to-be-published version of the Six Books preserved by a sixth-century manuscript in the Göttingen collection[16], and the full account, with slight variation, also occurs in several loose folios that were copied in 1197[17]. Yet this peculiar description of the Cross's discovery is absent from the sixth-century manuscript that was published by Wright in 1865[18], and it is also lacking in the version preseved by an unedited twelfth-century manuscript in Damascus (whose contents I know only from its Karshuni apograph, of which John Lamoreaux and I are preparing an edition)[19]. Likewise, the

[12] Jan Willem Drijvers, *Helena Augusta: The Mother of Constantine the Great and the Legend of her Finding of the True Cross*, Brill's Studies in Intellectual History 27 (Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1992), esp. 79-180.

[13] Ibid., 154-61.

[14] Smith Lewis, *Apocrypha Syriaca*, x.

[15] Shoemaker, *Ancient Traditions of the Virgin Mary's Dormition*, 54-7.

[16] Göttingen MS Syr 10, ff. 21b-22b. I have prepared an edition of this text to be published with translation in Shoemaker, *Early Syriac Dormition Narratives*.

[17] Wright, *Contributions to Apocryphal Literature*, ܐ-ܟ (Syr) and 24-41 (Eng).

[18] Wright, 'Departure of my Lady Mary'.

[19] Syrian Orthodox Patriarchate, Damascus, MS no. 12/17, ff. 196b.1-199b.1; see the catalogue published in Yuhanna Dolabani *et al.*, 'Catalogue des manuscrits de la bibliothèque du patriarchat Syrien Orthodoxe à Homs', *Parole de l'Orient* 19 (1994), 555-661, esp. 606. My knowledge of the contents of this manuscript, which I have not yet seen, depends on its Karshuni apograph, produced in 1732/3 and now in the collection of the Monastery of St Mark in Jerusalem. John C. Lamoreaux and I are currently preparing an edition and translation of the Karshuni version of the narrative of Mary's Dormition, and this version at least lacks this story of the Cross's discovery.

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Ethiopic and Arabic Six Books traditions, as they are presently known, do not include this episode[20].

In view of these circumstances we unfortunately cannot be certain if this story was an original feature of the Six Books narrative that was later eliminated as other traditions about the finding of the Cross came to dominate, or if it was instead inserted at a relatively early stage by an individual transmitter, thus explaining its presence in only some versions of the Six Books. Likewise, it is uncertain whether this account of the Cross's discovery was already a part of the Six Books in Greek or if it was added at the point of translation into Syriac. We do know, however, that this legend was in existence by the late fifth century, at which time the earliest manuscript recording it was produced[21]. Yet is is likely that the tradition is even older than this. There is no reason to suspect that the individual who translated the Six Books from Greek into Syriac would have composed this episode. It is rather awkwardly joined to the rest of the Six Books narrative at both its beginning and end, and it is particularly difficult to understand in the context of the debate that frames it. Moreover, there is little connection between the story of the Cross's discovery and the themes and contents of the Six Books narrative, excepting their shared anti-Judaism and their representation of the Jews as enemies of the Christian veneration of saints and relics. These features suggest that the story was an independent tradition that was at some point added to these traditions of Mary's Dormition, most likely because its representation of the Jews as enemies of the Roman Empire and opponents of the emerging cult of saints and relics added to the emphasis of these same themes in the Six Books narrative[22]. The fact that the Six Books has elsewhere incorporated an episode taken from the *Doctrina Addai*, as well as material from the *Testament of Adam*, increases the likelihood that this tradition too is borrowed[23].

This leaves us with two possibilities. In the case that this story of the Cross's discovery was present in the Greek version from which the Syriac was translated, then we know that it was already a part of the Six Books narrative

[20] Ethiopic: Marius Chaîne, *Apocrypha de Beata Maria Virgine*, 2 vols., CSCO 39-40, Aeth 22-23 (Louvain: L. Durbecq, 1955), 21-9 (Eth) and 17-42 (Lat); see now also the translation in Shoemaker, *Ancient Traditions of the Virgin Mary's Dormition*, 375-96. Arabic: Maximillian Enger, اخبار يوحنّا السليح في نقلة امّ المسيح *(Akhbâr Yûhannâ as-salîh fî naqlat umm al-masîh), id est Joannis apostoli de transitu Beatae Mariae Virginis liber* (Eberfeld: R.L. Friderichs, 1854).

[21] Smith Lewis, *Apocrypha Syriaca*, x.

[22] See n. 3 above.

[23] See, e.g., Smith Lewis, *Apocraphya Syriaca*, ܠܐ-ܠܚ (Syr) and 21-22 (Eng) (*Doctrina Addai*); ܥܕܐ (Syr) and 41 (Eng) (*Testament of Adam*). Although one might be tempted to conclude that the inclusion of material from the *Doctrina Addai* might seem to suggest composition of the Six Books in Syriac rather than Greek, note that while the Protonike narrative of the Cross's discovery did not circulate outside of Syriac and Armenian, earlier versions of the *Doctrina Addai* that lack the Protonike story, as well as other traditions from the *Doctrina Addai*, did circulate in Greek: see Drijvers, *Helena Augusta*, 147-63, esp. 147 n. 1 and 151.

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in the early fifth century, and since it likely existed in some sort of independent state prior to this, we could then assume the existence of this tradition by around the year 400. Alternatively, however, there is the possibility that the Cross episode was not present in the now lost Greek archetype and was added in only after the Six Books was translated into Syriac. In this case, given the probability that the legend originally existed independently of the Six Books, it is likely that the tradition would have already been in circulation by the early fifth century. Yet the incorporation of material from the *Doctrina Addai* in the Six Books may allow us to date its traditions about the finding of the Cross even more precisely. The *Doctrina Addai* is itself the source of one of the earliest traditions of the Cross's discovery, namely the story of the empress Protonike finding the Cross in the first century. Nevertheless, the earliest versions of the *Doctrina Addai*, which began to circulate in the later third century, did not originally include the Protonike legend, nor any other account of the Cross's discovery, until after 400. Only at the beginning of the fifth century was the story of Protonike's discovery of the Cross composed and added to the much earlier narrative of the *Doctrina Addai*[24]. The fact that the Six Books narrative includes an altogether different account of the Cross's discovery suggests that it depends on an earlier version of the *Doctrina Addai* that had not yet added the Protonike legend. If the redactor of the Six Books has used a copy of the *Doctrina Addai* containing the Protonike story, one would expect him to have reproduced the Protonike tradition rather than the peculiar version of the Cross's discovery that we find instead. Thus it seems likely that the Six Books was compiled at a time before the *Doctrina Addai* traditions had added the Protonike story and, further, that the Six Books' account of the Cross's 'prediscovery' also predates the Protonike story. This suggests, somewhat tentatively, that the account of the Cross's discovery in the Six Books may date to the later fourth century, if not possibly even earlier. It would also indicate, rather significantly, the composition of the Six Books narrative at this same time, the later fourth century[25].

In any case, we may conclude with a fair amount of certainty that the tradition of the finding of the True Cross preserved in the Six Books narratives dates to the early fifth century at the latest, and quite possibly to the later fourth century, if not even earlier. This version of the Cross's discovery is then contemporary with more well-known late ancient accounts, particularly the so-called Protonike and Judas Kyriakos traditions, both of which were composed

[24] Drijvers, *Helena Augusta*, 147-63.

[25] This is somewhat earlier than I have previously suggested in Shoemaker, *Ancient Traditions of the Virgin Mary's Dormition*, 54-7, although it comports with the suggestion by Richard Bauckham that the Six Books narrative is probably 'from the fourth century at the latest, but perhaps considerably earlier': Richard Bauckham, *The Fate of the Dead: Studies on Jewish and Christian Apocalypses*, Supplements to Novum Testamentum 93 (Leiden: Brill, 1998), 346-60, esp. 358-60.

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in the early fifth century[26]. In light of this, it will presumably be worthwhile to study this tradition in comparison with the other late ancient narratives of th Cross's discovery in order to understand more fully the significance of the True Cross in late antiquity. Such comparison is especially invited by the facts that the Six Books quotes from the *Doctrina Addai*, the source of one invention narrative, and includes in its prologue correspondene with Judas Kyriakos, the star of another True Cross tradition, in his legendary role as bishop of Jerusalem[27]. At the most general level, we may note that the narrative of the Cross's discovery preserved by the Six Books shares the strong anti-Judaism of the other traditions, and more specifically their representation of the Jews as jealous opponents of the power of Christian relics. It also shares in reporting the involvement of imperial officials in the Cross's discovery, as well as the use of violence to extract the location of the implements of crucifixion from the Jews, who have them under their control. It is, however, also strikingly different from these other traditions, perhaps most notably in that there is no empress or even a woman behind the Cross's discovery, nor does the miraculous reanimation of a dead body distinguish Christ's Cross from the others. But no doubt much remains to be learned beyond these superficial observations through further study of the traditions.

[26] Drijvers, *Helena Augusta*, 153 (Protonike) and 174-5 (Judas Kyriakos).

[27] Smith Lewis, *Apocrypha Syriaca*, ܚ-ܠ (Syr) and 16-17 (Eng); Wright, 'Departure of my Lady Mary', ܟ-ܐ (Syr) and 130-1 (Eng). On the identity of this figure with Judas Kyriakos, see Wright, 'Departure of my Lady Mary', 131, n. *m*. According to the Judas Kyriakos narrative of the finding of the True Cross, Judas Kyriakos, who reveals the location of the Cross, is made bishop of Jerusalem at the story's close: see Drijvers, *Helena Augusta*, 170-1.

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Melkite Canticles to the Virgin from a Syriac MS in the Russian National Library in the Context of Eastern Christian Liturgical Literature

Natalia SMELOVA, St Petersburg

The Manuscripts Department of the Russian National Library at St Petersburg possesses a curious Syriac MS (Syr. New Series 11) entitled in the Catalogue as well as in the inventory the *Akathistos to the Virgin*.

The short description of it given in the *Catalogue of the Syriac MSS in Leningrad* by Nina Pigulevskaya in 1960[1] is all that is published about the MS. There are also a number of documents on this subject that belong to the personal archives of Dr Pigulevskaya[2] and to the Manuscripts Department of the Russian National Library where she worked as a curator of Oriental MSS in the 1920s. According to the archival materials, the Library acquired the MS of the Akathistos in 1859 from K. von Tischendorf's collection.

Basic information on the MS provided by Dr Pigulevskaya is as follows. The parchment MS consists of 15 folios, their dimensions being 22 × 13 cm, in one column, with 18-21 lines per page. Folio 1r bears no text; some other folios (12, 13, 14) are damaged. The script is characterised as a Melkite hand. The whole text is written in black ink, while the general heading and the headings of each part are written in cinnabar. The text has no vocalisation; diacritical points are used for indicating plurals and pronouns. The MS is incomplete. Dr Pigulevskaya dates it to the tenth or eleventh century.

The Syriac text begins with words *ktbynn t'wtwqy* (Syr. New Series 11, fol. 1v), 'we write *Theotokia*', which permits one to define it as a collection of hymns to the Virgin. There are eight general parts entitled *ql'* (literally 'voices', 'sounds'), which means here 'modes'. According to Dr Pigulevskaya, the text by its contents and the presence of numerous *chairetismoi* (Greek χαίρε or χαίροις, Syriac *šlm lky*; salutations to the Theotokos) is similar to the Akathistos Hymn. Besides, it might be related by its headings to some genres of non-Chalcedonian literature – Coptic *Theotokia* and Jacobite *ql'*. But without any doubt the text is of Melkite origin. There are numerous Orthodox Christological formulae and the character of script itself to attest this. Thus the

[1] N.V. Pigulevskaya, 'Catalogue of the Syriac Manuscripts in Leningrad', in *Palestinskiy Sbornik* (Moscow-Leningrad), 6(69) (1960), 152 (in Russian).

[2] Archives of the Russian Academy of Sciences, St Petersburg Branch, fond 1036 (N.V. Pigulevskaya collection), inventory 1, files 17 and 19.

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text represents an example of original Melkite liturgical poetry written during or shortly after the Nestorian and Monophysite controversies.

The new study of the St Petersburg MS permits us to make some additions to the previous conclusion and to correct it. First of all, codicological analysis of the MS and checking flesh- and hair-sides of the parchment showed two well-defined quaternions. The second one lacks the last folio, and the total number of folios is fifteen. The present small codex could be either part of a more extensive liturgical book or a particular collection of the *Theotokia*.

Even if the text lacks some final strophes, it does not break its obvious octonary structure. There are in all fifty-one available strophes. Every mode consists of a different number of them, from five to nine. Use of the *chairetismoi* is irregular in the text as well. Thus one may suppose that the present hymnographic form is not the Akathistos Hymn at all, but probably a part or special form of the *Oktoechos* – the Orthodox liturgical book containing various sets of hymns in eight modes.

For designating modes the Syriac word *ql'* is used in our text. In the poetry of St Ephraim this word indicates a syllabic model for the following stanzas of a poem, or a melody, as E. Beck interpreted it[3]. In the West Syriac liturgy *ql'* seems to have two meanings – both a kind of modal indication and a sort of poem, *mdrš'* and *swgyt'* alike[4]. Using *ql'* for 'mode' in Melkite tradition is quite rare, since transcription of the Greek word ἦχος (*'ykws*) and Syriac *rkn'* with such a meaning became widespread (see Melkite *Oktoechoi* in the collection of the British Library)[5]. An example of the use of *ql'* for 'mode' may be found in the Palestinian Syriac *Horologion* of 1188, which comes from Jerusalem and was published by M. Black[6].

Textological analysis of the St Petersburg MS permitted us to recognise its contents as the *Theotokia* of *stichera* and *kathismata* of the Greek *Oktoechos*, translated into Syriac. The earliest known Greek MS of the *Oktoechos* (Sinait. Gr. 1593), which is of Melkite origin and dates presumably from the ninth century[7],

[3] See the corpus of genuine works of St Ephraim published by E. Beck in CSCO Syr (1957-62).

[4] A. Baumstark. *Festbrevier und Kirchenjahr der Syrischen Jacobiten* (Paderborn, 1910), pp. 62-8; H. Husmann, 'Zur Geschichte des Qala', *OCP* 45 (1979), 99-113, and other works by H. Husmann; J. Sanders, 'The Beth Gazo or the Octo-Echoes of the West Syrian Church', *The Harp* 5 (1992), 22-3.

[5] Brit. Lib. Add. 17133 (XI c.), Add. 14508 (XI or XII c.), etc.; see W. Wright, *Catalogue of Syriac Manuscripts in the British Museum*, part I (London, 1870), pp. 324-9.

[6] M. Black, *A Christian Palestinian Syriac Horologion (Berlin MS Or. Oct. 1019)* (Cambridge, 1954), pp. 359f.

[7] This collection of the *stichera* and *kathismata* represents a part of a greater *Parakletike* (Sinait. Gr. 1593 – Sinait. Gr. 776 – Brit. Lib. Add. 26113). See H. Husmann, 'Hymnus und Troparion: Studien zur Geschichte der musikalischen Gattungen von Horologion und Tropologion', *Jahrbuch des Staatlichen Instituts für Musikforschung Preussischer Kulturbesitz* (1971), p. 33.

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includes wide sets of similar hymns to the Virgin. At least nine of them seem to be an original version of the Syriac *Theotokia*. The Early Sinaitic *Parakletike* (Sinait. Gr. 778) dated to the tenth or eleventh century[8], adds three more pieces corresponding to the contemporary Syriac patterns. Marian *stichera* and *kathismata* of other early Greek and Syriac MSS of the *Oktoechos* are subjects for my further study. The published version of the *Parakletike*, or *Great Oktoechos* based upon late Greek MSS contains most of the canticles mentioned above. Marian hymns in the third and sixth modes (Syr. New Series 11, fol. 4v-5r and fol. 10v-11r) are entitled here *Theotokia Dogmatica*[9].

Syriac MSS originating from St Catherine's Monastery on Mount Sinai provide us with more material. Among new finds recorded in 1975 there are fragments of the Syriac *Theotokia*, described and photographed in the *Catalogue* edited by S. Brock[10]. There are two strophes (fol. 1r-1v and fol. 2v) of fragment 68, dated to the ninth century[11], that I managed to identify as *stichera* in the first mode, the Syriac text of which corresponds entirely to that of our MS (Syr. New Series 11, fol. 1v-2v).

An important argument for the Sinaitic origin of the present Syriac translation is its dependence upon the earliest Syriac translation of the Gospels – *Syrus Sinaiticus*, going back to the second century. One may take, for example, the expression *klnyn šrbt' yhbn lh twb'* found in the *Theotokion* in the third mode (Syr. New Series 11, fol. 5r), which corresponds to Luke 1:48 in the *Syrus Sinaiticus*: *twb' nhwyn yhbn ly klhyn šrbt'*, in contradistinction to the same passage in the Peshitta translation: *twb' ntln ly šrbt' klhyn*[12].

A curious example of the penetration of Melkite translated literature into Jacobite tradition is presented by *tkšpt'* (supplications) attributed in some MSS to Rabbula, bishop of Edessa[13]. The earliest MS containing *tkšpt* in eight modes is Vat. Syr. 94[14], entitled by S.E. and J.S. Assemani '*Oktoechos* of Severus of Antioch' and dating, according to its colophon, to the beginning of the eleventh century[15]. The MS originates from the monastery of the Virgin

[8] *Ibid.*, p. 34.

[9] Παρακλητικὴ ἤτοι Ὀκτώηχος ἡ Μεγάλη (Athens, 1994), pp. 249, 595-6.

[10] S.P. Brock, *Catalogue of Syriac Fragments (New Finds) in the Library of the Monastery of Saint Catherine, Mount Sinai* (Athens, 1995), pp. 65-7.

[11] *Ibid.*, pp. 66, 268-9.

[12] G.A. Kiraz, *Comparative Edition of the Syriac Gospels. Aligning the Sinaiticus, Curetonianus, Peshitta and Harklean Versions*, vol. 3 (Leiden, 1996), p. 16.

[13] Brit. Lib. Add. 17238; cf. J. Overbeck, *S. Ephraemi Syri, Rabulae Episcopi Edesseni, Balaei aliorumque opera selecta* (Oxford, 1865), pp. 245-6. Bibl. Medicea Laurenziana Cod. Orientalis 308 (XL), fol. 32v; cf. S.E. Assemani, *Bibliothecae Mediceae Laurenzianae et Palatinae codicum MSS Orientalium Catalogus* (Florence, 1742), p. 78.

[14] A. Cody, 'The Early History of the Oktoechos in Syria', in *East of Byzantium: Syria and Armenia in the Formative Period*, ed. N.G. Garsoïan *et al.* (Washington, D.C., 1982), p. 93.

[15] S.E. and J.S. Assemani, *Bibliothecae Apostolicae Vaticanae codicum manuscriptorum catalogus*, I, 2 (Rome, 1758), p. 500.

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(Deir al-Surian) in Wadi al-Natrun. There are at least five *tkšpt' dyldt 'lh'* (supplications to the Virgin) having the same Greek archetype as those from the St Petersburg MS. Two *tkšpt* (Vat. Syr. 94, fol. 165r and fol. 168v-169r) correspond to the Melkite translation of the *Theotokia* in the seventh and eighth modes (Syr. New Series 11, fol. 11v-12v and fol. 14r-14v),while three more strophes represent another Syriac version (Vat. Syr. 94, fol. 142v-143r, fol. 145v-146r, and fol. 156v; cf. Syr. New Series 11, fol. 1v-2r and fol. 3r-3v). Thus we have a clear illustration of the idea occurring in the work of H. Husmann and accepted by A. Cody of the penetration of Greek hymnography into Jacobite tradition by means of Melkite Syriac translations[16]. Perhaps liturgical use of *tkšpt* might have been influenced by Greek *stichera* and Syriac *'nyn'* alike.

A text differing from both these versions is encountered in the above mentioned Palestinian Syriac *Horologion* of the twelfth century. Here we find the *Theotokion* of the second plagal mode, *yldt 'lh' btwlt'. 'nty 'ytyky gpt' šryrt'* (Syr. New Series 11, fol. 11v), 'Mother of God the Virgin, thou art the true vine'[17], which has the *troparion* of the service of the third hour in the Greek Great *Horologion* as its archetype[18].

Of great interest in our MS is the *Theotokion* in the first plagal mode, *tht knp' dmrhmnwtky'* (Syr. New Series 11, fol. 9r), that is none other than the early Christian hymn '*Sub tuum praesidium*', 'ὑπὸ τὴν σὴν εὐσπλαγχνίαν', known from the papyrus JRL 470 of the fourth century[19]. This item passed over into the Great *Horologion* of the Greek church as a *troparion* for the service of Vespers[20] as well as into the *Triodion* for the Sunday of the Last Judgement[21]. Thus it represents the earliest pattern of the *Theotokia*.

Finally, I propose some preliminary conclusions of the present research. The text of the St Petersburg MS undoubtedly is the collection of the *Theotokia*, short hymns to the Virgin translated from Greek into Syriac for use in Melkite communions. The translation could have been made in St Catherine's Monastery on Mount Sinai, one of the Melkite strongholds. The presumed date of the translation is the ninth century, on the basis of the earliest known MSS – Sinait. Gr. 1593 and Sinaitic Syriac Sp. 68. The MS might have been

[16] H. Husmann, 'Die melkitische Liturgie als Quelle der syrischen Qanune iaonaie (Melitene und Edessa)', *OCP* 41 (1975), 5-56; idem., 'Syrischer und Byzantinischer Oktoëchos. Kanones und Qanune', *OCP* 44 (1978), 65-73; cf. Cody, 'Early History', pp. 97-9.

[17] Cf. Black, *Horologion*, pp. 205-6.

[18] 'Ωρολόγιον τὸ Μέγα (Athens, 1973), p. 84. Cf. Τριῴδιον (Athens, 1992), pp. 68, 83, 142, 219 (during Shrovetide and Lent).

[19] M.C.N. Roberts, *Catalogue of the Greek and Latin Papyri in the John Rylands Library Manchester* (Manchester, 1938), III, 46-7; F. Mercenier, 'L'Antienne mariale grecque la plus ancienne', *Mus* 52 (1939), 229-33; H. Husmann, 'Hymnus und Troparion', pp. 9-13, and other works.

[20] 'Ωρολόγιον, p. 125.

[21] Τριῴδιον, p. 77.

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brought by C. Tischendorf from Sinai and then acquired among numerous MSS from his collection by the Imperial Public Library (now the Russian National Library) in St Petersburg.

It seems to me that our MS represents a separate and unique collection of selected *Theotokia*, which was probably a special type of the *Oktoechos – Theotokia*. The history of this kind of liturgical book has not yet been studied, and it is difficult to ascertain whether the Syriac-speaking Melkites used an already existing Greek archetype or it was a product of their own tradition. The Syriac *Theotokia* could reflect, specifically, Sinaitic liturgical practice of veneration of the Virgin.

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Greek or Syriac? Chapters in the Establishment of a Syrian Orthodox Exegetical Tradition

Bas ter Haar Romeny, Leiden

After the seventh century, Arab rule gradually started to weaken the position of the Syrian Orthodox or West Syrian Church. In this period, members of this Church edited a number of anthologies and summaries of earlier exegetical literature. In the process of sifting, selecting, and summarizing, choices were made and new elements were added. Thus an authoritative interpretative tradition was built that helped to give answers to questions posed by the political and religious circumstances of the period. In this paper I shall discuss one aspect of the question of how these exegetical collections contributed to the formation of a specifically Syrian Orthodox identity. My main examples are the so-called *London Collection* (possibly compiled in the second quarter of the seventh century) and the *Collection of Simeon* (end of the ninth century; formerly known as *Catena Severi*). It will be argued that the difference in structure of these works indicates that their compilers had different perceptions of the tradition they wanted to lay down and pass on to the next generation.

Biblical Interpretation among the Syrian Orthodox

I shall start with a quick look at the history of Syrian Orthodox biblical interpretation, in order to position the works under discussion. The School of Edessa, where the great Syriac exegete Ephrem worked after 363 and which played a pivotal role in the development of the early Syrian exegetical tradition, became divided in the fifth century over the works of Theodore of Mopsuestia. This Greek Antiochene theologian and exegete was one of the main sources of inspiration for the Dyophysites. The adoption of his exegesis and anthropology also met with resistance, however. The early Miaphysite exegete and poet Jacob of Serug, for example, felt more at home with Ephrem's views and those of moderate Alexandrian exegetes. Yet Jacob of Serug and his opponents still had much in common. First of all, they shared a common Edessan tradition. In addition, it seems that the Miaphysite opposition to Theodore did not necessarily lead to the acceptance of the radical allegorizing trend of some of the Alexandrians. The Miaphysites sought to achieve a balance between the Antiochene 'historical' approach and spiritual exegesis. At the end of the sixth century, the West Syrians had a complex literary culture, which combined

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Greek, Hebrew, and indigenous components. They stood in interrelationship with surrounding cultures, but expressed their own interests with the help of all traditions available to them[1]. It is in this vein that we should also see the very influential work of the polymath Jacob of Edessa in the following century, when the advent of Islam relieved the Syrian orthodox from the pressures of the Chalcedonians[2].

The first centuries of Islamic rule were a period of reinventing tradition: the split between the Miaphysites, Chalcedonians, and Diophysites had become definitive, and the political landscape had changed because of the victories of the Arab armies over the Byzantines. The collections I will be discussing come from this period. The *London Collection* consists of extracts from various, mainly Greek authors in Syriac translation, forming a commentary on most of the Old and New Testament. For the Pentateuch we find the names of Cyril of Alexandria, Severus of Antioch, Gregory of Nazianzus, and Ephrem; for the Prophets, Athanasius, Cyril, Severus, Basil the Great, Gregory of Nyssa, John Chrysostom, and again Ephrem as the only Syrian authority. In addition, the *London Collection* has several appendices dealing with moral and other questions[3]. The core of the *Collection of Simeon* is formed by the *Commentary of the Monk Severus*. Severus' work consisted, as he himself states in a colophon, of a commentary on difficult words of the Old Testament, based mainly on Ephrem and Jacob of Edessa, and a commentary on the New Testament, based mainly on John Chrystostom. Simeon, after whom the collection is named, added a number of long insertions, as well as some marginal comments, often with a clear attribution to a specific author and a particular work[4].

From the period of Simeon, one could also mention the work of Moses bar Kepa, which likewise builds on predecessors. The tenth and eleventh centuries, however, showed little activity in Syriac exegesis. It was not until the period of the Syriac Renaissance, in the twelfth and thirteenth century, that Dionysius Bar Salibi and Barhebraeus compiled new exegetical collections. These works lean on the eighth- and ninth-century collections, but do show evidence of further 'cultivation' and 'pruning' of the tradition. Since the thirteenth century, hardly any new material has been added to the exegetical tra-

[1] Lucas Van Rompay, 'The Christian Syriac Tradition of Interpretation', in M. Sæbø (ed.), *Hebrew Bible/Old Testament. The History of Its Interpretation*, 1. *From the Beginnings to the Middle Ages (Until 1300)*, 1. *Antiquity* (Göttingen, 1996), pp. 612–41, especially 637–41.

[2] Lucas Van Rompay, 'Past and Present Perceptions of Syriac Literary Tradition', *Hugoye* [http://syrcom.cua.edu/Hugoye/] 3.1 (2000), §§ 11–23.

[3] The collection survives in a single manuscript, British Library Add. 12168. See William Wright, *Catalogue of Syriac Manuscripts in the British Museum Acquired since the Year 1838*, 2 (Piscataway, NJ, 2002 = London, 1871), pp. 904–8.

[4] Simeon's autograph is found in MS Vat. Syr. 103. Cf. S.E. and J.S. Assemani, *Bibliothecae apostolicae Vaticanae codicum manuscriptorum catalogus*, 1.3 (Paris, 1926 = Rome, 1759), pp. 7–28, with an important correction in T. Jansma, 'The Provenance of the Last Sections in the Roman Edition of Ephraem's Commentary on Exodus', *Mus* 85 (1972), pp. 155–67, esp. 160.

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dition. Some of the existing collections have assumed canonical status themselves, and are fostered and studied to the present day[5].

The Structure of the Collections: Building Different Traditions?

For most books, the London compiler does not follow a single commentary, but takes extracts from the Syro-Hexapla (the Syriac translation produced in 615-617 by Paul of Tella on the basis of the Hexaplaric Septuagint), while adding comments from various sources, sometimes with an attribution, at other times without. Wherever he takes over the scriptural reading from the commentary he wants to quote, the form of the biblical text quoted can help us to reveal the origin of the interpretation. It is significant, in this respect, that the Peshitta of the Old Testament (the second-century Syriac translation based on a Hebrew text) is found only in a very small number of instances. This is paralleled by the fact that nearly all exegetes quoted by name wrote in Greek. As we have seen, Ephrem is the only Syriac exegete mentioned. The impression one gains is that the London collector would have liked to do without the Peshitta altogether. If one compares his exposition on the versions of the Bible with that given by Moses bar Kepa around 900, the striking difference is that the latter also explains about versions in Syriac, in a passage added to the material he took from Epiphanius. In the *London Collection*, we do find information on the Syro-Hexapla, but not on the Peshitta. Yet the London compiler could not completely ignore the fact that most of his readers were familiar with this version. Thus he puts the book of Job immediately after the Pentateuch, as is quite common in Syriac tradition, in contrast to the order of the Milan Syro-Hexapla. And in his comment on the material that was to be used for building an altar in Exod. 20:24, he explains that the Syro-Hexapla's word 'mud' is in fact the same as 'earth' – the word known to the readers as the rendering of the Peshitta (London MS fol. 11a)[6].

It is not only the Greek biblical text that our compiler tries to make acceptable to his readers, but also the Greek exegetical material that he quotes. In this respect we should note not only the obvious fact that he offers all material in translation, or his token references to Ephrem, the greatest of Syriac

[5] Lucas Van Rompay, 'Development of Biblical Interpretation in the Syrian Churches of the Middle Ages', in M. Sæbø (ed.), *Hebrew Bible/Old Testament. The History of Its Interpretation*, 1. *From the Beginnings to the Middle Ages (Until 1300)*, 2. *The Middle Ages* (Göttingen, 2000), pp. 559–77, especially 753–7.

[6] On the issue of the biblical text in the *London Collection*, see also my 'The Greek vs. the Peshitta in a West Syrian Exegetical Collection', in K.D. Jenner and R.B. ter Haar Romeny (eds.), *The Peshitta: Its Use in Literature and Liturgy: Papers Read at the Third Peshitta Symposium, Oud Poelgeest, 12-15 Augustus 2001*, Monographs of the Peshitta Institute, Leiden (Leiden, forthcoming).

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exegetes from before the split. More important is perhaps the fact that he has used abbreviated versions of the existing full translations, those of Athanasius, Cyril, and Gregory of Nyssa, among others[7]. It would seem that our compiler is offering West Syrian readers, familiar with the Peshitta, a digest of Greek material in a form that is meant to replace earlier Syriac material. He tries to make this new tradition acceptable through its form and through a very limited number of links to the earlier tradition[8].

One might ask whether the London compiler was at all successful in this endeavour. At first sight, if we look at the numer of copies left to us, this does not seem to be the case. A real answer, however, can only be given if we have a fuller picture of the influence of this collection, or its constituent parts, on later West Syrian exegesis. It is already clear that authors such as Jacob of Edessa and his followers adopted large parts of these 'Greek' interpretations. The interpretations of Athanasius, Cyril, and Gregory of Nyssa were thus 'Syriacized' in three stages: after the full translation, an abbreviated version was produced; and later Syriac authors wrote their own commentaries on the basis of either the shorter or the full version, adopting interpretations without indicating the source.

Whereas some longer passages in the *London Collection* belong to the second of the stages just mentioned, I would argue that the Old Testament part of the *Collection of Simeon* or, more precisely, its core, the *Commentary of Severus*, represents the last. This work makes an impression completely different from the *London Collection*: the biblical text quoted is that of the Peshitta, the main authorities said to have been excerpted are Ephrem and Jacob of Edessa. The quotations from the Greek Bible are few and they are clearly marked as readings from the *Yawnaya*, 'the Greek'; the number of explicit references to Greek exegetes, most of which were added by Simeon rather than Severus, is likewise low. All in all, the work seems to be the opposite of the *London Collection*: this is the best of Syriac exegesis on the authentic Syriac Bible, with only passing references to Greek sources. The fact that the New Testament part is said to be based on John Chrystostom shows that there is no full opposition between Greek and Syriac; the reason for this may well be that there was no traditional Syriac alternative, as Ephrem had written a commen-

[7] The shorter version of Athanasius' *Expositiones in Psalmos* has been edited from BL Add. 12168 by Robert W. Thomson, *Athanasiana Syriaca* 4, CSCO 386–87, Syr 167–68 (Leuven, 1977), together with a fragmentary version of the longer text. Cyril is quoted for Genesis, among other books. For Gregory of Nyssa, see C. Van den Eynde, *La version syriaque du commentaire de Grégoire de Nysse sur le cantique des cantiques; ses origines, ses témoins, son influence*, Bibliothèque du Muséon 10 (Leuven, 1939), pp. 49–9.

[8] In this respect, and also in his choice of authors, his work is comparable to the theological treatise written to the monks of Senun by Philoxenus of Mabbog (d. 523). Philoxenus wrote this work at the end of his life. In earlier works, such as his *Memre* against Habbib, quotations of Ephrem were still of central importance. See Van Rompay, 'Past and Present Perceptions', § 10 with n. 5.

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tary on the Diatessaron, rather than on the four Gospels. Still, one cannot deny that there is a shift from a preference for all things Greek to an interest in what seemed to be authentic Syriac material. This fits very well with the atmosphere among the Syrian Orthodox in the eighth and ninth centuries.

Sebastian Brock describes the paradoxical situation that in the seventh century the acceptance of Greek learning among the Syrians was at its height, whereas there was considerable discontent with the Byzantine Empire, especially for its religious politics[9]. If we look at the attitude of some Syrian monks at the end of that century, who quarrelled with Jacob of Edessa because they thought his teaching was too much concerned with Greek writings[10], it seems that the popularity of Greek learning among the West Syrians had met its Waterloo in that period. The rise of a negative attitude towards everything Greek seems to have been connected with a growing awareness of language as a boundary marker. Miaphysites in the first centuries after Chalcedon used Greek and Syriac, as did Chalcedonians. Gradually, however, Syriac became the language of the former, and Greek of the latter[11]. The arrival of the Arab forces, and especially the formal abolition of Greek in the civil service by Walid I in 708, worked as a catalyst: for the Miaphysites, this was an additional reason to distance themselves from Greek.

But is it at all correct to suggest an opposition between Greek and Syriac traditions? If one looks at the way the material was presented at the time, the answer should be affirmative. That the opposition between Greek and Syriac authors is not just an invention of the twenty-first century onlooker is also clear from examples such as the 45th chapter of book I of Moses bar Kepa's *Commentary on the Hexaemeron*, the title of which is 'On the Creation of the Elements, according to the Greek and Syriac Teachers'[12]. In this chapter, Greek and Syriac fathers are placed in opposition to each other. The historian, however, would have to answer in the negative. Not only was the Syriac tradition Hellenized from its very start; I have also suggested above that what was

[9] Sebastian P. Brock, 'From Antagonism to Assimilation: Syriac Attitudes to Greek Learning', in N. Garsoïan *et al.* (eds.), *East of Byzantium: Syria and Armenia in the Formative Period (Dumbarton Oaks Symposium, 1980)* (Washington DC, 1982), pp. 17–34, reprinted as Chapter V of his *Syriac Perspectives on Late Antiqity*, Collected Studies CS 199 (London, 1984); especially pp. 17–25.

[10] See W. Wright, *A Short History of Syriac Literature* (London, 1894), p. 143, and J.M. Fiey, 'Jacques, dit "l'Interprète", évêque d'Édesse', *DHGE*, 26 (Paris, 1997), pp. 663–4. It was out of sheer necessity that Jacob of Edessa, with his great knowledge and love of Greek, became instrumental in what Lucas Van Rompay calls the 'redressing of the balance' between the two streams within Syriac culture ('Past and Present Perceptions', § 22).

[11] Cf. Sebastian P. Brock, 'Greek and Syriac in Late Antique Syria', in Alan K. Bowman and Greg Woolf (eds.), *Literacy and Power in the Ancient World* (Cambridge, 1994), pp. 149–60, reprinted as Chapter I of his *From Ephrem to Romanos: Interactions between Syriac and Greek in Late Antiquity*, Collected Studies CS 664 (Aldershot, 1999); especially pp. 157–9.

[12] Lorenz Schlimme, *Der Hexaemeronkommentar des Moses bar Kepha*, 1. Göttinger Orientforschungen I. Reihe, Syriaca 14 (Wiesbaden, 1977), pp. 174–5.

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styled as 'Syriac' had in fact assimilated a very large chunk of material from Greek-speaking authors. Jacob of Edessa was thoroughly influenced by Greek authors such as Cyril, and the monk Severus also added interpretations that cannot be traced back to either Ephrem or Jacob; in many cases these must have come from Greek sources. We see the paradox that an anti-Greek attitude (or at least a wish to appear independent from Greek learning) goes together with a full appropriation of the contribution of Greek authors to the Syrian Orthodox tradition. The boundary is therefore an imagined one, and the Syrianness of the tradition is invented. But is that, ultimately, not a characteristic of all traditions?[13]

Concluding Remarks

The West Syrian exegetical collections, though they seem much more conservative and irenic than the polemic and apologetic genres written by the same group of Syrians, did contribute to their sense of belonging together. They put less stress on the boundaries of Syrian Orthodox beliefs and views, and more on their content. They offered the right views on the physics and metaphysics of creation, they sketched the relation between the peoples on the earth, dealt with problems such as the origin of evil and what was to be expected at the end of time, and made explicit the ethical code and doctrines of the community on the basis of the authoritative text of the Scriptures. Offering this kind of content – a narrative of what a Syrian Orthodox Christian should think and believe – fulfilled an important function: it helped to strengthen the existing community. In an implicit way, however, the choice of content also set the boundaries between the Syrian Orthodox and the others. These boundaries appear when the use of sources in these collections is studied, as well as the differences between them and their East Syrian and Chalcedonian counterparts.

It is often stated that Syriac exegesis, and especially later Syriac exegesis, is not creative or original. It is true that earlier material plays a very important role, in all West and East Syriac exegesis. But wherever these sources are known and still available to us, they enable us to look into the mind of the compiler. It is the subtle strategy of adoption and rejection of earlier material that needs to be described. It not a few cases, the comparison with earlier material tells us more of what was considered important at a certain moment than a so-called original work might do. Therefore, in order to obtain a fuller picture of the contribution of the two collections, and exegesis in general, to the formation of a West Syrian identity, the methods of the two compilers

[13] Cf. Eric Hobsbawm, 'Introduction: Inventing Traditions', in Eric Hobsbawm and Terence Ranger, *The Invention of Tradition* (Cambridge, 1983), pp. 1–14.

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must be mapped further, and their work compared with other collections[14]. It has already become clear, however, that when we define these works as traditional, we should not forget that they were in fact inventing or building the tradition. The comparison between the two Syrian Orthodox collections indicates that the period of the seventh to the ninth century was indeed a critical one in this process. The way this tradition was perceived at the beginning of the period was not the same as at the end.

[14] This study is now being undertaken as part of the Leiden PIONIER project 'The Formation of a Communal Identity among West Syrian Christians', funded by the Netherlands Organization for Scientific Research (NWO). Its basis will be formed by an edition and annotated translation of the Pentateuch parts of the two collections discussed here.

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Is There an Armenian Tradition of Exegesis?

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This title is not meant to be facetious, since there is clearly a great number of biblical commentaries written in the Armenian language[1]. Rather, it is a shorthand way of asking whether there are any common factors in original works in that language. Armenian translations have long been exploited for the study of Greek and Syriac patristic texts; but the other side of the coin has been less studied. What are the general characteristics of Armenian commentaries? Related is the question as to which Greek and Syriac writings were influential in the formation of that tradition. Here the first question will occupy our attention.

The most obvious obstacle in broaching the subject is that of the many Armenian texts which fall into this general category, in literally thousands of manuscripts in Armenia, Jerusalem, Venice, and many other important libraries, not all have been carefully catalogued[2]. Only a selection of texts has ever been published. And of those published texts, only an even narrower selection can be found in any western library. Investigation is therefore cramped by the lack of access to all the sources relevant to the subject.

Here I shall concentrate on the earlier period, that is, from the time when Armenians began writing in their own language in the fifth century, down to the tenth century. It seems logical enough to begin at the beginning rather than in later times, when the mass of material becomes overwhelming – for by the twelfth century some authors were extremely prolific in commentary making. Less is known about the earlier centuries, since much has perished. So I shall concentrate on a few texts which have only recently been published, which are reasonably modest in length, and which have never been translated. I think that

[1] There is no complete study of this subject. For texts published up to 1992 see R.W. Thomson, *A Bibliography of Classical Armenian Literature to 1500 AD* (Turnhout, 1995), 250-3, 'Commentaries', with references to authors in the main Bibliography. A valuable introduction may be found in J.-P. Mahé, 'Traduction et exégèse, Réflexions sur l'exemple arménien', in *Mélanges Antoine Guillamont*, Contributions à l'étude des christianismes orientaux, Cahiers d'Orientalisme 20 (Geneva, 1988), 243-55; see also his 'L'Arménie et les Pères de l'Eglise: Histoire et mode d'emploi (Ve-XIIe siècle)', in *La documentation patristique. Bilan et prospective*, ed. J.-C. Fredouille and R.M. Roberge (Laval and Paris, 1995), 157-79.

[2] B. Coulie, *Répertoire des bibliothèques et des catalogues de manuscripts arméniens* (Turnhout, 1992); with two supplements in *Mus* 108 (1995), 115-30, and 113 (2000), 149-76.

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these will point to a variety of approaches and interpretations, and will provide a background against which later developments may eventually be assessed.

There is a further problem with the title – 'Exegesis'. For many years I have been studying a variety of Armenian literary works, historical as well as theological, and have tried to point to the ways in which the bible was used for rhetorical effect as well as as a basis for buttressing points of theology[3]. To what extent Armenian authors followed a common pattern of interpretation in these areas would certainly be worth investigation. But to keep this paper within bounds I shall focus on the specific genre of commentary. In fact, Armenians used different formats for the presentation of text and explanation. So here I shall not include works like the Catechism known as the *Teaching of Saint Gregory*, which is fundamental for Armenian biblical exegesis[4], or the numerous homilies which interpret the biblical narrative in a running paraphrase[5].

From the very moment when Armenians began to translate using their newly invented script they were, of course, faced with problems of exegesis. The rendering of the biblical text involved decisions about the meaning and interpretation of the Syriac and Greek. Hebrew was not known directly; although many authors were interested in the meaning of Hebrew names, their interpretations were derived from secondary sources[6]. The problem of translation is not directly addressed by the first Armenian writers who describe the invention of the script and the initial renderings from Syriac and Greek. But among the early translations is Eusebius of Emesa's *Commentary on the Octateuch* – one of those texts lost in the original, but preserved in Armenian, which drew patristic scholars to Armenian so long ago. Surprisingly, Eusebius's commentary was not published until 1980[7].

In his introduction Eusebius discusses the technical problems of translation, indicating that the right method is to transpose the sense from one idiom (Hebrew) into another idiom (Greek), not to render one of the literal meanings of a word which may make no sense in the second language[8]. This is

[3] See, for example, R.W. Thomson, 'Uses of the Psalms in some Early Armenian Authors', in *From Byzantium to Iran: Armenian Studies in Honour of Nina G. Garsoïan*, ed. J.-P. Mahé and R.W. Thomson (Atlanta, 1997), 281-300.

[4] R.W. Thomson, *The Teaching of Saint Gregory*, revised edn, AVANT 1 (New Rochelle, NY, 2001). The original edition was published in the series Harvard Armenian Texts and Studies, no. 3 (Cambridge, MA, 1970).

[5] Some of the homilies attributed to Ełišē fall into this category; see R.W. Thomson, *A Homily on the Passion of Christ attributed to Elishe*, Eastern Christian Texts in Translation 5 (Leuven, 2000).

[6] See further below for such secondary sources. Cf. F. Macler, 'Les traducteurs arméniens ont'ils connu et utilisé l'hébreu?', *Handes Amsorya* 41 (1927), 609-16.

[7] Ewsebeay Emesac'i, *Meknut'iwnk' ut'amatean groc' Astuacašnč'in*, ed. V. Hovhannēsean (Venice, 1980).

[8] This passage is expounded in Mahé, 'Traduction et exégèse', 248-50.

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particularly interesting, in that Eusebius' opinion is reflected in the Armenian practice of the fifth century, most notably in the translation of the Gospels, compared to the later Armenian Hellenophile tradition of very literal translation. In other words, in the early translation of the bible the translators strove for accuracy of rendering, employing the wide range of Armenian vocabulary and idiom in the context of each passage. Quite different was the approach of later translators dealing with scholarly works in Greek. They sought for consistency of vocabulary, always using the same word for a Greek term regardless of its resonance in Armenian, and inventing a wide range of new technical terms[9].

The interpretation of the meaning of the biblical text was thus inherent in the very first efforts of Armenians to write in their own language, and echoes down through the development of an original literature. A number of later commentators remark on this inherent problem of translation, not least Gregory of Narek. In his *Commentary on the Song of Songs*, to which I shall refer again later, he notes that John (that is, John Chrysostom) says that one cannot render in Greek all the meaning of the Hebrew. As for us Armenians, adds Gregory, translations from Greek and Syriac remain obscure (*mt'ayl*)[10].

It was not long before Armenians expanded their horizons beyond biblical, liturgical, and theological writings and began to tackle secular works that circulated in the schools of the Eastern Mediterranean in the fifth century. Such school texts included commentaries on all sorts of subjects, among which grammar and philosophy were particularly important[11]. The *Ars Grammatica* of Dionysius Thrax, for example, was not only translated with appropriate modifications for the Armenian language; it formed the basis for a long series of commentaries of ever-increasing complexity that informed the later Armenian understanding of language in general[12]. In philosophy the Armenian translations of commentaries on Aristotle attributed to David, pupil of

[9] For a survey of this style of rendering see C. Mercier, 'L'école hellénistique dans la literature arménienne', *Revue des études arméniennes* 13 (1978/79), 59-75; and A. Terian, 'The Hellenizing School. Its Time, Place, and Scope of Activities Reconsidered', in *East of Byzantium: Syria and Armenia in the Formative Period*, ed. N.G. Garsoïan, T.F. Mathews, and R.W. Thomson (Washington DC, 1982), 175-86. There was a similar change in translation styles in Syriac; see D.G.K. Taylor, 'Bilingualism and Diglossia in Late Antique Syria and Mesopotamia', in *Bilingualism in Ancient Society*, ed. J.N. Adams, M. Janse, and S. Swain (Oxford 2002), 298-331, esp. 324-30 = §4, 'Syriac and Greek'.

[10] Commentary to 1.4. Armenian text in *Grigori Narekac'i Matenagrut'iwnk'* (Venice, 1840), 282. Italian translation by V. Mistrih, 'Commentario sul Cantico dei Cantici di Gregorio di Narek', *Studia Orientalia Christiana Collectanea* (Cairo) 12 (1967), 465-534; 13 (1968/69), 199-261. The reference to Chrysostom is perhaps to his Homilies on Genesis. In IV.4 (PG 53, 42-3) he notes the difference in modes of expression between Hebrew and Greek. Gregory of Nyssa, whose commentary on the Song of Songs was Narekac'i's model, has no reference to problems of translation in his comments to 1.4.

[11] The whole range of commentary material is discussed in M.E. Širinyan, 'Meknołakan žanri kazmavorumě ev zargac'umě Hayastanum', *Aštanak* 3 (2000), 36-64.

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Olympiodorus, also set a pattern for later detailed commentary[13]. So, drawing on the patterns of Syriac and Greek biblical commentaries as well as this secular material – whether phrased in a 'Question and Answer' format, a progressive examination of a text verse by verse, or as a homily or paraphrase – Armenians developed a wide range of styles in which to address the meaning of the text to be expounded.

The origins of Armenian biblical commentary are obscure, partly because the works of authors mentioned by later sources have not survived, and partly because surviving texts or fragments are attributed to shadowy persons about whom legends accumulated over the centuries. In the first category falls a certain Peter of Siwnik' – the large province east and south of Lake Sevan which always had a sense of quasi-independence from Greater Armenia. Its fourteenth-century metropolitan, the noted historian and scholar Step'annos Orbelean, states that this Peter, a pupil of Movsēs K'ert'ołahayr and later bishop of Siwnik', attended the council of Chalcedon[14]. Unfortunately, by the time of Step'annos Orbelean elaborate tales had circulated concerning many obscure early Armenian authors – the historian Movsēs Xorenac'i being the most famous, but also other supposed disciples of Maštoc', inventor of the Armenian script, like David 'the Invincible Philosopher'. Such persons were claimed to have been defenders of Armenian orthodoxy against the heretical Greeks long before the final schism[15]. There was a historical Peter, leading bishop of Siwnik', who played a role in the council of Dvin held in 555, over a century after Chalcedon[16], and the confusion of various Peters is noted by the tenth century historian Uxtanēs[17]. In

[12] For the Armenian translation of the original and the commentaries by (or attributed to) Movsēs K'ert'oł, Step'annos Siwnec'i, Grigor Magistros, Hamam, and one anonymous, see N. Adontz, *Denys de Thrace et les commentateurs arméniens*, tr. (from Russian (St Petersburg, 1915)) R. Hotterbeex (Louvain, 1970). For later Armenian commentaries and works on grammar, see Thomson, *Bibliography*, 255-6, with names of authors whose published works appear in the Bibliography.

[13] For works attributed to David, known in Armenian as David the Invincible, *Davit' Anyałt'*, see Thomson, *Bibliography*, 107-11. For later commentaries, see the works of Vahram Rabun and Yovhannēs Orotnec'i, cited *ibid.*, 209, 226.

[14] The Armenian text of the *History of the Province of Siwnik'*, *Patmut'iwn nahangin sisakan* (Paris, 1860 (reprinted Tiflis, 1910) and Moscow, 1861), was not available to me. See the French translation by M. Brosset, *Histoire de la Siounie par Stépannos Orbélian* (St Petersburg, 1864), ch. 22 (pp. 52-4).

[15] See R.W. Thomson, 'A quoi Movses Xorenac'i doit-il sa réputation?' in *Movsēs Xorenac'i et l'historiographie arménienne des origines*, ed. D. Kouymjian (Antelias, Lebanon, 2000), 55-70, esp. 56-9 for these legends.

[16] For the council and the letters with references to Peter, see N.G. Garsoïan, *L'Église arménienne et le grand schisme d'orient*, CSCO 574, Subs 100 (Leuven, 1999), esp. 296-9 for Orbelean's confusions.

[17] The Armenian text of Uxtanēs, *Patmut'iwn Hayoc'* (Vałaršapat, 1871), was not available to me; see the English translation of the second part of this work (part III being lost): Z. Arzoumanian, *Bishop Uxtanes of Sebasteia. History of Armenia, Part II* (Fort Lauderdale, 1985), ch. 53, pp. 102-3.

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any event, none of the commentaries on the Old and New Testaments attributed to Peter has survived.

It is interesting, however, that this early exegete is associated with Siwnik', as the earliest surviving commentary on the Gospels was written by the eminent scholar Step'annos, bishop of that region in the early eighth century, who is particularly noted for his translation of Pseudo-Dionysius[18]. Step'annos Orbelean was later to claim that the bishop of Siwnik' received from Maštoc' and the patriarch Sahak I the right of biblical commentary and interpretation, whatever that may mean[19]. But he says nothing about biblical commentary in this province after the high point of the eighth century. We shall return to Step'annos on the four Gospels a little later, but first a word on the commentaries of Ełišē, again a supposed fifth-century writer with links to Maštoc'.

To a certain Ełišē, about whom nothing is known save later legends, is attributed one of the most important works of classical Armenian literature, the *History of Vardan and the Armenian War*. This describes the uprising of 450 against Sasanian rule in the Persian sector of Armenia, the death of its leader Vardan on the battlefield of Avarayr the following year, and the ensuing imprisonment of Armenian nobles and clergy. Scholarly opinion remains divided on whether it was written by a contemporary eyewitness, or is a later literary elaboration of the same episode as described in the History of Łazar Parp'ec'i, which can be dated to the beginning of the sixth century. That is not important here. The main problem is that other works are attributed to the same Ełišē: homilies, of which a cycle on episodes in the earthly life of Christ are the best known; a commentary on Genesis, of which fragments survive in the thirteenth-century compilation of Vardan Arewelc'i; a brief commentary on Joshua and Judges; and a text known as 'Questions and Answers on Genesis'. This last is generally considered to be a later work; but is the main collection of texts to be considered as the oeuvre of a single person, and if so, are they all of the fifth century?

Recent research has highlighted many common concepts and a certain consistency of vocabulary[20], but I am not convinced that a fifth-century date has been proven. Suffice it to say here that the commentary on Genesis and that on Joshua-Judges are valuable examples of early Armenian exegesis. For the

[18] This translation was made circa 718 in Constantinople with the assistance of a certain David, *kellarios* of the royal court. See the Introduction to the edition of the Armenian text, *The Armenian Version of the Works attributed to Dionysius the Areopagite*, ed. R.W. Thomson, CSCO 488, Arm 17 (Leuven, 1987).

[19] Step'annos Orbelean (tr. Brosset), ch. 7, p. 17, and ch. 28, p. 72.

[20] See B.L. Zekiyan, 'Quelques observations critiques sur le Corpus Elisaeanum', in *The Armenian Christian Tradition*, ed. R.F. Taft, OCA 254 (Rome, 1997), 71-123; V. Mistrih, 'Ecrits théologiques du vardapet Elisé, père de l'Église arménienne (Ve siècle): présentation et analyse', *Studia Orientalia Christiana Collectanea* (Cairo) 19 (1986), 301-56. There is a brief summary in the Introduction to R.W. Thomson, *A Homily on the Passion*.

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fragments on Genesis we depend on the selection made by Vardan Arewelc'i, which may totally distort the thrust of the original in its entirety. Nonetheless, what survives is primarily addressed to a description of the natural world with parallels in hexaemeral literature[21]. Its general conception of the physical world has parallels in other early Armenian writers. Ełišē is concerned with the four elements of matter; the six spheres that surround the earth, which is balanced in the middle; the movement of the luminaries and the changing seasons; the dry land and the seas, and the names thereof; the creation of animals and their naming by Adam, with etymologies of the animals' names. Ełišē notes that Moses was silent about Adam being in paradise for 1000 years. But there is no reference to the common Armenian concern with the six periods of a thousand years for the travail of this world. According to the *Teaching of Saint Gregory*, in the sixth age the world was renewed by Christ's incarnation. At the end of this age he will come again to bring the seventh age of rest for the just[22]. Such ideas are frequent in the homilies attributed to Ełišē, but not in the fragments on Genesis. Unusually for Armenian biblical commentaries, that by Ełišē has topical references. He identifies the site of Mount Ararat: it is not in Korduk', as some say, nor in Cappadocia, but is our Masis. The building of the tower of Babel gives him an opportunity to introduce the story of Bel and Hayk, the eponymous ancestor of the Armenians, who call themselves in Armenian *Hayk'*. The scattering of the tongues leads Ełišē to thoughts about the characteristics of various tongues, and the fact that Armenian combines the best of them all in itself.

The text of these fragments was published in 1992, edited by Levon Ter-Petrosyan. The Armenian text had originally been prepared as part of a dissertation in 1945 by Levon Xač'ikyan, later director of the Matenadaran, but remained in typescript for nearly fifty years. Xač'ikyan already had noted the parallels with other Armenian writers and identified source material in Eusebius of Emesa and perhaps Basil of Caesarea, John Chrysostom, Eusebius of Caesarea, Philo, Hermes Trismegistus, Plato, Heraclitus, the Physiologus, and Dionysius Thrax[23].

The *Commentary on Joshua and Judges* is of a different character altogether, if indeed these works are by the same author[24]. In the first place it is

[21] The most influential such work in Armenia was the *Hexaemeron* of Basil of Caesarea (only Homilies I-IX; the textual tradition of Homilies X and XI is different, and they were not rendered into Armenian). It is noteworthy that this text was translated into Armenian from the Syriac version, not directly from the Greek (as was Eusebius of Caesarea's *Ecclesiastical History*, for example). The Syriac text was published by R.W. Thomson in CSCO Syr 222 and 223 (Leuven, 1995). Armenian text ed. K. Muradyan, *Barseł Kesarac'i. Yałags vec'awreay araršut'ean* (Erevan, 1984).

[22] *Teaching of Saint Gregory*, esp. §667-670.

[23] See the Introduction to *Ełišē. Araracoc' meknut'iwn*, ed. L. Xač'ikyan (Erevan, 1992).

[24] Armenian text in Ełišē, *Matenagrut'iwnk'* (Venice, 1840), 167-98.

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not a running commentary on the biblical text where successive verses are explained, but a series of discrete short essays on events in those two books. It begins with Joshua's sending of two spies to Jericho, where the number two is contrasted with the twelve men, one from each tribe, in chapter 3, setting the tone of number symbolism that pervades the whole text. Even more explicit is the section on the fall of Jericho, where the episode is explained as a 'model, or type', *tip awrinaki*[25], of the multiple sins of original human nature. The seven walls surrounding Jericho are the seven senses (two eyes, two ears, two nostrils, and mouth) of men who had shut themselves up in rebellion against God. This text and all the homilies attributed to Ełišē are the most fertile in early Armenian literature for such interpretations, which remained popular in later commentaries, though on a more muted scale. Ełišē is not much interested in the mathematical properties of numbers such as may be found in the writings of Ananias of Širak – ten as a 'perfect' number, for example – but rather in specific parallels between a biblical reference and physical phenomena[26]. The longest section is the last, on the life of Samson. Here Ełišē sees in Samson's career a 'mystery', *xorhurd*, or 'allegory', *aylabanut'iwn*. The details of the Old Testament text may all be elucidated in terms of Christ's dispensation, the church, or the working of the Holy Spirit. Many of the Old Testament allegories were commonplaces – the crossing of the Jordan and baptism, Rahab and the church, Gideon's fleece and the Incarnation. These parallels may be found in Origen. But the extreme wealth of detail and single-mindedness of approach in this short commentary by Ełišē are remarkable.

The first author of commentaries about whose life we have some knowledge is Step'annos of Siwnik', particularly famous for his translation of the Pseudo-Dionysian corpus made in Constantinople around 718[27]. His career is described by his much later successor as bishop of that province, the historian Step'annos Orbelean, who refers to Siwnik' in the eighth century as a New Athens[28]. The first Step'annos was a son of a priest at Dvin, then the residence of the Armenian Catholicos. He had been brought up at the patriarchate, then studied at the famous monastery of Makenoc' under its abbot Solomon[29],

[25] Here the words *tip* and *awrinak* are combined, lit. 'type of a model'. For such vocabulary see below, pp. 106.

[26] For a general survey, see R.W. Thomson, 'Number Symbolism and Patristic Exegesis in some early Armenian Writers', *Handes Amsorya* 90 (1976), 117-38; reprinted in his *Studies in Armenian Literature and Christianity*, Variorum Collected Studies 451 (Aldershot, 1994). The treatise on numbers attributed to this Anania may well be the work of Anania Narekac'i, abbot of Narek and uncle of Gregory of Narek; see J.-P. Mahé, *Grégoire de Narek. Tragédie, le livre de lamentation*, CSCO 584, Subs 106 (Leuven, 2000), 53 and n. 202.

[27] See above, note 18.

[28] Step'annos Orbelean (tr. Brosset), ch. 31, pp. 81-8; Step'annos emphasizes the primacy of Siwnik' in translation and commentary, see above, n. 19.

[29] See M. van Esbroeck, 'Salomon de Makenoc', vardapet du VIII[e] siècle', *Armeniaca. Mélanges d'études arméniennes* (Venice, 1969), 33-44, for this famous scholar.

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before proceeding to Siwnik', where he became a disciple of the metropolitan Movsēs. Movsēs wished to make him his successor, but on the former's death Step'annos returned to Dvin, where he was charged with exposition of the scriptures. In Dvin he came into conflict with the prince of Armenia, Smbat Bagratuni Curopalates, whose allegiance alternately to the emperor and caliph dominated the politics of the period 691-711[30]. Smbat was a Chalcedonian, as indeed an imperial appointee would need to be; and according to the historian he worsted Step'annos in argument. So Step'annos betook himself to Constantinople to engage in deeper study. Here Orbelean's *History* gives a very fanciful account of his favour with the emperor Leo III (716-740), his good relations with the patriarch Germanos, and a visit to Rome and Athens before his return to Armenia, where he was consecrated bishop for Siwnik'.

Orbelean states that Step'annos composed commentaries on Genesis, Job, and Ezekiel, and wrote many other books in addition to hymns and musical chants. Kirakos Ganjakec'i of the thirteenth century adds a commentary on Daniel and a brief one (*hamarōt*) on the Gospels[31]. Of the biblical commentaries only this last has been published[32], though a short fragment of Step'annos on Job is included in the Armenian edition of Hesychius of Jerusalem's commentary on Job[33]. Step'annos also wrote a commentary on the Armenian translation of Dionysius Thrax[34], so his interest in grammar explains an important feature of the Gospel commentary – etymology. Curiously, the Pseudo-Dionysian corpus, which Step'annos translated with the cooperation of David, made no obvious impact on his explanation of the Gospels.

In this commentary Step'annos makes a clear distinction between the Gospels of Matthew and John. The former is the basis of the longest part of the work, which deals with the earthly life of Jesus. Step'annos calls Matthew a 'historian', who is to be contrasted with the 'theologian' John. A brief extract from Mark and longer quotations from Luke are added after the commentary to Matthew only to cover certain episodes not already found in Matthew. Since the original form of presentation of Ełišē on Genesis is unknown, this is the earliest Armenian commentary in the standard format of

[30] For this Smbat, see C. Toumanoff, *Studies in Christian Caucasian History* (Georgetown, 1963), 341; and J. Laurent, *L'Arménie entre Byzance et l'Islam depuis la conquête arabe jusqu'en 886*, nouvelle edition revue et mise à jour par M. Canard (Lisbon, 1980), 403.

[31] Kirakos Ganjakec'i, *Patmut'iwn Hayoc'*, ed. K. Melik'-Ōhanjanyan (Erevan, 1961), 29: *awetaranac'n hamařōt*.

[32] *Step'anos Siwnec'i. Meknut'iwn Č'oric' Awetaranc'ač'* [lit., 'Commentary on the Four Evangelists'], ed. M. Grigorean (Athens, 1988; reprinted Erevan, 1994). The work was originally discovered by Garegin Yovsep'ean, and noted in *Ararat* 1917, 193-8. The manuscript is now in the Matenadaran, no. 5551; it is dated to AD 1155. See Ō. Eganyan, A. Zeyt'unyan, P'. Ant'abyan, *C'uc'ak Jeŀagrac' Maštoc'i anvan Matenadarani*, Part II (Erevan, 1970), col. 131.

[33] *Isik'iosi Eric'u Erusałemac'woy. Meknut'iwn Yobay*, ed. K'. Č'rak'ean (Venice, 1913), 304-10.

[34] Text in Adontz, *Denys de Thrace*, 181-219.

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lemma from the biblical text followed by explanation. In citing and explaining his biblical text Step'annos often gives a rather free rendering of the Gospel verse, so his lemmata often diverge from the surviving standard Armenian text of the Gospels, which is the medieval Cilician text. In a different commentary to be discussed later, the author explicates one text, while the lemmata often present another[35]. But with Step'annos there is no such problem. Less clear is why much of the Gospel narrative is omitted. The book was described by Kirakos as *hamarōt*, 'brief, or abbreviated'[36]. Whether this was Step'annos' own expression is not clear. Many manuscripts contain only parts of the whole – that is, the section on Matthew, or more popularly, that on John.

Step'annos' procedure is straightforward: it is to elucidate problems. Unlike Ełišē's homiletic style, he is uninterested in the reader's emotional response; nor like some later commentators does he intend his book as an aid to spiritual reflection. He knows that the Hebrew and the Septuagint of the Old Testament may differ, as do the Greek renderings of Aquila and Theodotion from the Septuagint text; while in the Gospels there are numerous conflicts between the four evangelists – or at least, it seems that there are discrepancies, which Step'annos must explain as not being contradictory. A frequent expression is thus *xndreli ē*, 'it is to be investigated', to which the answer is *aseli ē*, 'one must say'. To justify his explanations he normally states, 'It seems to me', 'I think', 'perhaps', or some similar phrase to introduce the commentary. Like most Armenian authors, he rarely identifies his sources, though occasionally he notes that 'some have said'[37]. His only patristic reference is to 'the twelfth book of Origen's *Commentary on Matthew*', where verse 13 of chapter 15, 'Every plant which my heavenly Father has not planted shall be rooted up,' is explained[38]. Step'annos adds that he is not opposed to Origen's view, but prefers his own. Although fragments of Origen may be found in Armenian catenae, none of the full texts in Armenian ascribed to him is genuine[39].

[35] See below on Hamam, p. 107-110.

[36] This is repeated in the description of the text in the catalogue entry for the manuscript used in the printed edition, Matenadaran 5551, dated to AD 1155. See above, note 32.

[37] There are two references to Josephus (not taken from Eusebius' *Ecclesiastical History*). At Mt. 23.35 Step'annos notes that Josephus refers to the slaying of Zacharias; see 2 Chron. 24.41 and *Antiquities* IX.168. And at Jn 2.20 he notes that Josephus describes Herod rebuilding the temple; see *Jewish Wars* I.401. There was an old Armenian translation of the *Jewish Wars*, used by Movsēs Xorenac'i; see R.W. Thomson, *Moses Khorenats'i. History of the Armenians*, Harvard Armenian Texts and Studies 4 (Cambridge MA, 1978), 25-9, for the quotations and adaptations in Movsēs. No Armenian version of the *Antiquities* has yet come to light. Step'annos, of course, was familiar with Greek, but where he picked up these allusions to Josephus is unclear.

[38] Step'annos, p. 62. The relevant passage in the Greek is Book XI, §14, in PG 13, 945.

[39] The commentary on the Song of Songs mentioned in *CPG* I.1525 is not genuine. Nor is the text published by E. Petrosyan and H. Najaryan, 'Nšxarner Oroginesi hayeren t'argmanut'yunneric'', *Ējmiacin* 1979/2, 21-4, and 1980/5, 39-44. See the discussion and improved text in J.-P. Mahé, 'Origène et la baleine: un fragment pseudo-origénien *Sur Job et le Dragon* en traduction arménienne', *Revue des études arméniennes* 14 (1980), 345-65.

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Whether Step'annos read Origen while he was in Constantinople[40], or whether he found this passage in a florilegium remains to be investigated.

Step'annos frequently refers to his main theme: the Mosaic Law has been superseded. The events and prophecies of the Old Testament were models, or types, of Christ's dispensation and of the life of the church under the Holy Spirit. Various terms are used: *tip* and *awrinak* we have already noted – curiously in combination; also common are *stuēr*, 'shadow', and *aṙak*, 'allegory'[41]. Thus, in more general terms, one may proceed from the written text of scripture to the spiritual meaning, which is 'more profound', *xoragoyn*, or *xorhrdagoyn*, literally 'more mystical'[42]. A particularly clear example of his approach is his interpretation of the parable of the Prodigal Son[43]. There is no suggestion of any moral lesson, but each person and episode is explained in terms of the history of salvation, from the sin of Adam through the prophets to the incarnation, the church, the second coming of Christ, and the crown of the kingdom of heaven: Adam went down from paradise to this world; he was set upon by Satan and his cohorts; he was wounded by sin, from which he nearly died; the priest and Levite who passed by are the prophets and teachers who preceded Christ; Christ himself, called Samaritan in John 8.48, provided the oil of his mercy; the beast of burden was the body on which he bore the sins of the world; the inn is the church; the two pennies, the Old and New Testaments; the return of the Samaritan, the second coming.

Throughout his commentary Step'annos emphasizes that the intimations in the Mosaic Law became reality when Christ came. But the Jews wilfully continue to reject him. Unlike the violent diatribes of Ełišē's homilies, Step'annos is quite moderate in his treatment of Jews; nor does he have any clear opponents in view apart from occasional references to unspecified 'schismatics', and one to Marcion, 'who said that there were two heavens'[44]. Perhaps here he had in mind Eznik's famous treatise[45], but Marcionites were straw figures by the eighth century in Armenia. Marcion, Mani, and various Gnostics are occasionally vilified in later texts as well, but as figureheads for more contemporary opponents. More unusually for an Armenian author of this period, Step'annos, in this commentary at least, has no interest in numerology. Seven days, ten virgins, thirty pieces of silver, ninety-nine lost sheep, nothing tempts

[40] Orbelean states that Step'annos read at Saint Sophia, which is best understood as the patriarchal library.

[41] *Aṙak*: also the word for 'proverb', or 'parable'. See above, note 25, for *tip awrinaki*.

[42] Text to Mt. 15.52, Jn 1.51.

[43] Text to Lk. 10.30ff.

[44] Text to Lk. 10.22. See also Mt. 11.27.

[45] Eznik de Kołb, *De Deo*, ed. L. Mariès and Ch. Mercier, PO 28.3/4 (Paris, 1959), quotes Mt. 10.22 = Lk. 10.22 at §392. For the two heavens containing the Unknown God and the God of the Law, see §358; the third heaven contained the forces, *zawrk'*, of the God of the Law.

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him into number speculation or even direct parallels between biblical numbers and Christian motifs.

The historian Kirakos makes no further mention of biblical commentaries after Step'annos until the twelfth century, with the exception of the translation of the Syrian Nonnus of Nisibis' Commentary on John[46]. This was commissioned – from the Arabic – by Smbat Bagratuni, prince of Armenia 830-852. The Scholia on Gregory of Nazianzus attributed to Nonnus have perhaps attracted more attention, but are not directly relevant here[47]. Only one original Armenian commentary of the ninth century is known to me, that on Proverbs attributed to Hamam.

The writer Hamam, Arabic for 'pigeon', is an obscure figure. Arabic names were not uncommon in Armenia by the ninth century. The earliest attested Hamam was a noble of the Amatuni family who joined in a mass emigration to Greek territory in 789 described by the historian Łewond[48]. Our author Hamam is described as flourishing in the days when Ašot Bagratuni was king. This Ašot, prince of the Bagratids since 855, and nephew of the Smbat mentioned above, was given a crown by the Caliph in 884, the first of the Bagratids to attain royal status. He died in 890. No details are ever given by Armenian historians about the origin or life of Hamam, so he has sometimes been identified with the Hamam who was prince of Aluank' on the Kura river, mentioned by the historian Yovhannēs Drasxanakertc'i[49]. Though not impossible, it seems rather unlikely that a prince, described by Asołik as 'king' of Aluank', would have composed the various theological works attributed to the author Hamam. Be that as it may, it is interesting that the author is mentioned in the context of Aluank', which is contiguous to Siwnik', where the metropolitan Stephen had promoted exegetical studies in the previous century.

[46] Kirakos, p. 79. Armenian text ed. K'. Č'rak'ean, *Meknut'iwn Yovhannu Awetaranin* (Venice, 1920).

[47] S.P. Brock, *The Syriac Version of the Pseudo-Nonnus Scholia* (Cambridge, 1971); *idem*, 'The Armenian and Syriac Versions of the Pseudo-Nonnus mythological Scholia', *Mus* 79 (1966), 401-28.

[48] Łewond, *Patmut'iwn*, ed. K. Ezean (St Petersburg, 1887), §42. Z. Arzoumanian in the commentary to his translation, *History of Lewond* (Philadelphia, 1982), 195-6, notes the traditional etymology of the region Hamshen derived from Hamam. This seems to be first attested in the Pseudo-Yovhannēs Mamikonean, Armenian text ed. A. Abrahamyan, *Patmut'iwn Taronoy* (Erevan, 1941), p. 285, on which see L. Avdoyan, *Pseudo-Yovhannes Mamikonean. The History of Taron* (Atlanta, 1993), commentary, p. 249. For Hamshen, see R.W. Edwards, 'Hamšen: An Armenian enclave in the Byzantine–Georgian Pontos. A Survey of the literary and non-literary Sources', *Mus* 101 (1988), 403-42.

[49] Known as John Catholicos. For Hamam, see K. Maksoudian, *Yovhannēs Drasxanakertc'i. History of Armenia* (Atlanta, 1987), p. 279 (commentary to ch. XXXIII.20), who notes that he was later crowned. Step'annos Taronac'i, known as Asołik, *Patmut'iwn tiezerakan* (St Petersburg, 1885), III.3, speaks of him as *t'agawor* of Aluank'.

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Attributed to Hamam are various hymns, a commentary on the *Grammar* of Dionysius Thrax (of which extensive fragments survive in the major work of Yovhannēs Erznkac'i, late thirteenth century)[50], a commentary on the vocabulary of Dionysius Areopagita, and commentaries on aspects of Job and the Psalms[51], in addition to that on the Proverbs. There are interesting parallels with Step'annos of Siwnik' – another commentary on the same grammatical text of Dionysius Thrax, interest in the translation of Pseudo-Dionysius made by Step'annos, as well as several biblical commentaries.

The commentary on Propverbs was published in 1994[52]. Unfortunately, the other commentaries remain unpublished and unavailable for comparison. It would be particularly interesting to study that on the vocabulary of Dionysius, for Hamam's work on Proverbs contains many *hapax legomena*. The content of this commentary, however, does not reflect any overt influence of the theology of the Areopagite.

The commentary follows Step'annos' pattern of quotation of each successive verse with accompanying exposition. Hamam comments on practically every verse, though there are gaps, and the text ends abruptly in the middle of ch. 27. Since the Armenian version of the Old Testament follows the ordering and number of the Septuagint, this means that the final four chapters are missing. The first notable feature, as one reads the text continuously, is that the lemmata and the commentary often do not correspond at all closely. In some cases the lemma does not give the whole verse to which Hamam alludes in the commentary. That is not very surprising. More interestingly, the lemma often diverges in its text from the reading discussed in the commentary. These divergent lemmata are not based on the Greek or Syriac biblical text; nor are they of a discursive, interpretative nature, what one might call 'midrashic'. Perhaps the lemmata are secondary and were added later. The origin of the divergent readings remains a puzzle[53].

Unlike the earlier Step'annos of Siwnik' on the Evangelists, Hamam is not interested in textual problems and the interpretation of Hebrew words. Only once does he offer an etymology: 'Edom, which is darkness'[54]. Hamam's

[50] Details in R. Ervine, 'Yovhannēs Erznkac'i Pluz. Compilation of Commentary on Grammar' (dissertation for Columbia University, 1988). See also L.G. Xac'eryan, *Yovhannes Erznkac'i. Hawak'umn Meknut'ean K'erakani* (Los Angeles, 1983). Text also in Adontz, *Denys de Thrace*, 251-85.

[51] Asołik, III.2, refers specifically to Job, ch. 38 (*ov ē da*), to the book *Ambick'*, i.e. the long Psalm 118, and to the Benedictions at the head of the Psalms, i.e. Pss. 119-133.

[52] Hamam Arewelc'i, *Meknut'iwn Aṙakac'*, ed. M. Saribekyan (Erevan, 1994), in the same volume as Step'annos Siwnec'i on the Evangelists.

[53] More details on this question in R.W. Thomson, 'Traditions of Armenian Biblical Exegesis: The Example of the Book of Proverbs', forthcoming in a Festschrift for J.J.S. Weitenberg. That article studies the three known Armenian commentaries on the Book of Proverbs by Hamam, Nersēs of Lambron, and Grigor Tat'evac'i.

[54] Commentary to 19.26.

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etymology does not correspond with the published *Onomastica Sacra*, where Edom is glossed as 'red or earthy', the same meaning as that in the Armenian version of Philo's *Questions and Answers on Genesis*[55].

There are in Armenian very many word-lists and dictionaries. Some of them elucidate technical terms such as medicine or minerals, some of them explain specialized vocabulary, as in the works of Philo or pseudo-Dionysius, while some are straightforward dictionaries of non-Armenian languages[56]. In the last category there are lists of Hebrew words. Unfortunately, this vast mass of material has not been published yet, so the sources of Armenian interpretations have not been elucidated. It is pretty clear that Hebrew was not known in Armenia, but an enterprising enquirer would have found many translations of *Onomastica Sacra*, biblical commentaries, or other material such as the works of Philo, which he could raid to good effect.

In his *Commentary on Proverbs* Hamam's basic aim is a moral one, the thrust of his work being an exhortation to direct our lives towards the divine summons. For Hamam the Holy Spirit speaks through Solomon, and the Wisdom of the Book of Proverbs is God the Word, manifested in Christ. His emphasis is on the contrast between the Old Testament and the New, not so much to engage in typological parallels – such as one finds in the *Teaching of Saint Gregory*, for example, or in Step'annos – but to stress the incomprehension of Israel, who did not heed the prophets, in contrast to the church which proclaims the message of Christ. Within that general framework Hamam does not have one fixed interpretation of those passages in Proverbs that he interprets in terms of the New Dispensation; the same phrase may suggest different meanings in different places.

He shows no great interest in number symbolism, which, as already noted, was a very popular theme in Armenian writers and commentators. Only the first verse of chapter 9 is explained in such fashion: 'Wisdom has built her house and erected seven pillars.' The house is understood as heaven; thus the seven pillars are to be understood as arches and vaults and eternal dwellings. But here on earth the number seven refers to the seven eras of a thousand years each from creation, according to the seven spheres, that is, the spheres in which the seven planets move. The seven eras of time are an ancient theme in Armenian, greatly elaborated in the *Teaching of Saint Gregory*, and often repeated[57].

[55] See M.E. Stone, *Signs of the Judgement, Onomastica Sacra*, University of Pennsylvania Armenian Texts and Studies 3 (Chico, CA, 1981), p. 130. In Hebrew *'adom* is 'red', but *'damah* is 'earth, land'. Philo, *Questions and Answers on Genesis*, ed. R. Marcus, LCL (Cambridge, MA, 1953), IV 171 (p. 456). For Armenian commentaries on Philo, see G. Grigoryan, 'P'ilon Ałek'sandrac'u ašxatut'yunneri hay meknut'yunnerě', *Banber Matenadarani* 5 (1960), 95-116.

[56] See G. Uluhogian, 'Bibliography of Armenian Dictionaries', *Rivista di Studi Bizantini e Slavi* 5 (1985), 197-291, and works in Armenian by H.M. Amalyan listed in Thomson, *Bibliography*, 255.

[57] See above at note 22.

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One rather disappointing characteristic of most Armenian commentaries, at least to the modern critic, is the paucity of references to Armenia. Nor when opponents of the writer are mentioned are they identified as Armenians or foreigners: they are 'schismatics', often lumped together with Marcion or Mani, as already noted. Hamam even refers to the Gnostic Menander, whom Eusebius called a follower of Simon Magus. But Menander was hardly a threat to ninth-century Armenia, even if he does appear again in a long list of heretics in a Confession of Faith sent by the Catholicos Xač'ik to the metropolitan of Melitene in the late tenth century[58].

Yet, although Hamam makes no reference to Armenia or Armenians, as is normal, he does mention the Byzantines. Proverbs 30.29ff. mentions three animals which 'walk beautifully' – the young of a lion, the cock which struts in the forest, the goat that leads flocks – and then mentions the king who becomes a public orator. According to Hamam these are the four kingdoms which rule over the four corners of the earth. The first is that of Abraham and his offspring; but in these last times the Word of God reigned over the house of Jacob, and of his kingdom there is no end. The cock refers to the Babylonians, and the goat is the kingdom of the Medes and Persians. But the fourth is 'the firm and immovable Asian region, the worthy dominion taking its trophy from God, that is, the kingdom of the Romans'. Hamam goes on to quote Daniel ch. 7, where he describes the fourth beast who crushed the others, and now in faith and knowledge of God 'walks beautifully' in the gospel and the cross of Christ. It would be easier to interpret this praise for the empire if we knew who Hamam was and where he was writing. Not all Armenian writers were obsessed with Christological controversy, and Hamam never mentions Chalcedon or raises the issue of 'Nestorian' heresy. But clearly he was not a rabid anti-Chalcedonian. And he took a rather different line from Sebeos in the late seventh century, who interpreted the fourth beast as the kingdom of Ismael, which surpasses all kingdoms in evil[59].

That Proverbs, Ecclesiastes, and the Song of Songs formed a trilogy was common knowledge to Christian interpreters, though Hamam makes no mention of it. In his commentary on Proverbs the twelfth century Nersēs of Lambron does note a significance in the threefold structure of Solomon's work[60]. Proverbs is aimed at those of an early age (*matałahasak*); it is instruction for the path that leads to separation from the vanities of this world. Ecclesiastes offers instruction in the higher realities, while the Song of Songs is for souls inspired by the love of God in a passionless state, removed from this world. At

[58] For the letter, see the *Girk' T'łt'oc'* (Tiflis, 1901), 302-22; p. 307 for Menander.

[59] Sebēos, *Patmut'iwn*, ed. G. Abgaryan (Erevan, 1979), 162. English translation in R.W. Thomson and J. Howard-Johnston, *The Armenian History attributed to Sebeos*, Translated Texts for Historians 31 (Liverpool, 1999).

[60] See the Introduction to the Armenian text published by Prince Max, Herzog von Sachsen, *Nerses von Lampron: Erklärung der Sprichwörter Salomos*, 3 vols. (Leipzig, 1919, 1921, 1926), vol. I, 1-5.

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the end of the fourteenth century Grigor Tat'ewac'i, a noted theologian and philosopher (1340-1409) – again working in Siwnik' – also addresses this point. Proverbs is aimed at children; Ecclesiastes at adults; the Song at old men, *cerunik'*[61]. These explanations are rather different from Origen's. He saw the subjects of the three books as *ethike*, *physike*, and *theoretike*[62].

Origen's work, however, was a product of his younger days, not his old age, as was also a commentary on the Song by the famous Armenian poet Gregory of Narek, the millennium of whose death is commemorated this year[63]. Narekac'i's book of ninety-five prayers, or spiritual soliloquies, each of which is entitled 'conversation with God from the depths of the heart', is the most famous religious composition in Armenian, though its language is difficult and elusive. We now have a fine, sympathetic rendering in French by Jean-Pierre Mahé, who has identified the biblical imagery underlying the poetry[64]. The study of Gregory's imagery in the context of earlier Armenian exegesis, however, remains to be carried out.

Here, however, I shall briefly discuss his only biblical commentary, on the Song of Songs, composed in 977. In the colophon to his work Gregory notes that 'men have interpreted [its content] in various ways with uncomprehending minds.' Gregory takes as his starting point the work of an earlier Gregory, namely Gregory of Nyssa, to whose commentary he frequently refers. This was available in an Armenian version (unpublished, like most of the Armenian versions of Gregory of Nyssa's writings)[65]; but Grigor Narekac'i was perfectly capable of reading the text in Greek. His Armenian commentary is far from being a paraphrase of Nyssa's, whose own commentary ends at 6.9. He often refers explicitly to Gregory the Theologian (that is, Nazianzenus), the popularity of whose works in Armenia rivalled that of John Chrysostom's. Narekac'i also cites Chrysostom, as well as Basil.

But more importantly, he takes his general approach from the exegesis of a much earlier Armenian text – the tradition ascribed to Saint Gregory the Illuminator as recorded by the historian Agat'angełos. Narekac'i has in mind particularly the *Teaching of Saint Gregory*, which underwent a series of revisions and expansions before reaching the form in which it is known today, perhaps by the end of

[61] Grigor Tat'evac'i, *Sołomoni Arakneri Meknut'yunĕ*, ed. X. Grigoryan (Erevan, 2000), p. 16. But Grigor does not suggest that this explanation is of long standing.

[62] Origen, *In Canticum*, PG 13, 73A-B.

[63] For his Commentary on the Song, see above, note 10.

[64] For details see above, note 26.

[65] Cf F. Vinel, 'La version arménienne des *Homélies sur l'Ecclésiaste* de Grégoire de Nysse', *Revue des études arméniennes* 21 (1988/89), 127-43, esp. p. 127 for the Song. It is noteworthy that the Syriac translator of Gregory of Nyssa's commentary on the Song pointed out the difficulties of translating from Greek into Syriac; C. van der Eynde, *La version syriaque du commentaire de Gregoire de Nysse sur le Cantique des Cantiques*, Bibliothèque du Muséon 10 (Louvain, 1939); see pp. 71-6 for the Syriac text of the translator's letter to his patron, Latin translation on pp. 99-102.

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the sixth century[66]. He also includes as part of Saint Gregory's legacy the homilies known as *Yačaxapatum Čarkʻ*, which are ascribed to the Illuminator by other Armenian writers as well[67]. Some scholars have raised doubts about the authenticity of Narekac'i's commentary on the Song, on the grounds that its style is so different from that of his mature poetry. It does not seem impossible that a younger man's early prose style might differ from his poetry of twenty to thirty years later. But the exegesis is consistent between the commentary and the prayers[68]. All his life Gregory of Narek was absorbed by language of divine love. I take this early work to be an attempt to show the coherence of Greek patristic exegesis and Armenian tradition. Such a view also fits the known Greek sympathies of Gregory Narekac'i on the eve of Byzantine expansion into southern Armenia[69].

Gregory of Narek's emphasis on the tradition of Saint Gregory the Illuminator brings us back to the difficult question of dating the successive elaborations of the *History* of Agat'angełos and of the homilies ascribed to the Illuminator. As is clear from the problems surrounding the works attributed to Ełišē, much of the material on which we rely for knowledge of early Armenian theology, indeed Armenian literature in general, is of uncertain date and provenance. It is very easy to fall into circular reasoning depending on which assumptions are made about specific authors. Nonetheless, a few general remarks are in order before closing.

By the end of the tenth century the Armenians had assimilated and developed in their own ways a great body of commentary literature. So far as biblical exegesis is concerned, I have been able to touch on only a fraction of surviving material, and have totally disregarded commentaries on liturgical matters, for example[70]. I hope to have shown, however, that there was no single fixed approach to the interpretation of the bible in Armenia. Different scholars had different concerns and drew on different traditions. The texts discussed here are not greatly concerned with directing the audience to better moral behaviour. For that we have to turn to homilies on biblical themes[71].

[66] For the dating, see the Introduction to R.W. Thomson, *The Teaching of Saint Gregory*.

[67] The text has been published several times (recently in Venice, 1954), but there is no critical edition or detailed study of the homilies. German translation in *Ausgewählte Schriften der armenischen Kirchenväter*, ed. S. Weber, 2 vols. (Munich, 1927), vol. I, 237-318.

[68] The doubts expressed by V. Arak'elyan, *Grigor Narekac'u lezun ev očʻ* (Erevan, 1975), p. 36, have been countered by P. Xač'atryan, *Grigor Narekac'in ev hay mijnadarě* (Ejmiacin, 1996), 67-81.

[69] See J.-P. Mahé, 'Basile II et Byzance vus par Grigor Narekac'i', *Travaux et Mémoires* 11 (1991), 555-73.

[70] For these see Ch. Renoux, 'Les commentaires liturgiques arméniens', in *Mystagogie: Pensée liturgique d'aujourd'hui et liturgie ancienne*, ed. A.M. Tricca and A. Pistoia (Prome, 1993), 277-308.

[71] Cf. R.W. Thomson, 'Homilies and Biblical Commentary in Classical Armenian Writers', forthcoming in the Proceedings of a Symposium held at St Nersess Armenian Seminary in September 2002.

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Armenian writers are agreed that scripture is not only a historical record of events, but it also offers a deeper meaning, *xoragoyn*, pertaining to spiritual rather than physical realities. This is particularly important in the interpretation of the Old Testament in terms of the New Order. But our authors are not greatly concerned with precise definitions of 'model', 'type', 'allegory'[72], and they are far from the subtle distinctions of western medieval writers – the literal, allegorical, moral, and anagogical methods. One can find all these approaches in different Armenian texts, but not brought together.

It does not seem very helpful to apply vague terms such as 'Antiochene' or 'Alexandrian' to Armenian exegesis in general, since the supposed characteristics of both 'schools' may be found in Armenian texts[73]. The first desideratum is proper investigation of the individual commentaries and their sources. But given the vast amount of material, much of it still unpublished, any meaningful evaluation of the whole tradition will take some time to accomplish.

[72] Nor does Gregory of Nyssa make clear distinctions between *parabole*, *anagoge*, *tropologia*, *allegoria* – 'or whatever else one might wish to call it' – in the introduction to his *Commentary on the Song*, ed. H. Langerbeck, GNO 6.

[73] Cf. the comments in F. Young, *Biblical Exegesis and the Formation of Christian Culture* (Cambridge, 1997), esp. ch. 9, 'The Question of Method'. She points to the lack of precision in patristic usage of the 'senses' of scripture (pp. 186 ff.) and to a pattern of complex possibilities of approach (pp. 212-13).

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X. Clement, Origen, Athanasius

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'When Was God without Wisdom?' Trinitarian Hermeneutics and Rhetorical Strategy in Athanasius

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Despite the fact that Athanasius' trinitarian doctrine is heavily invested in scriptural exegesis, close analysis of the methods whereby he anchors his trinitarian doctrine in scripture and defends this doctrine in light of problematic texts has been disproportionatley scarce[1]. It is likely that one of the reasons for this lacuna is the fact that his exegetical arguments are often embedded in a polemical style that is prone to strike the modern reader as ill-tempered, and as having neither the tone nor the substance of a well-reasoned argument. I have no intention here of defending the tone of Athanasius' argumentation. But, as to the substance, I do think that a legitimate case can be made that Athanasius' trinitarian hermeneutics contain elements of theological method and content that have enduring value for the task of illuminating the scriptural bases for trinitarian doctrine and, moreover, that these same elements of method and content are operative even within some of the polemical manoeuvres that seem vulnerable to easy dismissal. As an illustration of the latter phenomenon, I would like to explore in this paper one pervasive polemical strategy in Athanasius' arsenal, his oft-repeated taunt against those whom he called 'Arians', that their doctrine amounted to saying that there was once when God was without reason

[1] For treatments of Athanasius' exegetical technique, see T.E. Pollard, 'The Exegesis of Scripture and the Arian Controversy', *BJRL* 41 (1959), 414-29; T.F. Torrance, 'The Hermeneutics of Athanasius', *Ekklesiastikos Pharos* 52-53 (1970-71), reprinted in Torrance, *Divine Meaning* (Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1995), pp. 229-88; Hermann-Josef Sieben, 'Herméneutique de l'exègése dogmatique d'Athanase', in *Politique et théologie chez Athanase d'Alexandrie*, ed. Charles Kannengiesser (Paris: Beauchesne, 1974), pp. 195-214; C. Stead, 'Athanasius als Exeget', in J. van Oort and U. Wickert (eds), *Christliche Exegese zwischen Nizaea und Chalcedon* (Kampen: Kok Pharos, 1992), pp. 174-84; J.D. Ernest, 'Athanasius of Alexandia: The Scope of Scripture in Polemical and Pastoral Context', *VC* 47 (1993), 341-62; C. Kannengiesser, 'The Bible in the Arian Crisis', in *The Bible in Greek Christian Antiquity*, ed. and tr. Paul M. Blowers, The Bible Through the Ages 1 (Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press, 1997), pp. 217-28; Kannengiesser, 'The Athanasian Understanding of Scripture', in *The Early Church in its Context: Essays in Honor of Everett Ferguson*, ed. A. J. Malherbe, F. W. Norris, and J. W. Thompson, Supplements to Novum Testamentum 90 (Leiden: Brill, 1998), pp. 221-9. Of these, the work that deals with some breadth and depth directly with the exegetical construction of Athanasius' Trinitarian doctrine is Torrance, to which we may also add C. Kannegiesser, *Athanase d' Alexandrie. Éveque et Écrivain: Une lecture des traités contre les Ariens*, Théologie historique 70 (Paris: Beauschesne, 1983).

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(*logos*) and wisdom (*sophia*)[2]. I will begin by offering some remarks towards qualifying the sharp and cursory dismissal of this Athanasian motif by Christopher Stead in his now classic essay 'Rhetorical Method in Athanasius'[3]. I will then attempt a rereading of this polemical motif by presenting it in a wider context that takes into account, firstly, Athanasius' recognition of his opponents' resources for defending themselves against such an argument and his refutation of such a defence; secondly, his construction of a hermeneutical theory that undergirds his polemical strategy, and, finally, a brief analysis of how the principles of this heremeneutical theory are applied in his polemics. The cumulative thrust of the rereading presented here is that Athanasius' recurrent 'When was God without Wisdom?' argument represents a logic that is paradigmatic of both his trinitarian hermeneutics and his hermenutical polemics.

In his highly influential article on Athanasius' rhetorical strategies, Stead cites this Athanasian motif as a prime example of the Alexandrian's propensity for fallacious and tendentious argumentation. He points out that Athanasius was well aware that the Arian position held that *logos* and *sophia* do exist eternally in God, albeit as impersonal attributes. Therefore, by the Arians' own logic considered as a whole, the fact that there was once when the Son was not does not entail that there was once when God was without reason and wisdom. Stead observes that Athanasius can only come to this conclusion by intruding his own middle term, which he describes as 'the Athanasian principle that God's Word and Wisdom are wholly identified with his Son'[4]. Such an amalgam of his opponent's premises with his own is designated by Stead as a 'mosaic' argument, which renders a logically and theologically invalid conclusion[5].

It seems to me that a full assent to Stead's summary dismissal of Athanasius' rhetorical strategy is only possible if one abstracts the latter from its exegetical context, as if what was in question were simply two completely autonomous doctrines of God, each purporting to base itself on objective and universal canons of logic and neither of which should be allowed to intrude its own premises on the reasonings of the other. But we are bound to give a more nuanced judgment once we give due weight to the fact that we are, rather, faced with an exegetical debate involving distinct configurations of scriptural data that is held in reverence by both parties, and which can thus be appealed to as a normative standard. The doctrine of the two Words and Wisdoms, shared by Arius and Asterius[6], was indeed serviceable in arguing that God did

[2] E.g., *Or. Ar.* 1:19, 1:24, 2:32, *Decr.* 15; *Ad Serap.* 2:2.

[3] *VC* 30 (1976), 121-37.

[4] Ibid., 136.

[5] Ibid., 136-7.

[6] For Arius' presentation of this theme, as reported by Athanasius, see the latter's reproductions of Arius' *Thalia* in *Or. Ar.* 1:5 and *De Synodis* 15. In its substance, this teaching fits too neatly into Arius' system for its authenticity to be in doubt. The same teaching is attributed to Asterius by Athanasius in *Or. Ar.* 2:37 and *De Synodis* 18. On the validity of this attribution to

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after all eternally possess Word and Wisdom, even if the pre-existent Christ was not eternal. Its full content, however, cannot be reduced to its function in shoring up an intelligent and rational doctrine of God but has to be seen, rather, in light of the exegetical exigencies of which it is the resolution. Seen in this light, it represents a synthesis of three elements: firstly, an acknowledgement of the scriptural identification of Christ as Wisdom, in deference to a well-enshrined tradition that includes, most notably, Origen and Eusebius of Caesarea[7]; secondly, an acknowledgement that the scriptural appellation of Wisdom pertains to the divine realm; and thirdly, the attempt to reconcile these two acknowledgements with the doctrine that the pre-existent Christ is not fully divine and not eternal, in contrast with the 'unbegotten' and 'uncreated' God. Thus, although Christ is Wisdom (as scripture says), he is not the Wisdom which is properly God, but a created Wisdom, which is not such essentially, but by participation.

Now, the first two premises of Arius and Asterius' 'two Wisdoms' doctrine – that Christ is scripturally identified as Wisdom and that the title of Wisdom is a divine name – are certainly shared by Athanasius. The essential point of divergence, as Stead has noted, is the disidentification, on the part of Arius and Asterius, between Christ and the proper Wisdom of God. In his employment of the 'When was God without Wisdom?' argument, Athanasius is fully aware of the response contained within his opponents' doctrine of two Words and Wisdoms, but it is precisely this latter doctrine that he is arguing to be invalid. A fair assessment of his use of this motif must then include a consideration of how it contains a refutation of the rival doctrine of the two Words and Wisdoms. Such a refutation is found principally in the second of his *Orations against the Arians*, sections 37 to 40. There he outlines his opponents' position, with distinct reference both to Arius and Asterius, as follows: The Word is not the unique Image, Wisdom, and Word of God, but there are many such. The proper Word and Wisdom of God exists unoriginately with God and is other than the Son. The Son is created through the agency of this innate and unbegotten Word and Wisdom, and is called Word and Wisdom, *kat'epinoian*, through participation in God's innate Word and Wisdom and on account of his relation to rational beings.

As is customary with Athanasius, he conflates the distinctive nuances of his diverse opponents in order to maximize the range of his own counterarguments, of which there are essentially three. First, he takes aim at Arius' doctrine that the names, or *epinoiai*, of the Son signify merely his relation to

Asterius, see M. Vinzent, *Asterius von Kappadokien. Die Theologischen Fragmente. Einleitung, Kritischer Text, Übersetzung & Kommentar*, Supplements to Vigiliae Christianae 20 (Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1993), pp. 303-5.

[7] For Origen, Wisdom/*Sophia* is the most primary of the titles (*epinoiai*) of the Son; see *On First Principles* 1, 2, 1; IV, 4, 1; *Com. Jn.* 1:125ff. For Eusebius, see, e.g., *Dem. Ev.* IV:2; V:1; *De eccl. theol.* III:2.

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creation. With this teaching, Arius locates himself within the Origenian tradition of approaching the doctrine of Christ from the standpoint of his scriptural *epinoiai*, but represents a significant modification of it by obviating Origen's distinction between the names that apply to the Son in himself and those that apply to the Son's relation to creation[8]. Athanasius' criticism is that emptying out the self-reference of the scriptural names of Christ threatens to ultimately turn the Son into a non-entity, a being who has no self-standing apart from his relation to us. He mocks: 'Perhaps he even has his being merely by way of our conception of him, on account of his relation to things that exist'[9]. Such a criticism has more point against the radical apophaticism of Arius than the more modified position of Asterius, who held that the Son actually represents and manifests in himself the non-exclusive properties of the Unbegotten God[10]. But the remaining two counterarguments presented by Athanasius in this section apply equally to both Arius and Asterius. The first was also duly noted by Stead and classified as the argument '*tu quoque*'[11]: that is to say, while the 'Arians' criticized Nicene doctrine for implying 'two Unbegottens', Arius and Asterius themselves are vulnerable to the same critique, since they too end up asserting an unoriginate Word and Wisdom within God. Here, Athanasius especially exploits the articulation of Asterius, who interprets the reference of 1 Cor 1:24 to 'Christ, the wisdom of God and the Power of God' by explaining, 'Thus, he preaches that the proper Power of God, which is innate and natural to him and coexists (*sunupárchousan*) unoriginately with him is other than Christ ...'[12] Athanasius retorts, 'Is it not utterly foolish for them to think that the Word which coexists eternally with God is God himself? For what coexists does not coexist with itself but with another'[13]. The final counterargument of Athanasius is really his main one, and this is that the doctrine of two Words and Wisdoms requires a disidentification between the scriptural titles of 'Word' and 'Wisdom' on the one hand, and 'Son' on the other, and that such a disidentification is scripturally unwarranted. So he asks,

> Where did they ever find it said by the holy Scripture or from whom have they heard that there is another word and another wisdom than this Son, so as to invent such things for themselves? ... The sacred writers do not indicate by name or deed any other Word or Wisdom[14].

[8] See R. Lorenz, *Arius judaizans? Untersuchungen zur dogmengeschichtlichen Einordnung des Arius*, Forschungen zur Kirchen- und Dogmengeschichte 31 (Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht,1980), p. 84.

[9] *Or. Ar.* 2:38.

[10] See Vinzent, p. 68.

[11] Stead, p. 126.

[12] Asterius, *Syntagmation*, Fr. 64 (Vinzent, p. 124), in Athanasius, *Or. Ar.* 2:37.

[13] *Or. Ar.* 2:38.

[14] *Or. Ar.* 2:39

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Despite these protestations, Athanasius is well aware that Asterius was able to refer to scriptural references to 'powers' of God – *dynamis* here being taken as a scriptural title equivalent to *logos* and *sophia*[15] – and Athanasius himself concedes examples of scriptural references to the 'words' of God, in the plural. Nevertheless, he insists that such incidental references do not cast any doubt at all on the fact that the global patterns of scriptural narrative and predication assign the titles of Word and Wisdom in an altogether unique manner to the Son. Thus, even if Jesus himself refers to 'the words, which I have spoken to you' (Jn 6:63), it was not one of these many words, says Athanasius, who became human for our sake. The Word who became flesh is the one to whom the scriptures apply the title of 'Word' in an altogether pre-eminent sense[16].

The implicit basis for Athanasius' argumentation here is his doctrine of scriptural *paradeigmata*, which stand at the centre of his trinitarian hermeneutics[17]. The present occasion allows us to give only a very rudimentary and highly condensed analysis of this important principle in Athanasius' doctrinal exegesis. The material contents of Athanasius' *paradeigmata* overlap considerably with Origen's *epinoiai*: they are the traditional images gleaned from the scriptures for identifying the Son and designating the relation between Father and Son[18]. These include, of course, the primary designations of the Son as Word and Wisdom of God, as well as the pervasive image of the light and radiance[19]. As might be expected, however, there is a significant shift from a primarily christological perspective in Origen to a more trinitarian application in Athanasius. Origen is concerned first of all with distinguishing the names that apply to the Son in himself from the names that apply to the Son's relation to creation[20], while Athanasius is concerned primarily with correlations between the Son's names and those of the God who is presumed to be the Father. This concern involves Athanasius in

[15] Asterius, *Syntagmation*, Fr. 64 (Vinzent, p. 124), in Athanasius, *Or. Ar.* 2:37.

[16] *Or. Ar.* 2:39.

[17] The significance of the doctrine of scriptural *paradeigmatai* has been much overlooked in studies of Athanasius' exegesis. It is not mentioned, for example, in the expositions of Athanasius's exegetical methods by Pollard, Sieben, Stead, or Kannegiesser (see note 1, above). Notable exceptions are the treatments of Torrance and the largely overlooked monograph by J. Pelikan, *The Light of the World: A Basic Image in Early Christian Thought* (New York: Harper, 1962). See also James D. Ernest, *The Bible in Athanasius of Alexandria*, The Bible in the Ancient Church 2 (Boston: Brill, 2004), 151-159.

[18] The *loci classici* of Origen's doctrine of *epinoiai* are *On First Principles* 1, 2, 1-13, and *Com. Jn.* 1:125-150. See H. Crouzel, *Origène* (Paris: Éditions Lethielleux & Namur: Culture et Vérité, 1985), pp. 246-9, and A. Orbe, *La Epinoia. Algunos prliminares históricos de la distinción kat' epinoian (En torno a la Filosofía de Leoncio Bizantino)* (Rome: Pontificia Universitas Gregoriana, 1955), pp. 16-31. For some examples of Athanasius' use of christological *paradeigmata*, see *Or. Ar.* 1: 16, 1:19, 2:32; *De Decretis* 12, 15; *Letter I to Serapion* 19-20.

[19] On the image of light and radiance, in particular, see Pelikan.

[20] See *Com. Jn.* 1:118-124; Orbe, pp. 23-7.

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a sustained analysis of the global patterns of scriptural predication. By way of offering an intensely condensed representation of this analysis, we can reduce it to the following principle: *the intertextual dynamics of scriptural language by which there exists a series of linguistic correlations between the identifications of the person of Christ and those of God are to be taken as representative of the ontological correlativity of the Father and the Son.* With a pervasive application of this hermeneutical principle, Athanasius undercuts his opponents' recourse to a single designation of the divine essence – whether it be *monas* or *agen(n)ētos* – by insisting that the divine essence can only be identified from the whole range of the interlocking patterns of scriptural predication, in their mutual relations. Applied to the issue which presently concerns us, this approach dictates that Wisdom can only be predicated of God consistently with its scriptural application, in which it is also identified with the Son. Therefore, to posit a Wisdom of God that is other than the Son is to fall outside the intertextual system of biblical predications. Such a God may be held to have Wisdom, but it would not then be the Wisdom which is depicted by the global patterns of scriptural predication and which is scripturally identified precisely as the Word who became flesh.

Now, it is altogether typical of Athanasius that he does not stop at merely articulating a theoretical construct to challenge the doctrine of his opponents. As a pastor, he considered it to be an essential part of his responsibility not merely to provide a rational response to the doctrines of his opponents, but to instill a sense of shock and affective repugnance as the standard reaction to such doctrine. One of the principal ways in which he tries to do this is by superimposing the 'Arian' doctrinal disidentification of the Father and the Son directly onto the scriptural *paradeigmata* – the patterns of correlation that he has excavated to demonstrate the linguistic correlativity of the scriptural identifications of Christ and God. In keeping with this strategy, Athanasius repeatedly intrudes Arius' alleged dictum 'there was once when the Son was not' into scriptural *paradeigmata* in order to yield discomfiting results: there was once when God was a light without radiance; a fountain without outflow; a being without truth, life, reason, and wisdom[21]. The essential point is to see that the logic of Athanasius' rhetoric does not actually lie *primarily and in the first place* in the objective referents for these images. What, after all, does it really and objectively mean to say that the 'Arian' God is a light without radiance and a barren fountain? The logic lies rather in the essentially linguistic nature of Athanasius' argument and amounts to the claim, if we may phrase it so anachronistically, that the 'Arians' violate the semiotic system by which the scriptures reveal divine being.

[21] E.g., *Or. Ar.* 1:24, 2:32; *De Decretis* 15; *Letter II to Serapion* 2.

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Conclusion

Athanasius' 'When was God without Wisdom?' argument was an important element of a coherent strategy designed to trap his opponents on the horns of an exegetical dilemma. If the Son is to be fully identified with God's Word and Wisdom, in deference to the patterns of scriptural predication, then the possession of Word and Wisdom cannot be predicated of God apart from the Son. But if, on the other hand, the Son is not to be fully identified with God's Word and Wisdom, in defiance of these scriptural patterns of predication, then these so-called 'Arians' must be made to pay the full price for their violation of these patterns of correlation. It does not matter that Arius and Asterius have made a logical compensation for this adjustment by asserting the existence of an immanent Word and Wisdom in God. By predicating of God a Wisdom other than the Word who became flesh, the 'Arians' were predicating of God a non-scriptural Wisdom, and therefore failing to represent a truly scriptural predication of God. By regularly depicting the God of Arius and Asterius as a God without Wisdom, a light without radiance, a fountain without an outpouring, Athanasius' ultimate point is that we have here a God other than the one identified by the scriptures through the mutual correlations of the identifications of God and Christ[22].

[22] The articulation of the exegetical dilemma with which Athanasius wanted to confront his opponents and the rhetorical ammunition he derived from trapping them on the horns of this dilemma are given condensed expression in a passage from his *On the Nicene Council* (*De Decretis*) 15: 'We have learned from the Holy Scriptures that the Son of God, as we have said, is the Word itself and Wisdom of the Father. For the apostle says: "Christ the power of God and wisdom of God" [1 Cor 1: 24]. And John, having said, "And the Word became flesh", immediately adds, "and we have seen his glory, glory as of the only-begotten from the Father, full of grace and truth" [Jn 1:14]. Since the Word is only-begotten Son, it is in this Word and in Wisdom that heaven and earth and all that is in them have come to be. And that the source and fountain of this wisdom is God, we have learned from Baruch, where Israel is reprimanded that it has "forsaken the fountain of Wisdom" [Bar 3:12]. So if they deny the Scriptures, then they are immediately estranged from the name of Christians and they would be appropriately called atheists and the worst enemies of Christ. For they have brought these names upon themselves. But if they agree with us that the sayings of the Scriptures are divinely inspired, let them dare to openly say what they secretly think, that once God was word-less and wisdom-less, and let them madly say, "There was once when he was not," and "Before he was generated, Christ was not."'

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The Procession of the Spirit in Athanasius

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To focus on one point of doctrine in so vital a thinker as Athanasius runs the serious risk of not seeing that point in its relationship to the whole thought of the writer. It is one of the merits of the penetrating study of Khaled Anatolios, *Athanasius: The Coherence of His Thought* (London: Routledge, 1998) that he has convincingly brought out the organic nature of the thought of the great Alexandrian. As John Henry Newman said,

> Creeds and dogmas live in the one idea which they are designed to express, and which alone is substantive; and are necessary because the human mind cannot reflect upon that idea except piecemeal, cannot use it in its oneness and entireness, or without resolving it into a series of aspects and relations[1].

The career of Athanasius between the first two councils brings out vividly the truth of Newman's analysis of the process of development, which he defines as 'that process ... by which the aspects of an idea are brought into consistency and form,... being the germination and maturation of some truth or apparent truth on a large mental field'[2]. The language expresses the organic view that characterizes Newman's understanding of Christian theology: creeds and dogmas live; they each express one idea which is substantive, but are incapable of expressing theology's coherent oneness.

On the third person of the Trinity the council of Nicea says simply that 'We believe ... in the Holy Spirit' (καὶ εἰς τὸ ἅγιον πνεῦμα). This bald statement of faith was quickly seen as unsatisfactory, calling as it did for development. Inevitably and necessarily, it led to the faith expressed at Constantinople and to subsequent development in pneumatic theology. In the works of the great Athanasius we can see this dynamic process of doctrinal development. In his earlier works his focus is on the Son and on his full consubstantial unity with the Father. This is the orthodox faith that had to be confessed in the teeth of Arian denials.

Following the lead of Newman, Anatolios has emphasized the soteriological thrust that brought Athanasius to a confession of the full divinity of the incarnate

[1] *Fifteen Sermons Preached before the Univeresity of Oxford between 1826 and 1843*, 3rd edn (London, 1872), 15.23 (pp. 331-2); quoted in *An Essay on the Development of Christian Doctrine*, 3rd edn (London, 1878 (1897)), 1.2.9 (p. 53).

[2] *Development*, p. 38.

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Logos. How can he save if he is not God? 'Therefore He was not man, and then became God, but He was God, and then became man, and that to deify us'[3]. The more the Arians would argue against Christ's divine status from texts which speak of his exaltation, the more Athanasius would point to the benefits brought in by it for the human family. It was human nature that was raised and glorified in him and through his passion. In other words, the more soteriological the argument turned the more Christologically defined it became.

> And if all those who are called sons and gods, whether on earth or in heaven, were adopted and deified through the Word, and the Son himself is the Word, it is plain that they all are through him, and he himself in the first place, or rather only he himself is the literal Son, and he alone is true God from true God, not receiving these prerogatives as a reward for his virtue, nor being another beside them, but being all these by nature and according to essence[4].

'Thus the pressure of the controversy,' as Newman explains,

> elicited and developed a truth, which was held indeed by Christians, but less perfectly realized and not publicly recognized. The sanctification, or rather the deification, of the nature of man, is one main subject of St. Athanasius's theology. Christ, in rising, raises His Saints with Him to the right hand of power. They become instinct with His life, of one body with His flesh, divine sons, immortal kings, gods. He is in them because He is in human nature, and He communicates to them that nature, deified by becoming His, that them It may deify. He is in them by the Presence of His Spirit and in them is He seen. They have those titles of honour by participation which are properly His[5].

If salvation through deification takes such a prominent role in the thinking of Athanasius, it is only natural that he should devote his attention to a consideration of the Holy Spirit and his work of sanctification. In *Contra Arianos* the question is approached from its Christological side. The Son, he says, must be of one substance with the Father since he possesses the Holy Spirit as his own, just as the Father does[6]. Being both God and man he both gave and received the Holy Spirit. The Spirit receives all that he has from the Son.

> Not then as the Son in the Father, so also we become in the Father; for the Son does not merely partake the Spirit, that therefore He too may be in the Father; nor does He receive the Spirit, but rather He supplies It Himself to all: and the Spirit does not unite the Word to the Father, but rather the Spirit receives from the Word[7].

[3] *Contra Arianos* 1.39; tr. J.H. Newman (revised), in LNPF, second series, vol. 4 (ed. Archibald Robertson (1892)), 329.

[4] *CA*. 1.39; LNPF 329, adapted.

[5] *Development*, 140.

[6] Cf. *CA* 1.46 (PG 26, 108AB).

[7] *CA* 3.24; LNPF 4, 406-7. In *CA* 1.37 also the difference between sons by grace, or acquisition, and Son by nature is made clear. Compare what is said in the *Expositio Fidei*, probably falsely attributed to Athanasius: '... the Word was before us and before all Creation, and is, the Wisdom of the Father. But the Holy Spirit, being that which proceeds from the Father, is ever in the hands of the Father Who sends and of the Son Who conveys Him, by whose means he fills

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In the letters to Serapion Athanasius is obliged by the denial of the Holy Spirit's divinity by the Tropikoi to focus more directly on the third person of the Trinity, and thus to come closer to the subject of the procession. His argumentation throughout the work is strongly scriptural, and on this point especially he does not intend to go beyond the express words of holy writ[8]. He regularly explains scripture by scripture, and faults his adversaries for not paying sufficient attention to the inspired texts[9].

If we are attentive to the scriptural text, Athanasius explains to these adversaries, we shall see that the Spirit is linked to the Son as his very own. Indeed, as C.R.B. Shapland says, 'The question of the Spirit arose out of the question of the Son. It was a crisis within a crisis.'[10] In these letters it is made clear that the relation of the Holy Spirit to the Son is the same in point of essence and rank as the relation of the Son to the Father[11]. Athanasius argues for the divinity of the Holy Spirit on the basis of his relation to the Son.

The Spirit, therefore, is distinct from the creatures, and is shown rather to be proper (ἴδιον) to the Son and not alien from God .... he is said to be in God himself and from

all things' (τὸ δὲ ἅγιον Πνεῦμα, ἐκπόρευμα ὂν τοῦ Πατρὸς, ἀεὶ ἐστιν ἐν ταῖς χερσὶ τοῦ πέμποντος Πατρὸς καὶ τοῦ φέροντος Υἱοῦ, δι' οὗ ἐπλήρωσε τὰ πάντα): PG 25, 208A; LNPF 85. The expression ἐν ταὶς χερσί is taken over from Dionysius of Alexandria, the disciple of Origen.

[8] Cf. J. Lebon, S.J. in Athanase d'Alexandrie, *Lettres à Sérapion*, SC 15 (1947), 70: 'saint Athanase saura parler avec l'Ecriture et se taire avec elle.' To the rash theologizing of the Arians and Tropikoi Athanasius protests, 'For all created beings, and especially we who are men, find it impossible to speak adequately concerning the things that are ineffable. All the more presumptuous, then, if, when we cannot speak, we devise for these subjects strange forms of expression other than those in the Scriptures', *Ad Serap.* 1.17 (PG 26, 572C); tr. C.R.B. Shapland, *The Letters of Saint Athanasius Concerning the Holy Spirit* (London: Epworth Press, 1951), 106.

[9] His enemies do not speak from scripture ('they find nothing there') but speak out of the abundance of their own heart (*Ad Serap.* 1.15). 'Where in the Scriptures have they found the Spirit referred to as an angel?' (1.11; Shapland, 87); nor is he ever called a son: 1.16; also 1.32, 33. 'Harken to the Scriptures,' he urges them, and learn something about theology: *Ad Serap.* 4.3 (P.G. 26, 641A).

[10] Shapland, 34-5. Of these letters Louis Doutreleau, the editor of Didymus, says that they add up to a veritable treatise on the Holy Spirit: Didyme l'Aveugle, *Traité du Saint-Esprit*, SC 386 (1992), 26.

[11] *Ad Serap.* 1.21 (PG 26, 580B). Also 3.1: 'It is natural, therefore, that I should have spoken and written first concerning the Son, that from our knowledge of the Son we may be able to have true knowledge of the Spirit. For we shall find that the Spirit has to the Son the same proper relationship as we have known the Son to have to the Father' (Shapland, 170). And 3.3: 'for we must take our knowledge of the Spirit from the Son' (Shapland, 173); 'make plain from the Son what we know concerning the Spirit' (3.4; Shapland, 173-4). 'For where the Word is, there is the Spirit also,' (3.5; Shapland, 174). The Spirit is our mode of apprehension of the Son and through him of the Father: 'When we partake of the Spirit we have the Son; and when we have the Son, we have the Spirit, as Paul said, crying in our hearts: "Abba Father!" [Galatians 4.6]' (4.4; Shapland, 184). Cf. also 3.6. Conversely, it is through the Son who comes from the Father that we received the Spirit, 'whom we have believed to be of God and to be given from the Father through the Son' (4.6; Shapland, 188).

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(ἐκ) God himself ... And if the Son, because he is of the Father, is proper to his essence, it must be that the Spirit, who is said to be from God, is in essence proper to the Son (ἴδιον εἶναι κατ' οὐσίαν τοῦ Υἱοῦ[12].

A little further on, he will extend to the Spirit the key term *homoousion* that had caused so much controversy when applied to the Son: 'But because he is one, and, still more, because he is proper to the Word who is one, he is proper to God who is one, and one in essence with him'[13]. Moreover, the Spirit's eternal mode of being is *through* the Son, as Athanasius states: 'The Spirit is not external to the Word but being *in* the Word is *through* him in God' (Οὐ γὰρ ἐκτός ἐστι τοῦ Λόγου τὸ Πνεῦμα, ἀλλὰ, ἐν τῷ Θεῷ δι' αὐτοῦ ἐστίν)[14].

Athanasius never explicitly states that the Holy Spirit proceeds from the Son. Nevertheless, the manner in which he speaks of his mission of deification points to the eternal relationship existing outside of time:

> As the Son, the living Word, is one, so must the vital activity and gift whereby he sanctifies and enlightens be one perfect and complete; which is said to proceed (ἐκπορεύεσθαι) from the Father, because it is from the Word, who is confessed to be from the Father, that it shines forth and is sent and is given[15].

With the opponents of the divinity of the Holy Spirit in view, Athanasius here describes the Spirit as God's vital activity (ἐνέργεια) of sanctification and enlightenment. A little further along in the same work to Serapion, Athanasius refers to the Spirit's being an anointing, and thus one who cannot be confused with creatures who are the subjects of anointing. And this unction is the breath (πνοή) of the Son, since we are in the Apostle's words the good odour (εὐωδία) of Christ[16].

[12] *Ad Serap.* 1.25 (PG 26, 588D-589A); Shapland, 128. Also 1.27, 1.32. This same language Athanasius uses of the Son in *Contra Arianos* 2.31: 'At the same time, things originate could not without the Word be brought to be; hence they were made through Him, – and reasonably. For since the Word is the Son of God by nature proper to His essence, and is from Him, and in Him, as He said Himself, the creatures could not have come to be, except through Him' (LNPF, 364).

[13] *Ad Serap.* 1.27 (PG 26, 593C); Shapland, 133. He will use this term again in 3.1 and explain it in 2.3 and 2.5. Cf. also its use in *Contra Arianos* 1.9, its only appearance in the first three books of that treatise. In *Ad Serap.* 1.31 he uses the expression that the Holy Spirit is acknowledged as God (θεολογούμενον) with the Word.

[14] *Ad Serap.* 3.5 (PG 26, 633A). Also: 'Since the Spirit is in the Word, it is clear that the Spirit is in God and through the Word', 3.6 (PG 26, 633B-C); Shapland, 176 (modified) Cf. E.B. Pusey, *On the Clause 'And the Son', in Regard to the Eastern Church and the Bonn Conference. A Letter to the Rev. H. P. Liddon, D.D.* (Oxford, 1876), 115.

[15] *Ad Serap.* 1.20 (PG 26, 580A); Shapland, 116-117. Cf. John Meyer, 'Clarifying the *Filioque* Formula', *Communio* 27.2 (Summer, 2000), 397: 'The very procession from the Father', comments Shapland in a footnote, 'is itself apprehended by us from our knowledge of His mission from the Word' (117, n. 16).

[16] *Ad Serap.* 3.3 (PG 26, 628B-629A). In a disputed work, the *De Incarnatione et contra Arianos,* the author states in so many words that the Son is, in the Father, the Fountain of the Holy Spirit: 'Therefore in his song David says to God, "For with you is the well of life, in your light we shall see light." For he knew that the Son, being with the Father, is the Fountain of the Holy Spirit.' The authenticity of this work has been challenged, although Quasten defends it: *Patrology* III (Utrecht, 1966), 28-29. Cf. Pusey, 115.

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To say that the Holy Spirit proceeds from the Father is to say that he shines forth, ἐκλάμπει, from the Son who is of the Father. This ἔκλαμψις of the Spirit from the Logos can be read as expressing an essential derivation. As early as the *Contra Gentes* (46) the Son is called the Brightness of the Father, ἀπαύγασμα, an appellation which Athanasius equates with image, resemblance, wisdom, word, and power, all names having to do with theology properly so called[17]. Speaking in his work against the Arians of the Son as the Gift of the Father who is the Giver, Athanasius expands on this theme:

And this one may see in the instance of light and radiance, for what the light enlightens, that the radiance irradiates; and what the radiance irradiates, from the light is its enlightenment. So also when the Son is beheld, so is the Father, for he is the Father's radiance; and thus the Father and the Son are one[18].

The radiance of the Son allows us to see the light which is the Father. 'For the radiance also is light, not second to the sun, nor a different light, nor from participation in it, but a whole and proper offspring of it'[19]. Athanasius argues from the perichoresis of the Father and Son, that they are *in* each other, to unity of nature and substance.

For the Son is in the Father, as is allowed us to know, because the whole Being of the Son is proper to the Father's essence, as radiance from light, and stream from fountain ... For the Father is in the Son since the Son is what is from the Father and proper to Him, as in the radiance the sun and in the word the thought, and in the stream the fountain; for whoever thus contemplates the Son, contemplates what is proper to the Father's Essence, and knows that the Father is in the Son. For whereas the Form and Godhead of the Father is the being of the Son, it follows that the Son is in the Father and the Father in the Son[20].

These quotations from the *Contra Arianos* are brought in to show how the great Alexandrian father will later extend his logic to include the Holy Spirit. For in the first letter to Serapion he argues for the divinity of the Holy Spirit on the ground that he is in the Son and the Son in him:

For as the Son, who is in the Father and the Father in him, is not a creature but pertains to the essence of the Father... so also it is not lawful to rank with the creatures the Spirit who is in the Son, and the Son in him, nor to divide him from the Word and reduce the Triad to imperfection[21].

[17] He uses these images in *Ad Serap.*2.1, 2 and *Contra Arianos* as well: e.g., 2.3-4, 3.13, and 3.23. Who can declare the holy Triad itself, asks Athanasius. Since tradition 'does not declare the Godhead to us by demonstration in words, but by faith and by a pious and reverent use of reason', we must use these illustrations of 'radiance, fountain and river, essence and expression' in speaking of the mystery of God: *Ad Serap.* 1.20 (PG 26, 577B); Shapland, 114, 115.

[18] *CA* 3.13; LNPF 395.

[19] *CA* 3.4; LNPF 395.

[20] *CA* 3.3 (PG 26, 328); LNPF 395, slightly adapted. Compare *Ad Serap.* 1.20.

[21] *Ad Serap.* 1.21 (PG 26, 580C); Shapland, 119. Cf. 3.3: 'But if we have confessed that the Son is not a creature, because he is in the Father and the Father in him, then the Spirit likewise cannot possibly be a creature; for the Son is in him and he is in the Son' (Shapland, 172).

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What is directly envisaged here is the divine character of the Holy Spirit, but we also read the ground of this conclusion. For Athanasius, the Son is divine because he is in the Father and from the Father; moreover, the Spirit is divine because he is proper to the Son, ἴδιον κατ' οὐσίαν τοῦ Υἱοῦ: 'And if the Son, because he is of the Father, is proper to his essence, it must be that the Spirit, who is said to be from God, is in essence proper to the Son'[22]. The logic seems to be that because of his being proper to the Son we can see that he is proper to the Father. If the Son is in the Father, he must be from the Father. If the Spirit is *in* the Son, he must be *from* the Son. There is a parallelism drawn between the relations of Father and Son on the one hand and Son and Spirit on the other, and Athanasius states this clearly as a principle: 'The Holy Spirit,' he says, 'is in the same relation of order and nature with the Son as the Son is with the Father'[23]. As the Son is the image of the Father, so is the Spirit the image of the Son[24]. In paragraph 25 of the first letter to Serapion Athanasius goes on to speak of the deificatory work of the Spirit in creation, stating that 'he in whom creation is made divine cannot be outside the Godhead of the Father'[25]. In this reasoning Athanasius seems to pass easily from the realm of theology to that of the economy, grounding the reality of earthly deification of creatures on the truth of the Spirit's heavenly and eternal relationship to the Son.

'The Spirit takes of the Son,' writes Athanasius[26], and he links the expression to John 16:14 ('He will glorify me, because he will take from what is mine and declare it to you' (NAB)). This expression will become a formula and will be repeated by Epiphanius[27] and Gregory of Nyssa[28]. In Shapland's interpretation, these writers indicate that 'they thought of the Spirit as receiving from the Son, not only a prerogative or an office, but His divine existence'[29].

[22] *Ad Serap.* 1.25 (PG 96, 589A); Shapland, 128. Cf. also 1.14: 'When mention is made of the Father, there is included also his Word, and the Spirit who is in the Son. If the Son is named, the Father is in the Son, and the Spirit is not outside the Word' (Shapland, 93-4).

[23] *Ad Serap.* 1.21 (PG 26, 580B). Cf. A. Palmieri, 'Esprit-Saint', *DTC* 5 (1913), 676-829, at 777.

[24] *Ad Serap.* 1.20, (PG 26, 577B) and 1.24 (PG 26, 588B).

[25] *Ad Serap.* 1.25 (PG 26, 589B-D); Shapland, 129. This is a point frequently made in the same work. Thus: 'But if, by participation in the Spirit, we are made "sharers in the divine nature", we should be mad to say that the Spirit has a created nature and not the nature of God. For it is on this account that those in whom he is are made divine. If he makes men divine, it is not to be doubted that his nature is of God' (1.24 (PG 26, 585C-588A); Shapland, 126-7); 'Who will unite you to God, if you have not the Spirit of God, but the spirit which belongs to creation?' (1.29 (PG 26, 597A); Shapland, 138), etc. Athanasius had already used this logic to underline the divinity of the Son: 'Again, if the Son were a creature, man had remained mortal as before, not being joined to God; for a creature had not joined creatures to God...' (*CA* 2.69; (PG 26, 293A); LNPF 386).

[26] *Ad Serap.* 1.20 (PG 26, 580B); Shapland, 118. Also 1.26.

[27] E.g., *Ancoratus* 6 (PG 43, 28A).

[28] *Adv. Mac.* 10 (ed. F. Mueller, *GNO* III/I (1958), 97; PG 45, 1313B).

[29] Shapland, 118, n. 24.

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In concluding the rich first letter to Serapion, Athanasius quotes the celebrated text of the Fourth Gospel on the Paraclete and masterfully brings together the themes he had expounded to meet the challenge of Arian denials:

True worshippers, therefore, worship the Father, but in Spirit and Truth, confessing the Son and in him the Spirit. For the Spirit is inseparable from the Son, as the Son is inseparable from the Father. The truth himself bears witness when he says, 'I will send you the Paraclete, the Spirit of truth which proceedeth from the Father, whom the world cannot receive', that is, those who deny that he is from the Father in the Son[30].

The trinitarian *lex orandi* was shown us by St Paul in his prayer for the Corinthians with which he concludes his second epistle to them: 'The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ and the love of God and the fellowship of the Holy Spirit be with you all' (2 Cor.13:14). Athanasius explains: 'For inasmuch as we partake of the Spirit, we have the grace of the Word and, in the Word, the love of the Father.' Being in the Word, he continues, means that the Spirit through the Word is also in the Father[31].

[30] *Ad Serap.* 1.33 (PG 26, 608A-B); tr. Shapland, 148-9.

[31] *Ad Serap.* 3.6 (PG 26, 633B); Shapland, 175. The baptismal formula, as given to us by the Lord himself in M. 28:19, also shows that the Catholic faith is grounded and rooted in the Trinity: 'For he who believes in the Father, in the Father knows that Son; and it is not apart from the Son that he knows the Spirit' (*Ad Serap.* 3.6 (PG 26, 636A); Shapland, 176).

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Origen's Encounter with Hippolytus

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The purpose of this communication is to discuss the evidence for the case that Hippolytus the commentator, the Church Father who left numerous writings to posterity now preserved in a fragmentary corpus, did not preach before Origen in Rome, but somewhere in the east, possibly in the environs of Antioch of Syria, or in one of the Christian centers along the coast of the Mediterranean between Athens and Alexandria.

This discussion is relevant to the 'Hippolytus question', that is, the ongoing scholarly enquiry regarding the location of the community of the writer Hippolytus[1]. It pertains particularly to current theories that Hippolytus, the author of a corpus that includes commentaries, anti-heretical compositions, chronographical works, and the so-called *Traditio apostolica*, was not Roman by origin, and perhaps not by residence, but a scion, if not a bishop, of the east.

It is also important in understanding influences that exerted themselves on Origen, primarily those giving rise to his biblical commentary writing, as well as his relationship with Ambrose, his patron[2].

The primary sources for our study are Eusebius' *Historia ecclesiastica*[3], book 6, preoccupied, as it is, largely with Origen[4], and Jerome's *Liber de viris illustribus*, entry 61 on Hippolytus. Book 6 of Eusebius' history is an essential cache of information on the travels of Origen beyond his home cities of Alexandria and Caesarea of Palestine.

Jerome's patrology contains a list of the literature of Hippolytus and in the same pericope mentions an encounter between Origen and Hippolytus that was historically significant, if true. Jerome claims to have read of the encounter in a text of Hippolytus, now lost, entitled *De laude domini salvatoris*. He says

[1] For an examination of the historical problem see J.A. Cerrato, *Hippolytus between East and West. The Commentaries and the Provenance of the Corpus*, Oxford Theological Monogaphs (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2002), 3-123.

[2] Recent studies treating the life of Origen include Joseph W. Trigg, *Origen*, The Early Christian Fathers (New York: Routledge, 1998), 3-66; Henri Crouzel, *Origen: The Life and Thought of the First Great Theologian*, tr. A.S. Worrall (San Francisco: Harper&Row, 1989); and Pierre Nautin, *Origène: sa vie et son œuvre* (Paris: Beauchesne, 1977).

[3] English translations of Eusebius used herein are from Eusebius, *The History of the Church*, tr. G.A. Williamson, rev. edn. Andrew Louth (London: Penguin Books, 1989), 179-220.

[4] Robert M. Grant, 'Eusebius and His Lives of Origen', in *Forma Futuri: Studi in onore del Cardinale Michele Pellegrino* (Torino: Bottega d'Erasmo, 1975), 635-49.

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Origen, through the patronage of Ambrose, composed commentaries on the holy scriptures 'in emulation' of Hippolytus, thereby asserting Hippolytan influence, perhaps even the initial impetus to use the genre.

Our thesis is as follows. Insofar as there was an *immediate causal connection* between Origen's encounter with Hippolytus and the inception of Origen's commentary production, as Jerome seems to suggest, the most likely places for their encounter were the regions of the east between Alexandria and Athens, not Rome.

Regarding an *immediate causal connection*, Jerome describes an encounter between Hippolytus and Origen, the outcome of which appears to have been the inception of Origen's commentary production. Jerome's language indicates that Ambrose, Origen's patron, was so smitten by Hippolytus' commentary work that he urged Origen to employ the same genre, providing him with the resources to write in a way that would match, if not outdo, the publications of Hippolytus.

The time between Origen's encounter with Hippolytus and the beginning of his own commentary activity seems immediate, perhaps within a year or two, based on a natural reading of the Jerome text. The structure of Jerome's narrative implies a causal connection between the Origen–Hippolytus encounter, Ambrose's enthusiasm, and Origen's work on his commentaries. He does not mention any lapse in time. In fact, he depicts urgency in the patronage of Ambrose that bears with it a sense of immediacy.

The passage from Jerome's *de viris illustribus* runs as follows. After acknowledging that he does not know the city of Hippolytus the bishop, whom he is about to discuss, he proceeds to list works of the Hippolytan corpus, most of which are biblical commentaries. He includes many Eusebius does not mention. He then writes,

> Hippolytus ... wrote ... a (pros)homily[5] *On the Praise of Our Lord Saviour*, in which he states he is speaking in church with Origen present. Ambrose, who, as we have said, was converted from the theresy of Marcrion to the true faith, urged Origen to write in emulation of this man. He supported him with seven, even more, secretaries and their expenses, and an equal number of copyists. Beyond this he exacted work from him every day with incedible zeal. Because of this, in a particular letter, Origen calls him a 'taskmaster' (*Vir. ill.* 61)[6].

The case for an *immediate causal connection* is grounded most persuasively not only in the clear intention of Jerome to speak of Hippolytan influence on

[5] This is the wording of Jerome. See the Greek term in the text of note 6.

[6] Jerome, *vir ill* 61: Hippolytus ... scripsit ... προσομιλίαν de laude domini salvatoris, in qua presente Origene, se loqui in ecclesia significat. huius aemulatione Ambrosius, quem de Marcionis haeresi ad veram fidem correctum diximus, cohortatus est Origenem in scripturas commentarios scribere, praebens ei septem et eo amplius notarios eorumque expensas et librariorum parem numerum, quodque his maius est, incredibili studio cottidie ab eo opus exigens. unde in quadam epistola ἐργοδιώκτην eum Origenes vocat.

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Origen, but also in what we can call the sudden emergence of focus on the *modus operandi* of Hippolytus.

The purpose of the pericope is to glorify the literary labour of Hippolytus. What was exemplary about Hippolytus, in Jerome's view, was not only his production of commentaries, but the way he worked in producing them. Apparently he used secretaries and copyists to a more effective degree than the Alexandrians had previously done.

The Latin construct *huius aemulatione* specifically signifies how Hippolytus served as a model of efficiency and productivity for the Origen entreprise. What is in mind here, although not exclusively, was the use of the commentary genre as supported by the employment of secretaries and copyists to facilitate the work.

Origen already possessed an extensive knowledge of exegesis at this point in his career and had been a biblical scholar of growing reputation for some years. He had worked on the Hexapla and instructed numerous students in the rigours of biblical theology. He had not, however, produced volumes in the commentary genre, that is, the passage-by-passage explanation of biblical texts encompassing entire books of the canon. At least he had not succeeded in producing them *en masse*.

This did not happen, according to Eusebius *and* Jerome, until the patronage of Ambrose provided him with the means and the motivation to do so. Both Eusebius and Jerome point to the support of Ambrose as a primary cause in the start of Origen's commentary production. Here Jerome says it was the work of Hippolytus and, it seems, the way he worked, that Ambrose gave to Origen.

The imitation of Hippolytus by Origen, thanks to Ambose, was subsequent to the encounter between Hippolytus and Origen, according to a natural reading of the Jerome text. In the encounter, it is implied, Origen learned of Hippolytus' *modus operandi*, as well as about his powers as an exegete.

This is the key. This explains why Ambrose is brought into the picture at precisely this point in a pericope about Hippolytus and why an emphasis suddenly emerges on secretaries and copyists in a paragraph that started out discussing the literature of a famous commentator and bishop. Jerome makes a switch from the titles of Hippolytus to an acknowledgement of the ingeniousness of his way of working, a method that was destined to catapult Origen into the commentary limelight, owing to the expenditures of Ambrose. This perhaps also explains in part the reference to a letter of Origen (now lost) in which he calls Ambrose his 'taskmaster'. It was productivity Hippolytus bequethed to Origen via Ambrose, a means of attaining speed and quantity, not primarily content.

Jerome does not identify the place of the Origen–Hippolytus encounter, because Hippolytus did not identify it in his own text. Jerome simply says of Hippolytus's language, 'He states he is speaking in church (*in ecclesia*) with Origen present'.

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Thus the meeting could have occurred in any number of communities in the Christian world of the third century in which Origen is known to have resided or visited[7], unless the encounter was an immediate cause of Origen's commentary activity. This would then narrow the range of geographical options to the east, particularly to the region from Alexandria to Athens. The basis for this judgement becomes evident from Eusebius' reports on Origen's whereabouts over the course of his career and on the dating of those whereabouts in the history[8].

If Eusebius is correct that Origen began to produce biblical commentaries after 222 as he openly states in *Historia ecclesiastica* 6.23[9], and if, as we have suggested, Jerome is to be interpreted as asserting an immediate causal connection between an encounter of Hippolytus and Origen and Origen's commentary work, then it can be established that the encounter occurred in the east, for Eusebius reports (we assume accurately) that Origen was in the east, between Egypt and Syria, throughout the years preceding the start of his commentary output.

Specifically, Origen was between Alexandria and Antioch of Syria in the period most closely associated with the beginning of his commentary production. Eusebius reports that Origen was resident in Alexandria, the city of his birth, and made four major journeys prior to the inception of commentary publication.

The first was to Rome in the episcopate of Zephyrinus (199-217), a brief visit according to Eusebius (*h.e.* 6.14), dated by the consensus of scholarship somewhere between the years 212-215. In Origen's own words, he had become 'anxious to see the ancient Roman church' (καὶ αὐτός που γράθει λέγων, εὐξάμενος τὴς ἀρχαιοτάτην Ῥωμαίων ἐκκλησίαν ἰδεῖν).

The second was a journey to Arabia, following his return to Alexandria from Rome (*h.e.* 6.19), and also after the conversion of Ambrose from the Marcionite camp (*h.e.* 6.18). The visit was prompted by an invitation from the 'ruler of Arabia' (παρὰ τοῦ τῆς Ἀραβίας ἡγουμένου), who wished to confer with Origen.

The third was to Caesarea of Palestine during what is called 'a violent campaign' (οὐ σμικροῦ κατὰ τὴς πόλιν ἀναρριπισθέντος πολέμου) against

[7] Elsewhere I have tended to treat the *ecclesia* of Jerome's text as indicating Hippolytus' own church (cf. Cerrato, *Hippolytus between East and West*, 251). The question of the *ecclesia* as the church of Hippolytus cannot be answered solely on the basis of Jerome's *vir. ill.* 61, but must be addressed with reference to the full range of evidence bearing on the Hippolytus question.

[8] Eusebius reports the travels of Origen in the following sections: Rome (6.14), Arabia (6.19), Caesarea of Palestine (6.19), Antioch of Syria (6.21), Greece (6.23), Caesarea of Palestine (6.26, relocation), Caesarea of Cappadocia (6.27), Athens (6.32), Bostra (6.33), Arabia (6.37).

[9] Eusebius, *h.e.* 6.23: ἐξ ἐκείνου δὲ καὶ Ὠριγένει τῶν εἰς τὰς θείας γραφὰς ὑπομνημάτων ἐγίνετο ἀρχή.

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Alexandria (*h.e.* 6.19). Origen fled the city, visiting the bishops of Palestine. This was the occasion of the famous preaching controversy with Demetrius.

The fourth, and the one immediately preceding the start of the commentary work, was to Antioch of Syria after the accession of the emperor Alexander Severus in 222 (*h.e.* 6.21). Origen travelled to Syria at the invitation of the emperor's mother Julia Mamaea and visited her in Antioch. According to Eusebius, he stayed for some time (παρ' ᾗ χρόνον διατρίψας).

Thus the possible geographical regions of encounter, in the widest sense, are Rome, Egypt, Palestine, Arabia (Jordan), and Syria. However, the more immediate the causal connection between the Hippolytan encounter and Origen's commentary production, then the more fitting and probable becomes the period of time that frames the visit to Antioch and the return journey to Alexandria. The date of this journey was certainly in or after 222.

The less immediate the causal connection, the more room there is to include other locales. Origen next travelled to Greece (*h.e.* 6.23), apparently in the early 230s, going by way of Palestine and perhaps all the way by land. If we interpret the Jerome text more loosely and view the Hippolytan influence as an impetus for Origen to compose commentaries (soon after he had made a start), rather than as the initial instigation, then a later date is viable, thus opening up the possibility of Origen's travels in the decade or so after 222.

The purpose of this essay is not to prove Origen and Hippolytus met in the east, but to demonstrate what must be proved in order to hold such a position. If an *immediate causal connection* – emphasis on 'immediate' – can be established, then the georgraphical focus is restricted accordingly. To view the encounter as taking place in Rome makes the least sense in the light of Jerome and Eusebius, given the fact that Origen had been in Rome some seven to ten years prior to the inception of his commentary work. It would seem the theory of a Roman encounter must seek to minimize, or dismiss, the witness of Jerome, insofar as it was his intention to speak of an immediate causal connection.

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Incorporeality and 'Divine Sensibility': The Importance of *De Principiis* 4.4 for Origen's Theology

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The structure and purpose of Origen's treatise *On First Principles* has tended to mystify its modern readers. Some have taken it to be a third-century essay in Christian systematics[1]; others, especially Henri Crouzel, have emphasized its speculative character as embodying a 'research theology', intended to remain within the boundaries of the articulated faith of the Church, but proposing solutions to the difficult problems of faith as hypotheses for further study[2]. The arrangement of themes within the work also strikes many as puzzling: as Dom Basilius Steidle observed in 1941[3], Origen in fact discusses the same series of subjects – God, as Father, Son and Holy Spirit; the nature and freedom of created intellects; and the world of matter in which they now undergo the dramatic history of fall and redemption – twice within the treatise: first somewhat summarily, in 1.1-2.3, and then, more at length and with a decidedly anti-Gnostic edge, but in the same order, in 2.4-3.6. This is followed, in book 4, by Origen's celebrated discussion of the character of Christian scripture and his proposed criteria for finding its meaning, and then – in the work's final chapter – with yet a third treatment of God as Trinity, created intellects and bodies, and the story of salvation, now in a more compressed style that seems intended to summarize and conclude the whole essay.

Since the early 1970s, a number of scholars have argued that the seemingly repetitious format of the first three books of the treatise can actually be found in a number of Greek technical and philosophical manuals that circulated in Origen's day, in which a general survey of the material is followed by a discussion of the same issues, point by point, in greater detail or from the perspective of a particular set of problems[4]. In an earlier

[1] See, for example, Adolf von Harnack, *Lehrbuch der Dogmengeschichte*, 4th edn, 3 vols. (Tübingen: J.C.B. Mohr; repr. Darmstadt: Wissenschaftliche Buchgesellschaft, 1964), 1, 652 n. 1; Franz-Heinrich Kettler, *Der ursprüngliche Sinn der Dogmatik des Origenes* (Berlin: Töpelmann, 1966).

[2] See 'Qu' a voulu faire Origène en composant le *Traité des Principes*', *BLE* 76 (1975) 161-86, 241-60; *Origen. The Life and Thought of the First Great Theologian*, tr. A.S. Worrall (San Francisco: Harper&Row, 1989), 163-9; see also Lothar Lies, *Origenes' 'Peri Archon': eine undogmatische Dogmatik* (Darmstadt: Wissenschaftliche Buchgesellschaft, 1992).

[3] 'Neue Untersuchungen zu Origenes' Περὶ ἀρχῶν,' *ZNW* 40 (1941), 236-43.

[4] See Marguérite Harl, 'Structure et coherence du Peri Archôn', in *Origeniana*, ed. H. Crouzel *et al.* (Bari: Istituto di lettera cristiana antica, 1975), 11-32; Gilles Dorival, 'Remarques sur la forme du Peri Archon', *Origeniana*, 33-45; 'Nouvelles remarques sur la forme du *Traité des Principes* d'Origène', *RAug* 22 (1987), 67-108.

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study[5], I suggested that Origen's discussion of the bible and its interpretation in *De Principiis* 4.1-3 is neither a digression nor a methodological appendix to a Christian dogmatic handbook, but in fact reveals the underlying goal of the whole work, as laid out in Origen's own preface: to offer the enquiring Christian reader a way of authentically finding the saving message of Christ in the whole bible – a model for discovering a spiritually nourishing interpretation of the scriptural text, which is governed by the faith of the community, as articulated in the 'canon' of the churches' baptismal profession. The purpose of the first three books, I argued there, is apparently to sketch out what Origen understands to be the dogmatic boundaries and central implications of Christian orthodoxy, in contrast to the revisionist interpretations of the Gospel put forward by his Gnostic contemporaries, and to frame what he understands to be mainstream teaching in 'a kind of organic and connected whole'[6], a scientific 'system' of explanation and hypothesis, that will allow fruitful discussion of the many important questions left open by the tradition of apostolic teaching. Against the background of this structure, using the rule of faith as the 'first principles' of authentic exposition, the Christian interpreter can confidently approach individual, difficult passages in the bible with a sense of the whole pattern, the comprehensive message it is understood to convey about God, the world, and human salvation.

What I would like to do here is to reflect further on the significance of *De Principiis* 4.4, the concluding chapter of the work, within this understanding of Origen's larger purpose[7]. Once again, I suggest that the key to seeing its significance lies in Origen's preface to the whole treatise. There, after insisting that the way to discover the life-giving teaching of Christ in Christian scripture is to remain within the framework of the apostolic preaching, and after briefly sketching the outlines of that preaching – which he will fill in abundantly in the three books that follow – Origen concludes by observing two things: first, that the scriptures were 'composed by the Spirit of God', and as a result have not only the obvious meaning suggested by the text, but 'another meaning that escapes very many' – a life-giving 'spiritual' meaning represented in the text by 'images of certain mysteries and divine realities'[8]; and secondly, that while the term 'incorporeal' (ἀσώματον; Latin *incorporeum*) is a philosophical one and does not appear in the bible, 'we will enquire nonetheless whether the reality itself (*res ipsa*) ... is found in the holy scriptures under another name'[9], and will therefore need to reflect on whether or not God is a body – a point, Origen says, 'not clearly articulated in our preaching' – as well as on the corporeality of Christ and the Holy Spirit, and on the relationship to

[5] 'Origen's *De Principiis*: a Guide to the Principles of Christian Scriptural Interpretation', in John Petruccione (ed.), *Nova et Vetera. Patristic Studies in Honor of Thomas Patrick Halton* (Washington: Catholic University of America Press, 1998), 3-21.

[6] *De Principiis* Praef. 10: in Rufinus's translation, *seriem quandam et corpus*.

[7] See my briefer treatment of *De Principiis* 4.4 in 'Origen's *De Principiis*', 17-18.

[8] *De Principiis* Praef. 8.

[9] *Ibid.* 9.

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bodies of 'every soul and intellectual nature'[10]. These two concluding observations of the Preface are together, I suggest, a clear indication of his purposes in writing Book IV, as well as the key to understanding the point of the entire treatise as an essay in both ecclesiastical hermeneutics and a peculiarly contemplative approach to soteriology. While the inspired character and spiritual meaning of the bible is not itself a part of the traditional 'rule of faith', and while the incorporeality of God and created intellects is, strictly speaking, a philosophical rather than a scriptural teaching, both must be held in mind by the Christian who wishes to understand scripture in its full, life-giving richness as the Word of life, offering those who truly grasp its meaning an essential share in the Word's own being.

In light of these two concluding observations in the Preface, *De Principiis* 4.4 can clearly be seen as a discussion of the Christian significance of incorporeality, both for the correct discovery of scripture's deeper, 'non-bodily' or spiritual meaning and for the interpretation of the real significance of the Church's faith in God and his saving work in created history. As Origen concedes, the term itself, τὸ ἀσώματον, comes from the world of Greek philosophy[11]. Plato, in his later dialogues, had identified 'true substance (οὐσία)' with the 'incorporeal forms' discovered in physical objects by the mind[12], and had asserted that 'incorporeal things (τὰ ἀσώματα), which are the greatest and most beautiful, are clearly disclosed only to reason, and to nothing else'[13]. The *Handbook of Platonism* by the author we now call Alcinous, composed probably during or slightly before Origen's own time, insists that the intelligible forms, the accidental qualities of things, the 'primary intellect' or God, and the individual soul are all incorporeal[14]. The Neoplatonist Porphyry, Origen's younger contemporary, emphasizing the importance of ascetical discipline in his treatise *On Abstinence*, suggests that its purpose is not only to give the mind peace from the distractions of unreasonable appetites, but to allow it to live on a new plane, 'so that we may not only hear about the mind and intelligible things, but may begin to enjoy contemplation itself and to exist in a state of incorporeality, in which we truly live by means of the mind ...'[15]

[10] *Ibid.*

[11] For a valuable survey of the use and significance of the term in Presocratic writers, where it seems to have generally conveyed the notion of being invisible, free of the sensible qualities of normal bodies, see Heinrich Gomperz, 'ἀσώματος', *Hermes* 67 (1932) 155-67. For Origen's theological use of the term, see Gedaliahu Stroumsa, 'The Incorporeality of God. Context and Implications of Origen's Position', *Religion* 13 (1983) 345-58. For a survey of the use of the idea of divine incorporeality in the Christian theological tradition, as well as its roots in Platonic ontology, see Grace M. Jantzen, 'The Doctrine of Divine Incorporeality' (Dissertation, University of Oxford, 1981), esp. 57-91.

[12] *Sophist* 246b; see also 247c.

[13] *Politicus* 286a.

[14] Alcinous, *The Handbook of Platonism* 9-11, 25 (tr. John Dillon (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1993), 16-20, 32-33). This 'Middle' Platonic introduction to philosophy has generally circulated, in modern editions, under the name of Albinus; Prof. Dillon has argued convincingly that its author was probably named Alcinous.

[15] Porphyry, *De Abstinentia* 1.31 (ed. Jean Bouffartigue (Paris: Les Belles Lettres, 1977), 66).

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Iamblichus, another – still younger – contemporary, describes the process of the soul's becoming like the forms it contemplates, through the study of mathematics, 'in the lightness of incorporeality'[16]. Origen was clearly familiar with this Platonic way of conceiving the divine realm and the human soul's divine potential; in his controversy with the Platonist Celsus, for instance, he insists several times that the biblical representation of God, despite its anthropomorphic imagery, clearly also conceives of him as incorporeal, although it normally expresses this in terms of God's *invisibility*[17]. In the *Commentary on John*, too, Origen clearly identifies the divine substance as incorporeal and intellectual[18], as immaterial light[19]. The divine Wisdom, who is 'above all creation' and who became flesh in Jesus, is described here as 'an incorporeal hypostasis, living and in a sense animated (ἔμψυχον), consisting of all sorts of conceptions (θεωρημάτων), which contain the structural principles (λόγους) of all things'[20]. Jesus, who tells the disciples that he has 'food of which they do not know' (John 4:32), also offers hidden nourishment for 'that part of us which is better than the body: incorporeal thoughts and words, and healthy ways of acting'[21]. Listening to his word means letting our own mind and spirit be nourished by his eternal knowledge.

This same conviction of the incorporeal reality of God, and the promise that created souls may share in the purity of that incorporeality by grace, lie behind Origen's argument in the closing chapter of *De Principiis*. He does indeed touch on the same range of subjects that occupied him, in two longer cycles, earlier in the treatise: God as Father, Son, and Holy Spirit; created intelligences; and the material cosmos in which these creatures now find themselves[22]. The lens through which he considers them now, however, is that of

[16] Iamblichus, *De communi mathematica scientia* 15 (ed. N. Festa (Leipzig: Teubner, 1975), 56.27-57.3).

[17] See *Contra Celsum* 1.15; 6.64; 7.27; 7.66. In *Contra Celsum* 7.38, Origen connects God's simplicity and incorporeality with his nature as resembling 'mind' (νοῦς), and with the biblical conception of the human person (for Origen, the human mind) as made in God's image: 'Since we affirm that the God of the universe is mind, or that he transcends mind and being, and is simple and invisible and incorporeal, we would maintain that God is not comprehended by any being other than him made in the image of that mind [i.e., the created intellect]' (tr. Henry Chadwick (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1980 (1953)), 425).

[18] *Commentary on John* 13.21 [123]; 20.18 (16) [158].

[19] *Ibid.* 13.22 [131-132]: '"God is light", according to John, "and there is no darkness in him" [1 John 1:5]. Let us examine how this light is to be understood, in the most intelligent way we can. "Light" is spoken of in two ways, after all: a bodily way and a spiritual way, which is the same thing as "intellectual" and what the scriptures would call "invisible", but what the Greeks call "incorporeal"'.

[20] *Commentary on John* 1.34 (39) [244].

[21] *Ibid.* 13.33 [204].

[22] In Rufinus' Latin translation of 4.4.1, Origen presents this as a 'recapitulation of details which we have mentioned in a scattered way, by way of a reminder'; a Greek fragment preserved in Eusebius, from Marcellus of Ancyra, characterizes 4.4 as 'explaining what had previously been omitted'. In either case, what is new here is the perspective and the detail, rather than the subjects treated.

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incorporeality, τὸ ἀσώματον. So Origen begins (in 4.4.1) by again discussing the hypostases of the Trinity, as he had in 1.1-3 and 2.4-7; now, however, his emphasis is on their unity, equality, and simplicity of being, their freedom from time and place, and the incorporeal way in which the Son is begotten. In treating of the Logos's relationship to humanity (4.4.2), Origen now points out that although Paul speaks of our being 'in Christ' and Christ's being 'in us', in fact the Logos, 'according to the majesty of his incorporeal nature, is not excluded from any place and is absent nowhere'. In becoming incarnate, the Word is not limited or divided from the Father – again, because of 'the nature of the incorporeal and invisible substance' (4.4.3). Origen's emphasis here, however, is not simply on God's incorporeal nature, but on the possibility offered to all intellectual creatures, through union with Christ and imitation of him, to 'participate in the Trinity' (4.4.5) or in the Pauline phrase, to be 'hidden with Christ in God' (4.4.4).

Origen then discusses matter, the philosophical term for 'the constituent parts of bodies', and characterizes it as something endlessly capable of change, because it never exists in itself without particular qualities (4.4.6-8); in the language of Psalm 138:16 (LXX), matter is the 'incompleteness of God' (*imperfectum Dei*). Although he has previously echoed the Platonic doctrine that the mind, in its own substance, is incorporeal, being an 'image of the invisible God' (Col 1:15)[23], Origen repeats here (4.4.8) what he has also argued earlier in the treatise: in order to change, to move, to adapt to new circumstances, rational natures need to use as instrument some form of material body. As he put it in 2.2.2,

> Consistent logical reasoning forces us to believe that, while rational beings were created first (*principaliter*), still it is only in theory and in our understanding that material substance is separable from them, and seems to have been made for them or after them; they have never lived or do live without it. For we shall be right in believing that life without a body is found in the Trinity alone'[24].

[23] *De Principiis* 1.1.6; see also 1.7.1: all rational creatures, including human minds, are 'incorporeal in respect of their proper nature', even though, as creatures, they are limited in power and presence.

[24] George Butterworth, in his translation of this passage (Origen, *On First Principles*, tr. G.W. Butterworth (London: S.P.C.K., 1936; repr. New York: Harper and Row, 1966), p. 81 n. 1), concludes that it has been altered by Rufinus, because it seems to contradict Origen's assertion in 1.7.1 that rational beings are, in their essence, incorporeal. However, a number of other passages in his works make it clear that he shared the Platonic notion that every finite intellectual being needs to make use of some kind of body as the 'vehicle' (ὄχημα) or instrument of its motion and activity, even though its own nature is incorporeal: see, for example, the fragment of his commentary on 1 Cor, frag. 30 on 6:15, in Claude Jenkins, *JTS* 9 (1908), 371; *Homilies on Judges* 6.5; and Methodius, *On the Resurrection* 3.18.1. See also Henri Crouzel, 'Le theme platonicien du "véhicule de l'âme" chez Origène', *Did* 7 (1977), 225-37; and my article, 'A Hope for Worms: Early Christian Hope', in Ted Peters, Robert John Russell, and Michael Welker (eds), *Resurrection: Theological and Scientific Assessments* (Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2002), 153-54.

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The result of the fall, then, was a change in the character of the bodies of fallen minds, not the creation of bodies for minds that had been wholly incorporeal before.

Origen concludes this final chapter of his treatise with reflections on human destiny as participation in the inner life of God, conceived now as the continuing refinement of our mental powers and moral virtue in terms of continuing growth towards incorporeal knowledge and goodness. The divine image in the human creature is seen not in our bodily form, but in our virtues, which are an acquired imitation of what God is always by nature (4.4.10). And because we are created in a kind of 'blood-relationship with God',

> it is possible that a rational mind also, by advancing from a knowledge of small to a knowledge of greater things, and from things visible to things invisible, may attain to an increasingly perfect understanding. For it has been placed in a body, and of necessity advances from things of sense, which are bodily, to things beyond sense perception, which are incorporeal and intellectual' (4.4.10, tr. Butterworth).

It is this transformed understanding, which Origen here characterizes by the Biblical label of 'a divine sensibility' (*sensus divinus*)[25]: the capacity, formed by the light of God's incarnate Wisdom, to read and understand in earthly things and texts even God's immaterial reality, while we live in a material world and use the senses and symbols of material bodies. The purpose of his *De Principiis*, he is suggesting here in its final sentences, is to point the faithful and diligent reader of the Christian bible towards the possibility, at least, of such an 'incorporeal' understanding of the contents of faith in the present life, and to hold out the promise of its continual growth in the life to come[26].

[25] Here, as earlier in 1.1.9, he alludes to a saying of Solomon, which Rufinus translates, *sensum divinum invenies*. This seems to refer to Proverbs 2:5, 'You will find knowledge of God' (LXX: ἐπίγνωσιν Θεοῦ εὑρήσεις), perhaps conflated with verse 3, 'If you demand perception (αἴσθησιν) with a loud voice ...' In *Contra Celsum* 7.34, Origen cites the same form of the phrase, αἴσθησιν Θεοῦ εὑρήσεις, as a saying of Solomon; it seems to have belonged to his version of the Greek Biblical text.

[26] In a catena fragment commenting on John 1:18 ('No one has ever seen God; the only Son, who is in the bosom of the Father, has made him known'), which the context suggests is to be attributed to Origen, the question is raised of whether it is ever possible for limited, embodied creatures to know God directly. The fragment concludes: 'The mind still subject to becoming, and for that reason also subject to time, does not see God as it should. Therefore the text does not simply say, "No one has seen God", but makes the addition of "ever", which signifies the element of time, so that what is being said is this: for as long a time as "ever" can be said, as signifying some subject, the mind is sold into the power of material life. Therefore it cannot see God by the direct action of the understanding. And we, for our part, understand him indistinctly, as far as is possible, from the conceptions of him we have contrived in our theology and maintain; but God himself does not have knowledge about himself through anything of this kind, but by his own proper relationship to himself, being himself both the act of knowledge and what is known. Therefore only the Son knows him, for he is known by the Father and knows the Father' (ed. E. Preuschen, *Origenes' Werke* 4, GCS 10 (Leipzig, 1903), 495.14-25). If this is by Origen, it would express in somewhat fuller terms the same sense that our knowledge of God can never reach perfection as long as our minds are limited by the categories of time and matter – a limitation that Origen seems, in the *De Principiis*, to suggest will always remain in some degree, as part of the embodiment of the created intellect.

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Ambivalence in Athanasius' Approach to Spiritual Direction

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Most of us, I believe, are familiar with Athanasius' *Life of St Antony*. The famous *vita* depicts a man who wishes to take seriously Christ's call, 'if you wish to be perfect, go sell all that you have and come follow me.' As Athanasius narrates, Antony sells his inheritance, provides for his sister, and then takes to the desert. Initially, Antony learns of the ascetic life from a variety of hermits (almost certainly laymen) before moving further in to the desert to perfect his renunciation in isolation[1]. After some twenty years of training, Antony emerges as a triumphant ascetic, superior to the demons and capable of leading disciples to similar spiritual heights[2]. The saint's spiritual authority is comprehensive: he commands wild animals, scatters demons and, most importantly, discerns the pastoral needs of his disciples[3]. There is little doubt that his ascetic achievement provides the basis of his spiritual authority. And yet despite Antony's greatness, or perhaps as an example of it, the saint humbly submits himself to the bishop. Near the end of the *vita*, Athanasius writes,

> Although [Antony] was such a man, he observed the rule of the Church most rigidly and insisted that all of the clergy were to be honoured above himself. For he was not ashamed to bow his head to bishops and presbyters, and if ever a deacon came to him for help he spoke with him about what was profitable, but then acknowledged his place during the prayer, not being ashamed to learn himself[4].

In other words, we have the most famous of the eremitic saints, an obvious authority in spiritual matters, subordinating himself to the lower clergy. It is, of course, possible to read this passage sceptically. Indeed, many commentators dispute the reliability of the *vita*[5]. Though such questions are important for reconstructing the historical Antony, Athanasius' apparent ambivalence concerning the criteria for spiritual authority is equally curious. Does the

[1] Athanasius, *Vit. Ant.* 4-5.

[2] Athanasius, *Vit. Ant.* 14.

[3] Concerning his control of animals, see *Vit. Ant.* 15. For his control of demons, see *Vit. Ant.* 6-7. And for his pastoral skill, see *Vit. Ant.* 15-17, 44, and 48.

[4] Athanasius, *Vit. Ant.* 67

[5] D. Brakke, *Athanasius and the Politics of Asceticism* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1995), pp. 201-65.

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bishop of Alexandria acknowledge ascetic experience to be a legitimate source of authority, or does he believe that all ascetics, Antony included, are subject to the clergy? And if they are subject to the clergy, do they lack entirely the ability to serve a pastoral function for their disciples? In this brief communication, I will argue that Athanasius' answer to these questions was inconsistent. In large part, that indecision developed from a tension between two distinct models of spiritual direction that informed Athanasius' pastoral decisions – a clerically oriented model that allowed the bishop to establish the boundaries of doctrinal conformity and a charismatic, spiritual father/spiritual disciple model grounded in ascetic experience that was emerging from the monastic community.

As in the *Life of St Antony*, Athanasius' correspondence reflects the strain between ascetic and non-ascetic criteria for leadership. Though he typically respected the ascetic community's pastoral operations, he did, on occasion, correct the teaching of monastic leaders he felt were ill-informed about certain issues[6]. And he consistently defended the authority of the Orthodox clergy[7]. Interestingly, the correspondence also evinces the bishop's numerous attempts to recruit experienced ascetics for the Egyptian episcopacy.

Athanasius' epistle to Dracontius is particularly illuminating. Dracontius had been an abbot, most likely at Nitria, when he was elevated to the episcopacy in 353[8]. The election did not sit well with his former colleagues, who, in turn, warned Dracontius that as a bishop he would lose the many spiritual benefits of the ascetic life. Heeding their counsel, Dracontius refused his office and returned to his monks[9]. Athanasius's letter, written in 354, relates his disappointment: 'Beloved Dracontius, you have caused us grief instead of joy, groaning instead of consolation; we expected to have you with us as a consolation and now we see that you are in flight'[10].

Of Athanasius' many arguments to persuade Dracontius, some of the most telling are those that detail the relationship between the clergy and the sacraments. He writes,

[6] In a letter to Ammonias, Athanasius corrects what he believes to be Ammonias' teaching on nocturnal emissions and marriage. Athanasius also involves himself in a succession dispute in the Pachomian community.

[7] To be sure, Athanasius' support for the clergy was restricted to those persons who held similar doctrinal views. See Brakke, *Athanasius*, pp. 57-62.

[8] See Leslie Barnard, *The Monastic Letters of Saint Athanasius the Great* (Oxford: SLG Press, 1994), pp. xi-xiii. See also Brakke, *Athanasius*, pp. 99-110.

[9] Many late ancient ascetics expressed resistance to ordination. In general, they feared that the responsibilities of office would be too great for them to manage – an indication of the monastic attempt to acquire humility. Indeed, Athanasius seems to know of some who had warned Dracontius that the 'bishop's office is an occasion for sin and from it comes the opportunity for sin' (*Ep. Drac.* 8-9).

[10] Athanasius, *Ep. Drac.* 2.

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For if all were of the same mind as your advisers, how would you have become a Christian, since there would be no bishops? Or if our successors are to inherit this opinion, how will the churches be able to hold together? Or do your advisers despise it because they think you have received nothing? If so, they are certainly wrong. Next they will think that the grace of the font is nothing, if some despise it[11].

Two issues are at stake. First, the sacrament of baptism unites all members of the Church. Because only the clergy can perform the sacraments, Athanasius reasons, the Church would disintegrate if every worthy candidate ignored his obligation. Second, Dracontius has received God's grace through ordination; if he turns back now he risks not only his own salvation, but also that of his flock. By binding the Church to the sacramental rites, Athanasius establishes the clergy as the principal agents of God's grace and authority on earth. Simply put, without the clergy there is no Church.

But at the same time, Athanasius appears determined to raise as many ascetics to the episcopacy as possible. He reminds Dracontius, 'You are not the only one who has been elected from among monks, nor the only one to have presided over a monastery'[12], Ammonias, Serapion, Apollos, Agathon, Muitus, and Paul (all ascetics) dutifully accepted the responsibilities of the episcopate – Dracontius should be no different[13]. Eventually, Dracontius conceded, and studies of the Egyptian episcopacy suggest that by the fifth century nearly every bishop in Egypt came from an ascetic background[14]. If this letter suggests any resolution to the ambivalence of Athanasius' position, it is that authority resides with the clergy (by virtue of ordination), but it is ascetics who are the most qualified to assume the priesthood.

There are at least two reasons that Athanasius would have selected ascetics to fill the pastoral void. First, as an ascetic himself, he likely believed that a monastic training well prepared a candidate for the ministry. In his twenty-fourth *Festal Letter*, the bishop declared,

For a just father raises his children well, when he is diligent in teaching others in accordance with his own upright conduct, so that when he meets with opposition, he will not be ashamed to hear, 'You who teach others, can you not teach yourself?' [cf. Rom. 2:21], but rather, like the good servant, may both save himself and gain others[15].

Though later authors (especially Gregory the Great) would be more explicit in their desire to recruit ascetics for the clergy, there is little reason to doubt Athanasius' reliance upon the value of ascetic experience.

[11] Athanasius, *Ep. Drac.* 4.

[12] Athansius, *Ep. Drac.* 7.

[13] 'And these, when elected, did not refuse, but, taking Elisha as an example and knowing the story of Elijah and having learnt all about the disciples and apostles, accepted their charge and did not despise the ministry' (*Ep. Drac.* 7).

[14] Jacob Muyser, 'Contribution à l'étude des listes épiscopales de l'Église copte', *Bulletin de la Société d'archéologie copte* 10 (1944), 115-76.

[15] Athansius, *Ep. Fest.* 24.2.

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A second explanation, the one that has found the most interest among scholars, is that of political and theological necessity. In the epistle to Dracontius, Athanasius remarks, 'Even if you are really weak, you should still accept the charge; otherwise enemies will use your flight as an excuse to harm the Church that would be left unoccupied'[16], Though obscured by other, more developed arguments, Athanasius' aside exposes the anxieties of the Orthodox community in Alexandria[17]. Indeed, Dracontius' see had a history of doctrinal infighting and was, for a time, occupied by the Melitians[18]. Athanasius complained that schismatic groups were appointing clergy in sees that were not their own[19]. And it is possible that his rivals were themselves recruiting candidates from desert monasteries[20]. Either way, Athanasius struggled to rally the ascetic community to his side against the Melitians and to place his allies into influential positions within the Egyptian hierarchy. When Dracontius did finally submit, he helped to establish a permanent link between the Alexandrian clergy and the monks of Nitria[21].

Let us turn more directly to Athanasius' theological confrontations to see how they impacted his selection of clerics. There is little doubt that Athanasius required potential candidates for ordination to conform to his version of Orthodox Christianity. In his nineteenth *Festal Letter*, for example, the bishop maintained that the difference between saints and sinners was the knowledge of the true faith[22]. And yet despite his heightened concern for heresy, Athanasius was willing to allow some Arian clergy to retain their rank upon an Orthodox confession of faith[23]. When Constantius died in 362, the pro-Nicene bishops in exile were allowed to return to their sees. Subsequently, Athanasius and his supporters convened a synod in Alexandria to determine what measures would be taken against Arian clerics. According to Athanasius, the provocateurs of heresy could be restored to communion, but they must forfeit their positions. However, those who had fallen away 'not deliberately, but by violence and necessity', would not only receive pardon, but could maintain their clerical standing[24]. As Athanasius explained in a letter to Rufinianus, the logic was twofold. First, the situation required οἰκονομία – in other words, a pastoral concession. Second, by allowing otherwise perfectly acceptable candidates to

[16] Athanasius, *Ep. Drac.* 6.

[17] Athanasius had good reason to fear. See Barnard, p. xi and Brakke, pp. 100-10.

[18] Athanasius, *Apologia Secunda* 71.

[19] Athanasius, *Ep. Fest.* 40.

[20] Brakke, *Athanasius*, p. 101.

[21] Brakke, *Athanasius*, pp. 108-9.

[22] Athanasius, *Ep. Fest.* 19. 6, 7.

[23] *Ep. Rufinianus.* See Charles Kannengieser, 'Athanasius of Alexandria and the Ascetic Movement of his Day', in *Asceticism*, ed. V. Wimbush and R. Valantasis (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1995), pp. 486-7.

[24] Athanasius, *Ep. Rufinianus.*

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continue, the Church would not have to raise unqualified candidates to the ranks of the clergy[25].

What was Athanasius' definition of a 'qualified' candidate? Unlike Augustine, John Chrysostom, or Gregory the Great, Athanasius never defined in clear terms his criteria for pastoral authority. The *Life of St Antony* suggests that ascetic experience was the source of that saint's authority. Could that apply to anyone? When Athanasius extolled Antony's skill and authority, he, no doubt, earned the respect of the ascetic community. But back in Alexandria, Athanasius argued that his own authority and that of his allies derived from the grace of the priesthood and that they preserved that grace through their continued support of Nicene Christianity. We know that Athanasius raised a number of monks to the episcopacy. But we do not have sufficient evidence that he believed that the pool of candidates was to be drawn exclusively from the ascetic community.

Finally, I would like to point to what I believe to be something of a paradox. I have argued that one explanation for Athanasius' ambivalence in spiritual direction was the rising tension between the ascetic and non-ascetic trajectories of Christian leadership (trajectories that, I might add, became more pronounced in the following century). Unlike many of the Church fathers in later generations, however, Athanasius did not distinguish between ascetic and non-ascetic patterns of spiritual direction, nor even between ascetic and non-ascetic Christians – indeed, theirs was a difference in degree, not in kind. Athanasius, perhaps better than anyone of his generation, took advantage of the monastic explosion that occurred in the Egyptian desert. He lobbied the ascetic community for the Nicene cause and he convinced its most capable leaders to serve the Church at large. Nevertheless, it is quite possible that he never realized just how much that same revolution in Christian piety had informed, perhaps even complicated, his own policies of spiritual direction.

[25] Ibid.

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Multiple Models of Atonement in Athanasius' *De Incarnatione*[1]

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Many studies have been made of the Christian doctrine of the atonement, but more often than not, different models are examined with the view of finding which one best explains the meaning of salvation. Thus, while much thought has been put into distinguishing them, not much has been put into examining how they are compatible or even integrated. What is not considered is how each of these models may simply reflect different aspects of the one salvific work of Christ in such a way that they can be integrated into a multifaceted, yet coherent doctrine. I would like in this short paper to explore how Athanasius' *On the Incarnation of the Word* is an example of such an integration. This is only a preliminary historical study of the models themselves and how they can be integrated using Athanasius as an example. If the possibility of such an integration is indeed shown, it would warrant developing an entirely new unified doctrine of the atonement unrestricted by the classic models.

Summary of Classic Models of Atonement

For convenient reference, I will divide the many versions of atonement into four groups[2]. According to the *solidarity* model, when God becomes human in Christ, all of humanity can then be divinized through the union of solidarity with the incarnate Word. The *satisfaction* model regards the suffering and death of Christ as a means to render divine justice in answer for human sin. Christ's full submission to the effects of sin, namely mortality, is payment of what is due for the original sin of humanity. In the *enlightenment* model, the powerful and life-reforming knowledge of the teaching and example of Christ empowers us to be converted to a life of virtue rather than sin. The *conflict* model focuses on Christ as a champion who does battle with and wins out over Satan, the agent of death, thereby liberating humanity from death to life[3].

[1] I would like to acknowledge the Committee for Faculty Development at Saint Mary's College of California, whose financial support enabled me to prepare and present this paper.

[2] See E.J. Yarnold, *The Second Gift* (Slough: St. Paul Publications, 1974), pp. 109-21.

[3] This model is most notably explicated in Gustav Aulén, *Christus Victor*, tr. A.G. Herbert (New York: Macmillan, 1931).

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The Solidarity Model

According to Athanasius, human mortality results from losing the grace of immortality and rationality that we had from being created in the image of God and having a share in the power of the Word (*DI* 3). If we transgress God's law, we cease contemplating God, and if we cease to know God, we cease to exist.

> The presence and love of the Word had called them into being; inevitably, therefore, when they lost the knowledge of God, they lost existence with it; for it is God alone who exists. (*DI* 4)

Mortality is here seen not as a punishment for transgression, but as a natural consequence of losing touch with the source of life.

Regaining the grace of immortality is beyond human capability, so God must refashion us through the agency of the Word, who first created us:

> [He took a body like our own] that he might turn again to incorruption those who had turned back to corruption, and make them alive through death by the appropriation of his body and by the grace of his resurrection. (*DI* 2.8)

The solidarity model is best summed up in this classic passage:

> Through this union of the immortal Son of God with our human nature, all were clothed with incorruption in the promise of the resurrection. For the solidarity of humankind is such that, by virtue of the Word's indwelling in a single human body, the corruption which goes with death has lost its power over all. (*DI* 9)

The Satisfaction Model

The physical corruption we experience, however, is more than just the natural consequence of losing the grace of immortality; it is also a punishment, a moral consequence for transgressing God's law. 'Not only did humans die', Athanasius says,

> corruption ran riot among them and held sway over them to an even more than natural degree, because it was the penalty of which God had forewarned them for transgressing the commandment. (*DI* 5)

A few sections later he notes again that 'corruption held us all the closer, because it was the penalty for the transgression' (*DI* 8). Hence the Fall involved a disruption not only of the natural order, but also of the moral order of divine justice, and this also needed to be rectified.

The law of God that decreed that death would follow upon sin must be upheld and honoured, for it would be unthinkable 'that God should go back upon his word and that humans, having transgressed, should not die' (*DI* 6). Therefore, because God is consistent, all must undergo death, the lawful

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penalty for sin. Only then could God redeem us from complete annihilation. It is by virtue of solidarity with the incarnate Word that when he suffers death, all share this experience and fulfil the penalty.

Thus, taking a body like our own, because all our bodies were liable to the corruption of death, he surrendered his body to death instead of all. (*DI* 8)

He became in dying 'a sufficient exchange for all ... he offered his own temple and bodily instrument as a substitute for the life of all, he fulfilled in death all that was required' (*DI* 9).

This language suggests the idea of penal substitution – Christ suffering punishment in our place – but this is not what he means. Taking into account what he says about solidarity, we suffer and die in union *with* Christ rather than having Christ do this *for* us.

The idea of sacrifice is traditionally included in the satisfaction model and is important for Athanasius because it expressed the motivation and the value or cost of what is given. Christ's sacrifice was the total gift of himself motivated by love for us and honour for the integrity of his Father and the created order. There is no idea of appeasement or bargaining:

He surrendered his body to death in the place of all, and offered it to the Father. This he did out of sheer love for us, so that in his death all might die. (*DI* 8)

There was a debt owing that had to be paid; for, as I said before, all humans were due to die. Here, then, is the second reason why the Word dwelt among us, namely, that having proved his Godhead by his works, he might offer the sacrifice on behalf of all, surrendering his own temple to death in place of all, to settle our account with death and free us from the primal transgression. (*DI* 20)

A full doctrine of the atonement must show not only that Christ died, but also why he suffered an ignoble death at the hands of others. Among other reasons[4], Athanasius explains how Christ died in such a way that he could sum up in himself the fullness of humanity in its sin and brokenness and make God and humanity truly at-one[5] again.

Since the saviour came to accomplish the death of all humankind and not his own, he did not lay aside his life by his own design ... but he accepted death at the hands of others, thereby completely destroying it in others. (*DI* 22)

He does not elaborate on this terse statement, but he seems to be making the following points. Christ's death was not a private or individual act relevant only to his own destiny. Rather, it had to involve all of us in a way that would affect everyone's destiny – when he dies, all must die with him. Further, only a death at the hands of others would suffice:

[4] Cf. *DI* 21-25.

[5] Making 'at-one' is the root meaning of 'at-one-ment'.

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Death came to his body, therefore, not from himself but from enemy action, in order that the saviour might utterly abolish death in whatever form they offered it to him ... He accepted and bore upon the cross a death inflicted by others, and those others his special enemies, a death which to them was supremely terrible and by no means to be faced; and he did this in order that, by destroying even this death, he might himself be believed to be the Life, and the power of death be recognized as finally annulled. A marvellous and mighty paradox has thus occurred, for the death that they thought to inflict on him as dishonour and disgrace has become the glorious monument to death's defeat. (*DI* 24)

To completely destroy in his body the full scope of evil that had condemned us to death, Christ had to embrace the worst act of evil possible. Paradoxically, in the attempt to sever Jesus from our world by rejecting and murderously crucifying him (thus deepening our alienation from God, that is, our death), Jesus is actually enabled to receive into himself all of humanity out of the depth of its alienation[6]. Once we suffer death in Christ, the way to be restored to life is clear, and this is possible through solidarity with Christ, over whom death has no hold, for when he rises all may rise with him.

The Conflict Model

Athanasius uses the idea of victory over evil forces whenever we in our plight are seen as under the power of death, sin, or evil forces. The Word has come to overpower Satan, the minister of death, and liberate those under his power:

The Word ... being himself incapable of death, assumed a mortal body ... 'that through death he might destroy him who has the power of death, that is, the devil and deliver all those who through fear of death were subject to lifelong bondage'[7]. (*DI* 20)

A repeated refrain Athanasius uses when discussing the resurrection is that death has lost its power over us, and remarkably we are now without fear:

It is clear that it is Christ himself and none other who is the arch-victor over death and has robbed it of its power. Death used to be strong and terrible, but now, since the sojourn of the saviour and the death and resurrection of his body, it is despised; and obviously it is by the very Christ who mounted on the cross that it has been destroyed and vanquished finally. (*DI* 29)

[6] René Girard's theories of *mimesis* and sacred violence are relevant here. Jesus breaks the cycle of violence by being the recipient, like a scapegoat, of human violence and responding with forgiveness and re-creative love. Cf. René Girard, *Violence and the Sacred* (Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1977); *idem*, *Things Hidden Since the Foundation of the World* (Stanford, Calif.: Stanford University Press, 1987); Raymund Schwager, *Must There be Scapegoats? Violence and Redemption in the Bible* (San Francisco: Harper & Row, 1987); *idem*, *Jesus in the Drama of Salvation: Toward a Biblical Doctrine of Redemption* (New York: Crossroad Publications, 1999).

[7] Hebrews 2.14-15.

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The Enlightenment Model

Thus far, Athanasius has focused on the Word redeeming us from physical mortality and natural corruption. But in section 11, he suggests that knowledge of God was a greater grace than immortality, hence its restoration is to be more valued. Thus, of greater importance is healing the soul or mind of fallen humans whose damaged ability to know God is perhaps their worst plight.

When God the Almighty was making humankind through his own Word, he perceived that they, owing to the limitation of their nature, could not of themselves have any knowledge of their artificer, the incorporeal and uncreated ... But, in fact, the good God has given them a share in his own image, that is, in our Lord Jesus Christ, and has made even themselves after the same image and likeness. Why? Simply in order that through this gift of Godlikeness in themselves they may be able to perceive the image absolute, that is, the Word himself, and through him to apprehend the Father, which knowledge of their maker is for humans the only really happy and blessed life. (*DI* 11)

The reflection of the divine in creation as well as the Law and the prophets proved insufficient to restore this grace of contemplation (cf. *DI* 12). The Word himself had to renew the image in which humanity was made in order to restore knowledge of God.

What else could God possibly do but renew his image in mankind, so that through it we might once more come to know him? And how could this be done save by the coming of the very image himself, our saviour Jesus Christ? (*DI* 13)

When, then, the minds of people had fallen finally to the level of sensible things, the Word submitted to appear in a body, in order that he, as a human, might center their senses on himself, and convince them through his human acts that he himself is not human only but also God, the Word and Wisdom of the true God. (*DI* 16)

For Athanasius, this recovered knowledge of God, this restoration of the soul, is a gift that is given at the same time as the restoration of bodily incorruption.

A final concern of atonement doctrine is the question of our role in salvation – is salvation totally the objective work of 'God in Christ reconciling the world to himself', or are we subjectively involved? Athanasius does not address this directly, but two passages suggest that he thinks salvation ultimately is an invitation to which we must respond:

Since even the best of humans were confused and blinded by evil, how could they convert the souls and minds of others? ... Wherefore, in all naturalness and fitness, desiring to do good, the Word came as a human ... and through his actions done in that body, as it were on their own level, he teaches those who would not learn by other means to know himself, the Word of God, and through him the Father. (*DI* 14)

For this reason he was born and manifested as human, for this he died and rose, in order that, eclipsing by his works all other human deeds, he might recall us from all the paths of error to know the Father. (*DI* 15)

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The role we play in this drama of salvation is similarly relevant to the solidarity model. Do we have any choice about being refashioned into incorruptibility? Again we find a passage suggesting that Athanasius thinks we do. The Word became flesh and suffered death

> that he might turn again to incorruption humans who had turned back to corruption, and make them alive through death by the appropriation of his body and by the grace of his resurrection. (*DI* 2.8)

Athanasius probably has in mind the sacraments of initiation when he speaks of appropriating the body of Christ and receiving the grace of the resurrection.

To conclude, although the *De incarnatione* is not presented as a complete doctrine of the atonement, the basic principles of Athanasius' understanding of this doctrine are discernible, and his use of ideas from all four classic models is significant. In short, humanity's fall from grace, its turning away from God, resulted in four significant consequences that only the incarnate Word could remedy. The lost grace of immortality was made available again by the immortal Word becoming human and letting all share in his risen body (solidarity); the forces of evil under which humanity had become helplessly enslaved were overpowered by Christ and are no longer a lethal threat as long as we are in union with Christ the arch-victor (conflict); the loss of knowledge of God has been restored by the teaching and example of Christ, the perfect revelation of the Father (enlightenment); and finally, full reconciliation is made possible by the incarnate Word's willingness to meet humanity in the depths of its sin by sacrificing himself to its violence and responding with loving forgiveness (satisfaction).

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Origen on the Foolishness of God

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'The absurd is – that the eternal truth has come into being in time, that God has come into being ...' (Kierkegaard)

In 1 Corinthians 1:21-25 the apostle Paul introduced a new phrase – if not a totally new concept – to the religious vocabulary of Jews and Christians when he referred to 'the foolishness of God'. The Church Fathers did not pick this phrase up with much enthusiasm, probably because they found themselves often defending the Christian message against the charge that it was foolishness. Theophilus' antagonist, Autolycus, considered the Christian teaching to be foolishness (Theophilus, *Autol* 2.1; 3:4); Justin's Jewish dialogue partner, Trypho, thought the concepts of the pre-existence of Christ, his incarnation, and divinity to be foolish (Justin, *Dial* 48.1); and Celsus, the second-century Platonic philosopher, depicted Christians as foolish in various ways (Origen, *Cels* 1.9; 3.47-48). 'They laugh at us as fools,' Origen says in a homily on 1 Corinthians, 'and say, "Christians say that there is a resurrection of the dead, and that we live after death, and that Jesus, whom the Jews crucified, was born from a virgin", and many other things like these' (*Cor Cat* viii, ed. C. Jenkins, *JThSt* 9 (1908), 237). Consequently, because they were so frequently on the defensive against actual charges of foolishness, most of the Church Fathers did not revel in the Pauline phrase 'the foolishness of God'.

Origen appears to have been the one Church Father who gave more than passing attention to interpreting and applying the phrase 'the foolishness of God' in a theological sense. He too considered it a daring phrase. 'Had it been I,' he says, and he means in contrast to Paul,

> who used the phrase, 'the foolishness of God', how the faultfinders would have maligned me! How they would have censured me! Even though I had said a thousand things they considered good, how I would have been denounced for using the phrase, 'the foolishness of God', which they think it not proper to say. (*Hom Jr* 8.8)

One cannot say that the phrase 'the foolishness of God' was really developed into a major theological concept until the time of the Renaissance and Reformation when Erasmus of Rotterdam made it a foundation stone in his theology, and Martin Luther used it in developing his theology of the cross in the *Heidelberg Disputation*[1]. Origen appears not to have been an influence on

[1] See Luther's commentary on propositions 20 and 21 in his 'Proofs of the Thesis ...' in the *Heidelberg Disputation.*

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Luther's use of the term[2], but M.A. Screech, in his book *Erasmus. Ecstasy and The Praise of Folly*, has shown that Origen was a primary source of Erasmus' understanding of the concept[3]. What I want to consider in this brief study is how Origen understood and used this Pauline concept.

I begin with a statement by Erasmus in which he has grasped an important distinction that Origen made. Erasmus notes that when Paul says in 1 Cor. 1:25, 'the foolishness of God is wiser than men', Paul 'attributes something of folly to God'. Then he says, 'Origen subsequently objected in his commentary that we cannot really explain this folly by reference to the views held by men, as we can in the passage "The doctrine of the cross is folly to those that are perishing"'[4]. Screech thinks that 'Erasmus was attracted by Origen's interpretation of the folly of God as something quite different from the rather obvious fact that Christianity seemed daft to unbelieving Jews and Gentiles ...'[5] Erasmus' statement means that Origen sees a difference between Paul's reference to foolishness in 1 Cor. 1:18 and 1:23, where the preaching of Christ crucified is labelled 'foolishness to those who are perishing' and 'foolishness to the Gentiles' – that is, they *perceived* it to be foolishness – and in 1 Cor. 1:25, where Paul says, 'The foolishness of God is wiser than men.' If Erasmus is correct, and I think he is, we can, then, distinguish between two uses Origen makes of this phrase, the one relating to a perceptual phenomenon and the other relating to a reality. I will treat the first rather summarily in order to have more time to discuss the latter.

The Foolishness of God as a Perceptual Phenomenon

In the 'perceptual' understandings of the phrase, the judgement of 'foolishness' lies in the eye of the beholder. Origen uses the phrase in this way when he discusses the initial perception of Christ that some people have in contrast to the same person's later, more advanced perception. Origen connects this application of the phrase 'the foolishness of God' with Isaiah 53. In his *Commentary on Matthew* he speaks of the two advents of the Word in the soul. When Christ comes to the soul initially people do not perceive his true beauty. What they see is 'the apparent foolishness of preaching' (*Cels* 6.77). People

[2] H. Blaumeiser's survey of the research on Luther's theology of the cross indicates no studies which have considered Origen to have influenced Luther (*Martin Luthers Kreuzestheologie*, Konfessionskundliche und Kontroverstheologische Studien LX (Paderborn: Bonifatius, 1995)), 31-72, esp. 55-9.

[3] (Harmondsworth: Penguin Books, 1988 (first published 1980)).

[4] Erasmus, *Praise of Folly and Letter to Maarten van Dorp 1515*, tr. B. Radice (Harmondsworth: Penguin Books, 1971), 124. The passage is cited as a key to Erasmus' understanding in Screech, *Erasmus*, 18.

[5] *Erasmus*, 21.

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respond to this coming with the words of Isaiah, 'We see him, and he has no form or comeliness, but his form is dishonourable.' This form of the Word, Origen says, 'is the foolish proclamation of the Christ, when we proclaim Christ born and crucified' (1 Cor. 1:21; 2:2). The second advent, however, occurs among the perfect of whom Paul says, 'But we speak wisdom among the perfect' (1 Cor. 2:6). These perceive and praise the beauty of the Word, no longer bound to physical perception, but beholding his rational beauty (*Ser Mt* 32; *Com Mt* 12.29-30)[6]. Origen has here interiorized the earlier Christian apologetic answer to the charge that Jesus of Nazareth did not fulfil the prophecies of the powerful Messiah predicted in the Old Testament. The apologists had answered that the Messiah comes twice, first in weakness and then, a second time, in power (see Tert., *Iud* 14; Justin, *Dial* 49.2). Origen says, in effect, that Christ is first perceived as foolishness, but, if one progresses, he is then perceived as wisdom, which he truly is.

1 Cor. 1:18 and 1:23 are the focal points of this understanding of the phrase. The perceptual aspect of Origen's understanding of 1 Cor. 1:18 and 23 is quite clear in a homily on Exodus where he uses the imagery of the rod of Moses which became a serpent and devoured the serpents of the Egyptian magicians. He takes Moses' rod to be a symbol of the cross, and, because the serpent symbolizes wisdom in the bible (Gen. 3:1; Matt. 10:16), he connects this incident with Paul's discussion of the cross in 1 Corinthians 1. Blending the two passages, Origen says that once the cross of Christ, whose proclamation *appeared to be 'foolishness'*, had been 'cast forth in the earth', it then became 'such a great wisdom that it devoured all the wisdom of the Egyptians', meaning the wisdom of this world (*Hom Ex* 4.6). The understanding that the perception is false is implicit in the perceptual interpretation of the phrase 'the foolishness of God'.

The Foolishness of God as Reality

The other interpretation that Origen gives to 'the foolishness of God' focuses on 1 Cor. 1:25 and is both bolder and more profound than the previous interpretation. Screech correctly points to the eighth homily on Jeremiah as the fullest exposition of Origen's doctrine of 'the true nature of Christian folly'[7], but that is not the only place Origen treats the theme.

What Origen means when he treats 'the foolishness of God' in 1 Cor. 1:25 is that the entire work of God in the incarnation is the work of God's foolishness. In a comment on Psalm 68:6, 'O God, you know my foolishness', a text that Erasmus took as the words of Christ, Origen says, 'God does not know the

[6] For a similar approach, but with different imagery, see *Cels* 6.77.
[7] *Erasmus*, 22.

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foolishness of all, but the foolishness of the one who became a fool because of fools, and who became outside the law because of those outside the law, and who became weak because of the weak'[8]. Notice that in these comments Christ's foolishness is not a perceptual issue, but is one of 'becoming'. The participle τοῦ γενομένου, 'the one who became', is repeated three times in the statement.

In his second homily on the Song of Songs, Origen takes the 'sachet of myrrh' in Song of Songs 1:13 to mean a tiny bit or a drop (*gutta*). He applies this to the incarnate Christ, in whom a 'small drop' (*modica stilla*) of the divine power and majesty descended to our humble state[9]. 'For what was he not made for our salvation?' Origen asks.

> We were empty and he emptied himself, taking the form of a servant. We were a foolish people and not wise, and he was made the foolishness of preaching so that the foolishness of God might become wiser than men. We were weak, and the weakness of God was made stronger than men. (*Hom Ct* 2.3; PL 23, 1131B-1132A)

Here again Origen does not use the language of perception, but of becoming.

Paul's *kenosis* passage in Philippians 2 is wedded to 1 Corinthians 1:25 in this interpretation. Even where it is not explicitly cited, it is always standing in the background. In the eighth homily on Jeremiah Origen introduces these two key verses by saying, 'The Logos is about to make the daring statement that that which visited the world "emptied itself" [Phil. 2:7], that the world might be filled with its emptiness. But if that which visited the world emptied itself,' he continues, 'that emptiness itself was wisdom, "for the foolishness of God is wiser than men"' [1 Cor. 1:25].

Origen draws two sweeping conclusions from this combination of biblical texts. One is that the 'men' mentioned in 1 Cor. 1:25 whose wisdom God's foolishness surpasses is not a reference to fools, but to the wisest this world can offer. And the other is that all *Christian* wisdom, including that of Peter, Paul, and the other apostles, falls under the rubric of 'the foolishness of God'. Origen makes these statements in his comments on Jeremiah 10:14a, which says in the LXX, 'Every person has been made foolish by knowledge' (ἀπὸ γνώσεως). If this is true of every person, Origen reasons, then this statement includes Paul himself, who 'saw' very little 'in a mirror' and grasped only an infinitely small amount of what he saw. When placed alongside God's perfect knowledge, Paul's knowledge is foolishness. God does not refute the wisdom of the world with his divine wisdom, Origen argues, but 'by this frivolous foolishness of God' (*Hom Jer* 8.7-8).

[8] *Praise of Folly*, 124; *Sel Ps* 68.6 (PG 12, 1513A).

[9] Cf. G. Bostock, 'Origen's Exegesis of the Kenosis Hymn (Philippians 2:5-11)', in *Origeniana Sexta*, ed. G. Dorival and A. Le Boulluec, BETL 118 (Leuven: Leuven University Press, 1995), 544-5.

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Origen delights, however, in the Pauline phrase in 1 Cor. 1:24 that Christ is 'the wisdom of God'. When Origen discusses the *epinoiai Christou* or 'aspects of Christ', 'wisdom' is always at the head of the list. Wisdom is the most basic and most definitive of the *epinoiai Christou*. Origen argues that Christ as wisdom has existed eternally with God (*P Arch* 1.2.1-3). When Origen speaks of Christ as wisdom, he does not mean the incarnate or *kenotic* Christ, but the pre-incarnate Christ who has existed eternally with God. When one advances to the point that one knows Christ as wisdom, it is this eternal wisdom of God that one comes to know. The incarnate Christ for Origen, the Christ of Philippians 2, the Christ anticipated in Isaiah 53, is the centrepiece of 'the foolishness of God' mentioned in 1 Corinthians 1:25.

In a homily on 1 Corinthians Origen quotes 1 Corinthians 1:21, 'in the wisdom of God the world did not know God through wisdom', and says, 'The wisdom of God is in the law and the prophets.' He immediately identifies this 'wisdom' in the law and the prophets as Christ. It was because the world failed to know Christ 'in the law and the prophets', that God, Origen says, 'sent Jesus Christ who was to be crucified on behalf of the human race, that those who have believed in Jesus Christ crucified might believe in the foolishness of the proclamation' (*Cor Cat* viii, *JThSt* 9 (1908), 237.13-18; cf. *Cels* 1.13).

One application Origen makes of the concept of divine foolishness relates to the message that simple believers understand. Here his focus is on 1 Cor. 1:21, 'For since in the wisdom of God the world did not know God through wisdom, it pleased God through the foolishness of the message proclaimed to save those who believe.' In two of the three passages where Origen applies 1 Cor. 1:21 to simple believers, he uses 2 Cor. 5:16, 'Although we have known Christ according to the flesh, from now on we know him no longer in this way', as the justification for his understanding[10]. Origen understands the latter verse to mean that Christian faith begins with knowing Jesus as he is described in the Gospels, but that it should progress beyond this to a spiritual understanding of Christ. Not all, however, progress beyond that initial stage. It is to such people that Paul writes in 1 Cor. 2:2, 'I decided to know nothing else among you except Christ Jesus and him crucified.' These, Origen says, 'were not able to know Christ in so far as he is "wisdom", but only in so far as he was "crucified"' (*Hom Ex* 12.4)[11].

When he discusses 1 Cor. 1:18 Origen shows that, as in Philippians 2, incarnation and cross are inextricably bound together in his understanding of the foolishness of God. He notes that there are many Gentile stories about local crises being averted by some individual who gives himself on behalf of the people. So, he says, it is not strange that one should die to remove the plague

[10] *Com Mt* 11.17; *Hom Ex* 12.4; *Cels* 5.16.

[11] See the study by R. Roukema, 'La prédication du Christ crucifié (1 Corinthiens 2,2) selon Origène', in *Origeniana Sexta*, 523-9.

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of ignorance, darkness, and destruction from the whole world. 'But who,' he asks, 'could undertake such a task?' It would have to be a divine power who would descend from heaven and who would be able to die for all 'with a certain ignominy' so that his death might become a trophy against the devil. He compares the latter to the ancient practice of victorious generals leading their enemies in triumph. 'The cross of Christ,' he says, 'is a trophy against Satan. This is why,' Origen adds, 'Paul says, "May I", who have known what the power of the cross is, "never boast except in the cross", for I was set free from evils because he died to deliver me from death' (*Cor Cat* vi, *JThSt* 9 (1908), 235; cf. *Com Jn* 28.262ff.).

Origen recognized that the majority of believers never advanced in their understanding beyond the preaching of salvation through the death of Christ on the cross. He saw this act of God in Christ and its proclamation in preaching to be salvific. And this was true not only for simple believers, but also for those who advanced in their understanding like Origen himself. He closes his eighth homily on Jeremiah by saying,

> My Saviour and Lord has assumed all the opposites, that he might destroy the opposites by their opposites, and we might be made strong from the weakness of Jesus, and we might be made wise from the foolishness of God and, once we have been introduced by these opposites, we might be able to ascend to the wisdom and strength of God, which is Christ Jesus, to whom belongs glory and power for ever. Amen. (*Hom Jer* 8.9)

Are Origen's two understandings of 'the foolishness of God' contradictory?

One must ask if these two understandings of 'the foolishness of God' are contradictory. The answer is 'no'. The incarnation and earthly life of Christ is *perceived* as foolishness by unbelievers and, Origen would add, they are correct. But it is a divine foolishness, and such foolishness begins several notches higher than the best of human wisdom. The perception of the message of Christ as foolishness is false only if one continues to perceive it in this way. Origen's doctrine of the foolishness of God is in complete accord with his broader doctrine of the 'aspects of Christ'. One always begins with the humanity of Jesus and from this beginning advances until one hears the words of Jesus in John 8:19, 'If you know me, you also know my Father' (*Com Jn* 19.38-9).

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Origen, the Church Rhetorician: The Seventh Homily on Genesis

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Origen has been regarded in the history of Christianity as one of the most influential interpreters of the scripture. The impact his allegorical hermeneutic had upon later Christians was such that Beryl Smalley explained that 'to write a history of Origenist influence on the west would be tantamount to writing a history of western exegesis'[1]. In the past century, Origen's theory of exegesis has been a fruitful research topic among patristic scholars and various aspects and implications of his theory have been explored[2]. But their interest has generally been limited to his allegorical exegesis in preaching or commentary, but has not yet been broadened to include his use of rhetoric, another major interpretive and compositional method in his time[3].

Only recently have a few scholars begun to read Origen with a rhetorical viewpoint. Karen Torjesen attempted to read some of his Old Testament homilies according to the ancient *progymnasmatic* patterns[4]. Robert M. Berchman showed how Origen could be read through the Stoic tradition of rhetoric in which the argumentative side of rhetoric was emphasized[5]. P. O'Cleirigh explained how Origen utilized the Aristotelian *topoi* of similarities and differences to persuade his Christian audience[6]. This paper is a continuation of such

[1] Beryl Smalley, *The Study of the Bible in the Middle Ages* (Indiana: University of Notre Dame Press, 1964), 14.

[2] Authoritative works on this topic include Henri de Lubac, *Histoire et esprit: L'Intelligence des Écritures d'après Origène* (Paris: Aubier, 1950; reprint, Paris: Éditions du Cerf, 2002); idem, *Exégèse Médiévale*, vol. 1 (Paris: Aubier, 1959), 198-304; R.P.C. Hanson, *Allegory and Event: A Study of the Sources and Significance of Origen's Interpretation of Scripture* (London: SCM Press, 1959; reprint, Louisville: Westminster John Knox Press, 2002); Henri Crouzel, *Origène et la 'connaissance mystique'* (Paris: Desclée de Brouwer, 1961); Robert M. Grant, *The Earliest Lives of Jesus* (New York: Harper, 1961); Karen Jo Torjesen, *Hermeneutical Procedure and Theological Method in Origen's Exegesis*, PTS 28 (Berlin: de Gruyter, 1986).

[3] Of the authors mentioned in footnote 2, Torjesen is an exception. See her *Hermeneutical Procedure*, 12-13, and the article, 'Influence of Rhetoric on Origen's Old Testament Homilies' in *Origeniana Sexta*, ed. Gilles Dorival and Alain Le Boulluec (Leuven: Peeters, 1995), 13-25.

[4] Torjesen, 'Influence of Rhetoric', 13-25.

[5] Robert M. Berchman, *From Philo to Origen: Middle Platonism in Transition* (Chico, California: Scholars Press, 1984), 215-23.

[6] P. O'Cleirig, '*Topoi* of Invention in Origen's *Homilies*', in *Origeniana Sexta*, 277-86.

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attempts to read Origen as a rhetorical writer. It will be shown in this paper that Origen was a Church rhetorician who, standing in the tradition of philosophical rhetoric, tried to persuade his audience with his newly adapted form of a Christianized rhetoric for the Church.

I. Origen and Philosophical Rhetoric

When Crouzel commented that Origen's homilies are 'without a trace of the rhetoric of the schools' because they are basically a verse-by-verse exposition of the scripture[7], or when Lienhard said that they are 'utterly lacking in rhetorical polish'[8], their judgement reflects the general tendency to identify rhetoric with its non-philosophical, especially sophistic tradition. But as P. O'Cleirigh notes the diversity of rhetorical traditions in antiquity, there was not just one single tradition of rhetoric at that time which we suppose must have influenced Origen. As opposed to technical or sophistic rhetoric, which was characterized by the subordination of dialectic to rhetoric, there was another form of rhetoric, that is, philosophical, which was characterized by the subordination of rhetoric to dialectic or the focus on *logos*, the logical way of argumentation[9]. It is when we read Origen's homilies with this philosophical form of rhetoric in mind that Origen the rhetorician begins to appear.

The classicist George A. Kennedy confirms the validity of such an approach. In his book *Greek Rhetoric under Christian Emperors*, Kennedy describes Origen as a central figure among the Christian apologists/exegetes who 'utilized Attic language and style in order to be taken seriously by an educated audience' and 'used his trained mind in the best way he could, through the arts of definition, division, and syllogistic reasoning'[10]. Here it is significant for us to note that Origen's language and style are not Asiatic, but Attic, and that his preaching is performed based on the Aristotelian *topoi* of definition and division and syllogistic reasoning and not based on the typical flamboyant style of the Second Sophistic[11]. If philosophical rhetoric is a legitimate form of rhetoric and Origen's homilies are proved to follow that very form,

[7] H. Crouzel, *Origen*, tr. A.S. Worrall (San Francisco: Harper & Row, 1989), 29.

[8] J.T. Lienhard, 'Origen as homilist', in *Preaching in the Patristic Age*, ed. David G. Hunter (New York: Paulist Press, 1989), 45.

[9] P. O'Cleirig, '*Topoi* of Invention', 278, footnote 7. For a discussion of the triple division of rhetoric into technical, philosophical, and sophistic, see George A. Kennedy, *Classical Rhetoric and Its Christian and Secular Tradition from Ancient to Modern Times* (Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press, 1980), 3-107.

[10] George A. Kennedy, *Greek Rhetoric under Christian Emperors* (Princeton, New Jersey: Princeton University Press, 1983), 184. See also his *Classical Rhetoric*, 138.

[11] For a discussion of the Second Sophistic in the Christian era, see Kennedy, *Classical Rhetoric*, 37-40; idem, *A New History of Classical Rhetoric* (Princeton, New Jersey: Princeton University Press, 1994), 230-56.

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then Origen can be rightly called a rhetorician standing in the philosophical tradition.

In the following pages I will analyze Origen's seventh homily on Genesis according to the canons of philosophical rhetoric. Specifically, I will examine his use of various types of logical argumentation. However, this rhetorical analysis does not exclude the method of other traditions such as the technical and the sophistic for they overlap considerably with each other.

II. Origen's Seventh Homily on Genesis

From the structural point of view, this homily is typical of all his homilies: it reveals a coherent compositional pattern of introduction, a verse-by-verse type of explication, and conclusion with doxology. Comparing this homily with the standard form of a commentary, we note a considerable similarity. Like a commentary, each section of the body begins with a quotation or a paraphrase of the text, followed by various types of logical proofs, and the same pattern repeats until the homily reaches its conclusion. In addition, as in the case of a commentary, there is usually no overarching thesis for the entire homily. Each section has its own thesis to prove, and these theses do not necessarily form into a single, overarching thesis for the whole piece.

This pattern of having multiple sections and distributing scriptural verses in the form of a quotation or a paraphrase at the beginning of each section is a distinctively Christian adaptation of classical rhetoric. According to the classical theory of *dispositio*, the *narratio* usually comes after the introduction and is followed by the *partitio*. But there is another option besides the regular pattern. If the speaker judges that the straightforward narration is not appropriate for his specific audience, he can choose incidental narrations that are distributed in various sections of the speech (*Her. Rhet.* 1.8.12 (LCL 403, 22)). In Origen's case, the incidental narrations are appropriate because he must preach on scriptural verses which do not necessarily have a single thesis. So his usual practice is first to divide the text into various logical sections and then to preach on each of them one by one[12].

Now let us turn our attention to Origen's seventh homily on Genesis. Since a similar pattern repeats in each section, I will consider only the introduction and part of the first section of the body which covers Genesis 21:4-8[13].

[12] His homily on 1 Kings 28 (SC 328, 172-208; GCS Origenes 3, 283-94) is an exception. It follows the traditional pattern of *dispositio*, i.e., the pattern of introduction, narration, proof, and conclusion.

[13] The general outline for the first section of the homily is as follows (section and line numbers are those of SC 7 bis). Introduction (7.1.1-4). Section I: A. Paraphrase (7.1.5-10); B. Stasis of Quality (7.1.11-16); C. Proposition (7.1.17-20); D. Rationale (7.1.21-24); E. Opposite (7.1.24-30); F. Digression with *anticipatio* (7.1.30-34).

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Introduction (7.1.1-4). After mentioning the reading of scripture by the lector, Origen begins his sermon with invocation. He prays that the veil be removed from the heart of his audience so that it may understand the scripture properly. What is characteristic in this invocation is that he quotes Paul without mentioning his name, but with the honourable appellation 'the Apostle' (*apostolus*): *Deprecemur Dominum ne, secundum verbum Apostoli, etiam apud nos, cum legitur Moyses, velamen sit positum super cor nostrum.* For Origen, Paul is *the* authority for the interpretation of the scripture because he is a master rhetorician who can read the text allegorically and reach the divine mysteries hidden in the letter. Since Paul's authority has already attained to an established state, Origen depends on it to enhance his own credibility as a preacher – the common rhetorical strategy called *ethos* (Arist., *Rh.* 1.2.3-4 (LCL 193, 16)).

Paraphrase (7.1.5-10). After the introduction, Origen begins to preach on the text with a paraphrase: the birth of Isaac, his circumcision, and his weaning from milk. Since it is a report of the past event, he uses an indirect mode of speech, the method which is usually used by the defendant or the plaintiff in court who reports what really happened: 'For it has been read (*lectum est enim*) that Abraham begot a son, Isaac, when he was a hundred years old' (cf. Hermog., *Prog.* 2.17-19 (Rabe 4-6)).

Stasis of *Scriptum et Sententia* (7.1.11-16). Stasis is defined as 'the first conflict of the pleas arising from the answer to an accusation'. There are four kinds of stasis. To take an example of a murder case, the stasis of fact concerns whether an act is committed or not; the stasis of definition concerns whether it is a murder or not; the stasis of quality concerns whether it is justifiable or not; and the stasis of transference concerns whether the current court has jurisdiction over the case or not[14]. The stasis of *scriptum et sententia* belongs to the stasis of quality. It concerns whether the literal meaning is equal to the original intention of the lawmaker or the text should be read in a different way so that the original intention may be obtained otherwise (*Her. Rhet.* 1.11.19 (LCL 403, 34-6)).

After paraphrasing the text, Origen raises questions by using the interrogative mode of speech. According to Hermogenes, it is usually used in the cross-questioning to reshape the 'fact' so that it may become useful to the interrogator's side (*Prog.* 2.19 (Rabe 6)). Origen asks, Is it probable for the Holy Spirit to inspire the biblical text simply to narrate a story? Or is there something 'divine' (*divinum*) and 'worthy' (*dignum*) in this story? By asking such questions, Origen positions himself before engaging his imaginary enemies. What is at stake is the relation between *scriptum* and *sententia*, a traditional stasis of quality. Based on that stasis, Origen develops his answer for the audience:

[14] M.L. Clarke, *Rhetoric at Rome: A Historical Survey*, rev. with a new introduction, D.H. Berry (London and New York: Routledge, 1996), 26. See also Cic., *Inv. Rhet.* 1.8.10 (LCL 386, 20); *Her. Rhet.* 1.18 (LCL 403, 18).

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they should not be prisoners at the level of what is written, but be free persons who rise up to the level where they focus on the intention (*propositum*) of the original writer of the text.

What is remarkable in the above discussion of the stasis of *scriptum et sententia* is that Origen depends on two Christian 'final headings', the divine and the worthy. Late Hellenistic rhetoric teachers mentioned the importance of the so-called *capitula finalia* or τελικὰ κεφάλαια (Hermog., *Prog.* 6.34 (Rabe 14); *Stat.* 3.26 (Spengel 149)). Those headings represent central values that a given society takes for granted as its foundation, such as justice, honour, utility, custom, and so on. So when an argument is based on those final headings, the audience is persuaded: the audience accepts the argument because it accepts the values. But for Origen, who is a Christian teacher, there is a different set of values to be emphasized for his Christian audience, of which the divine/spiritual and the worthy are prominent[15].

As far as the final heading of *divinum* is concerned, Origen believes that every letter of the scripture contains the *divine* meaning because it is the result of the divine inspiration. So its interpreter should be spiritual enough to read it correctly. The final heading of *dignum* is equally important. It is one of the most fundamental criteria when deciding on whether an interpretation is right or not: any interpretation is right when it deals with divine figures in a worthy manner (*PArch* 4.2.9 (SC 268, 334-41; GCS 22, 321-3)). So if one understands that Sara was so obsessed with jealousy that she caused Agar to be expelled, it is not a right interpretation, because Sara is not to be thought of in such an unworthy manner. What is interesting is that this concept of worthiness echoes in the Graeco-Roman virtue of justice. According to Aristotle, justice (δικαιοσύνη) is 'a virtue which assigns to each man his due in conformity with the law' (*Rh.* 1.9.7 (LCL 193, 90-3, tr. John Henry Freese)). Likewise for Origen, *dignum* is a Christian virtue which assigns to every person in the scriptures his or her due in conformity with the divine law. So if one attributes jealousy to Sara, it is not giving her what is due: it is unworthy and unjust at the same time.

III. Conclusion

I have shown in this paper how Origen employed the method of philosophical rhetoric to persuade his Christian audience. Rather than appealing to the

[15] The two Christian final headings which Origen uses in his homilies on Genesis are as follows (the numbers inside the parentheses are page numbers of SC 7 bis): the spiritual/allegorical/mystical (1.2 (28-34); 1.12 (54-6); 2.5 (98-106); 4.2 (148-50); 5.2 (166-8); 5.5 (174-80); 6.1 (182-6); 7.2 (196-202); 7.6 (208-10); 8.1.1-9 (212); 9.1 (236-42); 10.1 (254-8); 11.1 (276-80); 13.2 (312-8); 15.1 (350-2); 15.7 (368-70); 16.4 (382-4)); the worthy (1.2.49 (30); 2.1.106 (84); 3.4.16-31 (124); 3.5.6, 48 (126, 130); 3.6.75-83 (138); 4.5.14 (154); 4.6.33-39, 55-63 (160); 9.2.27-30 (244); 11.2.7-18 (280-2); 13.1.35-40 (312); 15.5.1-4 (364); 16.2.16-35 (376)).

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emotion of his audience with a dramatic style, he appealed to its logical mind. But his use of such rhetoric was not uncreative. He adapted it to suit the need of his Christian church. So while his contemporary rhetors found authoritative texts in Homer or Virgil, Origen found them in the scripture, especially in Paul. Instead of using the traditional form of *narratio*, Origen used incidental narrations to follow the flow of the biblical text. Among traditional final topics, he emphasized two, the divine and the worthy, for they are the most important principles of his allegorical hermeneutic. He also relied on the use of the stasis of *scriptum et sententia* to (re)interpret the scripture so that he might draw a most appropriate Christian meaning out of the text.

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The Restoration of the Elect: Clement of Alexandria's Doctrine of *Apokatastasis*

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Both Origen and Gregory of Nyssa were indebted to Clement for their doctrines of restoration[1], believing that God's purgative fire is one of chastisement or correction rather than one of punishment as retaliation for evil[2]. This is a pronounced aspect of Clement's doctrine of universal salvation and hinges on the tension between an individual soul's freedom to refuse the chastisements of God, over and against God's capacity to save all things. Beyond this issue, however, little attention has been given by scholars to the prominent aspect of Clement's doctrine which did not appear to have been transmitted to Origen or Gregory – namely, the idea of the restoration of the elect. Clement never refers to the restoration of all things as mentioned in Acts 3:21[3], rather his doctrine revolves around his treatment of an elect group of Christians – what he calls true gnostics.

Clement believed that the gnostic elect constitute what Matthew referred to as 'peacemakers'. They are the exemplars of peace in the world who will be 'restored in adoption (εἰς υἱοθεσίαν ἀποκατασταθήσονται)'[4], having come to the knowledge that the opposites of creation and all that wars against the disposition of the mind are actually under the Providence of God and in beautiful harmony. He says that the elect are 'made eternal by knowledge', 'restored into perfection (εἰς τελειότητα ἀποκαθιστάμενοι)', and rising to the 'nature of angels' to be 'restored on the summit (ἐν τῇ ἄκρᾳ ἀποκαταστάσει)'[5]. The summit here refers to the eighth grade, or ogdoad, that sits at the top of the 'mystic grades of advancement (τὰς προκοπὰς τὰς μυστικὰς)' of the church[6], where knowledge 'restores (ἀποκαταστήσῃ) the

[1] A. Harnack, *Lehrbuch der Dogmengeschichte*, 3rd edn, 3 vols (Freiburg, 1894-97), vol. 1, 645-6; J. Tixeront, *Histoire des dogmes*, 3 vols (Paris, 1905-1912), vol. 1, 277, 304-5.

[2] Origen, *De Princ.* 3.6.6, who works chiefly from 1 Cor 15:28 and Gregory, *Or. Cat.* 26.72. Cf. Clement, *Str.* 7.16.102.4-5.

[3] See A. Méhat, '"Apocatastase" Origène, Clément d'Alexandrie, *Act.* 3.21', *VC* 10 (1956), 196-214.

[4] *Str.* 4.6.40.2.

[5] *Ecl.* 57.1-5. See Jean Daniélou, *A History of Early Christian Doctrine Before the Council of Nicaea*, vol. 2, *Gospel Message and Hellenistic Culture*, tr. John Austin Baker (London, 1973), p. 460.

[6] For the 'grades of the church (κατὰ τὴν ἐκκλησίαν προκοπαί)', see *Str.* 6.13.106.1-107.3. On Clement's use of the ancient philosophical term προκοπή, see Judith L. Kovacs, 'Divine

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pure in heart to the crowning place of rest (ἀναπαύσεως)'[7]. Elsewhere, Clement refers to this as a 'restoration in everlasting contemplation (τῇ θεωρίᾳ τῇ ἀιδίῳ ἀποκατάστασις)' where gnostics are 'called by the name of gods (θεοὶ)'[8]. These phrases all refer to Clement's gnostics who, on receiving perfection by knowledge, are considered 'gods going about in a body of flesh'[9].

For Clement, gnostics were of the highest value to the church, chosen from the elect race of Christians[10]. He was therefore assured of the gnostic's role in the church and in the unity of faith as a universal body that works together towards edification of and restoration in Christ. After quoting Ephesians 4:11-13 he writes:

> [W]e are then to strive to reach manhood as befits the gnostic, and to be as perfect as we can while staying behind in the flesh (ἐν σαρκὶ καταμένοντας), hence making it our study out of perfect unity of mind to concur with the will of God, into the restoration (ἀποκατάστασιν) of the truly perfect nobility and kinship, into 'the fullness of Christ'[11].

Clement believed that Christians should strive for manhood in a way that befits the perfect man, the gnostic who has attained such perfection as is possible in a human being while still in the flesh[12]. The unity of faith is dependent on the role of the gnostic as an exemplar of Christ's perfection[13], and in this way is restored to the fullness of Christ. In this sense the gnostic was not merely peripheral to faith for Clement, but actually its core and the goal at which it should aim[14].

Pedagogy and the Gnostic Teacher According to Clement of Alexandria', *JECS* 9/1 (2001), 3-25, p. 10.

[7] *Str.* 7.10.56.7-57.2. Cf. Gregory of Nyssa, *Hom. Opif.* 17 PG 44, 189.21-25.

[8] *Str.* 7.10.56.6. Clement refers to this by the contradictory words 'endless end' (τὲλος ἀτελεύτητον), because there cannot exist any completion of one's contemplation of God (*Str.* 7.10.56.2-3; *Str.* 2.22.134.1-3).

[9] *Str.* 7.16.101.4.

[10] The church was created when, from the Greeks and the barbarians, there arose the peculiar race of Christians, who were 'the elect race (τὸ γένος τὸ ἐκλεκτόν)', according to Clement (*Protr.* 4.59.3; see also *Str.* 5.14.98.4). But from the elect it is the gnostics who are regarded as being of highest value to it (*Str.* 7.5.29.4). They therefore constitute the 'elect of the elect (τῶν ἐκλεκτῶν ἐκλεκτότεροι)' (*Str.* 6.13.107.2; see also *Q.D.S.* 36.1; *Str.* 1.19.92.4; *Str.* 5.3.17.5, citing Matt. 20:16). See D. Kimber Buell, 'Race and Universalism in Early Christianity', *JECS* 10/4 (2002), 429-68.

[11] *Str.* 4.21.132.1-2.

[12] The perfect man is genderless, yet still referred to as 'man'. See *Str.* 6.12.100.3: 'For souls, themselves by themselves, are equal. Souls are neither male (ἄρρενες) nor female (θήλειαι), when they no longer marry or are given in marriage. And is not woman translated into man (καὶ μὴ τι οὕτως μετατίθεται εἰς τὸν ἄνδρα ἡ γυνή), when she has become equally unfeminine (ἀθήλυντος), and manly (ἀνδρικὴ), and perfect?' Clement appears to follow the heretical Gnostic view here: cf. *Exc.* 21.1-22.2; 79-80.1.

[13] See *Str.* 4.16.100.6-101.1 citing 1, Tim. 4:12.

[14] See *Str.* 4.16.100.2 and *Str.* 6.13.106.1-2.

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The gnostic was crucial to the restoration of the whole community of the faithful. 'Though ... only one in number', Clement writes, the gnostic 'is honoured equally with the people. For being a part of the people, he becomes the complementary of it, being restored (ἀποκατασταθείς) from what he was; and the whole is summoned from the part (καλεῖται δὲ καὶ ἐκ μέρους τὸ πᾶν)'[15]. Clement makes it clear that the gnostic, though only one person, is of equal value with the whole people, believing that the gnostic achieves something that is of universal value through the search for knowledge. As Clement tells us, 'man, composed of body and soul, is a universe in miniature (τὸν σμικρὸν κόσμον)'[16], but it is only the gnostic who has come to fulfil this potential as a reality[17].

The notion that the gnostic is the elect of the elect and the agent through whom the whole is restored is powerfully represented in the treatise, *Quis Dives Salvetur?* Though not mentioning the *apokatastasis* directly, he writes,

> All the faithful, then, are good and godlike (θεοπρεπεῖς), and worthy of the name by which they are encircled as with a crown. There are some, however, the elect of the elect (τῶν ἐκλεκτῶν ἐκλεκτότεροι) ... distinguished by drawing themselves out of the surge of the world, like ships to the beach, and bringing themselves to safety ... whom the Word calls 'the light of the world', and 'the salt of the earth'[18]. This is the seed (σπέρμα), the image and likeness of God and His true son and heir, sent here as it were on a sojourn ... and all things are held together so long as the seed remains here; and when it is gathered (συναχθέντος), all these things shall very quickly be dissolved (λυθήσεται)[19].

This passage speaks of the elect of the elect as being capable of drawing themselves out of the world. Yet they are also the 'salt of the earth' and 'the light of the world', which, as Matthew 5:15 tells us, should, like a lamp, be put on a stand to light the whole house. The light metaphor, however, then changes to that of a seed, which is in the image and likeness and the 'true son and heir' of God with Christ. Notice that the plural ἐκλεκτότεροι becomes the singular σπέρμα. The elect come together and are united in one with Christ. This seed sojourns on the earth as Christ, but during its time here maintains the creative work of God, without which all things would dissolve. Once the seed is gathered the world will cease to be.

This idea is further confirmed by the discussion concerning the words of Salome in the little known *Gospel According to the Egyptians*, in the third book of the *Stromateis*. Clement is arguing against the heretical view that the

[15] *Str.* 2.19.98.2.

[16] *Protr.* 1.5.3.

[17] Philosophically speaking, this micro/macrocosmic transformation takes place when knowing a thing is to become that thing, where epistemology and ontology are one and the same thing. To know the universal is to be the universal.

[18] Matt. 5:13-14.

[19] *Q.D.S.* 36.1-3. Cf. Matt. 24:31/Mk. 13:27. See also Justin, *1Apol.* 28.2-3.

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works of the female are to be considered evil because they bring with them desire, birth and death:

> They say that the Saviour himself said, 'I came to destroy the works of the female', meaning by 'female', desire, and 'works', birth and death. What then would they say? Has this destruction in fact been accomplished? They could not say so, for the world continues exactly as before. Yet the Lord did not lie. For in truth he did destroy the works of desire, love of money, contentiousness, vanity, mad lust for women, pederasty, gluttony, licentiousness, and similar vices. Their birth is the soul's death, since then we are 'dead in sins'[20] ... Birth and death chiefly involved in the creation must necessarily continue until the achievement of complete separation and the restoration of the elect (ἀποκαταστάσεως ἐκλογῆς), on whose account even the beings mingled with the world are restored to the proper condition[21].

This is the most crucial passage concerning Clement's doctrine of *apokatastasis*. It stipulates that when Christ claimed that he had come to destroy the works of desire, he did not lie. However, since the world continues as it did before this would suggest otherwise. The list of sins he mentions still take place, yet since the coming of Christ, the perpetrators of the sins are, in some sense, dead. This is evidenced by the passage from Ephesians that claims that to give birth to sins is to be dead in them, not bodily, but psychically[22]. In other words, the life of sin is a form of death, but despite this the world seemingly continues as it always did. Something significant occurred with the coming of Christ. It had caused a kind of cosmic inversion whereby the life of sin appears merely as the semblance of life, and is really a form of death. Life appears to continue and will do so until such time as the restoration of the elect, that is, when the seed is gathered and the world undergoes dissolution.

The gnostic's role as a maintainer of the creation is also, therefore, a soteriological one. The gnostic is forced to make the ultimate choice whether to remain with Christ or to return to the world as a saving principle. Picking up the thread of the discussion concerning the role of the female in bringing life and death to the world, Clement writes,

> In fact the woman who first began transgression was named 'life'[23] because she became responsible for the succession of those who were born and fell into sin, the mother of righteous and unrighteous alike, since each one of us makes himself either righteous or disobedient. On this account I for my part do not think the apostle was expressing disgust at life in the flesh when he said, 'But with all boldness both now and ever Christ shall be magnified in my body, whether by life or by death. For to me to live is Christ and to die is gain. If, however, it is to be life in the flesh, that also means for me fruitful work. I do not know which I prefer. I am constrained on both

[20] Eph. 2:5.

[21] *Str.* 3.9.63.1-4.

[22] The death of the soul is mentioned immediately following the passage just quoted, at *Str.* 3.9.64.1.

[23] An allusion to Eve in Gen. 3:20, whose name in Hebrew means 'life-giving'.

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sides: I have a desire to depart and to be with Christ, which is far better; but to abide in the flesh is more needful for your sakes'[24]. Here he showed clearly, I think, that the perfect reason for departing from the body is love of God, and that if one is to be present in the flesh (ἐν σαρκὶ παρουσίας) one should give thanks (εὐχάριστον) remaining here for the sake of those who need salvation[25].

The course of life and death, and of life in the flesh, is not meant to be denigrated, but exonerated, and, as Paul's testimony exemplifies, is accepted as a thanksgiving by Clement's gnostic. The passage from Philippians expresses Paul's confusion as to which direction he should head – towards death in order to live in Christ, or towards life in order to be a living example to others in their search for salvation. He knows that to be with Christ would be better, and that death is simply another way of magnifying Christ, but his preference is to stay with those who need him. For this reason Clement's gnostic remains present in the flesh, giving thanks to God. Having gone through this preparation, the gnostic lives in complete detachment from the world, 'though still detained on earth', as Clement says elsewhere[26], living as though 'already without flesh (ἀσάρκος) and already grown holy without this earth'[27]. That is, liberation of the soul.

The gnostic is the subject of an underlying paradox, but one that is of the utmost importance to Clement. While the life of knowledge is the practice of death as it had been for Socrates, this does not mean that the gnostic denies life in the world, nor does it mean that the world is an evil place. Quite the contrary, it is crucial that the gnostic attempts to depart from this world in order to exist in it without being fettered by earthly passions – that is, to have it all the more[28]. It is only in this detached position that the gnostic sanctifies the world as a thanksgiving by being 'present in the flesh' and an image of the living presence of Christ in the world. For Clement this was Christ's *parousia*, the Wisdom that constituted the essence of *gnosis*, communicated through the apostles and which Clement believed was to be continued through the 'gnostic tradition (γνωστικὴ παράδοσις)'[29]. There was no existential angst in the delay of the *parousia* of Christ for Clement, since Christ had provided the perfect example of living life in accordance with the true philosophy by which the Christian philosopher could live his/her life. The gnostic life was evidence of Christ's ever-living presence in the world.

The gnostic life is esoteric by the very fact that few are capable of understanding the truth of things. For Clement this meant that the search for truth be

[24] Phil. 1:20-24.
[25] *Str.* 3.9.65.1-66.1. Cf. *Str.* 7.7.35.1.
[26] *Str.* 7.12.80.2.
[27] *Str.* 7.14.86.7. See also *Str.* 4.3.12.5-6, citing Gal. 6:14/Phil. 3:20. Cf. Plato, *Rep.* 618c-619a.
[28] *Str.* 6.9.75.3.
[29] *Str.* 6.7.61.1. See also *Str.* 6.9.71.1; *Str.* 5.10.64.4-6; *Str.* 7.7.47.4.

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accorded the highest respect, and that the people who seek for knowledge are to be considered indispensable to the Christian community. The esoteric life is the medium through which universal adherence to the Word of God could be accomplished, since the whole is summoned from the part. This can be usefully summed up in the paradoxical phrase, esoteric universalism. Clement wanted to ensure that the Christian community maintained its gnostic tradition by continuing to initiate its elect souls into the mysteries of God. If such a tradition were to be broken, the result for Clement, would be catastrophic for the world – the absence of Christ's presence within it, and also therefore for the beings mingled with it.

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Constructing a Narrative Universe: Origen's Homily I on Genesis

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A narrative implies a world – a linguistic universe within which this story can take place. This may not be apparent when narrative presupposes a world which is presumed to be known already. The question is more interesting with narratives which imply a 'what if?' What if the world were, in some way, not as we suppose it to be?[1] Origen's homilies imply a narrative universe significantly different from that which much of his own culture might presuppose[2]. In his first homily on Genesis, Origen outlined the construction of such a universe[3]. This homily establishes the linguistic context implied by his interpretation of the narratives of the patriarchs and of the Exodus.

Origen maintains that the deep structure of this universe is 'in Christ'. This establishes a connection among the layers of the worlds, and within Origen's threefold interpretation of scripture. 'In the Beginning' God created the heavens and the earth[4]. Origen took this to be a statement regarding origin and

[1] Recent useful studies of the homiletical use of narrative include Charles Rice, *Interpretation and Imagination: The Preacher and Contemporary Literature* (Philadelphia, 1970), and Fred Craddock, *As One Without Authority: Essays on Inductive Preaching* (Nashville, 1979). See also Walter Brueggemann, *Texts under Negotiation: The Bible and Postmodern Imagination* (Minneapolis, 1993), and *Biblical Perspectives on Evangelism: Living in a Three-Storied Universe* (Nashville, 1993). A provocative and helpful essay regarding how a text of fiction can 'make sense' in different ways when the known world is not taken as 'given' is Samuel R. Delany, 'Science Fiction and "Literature" – or, The Conscience of the King', in *Visions of Wonder*, ed. David G. Hartwell and Milton T. Wolf (New York, 1996), pp. 446-57.

[2] This divergence of expectations is vividly illustrated in Origen's *Contra Celsum* (PG 11, 641-1632). *Contra Celsum* is translated by Henry Chadwick, *Origen: Contra Celsum* (Cambridge, 1953). See, for example, Celsus' comfortable contempt for a philosophy of laundry workers in *Contra Celsum* III.55 (PG 11, 993-4), and, directly related to the argument of this paper, the sharp contrast in the conclusions of Origen and Celsus regarding the possibility of spiritual renewal, in *Contra Celsum* III.66-69 (PG 11, 1005-12). See also Torjesen's useful comments regarding Origen's 'transposition of ... rhetorical techniques from Hellenistic civic culture to Christian religious culture', in Karen Jo Torjesen, 'Influence of Rhetoric on Origen's Old Testament Homilies', in *Origeniana Sexta, Origene et la bible/Origen and the Bible*, ed. Gilles Dorival and Alain le Boulluec (Leuven, 1995), pp. 22-4.

[3] Origen, *In Genesim Homilia* I (PG 12, 145-61). The homilies have been translated by Ronald A. Heine in Origen, *Homilies on Genesis and Exodus*, FC 71 (Washington, D.C., 1982).

[4] Origen, *In Genesim Homilia* I.1 (PG 12, 145C).

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source, rather than mere sequence in time; 'in the Savior', in Jesus the Word, all things were made. This claim is elaborated in *First Principles*[5]: Christ is the image of God, 'in whom' all things were created, the Wisdom of God in which is every power and form of 'the creation that was to be'. 'All things that were made, were made by and in Christ'[6]. In *this* sort of universe, it is not arbitrary to see the story of Christ played out in many narratives on every level of creation. The course of Israel's history, the structure of the scripture, the shape of each Christian's life, are all formed 'in the Beginning' according to the pattern known to us in Christ.

There is no other authentic form for the story of faith or for any human story than the narrative of the Saviour. The 'inner man' is made and restored 'in' the Image of God[7]; and that Image is Christ[8]. Those who come to him are renewed daily, in a process of transformation by which the 'image of the devil' is erased and their original 'likeness' is restored by the one who made it[9]. The origin of creation in Christ makes stories of renewal plausible within this linguistic universe.

Stories of renewal also presuppose the possibility of significant change[10]. The ethic proposed by Origen is not a static obedience to a code, but is a continuing journey of transformation. It is an Exodus, out of darkness and toward the light of God[11].

Origen described a universe in which change, movement, and desire are essential elements; 'change and decay' are not parallels in his vocabulary. Consider Origen's treatment in his first homily of 'vegetation having seed'. Origen understands this 'seed' to refer to 'bodily affections', and maintains that these are not simply negative; these desires have in them the potential for thoughts and actions. These desires can serve justice and restrain sin, nurturing rational being, or they can feed the 'serpents' of irrational rage[12]. In either case they contain 'seed': things come from them. Desires can become the source, in our hearts, of future fruits[13]. Likewise male and female, which Origen interprets as

[5] Origen, *Peri Archon* I.2.2 and II.6.1-2 (ed. Paul Koetschau, Origenes Werke, 5 (Leipzig, 1913), pp. 30, 140-1). See also the useful discussion of Khaled Anatolios, 'Christ, Scripture and the Christian Story of Meaning', *Gregorianum* 78.1 (1997): 59-61.

[6] Origen, *Peri Archon* II.9.4 (GCS, p. 167, lines 17-18).

[7] Origen, *In Genesim, Homilia* I.13 (PG 12, 155C-D, 157A-B).

[8] *Ibid.*, I.13 (PG 12, 156C-D).

[9] *Ibid.*, I.13 (PG 12, 157C-D).

[10] Origen took issue with the popular philosophizing of Celsus, who argued against the likelihood of significant moral change. Origen argued that, on the contrary, for the Logos this is 'not only not impossible, but is not even very difficult'. Origen, *Contra Celsum* III.66 and III.69 (PG 11, 1005-6 and P.G. 11.1009-10).

[11] Allan E. Johnson, 'Allegorical Narrative and Evangelism: "Three Days' Journey" in Origen's Homilies on Exodus', *SP* XXXVI (2001) 440-444.

[12] Origen, *In Genesim Homilia* I.17 (PG 12, 159B-160A).

[13] *Ibid.*, I.4 (PG 12, 149D).

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spirit and soul, are created for a concord in which they can 'increase and multiply', producing good inclinations and useful thoughts[14] as the mind exercises dominion over impulses, inclinations, thoughts, and the body's desires[15]. This increase, this movement toward transformation, is blessed by God[16] and sustained by the origin and structuring of all creation in Christ. 'Seek the things that are above, where Christ is'[17].

This is reflected in his treatment of creation in *First Principles*. 'It is certain that no living thing can be idle and motionless – all seek to *act* ... Much more therefore is it necessary to a rational being – that is, human nature – to move and to act'[18]. Rational beings are subject to change; change makes sin possible[19], but also allows for a goal, the 'restitution of all things'[20]. Origen insists that the world cannot be static or cyclical[21]; because rational beings have wills, significant movement is possible. It is a universe of desire and movement, not as mere chaos, but as that which creates the potential for transformation. 'Thus, therefore, a way seems to be opened for the progress of the saints from that earth to those heavens'[22], a continuing journey even beyond earth through the heavenly places, 'growing at each stage'[23]. The narrative universe constructed in Origen's first homily on Genesis is one in which this journey of the Exodus can be told.

The journey of transformation moves within a threefold structuring of creation, reflected in Origen's threefold exegesis. Origen notes that while most things come into being by the command of God, at three points it is said 'God made'[24]. These three aspects of creation are therefore of unusual importance. The first is heaven and earth, the physical reality to which the letter of the scripture corresponds. The second is the 'two great lights', which Origen reads as 'Christ and the church', the spiritual focus of interpretation. And the third is humanity, whose immediate concern is the soul, the needs of which are addressed in moral interpretation. These three worlds are united in one perfect universe in Christ, whose own true domain is far more substantial than either earthly forms or human thoughts[25].

The triple cosmos is structured around boundaries and opportunities for movement. The firmament divides the heavenly 'waters above' from the

[14] *Ibid.*, I.15 (PG 12, 158 C-D).
[15] *Ibid.*, I.12 and I.16 (PG 12, 155A and 159A-B).
[16] *Ibid.*, I.14 (PG. 12, 158A-B).
[17] *Ibid.*, I.2 (PG 12, 148A-B).
[18] Origen, *Peri Archon* II.11.1 (GCS, p. 183.13-17).
[19] *Ibid.*, II.9.1 (GCS, p. 165.17-24).
[20] *Ibid.*, II.9.5 (GCS, p. 120.19).
[21] *Ibid.*, II.3.4 (GCS, p. 119.13-15); see also Origen, *Contra Celsum* IV.67-68 (PG 11, 1135-8).
[22] Origen, *Peri Archon* II.3.7 (GCS, p. 126.14-15).
[23] *Ibid.*, II.11.7 (GCS, p. 191.20).
[24] Origen, *In Genesim Homilia* I.12 (PG 12, 155A-C).
[25] Origen, *Peri Archon* II.3.6 (GCS, pp. 121-4).

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'waters of the abyss'[26], the place of the devil[27]. That firmament is also 'man in a body', if the rational being is able to discern and divide the higher from the lower waters, by applying the mind to heavenly things[28]. 'Man in a body' exists in a 'boundary condition', fertile with possibilities, placed on an edge between earth and heaven. On this borderline between potentials it is possible to use the things of earthly creation as stages on the way of a heavenly journey[29].

Human identity is analogous to the structures of this material creation, since both are formed 'in the Beginning'. In the creation of the firmament and the possibilities it borders, Origen finds the basis for a journey of transformation by which 'man in a body' becomes 'heavenly man'[30]. Earth and the soul are a setting for narratives of change.

In a divided creation, good and evil dispositions can be distinguished. Within the waters, moving things arise, impulses and thoughts of mind and heart – birds exploring heavenly things, and also the 'creeping creatures' of evil thoughts. A mind rightly directed on its journey discerns them both by God's enlightenment[31]. All are to be disclosed, brought into the sight of God[32]. As the waters of thought and impulse are divided, 'dry land' appears, 'deeds done in the flesh'[33]. In the flesh, in itself, no good dwells[34]; but when these actions and desires are made to appear and to come to the light of God, it becomes possible for them to bear fruit. Then God's Word renames the dry land 'earth'[35].

This act of distinguishing, of becoming 'firmament', is the foundation of later narratives. Origen sees a 'dividing of the waters'[36] in Joseph's flight from the seductive wife of his Egyptian owner, leaving earthly garments behind, and in the Isaac and Jacob narratives[37]. Origen also finds it at the root of the Exodus narrative; the 'fruitful earth' which arises after the watery 'thoughts of demons' have been separated away is itself led forth

[26] Origen, *In Genesim Homilia* I.2 (PG 12, 148A).

[27] *Ibid.*, I.1 (PG 12, 146C).

[28] *Ibid.*, I.2 (PG 12, 147-8).

[29] *Ibid.*, I.2 (PG 12, 147B-C); see also Origen *In Exodum Homilia* V.2-3 (PG 12, 325D-329A); *In Exodum Homilia* VII.1-3 (PG 12, 341A-343D); and Origen, *In Numeros Homilia* II (PG 12, 590A-B).

[30] Origen, *In Genesim Homilia* I.2 (PG 12, 147B-C).

[31] *Ibid.*, I.8 (PG 12, 152B-D). In this treatment of change and the 'motions of the soul', Origen's language is similar to that of the later Platonists; see Macrobius, *In Somnium Scipionis Expositio* XVI.25; tr. William Harris Stahl, *Macrobius: Commentary on the Dream of Scipio* (New York, 1952), p. 243.

[32] Origen, *In Genesim Homilia* I.9 (PG 12, 153A-B).

[33] *Ibid.*, I.2 (PG 12, 148B).

[34] *Ibid.*, I.11 (PG 12, 154C).

[35] *Ibid.*, I.2 (PG 12, 148C).

[36] *Ibid.*, I.8, (PG 12, 152D).

[37] *Ibid.*, I.3, (PG 12, 149B-C).

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by God into 'another earth', a land flowing with milk and honey[38]. Along the journey, the faithful may 'prepare such food' from these things that the Word and the Son of God may be received 'in the inn of our hearts'[39]. Thus those in whom Christ dwells ascend toward the truer heaven of God's throne[40].

The centre and source of all layers of creation is Christ, the 'greater light', the light of the world; and that light is reflected in the Church[41]. The 'lesser lights' – the teaching of the Church, the patriarchs[42], the apostles sent forth by Christ to gather a faithful people[43] – shine with the light of Christ. These greater and lesser lights illuminate rational beings whose dividing 'firmament' of the mind can be described as 'heaven', because their movement and desire are directed toward God's throne – 'the things that are above, where Christ is'[44]. Because the whole 'perfect world' is constructed 'in the Beginning', in Christ, even those things which seem to be against the faithful are declared by God to be 'good for them'[45], since overcoming them is part of the choosing and acting which are the soul's motion. This triple cosmos, formed in Christ, is a place of journeys. It provides the way of changes and the motivating force for significant change. Waters, earth, and the throne of God form the passages of transformation.

Scripture marks the stages of that journey[46]. At each station of the way, appropriate 'seeds' lure us forward and bring forth useful thoughts, until at last the sowing of Christ comes to a harvest in the faithful[47]. The interpretive framework developed in *First Principles* is not a static system. It is a path of transformation in which each will find the world of scripture to be the road on which faith's journey moves. The simple are taught by the 'body' of the Word, but those who 'have made a little progress' come to the soul; as Torjesen has pointed out, Origen makes familiar rhetorical structures[48] into the stuff of a Christian homily in which 'the presence of the Logos is invoked and the process of salvation is engaged'[49]. Even the 'perfect' do not come to a static perfection, but to a 'spiritual law' which is 'a shadow of the good things to come'[50]. The scriptures – in which we see Christ the Word, this

[38] *Ibid.*, I.2, (PG 12, 149A-B); see also *Peri Archon* II.3.6 and *In Psalm. Hom.* II.4.
[39] Origen, *In Genesim Homilia* I.17 (PG 12, 160D-161A).
[40] *Ibid.*, I.13 (PG 12, 156A-B).
[41] *Ibid.*, I.5 (PG 12, 149B-C).
[42] *Ibid.*, I.7 (PG 12, 151B).
[43] Origen, *Peri Archon* II.6.1(GCS, p. 140.20-4).
[44] Origen, *In Genesim Homilia* I.2 (PG 12, 148A-B).
[45] *Ibid.*, I.10 (PG 12, 153C).
[46] *Ibid.*, I.7 (PG 12, 151D-152A).
[47] *Ibid.*, I.4 (PG 12, 149D).
[48] Torjesen, pp. 24-5.
[49] *Ibid.*, p. 14.
[50] Origen, *Peri Archon* IV.2.4 (GCS, p. 312.1-313.4).

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'immense visible world', and 'the lesser world, that is, humanity'[51] – are a narrative universe in which stories of transformation can be told.

The narrative universe described by Origen is one of fruitful and directed change. It is neither static nor cyclical, but is a place of choices and significant movement, a setting for journeys of transformation. Meaning and will are not external to such a universe, nor an arbitrary imposition upon its stories; the only final meaning of all things is always Christ.

[51] Origen, *In Genesim Homilia* I.11 (PG 154D).

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The Use of Anti-Epicurean Polemics in Origen (Fr. *In Gen. Comm.* (= Eusebius, *P. e.* VII.20) and *De princ.* II.1.4)

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In this paper I intend to show how Origen defends the idea that matter was created by God. In the course of the discussion I will draw special attention to his polemical strategy. My paper is intended to show that Origen's argument has to be understood against the background of anti-Epicurean polemics of the Hellenistic period and the Early Roman Empire.

I shall analyse two texts in which Origen argues against the idea of ungenerated matter. The first stems from Origen's *Commentary on Genesis*[1] and addresses Christian philosophers who stand in a tradition that maintains the eternity of matter, as Hermogenes, for example, had done[2]. The second is taken from Origen's *On First Principles*[3] and argues against Platonists and others in general[4].

In both texts Origen opposes philosophers who acknowledge the existence of a divine creator and his providential care for the world, but at the same time hold to the idea of ungenerated and eternal matter[5]. Origen is astonished, as he says in *On First Principles*,

> how such men can find fault with those who deny that God is the Maker of this universe or that he providentially cares for it, and can charge them with impiety ... when they themselves are guilty of a like impiety in saying that matter is ungenerated and co-eternal with the uncreated God[6].

This passage clearly reveals Origen's strategy: he turns his opponents' criticism of Epicurean philosophy back on themselves. This strategy owes its polemical power to a widespread consensus which existed among otherwise divergent philosophical schools in the Hellenistic period and in the Early

[1] Cf. Eusebius, *P. e.* VII.20.1-9 (GCS Eusebius 8.1, pp. 402-3 Mras).

[2] Cf. 20.9 (403,16*f.* Mras) and Tertullian, *Adv. Herm.* 27-28.

[3] *De princ.* II.1.4 (GCS 22, pp. 109-1 Koetschau).

[4] Cf. *De princ.* II.1.4 (110,13-17 Koetschau) and the doxographic summary in Chalcidius, *In Tim. Comm.* §§280*f.*

[5] Cf. Origen, *In Gen. Comm.*, in Eusebius, *P. e.* VII.20.2 (402,13 Mras); 20,9 (403,16*f.* Mras); and Origen, *De princ.* II.1.4 (110,13-17 Koetschau).

[6] *De princ.* II.1.4 (110,13-17 Koetschau); tr. G.W. Butterworth, *Origen on first principles* (London, 1936), 79.

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Roman Empire. Almost everyone agreed that an Epicurean cosmology which denies divine providence has to lead to indifference towards the gods and atheism[7]. The pejorative description of the School of the Garden is, in fact, so omnipresent that it can be used in philosophical arguments as a polemical means even against acknowledged anti-Epicureans. Thereby, it aims at decrying the teachings of the opponent by comparing or equating them with Epicurean thought[8]. Origen is obviously using a polemical method that seems to be common in the debates among philosophical schools of his time.

In *On First Principles* and in the *Commentary on Genesis* Origen seeks to substantiate the accusation of Epicurean impiety in detail. He does so by arguing, first, that the assumption of ungenerated matter implies an Epicurean conception of god; second, that this assumption regards matter as the active and sufficient principle of generation; and third, that it thereby renders the existence of a divine creator superfluous and denies the teleological arrangement of the world. I would like to give some explanation of these three aspects of Origen's argumentation.

1. The assumption of ungenerated matter implies an Epicurean conception of god. In his *Commentary on Genesis* Origen addresses those who hold to the idea of ungenerated matter. He wonders whether one has to assume that it was by good fortune that God discovered the ungenerated matter ready for being acted upon. On the other hand, he continues, God would surely not have been able to execute a single work if the ungenerated matter had not been available to him. God thus would have remained without being creator, father, benefactor, good, or any of the other predicates which one reasonably attributes to him[9]. In Origen's view, lastly, the assumption of ungenerated matter leads to the consequence that one has to deny God's activity and all the predicates which point to his providential care for man and the world.

It is now interesting to see that eliminating these predicates is in accordance with Epicurus' theology and with his depiction of the gods, as it is summarised, for example, in his *Cardinal Doctrines*[10]. This conception of god, however, is violently criticised by the Stoics and Platonists[11], who refer to – in

[7] E. is regarded as an atheist who did not confess his attitude in public (e.g., Cicero, *De nat. deo.* I.85; cf. also *De nat. deo.* I.63; Sextus Empiricus, *Adv. dogm.* III.58). E. destroys religion (Cicero, *De nat. deo.* I.121; Plutarch, *Non posse* 1001bc). His conception of the gods abolishes their existence and keeps it only nominally (Poseidonius, in Cicero, *De nat. deo.* I.123*f.*). In general, E. is charged with godlessness because he denies divine providence (cf., e.g., Plutarch, *Non posse* 1001bc; *Ad Col.* 1119e; and in popular literature, Lucian, *Alex.* 25).

[8] Plutarch, for one, uses this strategy against the Stoics; see, e.g., *De comm. not.* 1082e; *De stoic.* 1033c, 1034c, 1050c.

[9] *In Gen. Comm.*, in Eusebius, *P. e.* VII.20.3 (402,16-20 Mras).

[10] Cf. Diogenes Laertius, *Vit.* X.139; the depiction of the gods by Epicurus (Diogenes Laertius, *Vit.* X.123) or by the Epicurean speaker Velleius (Cicero, *De nat. deo.* I.51*f.*); and the Epicurean caricature of the Platonic god in Cicero, *De nat. deo.* I.54.

[11] Plutarch argues against Epicurus' first *Cardinal Doctrine*, e.g., in *Non posse* 1001b, 1002e, 1003a and c-d.

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their words – the 'common conception of god' and unanimously describe god's nature as active, humane, and beneficent[12]. Therefore they regard the Epicurean denial of these predicates as evidence that the Epicureans neither name nor believe in god as god and thus are guilty of godlessness[13]. In the *Commentary on Genesis* Origen deliberately refers to this debate and attributes Epicurean godlessness to the advocates of ungenerated matter.

In *On First Principles* Origen argues in a similar way: if matter, ungenerated and available by chance, had not existed, god would have been idle, *otiosus*. The term *otiosus* translates ἀργός and acts as a signal for two polemical associations. First, in anti-Epicurean polemics *otiosus* refers to the Epicurean conception of the gods as dwelling in a blissful state of peace which the human soul also strives for[14]. The anti-Epicureans, however, who regard virtue as activity and blissfulness as being beneficent[15], use the term as a caricature of the Epicurean gods as being physically and mentally lazy and totally devoid of energy[16]. Origen picks up this signal word and thus insinuates that the assumption of ungenerated matter implies an Epicurean conception of god. Second, used in a Stoic or Platonic context, *otiosus* or ἀργός occurs as a predicate of passive matter[17]. By calling god *otiosus* Origen is obviously putting in his opponents' mouths a term as an attribute of god which they normally apply to matter. Thus, he reproaches them within their own framework for confusing god and the material principle when accepting a passive Epicurean god as a consequence of their idea of ungenerated matter.

2. *The assumption of ungenerated matter regards matter as the active and sufficient principle of generation.* In the *Commentary on Genesis*[18] Origen argues that if one presupposes an ungenerated matter, then God's creation would not differ at all from that which would come into existence spontaneously by itself and whose principal cause would already rest within matter[19].

[12] Plutarch, for example, summarises the consensus among Stoics and Platonists e.g. in *De stoic.* 1051d-f; *De comm. not.* 1075e.

[13] Cf. Plutarch, *Ad Col.* 1119e.

[14] In his essay *De otio*, Seneca looks critically at the Epicurean concept of *otium* and interprets it in a Stoic manner. He points to the Epicurean origin of the concept in *De otio* I.4; *ep.* 68.10.

[15] Cf. the two different definitions of μακάριος reported by Sextus Empiricus (*Pyrr.* III.5). The Academics criticise the Epicurean concept of virtue (Cicero, *De nat. deo.* I.111). According to Seneca, *voluptas* lies in being beneficent (*Ben.* IV.13), and *otium* as a desirable end always includes activity (*De otio* V.5*ff.*; *ep.* 56.6). Therefore, he rejects the Epicurean concept of *otium* (*epp.* 68.2., 73,2.9).

[16] Cf. the polemical paraphrase of the Epicurean *otium* in Seneca, *Ben.* IV.13 and the caricature of the Epicurean gods in Cicero, *De nat. deo.* I.67 and 102.

[17] In Chalcidius, *In Tim. Comm.* §278 (p. 282*f.* Waszink) *otiosus* is the Latin translation of ἀργός in the Symmachus translation of Gen. 1:2 (cf. Gen. 1:2 in Origen's *Hexapla* (p. 8 Field)) and applied to matter. Plutarch similarly uses ἀργός in *De stoic. rep.* 1054a; *De an. procr.* 1015a.

[18] At the end of *De princ.* II.1.4 he arrives at the same conclusion.

[19] Origen, *In Gen. Comm.*, in Eusebius, *P. e.* VII.20.6*f.* (403,2-7 Mras).

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This polemical conclusion has to be understood against the background of the Aristotelian classification of generation processes. According to this classification, one cannot find any effective and final cause in spontaneous or fortuitous generations; only the material principle is at the basis of these processes[20]. Origen takes up this classification and claims that from the assumption of ungenerated matter it consequently follows that the world is in fact generated as αὐτόματον solely from matter. Thereby, he is using a terminology that had already been established in polemics against atomistic and Epicurean cosmologies[21]. Thus, he polemically maintains that the advocates of ungenerated matter hold to an atomistic – Epicurean cosmology which renders god's providence as the final principal of the world's generation superfluous[22].

3. The assumption of ungenerated matter is in conflict with the teleological arrangement of the world. In the *Commentary on Genesis* Origen claims that it is foolish to say that the world, which is so skilfully arranged, was generated without a wise architect[23]. In this passage he is pointing to a standard argument that is used against Epicurus and his followers by those who defend a teleological cosmology. The argument infers the activity of a rational divine cause of the world based upon the world's regular and perfect constitution[24]. According to the argument, those who deny divine government display their lack of sensibility to the world's beauty[25]. Alluding to this argument Origen first of all recalls the anti-Epicurean consensus, which he and his opponents unanimously share. He then, from this very consensus, draws the conclusion that it is necessary to similarly establish a teleological relation between matter and the god who governs the world. With this argumentation Origen first reproaches

[20] Cf. Aristotle, *Met.* 7.9 1034ab. The Commentary on Aristotle's *Metaphysics* by Michael of Ephesus explains the generation ἀπὸ ταὐτομάτου as generation μηδενὸς κινοῦντος (*In Met. Comm.* CAG 1, p. 498, 5*f.* Hayduck). It regards matter (ὕλη) as ὡς ἡ ἀρχὴ καὶ αἰτία of generations ἀπὸ ταὐτομάτου (*In Met. Comm.* 498,8*f.* Hayduck). For its relation to Alexander of Aphrodisias' commentary, cf. P. Moraux, *Der Aristotelismus bei den Griechen*, 3, *Alexander von Aphrodisias*, ed. J. Wiesner (Berlin, 2001), 423*f.*

[21] Cf. Simplicius on Democritus (*In Phys. Comm.*, CAG 9, p. 327,23 Diels) and Aristotle's paraphrase of an atomistic cosmology (*Phys.* 2.4 196a24). Simplicius sees the concept of generation ἐκ ταὐτομάτου in opposition to a teleological concept of nature. He attributes it to the early natural philosophers, who claim ὑλικὴν ἀνάγκην αἰτίαν εἶναι τῶν γινομένων, and among the later philosophers to the Epicureans (cf. *In Phys. Comm.* 371,27-372,14 Diels).

[22] Origen draws this polemical conclusion in *In Gen. Comm.*, in Eusebius, *P. e.* VII.20.7 (403,7-9 Mras).

[23] Origen, *In Gen. Comm.*, in Eusebius, *P. e.* VII.20.8 (403,9-13 Mras).

[24] Aristotle (*Phys.* 2.4 196a28-196b4) and Simplicius (*In Phys. Comm.* 332,4*ff.* Diels) infer the divine causes of the heavenly movements from their regularity. Cf. Stoic cosmological proofs of the existence of the gods reported by Sextus Empiricus (*Adv. dogm.* III.111-114; 60, 75-122 discuss proofs ἀπὸ τῆς τοῦ περιέχοντος διακοσμήσεως or ἐκ τῆς κοσμικῆς διατάξεως). The Stoic speaker Balbus describes the beauty of the world which cannot be generated *fortuitane* (Cicero, *De nat. deo.* II.4, 15, 85*f.* 87-90, 91*f.* 98-114). Epicurus' opponents jeer at his cosmology (cf. Cicero, *Fin.* I.20; *De nat. deo.* II.93, 115).

[25] Cf. Cicero, *De nat. deo.* II.90, 97.

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those who hold to the idea of ungenerated matter for being in conflict with their own cardinal doctrines. He also insinuates that they thus participate in the foolishness and dullness of the Epicureans.

Origen is thinking along the same lines in *On First Principles*. Here he doubts that a matter discovered by chance might have been sufficient for creating a work as eminent as the world and for god's tremendous power[26]. Here again he first uses the world's constitution as an argument. But he then draws attention to god and his power. The assumption of ungenerated matter seems to him not only to be typical of people who do not have any sensibility for the world's perfection, but above all to be characteristic of people who do not have any idea about god's power and intelligence. At this stage Origen does not argue cosmologically as do most of the pagan critics of an Epicurean cosmology. He argues theologically. Thus, he reformulates his accusation of Epicureanism with which he charges the advocates of ungenerated matter. Their godlessness lies in the fact that they underestimate god's power. This perspective can also be found in the *Commentary on Genesis*, where Origen dwells in some detail upon god's intentional will and power[27].

If one evaluates Origen's use of anti-Epicurean polemics, one can detect a shift of accent when compared with pagan criticism of an Epicurean cosmology. The pagan advocates of a teleological conception of the world claim that an atomistic – Epicurean cosmology makes it impossible to appreciate the orderly constitution of the world. For Platonists and Stoics the world's character as an intelligent divine being is put at risk if its generation formally corresponds to the generation of the lowest classes of creatures[28]. For a Christian philosopher like Origen, it is above all god's power and divinity that is put at risk if one abandons the teleological arrangement of the world that has to include the creation of its underlying matter. Thus, the question of the nature of matter is becoming a central theological issue.

In conclusion, Origen charges those who hold to the idea of ungenerated matter with Epicurean godlessness. Thereby, he uses a polemical means that was common in the philosophical debates of his time. The way Origen defends the concept of created matter can be understood as a defence of a teleological conception of the world. Nevertheless, it stands out because it not only argues cosmologically, but also regards the subject as intimately linked with god's will and power.

[26] Origen, *De princ.* II.1.4 (110,22-111,1 Koetschau).

[27] Cf. Origen, *In Gen. Comm.*, in Eusebius, *P. e.* VII.20.1, 9, and the emphasis on ἡ σοφία καὶ θειότης αὐτοῦ at the beginning of the paragraph, *P. e.* VII.20.7 (403,6 Mras).

[28] For the lowest classes of creatures, which come into existence solely from matter, see Aristotle, *Hist. An.* 1.1 487b5; *Met.* 7.9; Alexander of Aphrodisias, *Comm. in Met. ap. Asclepium, Met.* 408,5-7; *Comm. in Met. ap. Aver. fr.* 10 (Freudenthal).

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Clement of Alexandria and Valentinian Exegesis in the *Excerpts from Theodotus*

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I. Introduction

Clement of Alexandria's *Excerpts fromTheodotus* is well known to students of Gnosticism as an important source for the teachings of followers of Valentinus. In the manuscript it bears the longer title 'Excerpts from the Works of Theodotus and from the So-Called "Oriental" School from the period of Valentinus'. Apparently the 'Oriental School' is a reference to the area centred in Alexandria[1], but there is doubt about whether the title is original[2]. In his edition in Sources Chrétiennes, Sagnard divides the work into four parts: (1) 1-28; (2) 29-43.1; (3) 43.2-65; (4) 66-86[3]. The third part parallels closely a section of Irenaeus' report on Valentinian teaching in *Against the Heresies* 1.1.4.5-7.5, and it is generally assumed that Clement took this section from the same source used by Irenaeus[4]. Sagnard suggests that the other three sections all come from the otherwise unknown Theodotus mentioned in the title[5], to whom Clement gives explicit credit five times[6]. It is also possible, as Markschies has suggested, that the work comes from several different Valentinian sources[7].

[1] On the distinction of two Valentinian schools, see Hippolutus, *Ref.* 6.35.5-7 and Tertullian, *De Carn.* 15, and discussion in J.-D. Kaestli, 'Valentinisme italien et Valentinisme oriental: leurs divergences à propos de la nature du corps de Jesus', in *The Rediscovery of Gnosticism*, ed. B. Layton, 2 vols (Leiden, 1980), 1, 391-403.

[2] See C. Markschies, 'Valentinian Gnosticism: Toward the Anatomy of a School', in *The Nag Hammadi Library after Fifty Years*, ed. J.D. Turner and A. McGuire (Leiden, 1997), 401-38, here 433-5.

[3] F. Sagnard, ed., Clément d'Alexandrie, *Extraits de Théodote*, SC 23 (Paris, 1970).

[4] O. Dibelius, 'Studien zur Geschichte der Valentinianer', *ZNW* 9 (1908), 230-47; cf. Sagnard, *Extraits*, 28.

[5] Sagnard, *Extraits*, 28-49, emphasizes the general coherence of all four Valentinian sections. He rejects (p. 29) the argument of R.P. Casey, *The Excerpta ex Theodoto of Clement of Alexandria* (London, 1934), 8, that *Exc.* 6-7 is not from Theodotus.

[6] *Exc.* 22.7; 26.1; 30.1; 32.2; 35.1. Sagnard, *Extraits*, 5-6, argues that this Theodotus is not to be identified with either of the two figures of that name mentioned by Hippolytus (*Ref.* 7.35 and 7.36).

[7] 'Valentinian Gnosticism', 434.

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This paper is not concerned with source analysis or what the *Excerpts* teaches us about the history of the Valentinian school, but rather with what it reveals about Clement's own theology and exegesis. I will focus especially on the first of the work's four parts, where the quotations from Valentinians are punctuated by comments that Sagnard and others have attributed to Clement. Before turning to these comments, I shall consider briefly two more general questions. (1) What kind of writing is the *Excerpts from Theodotus*? (2) What are the main themes in the Valentinian material Clement has chosen to include?

II. The Genre and General Content of the *Excerpts from Theodotus*

There have been various understandings of the character of the *Excerpts* and how this work relates to Clement's other writings. Zahn suggested that it is part of the lost eighth book of the *Stromateis*[8], while von Harnack thought it was a preparation for books that Clement never completed, which friends of Clement published after his death[9]. Nautin argued that the work consists of excerpts from a lost work, probably his exegetical *Hypotyposes*[10].

In an article entitled 'Valentinian Gnosticism: Toward the Anatomy of a School', Markschies considers the work's literary genre. The title, he points out, suggests the genre called *epitomé*[11], that is a collection excerpted from other works, which is well documented among both Christians and pagans, but Markschies thinks the work's genre is better described as a 'fragmentary counter-commentary'[12]. This expresses well the great importance of biblical exegesis in the *Excerpts*, but also useful is Casey's description of the work's genre as an 'author's notebook'[13]. Here Clement has collected texts from followers of Valentinus and added some of his own responses. There are several points in the *Stromateis* where Clement either alludes to, or adapts, specific ideas and terms found in the *Excerpts*[14]; this suggests that the collection was made in preparation for that work.

[8] T. Zahn, *Supplementum Clementinum*, Forschungen zur Geschichte des neutestamentlichen Kanons 3 (Erlangen, 1884), 93-103; 119-21, cited from Markschies, 'Valentinian Gnosticism', 434.

[9] A. von Harnack, *Geschichte der altchristlichen Literatur*, 2nd edn (Leipzig, [1904] 1958), II/2, 17-18. Von Harnack is following H. von Arnim, *De Octavo Clementis Stromateorum Libro* (Rostock, 1894).

[10] P. Nautin, 'La fin des Stromates et les Hypotyposes de Clément d'Alexandrie', *VC* 30 (1976) 268-302.

[11] See I. Opelt, 'Epitomé', *RACh* 5 (1962), 944-73.

[12] 'Valentinian Gnosticism', 434.

[13] Casey, vii.

[14] See, e.g., the allusion to *Exc.* 32 in *Str.* 4.12.90.2.

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Casey says that this 'author's notebook' is almost without parallel among works that have survived from antiquity[15], although two other works attributed to Clement, the *Prophetic Eclogues*[16] and the so-called Eighth Book of Clement's *Stromateis* offer possible parallels[17]. It is intriguing to speculate on who might have preserved this exegetical notebook and for what reason – do we have here indirect evidence of Clement's school-activity? Whoever is responsible, we can be grateful that it has survived through the centuries, for it provides an inside glimpse of the genesis of certain points of Clement's theology.

The main themes of the Valentinian portions of the *Excerpts* include the unfolding of the godhead (that is, the divine 'fullness' or *pleroma*), the origins, nature, and present plight of the human being, salvation through the divine Saviour, baptism, and eschatology. Most of these themes are reflected in one way or another in all four sections[18]. Speaking generally, the treatment of them is similar to that of other Valentinian texts, though there are particular features, for example the special emphasis in part four on spiritual powers and fate. As in other Valentinian texts, the origins of this world are traced back to the fall of part of the godhead, Sophia or Wisdom, who becomes subject to an irrational passion[19]. Sagnard has identified as the most central point the account of the 'spiritual seed', the elect offspring of this heavenly Sophia, and its salvation[20].

III. The Parts of the *Excerpts* attributed to Clement

What most interests Clement in these Valentinian texts appears to be the teaching about salvation. This includes their understanding of who Christ is and how he saves, as well as anthropology, especially the division of the human being into three parts, body, soul, and spirit, which have different origins and different final ends. Clement's particular interest in Christology and

[15] Casey, vii.

[16] Various suggestions have been made about the genre of the *Prophetic Eclogues*, see C. Nardi, ed., Clemente Alessandrino, *Estratti Profetici* (Florence, 1985), 9-12. Nardi assumes that the work is a rough draft for a planned work, which, like Clement's *Hypotyposes*, would consist of comments on scripture.

[17] On the genre of *Stromateis* 8, see Nautin, 'La Fin'; C. de Wedel, *Symbola ad Clementis Alexandrini stromatorum librum VIII interpretandum* (Dissertatio inanguralis, Weimar, 1905, discussed in L. Rizzerio, 'Foi, Gnosis, Dialectique, Logique: notes à propos de *Stromates* VIII de Clément d'Alexandria, *SP* XXXI (1997), 522-9.

[18] See the summary presentation of themes from the different parts in Sagnard, *Extraits*, 28-9 and 34-47.

[19] See *Exc.* 31.2; 67.4.

[20] *Extraits*, 48; also F. Sagnard, *La gnose valentinienne et le témoignage de St. Irénée* (Paris, 1947), 387-415.

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soteriology is evident both in his selection of Valentinian texts and in his own comments[21]. He comments on many themes, including faith, spiritual progress (*prokope*), the vision of God, and the hierarchy of spiritual powers. The sections that consider Christology (*Exc.* 4-5, 7-8, 13, and 19-20) are of interest as some of the earliest reflections on important christological passages from the New Testament, such as Matt 17, John 1, and Col 1. Clement ponders questions such as how the Logos of John 1:1 relates to the 'only Son' of John 1:18, and to the incarnate One of John 1:14. He emphasizes the 'constant identity' of the divine Logos, who is omnipresent and constantly working (*Exc.* 7.3-4).

This short essay cannot explore in detail all these themes, but will focus on one image, the 'body of Christ'(*Exc.* 1.3; 13.1; 17.2-3; 27; 33.2). The 'body' is a *leitmotif* running through many of the Clementine sections of the *Excerpts*. In *Exc.* 10-15 Clement discusses the 'bodies' of spiritual beings. In *Exc.* 27 he speaks of the 'body' of the soul, which is put off when the purified soul ascends to the spiritual world. These comments on 'bodies' have surprised and puzzled interpreters. Bousset thought that *Exc.* 6-20 and 27 reflected a materialistic view closer to Stoic philosophy than to what Clement teaches in the *Stromateis*[22]. To account for this difference, he argued that these parts of the *Excerpts*, along with a section of Clement's *Prophetic Eclogues* (43-64), do not express his own Platonic views, but rather those of his teacher Pantainos[23]. While this theory of a Pantainos-source has been discounted by later interpreters[24], Clement's comments on 'bodies' remain puzzling[25]. Why is he so interested in the term *soma*? And why does he use it in speaking about spiritual beings and about the human soul? I would suggest that a primary motivation is an exegetical one, and that one important source for Clement's reflections is far removed from Stoic materialism. This is Saint Paul's image of the 'church' as the 'body of Christ'. Clement's surprising comments on 'bodies', are, at least in part, a response to this image and to the tradition of exegesis it inspired. The rest of this paper will discuss how the image is used in New Testament texts and in the Valentinian and Clementine sections of the *Excerpts*.

[21] I follow the source analysis of Sagnard, *Extraits*, in attributing the following sections to Clement: *Exc.* 1.3; 4-5; 7.3-4; 8-9; 10-15; 17.2-4; 18-20; 23.4-5; 27; 31.1b; 33.2.

[22] See, e.g., *Strom.* 5. 71.1-4 and 7.35.5-37, discussed in Casey, *Excerpta*, 14-15.

[23] W. Bousset, *Jüdisch-christlicher Schulbetrieb in Alexandria und Rom*, Forsch. zur Relig. u. Lit. d. Alten u. Neuen Test. 6 (Göttingen, 1915).

[24] See discussion in Casey, *Excerpta* 10-16, and Sagnard, *Extraits*, 12-21.

[25] See, e.g., Casey, *Excerpta*, 15.

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IV. The Church as the Body of Christ

A. The Body of Christ in 1 Corinthians, Colossians, and Ephesians

In his first letter to the Corinthians, chapter 12, Saint Paul uses a striking image to address the problem of squabbling within the fledgling Christian community in Corinth:

> For just as the body is one and has many members, and all the members of the body, though many, are one body, so it is with Christ. For in the one Spirit we were all baptized into one body – Jews or Greeks, slaves or free. (1 Cor 12:12-13).

Paul's focus here, and in Rom 12:4-5 where he repeats this image, is on the church in the present time. He uses the image of the body to speak of the *ekklesia* as a corporate reality, and to encourage the Corinthians to realize their interdependence. Just as eyes and hands and feet need each other to function, so it is in the church. Strong and weak Christians, talented and ordinary ones, all have their role to play in the body of Christ, and they rise or fall together.

The image Paul conceived to address a practical issue was to reverberate, as we see first in the Deutero-Pauline letters of Colossians and Ephesians, which explore implications for both Christology and ecclesiology. Here the focus is extended beyond the present situation of the church into the past and into the future. We see this already in the hymn in Col 1:15-20, which emphasizes Christ's pre-existence and claims that the *pleroma* – the 'fullness'of divinity – dwelt in him. An element of hierarchy is introduced by the explicit identification of Christ as the 'head', which is given two interpretations. First, it refers to Christ as the beginning (*arche*, 1:18); he is not only the 'first-born' of the dead (1:18; cf. the 'first fruits' in 1 Cor 15:20) but also the 'first born of all creation' (1:15). 'All things were created in him' (1:16). Secondly, he is 'head' over all things in the sense that he is superior to everything, especially to superhuman spiritual powers (1:16), as is made clear in Col 2:9-10. This is connected with Christ's death; it is through his cross that Christ, the divine 'head' reconciles all things to God the Father (1:20).

If Col 1 extends the image in the direction of protology, Ephesians extends it in an eschatological direction. The 'body of Christ' is a *leitmotif* throughout this letter, mentioned in every chapter and used to describe the church in both present and future. It first appears in Eph 1:20-23, where Christ is described as the 'head' of the body, and his superiority to every 'ruler and authority' is emphasized. In Eph 2:13-16 there is an echo of 1 Cor 12 in the celebration of the unity of Jew and Gentile: by his cross and in his 'flesh' Christ has already brought the enmity of Jew and Gentile to an end and reconciled both to God 'in one body'. In chapter 5 the image is used to make a moral point: women should be obedient to their husbands, even as the church is obedient to Christ her 'head' (5:22-33). In Eph 1:23 Christ's body, the church, is described as his *pleroma* or fullness. The eschatological dimension is clearest in 4:13, which

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speaks of the perfecting of this 'body of Christ', 'until all of us come to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the Son of God, to a perfect man, to the measure of the fullness of Christ'. While the perfection of the 'body' is a future goal, even now Christians enjoy heavenly blessings (1:3). For, as Eph 1:4-5 says, they are God's elect people, set apart even 'before the foundation of the world' (cf. 1:9-11).

B. The 'Body of Christ' in the Valentinian Sections of the Excerpts

There are several passages in the *Excerpts* which show that Valentinian exegetes pondered these texts from Colossians and Ephesians and developed Paul's image in new ways. The very first excerpt speaks of the 'body' in which the Saviour became visible on earth:

> 'Father', he says, 'into your hands I commend my Spirit' [Luke 23:46]. Sophia, he [Theodotus] says, put forth the spiritual seed as a body for the Logos. The Saviour put on this body and descended. Therefore in his passion he entrusts Sophia to the Father, in order to receive her back from the Father and so that he not be detained here by those who have the power to rob him. Thus he entrusts all the spiritual seed, the elect, by the aforementioned saying.

The passage begins abruptly and is puzzling. While we need to be careful not to harmonize all Valentinian texts[26], Sagnard seems to be correct in explaining this by reference to Valentinian texts that speak of the celestial origins, the descent to earth, and the salvation of the spiritual elect, a pattern exemplified in the story of Sophia (see *Exc.* 30.2-31.2; Irenaeus, *Adv. haer.* 1.2.-1.7.5). Clement's excerpt begins *in medias res*, with an interpretation of a line from the Gospel passion narrative, where Jesus says from the cross, 'Into thy hands I commend my spirit' (Luke 23.:46). The Valentinian exegete identifies the Spirit of Luke's text with Sophia, and he interprets the verse to refer to the Saviour's entrusting Sophia to the Father and, with her, the spiritual seed, so that he can receive her back from the Father after he escapes from the hostile powers – apparently the archons who rule the spheres of heaven[27]. The second and third sentences describe the prologue to this act, the Saviour's descent to earth, for which Sophia devised a special spiritual body consisting of the spiritual seed, that is, the sparks of divinity found in the Valentinian elect.

A later excerpt makes it clearer that such ideas involve an interpretation of a New Testament image:

> The visible aspect of Jesus is Sophia and the church of the superior seeds, which he put on through the flesh, as Theodotus says. But the invisible aspect is the Name, which is the Only Son [John 1:18]. Thus when he says 'I am the Door' (John 10:7) he means

[26] On this point see the writings of C. Markschies on Valentinian Gnosticism, e.g., 'New Research on Ptolemaeus Gnosticus', *ZAC* 4 (2000), 225-54, especially 252-53.

[27] See Sagnard, *Extraits*, 55 n. 4.

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this: 'you who are of the superior seed will come up to the boundary where I am'. And when he enters the *pleroma* the seed will enter along with him when it has been collected and brought in through the Door. (*Exc.* 26.1-2)

The phrase 'visible aspect of Jesus' points to the 'body of Christ'. As in 1 Corinthians, Colossians, and Ephesians, this 'body' is equated with the church, but here the term *ekklesia* is understood to mean not Christians in general, but rather the assembly of the Valentinian elect, the 'superior seeds'. The 'body of Christ' is also equated with Sophia, presumably the fallen divine figure. Like *Exc.* 1.1-2, this text speaks of both the Saviour's descent and his ascent (cf. Eph 4:10). The *ekklesia* of the elect is the 'body' of Christ not only *after* his death and resurrection, as in 1 Cor 12, but also at the time of his descent to earth. In order to become visible in this world the divine Saviour puts on the spiritual *ekklesia* 'through the *flesh*'. Christ's taking on a spiritual body means that the spiritual elect are saved through his mission. The text also suggests, but does not explain, that the superior seed have a role to play in the accomplishment of salvation, for without this spiritual body the Saviour cannot appear.

Three other Valentinian excerpts reflect a similar theme. In *Exc* 42.2-3 Christ is called the 'head', and as in Col 1:20-22 and Eph 2:13-16, this 'headship' is linked to the cross. While Christ is the 'head' of the body, Jesus is the 'shoulders', who by the cross leads the elect 'seeds' into the *pleroma*. The body of Jesus which Christ lifts up is described as 'consubstantial' with the church. This section of the *Excerpts* begins in 43.2 with a description of the Saviour who is sent out from the *pleroma* to help Sophia and her offspring: he is the 'head of all things' [Col 1:16], who both descended and ascended' (cf. Eph 4:8-10).

A similar idea is expressed in *Exc.* 58.2, also from the third section, which, like the parallel account in Irenaeus, makes a distinction (not found in the other parts of the *Excerpts*) between *psychikoi*, or ordinary Christians, and *pneumatikoi*, the spiritual Valentinians. This text describes the appearance of the 'Great Champion' who 'assumes' the 'church', both the 'elect'and the 'called' (a contrast probably based on Matt 20:16: 'Many are called, but few are elect'). He saves and raises up the elements he puts on, and through them, what is 'of the same substance'. Unlike *Exc.* 1.1, this text assumes that the Saviour's body is not entirely spiritual, but also has a soullike (*psychikos*) component.

C. Clement's Reflections on the Church as the 'Body of Christ'

Several passages in the parts of the *Excerpts* attributed to Clement indicate that Valentinian exegesis has stimulated him to ponder the meaning of the scriptural words 'church', 'elect', 'body', and 'flesh'. In some of these texts Clement makes explicit reference to the church as the 'body of Christ'. I want

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to suggest that the image informs the other passages as well. Clement's reflections address two basic questions. (1) *Who* is the body, that is, the *ekklesia*? (2) *How* is the church the body of Christ?

In the first text, *Exc.* 1.3, Clement's responds to the first Valentinian excerpt discussed earlier, where the 'spiritual seed', also called 'the elect', is identified as the 'body' of the Saviour:

> We say that the elect seed is a 'spark' [Wisd 3:7] kindled by the Logos, and the 'pupil of the eye' [Deut 32:10], and a 'grain of mustard seed' [Matt 13:31], and leaven which unites into faith the races that seem to be divided.

Accepting the Valentinian idea of an elect group, Clement cites several scriptural images that refer to this 'elect seed'. The phrase 'which unites into faith the races that seem to be divided' is puzzling. It is closely paralleled in a description of 'the spiritual seed' in the next Valentinian excerpt (2.3): 'This seed unites the things that seem to be divided, viz. the soul and the flesh'. But Clement's reference to uniting the races 'into faith' also suggests a verse from one of the New Testament descriptions of the 'body of Christ', Eph 4:12-13: 'for building up the body of Christ, until all of us come to the *unity of the faith*... to a perfect man, to the measure of the full stature of Christ'[28].

In *Exc.* 1.3 it is not clear whether Clement understands the adjective 'elect' to refer to the church as a whole or to a select group within the church. Later, in *Exc.* 4.1, he uses 'elect race' from 1 Pet 2:9 to describe the church, but in *Exc.* 9 he contrasts the *eklektoi* ('the elect') with the *kletoi* ('the called') and cites different New Testament passages that refer to each group. This recalls the Valentinian use of these terms from Matt 20:16 in *Exc.* 58.1 (discussed above), but Clement has his own idea of what scripture means by *eklektos*: 'All', he says, 'are called equally', but the 'elect' are those who have greater faith.

The 'elect' are mentioned in several other of Clement's comments (*Exc.* 5.5; 11.1; 13.5). One of these is *Exc.* 13.1-5, found in the middle of the discussion of the 'bodies' of spiritual beings (*Exc.* 10-15). Drawing on what Paul says in 1 Cor 15 about 'spiritual bodies' and different degrees of glory (*Exc.* 11.2; 14.2; 15.1), Clement argues that the term 'body' has another sense beyond the obvious one of the human body of flesh; it can also mean the 'shape' or 'form' of spiritual beings. In the heavenly hierarchy, from angels through archangels and first-created angels up to the divine Son, the 'bodies' of spiritual beings become more and more pure (*Exc.* 12.1-2). In *Exc.* 12.3 Clement adduces several titles given to the divine Son in the New Testament, including 'light unapproachable' from 1 Tim 6:16 and 'power of God' (*dunamis theou*) in 1 Cor 1:24.

In *Exc.* 13 he then turns to another text, John 6, where Jesus first calls himself the 'bread from heaven' and then speaks of the 'bread' he *gives* – which he then equates with his 'flesh':

[28] Cf. Eph 2:13-16.

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This is the heavenly bread [John 6:31] and the spiritual food which gives life, both through food and through knowledge, 'the light of men' [John 1:4], that is, of the church. Those who ate the bread from heaven died, but he who eats 'the true Bread' of the Spirit will not die [John 6:49-50]. The 'living Bread', given to those who wish to eat by the Father – this is the Son. 'The bread which I will give', Jesus says, 'is my flesh' [John 6:51]. This means either that [bread] by which the flesh is nourished through the Eucharist, or – a better interpretation – 'flesh' means his body which is the church [Col 1:25; Eph 5:23], 'heavenly bread' [John 6:31], a blessed assembly. And perhaps this is because the elect are of the same 'substance' (*ousia*) by virtue of their state of subjection (*kata to hupokeimenon*) and because they will obtain the same end.

To Clement the term *sarx* in John 6 suggests the Pauline image of the church as the 'body of Christ', for which he proceeds to give a tentative explanation. The words *ousia* and *kata to hupokeimenon* are hard to interpret. *Ousia* recalls the term *homoousios* in the Valentinian *Exc.* 42.3: 'Therefore he [Christ] lifted up the body of Jesus, which is *consubstantial* with the church' (cf. *Exc.* 58.2). Both the Valentinian author and Clement claim that the church, as the 'body of Christ', shares his *ousia*, and Clement seems to be playing with the Valentinian formulation as he develops his own interpretation. Sagnard glosses *ousia* in this text as 'spiritual substance', and explains the phrase *to hupokeimenon* to mean 'filiation' or 'being a son'– a interpretation based partly on comparison of Clement's comments in *Exc.* 19.5 and 33.2, where the same verb is used[29]. In *Exc.* 13.5 the phrase seems to means that the 'elect' become Christ's 'body' when they are obedient to him, and to God the Father. Clement then suggests another reason why the 'elect' can be called Christ's 'body': because they will 'obtain the same end' – presumbly the eschatological end of perfection and ascent to God the Father.

Two other passages give clear evidence that Clement is responding to Valentinian exegesis. The Valentinian exegete he quotes in *Exc.* 17.1 had explained the image of the church as the 'body of Christ' by taking up the Stoic expression for one of several kinds of mixtures 'a complete blending of bodies'[30]: 'Jesus and the church and Sophia are a complete and powerful blending of bodies, according to the Valentinians'. In *Exc.* 17.2-3 Clement rejects this interpretation and searches for an alternative explanation of *how* the church can be the 'body of Christ':

[29] Sagnard, *Extraits*, 85 n. 4: 'Thus the "elect" receive their *spiritual substance* (*ousia*) from the Son, through their *submission* to the Son, in the same way as the Son receives his *ousia* from the Father, because of his relation as Son'. Sagnard (16-7, and 97 n. 2) takes *ousia* used of the son in *Exc.* 19.5 to mean 'essence'.

[30] See discussion of Stoic theories about different kinds of mixtures in Sagnard, *Extraits*, 216, Appendice B. See also E. Osborn, *Tertullian, First Theologian of the West* (Cambridge, 1997), 139-41, who cites Alexander of Aphrodias, *On mixture* 216.14-218.6 (*Stoicorum Veterum Fragmenta* (ed. von Arnim), 2.473).

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The human mingling in marriage produces the birth of one child from two mingled seeds, and the body when it is dissolved in the ground is mixed with the earth and likewise water is mixed with wine. But better and superior bodies have an easier kind of mixture. At any rate spirit is mixed with spirit. It seems to me that this happens by juxtaposition, not by mixture. Is it not the case, then, that the divine power pervades the soul and sanctifies it at the final stage of the soul's progress? 'For God is Spirit' [1 John 4:24], and '[the Spirit] blows where it will' [John 3:8]. For the Power [cf. 1 Cor 1:24] does not pervade through substance, but through power and strength. And Spirit is juxtaposed to spirit as spirit is to soul.

The relation between Christ and the church is not by 'blending', Clement says, but by juxtaposition, which happens when the divine power pervades the soul. When Clement uses the term *dunamis* here and in several other excerpts[31], he is probably thinking of 1 Cor 1:24, where Paul calls Christ 'the power of God'. In *Exc.* 17 *dunamis* provides a way to express the close relation between Christ and the soul, while avoiding any hint of materialism.

In another text, *Exc.* 33, Clement quotes a Valentinian comment about Christ, who was produced outside the divine *pleroma* by the fallen aeon Sophia (see *Exc.* 32.1-3) and then ascends to be adopted into the *pleroma*:

Christ, however, became an adopted son [Rom 8:15, 23] since he became the 'elect one' in relation to the divine aeons (*pleromata*) and the 'first-born' [Col 1:15] of things here [below].

The Valentinian exegete interprets the title 'first-born' from Col 1:15 to refer to this Christ's 'election' and 'adoption'. Clement sees some truth in this teaching:

This teaching is thus a misappropriation of our teaching, which holds that the Saviour is the 'first-born' [Col 1:15] of things that are subject [to the Father]. And he is like our 'root' [Rom 11.:16] and 'head', and the church is the 'fruit' [Rom 11:16].

Clement's interpretation of 'first-born' relies on the context in Col 1, where Christ is called the 'head' of his body the church (Col 1:18). To Clement, this suggests ascent to God, and he relates the image of head (and body) to Rom 11:16, where Paul contrasts the 'root' of a plant and its 'fruit'. The allusion is yet another indication of how Valentinian exegetes have directed Clement's attention to certain images in scripture, for this very verse from Romans is quoted in the Valentinian *Exc.* 58.2, discussed above.

Another reflection on what it means to be the 'body of Christ' is found in *Exc.* 27.1-4. The text interprets Lev 16, which describes the entry of the high priest into the holy of holies, read in light of Heb 9, where the high priest of Leviticus is identified as Christ[32]. Clement adds a further interpretation: the

[31] *Exc.* 4.2, 3; 5.3; 10.3; 12.3; 17.3-4; 24.2; 27.3, 6.

[32] For further discussion of this text, and of the similar exegesis in *Strom.* 5.6.39.3-40.4, see J. Kovacs, 'Concealment and Gnostic Exegesis: Clement of Alexandria's Interpretation of the Tabernacle', *SP* XXXI (1997), 414-37.

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high priest is not only Christ, but also a symbol of the perfected Christian soul. The passage portrays the ascent and final reward of the soul that has sought perfection, as it enters the noetic world and progresses through the angelic ranks to join the first-created angels in their vision of God:

> The high priest, upon entering within the second veil, puts aside the gold plate [Exod 28:36] ... This indicates his putting off of that which through purification has become pure and light, like a gold plate, putting off, that is, that which is as it were the soul's body, in which the brilliance of piety is engraved. Through this the principalities and powers recognized that it was wearing the Name [of the Son]. He puts off this 'body', the gold plate which has become light, 'within the second veil', that is, in the noetic world ... The soul, which is naked because of the power of the one who has knowledge, having become as it were the body of the Power [cf. 1 Cor 1:24], passes into the spiritual realm. This soul has become truly rational and high-priestly, since it is directly animated, so to speak, by the Logos ... How is there still room for correction through scripture and teaching in the case of the soul that has become pure to the point that it is deemed worthy to see God 'face to face' [1 Cor 13:12]?... Thus it belonged to God's plan for salvation (*oikonomia*) that the high priest should wear the gold plate and be instructed in *gnosis*. But it belongs to the [divine] Power that man becomes a bearer of divinity, moved directly by the Lord and becoming as it were his body.

As in other texts we have examined, Clement uses the word 'body' in a non-literal sense. He understands the gold plate the high priest wears as a symbol of the 'body' of the soul, that is everything that is not essential to it. During his life on earth, the ideal Christian has purified this 'body' so that it is pure and bright, like the priest's gold plate. Having already put off the physical body (symbolized by the priest's ordinary garments), the Christian now sheds also the 'body' of his soul. For it is only by becoming 'naked' that the soul can become the 'body' of the divine Power (that is the Logos) and be 'directly animated' by him.

It is probably not accidental that these reflections on the ascent of the soul to become the 'body of Christ' occur right after a Valentinian text that speaks of the 'church of the superior seeds' as the body of Jesus (*Exc.* 26.1 discussed earlier). Clement responds to the Valentinian understanding of the image with his own interpretation: it is not the pre-existent assembly of the spiritual elect who form Christ's body, but rather individual Christian souls, who ascend gradually, through learning and purification, to come very close to the Son.

V. Summary and Conclusion: Valentinian Influence on Clement's Exegesis of the New Testament

The image of the 'church' as the 'body of Christ' was introduced by Saint Paul to motivate the Corinthians to put aside their dissensions. The Deuter-Paulines expand the image in order to articulate an exalted Christology, in which Christ as 'head' of the 'body' is superior to the heavenly powers. The

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christological hymn of Col 1 particularly emphasizes protology – Christ as the origin and creator of all things – while Eph 4 develops the image in an eschatological direction, speaking of how the church will follow its 'head' by growing into a 'perfect man'. The Valentinians, following this Deutero-Pauline tradition, found the image a pregnant one. Clement clearly agrees, and, as he explores its various meanings, he is in close dialogue with Valentinian exegetes. He, too, gives new interpretations of themes found in Colossians and Ephesians, and he follows Valentinian exegetes in focusing especially on ascent to the divine realm – both the ascent of the Saviour who first descended and that of the Christian elect, his 'body', who follow the upward path of Christ the 'first-born'. But Clement, at least in the *Excerpts*, does not follow the Valentinians in speculating about the 'church' as the 'body of Christ' before the present time. He does not, for example, take up the Valentinian interpretation of Eph 1:4-5, which says that the saints were 'elected before the foundation of the world'[33]. In *Exc.* 41.2 the Valentinian author interprets this verse to mean that the 'seed' or essence of the spiritual elect existed before earthly and celestial realms came to be – an idea that was important in Valentinian theology, but was not congenial to Clement's understanding of divine 'election' (see *Exc.* 1.3 and 9). Nor does he adopt the Valentinian idea that the *ekklesia* of the elect supplied the 'body of Christ' at the time of his coming to earth and his passion (*Exc.* 1.1-2; 26.1; 58.1-2).

When Clement reflects on 'the body of Christ', his orientation is usually towards the future. The 'church' of the elect is the 'body of Christ', he says in *Exc.* 13.4, because it will 'obtain the same end'. The purified soul becomes at last the 'body of Christ' when Christ's power pervades it and brings it as near as possible to himself (*Exc.* 27). This eschatological focus is also apparent in many texts from the *Stromateis* that take up this image. From the relevant New Testament texts, the text most cited in the *Stromateis* is Eph 4:12-13: 'for the building up of the body of Christ, until all of us come to the *unity of the faith* and of the knowledge of the Son of God, *to a perfect man*, to the measure of the full stature of Christ'. Clement refers to this text again and again, especially in discussions of the '*true* gnostic', which is his name for the Christian who has elected to pursue perfection. Here in the *Stromateis* he explores further implications of Eph 4:12-13, for example of the phrase 'the unity of faith', to which he alludes cryptically in the very first comment he added to the *Excerpts* (*Exc.* 1.3). Not only, as we might expect, does he see these words as an argument for the legitimacy of the majority church, the 'one ancient and

[33] At several points in the *Stromateis* Clement alludes to Eph 1:4, which speaks of the elect having been chosen 'before the foundation of the world', usually interpreting it to mean that God has foreknowledge of who would be 'elect'. See *Strom.* 6.13.106.3; 7.17.107.5; and 6.9.76.3-4, where he says that 'those foreordained to be enrolled in the highest adoption' have 'predestined' themselves.

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universal church', against divisive groups such as Marcionites and Valentinians[34]. He also relates 'the unity of faith' to the final goal of the individual Christian, which is the 'likeness to God' described by both the Bible and Greek philosophy as the 'end' of life[35]. The one universal church, Clement says, imitates the unity of God, the highest principle (*Strom.* 7.17.107.4). The same can be said for the individual Christian, whose goal is to achieve the unchanging, passionless state that is characteristic of God, the divine Monad (*Strom.* 6.9.73.3-5)[36]. The phrase 'unity of faith' suggests to Clement the stability and harmony of *apatheia* – even as it holds out the promise of coming close to God in the 'divinity of love' (*Strom.* 6.9.73).

Discussions of Clement's exegetical method usually focus on his interpretation of texts from the Old Testament, where he trod the path of allegorical exegesis already well laid out by Philo and others[37]. Indeed, Clement's writings are full of explorations of the deeper meaning of the symbols of the Old Testament. But a cardinal tenet of Clement's theology is the unity of Old and New Testaments, as he says over and over as he defends the majority church's 'rule of faith' against Marcionites, Valentinians, and others. There is unity not only in theology – in that both testaments speak of one God and describe one universal path of salvation – but also in style. Jesus, like the Old Testament prophets, speaks in parables and enigmas, and Saint Paul's writings are full of references to higher 'mysteries'. When Clement sets out his theory of scripture's extensive use of symbolism in *Stromateis*, book 5, he is speaking of the New Testament as well as the Old. There is much in its words and symbols that merits close attention, and these inspired words have other senses beyond the obvious.

In each of the last four books of the *Stromateis*, Clement includes one chapter that he specifically identifies as a model exegesis. Of these, the chapters in books 5 and 6 treat passages from the Old Testament[38], while those in in books 4 and 7 provide early examples of the allegorical exegesis of New Testament texts, one each from the Gospels and the letters of Paul. *Strom.* 4, chapter 6, interprets the beatitudes of Matthew 5 as a description of the training by which the soul becomes perfect and ascends to God, while *Strom.* 7, chapter 14,

[34] *Strom.* 7.17.107.3-5. Clement notes here a further overtone of 'unity': it means also the accord of Old and New Testaments, a cardinal point of the majority church's 'rule of faith'.

[35] See, e.g., *Strom.* 2.22.131-136, and discussion in R. Wilken, *The Spirit of Early Christian Thought, Seeking the face of God* (New Haven, 2003), 57-61.

[36] Cf. *Strom.* 6.11.87.3.

[37] See, e.g, A. Van den Hoek, *Clement of Alexandria and His Use of Philo in the Stromateis* (Leiden, 1988); J.N.B. Carleton Paget, 'The Christian Exegesis of the Old Testament in the Alexandrian Tradition', in M. Saebo, ed., *Hebrew Bible/Old Testament. The History of Its Interpretation*, vol. 1, parts 1-2 (Göttingen, 1996), 1, 484-501.

[38] The decalogue is treated in *Strom.* 6.16.133-148; *Strom.* 5.6.32-40 interprets several texts from Exodus that describe the tabernacle and the garments of the high priest. See discussion of the latter in J. Kovacs, 'Concealment and Gnostic Exegesis'.

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explores a similar theme through reflection on Paul's discussion of lawsuits and fornication in 1 Corinthians 6.

Clement's exploration of the symbols in the New Testament has received less attention than his allegorical exegesis of Old Testament texts. But it is of considerable interest, because he is among the first interpreters of the New Testament, and he knows his text well. His notes preserved in the *Excerpts from Theodotus* give us a glimpse of his private wrestlings as he seeks to understand the richness of christological texts such as John 1, Col 1, and Eph 4-5. One reason he was so interested in the teaching of Theodotus and other Valentinians – interested enough to make his own annotated collection of excerpts from their writings – is that they had already explored these texts and reflected on images such as 'the body of Christ'. Although Clement does not accept all of their interpretations, these Valentinian exegetes gave him much to ponder.

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On Providence and Inspiration: A Short Commentary on ΠΕΡΙ ΑΡΧΩΝ 4.1.7[1]

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We come across a handful of passages in Origen's extant corpus where the intriguing comparison is made between the two books God has authored, the scriptures and the cosmos[2]. This comparison also surfaces at the end of Origen's argument for the inspiration of scripture in book 4 of *Peri Archon* (PA). Just as God's skilful providential plan is not always readily detected in all his created works, so is 'the divinity of scripture which extends through all of it' not easily discerned by the reader[3]. This passage and the elusive argument that precedes it has elicited surprisingly little commentary[4]. Today I would like to take some steps toward offering a more thorough account of this passage. In particular, there are two questions that I would like to answer: first, how can God's providence emerge in a treatise on biblical inspiration? And second, what purpose does the analogy between providence and inspiration here serve? My approach will be to locate our passage within its larger context, that is, Origen's argument for the inspiration of scripture, the topic with which he opens his extended hermeneutical treatise here at the beginning of book 4 of PA.

At the beginning of book 4 we learn that Origen's task is to discuss 'the reasons that compel us to consider the scriptures as divine'[5]. The main reason for this belief which emerges in the course of the discussion is that the scriptures, or at the very least their prophecies, were spoken with a *divine* power, from which one can conclude that the scriptures are divine, have come from God,

[1] GK = Origen, *Vier Bücher von den Prinzipien*, ed. H. Görgemanns and H. Karpp, 3rd edn (Darmstadt, 1992); PA = *On First Principles*; CC = *Against Celsus*; Phil = *Philocalia*.

[2] Cf. Phil 1.29 (from the *Commentary* on Ps 50) and 2.5 (from the *Commentary* on Ps 1).

[3] ἡ τῆς γραφῆς θειότης διατείνουσα εἰς πᾶσαν αὐτήν (PA 4.1.7/GK 690, 303.14 - 692, 304.1).

[4] Cf. Origen, *Philocalie, 1-20: Sur les Écritures*, introduction, text, translation, and notes by M. Harl, SC 302 (Paris, 1983) pp. 59-63, 148-51, 185-8; R.P.C. Hanson, *Allegory and Event* (London, 1959) pp. 189-91; H. Karpp, 'Kirchliche und außerkirchliche Motive im hermeneutischen Traktat des Origenes'De Principiis'4.1-2', in *Vivarium: Festschrift Theodor Klauser* (Münster, 1984), pp. 197-9.

[5] PA 4.1.1/GK 670, 293.3. Other references to the scripture as divine at GK 668, 292.11; 670, 293.1-2.

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are inspired[6]. Origen begins his argument, however, not with the prophecies themselves, but rather with that which they have brought about, the powerful expansion of Christianity. Moses' laws and Jesus' teachings have gained widespread acceptance throughout the world, which other legislators and teachers cannot claim for themselves[7]. Furthermore, those who accept Moses' law are subject to hatred, and those who accept Jesus' teachings face threat of death. Concerning Christianity it must be added that despite various forms of persecution, with few teachers and within few years, 'the word has been able... to be preached everywhere in the world' (Mt 24:14), so that Greeks and barbarians, wise and foolish have adopted the religion of Jesus[8].

This is only the start to Origen's argument for scripture's inspiration – as it stands he has proven nothing, since one could object that *non-Scriptural* factors have been responsible for the powerful success of Christianity and its book. Origen is indeed aware of what some of these are[9] and yet wants to say something more, *that the scriptures themselves* have helped bring about the rapid acceptance of the Christian message. He will now deepen his argument by turning to those passages in scripture which prophesy this prevailing of Christianity. 'We shall not hesitate to say that this achievement [the expanse of Christianity] is more than human, *since* Jesus taught with all authority and power that his word would prevail'[10]. This expanse is indeed remarkable, but what makes it 'more than human' for Origen is that predictions, such as Jesus', brought it about.

Jesus, who represents the 'NT' in this argument, delivered 'oracles' such as 'You will be brought before kings and governors for my sake, for a testimony to them and to the gentiles'[11]. Now at the time he delivered these prophecies, people had no way of knowing that his words were from God, 'but', Origen writes, 'when words spoken with such authority have come to pass it shows that God, having truly become incarnate, delivered to people the doctrines of

[6] These terms are synonymous: cf. PA 4.1.1; 4.1.6; 4.1.7; and 4.2.1.

[7] On Moses' success: CC 1.16; 1.18; 2.51-52. On Jesus': CC 1.26-31; 2.51-52; 2.79; 3.29-33; 3.68; 4.32; 5.62; 7.26; 8.47. On the philosophers' inability to convert the masses: CC 1.27; 1.64; 3.51; 6.2.

[8] PA 4.1.1/GK 674, 295.3-5. In PA 4.1.7 Origen will refer to the poor style of the scriptures which again confirms the divine power behind their success (cf. CC 1.62; 3.39; 3.68; 6.1-2; Comm Jn 4.1-3).

[9] Cf. PA 4.1.5.

[10] μεῖζον ἢ κατὰ ἄνθρωπον τὸ πρᾶγμα εἶναι λέγειν οὐ διστάξομεν, μετὰ πάσης ἐξουσίας καὶ πειθοῦς τῆς περὶ τοῦ κρατυνθήσεσθαι τὸν λόγον τοῦ Ἰησοῦ διδάξαντος (PA 4.1.2/GK 674, 295.6-9). Butterworth's translation of the genitive absolute blurs the argument: '*remembering that* Jesus taught with all authority ...' (Origen, *On First Principles*, tr. G.W. Butterworth (London, 1936 [Gloucester, 1973]), p. 258). Other references to the power in Jesus' words: CC 1.70; 2.13-15; 2.38; 2.45-46; 2.74; 7.54.

[11] Mt 10:18. One other prophecy of Jesus is cited (Mt 7:22-23/Lk 13:26) and another has probably fallen out of the Greek (there is a gap after καὶ in the MSS and Rufinus translates a third verse: Mt 24:14).

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salvation'[12]. Then follows a much longer section on the prophecies uttered in the OT, prophecies which pertain to the demise of Judaism, the coming of Christ, and the Gentile mission[13]. Here too Origen concludes that it was only

> after the advent of Jesus that the inspiration of the prophetic words and the spiritual nature of Moses' law came to light. For before the advent of Christ it was not at all possible to bring forward clear proofs of the divine inspiration of the old scriptures. But the advent of Jesus led those who might have suspected that the law and the prophets were not divine to the clear conviction that they were composed by heavenly grace[14].

It is in hindsight clear, based upon the fulfilment of prophecies about the expansion of Christianity, that they were pronounced with a divine power. In his own words, these prophecies 'were spoken with all power and authority and for this reason they have prevailed over the elect from among the nations'[15]. The scriptures have propelled the church's mission. This is how Origen wishes to establish that the scriptures have come from God – by locating the salvific power of God within them[16].

It is important to have in mind this argument for the inspiration of scripture that precedes our passage since it heightens our sensitivity to the new development at PA 4.1.7. If the scriptures have come from God, we expect them not only to have been spoken with a divine power – the topic up until now – but also to have a spiritual sense. This new problem is addressed in our passage: how can the Old and New Testaments be inspired 'if in every passage of the Scriptures what is superhuman in its thoughts [τὸ ὑπὲρ ἄνθρωπον] does not appear to grab hold of the uninstructed'[17]? In Origen's answer to this question there is no denial that our weakness cannot detect the hidden meaning in every passage. But this affords no grounds to object to scripture's inspiration since – and here comes the analogy – God's inspiration parallels his providence. Just as believers assent to divine providence even if it is not always clearly detected, so is it reasonable to believe in inspiration when God's inspired sense in scripture is not clearly detected in all its passages[18]. It does not follow from our inability to detect God's inspiration or providence that neither of these exist.

[12] PA 4.1.2/GK 676, 296.3-5.

[13] PA 4.1.3-5: Gen 49:10 (LXX); Hosea 3:4 (LXX); Deut 32:21; Ps 44:1-3 (LXX); Ps 71:7ff (LXX); Isa 7:14 (LXX); Isa 8:8ff; Micah 5:1; Dan 9:24; Job 3:8.

[14] PA 4.1.6/GK 686.301.13 - 688.302.3 (Butterworth slightly altered). For a very similar argument: CC 1.45; 6.10.

[15] μετὰ πάσης δυνάμεως καὶ ἐξουσίας εἰρημένα καὶ διὰ τοῦτο τῆς ἀπὸ τῶν ἐθνῶν ἐκλογῆς κεκρατηκότα (PA 4.1.6/GK 686, 301.11-13). In its literary context this statement is applied to OT prophecies, though it applies equally well to those in the NT.

[16] I am not aware of a similar reconstruction of the argument in PA 4.1.1-6.

[17] PA 4.1.7/GK 688, 302.14 - 690, 303.2.

[18] Note how Origen says providence is not diminished παρὰ τοῖς γε ἅπαξ παραδεξαμένοις αὐτὴν καλῶς (GK 690, 303.13-14) – the analogy implies that the same holds for inspiration, that it too must be 'accepted', i.e. believed in.

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Let us now address the two questions raised at the beginning of this paper. First, how can providence emerge in a treatise on biblical inspiration? This is not a surprising development when we keep the following in mind. To begin with, in Origen's theology God's inspiration of scripture can be described as an act of divine πρόνοια – for example, it is 'the Spirit who, by the providence of God through the Word... enlightened' the authors of Scripture[19]; and furthermore, Origen closely associates God's power with his πρόνοια – in an earlier section of PA the *virtus dei* was understood to be that

> by which he is lively, by which he established, holds together, and governs all things visible and invisible, by which he is sufficient for all things whose providence he orchestrates, to all of which he is present as if they were united ... [20]

If we recall the argument for inspiration which precedes our passage and which I presented in some depth, Origen's principal strategy for claiming scripture's inspiration was his assertation that the power of God was at work within it – there are more than a dozen references to δύναμις, ἐξουσία and κρατύνω in PA 4.1. The emphasis on the power of God in the argument for scripture's inspiration helps us explain why providence can emerge in a tractate on biblical inspiration.

The second question raised in the introduction was what purposes do we detect in the comparison between providence and inspiration? The first and rather obvious answer is that the analogy contributes to Origen's argument for scripture's inspiration. This comparison from providence furthers Origen's argument because it points to another corroborating instance of God's hidden presence. There is, however, another intriguing explanation to account for the emergence of this analogy – that it is a vehicle for an anti-Gnostic polemic, as M. Harl in particular has contended[21]. There is a good deal that speaks for this observation – above all, the fact that the analogy affirms that the Old and New Testaments all come from one source, the God who has created and providentially superintends the world[22]. On the other hand, we cannot easily overlook the fact that Origen here in PA 4.1 is attempting to establish *that* the scriptures

[19] τῷ φωτίζοντι πνεύματι προνοίᾳ θεοῦ διὰ τοῦ ... λόγου τοὺς διακόνους τῆς ἀληθείας (PA 4.2.7/GK 720, 318.9-10). Cf. also CC 7.7; Phil 2.4.

[20] *Intellegenda est ergo 'virtus dei', qua viget, qua omnia visibilia et invisibilia vel instituit vel continet vel gubernat, qua ad omnia sufficiens est, quorum providentiam gerit, quibus velut unita omnibus adest* (PA 1.2.9/GK 142, 40.2-5). Note how closely this definition resembles the one for providence in Hom Gen 3.2. There are numerous other passages where power is linked with providence: PA 1.4.3; 2.1.2; CC 1.26; 3.8; 3.27-28; 4.32; 5.50.

[21] Harl, p. 60.

[22] Harl, p. 60. There is more evidence for this anti-Gnostic thesis: in PA 4.1.1 Origen notes that his argument for scripture's inspiration will apply to both the Old and New Testaments; in the preface to PA the opening, anti-Gnostic article in the church's rule of faith concerns the God who creates all things and has given both Testaments (PA, pref 4); in Phil 1.29 and 2.4-5, where the almost identical comparison with providence is made Origen specifically refers to the 'heterodox' and those who withdraw from the Creator to fashion their own God.

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are inspired, a point not contested between him and the Gnostics. Nor can we overlook his identification of his opponent in this passage not as the 'Gnostic' or 'heterodox', but rather loosely as the one who is too 'uninstructed' (ἀνεπιστήμων) to detect Scripture's spiritual sense or God's providence[23]. Furthermore, we can magnify this conundrum by noting that Origen has also been criticizing the Jews (again, anonymously) when he was earlier referring to the demise of Judaism and the birth of Christianity as fulfilments of OT prophecies (PA 4.1.3-5). Does the presence of these two exegetical adversaries then not exacerbate our problem, since neither the Jews[24] nor the Gnostics denied the inspiration of Scripture, whether there was a divine power in them or not, whether there was a spiritual sense or not?[25] (If we recall the article on the inspiration of scripture in PA, preface 8, Origen refers only to the Holy Spirit's role in inspiration, and this does nothing to exclude the Jews' or Gnostics' view of the text.) So why would Origen level a critique against these groups here, knowing that they do not deny that the scriptures are inspired?

It seems to me that the solution to this dilemma is not to strip this hermeneutical treatise of its polemical undertow, but rather to entertain the possibility that here (as elsewhere in this work) the 'contrapuntal character' of Origen's theology is being sounded, where two (or more) independent melodies are combined to form a harmonious texture, yet all the while retaining their distinctive identities. While the main melody at the start of book 4 of PA is the argument *that* the scriptures are inspired, I would propose that there is also, and at the same time, a second melody in which Origen articulates something distinct yet complementary – the *character* of this inspiration. He is not only claiming that the scriptures are inspired (a point no Jew or Gnostic would deny), but is also delineating the content of this inspiration and by so doing, *is* distancing what he thinks belongs to the inspired spiritual sense from what his exegetical adversaries think belongs to this sense: a Jew cannot accept that Christ is the spiritual sense of OT prophecies, and a Gnostic will not concede that the creator God has inspired both Old and New Testaments.

This second melody becomes noticeably more prominent in the next section of book 4, where Origen is going to claim that the Jews and Gnostics (and *simpliciores*) do not discern the inspired sense of scripture. Note: it is not that they deny inspiration, but rather that they do not get what *belongs* to the inspired sense. To help clarify how the church understands this inspired sense, Origen refers to the Trinitarian agency in the inspiration of scripture, a great rarity in his surviving corpus (I am only aware of one other reference, at PA

[23] PA 4.1.7/GK 690, 303.1. And a little later he writes, 'But just as providence is not diminished because of the ignorance of those who have at least once properly accepted it ...' (GK 690, 303.12-14). Cf. also Hom Lev 14.4.5; CC 6.79; 8.32 for similar general references to the difficulties the 'uninstructed' have with God's providence.

[24] CC 5.60.

[25] CC 3.12.

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4.2.7): these scriptures 'were composed and have come down to us from the inspiration of the Holy Spirit by the will of the Father of the universe through Jesus Christ'[26]. By referring to the action of the 'Father of the universe' and 'Jesus Christ' in inspiration, he signals that what he understands by the spiritual sense of scripture (that is, its *content*) will be different from what the Jews and Gnostics understand by it since he has a different set of scripture-inspiring agents in mind[27].

But we have now entered a new section in PA which is not devoid of its own interpretive challenges, and so it is fitting to draw this paper here to an end, having identified the reasons which compelled Origen to introduce the providence of God into his defence of biblical inspiration.

[26] PA 4.2.2/GK, 700, 308.12-14.

[27] Cf. now my article, 'Why Does Origen Refer to the Trinitarian Authorship of Scripture in Book 4 of *Peri Archon*?' in *Vigiliae Christianae* 60 (2006), 1-8.

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A 'Subordinationist' Text in Origen's *De Principiis*

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As late as 1976 J.N.D. Kelly, in his *Early Christian Doctrines*, was citing *De principiis* I.3.8, which describes the varying ranges of the Father's, the Son's, and the Spirit's activity as an epitomizing example of Origen's thoroughgoing Platonic-style subordinationism[1]. The same year Henri Crouzel's article on this text appeared in the *Gregorianum*[2]. He was following up on two articles by Helmut Saake who had argued, from his analysis of the role of the Spirit in Origen, that this passage did not represent the perspective of a heterodox subordinationism[3]. Crouzel's purpose was to provide additional support, by way of the inner logic of the passage and the external witnesses of Pamphilus and Athanasius, for Saake's fundamental conviction. The scholarly consensus has since shifted and many scholars today would support the view that Origen's subordinationism was reasonably orthodox if not informed by the technical theological advances achieved in the two centuries following his death[4]. In the following I would propose additional evidence internal to the *De principiis* in support of this.

[1] The date of the forward for *Early Christian Doctrines*, rev. edn (New York: Harper & Row, 1978), pp. 131-2. *De prin.* I.3.5, the text often cited in this connection, is complicated by Paul Koetschau's insertion of fragment 9, drawn from Justinian, *Ep. ad Mennam* (Mansi IX, 524). Cf. Jerome, *Ep. ad Avitum* 2.

[2] 'Les personnes de la Trinité sont-elles de puissance inégale selon Origène, Peri Archon I, 3, 5-8?', *Gregorianum* 57 (1976), 109-25.

[3] 'Der Tractatus pneumatico-philosophicus des Origenes in Περὶ ἀρχῶν', *Hermes* 101 (1973), 91-114, and 'La notion de la Trinité à visée pansotériologique chez Origène et son déplacement intra-ecclésial chez Athanase d'Alexandrie', in Charles Kannengiesser, ed., *Politique et Théologie chez Athanase d'Alexandrie*, Théologie Historique 27 (Paris: Beauchesne, 1974), pp. 295-304.

[4] Recent writings on the theme of subordinationism would include Josep Ruis-Camps, 'Subordinacianismo en Origenes?', in Lothar Lies, ed., *Origeniana Quarta*, Innsbrucker theologische Studien 19 (Innsbruck-Vienna: Tyrolia, 1987), pp. 154-86. Cf. also his *El dinamismo trinitario en la divinizacion de los seres racionales segun Origenes*, OCA 188 (Rome: PIO Studiorum, 1970). J. Nigel Rowe's dissertation is likewise relevant – *Origen's Doctrine of Subordination: A Study in Origen's Christology*, European University Studies, series 23, Theology, vol. 272 (Berne: Peter Lang, 1987). Commentaries and monographs on the *De principiis* treating the question of subordinationism in general or I.3.5-8 in particular include Lothar Lies, *Origenes' 'Peri Archon': Eine undogmatische Dogmatik: Einführung und Erläuterung* (Darmstadt: Wissenschaftliche Buchgesellschaft, 1992); Manlio Simonetti, ed., *I Principi di Origene* (Turin: Unione Tipografico-Editrice Torinese, 1968); Herwig Görgemanns and Heinrich Karpp, eds, *Origenes: Vier Bücher von den Prinzipien*, Texte zur Forschung 24 (Darmstadt: Wissenschaftliche Buch-

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Earlier in the chapter on Christ (I.2.4), Origen wrote,

This Son, then, is also the truth and the life of all things that exist; and rightly so. For the things that were made, how could they live, except by the gift of life? Or the things that exist, how could they really and truly exist, unless they were derived from the truth? Or how could rational beings exist, unless the Word or reason had existed before them? Or how could they be wise, unless wisdom existed?[5]

We are presented here with the same sort of concentric ranges as those found in *De principiis* I.3.5-8 with comparable nuances in attribution. It is in the Son as Truth that all things whatsoever have the truth of their existence, in the Son as the Life of all things that living things live, in the Son as Word or Reason that all rational beings exist, and finally, in the Son as Wisdom that any rational creature is wise. A comparison of the two texts makes it reasonably clear that I.3.5-8 involves a specific sort of Trinitarian attribution as Crouzel claimed and which Origen tells us he intended as 'the testimony we bear to the unity of Father, Son, and Holy Spirit' (I.3.8)[6].

Secondly, the Son is presented here as having the same range as the Father over all created things. The same point was made earlier in I.2.2:

And because in this very subsistence of wisdom there was implicit every capacity and form of the creation that was to be, both of those things that exist in a primary sense and of those which happen in consequence of them, the whole being fashioned and arranged beforehand by the power of foreknowledge, wisdom, speaking through Solomon in regard to these very created things that had been as it were outlined and prefigured in herself, says that she was created as a 'beginning of the ways' of God, which means that she contains within herself both the beginnings and causes and species of the whole creation[7].

gesellschaft, 1976); Henri Crouzel, ed., *Traité des principes*, SC 252, 253, 268, 269, 312 (Paris: Éditions du Cerf, 1978-80). Relevant discussions can also be found in the following monographs: Henri Crouzel, *Théologie de l'image de Dieu chez Origène*, Théologie 34 (Paris: Aubier, 1956); Michel Fédou, S.J., *La sagesse et le monde: Essai sur la christologie d'Origène*, Collection «Jésus et Jésus-Christ» 64 (Paris: Desclée, 1995); Mark Julian Edwards, *Origen Against Plato*, Ashgate Studies in Philosophy & Theology in Late Antiquity (Aldershot, Hants; Burlington, VT: Ashgate, 2002); Marguerite Harl, *Origène et la fonction révélatrice du Verbe Incarné*, Patristica Sorbonensia 2 (Paris: Éditions du Seuil, 1958). Noteworthy among studies indicating the more primitive character of Origen's theological vocabulary are Richard P.C. Hanson, 'Did Origen Apply the Word Homoousios to the Son?', in Jacques Fontaine and Charles Kannengiesser, eds, *Epektasis: Mélanges patristiques offerts au Cardinal Jean Daniélou* (Paris: Beauchesne, 1972), pp. 293-303, and 'The Influence of Origen on the Arian Controversy', in *Origeniana Quarta*, pp. 410-23.

[5] Translations are from *Origen, On First Principles*, tr. G.W. Butterworth (London: S.P.C.K., 1936, repr. New York: Harper & Row, 1966).

[6] See Rowan D. Williams, 'The Son's Knowledge of the Father in Origen', in *Origeniana Quarta*, pp. 146-53.

[7] Cf. Henri Crouzel, S.J., 'Idées platoniciennes et raisons stoïciennes dans la théologie d'Origène', in *SP* XVIII.3 (Leuven: Peeters Press, 1989).

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Third, with regard to equality or inequality of power Origen is fairly clear throughout this Christological chapter that he understands Christ to be as much the power of God as the wisdom of God (cf. I.2.1 and I Cor. 1:24). In I.2.9 Wisdom's power comes to the fore in the phrase found in Wis. 7:25, 'a breath of the power of God'. This is one of the five definitions of God which also belong to his wisdom. The reference to power is 'that by which he is strong, that by which he both established and also preserves and controls all things visible and invisible'. The Son proceeds 'as will proceeding from mind, yet nevertheless the will of God comes itself to be a power of God'. Thus, power proceeds from power. Finally, in I.2.10 Origen clearly links this power to the creation of the world which is accomplished with divine Wisdom, concluding that 'the title Almighty cannot be older in God than that of Father, for it is through the Son that the Father is almighty'. Thus, 'Wisdom, through which God is called Almighty, has a share even in the glory of omnipotence'. 'The omnipotence of the Father and the Son is one and the same'. These citations can be multiplied. Given this, the concentric ranges of I.3.5-8 cannot be understood in terms of an inequality of power.

A fourth point of interest is that three of the four titles of Christ – Truth, Reason or Word, and Wisdom – which have ranges corresponding to the ranges in I.3.5-8, are explicitly presented as being summed up in the last title, Wisdom. The fourth title, Life, is implied. The passage just cited grounds the assumption of the Truth under Wisdom. Origen recapitulates this point in the next section (I.2.3): Wisdom 'fashions beforehand and contains within herself the species and causes of the entire creation'. But Wisdom is also 'understood to be the Word of God'. The reason for this is that

> wisdom opens to all other beings, that is, to the whole creation, the meaning of the mysteries and secrets which are contained within the wisdom of God, and so she is called the Word, because she is as it were an interpreter of the mind's secrets.

In short, the modality of the Son which, in one view, is the most restrictive – Wisdom, which grounds that restricted group of creatures, 'wise beings', who are the cream of creation – is also the most inclusive modality, including the broader ranges of all rational creatures and of all creatures whatsoever.

My next comment is a bit more tentative but perhaps sheds light on why Origen might have thought his audience could misunderstand him on the Spirit in I.3.5-8. If the Spirit's governance of the cream of creation, holy creatures, carries the implication that holiness, and thus the activity of the Holy Spirit, is implicitly inclusive of the ranges of rationality and of existence itself as wisdom is inclusive of rationality and the truth of existence, then, if the Father has dominion over things only insofar as they exist but the Spirit has dominion over them not only insofar as they exist, but also insofar as they are rational and also holy, then the Spirit is greater than the Father and greater also than the Son. The logic of inclusivity ingredient in the earlier Christological passage

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(I.2.4) would provide an impetus for Origen to clarify his position in this later passage. The Spirit is not greater, which is to say, more inclusive in his range of activity, than is the Father. For our purposes, the proof of this is that the range of the Son in his modalities as Truth, Word, and Wisdom is the same as the range of the Father, who is the creator of all things, the creator of rational beings, the creator of wise and holy beings.

In point of fact, there is no passage comparable to I.2.4 applicable to the Holy Spirit. It is, however, expressed in piecemeal fashion in the *De principiis*. Thus, when Origen returns to the subject of the Holy Spirit in II.7.1, the Spirit is characterized as being 'in the prophets and the apostles, that is, both in those who believed in God before the coming of Christ and in those who have taken refuge in God through Christ'. In the next section, however, the Alexandrine goes a bit further: 'Now we are of the opinion that every rational creature receives without any difference a share in the Holy Spirit just as in the wisdom of God and the word of God'. This is contrasted with the special coming of the Spirit which 'happened after Christ's ascension into heaven rather than before his coming into the world'. Earlier, Origen observes that he has found no scriptural passage affirming the creation of the Spirit and goes on to conclude that, so far as he can understand, it is the Holy Spirit who 'moved upon the waters' in Gen. 1:2 at the beginning of creation (I.3.3). Thus, at one point or other, Origen affirms the Spirit's involvement with all creatures and with all rational creatures, and not just with all holy creatures. His range of power matches that of the Father and of the Son[8].

Still, Origen is reluctant to expand the role of the Spirit beyond his inspiration of the prophets and apostles or his activity in sanctification. He generally does not explicitly describe the Spirit as having dominion over, or any sort of relationship with, non-holy or non-wise creatures, whether rational or otherwise. In the extant homilies on Genesis (clearly not the exposition indicated in *De principiis* I.3.3), he has not a single word about this creative activity of the Spirit. He clearly marks off his conviction that the Spirit is related to all rational creatures, indeed, to all creatures as his own opinion.

This last provides us with an important clue as to why his treatment of the Son and his treatment of the Spirit are so different with regard to the topic of this paper. In his summary of the apostolic faith of the Church at the beginning of the *De principiis* (I. *Praef.*4), the Spirit is positively characterized in three ways: the Spirit is honoured with the Father and the Son; the Spirit inspired the prophets and the apostles; the Spirit in the Old Testament is the same as in the New Testament with one difference which was indicated earlier – there is a special outpouring of the Spirit following on Christ's ascension. Origen will accordingly associate the Spirit with the Father and the Son in the Trinity; he will associate the Spirit with the Son in the prophetic word.

[8] Indeed, there is a link to the Son's fourth title, Life, in I.3.7.

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In contrast, there is more, relatively speaking, known about Christ from the apostolic proclamation. Christ was 'begotten of the Father before every created thing'; he 'ministered to the Father in the foundation of all things'; he emptied himself, came to earth, and was made man 'although he was God'; he 'took to himself a body' and 'was born of a virgin and of the Holy Spirit'; he suffered, died, rose from the dead, and ascended into heaven. For Origen, the apostolic faith clearly affirmed Christ's involvement in creation; nothing, on the other hand, is said of the Spirit's involvement, not even whether he himself was created. That the Spirit is associated with the Word in the inspiration of the prophets can provide the grounds for associating the Spirit with the Word in general, including the creation of rational creatures. Origen is willing to speculate this far, but he remains circumspect with regard to the Spirit in a way comparable to the relative silence of the apostolic tradition.

Of course, this stepping out in the direction of affirming the presence of the Spirit in some sense in all rational creatures, whether holy or not, and the identification of the Spirit with the Spirit of Gen. 1:2 are in accord with the dynamic of his thought as manifested in *De principiis* I.2.4 and I.3.5-8. This supports the notion of an overall coherence to Origen's thought which would allow one to make a firmer judgement about the place to be accorded various purportedly authentic fragments of his works. Jerome and Justinian were clearly basing themselves on something real in the text of the *De principiis*; it is equally clear, at least with regard to the text under consideration, that they misunderstood Origen.

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Text and Gnosis: The Exclusive Function of Written Instruction in Clement of Alexandria

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My task in this short study is threefold. First, I begin with a brief introduction of Clement of Alexandria's interest in hidden instruction as conveyed through texts, expressed primarily in *Stromateis* I.1. Second, since Clement considers Christ as the model for this sort of instruction, I discuss his use of a particular saying of Christ, specifically Matthew 10:27, in order to highlight Clement's preference for concealed meaning. Finally, I demonstrate how Clement's interpretive moves coincide with his understanding of salvation, which emphasizes the progressive function of Christ's instruction.

In the first book of his *Stromateis*, Clement of Alexandria evaluates the utility of written, rather than oral communication. In doing so, he considers the various advantages of writing over speaking, which serve to justify his own written endeavour[1]. Clement nevertheless stresses the care with which one must write and maintains that certain aspects of instruction are best saved for oral communication. He explicitly situates his own written work in this tradition of limited instruction. The *Stromateis* are not original, he explains, but rather remembrances of tradition, originating with Christ and passed on by Clement's own teachers. The instruction that his text relays, however, will not be accessible to all, but only to advanced readers, exemplified by Clement's ideal Christian, the *gnostic*. He thus offers the following description of the *Stromateis*: 'It will attempt to speak without being perceived, to disclose secretly, and to demonstrate silently'[2].

Clement explicitly attributes this restrictive method of instruction to Christ, his supreme teacher. In the first chapter of the *Stromateis*, he explains that Christ communicated 'the mysteries of God' only to those with the ability (*dynamis*) to receive it[3]. According to Clement, Christ 'did not disclose to the

[1] One advantage, for instance, is that writing can preserve tradition that memory alone might neglect. For a more thorough examination of Clement's arguments in *Stromateis* I.1, see E. Osborn, 'Teaching and Writing in the First Chapter of the *Stromateis* of Clement of Alexandria', *JThSt* 10 (1959), 335-43, and L. Roberts, 'The Literary Form of the *Stromateis*', *Second Century* 1 (1981), 211-22.

[2] *Strom.* I.1.15.1. For a similar sentiment, see *Strom.* I.1.18.1.

[3] *Strom.* I.1.13.1.

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many what did not belong to the many, but to the few to whom he knew that [such things] belonged'. Clement characterizes this select group as those with the capacity to receive his message[4]. Christ's own activity thus provides Clement with a model of restrictive teaching.

More specifically, Clement posits that Christ's use of parables exemplifies the need for veiled instruction. Clement relies on Matthew 13:13 to reveal the consequent misunderstanding of Christ's parables. In response to the disciples' inquiry, Christ explains, 'The reason I speak to them in parables is that "seeing they do not perceive, and hearing they do not listen, nor do they understand"'[5]. Rather than causing such ignorance, Clement explains, Christ simply exposes it[6]. In treating this lack of comprehension, Christ, the instructor, 'dispenses goods ... according to the ability (*dynamis*) to receive' and relies on the Christian to foster his own advancement[7]. Clement thus suggests in this first chapter that Christ himself conveys a hidden message, actually accessible only to a few. His subsequent use in the *Stromateis* of New Testament sayings attributed to Christ reinforces this point. Clement, in fact, seems to consider the bulk of Christ's sayings to be parabolic; consequently he typically ignores the surface reading of such texts in favour of the hidden. We can briefly explore this trend by taking a closer look at Clement's frequent employment of one particular saying attributed to Jesus, Matthew 10:27. His use of this text not only highlights Clement's preference for what he considers to be the concealed message of Jesus' sayings, but also reiterates the secretive and limited nature of texts, which for Clement include both scripture and his own *Stromateis*[8].

The gospel context for Mt 10:27 is Jesus' instruction of his disciples. Mt 10:26b reveals that 'nothing is covered up that will not be uncovered, and nothing secret that will not become known'. Verse 27 continues, 'What I say to you in the dark, tell in the light; and what you hear in the ear, proclaim from the housetops'[9]. Clement's interpretation of the verse, specifically the latter

[4] We may assume that Clement considers this group responsible for the proper tradition that he preserves. He also notes that, as with God, 'secret things (*aporrēta*) are entrusted to speech, not to writing', *Strom.* I.1.13.2. Clement goes on to indicate that 'what is hidden to the many shall appear manifest to the few', *Strom.* I.1.13.3. For additional discussion of this concept in Clement, see H.A. Blair, 'A Method of Exposition in the Stromateis of Clement of Alexandria', *Studia Biblica*, ed. E. A. Livingstone (Sheffield: University of Sheffield Press, 1979-80), 1, 1-7.

[5] NRSV.

[6] *Strom.* I.1.2.3.

[7] *Strom.* I.1.3.1.

[8] Clement's approach to scriptural texts, which includes both the Old and New Testaments, is premised on his identification of the *logos* as the author, who intentionally hides truth in symbols, *Strom.* VI.15. Consequently, understanding the concealed meaning requires significant effort by the reader. J. Kovacs reveals how Clement's concept of the *gnostic* teacher similarly reflects this use of concealment, in 'Divine Pedagogy and the Gnostic Teacher according to Clement of Alexandria', *JECS* 9 (2001), 3-25.

[9] For a parallel, see Lk 12:2-3.

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half, ultimately sets aside the most basic reading, which encourages open proclamation, and instead recommends that the 'darkness' of Christ's message be maintained.

The first instance of Clement's use of Mt 10:27 occurs in Book I of the *Stromateis*. Here, Clement uses it as follows: '"But what you hear in the ear", says the Lord, "proclaim upon the houses", exhorting them to receive the concealed traditions of true knowledge and expound them in an especially lofty manner'. Though he begins with a literal reading of the text, Clement utilizes the image of the housetop to characterize further the disciples' instructions. They are not simply to spread Christ's teachings, but to relay them in an elaborate style. Clement additionally identifies the content of the teaching as the hidden tradition of true knowledge. As he continues, Clement reiterates that limited access to this element of instruction is necessary. He writes, 'Just as we have heard in the ear, so deliver to others as is necessary; but [Christ does] not instruct us to carelessly surrender to the many what is spoken to them in parables'[10]. Clement thus limits the means of transmitting tradition.

Clement calls on Mt 10:27 twice more in the *Stromateis* in Book VI, Chapter 15[11]. Clement begins this chapter with a discussion of the way a *gnostic*, his ideal Christian, might mirror his master, Christ, in providing instruction. Once the *gnostic* realizes his 'likeness' to Christ, he may in turn teach others. Clement again employs Mt 10:27 as a model for instruction: 'he [the *gnostic*] teaches worthily "on the housetops" those capable of being built to a lofty height ...'[12] As in Book I, Clement limits the recipients of this instruction to those with ability. More specifically, he imaginatively utilizes the phrase 'on the housetops' as evidence for this advanced group of Christians. This corresponds well with Clement's effort in this chapter to explain the variant levels of Christian understanding. Ultimately, he submits that 'the *gnostic* alone is able to understand and explain the things spoken ... obscurely'[13].

As Book VI, Chapter 15 progresses, Clement returns to Mt 10:27 for a fuller explication of the verse. In this third instance of use, he is more explicit about what he thinks Christ means by 'hear'. For Clement, the meaning implies mystery and is thus limiting. In reference to Mt 10:27, he explains that the phrase 'hear in the ear' actually indicates 'in a hidden manner, and in a mystery (for such things are allegorically (*allēgoreitai*) said to be spoken in the ear)'. Clement employs another saying about 'hearing' in VI.15 to make a comparable point. With reference to Mt 11:15, which states, 'Let anyone with ears [*to hear*] listen', he curiously posits that what is meant is 'that hearing and understanding do not belong to all'[14].

[10] *Strom.* I.12.56.2.
[11] My references to Mt 10:27 in the *Stromateis* are not intended to be exhaustive.
[12] *Strom.* VI.15.115.1.
[13] *Strom.* VI.15.115.5.
[14] *Strom.* VI.15.115.6.

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Clement continues with a comment on how what is 'heard', meaning tradition (*paradosis*), should be transmitted. In reference to Christ's instructions in Mt 10:27 to 'proclaim on the housetops', Clement submits that the *gnostic* teacher should be 'understanding [Christ's words] sublimely, delivering them in a lofty strain', and clarifying scriptures according to the rule (*canon*) of truth. Clement explains the necessity for this instructive task – 'neither prophecy nor the Saviour Himself announced the divine mysteries simply, so as to be easily apprehended by all'[15]. Knowledge of such mysteries is thus limited to those Christians with advanced abilities, who may in turn progressively and selectively educate others.

Our consideration of his use of Mt 10:27 reveals Clement's desire to transcend the surface of the text and uncover its hidden meaning (that is, impose his own reading). While it corresponds with Clement's ideas about challenging written instruction, this strategy of reading texts, I suggest, also relates to Clement's conception of Christ's role as Saviour.

In Clement's scheme of salvation, Christ primarily mediates salvation not through his suffering death, but through his teachings. Clement's emphasis on Christ's role as an instructor is most apparent in his *Paidagogos*, a text which describes Christ's progressive instructional functions – he first persuades, trains, and then teaches[16]. Clement reasons, 'The *logos* is therefore called Savior, because he has left humans remedies of reason in the search for understanding and salvation'[17]. This signals a few critical elements of Clement's thought. First, Clement understands salvation as a progressive, incremental process. Second, Christ delivers the provisions to which a Christian must respond. This compels Clement to consistently emphasize the requirement of human initiative and effort in the progressive quest for salvation, which culminates (for some) in the reception of *gnosis*. An effort at interpreting scripture marks one significant way, for Clement, of advancing towards *gnosis*.

A third relevant aspect of Clement's primary understanding of Christ (or more broadly, *logos*) as teacher is the essentially 'non-historical' character of Christ's legacy. Christ's instructive activity is not limited to the period of the Incarnation, but is persistently present in the *logos*. The instruction, then, though historically embedded in certain texts, actually transcends their historical and literary framework. While the incarnation of the *logos* in Christ is significant for Clement's salvific scheme, the details and perhaps even the realities of that historical existence seem to be of little significance to Clement. It is not striking, therefore, that when Clement employs gospel traditions, he exhibits a general lack of interest in either literary or historical details. The actual story of Christ's passion, for instance, is not a subject that Clement

[15] *Strom.* VI.15.124.5-125.1.
[16] *Paid.* I.1.3.3; III.12.97.
[17] *Paid.* I.12.100.1.

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considers at length. In fact, references to Christ's actual suffering and/or death in Clement's writings are quite minimal[18]. This scarcity is reasonable since Clement's emphasis on both Christ's fundamentally instructive role and the progressive effort of the Christian significantly diminishes the soteriological relevance of Christ's death.

So, how then does all this relate to Clement's use of texts and maintenance of hidden instruction? Clement provides some clues in *Stromateis* VI.15. As he discusses why it is useful for the 'sense' (*nous*) of scripture to be concealed, Clement notes that the general gospel tradition (including the virginal birth, the concept of a son of god assuming flesh, as well as the suffering and resurrection) itself appears to many to be a parable[19]. Clement is, of course, not rejecting these events; at the same time, however, he does not appear to give them priority (either here or elsewhere). Rather, he is more concerned with their deeper, exclusive meaning. He goes on to to explain that only when the scriptures are 'opened up' to declare the truth 'to those who have ears' do they make sense[20]. In this discussion, Clement reiterates the intentional concealment within scripture as well as its utility. The veiling of scripture both inhibits potential misunderstanding (presumably for readers with limited skill) and encourages the quest for true *gnosis*[21]. Consequently, only those 'initiated into knowledge', will perceive the entire truth[22]. This understanding of a text's function parallels well Clement's description of his own work at the start of the *Stromateis*[23]. It also corresponds, as we have seen, with his reading of Mt 10:27, which both exemplifies and justifies the secretive nature of texts and tradition. And, finally, Clement's use of texts more broadly reflects his concept of salvation, in which the ideal Christian labours, in this case as a reader, to acquire salvation or *gnosis*.

[18] References to Christ's suffering typically occur alongside Clement's promotion of a progressive *gnostic* lifestyle. In addition, Christ's primary role as a teacher is highlighted. Consequently, Christ's death appears as simply one event in a more extensive soteriological scheme. For one example of this trend, see *Quis* 23.4.

[19] *Strom.* VI.15.127.1.

[20] *Strom.* VI.15.127.2. Clement subsequently compares Jesus to the prophets, who similarly employed parables and were killed in their attempt to explain scripture, *Strom.* VI.15.127.5.

[21] *Strom.* VI.15.126.1. Clement elsewhere identifies *gnosis* as a consequence of appropriate scriptural understanding, *Strom.* II.17.76.3.

[22] Clement elsewhere argues that the *gnostic* need not pay much attention to the literal elements of scripture, *Strom.* II.1.1.3; also, V.11. In *Strom.* VI.15, he reiterates this point by using an example from the *Shepherd of Hermas* (a text also called upon in I.1) to differentiate readings according to basic faith or more advanced *gnosis*, 131.2-3. For Clement and the supposed reader of the *Stromateis*, the latter holds greater validity.

[23] This parallel is enhanced by Clement's stress on the necessary rigour of reading both scripture and his own production, *Strom.* VII.18.

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The Pastoral Function of the Second Repentance for Clement of Alexandria

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Clement's scheme of salvation is progressive, ethical, and telic. The telos of salvation is to restore an individual's soul from its state of separation, division, and estrangement from God, on account of its enslavement to the passions, into the unity of God[1]. Curing the soul from its attachment to the passions requires a remedy of 'bitter medicines' which includes a rigorous training program of obedience to the Lord's commandments, where the force of habit in repeatedly choosing what is beneficial and rejecting what is harmful to one's soul gradually transforms its dispositions towards virtuous conduct as a natural consequence[2]. As the soul increasingly becomes virtuous and self-aware, it longs to know, and to appropriate as its own, the Teacher of the commandments. This longing or desire to seek out the Teacher is the first step of love and knowledge. The Father reciprocates this longing by revealing himself to the seeker as the latter studies the scriptures more profoundly and by empowering the seeker not merely to moderate his passions, but rather to advance to the passionless state[3]. As the believer progresses, he increasingly becomes like God in doing the good for its own sake, living self-sufficiently, and thinking similar thoughts[4]. At this point, with the believer having shown himself worthy, the Father bridges the chasm between Creator and creation by adopting the believer as a son and a friend; the believer is assimilated into the Godhead as a true gnostic, a lover of God, contemplating the Divinity directly and mediating God's benefits to the Christian community[5].

Clement's scheme of salvation implies a continual ethical progression where the believer becomes increasingly virtuous. It goes without saying that it is couched in idealistic language. Clement's description of salvation takes place in the apologetic context of the *Stromateis* where he endeavours to show

[1] The telos of assimilation to the Divine is fundamentally Platonic (*Theaet.* 176B). Cf. Eric Francis Osborn, *The Philosophy of Clement of Alexandria* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1957), 45-6.

[2] Cf. *Str.* 2.2; 2.13; 7.3; 7.7; 7.11.

[3] Cf. *Str.* 7.3; 8.1.

[4] 'God's greatest gift is self-restraint', *Str.* 2.20. Cf. *Str.* 4.22.

[5] Cf. *Str.* 1.26; 2.16; 2.19; 2.22; 4.13; 4.22; 5.6; 5.14; 6.14; 7.3; 7.7.

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the church's critics that only Christians are pious and truly know how to worship God. But does that mean that Clement's scheme of salvation had no practical basis? Perhaps the best way of answering this question is to explore how Clement deals with an extreme situation which is anything but ideal, where the continual progress of a believer is jeopardized by the presence of sin. The question we wish to pose is thus largely a pastoral one: what provision does Clement make for believers who lapse into sin while striving for perfection on the 'strait' and 'narrow' way?

Post-Baptismal Repentance in the *Stromateis*

The issue of post-baptismal sin was extremely controversial in the early church. Baptism clearly was for the remission of sins, but what provision was there for sin committed after baptism? Scripture itself seemed to be ambivalent on the issue[6]. On the one hand, the author of 1 John[7] suggest the possibility of forgiveness for some post-baptismal sins, while, on the other hand, the author of Hebrews[8] rejects such a suggestion. The topic was a chief concern to the author of the mid-second-century apocalypse the *Shepherd of Hermas*. There the author raises the possibility of forgiveness for the baptized, but only once and for a limited time. The offer was only open for present believers, not for those who would come in the future, and it was expected that those who did repent would change their conduct for the rest of their lives. To legitimize his pronouncement the author had to claim special revelation from heaven[9].

In the second book of the *Stromateis*, Clement addresses the issue of the second repentance, clearly influenced by the *Shepherd*[10]. Clement ignores the interim aspect of the second repentance in the *Shepherd* and considers it valid

[6] Cf. Carolyn Osiek, *Shepherd of Hermas*, Hermeneia (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1999), 29.

[7] 1 Jn 1.6-2.2 and 5.15-18.

[8] Heb. 6.4-17 and 10.26-31.

[9] Hermas, *Vis.* 2.2.4-5; *Mand.* 4.3.1-7.

[10] 'He, then, who has received the forgiveness of sins ought to sin no more. For in addition to the first and only repentance from sins... there is forthwith proposed to those who have been called, the repentance which cleans the seat of the soul from transgressions, that faith may be established. And the Lord, knowing the heart, and foreknowing the future, foresaw both the fickleness of man and the craft and subtlety of the devil from the first... Accordingly, being very merciful, [the Lord] has given, in the case of those who, though in faith, fall into any transgression, a second repentance; so that should any one be tempted after his calling, overcome by force and fraud, he may still receive a repentance not to be repented of' (*Str.* 2.13.57.1-2 translation adapted from that by W. Wilson in ANF 2 (Buffalo, 1887); cf. *Mand.* 4.3.1-7). Unlike the author of the *Shepherd*, Clement has no need to claim direct revelation. For Clement, the *Shepherd* was divinely inspired, on a par with other scripture accepted as authoritative by the church at the time. Cf. Adolf von Harnack, *Geschichte der altchristlichen Literatur bis Eusebius*, vol. 1, 2nd edn Jurt Alond (Leipzig: J.C. Hinrichs, 1958), p. 53.

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for his own day, several generations later. However, in contrast to the *Shepherd*, Clement restricts the application of the second repentance to involuntary sins. By distinguishing between involuntary and voluntary sins Clement is able to harmonize the ambiguity of the texts from scripture. The harsh prohibitions on post-baptismal repentance from Hebrews must, in Clement's view, refer to voluntary sin[11]. The more relaxed texts allowing a further repentance refer to involuntary sins. Clement agrees with Aristotle that a sin is involuntary when it is done in ignorance or under compulsion. Once someone has become cognizant of the sin and failed to apply himself to training in the commandments, which one is able to do in one's own power, then it becomes a wilful sin, not covered by a further repentance[12]. Believers who have availed themselves of the second repentance thereby remain in a precarious position with respect to their salvation[13].

If this passage was Clement's only reference to a second repentance, then we could be excused for considering it merely peripheral to his ideal salvific schema, that the notion of second repentance functions here merely to illustrate the differences between involuntary and voluntary sin. However, there is one other place that the topic occurs, not in his three major works, but rather in a small homiletic treatise where the idea of post-baptismal repentance is applied to a particular pastoral situation.

Post-Baptismal Repentance in *QDS*

Quis Dives Salvetur is a relatively small work[14] that addresses some of the problems experienced by wealthy believers in the Alexandrian community. One of the greatest problems is the rich believers' failure to appreciate the need for constant training to overcome the passions attendant with wealth. This failure Clement attributes either to ignorance, weakess, or compelling circumstances – in short, an involuntary sin which comes under post-baptismal repentance[15]. However, Clement here makes a further and extremely interesting distinction between baptismal and post-baptismal repentance. With baptismal repentance God gives remission for sins, but with post-baptismal repentance each man must obtain his own remission[16].

[11] Heb 10.26-27 is quoted in *Str.* 2.13 directly after the allusion to the Shepherd with respect to successive repentings. 1 John 5.16-17 is alluded to in close proximity in *Str.* 2.15.

[12] Cf. *Str.* 2.13.57.4-58.1.

[13] 'But he who has sinned after this, on his repentance, though he obtain pardon, ought to fear, as one no longer washed to the forgiveness of sins' (*Str.* 2.13.56.1).

[14] It is roughly the size of the Gospel of Mark.

[15] *QDS* 39. Translations bared on G.W. Butterworth, *Clement of Alexandria*, LCL (London: William Heinemann, 1919).

[16] *QDS* 40. Cf. *Ecl.* 15.2.

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The onus for obtaining post-baptismal remission falls directly on the wealthy believer. It is the believer's task to secure his own expiation for any involuntary sin. Clement couples this idea of self-expiation with another, even more idiosyncratic proposition – that the wealthy believer enlist the services of an advocate to plead his case before God. The assumption is that the religious status of the wealthy believer is so low that he cannot expect a direct hearing before God. Clement here, I suggest, uses the imperial model of civil administration based on patronage relations to describe the economy of the second repentance open to the wealthy believer. Just as an ordinary Roman citizen could not expect a direct audience before the emperor, but rather had to cultivate the friendship of someone with influence in the imperial circle to present his case, so too the wealthy believer needs to cultivate the friendship, or more precisely the patronage, of a man who is a friend of God:

> How then does a man give these things [namely, salvation]? Why the Lord gives them, on account of your honour and goodwill and attachment with this man. For 'I [that is, God] will give not only to my friends, but also to the friends of my friends.' (*QDS* 33)

This passage raises three questions. Precisely who is the friend of God with whom the wealthy believer is to cultivate a friendship? How does the wealthy believer cultivate a friendship with this friend of God? And what does this have to do with Clement's insistence that the wealthy believer acquire his own remission?

All of these questions are closely related. Rich men and those in power are thought especially to require friends, since what would be the good of their prosperity without an outlet for beneficence, which is displayed in its fullest form towards friends?[17] Having a surplus of wealth, the rich believer is in an ideal position to distribute his possessions in such a way as to obligate the recipient to reciprocate with a like benefit. Clement couches friendship-making in commercial terms: 'What splendid trading! What divine business! You buy incorruption with money' (*QDS* 32). There is no trace of queasiness over such an apparently unsavoury notion. The idea of acquiring one's own remission by using money to initiate friendships ostensibly had scriptural support: 'Make to yourselves friends from the mammon of unrighteousness,' commands the Saviour (Lk 16.9). Mutual obligations, reciprocity in gift-giving, the presence of goodwill, a relationship conducted over a long period of time are all necessary elements which constituted friendship in antiquity. Granted, Clement depicts an unequal friendship: the friend of God possesses a vastly higher status in the relationship in being able to give the rich believer something that is truly good (namely, salvation), while the rich believer is only able to benefit with something merely useful (namely, money).

[17] Aristotle, *NE* 8.1.

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Identity of the Friend of God

Identifying a friend of God among the believers of the community is no easy task, especially for someone who is as morally bereft as the wealthy believer, lacking any spiritual insight[18]. Clement exhorts the rich person to distribute his wealth as broadly as possible, without trying to discern the merit of any poor member of the community. In doing this the rich believer stacks the odds on his side. By giving freely to all in turn who need, the rich believer can be absolutely certain to find one of those who has power to save him with God[19].

The idea of the wealthy giving alms to the poor and the poor, being in a privileged spiritual position, interceding on the rich believer's behalf before God is hardly new. The privileged religious status of the poor is certainly present in the epistle of James[20], but it is from the *Shepherd* that Clement borrows several of his major ideas:

> The rich man has much wealth, but he is poor as touching the Lord, being busied about his riches, and his intercession and confession is weak and small, and has no other power. But when the rich man rests upon the poor, and gives him what he needs, he believes that what he does to the poor man can find a reward with God, because the poor is rich in intercession and confession, and his intercession has great power with God. (*Sim.* 2.5)

I wish to propose, however, that Clement in *QDS* does not follow the *Shepherd* completely. Clement does not share the belief that the poor man is rich in intercession *qua* poor man. Rather, he has translated the merits and attributes of the advanced Christian, the true gnostic, onto the faithful poor in the community[21]. Certainly, the faithful poor individual might have one or two attributes of the true gnostic (one may be able to beg the rich man's life before God, another may be able to hearten the rich man when he is sick, and so forth), but it is only in the true gnostic, the man of God, that all of these attributes are present in the one person[22]. Clement's aim is to overstate the attributes of the faithful poor to make them more attractive for the wealthy believer to support. Ultimately, however, it is the advanced Christian, the man of God, whom Clement urges the rich believer to enlist as an ambassador before God and to submit to as his spiritual trainer[23].

[18] In contrast, the true Gnostic has the power of discriminating potential beneficiaries according to desert. Cf. *Str.* 7.12.

[19] *QDS* 33.

[20] Ja 1.9; 2.5.

[21] In *QDS* 36 Clement, after lauding the individual merits of the faithful poor, introduces those 'more elect than the elect'. After this point in the treatise Clement stresses the need for the wealthy to enlist the services of an elite individual, a man of God (*QDS* 41), rather than an army of the pious poor (*QDS* 35).

[22] Compare the attributes of the man of God in *QDS* 41 with those of the many faithful in *QDS* 35.

[23] 'Let him spend many wakeful nights on your behalf, acting as your ambassador with God and moving the Father by the spell of constant supplications; for [God] does not withstand his children when they beg his mercies' (*QDS* 41.5-6).

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Conclusion

Clement's pastoral remedy for the wealthy sinner in *QDS* represents a highly idiosyncratic adaptation of the notion of second repentance from the *Shepherd*. Clement's idea of a sincere repentance infers that the wealthy believer is in no position to plead before God directly, but rather must acquire his own remission by distributing his superfluous wealth to the poor in the community and by submitting to an advanced Christian to act as his spiritual trainer and advocate before God. The relationship between wealthy believer and man of God is couched in Graeco-Roman friendship terms, yet it is the man of God who is in the ascendant position of patron, who acts as the mediator of the Father's benefits (that is, remission of sins). The wealthy believer is in the spiritually inferior position of client, never being able to requite benefits of equal measure, and the one on whom rests the onus for establishing and maintaining the relationship in the first place.

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Insights and Oversights in Origen's Reading of Romans 4:1-8

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Origen's commentary on Romans 4:1-8 (*Com Rm* IV 1) was singled out by Melanchthon for critical animadversions at the height of the Reformation controversy on justification by faith[1]. He believed Origen to be tone deaf to the Pauline kerygma of grace, due largely to the Platonist mentality that had shaped Christian thinking from early on. The chief bone of contention is Origen's importation of justification by works into a text designed to exclude it. 'The proof of true faith is that sin is not being committed ... For this reason then it is also said of Abraham in another passage of Scripture [James 2:21-24] that he was justified by the works of faith' (*S* 239; *B* 273). Melanchthon resolves the contradiction between James and Paul by admitting works only as a sequel on justifying faith, which play no role in justification itself. Origen resolves it by seeing Abraham's works as dependent on grace just as is the initial act of faith, itself interpreted as a commitment to works of righteousness.

Origen begins by talking of 'two justifications', *duo dikaiôseis* (corresponding to the 'law of faith' – which 'excludes boasting' – and the 'law of works' respectively (Rom. 3:27)). Abraham is justified by faith rather than by works (*ek pisteôs mallon edikaiôthê huper ex ergôn* [*H* VI 118]), but the two kinds of justification are in contrast rather than in opposition, and others can be justified by works even if Abraham is not: 'it can come to pass for the person who hopes for the justification by works that his works may be approved by men as well' (*S* 238; *B* 271). The 'as well' (*etiam*) indicates that works win divine approval – but not, it seems, final salvation if unaccompanied by faith.

What distinguishes faith is that it wins approval from God alone and not from others as well. This shift from the idea that *only* justification by faith allows one to have glory before God to the claim that it allows one to have glory before God *alone* is provided with a rational basis that further blurs the contours of the Pauline argument: God alone can see our 'disposition of faith', hidden in the heart. Origen derives the contrast from Paul (Rom. 2:16, 28-29),

[1] The text is extant in Rufinus' translation and in fragments of the original. *H* = Theresia Heither (ed.), *Origenes: Commentarii in Epistulam ad Romanos*, 6 vols, Fontes Christiani (Freiburg: Herder, 1991-96); *S* = Thomas P. Scheck (tr.), *Origen: Commentary on the Epistle to the Romans*, vol. 1, FC 103 (Washington' CUA Press, 2001); *B* = Caroline Hammond Bammel (ed.), *Der Römerbriefkommentar des Origenes*, vol. 2, Aus der Geschichte der lateinischen Bibel 33 (Freiburg: Herder, 1996).

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but develops it according to a Platonic opposition of outer and inner[2]. He quotes Dt. 29:29 to confirm a Platonic hierarchy between the inner virtue of faith and the external realm of works: 'the secret things belong to the Lord your God, but what is manifested is for you and your sons' (*S* 238). Justification by works is of a lower order because it is more external. It is mediated by saints 'who receive authority from God for passing judgment upon visible human works' or angels 'who are certainly able to glorify the one whose works they have approved' (*S* 239; *B* 271-2)[3].

A common-sense objection to justification *sola fide* further impedes Origen's access to Paul. He alludes to 2 Cor. 6:14 (also in *Com Rm* IV 7; *Com Jn* XIX 21; *Hom Lev* 12.3) to stress that faith and unrighteousness cannot coexist: 'for there is no common ground between faith and infidelity; there is no communion of righteousness with wickedness, just as light can have no fellowship with darkness' (*S* 239; *B* 272). This excludes any dynamic of *simul iustus ac peccator*. Instead, Origen makes elsewhere the rather unsatisfactory concession that most people are *nec iustus nec peccator* (*Hom Ex* 2.3) but something in between (*Hom Gen* 5.1; 3; *Hom Lev* 8.11)[4].

Origen states that Abraham had shown faith on many other occasions than that referred to in Rom. 4:3 (= Gen. 15:6). In the other situations his faith was *ex parte*, but now he shows *fides perfecta* (*B* 275, alluding to 1 Cor. 13:10). His partial acts of faith are summed up and surpassed in this act of perfect faith. Lk. 17:5 and 1 Cor. 13:2 show that faith has greater and lesser degrees. Subjected to quantitative measure, faith begins to look like a work that can be

[2] Heither claims that 'Origen understands Paul from the Jewish way of thinking that sees no opposition between faith and works' (*H* II, 160-1). That would be a strange way for Origen to save Paul from himself, given that the opposition is one of the keystones of the Pauline dialectic, especially at this point in Romans.

[3] Peter Gorday writes, 'Origen softens the polarization in Rom 4, because he senses that Abraham is being presented by Paul not so much in terms of a radical contrast (righteousness by faith vs. righteousness by works) but as a synthesizing and mediating figure' (*Principles of Patristic Exegesis: Romans 9-11 in Origen, John Chrysostom, and Augustine* [New York: Edwin Mellen, 1983], p. 207). But Paul sets up the idea of Abraham being justified by works as something to be refuted and presents him not as a figure synthesizing two kinds of righteousness, but as an example of righteousness by faith alone. Origen's harmonizing disposition is the constant source of the missed insights in his commentary. One might say that the opposition of faith and works in Rom. 4:1-8 is a simplistic moment in Paul's polemic, and that Origen corrects local twists and turns of Paul's dialectic in the light of the full Pauline vision. But Origen's comprehensive understanding of Romans as proclaiming a *translatio religionis* from a regime of carnal types and shadows to one of spiritual truth, while it captures the social context of the epistle, missed by Melanchthon, subjects the relation of the Testaments to a distorting Platonic paradigm. If this vision guides Origen whenever he smoothens out anfractuosities in the text, it is as productive of blindness as of insight.

[4] The same point is backed up by the claim in 1 John that to believe Jesus is the Christ is to be born of God and that the one born of God does not sin (*B* 272-3). The harmonizing importation of Johannine Christology blurs Paul's concern with faith as trust, *fiducia*. Paul attributes no Christological content to Abraham's faith, and Johannine sinlessness is also in tension with Paul.

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performed more or less well. The less perfect faith of others, such as the Israelites in Ex. 14:31, failed to justify, whereas Abraham had 'the perfection of faith, collected together from many parts into one whole, which deserved to be reckoned as righteousness' (*S* 242; *B* 277).

Origen proposes that all he has said of faith could apply as well to other virtues: mercy could be 'reckoned for righteousness, or wisdom or knowledge or gentleness or humility' (*S* 242; *B* 276). Melanchthon protests against the idea that faith is merely a synecdoche for all the other virtues (*fide sumus iusti, id est, perfecta fide complectente omnes virtutes*), though this is not explicitly stated by Origen. In the idea that other virtues could equally play the justifying role he finds the 'smoking gun' that convicts Origen of Pelagianism:

Hoc nihil aliud est dicere, quam homines propter opera et propter virtutes suas habere remissionem peccatorum et iustos esse. Cumque non attendat, quid agat Paulus, quid vocet fidem, quid sibi velit illa exclusiva: Non ex operibus, addit enarrationes confusas et perplexas, nec sibi constat. (*Corpus Reformatorum* 15, 749)

Origen does tend to conflate justification and sanctification, and to conflate sanctification and works[5]. But this works both ways – if he tends to make faith a work, he also gives works the graced character of faith. The link of faith with grace and works with due reward in Rom. 4:4 is taken as referring only to evil works. Good works are not in tension with faith, but are rooted in the grace of justification which they bring to fruition. In Philonic vein, Origen points out that all our works are gifts of grace, and since God provides the capital he can hardly be asked to reward our works as of due (*B* 277). For Philo, even ordinary perception and thought are impossible unless God opens up the senses: 'it is God who showers conceptions on the mind and perceptions on sense, and what comes into being is no gift of any part of ourselves, but all are bestowed by him, through whom we too have been made' (*De Cherubim* 127; cf. Prov. 20:12).

The faith that justifies is a moral change of outlook that comes before justification and earns it – in the sense of winning God's favour: *Dikaioi oun ton asebê dia tês pisteôs metathemenon apo tês asebeias hôste logizesthai tên metatheisan auton apo tês asebeias pistin eis dikaiosunên* (*H* VI 126). The faith of the good thief is portrayed as a perfect work: 'faith cannot be reckoned as righteousness to one who believes in part, but only to him who believes completely and perfectly,' and if it justifies the ungodly it is only after he turns aside from ungodliness and in order that 'he would no longer be ungodly' (*S* 244; *B* 279).

[5] The Greek text points out that one cannot have the perfect faith that moves mountains (1 Cor. 13:2) without having love (*H* VI, 122). Gottfried Beck exaggerates the import of this: 'Paul points clearly to the origin of faith in love. Love first enables faith' (*Das Werk Christi bei Origenes: Zur Deutung paulinischer Theologie im Turapapyrus des Römerbrief-Kommentars* [Diss., Bonn, 1966], pp. 57-8).

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Paul's quotation of Ps. 31:1-2 in Rom. 4:6-8 is read in this sense. Since it is impossible that in one who has reached the age of reason there be neither righteousness nor unrighteousness,

> no soul can be found without one of the two dwelling in it; and it is certain that if that [soul] should desist from evil, it would then be found in the good. But that soul is not in evil "whose iniquities are forgiven..." It is therefore logical that it is in the good. (*S* 245; *B* 279-80)

Again no room is left for any *simul iustus et peccator*, nor is the righteousness of the justified sinner grasped as an external righteousness, a righteousness granted by Christ rather than possessed by the soul as its own. Origen frequently refers to the attainment of the age of reason in discussions of the soul's knowledge of sin and righteousness, in a way that cuts athwart the concerns of biblical texts. The logical argument advanced here is not close to Pauline thinking.

But then Origen makes a statement that comes close to the heart of the Protestant vision of Paul and that Melanchthon singles out as *tolerabile dictum*, even if *id postea mox corrumpit* (*CR* 15, 749): justifying faith

> is firmly embedded in the soil of the soul like a root that has received rain, so that when it begins to be cultivated by God's law, branches arise from it, which bring forth the fruit of works. The root of righteousness, therefore, does not grow out of the works, but rather the fruit of works grows out of the root of righteousness. (*S* 245; *B* 280)

This lucid text momentarily unites Paul, Origen, Melanchthon, Catholicism, and Protestantism in a blessed accord (see *S* 45). The good thief's confession of faith (without works) associates him to Christ, the tree of life, embodying all righteousness and virtue (cf. V 9; *S* 364).

However, when Origen says *dikaiosunên autô logizesthai chôris ergôn* (*H* VI 126), he means only without the works that will be done and that must be done for the justification to be retained. Justification without works is a temporary, paradoxical situation, not the basic situation of the Christian, as it is for Paul. As he continues, we see what Melanchthon meant when he said *id postea mox corrumpit*:

> Because the starting point of a soul's conversion is to abandon evil, on account of its doing so it would merit the forgiveness of iniquities. But when it begins to do good, as if covering over each of the evils it has previously committed with later good actions and introducing a quantity of goods more numerous than the evils which had existed, it may be said to cover its sins. (*S* 246)

Saving faith has become a moral resolution to abandon evil, and despite the grace of forgiveness, it is not the Lord who covers the soul's sins but its own good deeds, quantitatively matching the sins!

Origen continues in the vein of celebrating moral achievement with little stress on dependence on grace:

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But when a [soul] would henceforth reach perfection so that every root of evil is completely cut off from it to the point that no trace of evil can be found in it, at that point the summit of blessedness is promised to the one to whom the Lord would be able to impute no sin. (*S* 246)

Paul's doctrine of forgiveness is changed into an eschatological promise of the blessings of final perfection, when the Lord can impute no sin since the soul has in fact freed itself from sin. 'Progressive overcoming of evil is progressive conquest of freedom, is self-realization. God wills that the being endowed with mind should move itself to the goal through itself, and therefore gives it freedom'[6]. That may not be 'Pelagianism', but it surely occludes the point that Paul is stressing in citing the Psalm verses.

The Reformers' questions are not the only ones to be put to patristic texts, and those questions can themselves be questioned in turn. But they remain thus far the most stimulating catalyst of a critical reading of patristic texts, seen as 'a product of the Greek mind on the soil of the Gospel' in Harnack's famous phrase. This critical reading attends to the tensions in patristic writing between conflicting forms of thought. Thus in these few pages of Origen we see how conventional moralism and common sense, philosophical reflection on ethical growth, Platonic dualism of internal and external, a Philonic doctrine of grace, a harmonizing quest to make scripture consistent with itself jostle against one another and against the equally complex thinking behind the Pauline text to generate a web of insights that often entail oversights, inviting contemporary readers to learn from both as they cut their own path to the matter at stake[7].

[6] Theresia Heither, *Translatio Religionis: Die Paulusdeutung des Origenes in seinem Kommentar zum Römerbrief* (Köln: Böhlau, 1990), p. 202.

[7] For a close study of these texts, see now Thomas P. Scheck, 'Justification by Faith Alone in Origen's *Commentary on Romans* and its Reception during the Reformation Era,' *Origeniana Octava* (Leuven: Peeters, 2004), pp. 1277-1288. He sees Origen as endorsed by the Council of Trent. But it may be that the Augustinian edge to Trent's teaching brings it closer to the Reformers than to Origen, closer, that is, to the recognition that initial dependence on unmerited justification is not a passing paradoxical moment but the continuing core of the believer's relation to God in Christ.

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L'éthique de Clément et les philosophies grecques

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Mon étude a comme but de déterminer la portée historique de l'influence que la philosophie grecque a exercée sur Clément dans le domaine précis de l'éthique.

Ce choix s'impose d'une part par le fait que, dans le domaine éthique, la relation entre Clément et la philosophie (ou les philosophies) ne va pas sans difficultés[1]. Et d'autre part, si nombreuses ont été les études qui ont déjà traité des rapports entre Clément et la philosophie[2], plus rares ont été celles qui ont mis en évidence la portée historique d'un tel rapprochement. D'une façon générale, lorsqu'on réfléchit sur les apports multiples de la philosophie grecque dans l'œuvre de Clément, on en conclut qu'il s'agit d'un auteur éclectique, qui touche à toutes les 'doctrines' pour choisir ici et là des éléments utiles à la construction de son propre enseignement 'chrétien', mais qui finit soit par helléniser celui-ci (Harnack, Lilla)[3], soit par falsifier la philosophie grecque (Meifort)[4].

Une toute autre lecture de la manière dont Clément exploite la philosophie grecque est proposée par Martin Grabmann dans un ouvrage assez ancien, mais encore très important: *Die Geschichte der scholastische Methode*[5]. Persuadé que la force motrice animant tout le mouvement philosophique et théologique des époques patristique et médiévale fut le souci de trouver une

[1] Vers la fin des années '50, E. Osborn (*The Philosophy of Clement of Alexandria* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1957), pp. 95 ss.), attirait l'attention des lecteurs sur la diversité des doctrines éthiques proposée par Clément dans son œuvre et il montrait que cette diversité n'avait jamais été justifiée.

[2] Au cours des années '70/80, trois autres études s'efforcent d'éclairer la difficulté. En 1971, celui de Salvatore Lilla (*Clement of Alexandria. A Study in a Christian Platonism and Gnosticism*, Oxford, Oxford University Press); en 1977, celui d' Elizabeth Clark (*Clement's Use of Aristotle: The Aristotelian Contribution to Clement of Alexandria's Refutation of Gnosticism* (New York: Mellen Press)) et en 1983, celui de D. Wyrwa (*Die christliche Platonaneignung in den Stromateis des Clemens von Alexandrien* (Berlin: De Gruyter)). Malgré leurs incontestables mérites pour le développement des recherches concernant les sources de Clément, ces travaux ont tous le défaut de ne pas s'intéresser au fait que Clément a toujours exploité plusieurs sources pour construire sa pensée.

[3] Cf. A. Von Harnack, *Lehrbuch des Dogmengeschichte*, 4° éd., Bd. 1 (Darmastad, 1964 (Tübingen, 1909), p. 643, 647 ss.; S. Lilla, *Clement of Alexandria*, p. 1-8, 227-34.

[4] Cf. J. Meifort, '*Der Platonismus bei Clemens Alexandrinus*', Heidelberger Abhandlungen zur Philosophie und ihrer Geschichte 17 (Tübingen, 1928).

[5] Fribourg en Brisgau: Herder, 1909-11 (dernière rééimp. Berlin: Akademie-Verlag, 1988).

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méthode capable de réconcilier la *ratio* avec *l'auctoritas* tout en respectant les lois propres à ces deux domaines, le célèbre historien de la philosophie médiévale affirme que l'intention de Clément dans son œuvre est de faire cohabiter philosophie et parole révélée, foi et raison, et que, à cette fin, le maître d'Alexandrie met au point une méthode très originale, basée sur la dialectique entre raison et révélation qui s'interrogent l'une l'autre d'une manière rigoureuse en vue de découvrir la vérité. Grabmann place alors Clément parmi les premiers représentants de ce mouvement qu'il nomme 'scolastique', et il voit dans sa manière de travailler une anticipation de la méthode anselmienne du *fides quaerens intellectum*.

L'hypothèse de Grabmann est intéressante parce qu'elle rend justice à l'une des caractéristiques fondamentales de Clément: la conscience des capacités de la raison et la conviction qu'entre celle-ci et l'autorité de la révélation il n'y a pas opposition mais complémentarité. Clément sait que la vérité est une même si, au fil du temps, elle a été fragmentée et partagée en mille morceaux[6]. Il sait aussi que toute doctrine venant du passé est porteuse d'un brin de vérité et qu'il faut donc l'accueillir comme telle. La tâche du savant est justement celle de rétablir cette vérité dans son unité originaire, en recomposant les différents morceaux en lesquels elle a été fragmentée comme on reconstruit un puzzle. Pour réussir dans ce travail, le dessin est fourni par le *Logos*, lequel est cette même vérité, enracinée déjà dans l'ordre naturel des choses (la *physikê akolouthia*), tandis que la force pour le réaliser vient de l'intelligence humaine, lorsqu'elle est instruite et préparée à cet effet par le *Logos* lui-même[7].

L'œuvre de Clément représente la mise en pratique de ce projet, et il faut voir en elle la tentative de réaliser une synthèse capable d'accueillir les apports venant du passé en montrant que chacun, dans ses différences avec les autres, lorsqu'il est interprété par une intelligence éclairée par la vérité elle-même (à savoir le *Logos*), contribue à la reconstruction de la vérité totale et, en cela, trouve son accomplissement.

Mon étude souhaite illustrer, sur quelques points de son enseignement moral, les caractéristiques de cette méthode que, d'après M. Grabmann, Clément aurait mi au point et exploité.

1. La question du bonheur

Le discours sur le Bien et sur le bonheur occupe une place de premier ordre dans l'éthique de Clément.

[6] Cf. *Stromates* I.57.1-6. Toute l'introduction au premier livre des *Stromates* dit aussi cela très clairement.

[7] Cf. *Stromates* I.57.1-6.

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En *Stromates* VII, par exemple[8], proposant un portrait du vrai gnostique, Clément le décrit comme l'homme le plus parfait, le plus impassible face aux circonstances de la vie, le plus doué de charité. Grâce à l'exercice et à l'engagement de son intelligence et de sa volonté, il a atteint au plus haut degré possible la ressemblance avec Dieu et, par conséquent, l'amitié avec Lui. Uni à Dieu de cette manière, il transforme sa foi en charité et en espérance et il ne peut plus être troublé. Vivant en paix et en pleine liberté, Clément laisse entendre qu'il doit être le plus heureux de tous.

Pour Clément, donc, la vie bienheureuse dépend à la fois d'une activité théorique, la contemplation du Bien et l'assimilation à Dieu, et d'une activité pratique, l'exercice de la vertu. Pour accéder à l'*eudaimonia* il faut deux niveaux différents, mais complémentaires, d'actualisation de l'existence: le niveau théorique (car il faut tout d'abord savoir ce qui est Bien), et le niveau pratique (car il faut réaliser dans l'action ce qu'on sait être le Bien).

Même si dans cette définition de la vie bienheureuse Clément dépend fortement d'Aristote[9], d'autres définitions proposées par lui témoignent qu'il n'oublie pas les autres idéaux de vie bienheureuse proposés par les philosophes grecs (par exemple l'idéal platonicien de l'*homoiôsis theô* et celui du *vivre suivant la nature* d'origine stoïcienne).

En *Stromates* II.131.4-5, par exemple, Clément reprend la définition classique de la vie bienheureuse comme résultat de l'*homoiôsis theô* qui était encore d'actualité dans la tradition platonicienne: il l'attribue à Platon en affirmant que, pour le philosophe athénien, la vie bienheureuse, qui correspond à la bonne position du *démon* dans l'âme (*eudaimonia*), s'obtient lorsque la partie rationnelle de l'âme est bien disposée et que l'harmonie règne en celle-ci: *démon* indique en effet la partie directrice de notre âme[10].

Mais, tout en suivant Platon lorsque celui-ci affirme que la perfection de la vertu est directement associée à la vie bienheureuse et à la science du Bien, l'une et l'autre étant des aspects de l'assimilation à Dieu comprise comme devenir juste et saint avec intelligence[11], Clément 'oublie' que l'*homoiôsis theô* platonicienne était inaccessible à l'homme, même vertueux, tant qu'il est en vie. L'idéal platonicien est alors compris comme la possibilité d'acquérir un état stable de perfection déjà en cette vie. L'*homoiôsis theô* devient ainsi un but en tout comparable à celui stoïcien de l'*apatheia* et à celui, plus chrétien, de la paix de l'homme de bonne volonté[12].

[8] Cf. *Stromates* VII, Chapitre XI.60.1 - 68.5, surtout: 60.2-4; 62.7 - 63.1; 64.4-7; 67.4-7. Ce dernier passage est très aristotélicien.

[9] Cf. E. Clark, *Clements Use of Aristotle*, p. 27-44.

[10] Pour le texte complet, cf. 131.2-133.3

[11] Cf. *Rép.* X, 613 ab; *Théét.* 176 b.

[12] Cf. *Stromates* VII.84.2 et VII.64.4. Mais l' ἀπάθεια acquiert chez Clément une connotation moins intellectuelle et plus morale: elle signifie en effet plus l'absence de péché qu'une attitude raisonnable.

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Et ce n'est pas tout, car Clément identifie l'idéal platonicien de l'assimilation à Dieu à la pratique de la justice et de la loi, c'est-à-dire à la réalisation de l'harmonie entre les impulsions et la raison[13]. Et la loi n'est plus, comme chez Platon, seulement la norme qui permet à l'homme d'obtenir une attitude mesurée ainsi que la maîtrise de soi[14]; pour Clément, loi et *Logos* coïncident. Après l'incarnation de celui-ci, suivre la loi correspondra donc à suivre le Logos.

En montrant que déjà pour Platon l'*homoiôsis theô* impliquait l'observance de la loi, mais en interprétant le fait de suivre la loi comme une suite du *Logos*, Clément parvient ainsi de nouveau à construire une synthèse qui réunit la tradition stoïcienne et platonicienne autour de l'idéal chrétien de la suite du Verbe de Dieu.

Que Clément soit d'ailleurs très intéressé à lier la définition platonicienne et stoïcienne d'*eudaimonia* se voit clairement aussi en *Stromates* II.100.3 - 101.1 où notre auteur s'efforce de prouver que l'*homoiôsis theô* platonicienne correspond à l'idéal stoïcien du vivre en accord avec la nature (τῷ ἀκολούθως φύσει ζῆν). En passant encore une fois par la référence à la loi et par la règle du respect de l'*akolouthia*, cette 'cohérence' existant entre toutes les choses qui est voulue par le *Logos* lui-même[15], notre auteur parvient à montrer que, devenir semblable à Dieu correspond de fait à suivre le *Logos*, Fils de Dieu. De nouveau, Clément trouve le moyen d'établir un accord entre l'Académie et le Portique en faisant référence au *Logos*.

La doctrine stoïcienne du τῷ ἀκολούθως φύσει ζῆν reçoit à son tour une interprétation particulière. En *Stromates* II.129.1, 4, Clément explique que, pour les Stoïciens[16], l'*eudaimonia* correspond au fait de vivre en conformité avec la vertu et avec la loi de la nature, c'est-à-dire de vivre suivant le logos (*eulogistein*). Citant finalement la position de Posidonius, Clément constate que, chez les Stoïciens aussi, l'idéal de l'*eudaimonia* peut être compris comme le fait de vivre en contemplant la vérité dans l'univers et de travailler à l'implanter autant que possible dans la vie, sans se laisser mener par la partie irrationnelle de l'âme. Cette définition, qui identifie pratiquement l'idéal du vivre conformément à la nature avec celui de la contemplation de la vérité et de l'implantation de cette même vérité dans l'ordre pratique, convient très bien à Clément. Elle permet en effet de joindre le τῷ ἀκολούθως φύσει ζῆν des Stoïciens, non seulement à celui, platonicien, de l'*homoiôsis theô*, mais aussi à l'idéal aristotélicien du bonheur conçu à la fois comme fruit de l'exercice de la vertu et de la vie contemplative. Ce qui semble plaire à Clément dans la définition de Posidonius, c'est donc surtout

[13] Cf. *Stromates* II.132.1-3 s. Sur la même thématique, cf. aussi *Stromates* I.165.1 ss. où Clément opère une comparaison entre Platon philosophe et législateur, et Moïse, législateur du peuple d'Israel.

[14] Cf. *Stromates* I.166.4-5.

[15] La valeur du terme d'*akolouthia* dans la pensée de Clément est étudiée plus loin.

[16] Il s'agit essentiellement de Zénon et de Cléanthe.

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l'association que celui-ci opère entre la dimension théorique et la dimension pratique du bonheur, parce qu'elle correspond parfaitement à celle qu'il veut défendre aussi.

La référence à la dimension pratique de la vie bienheureuse, Clément la doit surtout à Aristote. Notre auteur le reconnaît lui-même ouvertement en *Stromates* II.128.3-5, où il affirme que le Stagirite a identifié l'*eudaimonia* avec le fait de vivre suivant la vertu et de posséder les conditions extérieures et intérieures favorables à son acquisition tant pour l'âme que pour le corps[17]. *Stromates* II.34.1 et *Stromates* IV.166.1 confirment l'impression que Clément maîtrise l'enseignement d'Aristote à propos de la vie bienheureuse, car il y fait explicitement référence[18]. Fort de la connaissance qu'il en possède, Clément exploite cette doctrine éthique d'Aristote de manière à la rendre compatible avec le canon de sa foi. En *Pédagogue* II.102.3, par exemple, étant occupé à donner des conseils relatifs à la continence, il cite l'enseignement du Stagirite concernant les biens extérieurs et implicitement il laisse comprendre que celui-ci a eu raison d'affirmer le lien étroit qui les lie au bonheur, car Dieu lui-même s'est préoccupé d'habiller les lys des champs et de nourrir les oiseaux du ciel (*Luc* 12, 22-24).

En accueillant plusieurs sources philosophiques à propos de la doctrine de l'*eudaimonia*, en les interprétant de manière à pouvoir les combiner les unes avec les autres, et en les harmonisant avec la notion chrétienne du *telos* de la vie humaine, Clément parvient finalement à une nouvelle définition de vie bienheureuse marquée à la fois par l'idéal philosophique de l'*homoiôsis theô* et par l'idéal chrétien de la suite du *Logos*. Cela permet à l'idéal philosophique de perdre son caractère mystique et abstrait, qui souvent posait problème, et à l'idéal chrétien de se voir soutenu par une tradition ancienne qui faisait autorité.

Le contexte de *Stromates* II.134.1-2 confirme d'ailleurs cette interprétation. Exposant finalement sa propre doctrine du bonheur, Clément lie l'idée de l'acquisition de la ressemblance (exposée déjà par Platon) à celle d'une vie vécue en conformité avec la raison, le *logos* (proposées à la fois, bien que d'une manière différente, par Aristote et les Stoïciens) et il associe les deux à la notion d'obéissance aux commandements et à celle de l'acquisition de l'adoption filiale avec Dieu, dont la provenance biblique est évidente.

[17] Clément cite ici *Éthique à Nicomaque* I.10, 1100 a ss. I.6, 1098 a 15 ss. et VII.14, 1153 b 15 ss.

[18] Clément cite ici la doctrine aristotélicienne dite 'des trois biens (corporels, matériels et spirituels)' qu'Aristote expose en *Éthique à Nicomaque* I.8, 1098 b 12 - 1099 b 10 et la fait sienne. L'ancienne Stoà l'avait refusée, en proposant la notion de biens indifférents (*SVF* III.97 a; I.191-196; III.119), tandis que les moyens Stoïciens, comme Panétius ou Posidonius, l'avaient finalement accueillie (Arius Didymus, *In Stob. ecl.* II.123-125 Wachsmuth). Clément semble l'utiliser surtout en fonction antignostique: *Stromates* IV.17.4; IV.163.1 ss.; *Stromates* II.137.1 - 143.1; *Stromates* IV.89.1 - 94.4.

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Il devient alors clair que Clément cherche à réunir toutes les traditions philosophiques pour montrer comment chacune d'entre elles s'est efforcée d'indiquer dans la suite du Logos le véritable *telos* de la vie humaine. La 'philosophie barbare' a d'ailleurs suivi le même chemin, en montrant en plus que ce même *Logos* est une personne à suivre.

2. La notion de vertu

Dans le chemin qui mène au bonheur, la vertu occupe pour Clément une place centrale. Pour l'homme 'véritablement gnostique', la vertu est en effet un *habitus*, donc un état stable de l'existence[19] qui, devenant parfait, embellit l'âme de celui qui la possède[20].

La définition de cette vertu nous la trouvons, par exemple, à la fin du premier livre du *Pédagogue*[21]. En affirmant que tout acte contraire au Logos droit est une faute, Clément définit la vertu comme une 'disposition de l'âme qui s'accorde bien au *Logos* dans la vie tout entière'. Reprenant une idée stoïcienne, Clément montre ainsi que la vertu chrétienne correspond à une disposition qui s'accomplit en un double mouvement: tout d'abord, celui de soumission des différentes parties de l'âme à la partie raisonnable, logique, de celle-ci, et ensuite, celui de soumission de toute l'existence au seul *Logos* qui peut 'sauver' la vie de la destruction, c'est-à-dire le Christ. Le propos est effectivement fort stoïcien[22], mais Clément, en identifiant le *logos* 'raison universelle' avec le *Logos* Fils de Dieu, montre que le deuxième mouvement dans lequel s'accomplit la vertu est essentiellement l'œuvre de la foi. A plusieurs reprises, dans le II livre des *Stromates*, Clément définit d'ailleurs la foi comme la mère de toutes le vertus[23]. Et puisque en *Stromates* II.8.2 - 9.7, à l'aide de la logique aristotélicienne et de l'épistémologie stoïcienne, il considère la foi comme une connaissance inébranlable née d'un assentiment 'religieux' donné au *Logos*, alors il est clair que, pour lui, la vertu sera surtout l'acte de suivre et d'imiter le *Logos*, Fils de Dieu.

Cette vertu n'est cependant pas un don de nature[24]. Elle dépend de nous[25] et pour l'obtenir, il faut se soumettre à un enseignement et à un exercice[26]. Seulement alors elle deviendra comme une véritable seconde nature[27].

[19] Cf. *Stromates* IV.139.2; VII.46.1 ss.

[20] Cf. *Stromates* VII.64.6.

[21] Cf. *Pédagogue* I.101.1-2.

[22] Von Arnim l'a d'ailleurs classé parmi les fragments de l'éthique de Chrysippe. Cf. *SVF* III.293.

[23] En *Stromates* II.24.1, par exemple, mais aussi en 31.3, vérifier cette affirmation et regarder si effectivement il s'agit d'un emprunt aristotélicien.

[24] Ces affirmations sont dirigées essentiellement contre les Gnostiques hérétiques: cf. *Stromates* VII.19.3; VI.95.4

[25] Cf. *Stromates* IV.124.1

[26] Cf. *Stromates* VII.47.2

[27] L'homme 'véritablement gnostique' a dû, lui aussi, se soumettre à une discipline, même si, à la fin, l'entraînement est devenu pour lui un simple automatisme (*Stromates* VII.46.9;

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Une autre caractéristique importante de la vertu clémentine est le fait qu'elle s'accompagne toujours de la modération. Pour Clément, la mesure est le propre de la sagesse[28]. La passion est d'ailleurs décrite comme une impulsion démesurée en même temps que comme un mouvement de l'âme contre nature[29].

Or, la référence à la doctrine de la modération se montre à nouveau très significative en ce qui concerne la méthode de travail de Clément. En effet, cette référence est commune aussi bien à la tradition aristotélicienne qu'à la tradition platonicienne, mais elle ne signifie pas la même chose dans l'une ou dans l'autre. Si chez Platon le *metron* est surtout une norme absolue de référence car, en définitive, la mesure ultime est l'Un ou le Bien, chez le Stagirite, au contraire, la mesure est une médiété entre deux extrêmes à déterminer en situation[30]. Clément, quant à lui, trouve ces deux doctrines vraies toutes les deux, et il cherche à les adopter conjointement. Nous voyons alors que, lorsqu'il invite à suivre la raison, il fait allusion à la modération selon la notion aristotélicienne de *mesotès*[31], le propre du comportement raisonnable étant le bon équilibre entre excès et défaut[32]. Lorsqu'au contraire il veut affirmer que Dieu est la mesure de toutes les choses, Lui qui, toujours égal à Lui-même, a créé l'univers suivant la mesure, le nombre et le poids (στάθμιον, μέτρον καὶ ἀριθμόν)[33], Clément pense la mesure à la manière de Platon, comme une norme absolue et transcendante, car Dieu est mesure sans mesure. En ce sens, la mesure devient un principe immanent et transcendant à la fois. Et, de nouveau, Clément surmonte la difficulté de se référer conjointement à deux traditions, apparemment contradictoires, grâce au nouvel éclairage rendu possible par l'enseignement issu de la 'vraie philosophie'. En effet, si la raison est mesure (médiété) entre l'excès et le défaut, c'est parce qu'elle, étant *Logos*, est l''incarnation' de ce Dieu qui est mesure absolue et transcendante. Le choix de pratiquer l'éthique de la modération devient donc compatible avec la proposition de l'idéal de l'assimilation à un Dieu qui est mesure sans mesure de toutes les choses. En reprenant l'éthique de la modération d'origine aristotélicienne et platonicienne à la fois, Clément veut montrer à quel point la moralité chré-

VII.64.4-7). En ce sens, la vertu est accessible à tout le monde, même aux moins fortunés (*Stromates* I.34.4)

[28] Cf. *Stromates* I.36.1. Si d'ailleurs, comme nous avons vu, on peut jouir aussi des biens corporels et des biens extérieurs, c'est justement parce qu'on peut leur imposer mesure et temps (*Pédagogue* II.46.1).

[29] Cf. *Stromates* II.59.6

[30] Cf. *Éthique à Nicomaque* II.6-9, 1106 a 26 - 1109 b 26.

[31] Le juste milieu, pour Aristote est tantôt une médiété, tantôt un sommet (*Éthique à Nicomaque* II.6, 1107 e 7-8), et il est toujours fixé en relation aux circonstances et par rapport à nous (cf. *Éthique à Nicomaque* II.5, 1106 a 32). Clément reprend la version aristotélicienne de la médiété: cf. *Pédagogue* II.11.4; II.16.2; III.51.2; *Stromates* II.59.6.

[32] Nous constatons cela surtout dans les préceptes de vie pratique proposés par Clément à ses disciples dans le *Pédagogue*.

[33] Cf. *Protreptique* 69,1-2.

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tienne ne fait qu'accomplir, dans la suite du *Logos*, ce que Platon et Aristote avaient déjà enseigné, chacun à sa manière.

Mais la méthode de Clément montre encore mieux ses caractéristiques et son efficacité là où elle rencontre les problèmes que la philosophie grecque n'avait pas été en mesure de surmonter. J'en montrerai un seul exemple.

Il s'agit de la question de savoir si la vertu se situe au bout du chemin qui conduit jusqu'à l'éradication totale des passions (l'*apatheia*) ou de celui qui se limite à apprendre la modération de celles-ci (la *metriopatheia*). Exactement comme dans les autres cas examinés, ici aussi Clément choisit finalement les deux possibilités, les reconnaissant partiellement vraies toutes deux, chacune dans son domaine. D'une part, en effet, il accepte l'éthique de l'*apatheia* et la propose comme le seul chemin qui peut procurer la perfection et la véritable gnose. Dieu en effet est *apathès*[34]. Mais d'autre part, reconnaissant qu'il s'agit d'un idéal qui n'est pas praticable d'une manière absolue, le maître d'Alexandrie propose aussi l'éthique de la *metriopatheia* et il la conseille dans les situations où elle peut être bénéfique[35]. L'idéal de la *metriopatheia* se retrouve donc dans le discours éthique de Clément, malgré le fait que la perfection de l'existence corresponde pour lui à l'éradication de toutes les passions.

En conclusion, nous constatons que, en ce qui concerne la notion de vertu, Clément construit son propre enseignement en réunissant globalement tous les apports venant de la philosophie grecque pour montrer que, chaque doctrine, prise en elle-même, comporte une vérité dont il faut tenir compte. Cette vérité, cependant, est seulement partielle et elle peut être utile seulement lorsqu'on en reconnaît le caractère limité et qu'on la complète avec l'apport d'autres éléments de la tradition.

3. La question de la *phronèsis*

Comme l'on sait, la signification de la notion de *phronèsis* a été très controversée dès l'antiquité. Deux significations différentes, voire opposées, lui étaient en effet attribuées: la première, plus proche du sens que Platon lui avait accordé l'identifiait à une sagesse théorique, ayant comme fonction d'indiquer la connaissance parfaite des choses dans leur vérité; la seconde, plus proche du sens aristotélicien, mais aussi du sens populaire, l'associait à une sagesse pratique capable d'orienter l'homme dans ses choix et dans son action, sans nécessairement la faire correspondre à une science quelconque.

Clément définit la *phronèsis* comme une vertu pratique et théorétique à la fois, étant vraisemblablement influencé par la doctrine de Xénocrate conservée

[34] Cf. *Stromates* VII.13.3; VII.84.2; VI.73.6 - ici c'est le Christ qui est *apathès*; VII.86.5.
[35] Cf. *Stromates* II.39.4.

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par Aristote dans les *Topiques*[36]. En ce sens, Clément cherche à se faire l'héritier de traditions différentes et s'efforce de les réunir toutes, en les rendant compatibles avec l'enseignement de la 'vraie philosophie'.

D'une manière générale, la *phronèsis* est pour notre auteur une sagesse donnée par Dieu, qui rend l'homme intelligent lui permettant d'acquérir la ressemblance avec Lui[37]. En ce sens, elle est une des caractéristiques de l'homme le plus parfait, le 'véritable gnostique', et elle peut être définie comme une qualité 'divine' qui lie l'homme à Dieu[38]. Dans cette signification, la référence principale de Clément est la tradition biblique, et plus précisément celle du *Livre de la Sagesse* et des *Proverbes* où *phronèsis* indique effectivement un don de Dieu qui rend l'homme plus intelligent[39], une *gnôsis* transmise par les prophètes[40] que Dieu fait grandir en l'homme[41] et finalement une des vertus cardinales[42].

Dans d'autres contextes, cependant, Clément identifie la *phronèsis* avec une sagesse pratique accompagnée d'une capacité de s'orienter dans les situations contingentes, de repérer en celles-ci l'ordre et la 'cohérence' 'logiques' (*orthos logos*) et d'agir en conséquence[43]. Cette *phronèsis*, que la philosophie possède en partage, doit guider l'homme dans l'action, et l'ouvrir à la vérité[44].

Lilla a fait remarquer que, dans l'usage de cette notion, Clément dépend fortement des moyens platoniciens lesquels identifiaient aussi la *phronèsis* avec une discipline théorique et pratique à la fois. D'après lui, dans sa dimension théorique, la *phronèsis* de Clément serait une seule et même chose avec la *gnôsis*[45]. Cette interprétation ne me semble pas satisfaisante.

En *Stromates* VI.154.1-4, en effet, Clément associe la *phronèsis* à la *sunesis*[46] en ajoutant que la philosophie grecque la possède en partage. Or, chez le maître d'Alexandrie, *sunesis* signifie une connaissance globale que les hommes (mais aussi les animaux en *Stromates* VI.3.1) peuvent avoir du monde et qui leur permet de s'orienter dans celui-ci. En l'homme, la *sunesis*

[36] Cf. *Stromates* II.24.1; Xenocrates, *Fr.* 7 Heinze = Aristote, *Topiques* VI.3, 141 a 6 ss.

[37] Cf. *Stromates* II.81.1; II.131.5;. II.133.3; II.136.6; IV.140.2; VI.57.1; VI.97.1. On constate ici clairement un lien entre la φρόνησις et l'assimilation à Dieu ainsi qu'elle est présentée dans le *Théét.* 176 b.

[38] Cf. *Stromates* V.72.2; VI.125.4; VI.160.2

[39] Cf. *Protéptique* 100.2; *Pédagogue* I.6.6; I.48.3; II.70.3; II.76.3; *Stromates* I.27.2: cit. de *Prov.* 2, 3-6.

[40] Cf. *Pédagogue* I.91.3 ss.: cit. de *Prov.* 3, 13 et de *Baruch* 4, 4.

[41] Cf. *Pédagogue* III.18.2.

[42] Cf. *Pédagogue* III.64.1; *Stromates* I.97.3; II.78.1-3; II.80.5; VI.95.4; VII.18.2.

[43] Cf. *Stromates* VI.154.1-4.

[44] Ici *Stromates* VI.154.4 ressemble fort à ce que Clément dit en *Stromates* I.177.1 ss. à propos de la dialectique.

[45] Cf. S. Lilla, *Clement of Alexandria*, p. 72-6.

[46] Le même rapprochement nous le trouvons aussi en *Stromates* II.17.3.

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rend possible la recherche de la vérité et la pratique de la justice[47]. Dans le même sens, en *Stromates* I.32.4, Clément définit *sunesis* la philosophie grecque parce qu'elle permet à celui qui la pratique d'approcher la vérité[48]. Et c'est encore en ce sens qu'en *Stromates* II.17.3 la *sunesis* se trouve associée à la foi du chrétien, la *pistis*. *Sunesis, phronèsis* et *pistis* correspondent donc à un niveau comparable d'approche de la vérité lequel consiste en une compréhension globale et concrète du réel que la raison humaine peut atteindre, mais qui n'est pas encore une *gnôsis*.

Stromates VII.66.2 va dans le même sens. Parlant de la vertu du courage, Clément affirme que la *phronèsis* est une *hexis* permettant d'exercer au mieux les vertus[49]. Elle aide en effet à pratiquer toutes les activités d'une manière 'rationnelle', c'est à dire par un choix délibéré et conforme à *l'orthos logos*[50]. En ce sens, Clément présente la *phronèsis* comme une capacité de délibération qui permet à l'homme de suivre le *logos* dans l'action pratique, en orientant celle-ci au bien, ce qui la rend très proche de la notion aristotélicienne décrite dans le livre VI de l' *Éthique à Nicomaque*.

Ceci dit, cependant, suivant sa méthode caractéristique, Clément accueille aussi les autres traditions philosophiques, lesquelles lui permettent d'affirmer que la *phronèsis* est une science théorétique. Cela se voit surtout en *Stromates* VI.154.4, là où *phronèsis* est comprise comme une puissance théorétique capable de distinguer et de réunir les choses qui se tiennent ensemble dans l'*akolouthia* et d'en tenir compte en vue de déterminer ce qui est à faire et à pas faire.

Or, la notion d'*akolouthia* implique, chez Clément, une vision du monde bien particulière, centrée sur la figure du *logos*. Elle suppose la conviction que le monde se tient ensemble comme une totalité organique, dotée d'un ordre nécessaire, qui correspond à la logique suivant laquelle notre intellect organise les concepts[51]. Si le monde est intelligible et la connaissance possible, c'est parce qu'une loi nécessaire, que notre intellect peut découvrir et se représenter, lie ensemble, et à leur place, toutes les choses créées, présentes et futures. L'idée est d'origine stoïcienne, mais Clément la 'christianise' en la modifiant en profondeur. En effet, le *logos* auquel l'*akolouthia* se réfère n'est plus la

[47] Cf. *Stromates* II.76.3: la σύνεσις est 'science des rapports possibles ou bien la détermination de ces rapports, ou bien la capacité d'établir des rapports entre les êtres desquels il y a φρόνησις et ἐπιστήμη'. Posséder la σύνεσις implique alors avoir l'intelligence ou la compréhension d'un secteur particulier du réel, ce qui ne signifie pas nécessairement en posséder une connaissance théorique approfondie.

[48] Cf. *Stromates* I.32.4, et aussi, bien que d'une manière un peu particulière, *Stromates* VI.63.1 et VI.93.1.

[49] Ici il s'agit surtout de la vertu du courage, qui est prise à mode d'exemple.

[50] A ce propos, cf. le commentaire d'A. Le Boulluec en *Clément d'Alexandrie, Stromates VII*, SC 428 (1997), p. 208.

[51] Cf. L. Rizzerio, 'La nozione di ἀκολουθία come "logica della verità" in Clemente di Alessandria', *Rivista di Filosofia Neoscolastica* 79 (1987), 175-95.

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raison universelle, mais bien le Verbe de Dieu 'fait chair'. Or, cela change radicalement la signification très théorique de ce terme. En effet, si le *Logos* est une personne, alors le respect de la 'cohérence' de ce même *logos*, tant dans la nature que dans le langage, coïncidera avec le fait de suivre (*akolouthein*) une personne. Et si *phronimos* est l'homme qui possède les qualités intellectuelles pour reconnaître la 'cohérence' (*akolouthia*) du *logos* dans la nature et qui agit en conséquence, puisque le *logos* est une personne, sa *phronèsis* coïncidera aussi bien avec une connaissance théorique qu'avec l'imitation du Christ et la pratique de son enseignement.

Le rapprochement entre *akolouthia* et *phronèsis* confirme donc que, pour Clément, la *phronèsis* est aussi bien une puissance théorétique qu'une sagesse pratique[52]. Si elle est une *hexis* qui coïncide avec le fait de savoir retrouver partout le *logos* et de s'y conformer en toute activité, elle est aussi une connaissance parce que la suite du *Logos* implique une connaissance préalable (la foi, en effet, est aussi connaissance et demande une certaine connaissance de l'Écriture) et conduit à une connaissance véritable, la *gnôsis*. Le théorique et le pratique, la contemplation et l'action, se trouvent ainsi irréversiblement conjoints dans le même but à atteindre: connaître la vérité et agir en conséquence.

En ce qui concerne la notion de *phronèsis*, on peut donc affirmer que le maître d'Alexandrie, en passant par la tradition chrétienne, a récupéré et intégré les conceptions aristotélicienne et platonicienne de ce terme en les réunissant dans une seule et même définition et en sortant la philosophie grecque d'une impasse[53].

4. L'amitié et la vertu

Clément utilise beaucoup le terme *philia*. Pour lui, ce terme décrit avant tout cette 'amitié de Dieu qui a une nature parfaite et divine'[54] et qui trouve son origine en Dieu lui-même, car Dieu est amour désintéressé et il crée le monde à son image par un acte bienfaisant. Pour Clément, la bienfaisance de Dieu est le moteur de l'amitié véritable laquelle, étant ainsi fondée, engendre naturellement en celui qui la reçoit un état de communion de vie et de biens avec Dieu, et cela même s'il n'y a aucune égalité entre les partenaires. Clément élève ainsi on ne peut plus haut la *philia*, en lui laissant indiquer, au même titre que

[52] Clément la définit parfois comme une δύναμις. Cf. *Stromates* VII.66.2, et Aristote, *MM* I.34, 1197 a 13-14.

[53] Ce qui nous frappe dans cette situation, c'est que la position de Clément est plus originale de celle de ses contemporains, et par exemple de celle qui fut tenue par Alcinoos, qui reste plus fidèle à la tradition platonico–stoïcienne, nous restituant la même définition de *phronèsis* que nous trouvons chez Cicéron. Cf. *Did.* 183 23-24.

[54] Cf. *Stromates* IV.57.1. Ce type d'amitié est inébranlable.

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l'*agapè*, la relation existant entre l'homme et Dieu[55], ce qui représente une véritable nouveauté dans le langage.

Malgré le fait que l'amitié soit d'abord un don de Dieu, l'homme n'est pas passif dans cette relation car, en étant son ami, Dieu l'appelle tout de suite à 'jouer sa partition' et à mettre en action sa liberté. Pour qu'il y ait amitié, dit Clément, en suivant Aristote de près, il faut en effet qu'il y ait ressemblance entre amis. Cette *philia* qui est don de Dieu, exige alors de l'homme un changement radical dans son mode de penser et d'agir. Pour devenir véritablement l'ami de Dieu, l'homme doit en effet dépasser son état naturel, à savoir, pour Clément, son statut de créature constituée à l''image' de Dieu, en vue d'acquérir la véritable ressemblance avec Lui[56]. En *Stromates* VII.57.4-5 Clément parle d'un chemin qui est comme une montée vers le Bien de type platonicien. Pour correspondre à l'amitié, il faut parcourir celui-ci jusqu'à son parfait accomplissement.

Du haut de sa perfection, la vraie amitié se répand sur l'ensemble des hommes amis de Dieu et se transforme immédiatement en charité envers tous. En étant aimé par Dieu d'une manière totale et désintéressée, étant devenu son ami, l'homme est invité à pratiquer la même bienveillance envers ses proches, ses ennemis, voire les pécheurs. Les bénéfices de l'amitié avec Dieu retentissent donc tout naturellement sur les relations humaines qui prennent en effet comme modèle la bienveillance divine.

Cette conception de *philia* est très originale pour la tradition grecque. Pour celle-ci, en effet, l'égalité entre les partenaires était la condition *sine qua non* de l'amitié. Or, dans la *philia* clémentine les partenaires étant l'homme et Dieu, l'amitié se construit à partir d'une évidente inégalité. Mais cette même conception est très originale aussi pour la tradition chrétienne, qui avait banni le terme *philia* du vocabulaire réservé à décrire les relations entre Dieu et l'homme, justement parce qu'elle considérait que l'affection entre l'homme et Dieu ne pouvait pas être comprise comme un amour d'égal à égal.

Clément, habitué à travailler ensemble différentes traditions dans le respect de celles-ci et dans la conviction que toutes contiennent une parcelle de vérité, ne s'arrête pas à cet interdit. Sa toute nouvelle notion de *philia* devient alors très importante pour le développement de l'usage de ce terme en milieu chrétien.

En *Stromates* II.101.3 - 102.1, Clément propose un petit traité sur l'amitié d'inspiration stoïcienne et aristotélicienne. Il y propose une triple définition ou détermination de la φιλία qui est visiblement empruntée à Chrysippe[57]. Aris-

[55] Cf. *Stromates* IV.93.3, mais aussi II.45.3; VI.73.6; VII.62.7; VII.68.3.

[56] Sur ce thème de la liberté et de la responsabilité nombreux sont les passages du texte de Clément qui pourraient être cités. À titre d'exemple, cf. *Stromates* I.173.6; VII.5.5; VII.21.2.

[57] Les commentateurs et les éditeurs des Stoïciens n'hésitent pas à proposer l'extrait de Clément comme un témoignage fidèle de la proposition de Chrysippe: *Stromates* II.101.3 devient ainsi le *Fragmenta moralia* 9, SVF III.723.

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tote aussi, cependant, en *Éthique à Nicomaque* VIII.2, 1156 a 5-10, avait fait état de trois sortes d'amitié, l'une liée au plaisir, l'autre à l'utile et la troisième à la vertu. Clément ne voit aucune difficulté à réunir les deux définitions[58]. La référence finale à Hippodame le pythagoricien[59] ne fait que confirmer l'intention de fond de notre auteur: montrer la continuité existant entre les différents sources de la tradition grecque et exploiter celles-ci en vue d'affirmer la validité de l'enseignement chrétien.

Cette exploitation ne se fait d'ailleurs pas attendre. Sachant très bien de quoi il parle lorsqu'il utilise la notion grecque de *philia*, Clément préfère employer celle-ci plutôt que celle d'*agapè* pour affirmer deux choses qui lui tiennent particulièrement à cœur et que, ni les Grecs, ni même les chrétiens ne semblaient pas vouloir entendre

En premier lieu, en utilisant le terme *philia* pour décrire la relation entre l'homme et Dieu, Clément veut préciser que l'homme et Dieu sont unis par un lien concret, de type personnel, établi sur la base de l'union spirituelle entre deux personnes (la *philia* grecque étant cette relation personnelle). Suivant ce qu'Aristote avait laissé comprendre à propos des rapports entre la justice et l'amitié, il veut aussi préciser que la relation entre l'homme et Dieu implique un rapport de type privé et non 'politique'. Dans le choix du terme *philia*, Clément semble donc trouver un raccourci pour indiquer, à la fois aux chrétiens et aux Grecs, que le vrai Dieu n'est ni le Dieu de la loi, ni celui de la cité, mais le Dieu de l'amour qui s'intéresse à l'homme.

En second lieu, en utilisant la notion grecque de *philia* pour décrire la relation entre l'homme et Dieu, Clément veut affirmer que, malgré les différences, une certaine égalité existe bien entre l'homme et Dieu. Cette égalité ne se situe pas au niveau de la substance, mais de l'action bienveillante. Par son action bienveillante, en effet, Dieu s'est fait l'égal de l'homme, en le créant à son image d'abord, et en lui envoyant son Fils ensuite, afin de lui permettre d'acquérir la ressemblance et la familiarité (*huiothesia*) avec Lui. Et c'est donc en imitant cette même action bienveillante, à laquelle doit-il répondre par toute son existence, que l'homme obtient en quelque sorte l'égalité avec Dieu. Cette réflexion sur la bienveillance est importante car elle permet à Clément de trouver les moyens pour résoudre un problème que la notion grecque de *philia* avait laissé ouvert

Chez Aristote, en effet, ce thème est développé en étroite liaison avec l'idée que l'ami est un autre soi-même et qu'on doit donc désirer pour lui le même bien que nous désirons pour nous-mêmes[60]. Dans ce schéma, il y a cependant

[58] En se référant justement à la vertu, il opère au contraire une synthèse, voire une véritable 'fusion', entre elles. Pour les Stoïciens, en effet, l'amitié n'est pas une vertu, mais seulement un instrument utile en vue d'obtenir le bien final (cf. Stobée, *Eclog.* II.5).

[59] Il s'agit ici vraisemblablement d'Hippodame de Milet, célèbre architecte et urbaniste de l'âge de Périclès (cf. Aristote, *Politique* II.8, 1267 b 22).

[60] Cf. *Éthique à Nicomaque* VIII.2, 1156 a 1-5; VIII.4, 1156 b 5-30.

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un problème. Il s'agit du fait que, dans cette optique, ce qu'on aime dans l'ami ce n'est pas l'ami en tant que tel, individu différent de moi et irréductible à mes désirs, mais mon propre bien à moi[61]. La perspective de l'amitié aristotélicienne est donc fort 'égoïste'.

Les Stoïciens avaient compris le problème, mais ils ne l'avaient pas résolu. Ils s'étaient limités à adopter une perspective originale pour défendre ce même égoïsme de l'amitié. Pour eux, en effet, la *philia* est liée à ce mode d'exister qu'est l'*oikeiôsis*, c'est-à-dire à cette tendance naturelle que chaque être vivant possède et qui le pousse à se conserver et à se multiplier en s'appropriant ce qui se révèle utile à l'existence et en refusant ce qui lui est nuisible[62]. C'est en ce sens que l'*oikeiôsis* devient *philia*: en s'appropriant d'une chose qui lui est extérieure et étrangère, l'homme la rend chère à lui-même (*philè*) jusqu'au point de la reconnaître comme partie de lui-même. L'amitié stoïcienne ne sort donc pas de la perspective 'égoïste'[63].

En affirmant que l'homme peut devenir l'ami de Dieu lorsqu'il se fait l'égal de Celui-ci grâce à son action bienveillante, Clément renverse la perspective de la *philia* grecque et sort celle-ci de l'égoïsme qui l'emprisonnait.

Cela se voit très bien dans le *Quis dives salvetur*. Au §33 en effet, après avoir insisté sur le fait qu'il faut donner avec générosité à celui qui demande sans tenir compte ni de son rang ni de son âge, Clément montre que cette attitude trouve son fondement et sa justification dans la parole de Dieu qui nous a invités non seulement à 'donner' ou à accomplir un bénéfice, mais surtout à 'se faire des amis' en partageant avec eux, et dans la durée, notre propre existence[64]. Le don est donc utile en tant qu'expression de cette volonté de se mettre ensemble et de vivre une vie commune[65]. Mais, où trouver le soutien pour cette inlassable générosité? La réponse de Clément est claire: l'énergie du don de soi vient justement de l'imitation de la bienveillance divine qui se trouve au fondement même de la relation d'amitié. Si Dieu a été le premier à donner sans se soucier du mérite des hommes à qui il donnait, nous, qui voulons être amis de Dieu et lui ressembler, nous devons aussi, tout comme Lui, donner à notre tour sans compter et sans regarder à celui à qui nous donnons.

La notion de bénéfice ou de bienveillance présente dans la *philia* grecque reste donc d'actualité dans l'amitié clémentine, mais elle se retrouve justifiée

[61] Même là où la vertu est parfaite, ce que j'aime dans mon ami c'est mon propre bien à moi. On ne peut donc pas nier que cette attitude est profondément égoïste.

[62] Ce travail d'appropriation progressive suppose la certitude qu'il existe une certaine ressemblance entre toutes les choses en tant que parties d'un même univers.

[63] Il est vrai que les Stoïciens semblent connaître une forme d'amitié désintéressée, par laquelle on aime l'autre pour ce qu'il est, comme Cicéron en témoigne. Mais il s'agit là d'un cas limite, pour lequel on pourrait aussi trouver une ultime justification dans l'amour de soi.

[64] Cf. *QDS* 32, la référence à l'Écriture Sainte est *Luc* 16, 9.

[65] L'amitié, conclut Clément, exactement comme la foi et la véritable gnose, n'est pas l'œuvre d'un jour mais de toute une vie. Ce propos n'est pas sans nous rappeler l'idée d'Aristote.

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autrement. Loin de se fonder sur l'amour de soi, le don à autrui se base sur l'ouverture de l'amitié à Dieu: c'est parce que le *philos* imite Dieu, ou le Logos lui-même, qu'il s'engage sur la voie du don. La *philia* de Clément ouvre donc véritablement l'amitié à la possibilité du don à autrui, tout en sauvegardant le bien propre de celui qui aime et qui donne[66].

En *Stromates* II.102.2, d'ailleurs, Clément clôture le petit traité sur l'amitié que nous venons d'analyser en montrant que la problématique du don est inversée: celui qui donne reçoit et celui qui reçoit donne. L'avantage de la bienveillance et du bénéfice pour celui qui l'accomplit ne réside plus dans le fait que, en étant bienveillant, l'homme prend soin directement de ses intérêts. Si le don correspond au véritable bénéfice, c'est parce que, en l'acceptant, l'ami me permet de me rendre davantage semblable à Dieu qui est bienveillance gratuite.

Cela signifie que, tout en reprenant la notion grecque de *philia* ainsi que ses caractéristiques de bienveillance et de bénéfice, Clément parvient à fonder une nouvelle conception de la relation d'amitié, l'élargissant au rapport avec Dieu et en éliminant son caractère fortement égoïste.

Conclusion

En guise de conclusion, je voudrais proposer deux remarques et anticiper une objection possible.

Dans tous les contextes que nous avons examinés, Clément se montre accueillant vis-à-vis des différentes doctrines philosophiques, et cela parce qu'il est convaincu qu'elles ont toutes quelque chose de vrai, même si chacune d'entre elles, prise en elle-même, ne porte qu'une vérité partielle. Pour que cette partialité vienne au jour, il faut que ces mêmes doctrines puissent être interprétées par une raison capable de composer une synthèse qui dépasse les particularités de chacune et dévoile son véritable sens. En effectuant ce travail, Clément parvient à montrer que toute la philosophie grecque n'a finalement exprimé qu'une seule chose: pour vivre bien il faut suivre le *Logos*. Cet enseignement, qui est aussi celui de la 'véritable philosophie', a pu être mis au jour grâce notamment à l'éclairage apporté par celle-ci. Dans le chapitre sur la vie bienheureuse et dans celui sur la vertu, j'ai essayé de mettre en évidence comment Clément s'y prend pour arriver à cette conclusion.

La doctrine du *Logos* est donc centrale dans la pensée de Clément. D'une part, en tant que 'grec', il est personnellement convaincu que la raison doit

[66] A propos de ce caractère désintéressé du bénéfice et sa mesure déterminée par l'exemple de la bienveillance de Dieu envers nous, cf. *Stromates* II.84.4 – 86.7. Il n'est pas question directement du φίλος dans ce contexte, mais bien de l'ἀδελφός qui est finalement l'équivalent de l'ami pour Clément.

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'gouverner' notre âme et ses actes; d'autre part, en tant que chrétien, il veut montrer l'aspect raisonnable de l'Incarnation. Or, l'Incarnation est un mystère que la raison accepte difficilement, St Paul avait déjà mis en garde les chrétiens à ce propos. Pour rendre moins ardu, surtout aux Grecs, ce travail de reconnaissance et d'acceptation, Clément cherche à montrer à quel point toute la pensée humaine avait déjà affirmé la centralité du *Logos*, même si elle n'avait pas été tout le temps consciente de ce fait. La 'vraie philosophie' se doit donc de le faire découvrir au plus grand monde.

En quoi le travail de Clément se distingue-t-il d'un pur assemblage de doctrines 'éclectiques'? Même si la méthode utilisée touche parfois à l''éclectisme', parce que notre auteur ne se gêne pas d'interpréter à sa manière les doctrines qu'il accueille, en réalité Clément effectue son travail ouvertement, en dévoilant ses sources pour montrer jusqu'à quel point elles sont compatibles les unes avec les autres. Le résultat est la composition d'une synthèse par laquelle Clément parvient même à trouver des solutions à des problèmes que la philosophie grecque avait laissé sans solution (c'est le cas de la *phronèsis* et de la *philia*).

Le travail de Clément ressemble donc plus à un exercice de dialectique qu'à l'assemblage éclectique de données éparses. Ce travail est le résultat de la méthode dont la caractéristique principale réside dans le fait de savoir récupérer les différentes opinions des philosophes du passé et de l'Écriture, de les comparer et, grâce à l'éclairage apporté par le *Logos*, de pouvoir les réunir et les dépasser dans une œuvre nouvelle qui les contient toutes. Cette œuvre nouvelle est pour Clément la 'vraie philosophie' qui s'annonce alors comme l'accomplissement de la philosophie grecque.

Grabmann n'a donc probablement pas tout à fait tort à considérer Clément comme un des précurseurs de la position anselmienne: *fides quaerens intellectum*.

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Unity of the Symbolic Domain in Clement of Alexandria's Thought

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In a previous work[1] I tried to formulate the first step for a comprehensive interpretation of Clement in which a specific conjunction of biblical texts, particularly New Testament ones, acts as a hermeneutic key not only for the decipherment of the *Stromateis*, but also for the reconstruction of his system of thought. In my opinion, the organizing principle of Clement's epistemology lies in a peculiar exegetical combination of 1 Cor. 13, in its double aspects of the vision *per speculum et in aenigmate* and of the hierarchical structure of the virtues, with the Johannine tradition according to which God is ἀγάπη. In this scheme, basing himself on faith, the Christian lives in hope, and his τέλος, end and perfection at the same time, is ἀγάπη. It is a question of a contemporaneously gnoseological programme, because the ultimate aim is the vision of God, in which, however, the platonic θεωρία is moulded within the Christian concept of the ὁμοίωσις by ἀγάπη to the Logos, and of a spiritual life of progression in the Pauline virtues, in which the fullness of the virtues and their absorption into the divine ἀγάπη corresponds to the fullness of the contemplation. The objective dimension of this fulfilment is constituted by the θεωρία of God *facies ad faciem*, the subjective one by ἀπάθεια, intended as a reflection (and reintegration) of the immutability of God, of that God who is exactly ἀγάπη[2]. Moreover, it is important to understand how the distinction made here between the epistemological and the spiritual in Clement is quite artificial. Here, as in many other cases of ancient authors, the presumed dualism or presumed contradictions are only ours, since in a scheme such as that here proposed, love is knowledge and knowledge is love, inasmuch as the point is given by the unitary assimilation with the One, which is ἀγάπη. The famous Gregorian formula whereby *amor ipse notitia est*[3] is a mere pale reflection of the profound unity of the spiritual and the epistemological that we find in Clement[4], and which Clement in his turn found in 1 Cor. 13.

[1] M. Rizzi, 'Il fondamento epistemologico della mistica in Clemente Alessandrino', in *Origene maestro di vita spirituale – Origen: Master of Spiritual Life*, ed. L.F. Pizzolato and M. Rizzi (Milan, 2001), pp. 91-122 (with wider bibliography for the topics here discussed).

[2] See Clem. Alex., *Strom.* VII.3.13.

[3] Greg. Magn., *Hom. in Ev.* 27.4.

[4] See, e.g., Clem. Alex., *Strom.* VII.16.102.1-2.

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If the above be correct, the next stage will be to examine in which field a similar epistemological model may be applied. If the first point is constituted by the contemplation of and ὁμοίωσις with God, which re-establishes the original condition of man created κατ' εἰκόνα, in order to reach such an end it is necessary to reconsider comprehensively the cosmos created by God, which is explicitly assumed as good by Clement.

In book I of the *Stromateis* Clement dwells on the doctrine of σπέρματα τοῦ λόγου, in order to show how Greek and Barbarian participated and still participate in the Logos of truth. With regard to the apologetic tradition and to Justin in particular, Clement draws a more profound analogy between the truth-Logos, co-eternal and co-extensive with God, and the cosmic aeon, αἰών, which gathers into itself past, present, and future. With temporal extension, a typical expression of the creation[5], is connected the articulation of the parts (μέρη) of the cosmos; thus, 'he who brings again together the separate fragments, and makes them one, will without peril, be assured, contemplate the perfect Word, the truth'[6]. For Clement, then, the creation constitutes a potential continuum which man is called to run through with his knowledge, to gather its more profound essence, which coincides precisely with the Logos-truth.

The elements in play in this scheme are, on the one hand, the Logos as manifestation of unity and truth, a recognizable expression of God in that he is his image, and, on the other, its articulation in time and space (parts), which are peculiar to the cosmos. To bring together the series of elements so that they coincide is the joint work of revelation (the operation of the Logos from on high) and of gnostic progress (the work of man from below). In this sense, it seems to me that the Clementine scheme is more articulated than the sole idea, already present, for example, in Philo and later in Origen, of the creation and subsistence in the Logos of rational natures. However, it is possible to speak of a true and peculiar development of the unity and truth of the Logos in time and space (hence the different μέρη), in which creation consists and from which the cosmos is substantiated.

A similar articulation of ideas as an organizing principle of Clement's thought appears in various places in the *Stromateis*, of which I give one single example. A little after the passage quoted above, Clement gives a peculiar interpretation of the Delphic precept 'know thyself', in which he insists on reconnecting the parts with the whole, a procedure in which gnosis consists:

> It [the Delphic precept] may be an injunction to the pursuit of knowledge. For it is not possible to know the parts without the essence of the whole; and one must study the genesis of the universe, that thereby we may be able to learn the nature of man[7].

[5] See *Strom.* VI.16.142.3-4.

[6] *Strom.* I.13.57.6 (all the English translations of Clement's work are those of W. Wilson in ANF 2 (Buffalo, 1887).

[7] *Strom.* I.14.60.4.

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In this case it does not seem to me that the idea expressed can be simply reduced to the Stoic analogy between micro- and macrocosm, between anthropology and physiology, understood as a study of the φύσις, but rather to the logocentric gravitation of Clementine epistemology as reconstructed here.

In his anti-gnostic polemics, too, particularly against Basilides, Clement, in the fourth book of the *Stromateis*, reaffirms the unity and continuity of the cosmos, man included. As is well known, the gnostic interpretation of Platonism underlined the anti-cosmic dimension, to the point of not merely separating the elect from other men, but even of assigning to them a character that was supracosmic by nature (ὑπερκόσμιον φύσει). Clement's reply is particularly clear and strictly connects the unity of God, the unity and goodness of the cosmos, and the fact that everything belongs to it: 'For all things are of one God. And no one is a stranger to the world by nature, their essence being one, and God one'[8]. In this case, too, it would, in my opinion, be reductive to limit oneself to a dependence on the monistic concepts of Stoicism, as upheld by some. This text (and others, as, for example, VI.16.142.3) can be better understood if it is linked again to the scheme of unity/parts and truth/time with which this paper deals.

A related passage is not only valuable as a summary, but can enable us to go a stage further:

> God, then, being not a subject for demonstration, cannot be the object of science. But the Son is wisdom, and knowledge, and truth, and all else that has affinity thereto. He is also susceptible of demonstration and of description. And all the powers of the Spirit, becoming collectively one thing, terminate in the same point – that is, in the Son. But He is incapable of being declared, in respect of the idea of each one of His powers. And the Son is neither simply one thing as one thing, nor many things as parts, but one thing as all things; whence also He is all things. For He is the circle of all powers rolled and united into one unity. Wherefore the Word is called the Alpha and the Omega, of whom alone the end becomes beginning, and ends again at the original beginning without any break. Wherefore also to believe in Him, and by Him, is to become a unit, being indissolubly united in Him[9].

This does not merely express a powerful doctrine of apocatastasis, to which Origen would be substantially indebted: in Clement's view the cosmos constitutes a continuum whose different places and levels are made up of different configurations of the quality of matter and time, all, however, destined to flow into the unitary contemplation of the Logos. Gnosis, which according to the definition of *Strom.* VI.7.61.1 is 'a sure and irrefragable apprehension of things divine and human, comprehending the present, past, and future' corresponding to the truth that encloses in itself past, present, and future, indicates an intensity of polarization of difference and time in the direction of unity and

[8] *Strom.* IV.26.165.4.
[9] *Strom.* IV.25.156.1-157.2.

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truth, just as in the system of the three Christian virtues hope represents the anticipation of the final condition of agapistic contemplation. There follows a comprehensive and unitary representation of the reality that sees once again the Logos at its beginning and at its end:

> For on one original first Principle, which acts according to the [Father's] will, the first and the second and the third depend. Then at the highest extremity of the visible world is the blessed band of angels; and down to ourselves there are ranged, some under others, those who, from One and by One, both are saved and save. As, then, the minutest particle of steel is moved by the spirit of the Heraclean stone when diffused over many steel rings; so also, attracted by the Holy Spirit, the virtuous are added by affinity to the first abode, and the others in succession down to the last[10].

The original unity of the cosmos and its apocatastic reintegration are united with the idea, derived from Jesus' saying 'In my Father's house are many mansions', of the positioning in continuum of the soul progressing in the visible world, the pure intelligible condition being reserved only to the Father; the image of the magnet, taken from Plato (*Ion* 533d-e), then makes sense of the interpretation of gnosis as an indicator of polarization in the growing process of knowledge and contemplation which underlies the whole of Clement's thought.

Once the unity of the field of relevance of the epistemological model of Clement has been thus established, it remains to determine the specific modality of intellection that is applied in it. All the works of Clement leave no doubt on this point: the symbolic method represents the instrument of intellectual cognition *par excellence*. Its value, however, as Tzevan Todorov partially showed[11], does not appear to be limited exclusively to the exegesis of scripture, in particular to allegorical reading, but extends to the whole field of creation by virtue of the omni-comprehensive unity of the Logos, which founds and sustains it. The possession of the symbolic procedure, or – as expressed in other terms – of the enigmatic procedure (*Strom.* II 1,1,2) or of modes of expression in veiled terms (*Strom.* V 4,19,3), constitutes the instrument of knowledge that permits the unification of the different aspects of reality and its gnoseological crossing over to reach the final unitary contemplation of the Logos.

In this case as well, there are several texts that support a similar interpretation. On a primary level, which has been studied copiously, there are the affirmations that refer to the symbolic procedure as a form of expression typical of the transmission of religious and philosophical knowledge. Philosophizing by enigma is typical of both Greek and biblical wisdom (*Strom.* I.14.60.1), that 'delivered the truth in enigmas, and symbols, and allegories, and metaphors, and such like tropes'[12]. In this sense, the symbolic procedure

[10] *Strom.* VII.2.9.3-10.2.
[11] T. Todorov, *Théories du symbole* (Paris, 1977), pp. 31-3; 48-50.
[12] *Strom.* V.4.21.4.

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would appear limited to the exegesis of the text of the bible and of philosophical tradition.

At a deeper level, however, the value of the symbol is given by its coincidence with the very structure of human thought, which, in line with the model here reconstructed, sees in nature a condition which at the same time reveals and hides the truth. If in order to grasp the ultimate foundation, that is, the Logos, it is necessary to know how to go over and reconnect the parts and the times, such a reconnection is possible precisely by virtue of an interpretation of reality that in everything and through everything coincides with a symbolic interpretation. In fact, if reality in its components constitutes a unitary continuum, by reason of its condition it is possible for man to go over it and understand it in this life only in symbolic terms, that is, by passing from differentiated exterior manifestations to the progressive perceptions of its intimate unity, in a manner precisely analogous to the mechanism of scriptural interpretation, which permits one to transcend the literal word to reach different and infinite grades of spiritual meaning, which coincides with the inexhaustibility of the Logos. As is shown by the famous case of the exegesis of the Temple and of the robe of the High Priest in book V of the *Stromateis*, Christian revelation, as much as the Greek sapiential tradition, becomes a sort of map of reality, thanks to which the threads can be reconnected through an uninterrupted process of symbolic research[13]. For example, the correspondence between exegesis and interpretation of creation is expressly affirmed in relation to an exemplification of the symbolic method, the 'Gnostic' interpretation of the Decalogue: 'If the tables that were written were the work of God, they will be found to exhibit physical creation'[14]. Cosmos and scripture are very closely related: the Gnostic, then, is he who firmly acquires the truth of the good, of evil, and of the origin of everything, from the beginning of the world to its end (*Strom.* VI.9.78.5). In this sense, no manifestation of reality and of nature is without a symbolically accessible meaning, as is shown by the exegesis given by Clement precisely in relation to that which might seem to be just a banal instinctual manifestation:

> It is not, then, without reason that we commanded boys to kiss their parents, holding them by the ears; indicating this, that the feeling of love is engendered by hearing. And 'God', who is known to those who love, 'is love', as 'God', who by instruction is communicated to the faithful, 'is faithful'; and we must be allied to Him by divine love: so that by like we may see like, hearing the word of truth guilelessly and purely, as children who obey us[15].

Anthropological observation, dictates of scripture and epistemological principles[16] combine in unity through the adoption of the symbolic method as a

[13] See, e.g., *Strom.* VI.15.121.4-122.1, 126.3.

[14] *Strom.* VI.16.133.1.

[15] *Strom.* V.2.13.1-4.

[16] On the epistemological principle of 'the like by the like', see Rizzi, *Il fondamento epistemologico*, pp. 98-101 (with bibliography).

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comprehensive and unifying hermeneutic key that takes the text of the bible as a starting point, but does not exhaust itself in it, and extends itself to every manifestation of anthropic and cosmic reality.

Thus Clement stands in a precise semiotic line of Platonism extending from Numenius to Plotinus, as Robert Lamberton has shown, and which from a religious point of view would lead to theurgic Platonism: both language and universe are structured out of different elements, στοιχεῖαι in the Stoic lexicon, ἀρχαί in the Platonic, μέρη in that of Clement, who knows and even uses the other two, which combine to express, naturally in an imperfect way, the underlying true reality. We may conclude with Lamberton that herein is implicit 'the belief that the material universe itself constitutes a system of meaning, a language of symbols that, properly read, will yield a truth that transcends its physical substrate'[17]. Following him, Frances Young has observed that in this light can be understood the Christian search for the ὑπόθεσις or σκοπός, which unifies scripture, and she correctly notes that was intrinsic to the Christian appropriation of Jewish writings, even before Origen[18]. Here, I believe that Clement marked a boundary never afterwards reached, even by Origen himself. On the one hand, this is because for the latter it is the bible that contains and exhausts in itself the world: the possibility of every human experience is subsumed in the performative act of exegesis, which becomes the place of the mystic contemplation of the Logos[19], while, as we have seen, in Clement the bible is a sort of map of the cosmos, and contemplation is consumed in its transcendence[20]. But above all, on the other hand, it is because in a similar scheme for Clement every specific Christian manifestation fully pertains to the unitary logic of the symbolic field, which transcends the very confines of this world and the next, of this life and the next[21].

[17] R. Lamberton, *Homer the Theologian* (Berkeley, 1986), p. 77.

[18] F. Young, *Biblical Exegesis and the Formation of Christian Culture* (Cambridge, 1997), p. 27.

[19] See B. McGinn, *The Foundations of Mysticism* (New York, 1994), pp. 110-130; G. Lettieri, 'Origene interprete del Cantico dei cantici. La risoluzione mistica della metafisica valentiniana', in *Origene maestro di vita spirituale*, pp. 141-86.

[20] See, e.g., Clem. Alex., *Strom.* VII.13.82.5-7.

[21] For a first attempt at research in such a direction, see the monographic section of *Adamantius. Journal of the Italian Research Group on Origen and the Alexandrian Tradition* 9 (2003), 8-66, with papers by Monaci, Neri, Lugaresi, and Rizzi; see also M. Rizzi, 'La vita del cristiano come "sacrificio" tra Giustino e Clemente Alessandrino', *Annali di Scienze Religiose* 7 (2002), 15-28, esp. 21-27.

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Some Comments on the Ecclesiology of Origen of Alexandria

William G. Rusch, New York

Across some eighteen centuries of Christian experience and thought, Origen of Alexandria has been a baffling and enigmatic figure. The voluminous and multifarious character of his works, products of his restless genius and limitless energy, has resulted in an intriguing collection of labels being assigned to him through the years. It has been a challenge to discover the 'real' Origen. Is he heretic or saint? Is he philosopher or theologian? Is he finally pagan or Christian? Is he all of the above, and at the same time?[1]

Much of the history of scholarship about this presbyter of the third century could be traced around these questions. Questions about the identity of Origen did not await the modern era[2]. Already at the end of the third century and the beginning of the fourth there were debates about him. It would seem that by the year 553 and the Second Council of Constantinople, the Eastern church decided that he was a heretic. The Western church has not been so confident. The opinion is unanimous that he was a genius, influential and multidimensional, but who was this Origen of Alexandria? Jean Daniélou painted the portrait of an Origen who was at the same time philosopher, exegete, systematic theologian, sacramentalist, and mystic[3].

The purpose of these comments is to explore whether it is possible to gain some new insights into, or greater precision about, the identity of Origen. This effort will be made by examining all too briefly his comments about the church.

Considerable attention has been devoted to ferreting out what Origen thought about the church[4]. Usually the goal of such endeavours has been to gain an impression of the church of Origen's day. What was the church actually like which he experienced, and what did he think that the church should be?

[1] See the summary of views related by H. Crouzel in *Origen*, tr. A.S. Worall (Edinburgh, 1989), preface.

[2] See G. Evans, 'Origen in the Twelfth Century', in *Origeniana Tertia*, ed. Richard Hanson and Henri Crouzel (Rome, 1985), 279-85.

[3] See Jean Daniélou, *Origène* (Paris, 1948).

[4] See, for example, J. Chenevert, *L' Église dans le Commentaire d'Origène sur le Cantique des Cantiques* (Brussels, 1969); F. Ledegang, *Mysterium Ecclesiae: Images of the Church and Its Members in Origen* (Leuven, 2001); G. Sgherri, *Chiesa e Sinagoga nelle opere di Origene* (Milan, 1982).

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As far as I can determine, little learned focus has been given to what his views of the church tell us about him as a person and a thinker. In the light of his comments about the Christian community do we have an insight into Origen? To conduct this enquiry, we must note what Origen in fact did say about the church. Another approach would be to complement this effort with an examination of what he did at various points in his life, which would reveal something of his views of the church. But this consideration lies beyond what is possible here.

The first fact to note is that Origen never composed a systematic treatise on ecclesiology. Yet this omission must be placed in context. Neither did anyone else in the patristic period! Even Cyprian, his Western contemporary, who wrote a work on the unity of the church, has given us more of an apologia than a systematic construct. Augustine of Hippo, who was ever influential in the West, contributed much to understanding the church – without ever writing a separate work on the subject. *Loci* on the church had to await the Reformation of the sixteenth century. This lacuna in Origen's literary corpus should not be exaggerated. What this tells us is that Origen was understandably a person of his time and environment in this regard.

Nevertheless, Origen's writings reveal that he was a keen, accurate and candid observer of the church of his day. He was not a pedantic scholar ignorant of, or indifferent to, his contemporary church. He saw the church not merely as a local institution but scattered across the known world of his day (*Commentarii in Canticum canticorum* 1; *Homiliae in Ezechielem* 1.2; *Commentarii in Matthaeum* 16.22 and 17.24). The church was a concrete reality; it was the place where a believer prays (*De Oratione* 20.1). The church is a global republic with its own legal system. Long before Augustine, the church is for Origen the 'city of God' (*Commentarii in Canticum canticorum* 2; *Contra Celsum* 4.22; *Homiliae in Ieremiam* 9.2; and *Homiliae in Iesu Naue* 8.17). This church is specific. Just as the human body is animated by the soul, so is the church animated by Christ (*Contra Celsum* 6.48 and *Commentarii in Matthaeum,* 14.17). This empirical church is also a combination of good and evil (*Homiliae in Iesu Naue* 21.1 and *Commentarii in Matthaeum* 10.13). Origen is the realist and no idealist here. The typical churchgoer is inattentive during sermons (*Homiliae in Genesim* 10.1 and 11.3). There is evidence in the church of fraud. Monies given for the poor have been misused (*Commentarii in Matthaeum* 16.22 and *Homiliae in Leuiticum,* 7.7). There are leaders in some Christian communities who are arrogant and ambitious (*Homiliae in Numeros* 12.4; *Commentarii in Matthaeum* 16.8; *Commentariorum series* 12). Some good church members have been unjustly excluded from the church (*Homiliae in Leuiticum* 14.3 and *Commentarii in Matthaeum* 15.15). Origen notes and regards highly the threefold structure of the church. He has references to bishops, presbyters, and deacons (*Contra Celsum* 8.75; *Commentarii in Matthaeum* 15.26; and *Homiliae in Ieremiam* 14.16). Origen is also aware

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of teachers in the church. More than once he hints that they have a higher value than the offices in the threefold structure (*Homiliae in Leuiticum* 5.3 and 12.7). Do we have here the hint of a self-pride in Origen? A statement made in the light of his own work and life experience? It is an intriguing possibility.

Also, Origen was not merely an observer of the church, who accepted the institution as he saw it. Origen's comments about the church reinforce the view that he was a thinker about the church, but one who had the ability and flexibility not to place everything in his intellectual purview into a system.

Very much rooted in his Alexandrian context and as a representative of that tradition, Origen probed to discover beyond the visible and transient things of this world the mystery of invisible and eternal realities (*Homiliae in Numeros* 3.13). This approach led Origen to ponder a sharp tension between the empirical, or earthly church and the heavenly church. The earthly church did not exhaust what was church for him. Thus Origen developed the idea of two churches, two hierarchies (*Homiliae in Lucam* 13). On this basis he concludes that the empirical church includes many persons who are not truly members of the church. It is the heavenly church that is composed of the perfect believers, those persons who are united with the Logos (*De Oratione* 20.1 and *Commentarii in Canticum canticorum* 2). In sharp distinction from the earthly church, it is the heavenly church that is without spot or wrinkle (*Commentarii in Matthaeum* 12.12). It is holy and without blame. The reason for this is that the heavenly church is joined to Christ (*Commentarii in Canticum canticorum* 1.4). The body of Christ is not merely a *tupos* of the church. Rather, it is, animated by the Son of God, the church (*Contra Celsum* 6.48). This church did not await the incarnation, for it existed before creation (*Commentarii in Canticum canticorum* 2.8). For Origen the elect portion of the earthly church is the heavenly church. Origen is clear that there is no salvation outside of the church (*Homiliae In Iesu Naue* 3.5). Somehow for Origen this earthly church and this heavenly church do coincide, although he continued to insist that the earthly church with all of its defects is a shadow or image of the heavenly church (*Commentarii in Canticum canticorum* 2).

It is not the purpose of these comments to investigate the question of where Origen obtained this dualistic view of reality. Was his source Platonism in its later manifestations, his reading of the bible, especially Paul and the Letter to the Hebrews, with a particular hermeneutic, or finally a combination of both? Rather, it is appropriate to indicate here that such remarks by Origen reveal an intellectual person, attuned to secular and religious thought of his age – if that distinction can be made with him – who drew understandings and conclusions from more than empirical evidence. This is not surprising, but as a recognized facet of his being it serves as a reminder of the breadth of his personage.

Origen's use of one image for the heavenly church is particularly insightful in the quest for his identity. This is the heavenly church as the bride of Christ (*Commentarii Canticum canticorum* 1 and 2). Origen identifies the bride with

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the church or the soul. In this way he connects an ecclesiological dimension to spiritual life. Christ seeks the bride, and the bride awaits and desires Christ. For Origen all of history from Adam onward is a preparation for this encounter of Christ with his bride. He makes the distinction between the first call to the wedding, to Israel and the synagogue, which was rejected (*Commentarii in Matthaeum* 14.7; and *De Oratione* 20.1) and the wedding of Christ and the church (*Commentarii in Matthaeum* 17). This schema allows Origen to affirm both God's unitary purpose in history and also its discontinuity. Since the coming of Christ was not recognized by most of Israel, there is now the call to the Gentiles. The church becomes the community to the nations. Its role is based on God's call to the Gentiles after the refusal of the call to Israel. Origen sees this transfer from one call to another as a passage from one generation to another. It is in the context of this second call that the church adheres in simple faith to Christ (*Homiliae in Leuiticum* 12.5). Thus Origen works out a theology of two peoples (*De Principiis* 4.1.4; *Commentarii in Matthaeum* 12.4; and *Homiliae in Ieremiam* 11.6). Closely connected to this theological position is the emphasis that Origen places on the unity of the church. For him the church is not merely an organization that could be grasped in sociological terms. The church is a body that imitates Jesus. It is the risen body of Christ and therefore one. For Origen this is the meaning of the expression 'being in Christ' (*Commentarii in Iohannem* 10.35; *Commentarii in Matthaeum* 12.25 and 14.47; and *Contra Celsum* 6.79). Because members of the church have a unity with the Lord, they have a unity with each other (*Commentarii in Matthaeum* 24.21).

Now it is no novelty to point out these aspects of Origen's thought. They are indeed well known. Yet they are important here because they underscore two aspects of Origen the person.

First, this schema is rooted in his careful and deep reflection about the biblical text. Origen must have spent hours, and probably days, in an engagement with a specific text of the bible. His efforts related to textual criticism are well known and bear out this conclusion.

Second, independent thinking or recourse to pagan philosophy is not the source for this Origenist construct. Rather, it is a wrestling with the entire text of the bible, its two testaments, that has yielded this understanding of the church. Origen's ecclesiology discloses for us a person who should aptly be described as an intense reader and student of the bible, who is not a biblicist – the latter being an impossible category for any Alexandrian. Attention to Origen's views of the church with a recognition of his many biblical scholia, commentaries, and homilies presents us with an individual who is much more comprehensible in an ecclesial rather than academic context.

This recognition is in harmony with the self-portrait Origen provides to his readers on more than one occasion. In his *Homilies on Luke* Origen is sharing with his audience his struggle to interpret a passage of scripture. In this

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process he states, *Ego vero, qui opto esse ecclesiasticus et non ab haeresiarchae aliquo, sed a Christi vocabulo nuncupari et habere nomen, quod benedicitur super terram* ... ('I hope to be a person of the church. I hope to be designated and addressed, not by the name of some heresiarch, but by the name of Christ, which is blessed on earth'; *Homiliae in Lucam* 16.6). If we accept the accuracy of Jerome's translation and a general dating of around 233-4, we have a self-description of Origen at mid-career, or slightly older, probably soon after his arrival in Caesarea[5].

But is it anything more than an occasional reference? This appears not to be the case. Already in the same collection of homilies Origen had employed the phrase *ecclesiasticus vir* (*Homiliae in Lucam* 2.2). But in this latter case he does not apply the term to himself. Origen also uses the term in his homilies on Leviticus (*Homiliae in Leuiticum* I.1), in his homilies on Isaiah (*Homiliae in Isaiam* 7.3, and in his Commentary on Romans (*Commentarii in Epistulam ad Romanos* 3.1). While it is not possible here to enter into the question of the exact dating of these works, it would appear safe to state that Origen was using this term and applying it to himself at least in the decade between 233 and 244. If Henri Crouzel's date is correct, then Origen began to use the expression around mid-career at least and continued its use in the years shortly before his death[6].

The intention of the phrase is obvious. The Christian is a person of the church in contrast to the heretic. It is Origen's desire here to make a statement of self-identity. His claim is to be seen not as a philosopher, but as a person attached to a community, and that community is the church. For many Christian authors and thinkers, such a claim would not in any sense be remarkable. But it is in the light of competing labels placed on Origen that such a self-disclosure should be taken with considerable seriousness, and not rejected unless there is compelling evidence to the contrary.

From this survey of his comments on the church, then, what discernment would emerge to assist in the painting of a contemporary portrait of Origen which would be in conformity with what he tells us about himself?

Such a portraiture would disclose that Origen is understandably a person located in his particular time and place. He is a resident of the Roman Empire in the East in the third century of the Christian era. The lack of a formal treatise on ecclesiology is documentation of this fact. This means he should not be judged by later standards or debates, although this has happened to him on occasion.

[5] See William G. Rusch, 'Some Comments on Origen's *Homilies on the Gospel According to Luke*', in L. Perrone (Ed.), *Origeniana Octava*, (Leuven, 2004), 727-731.

[6] See Joseph T. Lienhard, 'Origen as Homilist', in David Hunter (ed.), *Preaching in the Patristic Age* (New York, 1989), 40.

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Origin is also an acute and candid observer and commentator of his time. His frequent descriptions of the church and churches of his day reveal this aspect of his nature. But he does not simply observe and note. He also evaluates. He has the ability to be a harsh judge even of things and persons that matter to him. His remarks about the conduct of church members and officers make this clear. He works beyond merely sensual aspects of things. He deeply reflects about their being. His innate abilities, linked with his theological and intellectual heritage, allow him to be creative and put forth new ideas. Origen does not simply repeat the familiar. His views on the earthly and heavenly church indicate this. Finally, Origen does not perceive himself as a neutral bystander in all of this.

If history has assigned him a collection of labels, including Hellenist, Platonist, moralist, and syncretist, to name a few, we have from his own pen a label he wished for himself. He desired as a person of commitment to be identified with the community of faith that was known as Christian and to be seen as one who rejected false views about that community and its Lord. He should be taken at his word much more so than has been done at some points in the past. If this can be done, a portrait will emerge that gives us much more an *ecclesiasticus vir*, a believing Christian, and much less of a pagan philosopher, whose views are suspect among his fellow believers.

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Was Origen Systematic? A Reappraisal

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In 1962 the late Henri Crouzel posed the question, hard to translate 'Origène est-il un systématique?'[1] For most of the ensuing decades Crouzel himself dominated Origen studies with his monographs, editions of texts, articles, reviews, and bibliographies. He also wrote on Origen's life and work for a wider readership. The article that posed this question was a scholarly manifesto, a heartfelt plea to understand Origen on his own terms. I will take the liberty of summarizing the main features of his approach.

(1) We must, above all, take Origen seriously as a believing Christian who was not, in our terms, a philosopher but a theologian. Origen used Greek philosophy to create a work that is truly Christian and truly his own[2];

(2) We should not let Origin's enemies define him as a heretic. Admittedly these 'enemies' may seem like anyone Crouzel disagreed with, but he had Jerome and Justinian especially in mind. This means rejecting Koetschau's reconstruction of *Peri Archon* in the GCS edition. On the other hand, we should take seriously the views of Origen's friends, especially Rufinus, because 'love is still, all things considered, the best, perhaps the only road to an authentic understanding'[3].

(3) Origen did not teach or presuppose a double truth, holding to the bible and more conventional beliefs for the benefit of simple Christians but hinting at more speculative and systematic views for the benefit of a spiritual elite[4].

(4) Origen sets forth his views, not systematically, but hypothetically and conjecturally[5]. Crouzel thus takes up a commonplace among defenders of Origen that we see already in Pamphilus' *Apologia* – that Origen lacked the characteristic obstinacy of heretics[6].

For Crouzel, 'Origène est-il un systématique?' meant, 'Is there, at the heart of his speculation, a rational system that could easily be expressed as a series

[1] Henri Crouzel, 'Origène est-il un systématique?', in Henri Crouzel, *Origène et la philosophie* (Paris: Aubier, 1962), pp. 179-215.

[2] *Ibid.*, p. 212. See Henri Crouzel, 'Le Dieu d'Origène et le Dieu de Plotin', in *Origeniana Quinta*, ed. Robert J. Daly (Louvain: Peeters, 1992), pp. 406-17.

[3] *Ibid.*, p. 214. Translations are my own.

[4] *Ibid.*, pp. 206-7.

[5] *Ibid.*, p. 215.

[6] See *Origène* (Paris: Éditions Lethielleux, 1985), pp. 216-23.

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of propositions, deriving one from another?'[7] His answer, put consisely, was 'no': Origen was not a system builder but a mystic. This question is still relevant, first, because, for better or worse, Crouzel set up enduring categories for interpreting Origen. Ulrich Berner, in his masterful survey, divided Origen scholars into those who saw Origen as 'systematic' and those who, like Crouzel, adopted a 'non-systematic or mystical' position; few scholars fell into a 'mediating' group[8]. It is also still relevant because we cannot grasp Origen's work as a whole without dealing with the issue of whether or not such issues as the pre-existence of souls, universal salvation, the role and ultimate status of corporeality, and the Son's subordination to the Father were fundamental to his thought.

Seeking ourselves to understand Origen on his own terms, we might ask whether Origen actually did express an intention to construct a system. It seems so. Although he uses the word σύστημα often, it does not function as a technical term in this sense. The term that does seem to have that function is σῶμα, 'body' or 'body of truth'. In this article Crouzel was silent about one *texte clef*, the final sentence in Origen's preface to *Peri Archon*:

> It is therefore necessary for someone who desires to construct any connection and body [*seriem quandam et corpus*] according to the commandment which says 'Enlighten yourselves with the light of knowledge' [Hos. 10:12] to use points such as these [i.e., the fundamental doctrines of the Church's rule of faith that Origen had just enumerated] as elements and first principles, so that with clear and necessary argument he may investigate what is true in individual matters, so that, as we have said, one body may be constructed from examples and affirmations which he finds in the holy scriptures or which he discovers by careful investigation and direct pursuit of their consequences[9].

This sounds like an announcement that Origen intends to construct, as a heuristic device, a means of enlightenment, something much like what Crouzel denied. In his introduction to his own edition, with Manlio Simonetti, of *Peri Archon*, Crouzel asks if this passge does announce an intention to construct 'a system in the modern sense, a doctrinal construction deriving rigorously from principles or postulates by means of reasoning?' He answers that 'Research theology (*la théologie en recherche*), its antitheses, its affirmations in doubtful form, are sufficient cracks in this edifice'[10]. In their edition, by contrast, Herwig Görgemanns and Heinrich Karpp point the reader to the other place where Origen uses the term 'body' in this technical sense. This is in *Commentary or John*, Book 13, discussing John 4:36, 'that the sower and the reaper may rejoice together':

[7] 'Origène est-il un systématique?', p. 180.
[8] Ulrich Berner, *Origenes* (Darmstatt: Wissenschaftliche Buchgesellschaft, 1981).
[9] Origen, *Peri Archon* Preface 10.
[10] SC 252, p. 51. See also *Origène*, p. 222.

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I suppose that for every art and science that involves many propositions, the sower finds the principles, which others take and elaborate, who themselves transmit the things they have discovered to others. Thanks to their discoveries, their successors — even if they cannot discover the first principles (ἀρχὰς), put together their consequences, and bring to completion the arts and sciences — collect, as in a harvest, the fruit of these arts and sciences which have been brought to perfection.

If this is true with arts and certain sciences, it remains to be seen how much more is it true of the art of arts and science of sciences. For after elaborating those things discovered by the very first, their successors have, with those things discovered, transmitted to those who follow them, so that they may examine them attentively, raw materials for gathering together with wisdom one body of truth[11].

Görgemanns and Karpp further provide a characteristically dual pedigree for this technical use of 'body'. They point the reader to a passage early in Irenaeus' *Against Heresies*, Book 1, where he states that we can only come up with the true interpretation of individual bible passages 'by comparing them to the body of truth' (προσαρμόσας τῳ τῆς ἀληθείας σωματίῳ) that we find in his list of fundamental doctrines held by the Church throughout the whole world[12]. They also point to the second-century Platonist Atticus, who stated that Plato 'had displayed as a whole living body' the various elements of philosophy that had been scattered up until his time like the limbs of Pentheus torn apart by the Bacchants[13]. These passages imply that Origen, in announcing his intention to construct 'a connection and body', had a well-defined intention for *Peri Archon* and one that his contemporaries would have understood and that might easily be described as a system derived logically from fundamental principles.

How do Crouzel's answers stand up after four decades? (1) We must understand Origen as a believing Christian who was not a philosopher but a theologian. Although the distinction between philosophy and theology may seem anachronistic, it is safe to say that few, in any, scholars today would claim that Origen sought to reinterpret Christianity in philosophical terms. Most would agree with Crouzel that he sought the transforming knowledge of God revealed in Jesus Christ. (2) We should not let Origen's enemies define him. Although this has yet to be reflected in a new English translation of *Peri Archon*, Koetschau's edition has been effectively superseded. Even so, Simonetti himself observed that, in mediating his thought, Origen's admirers may be as misleading

[11] Origen, *Commentary on John* 13.46.302-303. See Herwig Görgemanns and Heinrich Karpp (ed.). Origenes, *Vier Bücher von den Principien*, third edn, Texte zur Forschung 24 (Darmstatt: Wissenschaftliche Buchgesellschaft, 1992), p. 99. Brian E. Daley discusses this passage and its implications in 'Origen's De Principiis: A Guide to the Principles of Christian Scriptural Interpretation', in *Nova et Vetera: Patristic Studies in Honor of Thomas Patrick Halton*, ed. John Petruccione (Washington, DC: Catholic University of America Press, 1998), pp. 3-21.

[12] Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* 1.1.20 Harvey = 1.9.4 Rousseau-Doutreleau (SC 264, 150).

[13] Atticus, in Eusebius, *Praeparatio Evangelica* 11.2.

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as his detractors[14]. (3) Origen did not teach or presuppose a double truth. This is the most counter-intuitive, to put it kindly, of Crouzel's assertions. Holger Strutwolf argues cogently for the systematic character of Origen's work. He claims, as did F.-H. Kettler, an early critic of Crouzel, that, if the system is not fully developed in *Peri Archon*, it is only because that work itself was relatively exoteric and intended merely as an introduction to Origen's system [15]. (4) Origen put forward his views tentatively and conjecturally, in the spirit of research. This is clearly anachronistic if it implies that Origen left his hypotheses provisional until they could be approved or disapproved by some non-existent magisterium. In his work on Origen's life and work, Crouzel simply ignored evidence that Origen rejected episcopal authority[16]. Three contributors to the Origen dictionary argue that particular doctrines later deemed heretical are not dispensable hypotheses, but integral to Origen's thought[17]. But what about the 'cracks' Crouzel noted in Origen's system? Nonetheless, anyone who reads Origen can testify that he frequently expressed himself tentatively and left issues open. Has anyone adequately explained how and why Origen could be both 'systematic' and 'hypothetical and tentative' at the same time?

The best explanation, to my knowledge, of this apparent conundrum comes from a figure often spoken of in connection with Origen but rarely looked to as an expositor of this thought, John Henry Newman. I call your attention, in particular, to Newman's fourteenth sermon preached to this university, entitled 'Wisdom, as Contrasted with Faith and with Bigotry'. Newman does not mention Origen, but the *Tracts for the Times* written by him and his associates evidence a wide and careful reading of Origen's works[18]. Readers of Origen will hear Alexandrian echoes in Newman's choice of a sermon text, 1 Corinthians 2:15, 'He that is spiritual judgeth all things, yet be himself is judged of no man', and those echoes grow stronger when he begins his sermon with a citation of 1 Corinthians 2:6-7: 'We speak wisdom among them that are perfect, yet not the wisdom of this world... but we speak the wisdom

[14] 'Piuttosto, l'interprete dovrà cercare di recuperare, al di là dello schermo più o meno spesso degli "intermediari", siano essi ammiratori o detrattori, la problematica voce dell'Allesandrino in cui si fondono in delicato equilibrio le istanze religiose dell'esegeta fedele all'insegnamento ecclesiastico e quelle dell'intellettuale proteso a trovare spiegazioni razionalmente fondate di quel medesimo insegnamento', in *Origene Dizionario: la cultura, il pensiero, le opere*, ed. Adele Monaci Castagno (Rome: Città Nuova, 2000), p. 375.

[15] Holger Strutwolf, *Gnosis als System: Zur Rezeption des valentinianischen Gnosis bei Origenes* (Göttingen: Vandenhoeck & Ruprecht, 1993), p. 364.

[16] He dismisses Pierre Nautin, *Origène: sa vie et son œuvre* (Paris: Beauchesne, 1977) with a footnote in *Origène*, p. 18.

[17] *Origene Dizionario*, pp. 360 (Giulia Sameni Gasparro), 26-7 (Emanuela Prinzivalli), and 391 (Gaetano Lettieri).

[18] See Robin C. Selby, *The Principle of Reserve in the Writings of John Henry Cardinal Newman* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1975). Isaac Williams, a protégé of Newman, relies heavily on Origen in *Tracts for the Times* 80 and 87, 'On Reserve in Communicating Religious Knowledge'.

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of God in a mystery, even the hidden wisdom[19]'. Newman presents faith, in keeping with his earlier University Sermons, as a sort of reason that we arrive at by instinct rather than by reasoning and proof. As Newman presents them, both wisdom and bigotry involve, in contrast with faith, the systematic application of reason. Bigotry, reasoning from inadequate and narrow principles, warps the mind and stiffens it, effectively preventing it from entering genuinely into the minds of others. Bigotry cannot learn anything new, because it already has all the answers. Newman finds bigotry best exemplified in Protestant evangelicalism. Wisdom, reasoning from adequate principles, makes use of its system, the 'church system', to enlarge the mind. Newman insists that, without some sort of system, such enlargement, such a genuine learning from things as they actually are, would be impossible.

> [A] philosophical cast of thought, or a comprehensive mind, or wisdom in conduct or policy, implies a connected view of the old with the new; an insight into the bearing and influence of each part upon every other; without there is no whole, and could be no centre'. It is the knowledge, not only of things, but of their mutual relations. It is organized, and therefore living knowledge[20].

By contrast,

> the censure often passed on what is called undigested reading, shows us that knowledge without system is not Philosophy. Students who store themselves so amply with literature or science, that no room is left for determining the respective relations which exist between their acquisitions, one by one, are rather said to load their minds than to enlarge them[21].

I suggest that it is Origen who provides Newman with this understanding of Christian wisdom. This gives us a persuasive answer to Crouzel's question, 'Origène est-il un systématique?' In this case the answer is 'yes'. Origen uses the system set forth in *Peri Archon* as a means of enlargement or, as he would put it, enlightenment. I also suggest that this capacity for enlargement is what makes it necessary for Origen's system to be tentative and hypothetical. It is not fixed and static but dynamic, always assimilating new ideas, like a living body. In this way Origen partakes at least some of the qualities of an 'open work' in Umberto Eco's sense, open and therefore dynamic because the human soul is continually being transformed[22]. Crouzel spoke of Origen's

[19] John Henry Newman, *University Sermons*, ed. D.M. MacKinnon and J.D. Holmes from 3rd edn (London: S.P.C.K., 1970), 14.1 (p. 278).

[20] *Ibid.*, ed. D.M. MacKinnon and J.D. Holmes from 3rd edn (London: S.P.C.K., 1970), p. 14.21 (p. 287).

[21] *Ibid.*, ed. D.M. MacKinnon and J.D. Holmes from 3rd edn (London: S.P.C.K., 1970), p. 14.26 (p. 289).

[22] See the definition of an 'open work' or 'work in movement' in Umberto Eco, *The Open Work*, tr. Anna Cancogni (Cambridge MA: Harvard University Press, 1989), p. 21. Eco's dismissal of allegory, as he understands it from the *Letter to Can Grande* ascribed to Dante (pp. 5-7), assumes a rigidity not characteristic of Origen.

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professions of tentativness as 'cracks' in the edifice of his system. His image is less persuasive when we use Origen's own metaphor. Origen's system, the body of truth, is dynamic and growing, not fixed and static like a building. It undergoes transformation as the theologian's own understanding is transformed in an ongoing spiritual process. The apparent contradiction between 'systematic' and 'théologie en recherche' is, to use one of Newman's favourite terms, unreal.

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Athanasius: The Incarnation and the Soul of Christ

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To read the literature one would think that the single and most decisive issue concerning Athanasius' Christology is that of whether or not he affirmed that Christ possessed a human soul. Any other aspect of Athanasius' Christology appears at best to be secondary and even inconsequential. While some have admirably defended Athanasius, yet the common perceived consensus is that his understanding of the Incarnation makes no provision for a soul, or, if it does allow for a soul (especially after the Synod of Alexandria in 362), that soul has no christological or soteriological significance. The soul is merely acknowledged, along with the body, as a constitutive factor within Christ's human composition[1].

While the issue of Christ's soul is indeed crucial for an adequate understanding of the Incarnation, I believe that Athanasius would be perplexed as to why the issue ever arose in the first place and bemused that, having arisen, that it has become such a *cause célèbre*. His bewilderment would not arise out of his own ambivalent or indifferent attitude towards the issue of Christ's soul, for I believe that, from the very onset of his theological work, he took the presence of a soul as a given, and even a soteriologically significant given. Rather,

[1] It is not possible to provide here a complete bibliography pertaining to this issue. G.D. Dragas notes that F.C. Baur raised it for the first time (*Die christliche Lehre von der Dreieinigkeit und Menschwerdung Gottes*, (Tübingen, 1841). However, it was K. Hoss, *Studien über das Schriftum und die Theologie des Athanasius auf Grund* (Freiburg i. B., 1899), and A. Stülcken, *Athansiana, Literar- und dogmengeschichtliche Untersuchungen*, TV 19.4 Leipzig, 1899) who popularized the issue within patristic Christology (*St. Athanasius Contra Apollinarem*, Church and Theology VI (Athens, 1985), p. 289). Some of those who have been critical of Athanasius are: A. Grillmeier, *Christ in Christian Tradition*, vol. 1, *From the Apostolis Age to Chalcedon (AD 451)*, revised edn, tr. John Bowden (London: Mowbrays, 1975), pp. 308-28; R.P.C. Hanson, *The Search for the Christian Doctrine of God* (Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1988), pp. 446-58, 645-51; J.N.D. Kelly, *Early Christian Doctrines*, fourth ed. (London: Adam & Charles Black, 1968), pp. 284-9; M. Richard, 'Saint Athanase et la psychologie du Christ selon les ariens', *MSR* 4 (1947), 7-49. Besides Dragas (pp. 289-399) some others who have defend ed Athanasius are K. Anatolios, *Athanasius: The Coherence of His Thought* (London: Routledge, 1998), pp. 70-3, 78-84, 140-55, 201-2, 226 nn. 116 and 121; A. Pettersen, *Athanasius* (London: Geoffrey Chapman, 1995), pp. 130-2; T.E. Pollard, *Johannine Christology and the Early Church* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1970), pp. 232-44; T.F. Torrance, *Theology in Reconciliation* (London: Geoffrey Chapman, 1975), pp. 224-31.

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he would readily perceive that for one to raise the issue of whether or not his Christology allowed for and sanctioned a soul within Christ manifested that one completely failed to grasp, and so was completely ignorant of, his incarnational and soteriological concerns. Focusing exclusively on his *Contra Arianos III*, I want, in this brief communication, to present succinctly Athanasius' understanding of the Incarnation and in so doing liberate him from the charge of being an Apollinarian before Apollinarius.

Within *Contra Arianos III* Athanasius worked out his understanding of the Incarnation in response to the Arian assertion that the weaknesses ascribed to Christ in the Gospels, such as growth, fear, and ignorance, confirm their judgement that the Son must be a creature (see 26-27). They 'deny the Eternity and Godhead of the Word in consequence of those human attributes (ἀνθρωπίνων) which the Saviour took on Him by reason of that flesh (σάρκα) which He bore' (27)[2].

While it is common knowledge that he never denied that Christ possessed a soul, it is in his refutation of the Arian charge that Athanasius is sternly reprimanded for not employing it when it would appear to be the most obvious christological explanation to exploit. In contrast to the absence of a soul within Arian Christology, Athanasius, by arguing that Christ did possess a human soul, could then have emphasized that all of the human attributes resided within it so as to protect, and so endorse, the full divinity of the Word. However, in so censuring Athanasius, his critics neglect his deeper and more fundamental incarnational and soteriological concerns. While the human attributes such as ignorance and fear do reside in a human intellect or soul, of which Athanasius was well aware, his strategy was not to protect the divinity by using the soul as a shield against all that pertains to being authentically human. For Athanasius, if the soul became the primary centre and so subject of the human experiences, then, while the divinity of the Logos may be preserved, yet the truth of the Incarnation would be abandoned. Athanasius was not about to become a Nestorian before Nestorius![3]

Athanasius' primary concern was to establish the proper incarnational principle for interpreting the manner in which the human attributes are predicated of Christ. For Athanasius, this hermeneutical tool lay within the appropriate understanding of the *skopos* of the Gospels or the economy. The story that is being told is the story of the one and the same Son, who 'is God's Son, for being Son, He is inseparable from the Father, and never was there when He was not, but He was always' (28), and who 'afterwards for us ... took flesh of

[2] Translations are taken (with slight changes) from LNPF second series, vol. 4, ed. A. Robertson (New York, 1897), reproducing the tr. of John Henry Newman, LOF (Oxford, 1842-44).

[3] Some critics seem to want Athanasius to espouse a Nestorian position, thus giving the impression that they themselves tend toward Nestorianism. See Grillmeier, pp. 314-15; Hanson, p. 449; and Kelly, p. 287.

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the Virgin, Mary Bearer of God, and was made man. And this *skopos* is to be found throughout inspired Scripture' (29; see also 28). Thus, 'let us, retaining the general *skopos* of the faith (τὸν σκοπὸν τῆς πίστεως) acknowledge that what they [the Arians] interpret ill, has a right interpretation' (35). While Athanasius ardently defended the full divinity of the Son, he refused to allow such a defence to undermine the integrity of the Incarnation, for it is to this purpose that the divinity must be upheld – so that it is truly the same divine Son who actually exists as an authentic man. Thus, as the *skopos* of the economy demands, the Son who is God must be the same Son who is man.

By insisting that it is one and the same Son, Athanasius was insisting that the incarnational 'becoming' terminates in an incarnational 'is'. In accordance with John's Gospel, the Word who was eternally God 'became man, and did not come into man', and it is equally here, then, as well that Athanasius insists that the biblical word 'flesh' means 'man' in his completeness (30). For Athanasius neither adoptionism nor merely the assuming of a material body will do. 'To become flesh' demands both that the Son *truly exists* as man and that it is *truly as man*, assuming all that pertains to being authentically human, that the Son exists. Athanasius noted that when the Logos came to the saints of old and hallowed them, it was never said that 'he had become man (γεγένηται ἄνθρωπος), nor, when they suffered was it said that he himself suffered' (31). It is only right, thought Athanasius, for the Son 'in putting on human flesh, to put it on whole with the affections (πάθη) proper to it' (32). Note that Athanasius insisted that the Son assumed the whole of what it means to be human and thus the *pathe*, those passible affections proper to it – passible affections that bear not merely upon the body as such, but upon the whole of the humanity, body and soul. Athanasius' whole concern was to establish this incarnational principle that 'when the flesh suffered, the Word was not external to it (ὅθεν τῆς σαρκὸς πασχούσης οὐκ ἦν ἐκτὸς ταύτης ὁ λόγος) ... and when He did divinely His Father's works, the flesh was not external to Him, but in the body itself did the Lord do them (οὐκ ἦν ἔξωθεν αὐτοῦ ἡ σάρξ, ἀλλ' ἐν αὐτῷ τῷ σώματι ταῦτα πάλιν ὁ κύριος ἐποίει)' (32)[4]. In the light of, and in accordance with, the above understanding of the Incarnation, Athanasius proceeded to interpret, in an almost monotonous fashion, the various Gospel passages that

[4] Athanasius argued that not only must the human affections and passions be predicated of the Son, but also that the Son's 'divine' deeds must equally be done as man. As incarnate the Son did not do divine deeds in a man, but he performed divine deeds as a man, for that is the manner in which the Son existed (see 32). It is in this sense that Athanasius' understanding of the Son using his humanity as an instrument (ὄργανον) must be understood. It is not an instrument external to him, but an instrument that is integral to the manner and mode of his very being and so acting – as man (see 31 and 35). Such an understanding of the Incarnation refutes any notion that Athanasius underplays or disregards the humanity of Christ. Moreover, it makes mockery of Hanson's own derision that Athanasius espouses a 'Space-suit Christology' where the Son's 'relation to this body is no closer than of an astronaut to his space-suit' (p. 448).

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the Arians believed demonstrated the Logos' createdness. Here I will focus on only one, and that the most problematic – Jesus' ignorance.

The Arians accusingly asked, if the Son is truly divine, how was it that Jesus needed to ask questions, such as where Lazarus was buried, and equally how was it that he admitted that he was ignorant of the last day? While the Word as God is omniscient, and so had no need to ask questions, nor was he then ignorant of the last day, yet, in accordance with the *skopos* of the economy and thus in keeping with the incarnational principle, Athanasius insisted that this very same Word did actually exist as man, and so as is only proper, was genuinely ignorant as man (see 37 and 38):

> it is plain that He knows ... as the Word, though as man He is ignorant of it [the last day], for ignorance is proper to man, and especially ignorance of these things. Moreover this is proper to the Saviour's love of man; for since He was made man, He is not ashamed, because of the flesh which is ignorant, to say 'I know not,' that he may shew that knowing as God, He is but ignorant according to the flesh. (43)

This is the incarnational paradigm that Athanasius employed throughout his interpretation of those scriptural passages that the Arians proffered as confirmation of the Word's non-divinity[5]. The real matter at hand for Athanasius was not, then, the issue of Christ's soul, but the proper incarnational understanding of how divine and human attributes are predicated of one and the same Son. The proper employment of this hermeneutical principle, for Athanasius, did not merely illustrate, but actually authenticated the truth of the Incarnation (see 35 and 57).

Critics have faulted Athanasius' interpretation on a number of further points. Firstly, the fact that Athanasius insisted that it was the Son who was the subject of the ignorance and yet that he, as God, is omniscient, demands, they insist, that the ignorance was merely feigned. Such a criticism misses entirely Athanasius' incarnational concern. The ignorance is not feigned in the slightest since Athanasius' entire concern was to ensure that, since the Son had actually become man, then all that pertains to being man, including ignorance, was properly his own. It was an authentic, and not a bogus, human life that the Son lived. Secondly, the fact that Athanasius did not have recourse to the soul or human intellect by way of situating the ignorance does not in any manner undermine his Christology. While Athanasius did not state that ignorance

[5] Thus, while the Son as divine is impassible, fearless, immortal, in no need of increase, yet as man the Son was passible, fearful, dies, and increases (see 31, 34, 52-57). All of these human weaknesses, as with ignorance, imply the presence of a human soul and intellect. Moreover, while Athanasius does describe the death of Jesus as the separation of the Son from his body, this does not imply, as the critics assume, the absence of a soul. It is again the insistence that it is actually the Son who dies as man. That Athanasius does see death as the departure of the soul from the body is witnessed in his twice noting that Jesus calls back Lazarus' soul when raising him from the dead (see 38 and 46).

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resided in the human soul or intellect, these were undoubtedly present within his stress on the authenticity of the Son's ignorance, which resided not in a body, but within a human intellect. The reason the soul or intellect is not mentioned is precisely because Athanasius' primary incarnational concern was to confirm that what is truly human, in this case genuine human ignorance, was rightly predicated of the Son of God, for it was he who existed as man. The Son, for Athanasius, is the primary and immediate bearer of the ignorance, and not the soul. While the soul is present, it is not present, for Athanasius, as an intermediate 'subject' shielding the divine Son from authentic human weakness. Thirdly, that Athanasius stressed that it was the Son who was the true subject of all the human attributes does not betoken, as some critics aver, a Logos/Sarx rather than a Logos/Anthropos Christology. Rather, this again illustrates Athanasius' true incarnational concern that it must be the Son who actually lived a human life. The criticism itself bears no relationship to his actual Christology; rather, it is the mere imposing of a flawed and erroneous template by which to interpret, and in the end falsely, his Christology. Actually, the whole issue and the ultimate censure of Athanasius' Christology for not subscribing to a human soul would never have arisen if these misconceived and artificial templates had not been capriciously imposed upon the whole of patristic Christology.

By way of conclusion, Athanasius employed, for soteriological reasons, this incarnational hermeneutical principle. All human attributes, attributes that imply a union of body and soul, such as suffering, ignorance, fear, and so on, must be predicated of the Son for it is only in the Son, assuming our human weaknesses in becoming man that we have been 'thoroughly delivered from them' (33). Being deified and made ourselves Word through baptism (33) only became possible because 'as the Lord, putting on the body, became man, so we men are deified by the Word as being taken to Him through His flesh, and henceforward inherit life everlasting (ὡς γὰρ ὁ κύριος ἐνδυσάμενος τὸ σῶμα γέγονεν ἄνθρωπος, οὕτως ἡμεῖς οἱ ἄνθρωποι παρὰ τοῦ λόγου τε θεοποιούμεθα προσληφθέντες διὰ τῆς σαρκὸς αὐτοῦ καὶ λοιπὸν ζωὴν αἰώνιον κληρονομοῦμεν)' (34; see 56 and 58). For Athanasius, then, it is only because the Son became an authentic human being so as to experience all that is thoroughly human, and thus undertake experiences which by their very nature imply both a body and a soul, that he was able to save us from sin and death so as to share with us his incorruptible life.

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XI. The Cappadocians

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The Poetic *Parrhesia* of Gregory of Nazianzus

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The voice of Gregory of Nazianzus is confident and bold. His forthright assertions of his devotion to God, his victimization in Constantinople, and the orthodoxy of his theology are unifying features of his ninety-nine autobiographical poems. It is therefore with some surprise that we read the final four lines of poem 5, a twelve-line lament for the Anastasia church in Constantinople, where he had preached upon his arrival in the capital[1]:

How is it I am childless, but my children live? Father,
glory to you, even if something worse than this should befall me.
Perhaps you fault my *parrhesia*.
Who will shout about you with knowledge, Trinity? (5.9-12)

A key to interpreting this unusual expression of self-doubt lies in Gregory's understanding of his own *parrhesia*. The word is often translated simply as 'boldness'[2]. Examination of the word's usage in five autobiographical poems reveals a contextual pattern that includes references to suffering, knowledge, and the unknown future, as well as a direct address to the Trinity.

The last twenty years have witnessed a blossoming of publications on the ancient concept of *parrhesia*. Scholars have identified its usage in the Classical Athenian world as political, the democratic right of each citizen to bold public speech[3]. By the Hellenistic period, it carries more personal and private

[1] All translations are my own, based on the Greek text in *PG* 37.

[2] For a history of the term, see G. Scarpat, *Parrhesia, storia del termine e delle sue traduzioni in latino* (Brescia: Paideia 1964); H. Schlier, in *Theologisches Wörterbuch zum Neuen Testament*, ed. G. Kittel *et al.* (Stuttgart: Kohlhammer 1933-79, 5), 869-83 s.v. *parrhesia*; L.J. Engels, 'Fiducia', in *RACh* 7, 852-60; and A. Momigliano, in *Dictionary of the History of Ideas*, ed. P.P. Wiener (New York: Scribner, 1973-4), 2, 252-3. See also the Introduction to *Philodemus, On Frank Criticism*, ed. and trans. D. Konstan, D. Clay, C. Glad, *et al.* (Atlanta: Scholars Press, 1998). On Gregory's understanding of the term, see F. Gautier, *La Retraite et la sacerdoce chez Grégoire de Nazianze*, Bibliothèque de l'École des hautes études sciences religieuses 114 (Turnhout: Brepols, 2002), pp. 14, 21; and J. McGuckin, *St. Gregory of Nazianzus: An Intellectual Biography* (Crestwood, NY: St. Vladimir's Seminary Press, 2001), pp. 141, 192, 195, 206, 213, 261, 331, 383. On the significance of the term for discourses of social power in late antiquity, see P. Brown, *Power and Persuasion in Late Antiquity, towards a Christian Empire* (Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 1992), pp. 61-70, 106-8, 116-7, 144.

[3] For the political connotations, see S.S. Monoson, 'Frank Speech, Democracy, and Philosophy: Plato's Debt to a Democratic Strategy of Civic Discourse', in *Athenian Political Thought*

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associations (both among the moral philosophers and in the Judaic tradition), and is understood to reflect one's right to instruct and speak openly to equals[4]. In the New Testament, as in works of the previous centuries, its usage varies widely, but it is generally seen to encompass the openness of men's relationship with God[5]. It has been summarized as an inner divine gift and its external expression[6]. It is the boldness of speech necessary for Christian teaching and the direct access to God that is granted to men through Christ's sacrifice[7].

Gregory's usage in the context of the autobiographical poems interweaves elements of all of these conceptions of the term in another marriage of the Greek and Christian traditions for which he is renowned. I will examine Gregory's references to his own *parrhesia* in the autobiographical poems, and using these and the traditional readings of the term, I will propose a reading for the problematic poem 5.

In Poem 14, an acrostic, Gregory laments how, despite his knowledge, he was forced from the episcopal throne of Constantinople. In the hidden message of the acrostic he advises his readers, 'Approach the acrostics and you will know clearly', suggesting that he as the author is their source of knowledge.

and the Reconstruction of American Democracy, ed. J.P. Euben, J. Wallach, and J. Ober (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1994), pp. 172-97; Y. Nakategawa, 'Isegoria and parrhesia', *Journal of Classical Studies* (Kyoto) 37 (1989), 1-11. On the influence of the idea of free speech in Athenian literature, see J. Henderson, 'Attic Old Comedy, Frank Speech, and Democracy', in *Democracy, Empire, and the Arts in Fifth-Century Athens*, Center for Hellenic Studies Colloquia 2, ed. D. Boedeker and K. Raaflaub (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1998), pp. 255-73; A. Carmignato, 'Demostene e la "parrhesia": diritto di critica e rifondazione dei valori democratici', *Invigilata Lucernis* 20 (1998), 33-57; and on Aeschylus, W. Wróblewski, 'Die Parrhesia als wesentliches Merkmal der athenischen Demokratie im Licht der literarischen Zeugnisse im 5. Jh. vor Chr.', *Eos* 78 (1990), 91-9. See also *TWNT* 5, s.v. *parrhesia*, A (pp. 869-72).

[4] See Konstan, Clay, Glad, *et al.*, *Philodemus*; C. Glad, *Paul and Philodemus: Adaptability in Epicurean and Early Christian Psychagogy*, Supplements to *Novum Testamentum* 81 (Leiden: Brill, 1995); D. Konstan, 'Friendship, Frankness and Flattery', in *Friendship, Flattery and Frankness of Speech: Studies on Friendship in the New Testament World*, Supplements to *Novum Testamentum* 82, ed. J.T. Fitzgerald (Leiden: Brill, 1996); and in the same volume, C. Glad, 'Frank Speech, Flattery, and Friendship in Philodemus', pp. 21-59, and D. Fredrickson, '*PARRHESIA* in the Pauline Epistles', pp. 163-83. See also *TWNT* 5, s.v. *parrhesia*, B (pp. 872-7).

[5] See Glad, *Paul and Philodemus*; S. Marrow, '*Parrhesia* in the New Testament', in *CBQ* 44 (1982), 431-46 (esp. p. 444 for distinctions between New Testament and other uses of the term); the articles in Part III of Fitzgerald, *Friendship, Flattery, and Frankness of Speech*, esp. A. Mitchell, SJ, 'Holding onto confidence: *parrhesia* in Hebrews', pp. 203-26; W.C. van Unnik, 'The "Book of Acts" – the confirmation of the Gospel', in *Sparsa Collecta: the Collected Essays of W. C. van Unnik*, vol. 1, Supplements to *Novum Testamentum* 29 (Leiden: Brill, 1973-83), pp. 340-73, and idem, 'The Christian's freedom of speech in the New Testament', in *Sparsa Collecta*, vol. 2, Supplements to *Novum Testamentum* 30 (Leiden: Brill, 1973-83); and *TWNT* 5, s.v. *parrhesia*, C (pp. 877-83).

[6] See Mitchell, 'Holding on to Confidence', pp. 213-4.

[7] This is clearly discussed by Marrow in the final section of his '*Parrhesia* and the New Testament'. See also van Unnik, 'The "Book of Acts"'.

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He begins the poem with a statement of his own knowledge through experience, and in line 11 he writes, 'I am the clever one (for I am not in the habit of thinking about trivial matters).' Having established his knowledge as a theme of the piece, he quotes his own theological battle-cry of the divinity of the Holy Spirit and claims in line 43 that no one can stop him from speaking these things. At the heart of the piece is an opposition between Gregory, who has a voice supported by his knowledge, and the poem's addressees, rival bishops, who have the episcopal thrones. It is to these men that he cries out in the poem, exercising his right to assertive expression before his political equals, or *parrhesia* in the Classical sense[8].

Gregory closes poem 14 by relating his suffering to his future salvation: 'Indeed, I suffered much, but even so, not earning an unfair / wage, as so many rewards await those dear to God' (59-60). He continues in lines 61-64 with Old Testament figures who overcame suffering – Isaiah, the three in the fire, and Daniel, and he follows these with mentions of the sufferings of Paul and Peter. Christ as sufferer completes the list in the poem's last three lines[9]:

Was the Forerunner not the sacrifice for *parrhesia*?
They know that I am dead. Thus, Father, I am
yours, even if you should wish to distress me with worse. (14.65-68)

Parrhesia is the result of Christ's suffering and death, in accordance with its New Testament usage[10]. Because the rhetorical question about the divine sacrifice follows directly after Paul and Peter, teachers about the Trinity, *parrhesia* in this context seems to refer to Christian teaching. The topics in these lines shift from Christ, to his death, to *parrhesia* (the centre of the series), to Gregory's 'death' in the eyes of his rivals, and finally to Gregory's relationship with God. Speaking about the Trinity thus appears as the fulcrum of the relationship between the Trinity (represented here by Christ) and men (represented by Gregory). The lines' structure parallels Gregory and Christ in their

[8] Van Unnik ('The "Book of Acts"', p. 369) discusses the *parrhesia* of the Apostles in appearing before Jewish leaders to speak about Christ and the plans of God. Gregory uses the term with similar connotations when praising Basil's speech before authorities (*Or.* 43.34, 50), as well as his brother Caesarius' (*Or.* 7.11).

[9] 'Forerunner' may first call to mind John the Baptist (see Gregory's *Oration* 6.7 and *Carmen* 1.2.3.24), but as Lampe's entry for the word reveals, it can refer to a variety of figures. Gregory, for example, also uses it of John the Evangelist (*Or.* 28.20). The word appears only once in the New Testament (Heb. 6:20), and there of Christ in reference to his salvific work. As Bauernfeind writes in his entry for the term in *TWNT* 8, 235, the word in this New Testament usage is 'part of the vocabulary of Christian edification'. This linking of Christ as Saviour with education corresponds well with Gregory's concerns in poem 14. Though John the Baptist as a speaker could be the 'Forerunner' in the poem, the NT usage and the nexus of vocabulary and imagery connecting *parrhesia* and Christ lead me to read it as Christ here. Moreover, Christ arguably functions more effectively than John the Baptist as a transitional figure in the progression from the human Old Testament and New Testament to the divine Father.

[10] See, e.g., Schlier's discussion in *TWNT* 5, 872-83.

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suffering, implying the former is consequently granted *parrhesia*, a right to which he already laid claim above in line 43. Moreover, his direct address to the Father is evidence of this *parrhesia*.

Gregory is prepared to suffer more because he knows that he belongs to God. His statement to this effect reflects the eschatological element that has been noted in New Testament usage of *parrhesia*[11]. He contrasts this knowledge with that of his rivals, which is mentioned in the same line. They 'know' he is dead, but their knowledge is incomplete, because Gregory's death is merely earthly and professional – a departure from Constantinople's community of ecclesial authorities. Gregory's knowledge, however, concerns his salvation and allows him both the right to address God and, through the poem, to instruct, like Paul, Peter, and Christ, and the moral philosophers[12].

A similar combination of Gregory's professional death, his belonging to the Trinity, and *parrhesia* appears in poem 70 with a direct address to Christ. In the second half of the seven-line poem, he laments his return to Nazianzus:

I am banished here, I do not have a station in life.
You call me from there, I do not have *parrhesia*.
I am yours, Christ; save me as you wish. (70.5-7)

Gregory paints himself as an exile – a political image that, in conjunction with the complaint of having no station in life, characterizes the use of *parrhesia* here as political. Yet Gregory attributes his banishment and subsequent lack of station and freedom to speak to the call of Christ. One might read the *parrhesia* lost as that between him and God, but the direct address to Christ and hence the poem itself deny this interpretation. Gregory ends the poem with a statement similar to the final line of poem 14, the notion that the Trinity will save or cause him suffering as it wishes. He thereby indicates his recognition and knowledge of the divine presence in his life. The *parrhesia* he has lost is that between himself and the laity; the see of Constantinople was the 'station' that allowed him the opportunity to provide instruction to the faithful ready to receive his teaching.

The elements noted in the passages above are present again in poem 30 – a claim to knowledge, suffering, a direct address to the Trinity, and mention of his own *parrhesia*. The poem is a history of Gregory's own inspiration for speech about the Trinity and of his experiences in the capital. He begins with a statement about the necessity for human endurance of the trials God brings;

[11] Mitchell, 'Holding on to Confidence', pp. 208-10, where he discusses E. Grässer's comments regarding the eschatology underlying *parrhesia* in the latter's *Der Glaube im Hebräerbrief*, Marburger theologische Studien 2 (Marburg: N.G. Elwert, 1965). See also Marrow, '*Parrhesia* and the New Testament', pp. 440-1, and *TWNT* 5, 876-7. D. Frederickson ('*PARRHESIA* in the Pauline Epistles', pp. 163-83; esp. pp. 179-80) relates the Pauline usage to suffering.

[12] Marrow, '*Parrhesia* and the New Testament', pp. 442-3.

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he then claims that he had been 'an ally to the stumbling logos' in the Arian-controlled Constantinople and that his suffering there has been noted. He next turns the discussion to the content of his speech:

For nothing ever so
  shook the whole earth
as the *parrhesia* of the Spirit –
  of God glorified,
which has made me hateful
  to my friends, I know.
And to you, Blessed One, the greatest thanks
  for this noble dishonor. (30.13-20)

In this context, *parrhesia* about the Spirit can be interpreted as Gregory's own preaching, which is consistently marked by assertions of the full divinity of the Holy Spirit. It is this expression of his theological stance, he 'knows', that lies behind his forced resignation, that is, that 'has made [him] hateful to [his] friends'. He makes a claim here to momentous theological statements with serious political consequences, yet he projects assurance in the ultimate value of exercising his free speech by labelling his ecclesial struggles a 'noble dishonor'. By suggesting that the reward for his theological teaching lies beyond the earthly sphere, he makes an implicit claim to knowledge of that other sphere, which is the very knowledge that justifies and demands his exercise of *parrhesia*, or theological preaching and instruction.

Parrhesia does appear in an autobiographical poem, 41, without these formulaic elements, but it is used in a negative sense of Maximus the Cynic, challenger for Constantinople's episcopal throne. Gregory exclaims in line 32 that Maximus is recognizable by his *parrhesia*. Just before the term appears, Gregory writes that the wise are restrained – the opposite of the boldness synonymous with *parrhesia*. He thus implies that Maximus's words lack wisdom. Following line 32, there is no direct address to the Trinity, only a comment about human laughter and mockery. Maximus has no direct access to God. The divine knowledge through suffering and the rights to pedagogical speech and direct access to God evidenced by Gregory's *parrhesia* are not universal; *parrhesia* is not inherently positive, but dependent on the character of the one exercising it[13].

In returning to poem 5, it is now possible to interpret Gregory's questioning use of the term. The formulaic elements of positive exercise of *parrhesia* are all present: suffering, a claim to knowledge, a direct address to the Trinity, and mention of the unknown future. Gregory reveals his knowledge of the true relationship between the Trinity and men in addressing God as 'Father' just

[13] A caveat to make use of *parrhesia* 'with reason and measure' appears in autobiographical poem 12.761ff., and there are similar comments in *De vita sua* (lines 1617, 1751). Gregory mentions his own positive use of it in the latter poem at lines 690 and 1659.

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after asking, 'How is it I am childless, but my children live?' He juxtaposes the impermanence and vulnerability of earthly relationships, even between priest and flock, and the permanence of the care of the true Father for all his children. Gregory claims in lines 4-5 to have effected a resurrection of the faith through his preaching in the Anastasia, making his exercise of *parrhesia* an act of *imitatio Christi*. Put in such terms, it is difficult to fault his free speech. Three unanswered questions appear in the final five lines of the poem, but the comment on *parrhesia* is a potential statement, expressing less doubt and confusion than the direct questions. It can be read as a rhetorical device, especially given that the rest of the poem is an argument for his proper use of speech in imitation of Christ.

Gregory's doubting his *parrhesia* in poem 5 can be interpreted in accordance with any one of the three traditional understandings of the term. First, as a political statement, it suggests that he was overconfident in his rhetorical skills as support for his theological arguments, especially in such a hostile political climate. This doubt reveals Gregory's lack of confidence in an ultimate victory in the contemporary theological battles, a confidence, as John McGuckin has pointed out, that has been retrospectively attributed to him by those who know of his later acclamation as the 'Theologian'.[14] Second, interpreting *parrhesia* as moral instruction, we can read the statement as implying that Gregory doubts his fellow bishops and priests are his equals, and that he feels the laity are as yet unprepared to receive his teaching. Third, if the term refers to Gregory's own relationship with the Trinity, the insecurity seems to concern how his suffering in the events of 381 reflects and affects his salvation – an interpretation supported by his wondering whether more suffering will be his lot.

The reader, however, who understands the term on all three levels – whose knowledge of *parrhesia* is equal to Gregory's and who thus shares *parrhesia* with him – derives a fuller meaning from the poem. The poem itself belies his doubting the Trinity's acceptance of his 'free speech' or 'boldness' in that Gregory uses it to address the Trinity and to instruct his audience about the nature of the relationship between man and God. It exemplifies how with humility and recognition of the divine presence in one's life, a man may directly address the Trinity.

Gregory is unsure not of his past *parrhesia*, but of his future *parrhesia* – that which is to be shared with the audience of his poetry and on which depends his and their open communication with God, and, therefore, salvation. He perhaps wonders about the acceptability and efficacy of this new form of Christian teaching through personal poetry. His orientation toward the future is reflected in the closing question of poem 5, 'Who will shout about you knowingly, Trinity?' to which we can answer, 'Gregory will, and with confidence.'

[14] J. McGuckin, 'Autobiography as Apologia in St. Gregory of Nazianzus', *SP* XXXVII (2001), 160-77, esp. pp. 167-8.

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Is Gregory of Nazianzus the Author of an Unedited Text on the Plagues of Egypt?

Guillaume BADY, Lyon

At the end of 1995, Jean Bernardi and André Tuilier asked me to help them in their great project of a new critical edition of the *Poems* of Gregory of Nazianzus for the Collection des Universités de France[1]. Recently, while I was working on a description of every manuscript's content, I got stuck in identifying one piece of verse I found in the *Londiniensis add.* 32643. This is the text I would like to lay out for you here, before I discuss the problem of its authenticity.

1. Presentation of the Text

a) Presentation of the Manuscript

The manuscript[2] is a small vellum codex; in its present shape, it comprises 195 folios and measures 135x110mm. It is mostly made of trinions, with occasional quaternions and quinions. The last quires from folio 168 were added later, since the lections from the Gospels they contain show a writing that can be dated to the fourteenth century, whereas the first part of the codex is written in a small, brown elegant writing of the early twelfth century. Uncials (like A, E, H, K, N) are mixed with minuscules, square breathings are noted as well as round ones, and every accent is indicated; abbreviations are not infrequent.

The manuscript contains a selection of short texts, like quotations from John of Damascus (f. 1) and the Council of Nicaea (f. 26v), an anonymous presentation of the prophets (f. 31v) and of the odes of the Old Testament

[1] The first volume, *Grégoire de Nazianze. Œuvres poétiques, tome I, 1ère partie, Poèmes personnels, II, 1, 1-11,* was published in 2004 in the Collection des Universités de France, Série grecque 433 (Paris: Les Belles Lettres, 2004). A. Tuilier and I prepared the critical text and J. Bernardi translated it with a full introduction.

[2] See the short description of it in the *Catalogue of Additions to the Manuscripts in the British Museum in the Years MDCCCLXXXII-MDCCCLXXXVII* (London, 1889), p. 169; see also M. Richard, *Inventaire des manuscrits grecs du British Museum*, Publications de l'Institut de Recherche et d'Histoire des Textes 3 (Paris, 1952), p. 55.

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(f. 44), a so-called dialogue between Basil and Gregory the Theologian (f. 46), a letter (*ep.* 80, f. 49v) and several poems of Gregory (entitled Γρηγορίουί τοῦ θεολόγου πρὸς τὴν ἑαυτὴν ψυχὴν ἡμιάμβια, f. 51) – among them the text I am discussing – and then various texts from Anastasius of Sinai (f. 69), John Chrysostom (f. 87), Hesychius of Jerusalem (f. 105), Christophoros of Alexandria (f. 118v), and fragments from the Gospels (f. 185v).

Our text is written in one column on f. 53rv. The ruling type is Leroy 20A1. The letters mostly hang under the horizontal ruling lines; each one of the ten lines of text starts with a number, from A to I, placed on the left margin line and followed by the initial of every line a little bit to the left of the text ruling line. The end of each stich is marked by a double dot followed by a dash.

The disposition in stichs and the presence of the text among Gregory's verse seem to give a clue. But it is too early to say anything.

b) Text and translation

Now here is the text itself. The only critical note to mention is that the article τῇ in line 7 is written *supra lineam* by the same hand.

Αἱ τοῖς Αἰγυπτίοις ὑπὸ θεοῦ μάστιγες διὰ τὸν Ἰσραὴλ ἐπενεχθεῖσαί εἰσι αὗται·
A Τὸ ὕδωρ τοῦ ποταμοῦ εἰς αἷμα μετεβλήθη·
B Ὀλεθρίους βατράχους ἀνέδωκεν ἡ γῆ·
Γ Οἱ σκνῖπες τὸν ἀέρα καὶ τὴν γῆν ἐκάλυψαν·
Δ Ἡ κυνάμυια ἐπῆλθεν ἰοβόλος·
E Τοῖς κτήνεσι θάνατος ἐφώρμησε·
ς Φλυκτίδες τοῖς τῶν ἀνθρώπων ἀνεφύησαν σώμασιν·
Z Ἔβρεξε χαλάζα, καὶ πῦρ φλογίζον ἐν τῇ χαλάζῃ·
H Ἀκρὶς καὶ βροῦχος ἅπαν χλωρὸν καὶ ξύλον κάρπιμον ἐν Αἰγύπτῳ κατήδετο· | 53v
Θ Σκότος ψηλαφητὸν πᾶσαν τὴν γῆν ἐκάλυψεν Αἰγύπτου·
I Πᾶν πρωτότοκον ἀπὸ ἀνθρώπου ἕως κτήνους ὠλοθρεύθη τῶν Αἰγυπτίων.

Here is our translation:

The plagues inflicted by God upon the Egyptians are the following:
the water of the river was turned into blood;
the earth sent up deadly frogs;
the gnats covered the air and the earth;
the venomous dog-fly came up;
death attacked the livestock;
boils grew on the bodies of men;
hail fell and fire burning in the hail;
locust and larva devoured every plant and fruit-bearing tree in Egypt;
a darkness that can be felt covered the whole land of Egypt;
every firstborn, from man to livestock, perished among the Egyptians.

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2. Discussion about the authenticity

a) External evidence

In the manuscript the text is not explicitly attributed to any author. The location of the text among Gregory's poems cannot at any rate be conclusive, for two fragments from other authors have been inserted among them as well, the first placed immediately after our text on f. 53v and allegedly taken from Basil and Gregory of Nyssa (though it cannot literally be found in any of the known works of either of the two brothers)[3], the second taken from Basil's *In sanctam Christi generationem*[4] (PG 31, 1460C-1461A), on f. 62v-63r.

The actual sequence of f. 51-68v, then, is the following (numbers follow Migne's order):

II.1.88 – text on the plagues of Egypt – Βασιλείου καὶ Γρηγορίου Νύσης [*sic*]· πῶς ἐπιγινώσκει ἡ ψυχὴ τὸ ἴδιον σῶμα – II.1.78 – II.1.26 – II.1.80 – II.1.64 – I.2.11 – II.1.86 – II.1.77a – I.2.35 – I.2.37 – *epitaphium* 2 – II.1.45 (vv. 1-31) – I.1.15 (Ἡ τοῦ Μωυσέως δεκάλογος) – I.2.33 – Basil's *In sanctam Christi generationem* – I.1.16 (Εἰς τὰ θαύματα Ἠλίου τοῦ προφήτου καὶ Ἐλισαίου) – II.1.14 – *epitaphia* 119, 22, 23, and 24 – II.1.91 – II.1.90 – *epitaphia* 120 and 121 – II.1.46

This selection of Gregory's poems diverges from any other in Gregory's manuscripts; it does not seem to follow any specific order nor any precise aim, except that of being instructive; death is the major topic, together with asceticism; from that perspective, the selected epitaphia are among the best.

More generally, as one can see, the codex seems simply to be an anthology meant for teaching and spiritual reading, picking up passages from different authors without any visible link between them. Under those circumstances, the text on the plagues of Egypt might well have been written by a writer other than Gregory.

Besides, the *Londiniensis* is the only extant manuscript of the text; since it is by far neither the oldest nor the most complete manuscript among those of Gregory's poems, it becomes clear that, in terms of external evidence, the text cannot be attributed to Gregory of Nazianzus: *testis unus, testis nullus*, as the saying goes.

[3] Βασιλείου καὶ Γρηγορίου Νύσης· πῶς ἐπιγινώσκει ἡ ψυχὴ τὸ ἴδιον σῶμα:- Ὥσπερ σφραγὶς ἐν κηρῷ· διαμένει γὰρ τῷ μνημονικῷ τῆς ψυχῆς σημεῖα τοῦ σώματος· καὶ ἐν τοῖς ἀλόγοις τοῦτο ἴδοις· ὁ γὰρ νεογνὸς ἀρνὸς πολλὰς παρατρέχων πήγας πρὸς τὴν μητρῷαν θήλην τρέχει μήτε τῷ ὁμοχρόων ὁμόφρονι δελεαζόμενος.

[4] Title: Τοῦ ἁγίου Βασιλείου ἐκ τοῦ εἰς τὰ γενέθλια λόγου. *Incipit*: Τίνα τρόπον, φησίν, ἐν σαρκὶ ἡ θεότης; *desinit*: οὐ τῇ θεότητι τῆς οἰκείας μετέδωκεν ἀσθενείας.

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b) Internal evidence

Some internal evidence might mitigate this judgement. As a matter of fact, there are many similarities with Gregory's poem on the Plagues of Egypt (I.1.14, in PG 37, 475-476). It should be noted here that there are more than a few doublets (of sentences or verses) in Gregory's works. Now here is Gregory's text (words similar to the *Londiniensis* text are in italics):

Μάστιγας Αἰγύπτοιο κακόφρονος αἰὲν ἀρίθμει,
Ὅς κεν ὑποτρομέῃς κάρτεϊ τῷ μεγάλῳ.
Αἵματι μὲν πρώτιστον ὕδωρ ἐρυθαίνετο γαίης,
Δεύτερον αὖ βατράχους ἔβρασεν οὐλομένους.
Τὸ τρίτον αὖ, σκνίπεσσιν *ἀὴρ καὶ γαῖα* καλύφθη.
Καὶ κυνόμυια φάνη τέτρατον ἐξαπίνης.
Πέμπτον, τετραπόδεσσιν ἐπέχραε λυγρὸς ὄλεθρος.
Φλυκτίδες *ἀνθρώπων σώμασιν*, ἕκτον ἄχος.
Ἕβδομον, ὅσε χάλαζα μέση πυρὸς, ὄμβρος ἄμικτος.
Ὄγδοον, ἐξ ἀκρίδος ὤλετο *χλωρὸν ἅπαν*.
Εἶνατον, Αἰγύπτοιο πέδον κατὰ νὺξ ἐκάλυψε
Πρωτοτόκων δὲ μόρος ἡ δεκάτη βάσανος.

The two texts have sixteen words in common. But this might not be relevant, for if you look at the biblical text of Exodus 7:17 to 11:5, you will find the actual origin of the text's vocabulary: τὸ ὕδωρ τὸ ἐν τῷ ποταμῷ and μεταβαλεῖ εἰς αἷμα occur in 7:17; βατράχους and ἐκάλυψεν τὴν γῆν in 8:2; σκνῖφες in 8:12 (σκνῖπες is an older form); ἡ κυνόμυια in 8:25 (κυνάμυια again is an older form); τῶν κτηνῶν in 9:6; φλυκτίδες and ἀνθρώποις in 9:9; χάλαζα, ἔβρεξεν, and πῦρ φλογίζον ἐν τῇ χαλάζῃ in 9:23-24; ἀκρίς, χλωρὸν and πάντα τὸν καρπὸν τῶν ξύλων in 10:14-15; σκότος ἐπὶ γῆν Αἰγύπτου ψηλαφητόν in 10:21; πᾶν πρωτότοκον and ἀπὸ ... ἕως in 11:5. A proof that the author of the text, or at least the copyist, had an eye on Exodus is that he added *supra lineam* the article τῇ I mentioned above in ἐν τῇ χαλάζῃ to imitate Ex 9:24.

Furthermore, some words and phrases that are not familiar to Gregory seem to be inspired by other biblical passages: ἰοβόλος from Wi 16:10, ἀνεφύησαν from 1 Rg 5:6 (about rats bringing death), βροῦχος from Ps 105:34 or Jl 2:25, ξύλον κάρπιμον from Gn 1:11, πᾶν χλωρόν from Gn 2:5 (see also Deut 29:22; Is 27:11; Rev 9:4); and ὀλοθρεύω is a verb used particularly in the bible (see Ex 12:23 for example).

However, three phrases that can be read in our text as well as in Gregory's have no equivalent in any other text, even as variants in biblical manuscripts: I have underlined, then, the mention of 'air and earth' for the third plague, the 'bodies of men' for the sixth, and ἅπαν χλωρὸν for the eighth (the form ἅπαν instead of πᾶν here not being negligible).

As a consequence, our text must have been directly influenced by Gregory's poem. The manuscript's actual content provides evidence of that, for in the series of Gregory's poems you can find two pieces of verse following poem

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I.1.14 in the Maurists' order – namely, I.1.15 (on Moses' Decalogue) and 16 (on Elijah's miracles); number 15 actually follows number 14 in the manuscript tradition.

Our text might have been written in the margin of Gregory's poem and then selected by the author of the *Londiniensis* anthology, who obviously had a large library at his disposal, comprising a larger selection of Gregory's verse than the *Londiniensis* shows. It could even be suggested that the text was composed by the author of two other texts in the selection that seem to be similar in their didactic presentation – the one on the prophets (f. 31v) and the one on the odes of the Old Testament (f. 44). That author could even be the one who produced these miscellanea; in that case he must have lived after Christophoros of Alexandria (patriarch from 817 to 848) and after the alleged sub-archetype of the ζ family in Gregory's manuscript tradition, which the *Londiniensis* belongs to – that is to say, not before the tenth century.

In the end, our text cannot really be compared to Gregory's elegiac distichs. For it simply is not a poem: it obeys no prosodic system, not even by counting accents or syllables. One might recognize a grammatical chiasm (line 1/2) and a hyperbaton (line 6), or perceive words sounding like locusts (line 8) and long vowels imitating the widespreading shadow (line 9), but that does not make a ten-line text a true poem.

On the contrary, there are many clues showing that the text is nothing but mere prose. The title is not a formal one, as one would expect for a poem: it consists of a sentence, and, in spite of announcing a literary piece, it simply refers to the plagues themselves. The author avoids poetical forms (compare Αἰγύπτου and Αἰγύπτοιο, σκνῖπες and σκνίπεσσιν, ἐκάλυψαν and καλύφθη), even though the text provides rare forms such as κατήδετο (for κατεδήδετο?) and ὠλοθρεύθη that are not witnessed anywhere else.

c) Negative evidence given by other texts

Last, but not least, I have been fortunate to find three other texts on the plagues of Egypt in various manuscripts. I was unable to read them all, but the available information on them tends to show that they have no link with Gregory's poem or with the *Londiniensis* text. Moerover, the manuscripts do not contain any of Gregory of Nazianzus' works.

The first is in Athens, National Library 2429, of the fourteenth century, f. 71v. I only know its title (Ποῖαι εἰσὶν αἱ πληγαί, ἅσπερ ἐπήγαγεν τοῖς Αἰγυπτίοις ὁ θεὸς ὑπὲρ Ἑβραίων) and *incipit* (Δέκα πληγὰς ὁ Θεὸς τοῖς Αἰγυπτίοις) from the catalogue[5].

[5] L. Politis, *Κατάλογος χειρογράφων τῆς Ἐθνικῆς Βιβλιοθήκης τῆς Ἑλλαδος ἀρ. 1857-2500* (Athens, 1991), p. 428.

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The second is from Saint Stephen's monastery in the Meteora (*Hagiou Stephanou* 22), of the sixteenth century, f. 277r. It seems to differ widely from the *Londiniensis* text[6]. It is entitled Τὸ κατ' εἶδος τῆς δωδεκαπλήγου τῆς ἐν τῇ Αἰγύπτων. The first, second, and twelfth lines, numbered in the left margin, are the following[7]:

α ἡ ῥάβδος τοῦ Μωυσέως ἐγένετο δράκων ῥιφεὶς ἔμπροσθεν τοῦ φαραῶ
β τὰ ὕδατα μεταστραφέντα εἰς αἷμα
ιβ ἀπώλοντο ἐν τῇ θαλάσσῃ οἱ Αἰγύπτιοι πάντες.

The third text is *Marcianus gr. app.* VII 18, of the sixteenth century, f. 227v, which I saw on microfilm at the Institut de Recherche et d'Histoire des Textes in Paris. Entitled Εἰς τὰς δέκα πληγὰς τῶν Αἰγυπτίων, it reads as follows (with numbers in the left margin corresponding to each plague):

Αἰγυπτιακὰς εἰ μαθεῖν πληγὰς θέλεις,
α μεταβολὴν ὕδατος εἰς αἷμα μάθε·
β γ πλῆθος βατράχων καὶ σκνιπῶν αὖθις βίαν·
δ φορᾶν χαλάζης καὶ πυρὸς δεινὸν σέλας·
ε ς ἀκρίδα συχνὸν, ψηλαφητόν τε σκότος·
ζ τὰ σαρκὸς ἕλκη φλυκτίδων ἄνθη ξένα·
η θ τὴν κυνόμυιαν τὴν φθορὰν τῶν ἀλόγων·
ι γόνων τε πρώτων ἐξαπίναιον μόρον.

And there is a fourth in Japan. I thank Professor Neil McLynn for letting me know of its existence just after the presentation of this paper; he then examined on the manuscript and checked that it did actually differ from the *Londiniensis* text. I quote his words: 'It is a very loose paraphrase, somewhat similar to your text; moreover, it forms part of a small group of such variations on Gregorian themes.' Interesting as it is, this should be the subject of another study.

Though the information is not exhaustive, it is likely that there are no exact coincidences between these texts. Incomplete and negative as it is, the comparison between them only makes more striking the similarity of the three phrases I noted in Gregory's poem and in the *Londiniensis*.

Finally, this leads us to a double conclusion. On the one hand, the fine ten-line text in *Londiniensis add.* 32643 might have been a school exercise; at least, it belongs to a didactic and mnemonic genre. From that point of view, the plagues of Egypt seem to have raised a peculiar need for a clear numbering throughout the centuries. On the other hand, the *Londiniensis* text was very

[6] Cf. D.Z. Sophianos, *Les manuscrits des Météores*, vol. III, *Les manuscrits du monastère de Saint-Etienne (Hagios Stephanos)*, (Athens, 1986), p. 62, nº 94.

[7] The text is followed by an interesting note on the number of plagues (10 or 12): Τινὲς δὲ δεκάπληγον ταῦτα λέγουσιν ὑπερεξεροῦντες τοῦ ἀριθμοῦ τήν τε πρώτην, τῆς περὶ τῆς ῥάβδου φημί, καὶ τὴν τελευταῖαν τὴν περὶ τοῦ καταποντισμοῦ.

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probably inspired by one of Gregory's poems. In as much as Gregory's poem was obviously intended for instruction, it testifies to the Nazianzen's didactic influence in Byzantine times.

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Eikôn Theou: Meanings of Likeness in Gregory of Nazianzus

Jostein BØRTNES, Bergen

In the florilegia to his *Treatises against the Iconoclasts*, John of Damascus quotes extensively from the Cappadocian fathers[1]. But there are very few texts from Gregory of Nazianzus, only one, in fact, where he actually speaks about an eikon in the sense of a painted picture. This occurs in the story about Polemon, once 'a servant of exceedingly shameful pleasures', 'later possessed by a longing for the good', and 'suddenly seen getting the better of the passions'. In the second part of the quoted passage, Gregory tells the story of his wonder-working *eikon*:

A dissolute youth invited in a whore.
But when, they say, she came up to the gateway,
there, gazing at her, was Polemon in an eikon [Πολέμων ἐν εἰκόνι],
seeing it, and it was awesome, indeed,
she left at once, defeated by the sight,
put to shame by the one depicted, as if he were alive.
(*PG*,37, 738, Carm. 1. 2, 10, 802-807)[2]

The 'magical power of the gaze' that we find in these lines is, as Thomas Mathews has recently observed, a common feature in early Christian and contemporary non-Christian *eikons*[3]. The *eikon* Gregory refers to belongs most probably to this second category. In modern scholarship Polemon is assumed to be the rhetor Antonius Polemon (c. AD 88-144), whom Gregory, according to Jerome, liked to imitate (*secutus est autem Polemonis in dicendo charactera*: Hier., *de vir. ill.* 117). There may, however, be a conflation here with the Athenian Polemon, head of the Academy from 314 to ca. 276 BC, who, according to one account, quoted by Wayne A. Meeks, was "so profligate and dissipated that he actually carried about him money to procure the immediate gratification of his desires, and would even keep sums concealed in lanes and alleys"[4]. Gregory's

[1] Cf. St John of Damascus, *Three Treatises on the Divine Images*, tr. with introd. by Andrew Louth (New York: St Vladimir's Seminary Press, 2003).

[2] Louth, p. 145. Translation altered.

[3] Cf. in particular Thomas F. Mathews, *The Clash of Gods: A Reinterpretation of Early Christian Art*, (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 2003), in particular pp. 177-95, the new chap. 7, 'The Intimate Icon'.

[4] Wayne A. Meeks, *The Origins of Christian Morality: The First Two Centuries*, London & New Haven: Yale University Press, 1993, 22.

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exemplum is thus an interesting gloss on the recent debate about pagan and Christian domestic cult eikons in Late Antiquity[5].

The story about Polemon is the only place I know of where Gregory talks about a particular domestic *eikon*. But *eikons* in the sense of painted panels are discussed in a different context in Gregory's fourth oration, his first *Invective against Julian* (written and published shortly after the emperor's death in 363). 'There is a law relating to the emperor', Gregory says here, 'that those in power should be honoured by official portraits' (*or.* 4.80)[6]. It appears from Gregory's diatribe against Julian that by the mid-fourth century the cult of the emperor's image, so problematic for Christians in the preceding century, had been given a new, Christian meaning and was an accepted fact of Christian life[7]. The empire was perceived as a *mimesis* of the heavenly kingdom, the emperor as the *eikon* and vicegerent of Christ. It is only when Julian combines the eikon of the emperor with eikons of the pagan gods that the Christians are again forced to choose between paying homage to the emperor together with the idols, thereby insulting the emperor by accepting the idols as his equals, or to abstain from the proskynesis and be accused of lese-majesty, running the danger of suffering condemnation for 'the true Emperor and the true faith' (*or.* 4.81).

Still, although the adoration of imperial images and statues had been confirmed by law, Gregory's feelings about them remained ambivalent. Many years later he returns to the topic in oration 28 criticising those

> who have worshipped eikons and statues (εἰκόνας καὶ πλάσματα), first of their beloved ones, in particular those most exposed to grief and with the closest relationships with the corpses, honouring the departed with memorials. Later even those of strangers, too. Men remote from these strangers in time and space and ignorant of the first nature, followed the traditional worship as a law and a necessity. For with the time the custom consolidated into a law. (*or.* 28.14)[8]

Worshippers of images and statues have erred in their efforts to comprehend God and the first cause. For since thinking beings are unable to grasp him, they may do one of two things:

[5] Panel paintings of philosophers is discussed by Pliny in connection with Epicurus, whose *eikons* 'were so popular in domestic cults that he blames them for the decline of the Roman tradition of verist ancestor portraiture' (Mathews, p. 180).

[6] Translated from Grégoire de Nazianze, *Discours 4-5: Contre Julien*, ed. Jean Bernardi, SC 309 (Paris: Du Cerf, 1983).

[7] The Roman ruler-cult was Christianised already in the first half of the fourth century. Cf. Norman H. Baynes, 'Eusebius and the Christian Empire' (1933), in *Byzantine Studies and Other Essays*, (London: Athlone Press, 1955 Westport, Conn.: Greenwood Press, 1974), pp. 168-72.

[8] Grégoire de Nazianze, *Discours 27-31 (Discours Théologiques)*, ed. Paul Gallay, SC 250 (Paris: Du Cerf, 1978). In addition, I have used the translations in *Faith Gives Fullness to Reasoning: The Five Theological Orations of Gregory Nazianzen*, introd. and comm. by Frederick Norris, tr. Lionel Wickham and Frederick Williams (Leiden: Brill, 1991).

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Either they look at things visible and make of these a god – a gross mistake, for what visible thing is more sublime, more godlike than the observer, and to what degree, that it should be the object, be the subject, of worship? – Or they discover God through the beauty and order of things seen, using sight as a guide to what transcends sight without losing God through the grandeur of what they see. (*or.* 28.13)

In contrast to the first belief, according to which gods are made out of visible things, the second conceives of god as transcending the order and beauty of creation. But reason, which proceeds from God (ὁ ἐκ Θεοῦ λόγος) and is implanted in all from the beginning, leads us from visible things to God (*or.* 28.16).

'Have you ever heard of God as an embodied being?', Gregory asks towards the end of his fourth *Theological Oration*, responding that this is 'a non-factual, mental picture' (Πότε δὲ σῶμα Θεὸν ἀκήκοας; Τοῦτο οὐκ ὂν ἀνεπλάσθη) and that 'the various powers or workings of God have been represented by various corporeal images' (*or.* 31.22).

By translating his mental images into rhetorical *eikons*, Gregory conveys to his listeners the meaning of 'remembering God' (μεμνῆσθαι Θεοῦ) and 'meditating day and night' (μελετᾶν ἡμέρας καὶ νυκτὸς) in 'continual remembrance' of God (τὸ μεμνῆσθαι διηνεκῶς) (*or.* 27.4)[9].

Mary Carruthers has shown that remembrance or recollection of God (μνήμη Θεοῦ) – the nominal equivalent to Gregory's verbal expression, 'to remember God' – was a technical term in early monasticism, where it describes 'the constant meditation based on reading and recollecting sacred texts'. It is a kind of 'memory', she says, that is

not restricted to what we now call memory, but is a much more expansive concept, for it recognizes the essential role of emotion, imagination, and cogitation within the activity of recollection. Closer to its meaning is our term 'cognition', the construction of thinking. Monastic meditation is the craft of making thoughts about God[10].

In this form of verbal image making, the art of mimetic representation is less important than the art of memory, or *mneme*. Carruthers asserts that the main difference between an art of *mneme* and the aesthetics of *mimesis* is that

works by *mneme* stress the cognitive use and the instrumentality of art over questions of its 'realism'. *Mneme* produces an art for 'thinking about' and for 'meditating upon'. An art of tropes and figures is an art of patterns and pattern making, and thus an art of *mneme* or *memoria*, of cogitation, thinking[11].

[9] Mental images and the *eikôn Theou* in fourth century Christian theology is discussed in Elizabeth A. Clark, *The Origenist Controversy* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1992), especially pp. 43-84: 'Image and Images: Evagrius Ponticus and the Anthropomorphite Controversy'.

[10] Mary Carruthers, *The Craft of Thought: Meditation, Rhetoric, and the Making of Images, 400-1200* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1998), p. 2.

[11] Carruthers, p. 4.

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When *eikons* are used in their *mnemic* function, it is not their 'truth content' that matters, but their meaning 'as sites upon which and by means of which the human mind can build its compositions, whether these be thoughts or prayers'[12].

In their cognitive, *mnemic* function, Gregory's *eikons* are indispensable for his art and method of remembering God. But there comes a point when Gregory has to leave his cognitive imagery behind, when he must admit that he has 'failed to find anything in this world with which I might compare the divine nature':

there is nothing that fastens my thought on the examples when I contemplate the mental image I have (Καὶ ὅλως οὐδέν ἐστιν ὅ μοι τὴν διάνοιαν ἵστησιν ἐπὶ τῶν ὑποδειγμάτων θεωροῦντι τὸ φανταζόμενον) ... So, in the end I resolved that it was best to have done with images and shadows (τὰς μὲν εἰκόνας ... καὶ σκιάς), deceptive as they are and far removed from reality. (or. 31.33)

So far, verbal *eikons* have been an essential part of Gregory's 'cognitive invention', or 'cognitive representation'. Now, the dominant function of Gregory's *eikons* is no longer their *mnemic*, cognitive function. The focus is now their 'doctrinal sense', Carruthers' term for 'the verisimilitude of an image: does God look like a human being?'[13] As we have just seen, Gregory's answer to this question is in the negative. Nothing is similar to God.

When Gregory turns to the problem of divine likeness, he claims that it will only be achieved 'when this divine thing, I mean our mind and reason (ἡμέτερον νοῦν τε καὶ λόγον), mingles with its kin, and the *eikon* returns to the archetype it now longs after (ἡ εἰκὼν ἀνέλθῃ πρὸς τὸ ἀρχέτυπον, οὗ νῦν ἔχει τὴν ἔφεσιν)' (*or.* 28.17).

But how can embodied human beings be images of a Godhead situated beyond all creation? His poem 'On the Soul' is one of several texts in which Gregory tries to come to terms with this problem:

With these words he took a portion of the new-formed earth
and established with his immortal hands my shape,
bestowing upon it a share of his own life. He infused
Spirit, which is a fragment of the Godhead without form.
From dust and breath I was formed, a mortal man eikon of
the immortal.

(70-75)[14]

This passage is an illustrative example of how Gregory constructs his rhetorical images. By bringing together elements from the two accounts of the cre-

[12] Carruthers, p. 72.

[13] Carruthers, p. 73.

[14] Translated by D.A. Sykes in St Gregory of Nazianzus, *Poemata Arcana*, ed. with a textual introd. by C. Moreschini, introd., tr., and comm. by D.A. Sykes, Engl. transl. of textual introd. by Leofranc Holford-Stevens, (Oxford: Clarendon Pess, 1997), p. 37. The last line my transl. (JB).

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ation of man in the Genesis, adding a third from his classical repertoire, the 'χείρεσιν ἀθάνατησιν' from the *Iliad* (χείρεσσ' ἀθανάτησι *Il.* 16. 704), Gregory represents himself both as 'mortal' and as 'image of the immortal' (βροτὸς ἀθανάτοιο εἰκών) shaped by 'the formless Godhead's immortal hands'. Georgia Frank has recently observed that Gregory uses an embodied language to describe God, in spite of his insistence on God's indescribability[15]. He uses the verbal *eikon mnemically* in order to visualise the *mimetic* relation between image and archetype, playing on the double meaning of 'immortal', using it both as an epithet of the Creator's hands and as a metonomy for Christ. Gregory sees his own self as the mortal image of the Son, 'the Word of God, the timeless Son, the image of the prototype, a nature equal to his who begot him', as Gregory puts it in his poem 'On the Son'[16]. Through *mimesis* of the Son's archetype, the Christian will at some transcendent point become transformed into an *eikon* of the Father.

[15] The Cappadocians 'would probably have been surprised by how rapidly such embodied language was dropped ... Pseudo-Dionysius avoids God's body altogether'. See Georgia Frank, *The Memory of the Eyes: Pilgrims to Living Saints in Christian Late Antiquity* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2000), p. 89.

[16] Sykes, p. 5.

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Athens and Strategic Autobiography in Basil of Caesarea and Gregory of Nazianzus

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1. Introduction*

I take it as admitted by men of sense, that the first of our advantages is education; and not only this our more noble form of it, which disregards rhetorical ornaments and glory, and holds to salvation, and beauty in the objects of our contemplation; but even that external culture which many Christians ill-judgingly abhor, as treacherous and dangerous, and keeping us afar from God[1].

With these well-known words of his *Funeral Oration in honour of Basil of Caesarea*, Gregory of Nazianzus began his account of the late metropolitan's education, and especially of the time which he had spent studying in Athens. Gregory's defence of the education which Basil had received at pagan schools hints at the fact that some Christians in the eastern part of the Roman Empire in the later fourth century were still critical of those who were too learned in pagan thought and culture. These words also show that Gregory had to defend his own education. In the poem entitled *On himself and the bishops*, which he composed shortly after his resignation of the metropolitan see of Constantinople, he described his vision of an ideal bishop[2]: especially in his day, 'at this time of unbridled tongues where the most formidable cities and assemblies are in debate', there was a need for bishops who were skilled in dealing with theological controversies. Gregory then introduces an objection raised by one of the fictitious addressees of the poem:

But I shall be confronted, of course, by the fishermen and publicans who were evangelists. Though barren of eloquence their simple preaching drew the universe into the net, and even the wise were caught.

Being himself a rhetorician educated in Athens, Gregory was also affected by such charges.

* I would like to thank Dr. Stephen Lake, Konstanz University, Germany, for improving the English version of this paper.

[1] Greg. Naz., *or.* 43.11 (Tr. C.G. Browne and J. E. Swallow (NPNF series 2, 7)).

[2] Greg. Naz., *carm.* 2.1.12. 180-2. 184f., 192-5 (Tr. D.M. Meehan (FC 75)).

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2. Gregory Strikes Back – Strategies Concerning Athens

After his retirement from the see of Constantinople, Gregory turned to a counter-attack against his critics. Within this polemic, Athens appears to play a crucial role and its representation forms part of a wider strategy. In Gregory's view, Athens now serves as an intermediary of Christian faith. In his extensive poetic autobiography, he expressly mentions the role which a pagan education played:

I sought to turn bastard letters into the service of those that are genuine[3].

Gregory claims that this was his motive for being educated in pagan learning. He then recounts his own experiences of Athens. In the aforementioned poem *On himself and the bishops*, he replies to the question how the apostolic ideal of being fishermen can be compatible with a good education:

If the authors [sc. of the New Testament] had not a measure of the cultivation you are unprepared to allow them, how did they succeed in persuading kings and cities and assemblies, people who accused them, questioned them in their words, before tribunals, in crowded theaters? Their audiences were composed of wise men, lawyers, haughty Greeks; but their timely speech was persuasive; they confuted with full confidence[4].

Here, there is an intertextual reference to the Athenian episode of the Acts of Apostles[5] when the apostle Paul addressed the Areopagus. And the reader should then recognise that there is no great difference between the cultivation of the apostles and the learning of Gregory. Where, if not in the famous παίδευσις τῆς Ἑλλάδος, can one acquire the kind of skills needed by a bishop?

Gregory also uses Athens as a symbol for the community of educated people, and he presents his own *Vita*, including his studies in Athens, as a paradigm for young people of the upper classes. This presentation of an ideal education appears in one of his long poems *qui spectant ad alios*, addressed to his nephew Nikobulos, where he explicitly mentions Beirut, Alexandria, and the 'Attic nightingale' as cities in which one might pursue one's studies[6]. Equally in the collection of letters, which was sent to the same Nikobulos in the 380s and thus made public, he supposedly[7] included letters which recommended

[3] Greg. Naz., *carm.* 2.1.11. 113f. (Transl. Meehan).

[4] Greg. Naz., *carm.* 2.1.12. 238-44 (Transl. Meehan).

[5] Cf. Beno Meier, *Gregor von Nazianz: Über die Bischöfe (Carmen 2, 1, 12). Einleitung, Text, Übersetzung, Kommentar* (Studien zur Geschichte und Kultur des Altertums, N. F. 2, 7 (Paderborn, 1989)), 100. Alfred Breitenbach, *Das 'wahrhaft goldene Athen'. Die Auseinandersetzung griechischer Kirchenväter mit der Metropole heidnisch-antiker Kultur* (Theophaneia 37 (Berlin, 2003)), 177f.

[6] Greg. Naz., *carm.* 2.2.5. 226-31; Breitenbach, 186-8.

[7] Cf. Neil McLynn, 'Gregory Nazianzen's Basil. The Literary Construction of a Christian Friendship': *SP* XXXVII (2000), 189f.

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young students to Athenian Sophists, and which do not fail to refer to his own time as a student in Athens[8]. This dialogue with the Sophists shows that Gregory considered himself to be part of a community of educated people because of his own Athenian education. Further, with the publication of his letters, he openly asserted not only that his education was nothing to be ashamed of, but that it should be taken as an example by the young. Nikobulos had then chosen the right path (at least formally), by acquiring what would in fact be appropriate for every Christian bishop – the ability to correspond and talk with educated decision makers and policy makers of the time.

In these letters, there is another strategic application of the image of Athens: especially in the correspondence with Basil, she serves as a reminder of the good old times, as an expression of unity and friendship, evoking a tender feeling in times of tension[9]. When, for example, Gregory confronts Basil with a charge uttered by a third person, that Basil denied the divinity of the Holy Spirit, the bishop of Sasima had to correct the possible misunderstanding, that he himself might share this untenable view of Basil's. He did so by referring to Athens:

> They admired everything connected with you, and they brought me in as professing the same philosophy; and they spoke of our friendship, and of Athens, and of our conformity of views and feelings on all points. Our philosopher was annoyed by this[10].

Gregory not only characterises the opponent as 'our philosopher', in this context an openly disrespectful expression, he also appeals to the common attitudes and beliefs that began with their friendship in Athens and leaves no doubt about his loyalty towards Basil. Although this last allusion to Athens seems to serve a rather limited end, it is nevertheless related to yet another strategy.

3. Gregory's Autobiography and the Biography of Basil

One aspect plays a crucial role in Gregory's justification of his life and education: his autobiography is to a large extent a biography of Basil, and vice versa[11]. In his poem *De Vita Sua*, Gregory recounts his time in Athens, and Basil, of course, has his appropriate place there as well. Gregory says,

> Here, too, God favored me. He associated with me the very wisest person, one towering above all others in learning and in life. You will very easily identify the man I mean. Basil, of course, it was, the great ornament of our generation[12].

[8] Cf. Breitenbach, 189f.
[9] Breitenbach, 182-5.
[10] Greg. Naz., *epist.* 58.4 (Transl. Browne and Swallow).
[11] Cf. McLynn, 178-93.
[12] Greg. Naz., *carm.* 2.1.11. 221-5 (Transl. Meehan).

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The *Funeral Oration for Basil* deals *in extenso* with the time spent in Athens and with their friendship. In a way, Basil was out of his element in Athens, but the reason for this was that he in fact knew nearly everything before he reached the city. He surpassed all the students in knowledge, and they begrudged him his exceeding competence. Throughout Gregory's hagiographical description of his friend, one fact emerges with utmost clarity: his friendship with Basil has to bear part of the pressure that lies on Gregory. In a way, their friendship serves as an acquittal from the charge of having received too much education.

More authentic than the above-mentioned, explicitly literary testimonies, are the letters. Gregory's letters to Basil mention the time they spent together in Athens surprisingly often. When Gregory published his letters, he published at the same time – a literary novelty – letters of Basil, too, who had meanwhile become 'the Great'. The dedication letter of the combined collection of letters of Basil and Gregory reads as follows:

I have always preferred the Great Basil to myself, though he was of the contrary opinion; and so I do now, not less for truth's sake than for friendship's. This is the reason why I have given his letters the first place and my own the second. For I hope we two will always be coupled together; and also I would supply others with an example of modesty and submission[13].

Beside this letter, which belongs to a series of four so-called 'programmatic letters' and which already reflects the intense relationship between the two Cappadocians as construed by Gregory, another letter, written shortly after the departure from Athens, can be considered as particularly exemplary for our purpose. It is addressed to his friend Basil, and opens as follows:

I have failed, I confess, to keep my promise. I had engaged even at Athens, at the time of our friendship and intimate connection (συμφυΐα) there (for I can find no better word for it), to join you in a life of philosophy[14].

This letter is programmatic in two respects. First, Gregory interprets his later years as a direct continuation of his Athenian life. Not even pagan philosophy in the metropolis of antique pagan culture could hurt the two friends: they have used the true philosophy as a shield, and they will continue to practise this philosophy in thought and deed. Second, we find at the beginning of this letter, which may be identified as one of Gregory's earliest writings[15], the topos 'We belong together, we are one'. This topos, so explicitly and clearly formulated (the word συμφυΐα being explicitly characterised as the only appropriate word), has significance for the whole collection and beyond.

[13] Greg. Naz. *epist.* 53 (Transl. Browne and Swallow).

[14] Greg. Naz., *epist.* 1.1 (Transl. Browne and Swallow).

[15] Cf. for its prominent position in the manuscripts Paul Gallay, *Les manuscrits des lettres de Saint Grégoire de Nazianze* (Paris, 1957), 20, and for individual families of manuscripts, cf. 16-8, 48-50, 55 (families u, d, f, where *epist.* 1 is in the second position), 29-33 (family v, where *epist.* 1 also follows *epist.* 60), 63 (family g, where *epist.* 1 is in the sixth position).

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In the poem *De Vita Sua*, Gregory also calls himself and Basil 'one soul, connected by two bodies', and using almost the same words in the *Funeral oration* he says, 'In our view, we were one soul, that possessed two bodies'.

4. Gregory's Last Strategy: Uncovering Basil's Strategy

A few years after Basil's death in 379, Gregory of Nazianzus needed to begin defending his own career. This he did in quick succession: the poems, among them the great autobiographical poem *De Vita Sua* and the poem *On himself and the bishops*, appeared shortly after the Council of Constantinople. The *Funeral Oration in honour of Basil* was probably published in 382. He wrote epigrams and epitaphs ceaselessly, and he published letters showing the continuation of his Athenian friendship with Basil, and in a sense the very continuation of Athens itself in Cappadocia. The image of Basil, the student in Athens, the best friend of Gregory, with whom the latter had developed a kind of spiritual brotherhood, is thus firmly established. Every reader of their texts is now conditioned: the topics 'Athens', 'the beginning of the friendship in Athens', 'a life-long concordance in all matters', 'Christian philosophy in Athens' come immediately to mind. In this way, Gregory achieved a defence of 'his Athens', his pagan education: after the figures of Gregory and Basil had coalesced, a criticism or condemnation of one of them was not possible without implicating the other. Anybody who wished to object to Gregory's education thereby also criticised Basil. Likewise, anyone who venerated Basil, 'the great ornament of our generation', as a saint, should not neglect to show the same honour to another, who was almost identical with this same saint. Gregory undoubtedly succeeded in rehabilitating himself, and made Athens acceptable to Christians as well.

The most important point to note, however, is the fact that everything we know about Basil and Athens comes from Gregory. There are (in the unquestionably authentic corpus) no autobiographical testimonies of Basil about Athens, except one implicit and one explicit reference.

In Cappadocia, the conflict between Basil of Caesarea and the radical ascetic Eustathios of Sebaste was well known. When it came to a definite breach between them in the 370s, Basil published an open letter, in which he also described his spiritual development and his efforts to achieve a compromise with Eustathios. In this letter, he looked back to the time when he, Basil, had wanted to join the ascetic movement of Eustathios. He wrote as follows:

> I have lavished much time on the vanity, and have consumed almost my youth in the futility, which were mine while I occupied myself with the acquirement of the precepts of that wisdom made foolish by God ...[16].

[16] Bas. Caes., *epist.* 223.2 (Transl. R.J. Deferrari (LCL)).

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Above all, he continued, his care had been to make some amendment in his character, 'which had for a long time been perverted by association with the wicked'.

Basil names no names, but in retrospect, he is obviously not very pleased to have been educated in pagan learning. Anyone who knew the career of Basil even slightly will have remembered that he had spent his youth in the schools of Caesarea in Cappadocia, in Constantinople, and especially in Athens. So we see here another strategy of the fourth century in handling Athens: at least in specific situations and in dialogue with certain individuals, Basil decided simply to disavow Athens, or at least to deny any importance to this city for his *Vita*. Athens had been a mistake, a waste of time.

In spite of the prominence of this conflict with Eustathios, it might have been supposed that this open letter, or at least the statements about Athens, could have been quickly forgotten, and that Gregory had later sought to create a new and different image of Basil. But there existed another letter, which probably came to light only after Basil's death, and which is in fact his first letter according to modern numeration. This first letter of Basil's, from about 357, is also addressed to Eustathios of Sebaste. Basil claims to admire the philosophy of the ascetic so strongly that he abandoned his studies. About his studies, he tells us,

'Owing to the repute of your philosophy, I left Athens, scorning everything there'[17].

In my view, the existing parallels between this and the first letters of Gregory, the biographical situation of Nikobulos (the addressee of Gregory's collection of letters), and the numerous quotations from pagan literature in this letter make it probable, or at least not inconceivable, that it was also included in Gregory's collection. Considering the dedication letter and Gregory's early letters, it could well have been placed at the head of the collection, where in fact it appears in several manuscripts[18]. The question arises, how did contemporary readers understand these words? And the probable answer is, exactly as Gregory is supposed to have wanted them to understand them. This is indeed the real sense of it: it is a letter full of rhetorical topoi consistent with the conventions of the time, first and foremost a *captatio benevolentiae* towards the ascetic Christian Eustathios, whose philosophy is strongly contrasted with that

[17] Bas. Caes., *epist.* 1.12f. (Transl. Deferrari).

[18] I am aware that since Paul Gallay (Paul Gallay, *La vie de Saint Grégoire de Nazianze* (Dissertation Lyon, 1943), 236 n. 5; Paul Gallay, ed., *Gregor von Nazianz, Briefe* (GCS (Berlin, 1969)) XLV n. 1; cf. Stig Y. Rudberg, *Études sur la tradition manuscrite de saint Basile* (Lund, 1953), 43f.; Robert Pouchet, *Basile le Grand et son univers d'amis d'après sa correspondance. Une stratégie de communion* (Studia Ephemeridis Augustinianum 36 (Rome, 1992)), 69f.) contradicted the opinion of M. Bessières, 'La tradition manuscrite de la correspondance de Saint Basile', *JThSt* 23 (1922), 245, it has been widely accepted that Gregory included only those letters of Basil in his collection which were addressed to himself, in spite of the fact that Gregory does not make this explicit in his letter to Nikobulos cited above.

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of Athens. In fact, although Basil left Athens at this time, he remained in spirit true to his Athenian education.[19]

Basil had his own autobiographical strategy concerning Athens, and perhaps he would have wished that the image depicted in his one and a half statements about Athens would have prevailed. As indicated above, the two letters to Eustathios are his only references to his studies, and Athens is named only in the first letter (according to modern numeration) as the city of his studies. But Basil died too early. His roommate of Athenian days survived him, and *his* plans were quite different. Even if it was not Gregory of Nazianzus who edited Basil's first letter, but, for example, Gregory of Nyssa at Annesi, as has been suggested[20], his strategy nevertheless enabled the reader of Basil's letter to detect the strategy of the author. Whether the reader also recognised the strategy of Gregory remains an open question.

[19] Although Basil's tractate *Ad adolescentes* in places has Athens as its background, it contains no autobiographical traces and more extensive discussion of it here would exceed the constraints of this presentation; see further, e. g. Breitenbach, 233-6.

[20] Pouchet, 58.

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'The Human Form Divine': Christ's Risen Body and Ours According to Gregory of Nyssa

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When Christians are tempted to speculate about what it might mean to be raised from the dead, modesty of discourse seems to be the most appropriate virtue. Paul learned this, perhaps, on the Areopagus, and put it into practice in his discussion, in 1 Corinthians 15, of the 'spiritual body' to come: what we know about it now is summed up, for Paul, in the phrase, 'We shall all be changed' (1 Cor 15:51, 52). Gregory of Nyssa, too, for all the abundance of his rhetorical powers, was usually eager to emphasize that what we can say with any certitude about the risen human body – Christ's or our own – is extremely limited, and that whatever conjectures the preacher or the theologian does offer must be rooted in Scripture, and hedged with imaginative caution. So, for instance, in his treatise *On the Dead*, he takes up Paul's allusion to the 'house not made by hands', which we hope to 'put on' after 'the earthly tent we live in is destroyed' (2 Cor 5:1-2), and begins his comment by saying:

> Let no one describe for me the character and shape and form of that 'house not made by hands' according to the model of the traits now obvious to us, whose details distinguish us from each other. For since it is not simply resurrection that is proclaimed to us by the divine writings, but holy scripture also assures us that those who are renewed in the resurrection must be 'changed', it is quite necessary that what we shall be changed to remain completely hidden and unknown, since no model of the things we hope for can be observed with clarity in this present life[1].

Gregory was convinced, as virtually the whole chorus of his Patristic predecessors had been, that resurrection from the dead is perhaps the central and most characteristic feature of the hope communicated in the Christian Gospel: an inseparable part of the promise of the unity and eternal beatitude of all rational creatures that for Gregory was the goal (σκόπος) of God's creative activity[2]. He was aware, too, of the sharp critiques raised by the opponents of

[1] *De mortuis* 20 (ed. Giuseppe Lozza (Turin: Società Editrice Internazionale, 1991) 72.19-26; ed. Günther Heil, *Gregorii Nysseni Opera* [= GNO] IX/1 (Leiden: Brill, 1967) 62.9-18).

[2] *On the Soul and the Resurrection* (PG 46, 152 A1 – C13). For a general discussion of the universality and various forms of early Christian hope in the resurrection of the dead, see my articles, 'The Ripening of Salvation: Hope for Resurrection in the Early Church', *Communio* 17 (1990), 27-49; 'A Hope for Worms: Early Christian Hope', in Ted Peters, Robert John Russell, and Michael Welker (eds), *Resurrection. Theological and Scientific Assessments* (Grand Rapids:

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Christianity against what seemed an impossible and unseemly expectation, and in several of his works rehearsed classical Christian arguments to refute them[3]. Yet for all the clarity of his commitment to this central aspect of the faith of Christians, Gregory is anything but simplistic in his apologetic on its behalf. Like Origen, his great intellectual ancestor, in fact, he seems to have approached the Christian doctrine of the resurrection of the body not only with modesty, but with a certain ambivalence, a certain felt need to refine and qualify what to many of his contemporaries – especially to Origen's late-fourth-century critics – simply had to be taken at face value.

Gregory, like Origen, his own brother Basil, and his colleague and friend Gregory of Nazianzus, was a humanist: a man of the highest education and refinement, deeply versed in the philosophy, the rhetorical art, and even the medical and physical science of late antique Greek culture. To a large degree, this education set the terms for his ability to make sense of the resurrection hope. Greek science and philosophy had wrestled with the issues of living as an organic, materially needy, yet reflective and self-determining animal, in a large but limited physical world – in other words, with the problems surrounding consciousness and embodiment – since at least the fifth century before the Christian era. While some philosophical schools were materialist, and recognized nothing as real that cannot in principle be weighed and measured, most educated Greeks believed that the heart of reality, and of the human individual, lay in some kind of free intelligence, capable of recognizing beauty and goodness and acting purposefully to bring them to realization: in a divine, creative mind; in a cosmic Logos, a reasonable principle of order and regularity; in a whole range of intelligible universals or 'forms' which acted as the structural principles of individual things, the norms for their being *something* rather than simply anything at all. For Plato and the later Platonic tradition, the order of the forms, as well as God and the human soul, were all incorporeal: beyond the direct grasp of the senses, yet supremely real precisely because they were uncompromised by the deceptive limitations of materiality[4]. To

Eerdmans, 2002), 136-64. For Gregory's conception of the resurrection of the body, see also B.J. Salmona, 'Origene e Gregorio di Nissa sulla risurrezione dei corpi e l'apocatastasi', *Augustinianum* 18 (1978), 383-8; T.J. Dennis, 'Gregory [of Nyssa] on the Resurrection of the Body', in Andreas Spira and Christoph Klock (eds), *The Easter Sermons of Gregory of Nyssa* (Philadelphia: Philadelphia Patristic Foundation, 1981) 55-80; L. Hennessey, 'Gregory of Nyssa's Doctrine of the Resurrected Body', *SP* XXII (1989), 28-34; A. LeBoulluec, 'Corporéité ou immortalité? La condition finale des ressuscités selon Grégoire de Nysse', *Augustinianum* 35 (1995), 307-26; Morwenna Ludlow, *Universal Salvation: Eschatology in the Thought of Gregory of Nyssa and Karl Rahner* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000), 45-76.

[3] See, for instance, *On the Making of the Human Person* 25-26; Sermon *On the Holy Pascha* (GNO IX/1, 253.6-264.3).

[4] See, for instance, Plato, *Sophist* 246b, 247c; *Politicus* 286a; Alcinous [or Albinus], *The Handbook of Platonism* 9-11, 25 (tr. John Dillon (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1993), 16-20, 32-3).

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withdraw oneself from involvement in the world of the senses by ascetical practice, to train one's own intellect to contemplate incorporeal, immaterial realities, enabled the human mind to escape the 'coarseness' of sense-experience and the insatiable drives of the embodied spirit, and to share more fully in what Iamblichus approvingly called 'the lightness of incorporeality'[5]. Origen, the inspiration for so much of the Cappadocians' approach to theology, emphasizes the importance of understanding the essential incorporeality of both God and created intellects, if one is to understand Scripture and its promise of salvation correctly[6]; yet Origen also suggests, along with the earlier Platonic tradition, that created intellects all need the 'vehicle' (ὄχημα) of some kind of body – even if it is a highly refined and spiritual one – if they are to exist and move in a spatially extended universe[7]. So he asserts, in *De Principiis* 2.2.2, that souls are separate from bodies 'only in theory and in our understanding', and towards the end of the same work (4.4.8) explains this assertion at greater length:

Every created thing is distinguished in God's sight by its being confined within a certain number and measure, that is, either number in the case of rational beings or measure in the case of bodily matter. Since, then, it was necessary for intellectual nature to make use of bodies, and this nature is proved to be changeable and convertible by the very condition of its being created ... so, as God necessarily had foreknowledge of the differences that were to arise among souls or spiritual powers, it was necessary for him to make a bodily nature capable of changing at the Creator's will, by an alteration of qualities, into everything that circumstances might require, so that each, in proportion to its merits, might wear a different bodily covering of this or that quality. This nature must necessarily endure so long as those endure who need it for a covering; but there

[5] Iamblichus, *De communi mathematia scientia* 15 (ed. N. Festa (Leipzig: Teubner, 1975) 56.27-57.3); cf. Porphyry, *De Abstinentia* 1.31 (ed. Jean Bouffartigue (Paris: Les Belles Lettres, 1977), 66).

[6] See *De Principiis* 1.1.6; 1.7.1; 4.4. For a further discussion of Origen's treatment of incorporeality, see my paper delivered elsewhere at this Conference, 'Incorporeality and 'Divine Sensibility': the Importance of *De Principiis* 4.4 for Origen's Theology'.

[7] For the Platonic conception of the soul's original 'body' as fine matter, used by the soul as its instrument or 'vehicle' in order to 'descend' from unity with the divine world soul into the realm of space and time, see especially Proclus, *The Elements of Theology* Props. 205-210 (ed. E.R. Dodds (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1933), 180-5); and see also Iamblichus, *De Mysteriis* 5.12 (ed. Édouard des Places (Paris: Les Belles Lettres, 1966), 167-9), referring to the 'body-like vehicle' (ὄχημα σωματοειδές), not made of any earthly material we know, which is used by the *daimones*; Damascius, *De Principiis*, R. I, 264 (ed. L.G. Westerink, 3 (Paris: Les Belles Lettres, 1991), 73-4), discussing the 'ensouled instrument', 'which we also call a "vehicle" (ὄχημα)', used by the divine soul in which our souls participate. For Origen's use of the notion, see the text quoted by Methodius, *On the Resurrection* 3.18.1 (Greek text: Photius, *Bibliotheca* 234.310a). See Henri Crouzel, 'Le theme platonicien du "véhicule de l'âme" chez Origène', *Didaskalia* 7 (1977), 225-37. See also Dodds, *Proclus: The Elements of Theology*, 313-21 ('Appendix II: The Astral Body in Neoplatonism'); H.S. Schibli, 'Hierocles of Alexandria and the Vehicle of the Soul', *Hermes* 121 (1993) 109-17; and Abraham P. Bos, 'The "Vehicle of the Soul" and the Debate over the Origin of this Concept', in this collection.

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will always be rational natures who need this bodily covering. Therefore there will always be bodily nature, whose covering rational creatures must necessarily use[8].

For Origen as for the Neoplatonists, the issue was not whether intellects are embodied, so much as the qualities of the bodies they use.

Whether or not Gregory of Nyssa knew this text of *De Principiis* 4 – and it is hard to believe he did not – his own conception of the Christian hope in bodily resurrection seems to rest on the same philosophical and anthropological assumptions, and uses much of the same terminology. What I would like to do in this essay is to explore those assumptions a bit further, and to make some suggestions about what they seem to imply for his understanding of the risen body – Christ's now, and our own in the eschatological future. In attempting this, I must first simply recall two cautionary principles for all general discussions of Gregory's theology: that he is not a systematic writer, but rather – like any good rhetorician – always adapts his arguments and even his positions to his audience and his literary genre, however much he remains committed to a more or less consistent theological perspective; and that it is always very difficult for a modern student of Gregory to speak with certainty about the development of his ideas, simply because our knowledge of the chronology of his writings is so sketchy[9]. To try to date his works, or to assign some of them earlier or later positions in his *oeuvre* without external criteria and simply on the basis of content, requires an overarching conception of the growth of his theological thought that we simply do not have, and that supposes a concern for theoretical continuity he himself may not have shared. We will base our considerations here mainly on his three genuine Easter homilies; on his treatises *On the Dead*, *On the Making of the Human Person*, and *On the Soul and the Resurrection*; on his *Catechetical Oration*; and on his two works criticizing the Christology of the Apollinarian sect – the letter *To Theophilus of Alexandria* and the *Antirrhetikos against Apollinarius*. In doing so, we must be

[8] Tr. George W. Butterworth, *Origen: On First Principles* (London: S.P.C.K., 1936 [New York: Harper and Row, 1966]), 324-25 (altered).

[9] The best general survey of what can be said about the chronology of Gregory's works with any certainty is Gerhard May, 'Die Chronologie des Lebens und der Werke des Gregors von Nyssa', in Marguerite Harl (ed.), *Écriture et culture philosophique dans la Pensée de Grégoire de Nysse* (Leiden: Brill, 1971), 51-67. As May suggests, the more or less certain dates on which any attempted chronology must be based are the following: his ordination as bishop before Easter, 372; his exile from Nyssa between the winter of 375-76 and 378 – a time in which he may have done a good deal of writing; the death of Basil, 1 January 379, which is followed by *On the Making of the Human Person* (379); the death of Macrina in late 379 or early 380, followed by *On the Soul and the Resurrection*; and the election of Theophilus as bishop of Alexandria in 385, after which both anti-Apollinarian works are probably to be placed. In addition, the *Catechetical Oration* refers to the more detailed treatments of Trinitarian questions in earlier works, which would seem to place it after the debates leading up to the Council of 381. For a more speculative approach to Gregory's chronology, see Jean Daniélou, 'La chronologie des oeuvres de Grégoire de Nysse', *SP* VII (= TU 92 (Berlin: Akademie-verlag, 1966)), 159-69.

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content with a picture of the risen body whose overall features seem to be characteristic of his thought, even if their details are not always consistent with each other.

I. Ontology and Anthropology

With these cautions in mind, it seems helpful to make some general statements about Gregory's general approach to the ontology of created being, and to the particular characteristics of the human person, before turning to the treatment of the resurrection in his various writings.

(1) *Change and Growth*

Perhaps more than any other early Christian writer, Gregory emphasizes that human existence is characterized by constant change, as its qualities continually alternate from one dominant condition to its opposite. In *On the Making of the Human Person*, for instance, he compares the human body to a flowing stream;

> ... so, too [he continues], the material element of our life here suffers change in the continuity of its succession of opposites by way of motion and flux, so that it never can desist from change, but in its inability to rest keeps up unceasingly its motion, alternating by like ways – and if it ever should cease moving it will surely also cease being[10].

In his *Catechetical Oration*, Gregory broadens this principle to include not simply material things but every creature, simply in virtue of coming to being from nothing.

> That alone is unchangeable by nature which does not originate through creation. But whatever is derived from the uncreated nature has its subsistence out of nonbeing. Once it has come into being through change, it constantly proceeds to change. If it acts according to its nature, this continual change is for the better. But if it is diverted from the straight path, there succeeds a movement in the opposite direction[11].

This conviction that creatures are inherently changeable, yet naturally disposed to change for the better – since evil, as the negation of real being, is always a violation of nature rather than its goal – underlies, in turn, Gregory's highly teleological style of thinking, and leads to his well-known principle that

[10] *On the Making of the Human Person* 15.1 (tr. H.A. Wilson: NPNF Second Series 5, 400). Cf. *On the Soul and the Resurrection* (PG 46, 141 A C). For a similar description of the constant flow of every body's material components, see the passage from Origen's commentary on Psalm 1:5 quoted by Methodius, in Epiphanius, *Panarion* 64.14.2-6.

[11] *Catechetical Oration* 8 (GNO III/4, 35.16-23; tr. Cyril C. Richardson, *Christology of the Later Fathers*, Library of Christian Classics 3 (Philadelphia: Westminster, 1954), 286; see also *ibid.* 6 (GNO III/4, 24.1-12; Richardson, 280), 21 (GNO III/4, 55.9-56.10; Richardson, 297-8).

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human perfection or fulfilment consists in unending progress towards the infinitely Good, which is God; 'for perhaps to be so disposed that one always wishes to grow in goodness', he writes in the prologue to his *Life of Moses*, 'is the perfection of human nature'[12]. Like every plant, which only becomes what it is naturally equipped to be by a long and gradual process, Gregory writes in his treatise *On the Dead*,

> we have not come into existence, at the Creator's hands, in order to become embryos, nor does the purpose of our nature look towards the life of infancy, nor at the successive stages which it constantly puts on in the process of change, altering our form along with time, nor at the dissolution which afterwards will come upon the body through death. All of these things, and others like them, are parts of the road on which we walk. But the goal and end of the journey through these stages is restoration to our original state (ἡ πρὸς τὸ ἀρχαῖον ἀποκατάστασις), which is nothing else but likeness to the divine'[13].

(2) *The Status of Matter*

Gregory tends to conceive of matter simply in terms of the 'properties' (ἰδιώματα) or qualities (ποιότητες) that characterize it at any given time, and in several passages in his works suggests that it is nothing more than such a 'bundle of properties'[14]. The reason he takes this position – in opposition here to Origen[15] – seems to be his understanding of creation *ex nihilo*, and his reluctance to conceive of it as God's ordering of some receptive, qualitatively neutral pre-existent matter: if God, who is pure intelligence, is the sole cause for material creation, matter must somehow consist in its intelligible qualities. So Gregory writes in *On the Making of the Human Person*:

[12] *Life of Moses*, Prologue 10 (SC 1 ter, 50). For the same idea, see *ibid.* part II. 239; also the last sentence of his treatise *On Perfection*: 'Let no one be grieved if he sees in his nature a penchant for change. Changing in everything for the better, let him exchange "glory for glory" [2 Cor 3:18], becoming greater through daily increase, ever perfecting himself, and never arriving too quickly at the limit of perfection. For this is truly perfection: never to stop growing towards what is better and never placing any limit on perfection' (GNO) VIII/1, 213.24-214.6; tr. Virginia Woods Callahan, FC 58 (Washington: Catholic University of America Press, 1967), 122).

[13] *On the Dead* 14 (ed. Lozza, 60.21-27; GNO IX/1, 51.9-18). Cf. *On the Making of the Human Person* 29.3-4, where Gregory emphasizes that the full, developed form of the human being is present potentially at conception, but only becomes visible in the course of a development that, presumably, reaches beyond the present life to resurrection and final, endlessly dynamic, perfection.

[14] The phrase is Richard Sorabji's: see his *Matter, Space and Motion: Theories in Antiquity and Their Sequel* (Ithaca: Cornell University Press, 1988), 52-5, where he characterizes Gregory of Nyssa as anticipating the ontology of Berkeley and nineteenth-century idealism.

[15] See *On First Principles* 4.4.7, where Origen discusses this as a position held by others, but seems himself to hold that substantial change requires the existence of some 'substratum', such as Aristotle's prime matter, which is never encountered apart from qualities but which is nevertheless distinct from and causally prior to them.

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If, then, colour is an intelligible thing, and resistance also is intelligible, and so with quantity and other similar properties, while if each of these should be withdrawn from the substratum, the whole idea of the body is dissolved; it would seem to follow that we may suppose the concurrence of those things, the absence of which we found to be a cause of the dissolution of the body, to produce the material nature ... Yet if the perception of these properties is a matter of intellect, and the Divinity is also intellectual in nature, there is no incongruity in supposing that these intellectual occasions for the genesis of bodies have their existence from the incorporeal nature, the intellectual nature on the one hand giving being to the intellectual potentialities, and the mutual concurrence of these bringing to its genesis the material nature[16].

In his *Antirrhetikos* against Apollinarius, on the other hand, Gregory unhesitatingly draws on the classical understanding of matter (ὕλη) in describing the formation of the human individual, in Mary's womb, who was to be united with God the Word:

Human nature has its concrete subsistence (τὴν ὑπόστασιν) from the concurrence of an intellectual soul with a body; both come into being when a kind of material beginning lays the foundation for its formation. This matter, formed into a living thing by divine power, becomes a human being – so that, if one were to suppose hypothetically that the creative power of God were not involved in the formation, the matter would remain ineffective and without motion, because it had not been generated into life by his creative activity. Just as in our own case, then, a life-giving power is observed in matter, from which a human person formed of soul and body is shaped into being, so in the Virgin's womb the power of the Most High, beginning to work immaterially in her immaculate body by the life-giving Spirit, and using as matter the incorrupt flesh of the Virgin, received the contribution of the Virgin's body to what was being formed, and so the truly new Man was created, the first and only one to reveal in himself this manner of origin, created in a divine and not a human way ...[17]

Although he is speaking here of 'matter' in a physiological rather than a strictly ontological context, Gregory clearly finds the concept a useful one for speaking about the full humanity of Christ. Nonetheless, the passage emphasizes the dynamic qualities of this matter, when guided by the creative power of God, and is compatible with his insistence, in other contexts, on matter's ability to be completely transformed by that same power.

(3) *Body and Soul*

Gregory insists, in all his works dealing with Christian anthropology, that the human person was from the beginning, and always will be, an organic

[16] *On the Making of the Human Person* 24 (tr. Wilson, 414); cf. *On the Six Days of Creation* (PG 44, 69B-C). In *On the Soul and the Resurrection* (PG 46, 124 B-D), Gregory writes, 'Nothing of what appears in relation to the body is body in itself, not shape, nor colour, nor weight, nor dimension, nor quantity, nor anything else of what is related to quality, but each of these is a principle (λόγος). The concurrence and union of these with one another becomes a body'.

[17] *Antirrhetikos against Apollinarius* 54 (GNO III/1, 223.15-224.2).

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composite of matter and spirit, body and soul. In his treatises *On the Making of the Human Person* and *On the Soul and the Resurrection*, particularly, Gregory is careful to insist on this compound character of the human person, and to reject the notion that souls were created before their bodies[18]. The body, it is true, is a mixture of heterogeneous, mutually reacting and often competing elements, which break apart and scatter when the soul leaves them at death[19]; the soul, in the classically Platonist definition Macrina offers in *On the Soul and the Resurrection*, is

> an essence which has a beginning, a living and intellectual essence which by itself gives to the organic and sensory body the power of life and of the reception of sense-impressions, as long as the nature which can receive these maintains its existence[20].

As the dialogue continues, Gregory develops this understanding of the soul, portraying it as something which holds all the material components of the body together in a dynamic and growing organism – as something transcendent to the body and known in it only indirectly, through what it enables the body to do, just as the transcendent God is only known in creation through his operations. Yet even death cannot completely sever the soul from its decomposing body, in Gregory's understanding; as the form or εἶδος of the human composite, the soul 'stamps' its own unique character permanently on all its body's elements and particles, and is in turn indelibly (if analogously) 'stamped' or marked by them. So, at the time of resurrection, the soul – which itself has no specific location, being immaterial, and therefore remains present to all its scattered material particles, however far they have travelled – once again easily reassembles its own matter according to its own continuing form[21].

In all of his reflection on the complex constitution of the human person, Gregory clearly wants to emphasize that embodiment is not punishment, nor even God's providential response to a primal fall, as Origen somewhat tentatively proposes in *On First Principles* 1.8 and 2.8-9. Gregory suggests that God's purpose in creating human beings was precisely to be the final, synthetic piece in a complex cosmic pattern, a 'little world' in himself, uniting the angelic and the earthy in a single being capable of praising the creator in the

[18] *On the Soul and the Resurrection* (PG 46, 112 C – 117 C); *On the Making of the Human Person* 28.1-29.4.

[19] *On the Soul and the Resurrection* (PG 46, 20 B; 48 B); *On the Making of the Human Person* 27.3-5; *On the Dead* 5 (ed. Lozza, 40.9-22; GNO IX/1, 31.20-32.12), 11 (ed. Lozza, 50.29-52.31; GNO IX/1, 42.4-44.4).

[20] *On the Soul and the Resurrection* (PG 46, 20 B; tr. Catharine P. Roth (Crestwood: St. Vladimir's, 1993), 37-8 [altered]). For a similar conception of the role and nature of the soul, see *On the Making of the Human Person* 9-11.

[21] *On the Making of the Human Person* 27.2-5; *On the Soul and the Resurrection* (PG 46, 44 C – 45 A; 73 A -76 B).

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name of all creation[22]. Even the difficulties inherent in the soul's embodiment – more obvious, perhaps, to antique culture than to our own – including disease and mortality, the struggle for survival, and above all the constant encroachment on the soul's freedom to act and know by physically rooted disorders or 'passions', are not in themselves evils, in Gregory's view, so much as purifying challenges to be overcome[23]. So, even in the work that offers what is, in some ways, his darkest view of embodiment, *On the Dead*, Gregory insists that this present life of 'heavy' or 'coarsened' corporeality – signified by the 'tunics of skin' of Genesis 3:21 – is a blessing, precisely because it offers to us the theatre in which we can perfect our natural freedom by discipline and growth in virtue:

> That tunic of skin, which bears within itself all the characteristics that define irrational nature – pleasure and anger and gluttony and greed and the like – offers human choice the way of impulses in both directions, since it is the material leading both to virtue and to vice. Living in these conditions during his life on earth, the human person, if he distinguishes from the irrational what is properly his own, by making use of his free choice, and looks to his own welfare by leading a respectable life, will shape this present life in a way purified from the evil that has been mixed into it, mastering irrationality through his reason ... This is what has made the use of the body necessary for us: through it our power of self-determination is preserved, and our ascent back towards the Good is not hindered. Rather, by following this fluctuating route through our willing choices, our impulse towards what is better is realized. Some have already made their lives spiritual, in freedom from passion, while still in this life of the flesh – such, we hear, have the patriarchs and prophets become, and those who with them or after them ran towards perfection through virtue and philosophy ..., while the rest, in the activity of a later time, in the purifying fire, will cast off their attachment to matter and willingly ascend to that grace which is our nature's lot from the beginning, by their desire for all that is good[24].

Throughout Gregory's works, the body in itself is not described as an obstacle to the soul's progress and perfection; like Origen and the Neoplatonists, in fact, Gregory assumes that some kind of body is needed by every limited intellect as an instrument and 'vehicle' for action[25], and that the particular role of the human creature in the world is to unite in a single person angelic and animal qualities, intellect and matter. What is presently a hindrance to human moral and intellectual life, in Gregory's eyes, is the 'coarsened' state of the body's functioning – its rebellion against rational control – and the undue

[22] *On the Making of the Human Person* 2.2; *On Infants Dying Prematurely* (GNO III/2, 77.12-79.2).

[23] See *Catechetical Oration* 16 (GNO III/4, 45.22-48.2).

[24] *On the Dead* 15-16 (ed. Lozza, 64.32-65.22; GNO IX/1, 55.18-57.2). For a criticism of this work as being too negative in its evaluation of embodiment, see Dennis, 'Gregory on the Resurrection of the Body', 69-71.

[25] He refers to the body as the soul's ὄχημα in *On the Soul and the Resurrection* (PG 46, 45 B7).

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influence of the body's needs on the soul's freedom, in the form of the passions[26]. And this condition is the result of the soul's historic misuse of its own freedom, not of its embodiment. As Gregory writes in *On the Dead*, 'It is not the body that implants [in us] impulses towards evil, but our faculty of choice, which perverts [desire for] the object of need into unnatural lust'[27].

(4) *The Image of God*

A central theme in Gregory's theological anthropology is, of course, the phrase of Genesis 1:27, that the human person was 'made in the image of God'. Although he uses this text in a variety of ways – including his celebrated discussion of the distinction of the sexes in *On the Making of the Human Person* 16-17 – Gregory consistently takes its central meaning to be its emphasis on the intellectual substance, freedom, and natural moral virtue of the embodied human soul. In his little treatise *On Infants Dying Prematurely*, for instance, Gregory argues that our ability to know God, and to find life-giving nourishment in that knowledge, requires that we must first be akin to God, since – as ancient psychology in general assumed – all knowledge presumes some prior likeness of knower to known: 'therefore, as the scripture says, man was made in the image of God, that like, I take it, might be able to see like ...'[28] God is essentially mind and word, he writes in *On the Making of the Human Person*, and scripture tells us that God is love; so our human ability to know and to love is what most closely resembles God in us[29]. And being God's image – sharing in what William Blake called 'the human form divine'[30] – also implies, for Gregory, as for the author of Genesis 1, a human sovereignty over the rest of creation analogous to that of the Creator, rooted in the sovereignty within the human individual – the 'little world' – of the rational will:

For the soul immediately shows its royal and exalted character, far removed as it is from the lowliness of private station, in that it recognizes no lord and is self-governed (αὐτεξούσιος), swayed autocratically by its own will ... So the human nature, as it

[26] For full discussions of the role of the passions in our present life, see *On the Soul and the Resurrection* (PG 46, 48 C – 65 B); *On the Making of the Human Person* 18; *Catechetical Oration* 6-7 (GNO III/4, 23.8-28.20), 16 (45.22-49.16).

[27] *On the Dead* 17 (ed. Lozza, 70.5-6; GNO IX/1, 59.19-22).

[28] *On Infants Dying Prematurely* (GNO III/2, 79.23-24; see the whole discussion in 79.2-80.2).

[29] *On the Making of the Human Person* 5 (Wilson, 391).

[30] See Blake's poem, 'The Divine Image', lines 9-12, in the *Songs of Innocence* (1789):

For Mercy has a human heart,
Pity a human face,
And Love, the human form divine,
And Peace, the human dress.

(ed. Geoffrey Keynes (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1966), 117)

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was made to rule over the rest [of creation], was, by its likeness to the King of all, made as it were a living image, partaking with the archetype both in rank and in name ...[31]

The real importance of the human person's role as image of God, however, seems to lie for Gregory not in what it enables man to do, but in what it calls him to be. Our true identity is defined by the beauty and perfection of God, which consists not in perceptible qualities, but in virtue: 'Purity, freedom from passion, blessedness, alienation from all evil, and all those attributes of the same kind which help to form in us the likeness of God – with such colors as these did the Maker of his own image mark our nature'[32]. Conversely, whatever is not understood to be part of God's way of being and acting, such as the passions experienced by the soul in its present state, cannot be proper to human nature as God's image:

We should consider nothing peculiar to the soul which is not also proper to the divine nature. For he who said that the soul is a likeness of God has proclaimed that everything which is alien to God is outside the definition of the soul, for the likeness would not be preserved if there were differences. Therefore, since clearly no such thing as desire or anger appears in the divine nature, logically one would suppose that these are not essentially united with the soul, either[33].

It is in the ordered, virtuous lives of holy people that we come to understand what Genesis means in calling us 'the image of God', and so learn what human nature really is[34].

II. The Form of the Risen Body

This somewhat lengthy summary of Gregory's understanding of the constitution of the human person, as an embodied soul made to be free and virtuous in God's image, will enable us to describe more briefly the characteristic features of his understanding of bodily resurrection.

(1) First of all, Gregory clearly believes that the resurrection Christians hope for will involve this present human body, which has been an integral part of human existence since the very beginning. He not only stresses that the future resurrection is taught in the scriptures[35]; he also revives some of the classic Christian apologetic for a bodily resurrection from the second and third centuries, pointing to natural analogies, such as the growth of plants from apparent decay; appealing to God's creative power, latent in the countless

[31] *On the Making of the Human Person* 4 (tr. Wilson, 391).
[32] *On the Making of the Human Person* 5 (tr. Wilson, 391 [altered]).
[33] *On the Soul and the Resurrection* (PG 46, 52 A9 – B2; tr. Roth, 51).
[34] *On the Making of the Human Person* 18.7-8 (Wilson, 408-9).
[35] See, for example, *On the Making of the Human Person* 25.

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natural mysteries that surround us each day; and stressing the moral necessity of a resurrection of our bodies, if our deeds in this life are to be justly rewarded or punished in the next[36]. In contrast to Origen, in fact – perhaps in an effort to escape some of the criticisms being levelled at Origen in the late fourth century[37] – Gregory characteristically insists that the resurrection will mean the reassembling, by the soul, of the scattered material particles of the present body, 'stamped' by their relationship to the soul, which remains present to them even in the state of dissolution and decay which follows death[38]. In *On the Making of the Human Person* 27, Gregory explains this – as Origen had done – in terms of the soul's enduring existence as that which gives continuing *form* (εἶδος) to its material body:

> Since various differences of combination [in the body's material components] produce varieties of forms ..., while the form necessarily remains in the soul as in the impression of a seal, those things which have received from the seal the impression of its stamp do not fail to be recognized by the soul, but at the time of the restoration (ἀποκατάστασις) it receives back to itself all those things which correspond to the stamp of the form[39].

(2) Gregory is also convinced, however, that the *form* of the risen body, in the sense of its perceptible characteristics, will be vastly different from that of the body we now know. Towards the end of the dialogue *On the Soul and the Resurrection*, Gregory portrays himself, as devil's advocate, pointing to the dilemma raised by physical continuity: if the bodies that are raised are exactly the same as our present bodies, we will still suffer from our present limitations of age, disease, and deformity; but if they are wholly different, can they any longer be thought of as our present, material selves?[40] Macrina, representing a more enlightened faith, responds that like people at night discussing the dawn, we must be content with knowing that 'every reasoning which conjectures about the future restoration will be proved worthless when what we expect comes to us in experience'[41]. Here and elsewhere, Gregory takes up Paul's

[36] *On the Making of the Human Person* 26-27; *On the Holy Pascha* (GNO IX/1, 255.24-264.3 (analogies; power of God), 264.3-268.21 (necessary for retribution)).

[37] This is emphasized by Dennis, 'Gregory on the Resurrection of the Body', 60-1, 68-9. On the influence on Gregory of Methodius' critique of Origen's notion of the risen body, see Lloyd G. Patterson, *Methodius of Olympus. Divine Sovereignty, Human Freedom, and Life in Christ* (Washington: Catholic University of America Press, 1997, 186-96.

[38] See above, n. 21.

[39] *On the Making of the Human Person* 27.5 (tr. Wilson, 418 [altered]). In a fragment of his commentary on Psalm 1:5 quoted – in a hostile context – by Methodius, Origen had spoken of the form or εἶδος of the body as the stable element which makes possible personal continuity in a person whose material components are constantly in flux: see Epiphanius, *Panarion* 64.14.2-6 (see above, n. 10). Methodius had interpreted this as referring simply to the body's external appearance, but Origen clearly seems to have a more ontological principle of continuity in mind.

[40] *On the Soul and the Resurrection* (PG 46, 137 B – 145 A).

[41] *On the Soul and the Resurrection* (PG 46, 145 C4-7; tr. Roth, 113).

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comparison (1 Cor 15:37-44) of the risen body to the full ear of wheat, produced from a seed as the fruit of a single, living organism, yet scarcely conceivable to one who now simply sees the seed alone.

When the grain in the earth leaves behind after its dissolution the small quantity of its size and the particular quality of its shape, nevertheless it does not abandon itself. While remaining in itself it becomes an ear which differs completely from its former self in size, beauty, variety and form. In the same manner the human nature also, when it abandons to death all the properties which it acquired through the state of subjection to passion – I mean dishonor, corruption, weakness, difference of age – does not abandon itself. Instead, as if ripening into an ear, it changes into incorruptibility, glory, honor, power and every kind of perfection[42].

(3) Gregory also insists that this 'new' form of the risen body will be its 'original' one – the body as originally intended by God in creating the human person.

To describe this doctrine and limit it with a certain definition, we shall say this: that resurrection is the restoration of our nature to its original condition (ἡ εἰς τὸ ἀρχαῖον τῆς φύσεως ἡμῶν ἀποκατάστασις). In the first life, of which God himself became the creator, there was presumably neither old age, nor infancy, nor the sufferings caused by the many kinds of diseases, nor any other type of bodily misery; for it is not likely that God created such things. Human nature was a divine sort of thing (θεῖον τι χρῆμα), before humanity started on the course of evil[43].

This idea runs through much of Gregory's anthropology and theology of creation: the end (τέλος) of the temporal process God has set in motion will be its return 'to the grace of the beginning'[44]. In Gregory's scheme of salvation history, this means that the final form of human corporality will no longer be 'weighed down' with the unnatural qualities that make our present existence sorrowful and unstable; although the body will still be a body – still solid, still limited spatially, perceptible to the senses, recognizable as the body of a particular individual – it will no longer be characterized by what Genesis calls the 'tunic of skin' that presently clothes it with corruptibility.

To reach that state of 'original' purity and beauty, Gregory is convinced, both body and soul – more precisely, the soul in its relationship to its body – must undergo a difficult and painful purgation, either through the voluntary ascetical practices we take on ourselves in this present life, to train us away

[42] *On the Soul and the Resurrection* (PG 46, 153 D3 – 156 A13; tr. Roth, 118). For a development of the same image, see *On the Holy Pascha* (GNO IX/1, 259.17-260.23).

[43] *On the Soul and the Resurrection* (PG 46, 145 C13 – 148 A9; tr. Roth, 113).

[44] See, for instance, *On the Soul and the Resurrection* (PG 46, 156 B – 160 A); *Catechetical Oration* 8 (GNO III/4, 34.11-17), 26 (GNO III/4, 66.10-67.13). See also Jean Daniélou, 'L'apocatastase chez Saint Grégoire de Nysse', *RSR* 30 (1940), 328-47; Monique Alexandre, 'Protologie et eschatologie chez Grégoire de Nysse', in H. Crouzel and U. Bianchi (eds), *Arché e telos: L'antropologia di Origene e di Gregorio d Nissa. Analisi storico-religiosa* (Milan: Vita e pensiero, 1981), 122-59; Ludlow, *Universal Salvation* (above, n. 2), 77-111.

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from the domination of the passions, or in a process of divine judgement and cleansing that awaits us at death.

To thoughtless persons [Gregory writes in his *Catechetical Oration*] this is a threat and a harsh means of correction, so that by fear of a painful retribution we may be brought to our senses and flee evil. The more thoughtful, however, believe it to be a healing remedy provided by God, who thus restores his own creation to its original grace. Those who, by excisions or cauteries, remove moles and warts which have unnaturally grown on the body do not benefit and heal the patient painlessly, although they do not use the knife to hurt him. In the same way, whatever material excrescences have hardened on the surface of our souls, which have become fleshly through their association with the passions, are, at the time of judgment, cut off and removed by that ineffable wisdom and power of him who, as the Gospel says, heals the sick[45].

Gregory's treatise *On the Dead* speaks of this process of purification in another image: that of smelting iron. A block of unrefined ore may have its uses, Gregory observes, as an anvil or a weight, but if something more technologically refined is needed, such as a breastplate or a sword, the ore must be broken down and the dross purged away by fire. So death itself serves the soul as the key to purification, breaking the body apart in order to smelt away the passions that attach the soul to matter, and preparing it to be reassembled as something far more useful and more beautiful[46].

Towards the end of that same treatise, Gregory speculates, perhaps more boldly and concretely than in any other of his works, on what this reshaping of the human composite, this reclaiming of humanity's original and glorious form, might imply. After reflecting on the difficulties involved in supposing that the risen body will be exactly the same, in form and qualities, as the present body, Gregory observes that even in this life our bodies are constantly changing in these respects, although their basic components remain. Central to the new form that will reclaim humanity's original glory will be the presence in our bodies of qualities we associate with the divine realm, qualities that will make us all like God and like each other:

If, then, heaviness will no longer remain in the bodies of those who have been changed, but those being transformed into a more divine state shall be 'lifted up in the air', along with bodiless natures [cf. 1 Thes 4:17], it seems reasonable that the other qualities of the body, too, will be transfigured into something more divine: their colour, their shape, their general outline, and all their individual details. For this reason we see no necessity to imagine in those transformed by the resurrection the kind of difference which nature now necessarily maintains, because of the continuity of our

[45] *Catechetical Oration* 8 (GNO III/4, 32.18-33.9; tr. Richardson, 284); see also the more extended development of the same idea in *On the Soul and the Resurrection* (PG 46, 85 C – 103 B).

[46] *On the Dead* 18 (ed. Lozza, 70; GNO IX/1, 59.23-61.7). For this conception of death as a beneficial remaking of our material nature, see also *Catechetical Oration* 8 (GNO III/4, 30.25-31.21) and 26 (GNO III/4, 66.10-22), the latter of which uses the same image of smelting gold.

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descendants [i.e., sexual difference] – though on the other hand, it is not possible to demonstrate clearly that this will not remain, since we are ignorant of what these organs will become, in the process of change. But there is no doubt that there will be but one race (γένος) including all people, when all of us become one Body of Christ, transfigured by the one mark, as the divine image radiates equally in all ...[47]

In this present life, he continues, our moods and wishes, our virtues and our vices, reveal themselves in our faces;

so, too, when our nature is transformed into something more divine, the human person will be given form by his or her character (ἦθος) – not being one thing and appearing to be another, but recognized just for what one is: the wise or just or meek or pure or loveable or devout person being found to be precisely that or even more, or found to be less in one of these [virtues] but more in another. On the basis of these and similar qualities, some recognized as good and some as just the opposite, individuals will be distinguished from one another as if into different categories (ἰδέας), until, 'when the last enemy is destroyed' [1 Cor 15:26], as the Apostle says, and evil is totally expelled from all reality, a single divine beauty, in which we were formed at the beginning, will radiate over us all. This means light and purity and incorruption and life and truth and everything of that kind – for it is hardly unlikely that the children of the day and the light will appear as they are – and no change or difference of light or purity or incorruption will be discovered, to mar their homogeneity; but one grace will shine on all, when, having become children of the light, they will 'shine like the sun' [Matt 13:43], according to the word of the Lord, who cannot lie. And that 'all will be made perfect in unity' [John 17:23], according to the promise of the word of God, means simply that one and the same grace will be revealed in all of them, just as each will share the same joy with his neighbour as a gift of God. For this reason, each will rejoice when he gazes on his neighbour's beauty, and the other will rejoice in turn, and no evil impulse will be there to change their form into an appearance of ugliness[48].

In this striking passage, Gregory sketches a picture of a transformed humanity, gradually being unified to a degree unattainable in this present life by their conformity with Christ. Like the light, radiant bodies of the gods, or the ethereal bodies of the sun and the stars, depicted by Neoplatonism, Gregory imagines the risen bodies of the saints as splendid and subtle, freed from all the negative qualities we presently encounter in our materiality; but the determining feature of these bodies will be, in the end, their virtue, the holiness and goodness that most closely resemble the holiness and goodness of God, the source and standard of virtue[49]. Just as embodiment now weighs down the soul

[47] *On the Dead* 20 (ed. Lozza, 72.31-74.3; GNO IX/1, 62.24-63.11). For a more unambiguous affirmation that the risen body will lack sexual differentiation, see *On the Making of the Human Person* 15-16. For a different interpretation of Gregory's argument in this passage, see John Behr, 'The Rational Animal: a Rereading of Gregory of Nyssa's *De hominis opificio*', *JECS* 7 (1999), 219-47.

[48] *On the Dead* 20 (ed. Lozza, 76.7-27; GNO IX/1, 65.13-66.16).

[49] So *Homily 9 on the Song of Songs* (GNO VI, 285.17): 'Virtue is not outside the divinity'; *Contra Eunomium* 3.7.60-64 (GNO II, 236.10-237.18): 'The Lord is virtue', just as Christ is 'the

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with passion – or, rather, is weighed down by it – resurrection will reveal a body made light and glorious by the soul's free affirmation of the good.

(4) So far, we have said little specifically about Gregory's treatment of the risen body of Christ. Really, however, little more needs to be said. Gregory sees in the resurrection of Jesus both the assurance and the paradigm of the fulfilment for which all of us hope. In *On the Making of the Human Person* 25, for instance, Gregory sets out to show the credibility of Christian hope for resurrection by pointing to the fulfilment of biblical prophecy in him, to the miraculous healings performed by Jesus during his ministry, and finally to his own resurrection from the dead, which he brought about 'to confirm his word in his own humanity'[50]. The exuberant rhetoric of Gregory's Easter homilies rests on the understanding, emphasized first by Paul in 1 Cor 15, that the news of Jesus' resurrection is itself the proclamation of resurrection as a hope for all: 'Because of this day', Gregory exults, 'men and women are heirs of God and coheirs with Christ'[51].

In Gregory's thought, this link is itself connected with a pervasive Christological pattern, what I have called elsewhere his 'Christology of transformation'[52]. Gregory understands the personal union of God the Son and a complete human being not simply as a paradox or a mystery, but as a redeeming process of thorough divinization: the humanity of Jesus belongs to the Son, and so in him, in the person of Jesus, the Son lives out the life of virtue and obedience and self-sacrificing holiness that not only restores the full, 'original' image of God in his own individual humanity, but begins the purification and restoration that will include the whole human race, shape us into a single form. So he writes, in the *Catechetical Oration*,

> For when, in his case, soul and body had been separated by that successive movement of change our nature undergoes, he joined the parts together again with a kind of glue – I mean by divine power. And so he united what was separated in an unbreakable union. This is what the resurrection means: the restoration of elements into an indissoluble union after their separation, so that they can grow together. In this way humanity's primal grace was restored and we retrieved once more eternal life[53].

In Jesus, to use Paul's phrase, we see the 'first fruits' of a growth in characteristically divine qualities that will eventually transform us all[54].

fount of light and truth and every good thing'. On the divine image in rational creatures as primarily consisting in virtue, see also Origen, *On First Principles* 4.4.10.

[50] *On the Making of the Human Person* 25.12 (Wilson, 417).

[51] *On the Holy Pascha* (GNO IX/1, 251.21-22).

[52] See my articles, 'Divine Transcendence and Human Transformation: Gregory of Nyssa's Anti-Apollinarian Christology', *SP* XXXII (1997), 87-95, and '"Heavenly Man" and "Eternal Christ": Apollinarius and Gregory of Nyssa on the Personal Identity of the Savior', *JECS* 10 (2002), 470-88.

[53] *Catechetical Oration* 16 (GNO IV, 48.9-17; tr. Richardson, 293).

[54] For reference to the risen body of Christ as the 'first fruits' of human redemption, see, for example, Gregory's essay or homily on 1 Cor 15:28 (GNO III/2, 14.10-13; 16.13-22); *To*

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So Gregory insists, in his works against the Apollinarians, that the classical Christology professed by him and his colleagues did not suggest a Christ who was divided, but presented rather the picture of a Christ in whom an integral humanity has already begun to be divinized, morally transformed by virtue and even physically transformed in resurrection:

Everything that was weak and perishable in our nature [he writes to Theophilus of Alexandria in his letter against the Apollinarians], mingled with the Godhead, has become that which the Godhead is ... The firstfruits of the human nature which he has taken up, absorbed (one might say figuratively) by the omnipotent divinity like a drop of vinegar mingled in the boundless sea, exists in the Godhead, but not in its own proper characteristics (ἰδιώματα). For a duality of Sons might consistently be presumed, if a nature of a different kind could be recognized by its own proper signs within the ineffable Godhead of the Son ... but since all the traits we recognize in the mortal [Jesus] we now see transformed by the characteristics of the Godhead, and no difference of any kind can be perceived – for whatever one sees in the Son is Godhead, wisdom, power, holiness, freedom from passivity – how could one divide what is one into double significance ...?[55]

What has changed in Christ – first during his lifetime, in a hidden way, but now gloriously revealed in the resurrection – is not the materiality of his created body in itself, or the intellectual structure of his created soul, but their 'qualities' or 'characteristics': divinity shines through his humanity, so powerfully that his humanity can hardly be seen any longer.

In the *Antirrhetikos against Apollinarius*, Gregory expresses this sense of transformation in a still more radical way. The Son, he observes, is always called 'Christ' because he is always anointed with the Spirit:

We say that he is always the Christ, both before the economy and after it; but he is human neither before it nor after it, but only during the time of the economy. For the flesh, in its own proper characteristics (ἰδιώμασιν) did not exist before the Virgin, nor after his ascent into heaven. 'For even if we once knew Christ according to the flesh', scripture says, 'we no longer know him thus' [2 Cor 5:16 ... But since humanity is changeable, but the divine unchangeable, the divinity is not moveable by alteration, either towards the better or towards the worse ...; but the human nature in Christ does possess the ability to change for the better, being transformed from corruption to incorruption, from what is perishable to what is imperishable, from what is short-lived to what is eternal, from what is bodily and of perceptible shape to what is bodiless and without shape[56].

Theophilus (GNO 8/1, 126.19-20); *Homily 14 on the Song of Songs* (GNO VI, 427.21-22). For a discussion of his use of this biblical image, see Reinhard M. Hübner, *Die Einheit des Leibes Christi bei Gregor von Nyssa. Untersuchungen zum Ursprung der 'physischen' Erlösungslehre* (Leiden: Brill, 1974), 97.

[55] *To Theophilus* (GNO VIII/1, 126.21-127.9).

[56] *Antirrhetikos* 53 (GNO VIII/1, 222.23-223.10).

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As we have already seen, Gregory's ontology of creatures concerns itself more with the qualities of a thing than with questions of underlying matter. In its characteristics, if not in its ontological make-up, Christ's humanity is now wholly divine. And the promise implied by that news, in Gregory's view, is that our own humanity, by being joined to his through faith and conversion and the sacraments of the Church[57], will in the end share and continually grow in that same divinity: remaining what it is, as a finite creature, yet with Christ so transfigured as to seem swallowed up in the boundless ocean of God.

Gregory's view of the transforming event of Christ's resurrection, and the hope he proffers for a similar final transformation of ourselves, may seem to show shockingly little sense of the enduring value of our present human body. It can also be seen, however, as an astounding affirmation of humanity's potential, and of the original greatness, intended by God, that determines the ultimate greatness of our vocation. If one looks beyond his Neoplatonic language and conceptuality, perhaps Gregory is not saying anything very different, in his theological anthropology, from what we read in the First Letter of John: 'Beloved, we are God's children now; it does not yet appear what we shall be, but we know that when he appears we shall be like him, for we shall see him as he is. And everyone who thus hopes in him purifies himself, as he is pure' (I John 3.2-3). That hope in transformation, and the call to purification that accompanies it, are the twin compasspoints that guide Gregory's theology of resurrection.

[57] For this ecclesial and sacramental dimension of Gregory's understanding of the process of redemption, see especially *Catechetical Oration* 33-40: GNO III/4, 82.5-106.18.

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Iatros and Medicus: The Physician in Gregory Nazianzen and Augustine

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In one of Gregory Nazianzen's most famous passages, he declares, 'That which is not assumed [by Christ] is not healed'[1]. This seminal aphorism is not an isolated example of medical imagery in Gregory's writings. His rhetoric was a product of the philosophical education of his time and the Second Sophistic, wherein language of illness and healing, doctors and remedies, is commonplace[2]. Christian theologians had further reason to take advantage of medical metaphor in view of Christ's ministry to the sick and the sinner, and in defence of Christ as the true healer of souls. Furthermore, built into Greek, as well as Latin, is a blurring of boundaries between vocabulary of healing and salvation, of healer and saviour: *sōzō* and *sōtēr*, *salus* and *salvator*, embrace a polyvalence difficult to translate. Various individuals in Late Antique paganism offered themselves as *Sōtēr*, be they emperors or Asclepius, and patristic teachers became adept at arguing the superiority of Christ as Saviour. Gregory Nazianzen had an even greater excuse to mine this *topos* for its riches: he himself had some medical training, and his brother Caesarius was one of the most famous physicians in Constantinople, having been declared its *archiatēr*. This paper will lay aside ambiguous terms such as *sōtēr* and *salvator* and focus on Gregory's use in his orations of relatively unambiguous medical terms for 'physician', both *iatros* and *therapeutēs*[3] and their cognates, and make some brief comparisons to Augustine's use of *medicus* in his sermons.

Gregory refers often in his orations to the physician *qua* physician. For the most part these references are overwhelmingly positive[4]. In numerous

[1] *Theological Epistle* 101.

[2] Rosemary Radford Ruether, *Gregory of Nazianzus: Rhetor and Philosopher* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1969), 88-9. Plato compared a wise ruler to a physician (e.g. *Politicus* 293-299). Hellenistic philosophers – Epicureans, Sceptics, and Stoics – presented themselves as physicians of the soul who made prescriptions for the improvement of the ethical life. See Martha Nussbaum, *The Therapy of Desire: Theory and Practice in Hellenistic Ethics* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1994).

[3] *Therapeutēs* has some ambiguity in that it can mean 'servant' or even 'worshipper', but the examples given here will have a clear medical context.

[4] For a more thorough discussion, see Mary Emily Keenan, 'St. Gregory of Nazianzus and Early Byzantine Medicine', *Bulletin of the History of Medicine* 9.1, 8-30.

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passages, particularly in *Oration* 7, the *epitaphos* for his brother Caesarius, Gregory clearly honours the profession and holds it up as a pattern for Christian ministry. A few negative illustrations, however, exist. The figure of the unscrupulous doctor was a type often used in rhetoric. In urging his listeners to receive baptism sooner rather than later, Gregory paints a vivid deathbed scene in which an *iatros atechnos* makes money off false reassurances to a dying man – and then from post-mortem lectures on the disease[5].

A large number of references to *iatros* in Gregory apply to Christ, or more generally to God. These fall into several subheadings. The first would be straightforward references to the miracles of Christ and to God's sustenance of human health. Gregory relates several stories of healings, especially within his own family, attributed to prayer. In *Oration* 18.29, as his father lies dying, the family calls on 'the Great Physician' and his father recovers. In *Oration* 37.3, it is the humility of Christ that brings healing. This theme of Christ the humble physician, as shall be seen below, becomes a major strand in Augustine's preaching.

More common in Gregory, as well as in Augustine, are metaphorical references to Christ as the Physician of souls. *Oration* 32.25 compares Christ to a physician who knows how to get his patient to take his medicine by adding some sweetness to it. In two redundant passages, Gregory compares Christ dining with tax collectors and sinners with a doctor bending over the suffering patient and having to put up with foul smells emanating from the sick[6].

Another, less common, comparison calls the ordinary believer to be a doctor to the souls of his friends. He is to rebuke sin or destructive habits in others and to confront their errors of doctrine[7]. As an extension of that exhortation, Gregory directs the listener to spiritual self-healing, referring to the believer as 'the only true healer of your disease'[8]. This call could be interpreted as suggesting a rather extreme form of personal responsibility for salvation.

The most prevalent comparison in Gregory's orations is the preacher as healer. In his brother's *epitaphos*, he concludes with a promise of the healing power of his rhetoric:

> What now remains? To bring the healing of the Word to those in sorrow. And a powerful remedy for mourners is sympathy, for sufferers are best consoled by those who have to bear a like suffering[9].

[5] *Oration* 40.11.

[6] *Or.* 38.14 and 45.26.

[7] *Or.* 33.6 and 34.2.

[8] *Or.* 40.12 in *Select Orations of Saint Gregory Nazianzen* tr. Charles Gordon Browne and James Edward Swallow, LNPF second series 7 (New York: Christian Literature Company, 1894). Unless otherwise noted, English translations are from this text.

[9] *Or.* 7.18.

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Other references of this type abound[10]. A preacher's use of pagan philosophy/logic/rhetoric, separated from its idolatry, he compares to 'healthful drugs from certain of the reptiles'[11]. But the bulk of his illustrations compare the training of a pastor to that of a doctor, and for the most part he is rather critical of his fellow preachers.

> [T]here is not a physician... who has not first studied the nature of diseases... but a prelate is easily found, without laborious training, with a reputation of recent date.... We manufacture those who are holy in a day, and bid those to be wise, who have had no instruction[12].

Gregory laments the lack of philosophical preparation of pastors, and worries about the consequences for their character.

In Gregory's lengthy *Oration* 2 – often referred to as his *Apologia*, explaining why he fled Nazianzus after his ordination – medical language is concentrated in sections 18-33 (out of 117). The extended comparison between physicians and pastors establishes his argument for pastors to care for the souls of those they oversee. The same sort of rigorous, philosophical education required at that time for physicians of the body should be, in Gregory's opinion, required for physicians of the soul. He thereby excuses himself for his flight from duty, in that he was following his own advice as to what makes for a good teacher – plenty of solitude and reflection, the *otium* necessary to enter into true philosophy.

In *Oration* 2.3 Gregory lays out his main theological and scriptural justification for comparing a pastor to a physician: the Church is the Body of Christ. This Body suffers from sickness and requires healing. Moreover, just as a body is ruled by one part, the local body of Christ is to be presided over by its pastor or bishop, 'performing the function of the soul in the body'[13]. The goal of pastoral care is 'the perfecting of the church'[14]. Several passages later, Gregory laments the state of the leadership of the church: 'we undertake to heal others while ourselves are full of sores'[15]. This is unfortunate, as the work of a physician of souls far outweighs the work of a medical doctor: 'Any one may recognize this, by comparing the work of the physician of souls with the treatment of the body; and noticing that, laborious as the latter is, ours is more laborious'[16]. A physician might scrutinize a patient and prescribe appropriate medicines and diet, and override the wishes of the patient who would work against his recovery, and even resort to cauterization and surgery and other

[10] *Or.* 33.1, 41.7, *Ep.* 64, *Ep.* 163.
[11] *Or.* 43.11.
[12] *Or.* 43.26.
[13] *Or.* 2.3.
[14] *Or.* 2.3.
[15] *Or.* 2.13.
[16] *Or.* 2.16.

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remedies that ancient medicine labelled 'severe'[17]. 'But none of these,' says Gregory, 'laborious and hard as they may seem, is so difficult as the diagnosis and cure of our habits, passions, lives, wills'[18]. Gregory calls the physician of souls to what many schools of ancient medicine, including that of Hippocrates, de-emphasized – diagnosis. Pastors need to go beyond treating the presenting symptoms to get at the root of the matter.

To aid in diagnosis, Gregory returns throughout Oration 2 to the importance of the close 'watchfulness' of the physician of souls[19]. Likewise the 'patient' ought to be eager to reveal his disease to his *therapeutēs*, rather than flee treatment[20]. The *pathos* of our sin we ought not to hide away to fester in its malignancy, but expose to the medicines of wisdom by which the sickness of the soul might be healed[21].

Thus Gregory argues that the pastoral 'healing business'[22] 'far exceeds in toilsomeness, and consequently in worth, that which is confined to the body'[23]. He maintains its superiority over the standard medical practice of the time, which was 'mainly concerned with the surface, and only in a slight degree investigates the causes which are deeply hidden'[24]. For the vigilant pastor, however, his whole therapeutic treatment focuses on looking for problems invisible to the eye, hidden away in the soul[25]. The ultimate superiority of the task of the soul's physician, Gregory argues, lies in the teleological purpose. The doctor of the body cares for the flesh, which is passing away, while the goal of pastoral care is to give 'wings to the soul' towards theosis[26]. Finally, the pastor is called upon to 'heal himself' in addition to healing others, although the latter task Gregory allows as the greater[27].

By way of conclusion, some points of similarity and difference can be drawn between the figure of the physician in Gregory's *Orations* and Augustine's *Sermons*. Why these two preachers? Firstly, Augustine had access to, made reference to, and clearly admired Gregory's sermons, notably *Oration* 2, the main text under consideration here. The Bishop of Hippo had before him not only Rufinus' Latin translation/paraphrase, but also probably the original Greek[28]. Despite Augustine's oft-cited protestation of not knowing Greek, his attempts to retranslate original Greek texts rather than depend

[17] *Or.* 2.18.
[18] *Ibid.*
[19] *Or.* 2.19.
[20] *Ibid.*
[21] *Or.* 2.20.
[22] *tēn iatrikēn* (author's translation).
[23] *Or.* 2.21.
[24] *Ibid.*
[25] *hē pasa therapeia* (*ibid.*).
[26] *Or.* 2.22.
[27] *Or.* 2.26.
[28] For example, in *Contra Iulianum* I.15, Augustine cites Gregory Nazianzen at length.

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solely on Rufinus demonstrate a workable knowledge of the language, which perhaps grew throughout his episcopacy[29].

Some brief disclaimers: the Gregorian sermonic corpus amounts to about one-tenth the Augustinian; thus probably only a small percentage of Gregory's addresses have survived extant. These orations, and especially his *Apologia*, appear to have been refined and amplified by their author before publication. Augustine, however, while he wished to polish the texts of his extemporaneous sermons recorded in shorthand by his *notarii*, died before accomplishing the task. Thus, between the larger sample and the lack of editing of Augustine's sermons, it is perhaps not unreasonable to find a copious supply, and even repetition, of medical imagery in the sermons of Augustine. Some of Augustine's redundant ad lib medical illustrations might not have survived his editorial pen.

They echo, nonetheless, each other's life as well as rhetoric. Both had absorbed the regnant canons of literature and philosophy, and both became *rhetors*. Both left their small-village origins to go abroad to their respective capitals of culture[30]. Both had thought-structures influenced by Hellenistic philosophy and rhetorical *topoi*, and in particular medical metaphor. Their similarities go beyond a common *paideia* and into a shared spiritual sensitivity. Both rather famously ran away: Augustine resisted the call to Christianity, and Gregory upon ordination fled Jonah-like to Pontus. Both came into ministry in their mid-thirties and were somewhat reluctant priests, placed into positions against their will. Both declared a preference for a quiet life of contemplation rather than a public life of priestly and episcopal duties. Both wrote some of the first soul-baring assessments of an inner life, Gregory's poetic version predating Augustine's prose *Confessions*[31]. While general anxiety about health abounded in their era, both did write repeatedly and in some detail about their physical struggles, particularly in their letters[32]. Both had personal connections with the medical profession, Augustine through close

[29] See Augustine, *Contra Iulianum* I.18, on translating Basil, and I.22, in which he cites John Chrysostom in Greek and then translates into Latin. Clearly, Augustine had gained much more confidence in his ability to handle the Greek text by this later, anti-Pelagian period of his life and ministry. For more on Rufinus' transmission of Gregory Nazianzen, see M. Monica Wagner, *Rufinus, the Translator: A Study of His Theory and His Practice as Illustrated in His Version of the Apologetica of St. Gregory Nazianzen*, Patristic Studies 73 (Washington, DC: Catholic University of America Press, 1945). See also F.X. Murphy, 'Rufinus of Aquileia and Gregory the Theologian', *Greek Orthodox Theological Review* 39. 3-4 (1994), 181-186.

[30] Augustine to Carthage and thence to Rome and Milan; Gregory to Caesarea and thence to Alexandria and Athens.

[31] Gerard H. Ettlinger, 'The Orations of Gregory of Nazianzus: A Study in Rhetoric and Personality', in *Preaching in the Patristic Age*, ed. David G. Hunter (New York: Paulist Press, 1989), 101.

[32] 'The constant use of medical images may be explained in part by Gregory's own preoccupation with his health, making this kind of figure particularly congenial to him' (Ruether, 89).

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friends who were doctors, and Gregory through his own training and that of his brother. And both related contemporary examples of healing attributed to prayer.

In terms of frequency, Augustine makes more use of the image of the physician than does Gregory, even taking into account redactional differences of the texts under examination. The image of Christ the healer of sin-sick humanity is central to Augustine's preaching. With the exception of the *Apologia*, there are few extended medical metaphors in the orations of Gregory, whereas Augustine delights in extravagantly lengthy illustrations. In terms of redundancy, Gregory reiterates an illustration verbatim at least once[33]. Augustine often repeats his narratives, but since the texts record sermons delivered without a script, there are discernible variants. One illustration that both preachers are fond of is the threefold healing offered by Christ the Physician to Peter after his denial. The similarities of expression are striking enough to suggest perhaps some possible borrowing by Augustine.

In the main, however, Augustine utilizes *medicus* almost exclusively to refer to God, and overwhelmingly to the ministry of Christ to the believer. His foundational verse is repeated over and over in his sermons: 'Those who are well have no need of a physician, but those who are sick; I have come to call not the righteous but sinners'[34]. His illustrations merely expand this idea in vivid ways. With Augustine, unlike Gregory Nazianzen, direct references to the preacher or pastor as *medicus* are few. Several indirect references, however, allude to the healing power of the preaching of Paul to the Gentiles or of Augustine himself to his congregation. In a few passages Augustine, like Gregory, calls on the believer to be a doctor to an erring friend[35]. Yet Augustine seems reluctant to refer to himself directly as the *medicus animarum* of those gathered in his basilica. At times, he begins to refer to himself as such, but then retreats in humility: 'So then when I say all this I am only hating your fevers, *or rather in me the word of God*, with which you should come to an agreement, is hating your fevers. What after all am I,' he says, 'but someone needing to be set free with you, cured with you?'[36] Augustine sees the task of his preaching to bring healing; but he saves the title of *medicus* almost exclusively for Christ.

Such consistency in his references to Christ as the Great Physician reveals Augustine's sensitivity to his own need for spiritual healing. It also reflects a

[33] *Or.* 38.14 and 45.26. The identical wording of the two passages suggests to this author that Gregory plucked one from the other in his editorial process. Augustine's repetition, however, does not typically exhibit this sort of exactness, which would be consistent with recorded speech.

[34] Mk 2:17; Lk 5:31; Mt 9:12. Matthew omits the second clause.

[35] E.g., *Sermon* 49.6.

[36] *Sermon* 9.10, in *The Works of Saint Augustine, A Translation for the 21st Century*, ed. John E. Rotelle. *Sermons*, vol III/11, *Newly Discovered Sermons*, tr. Edmund Hill, (Hyde Park, NY: New City Press, 1997).

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mature, Christocentric soteriology and ecclesiology, as well as a developing sacramental theology. He regarded his preaching and his ministry as bishop merely as signposts to the real Doctor. On the other hand, Gregory's orations, and in particular his *Apologia* composed early in his ministry, are imbued with a more Hellenistic flavour of the pastor-philosopher as the physician of souls. This construct may reflect Gregory's personal familiarity and identification with the role of physician, as well as his apophatic theology[37]. If God is clouded in mystery, it helps to have someone close at hand tending one's soul. In the dynamic tension between God's self-revelation and hiddenness both of these pastoral models may well be needed.

[37] See Gerald Fitzpatrick, 'St. Gregory Nazianzen: Education for Salvation,' *The Patristic and Byzantine Review* 10, no. 1-2 (1991), 47-55.

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'Doctrines in the Form of a Story': Narrative Theology in Gregory of Nyssa's *Oratio Catechetica Magna*

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One of the most significant developments in Anglo-American theology during the past three decades has been the rediscovery of the importance of narrative for Christian theology[1]. Although the diversity of narrative theology proposals resists facile description, the main emphases of the movement may be summarized in terms of three basic theses:

1. the originary language of Christian faith and practice is primarily narrative rather than propositional in form;
2. the Christian narrative both shapes and is shaped by the Christian community;
3. as persons become Christian, their stories are shaped by their identification with the Christian community and its narrative.

It is difficult to avoid being reminded of these emphases when one reads Gregory of Nyssa's *Oratio Catechetica Magna*. While I am not attempting to portray Gregory as a sort of incipient Lindbeckian postliberal, I do wish to explore five features of the *Oratio* that suggest something akin to a narrative theology.

First, Gregory maintains that Christian doctrines may be communicated not only by propositional statements, but also via narratives. In chapter 5 of the *Oratio*, Gregory grounds the teaching that God created humanity for participation in the divine goodness in the 'single statement (δι' ἑνὸς ῥήματος)' of Gen 1:27 that humanity was created 'in the image of God'[2]. The same teaching is also communicated in 'whatever Moses relates more along the lines of historical narrative (ἱστορικώτερον), presenting to us doctrines in the form of a story (ἐν διηγήσεως εἴδει δόγματα)'[3]: the story in Genesis 2 of the first man's placement in the garden of Eden and his enjoyment of its fruit makes the same doctrinal point as the affirmation of the *imago dei* in Gen 1:27[4]. In

[1] See, e.g., S. Hauerwas and L. Jones (eds), *Why Narrative? Readings in Narrative Theology* (Grand Rapids, 1989).
[2] GNO III 4.18.5-7.
[3] GNO III 4.18.9-11.
[4] GNO III 4.18.11-15.

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chapter 8 the teaching that mortality is a consequence of the Fall is also a 'doctrine (δόγμα)' that 'Moses sets forth in the manner of historical narrative (ἱστορικώτερον)'[5], namely the account of the clothing of Adam and Eve with 'garments of skins' (Gen 3:21). Outside of the *Oratio*, a similar expression appears in the *Apologia in Hexaemeron*: in the creation story, 'doctrines (δογμάτων)' about the nature of created beings are expressed 'in the form of a story (ἐν διηγήσεως εἴδει)'[6]. These expressions are distinctively Nyssene, unparalleled in the *Thesaurus Linguae Graecae* canon[7].

While these texts make it clear that Gregory regarded both proposition and narrative in the biblical text as expressive of doctrine, the relationship between narrative and proposition portrayed therein admits of two possible interpretations. One the one hand, it is possible that Gregory conceives of a priority of doctrinal proposition to narrative. Such an interpretation would hinge on an understanding of δόγμα as a fixed, propositional tenet of Christian theology[8] and the equation of δόγμα and ῥήμα in the text from chapter 5, so that the doctrinal proposition (ῥήμα) that the *imago dei* includes the capacity for participation in the divine goodness is the doctrinal proposition (δόγμα) that may also be communicated through the literary form (εἶδος)[9] of narrative. On the other hand, if we understand δόγμα more generally as that which is taught in Christian teaching[10], that which is taught is not necessarily propositional in nature. In the context of the *Oratio*, that which is taught in catechetical instruction is not a body of doctrinal propositions but rather the triune God whose story includes the creation, fall, and restoration of humanity. If δόγμα may be understood in this more general sense, one may more naturally distinguish between δόγμα and ῥήμα in the text in question in chapter 5, with the result that ῥήμα and διήγησις are each a literary form (εἶδος) of δόγμα. In this reading, which makes the best sense of the relationship between narrative and proposition in the *Oratio*, there is in the biblical text neither a priority of doctrinal proposition to narrative nor a priority of narrative to doctrinal proposition. Rather, that which Christianity teaches – the being and economy of the triune God – is what has priority to its expression in the biblical literary forms of narrative and doctrinal statement.

[5] GNO III 4.29.22-30.2.

[6] PG 44, 72.

[7] *TLG* CD-ROM E (Irvine, Calif., 1999), used with *TLG Workplace* version 8.0 (Cedar Hill, Tex., 2000), with the following search strings: (1) διηγησ AND ειδ, (2) διηγησ AND δογμα, and (3) δογμα AND ἱστορικ, with the word proximity limited to a three-word interval or less. Other than these three passages from Gregory, additional matches yielded by whole TLG canon searches are unrelated constructions.

[8] Cf. G.W.H. Lampe (ed.), *A Patristic Greek Lexicon* (Oxford, 1961), *s.v.* 'δόγμα, τό', B.5.

[9] Cf. this usage of εἶδος in rhetorical literature noted in H. Liddell and R. Scott, *A Greek-English Lexicon*, rev. H.S. Jones (Oxford, 1968), *s.v.* 'εἶδος, εος, τό', II.

[10] The German *Lehre* comes nearer to communicating this sense of δόγμα, though it too may in some usages carry propositional overtones; cf. F. Mann (ed.), *Lexicon Gregorianum: Wörterbuch zu den Schriften Gregors von Nyssa* (Leiden, 2000), *s.v.* 'δόγμα, ατος, τό', III.

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Second, according to the *Oratio* biblical narrative is multivalent in its communication of doctrine. In chapter 8, 'Moses sets forth doctrine in the manner of historical narrative (ἱστορικώτερον) and through hidden meanings (δι' αἰνιγμάτων)'[11]. This language recalls the manner in which Gregory in *De Vita Moysis* discerns multiple meanings in the same biblical story when read from two different perspectives, a literal reading of historical narrative (ἱστορία) and a non-literal or allegorical reading (θεωρία, for which Gregory sometimes employs αἴνιγμα synonymously)[12]. In this passage of the *Oratio*, reflection on certain features of the historical narrative of the clothing of Adam and Eve with 'garments of skins' leads Gregory to the conclusion that the theological meaning of the narrative is not found in the literal sense of the 'skins' but in the αἴνιγμα of the story. This does not mean that doctrine is communicated only by the allegorical sense of the text: from one perspective, the story is a realistic narrative about the provision of clothing for the first humans in the aftermath of their fall; from another perspective, Gregory can read the story as an account of humanity's acquisition of a mortal nature. Both meanings of the narrative are doctrinally significant in the context of this section of the *Oratio*, even if in this case it is the non-literal reading that is initially more suggestive of doctrine.

Third, the communication of doctrine in narrative form is something that occurs not only in the biblical text, but also in the teaching of the catechist. The audience implied by the *Oratio* is not catechumens but rather catechists, for whom Gregory models appropriate approaches to initiating catechumens into Christian teachings. A notable feature of Gregory's approach to catechetical instruction is his preference for summary of biblical narrative, rather than quotation of specific biblical passages, as the means of acquainting catechumens with the teachings of scripture. Apart from a concentration of biblical quotations near the end of the *Oratio* in the sections on baptism, the Eucharist, the Christian life, and the life of the age to come (chapters 33-40), there are very few citations of scripture, especially when compared with two other works of similar length and content, Athanasius' *De Incarnatione* and Augustine's *De Catechizandis Rudibus*[13]. In chapters 1-32 of the *Oratio*, which deal

[11] GNO III 4.30.1-2.

[12] Gregory summarizes this relationship between ἱστορία (Book I) and θεωρία (Book II) in *De Vita Moysis* in *V. Mos.* 1.77 and 2.320 (GNO VII 1.33.3-6 and 144.15-20). On the equivalence of θεωρία with αἴνιγμα and other terms in Gregory's hermeneutical vocabulary, see J. Trigg, *Biblical Interpretation*, Message of the Fathers of the Church, vol. 9 (Wilmington, Del., 1988), pp. 144-5.

[13] *Or. Catech.* contains thirty-five citations in forty-seven Greek columns in the Migne edition (PG 45, 11-105), an average of 0.74 citations per column; Ath. *Inc.* has ninety-three citations in fifty Greek Migne columns (PG 25, 96-197), an average of 1.86 citations per column; Aug. *Catech. Rud.* has forty-six citations in thirty-nine Migne columns (PL 40, 309-48), an average of 1.18 citations per column.

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with the earliest stages of catechesis up to the preparation of catechumens for the mysteries of baptism and the Eucharist near the end of their pre-baptismal instruction, there are only twelve citations of scripture, but there are seventy-two indirect allusions to scripture in these chapters[14]. Some are echoes or paraphrases of biblical passages, but the vast majority of these allusions are references to events narrated in scripture with no accompanying quotation. Frequently these appear in clusters of narrative summary, as in the following four examples. In chapter 9, Gregory anticipates objections to the distinctively Christian concept of God as incarnate: 'I refer to the human birth, the growth from infancy to adulthood, the eating and drinking and weariness and sleep and grief and tears, the false accusations and trial, the cross and death and burial in the tomb'[15]. In this cluster Gregory summarizes twelve specific passages in the Gospels with only a word or two[16]. In the familiar portrayal of the work of Christ as an ensnaring ransom in chapter 23, a cluster of fourteen allusions to unique aspects of the life of Christ narrated in the Gospels serves to explain why the devil was so attracted to the bait of Christ's flesh that he became ensnared[17]. A cluster of seven narrative allusions in chapter 29 summarizes the story of fallen humanity from the choice of evil to the time of the incarnation[18]. Near the end of the section on the incarnation, atonement, and restoration of humanity in chapter 32, Gregory alludes briefly to six passages in the Gospels and Acts that summarize the story of Christ's resurrection and ascension, the 'mere mention' of which is sufficient for impressing catechumens with the 'supernatural nature' of the biblical story[19]. One finds a similar catechetical use of narrative summary in the *Apostolic Constitutions*, Augustine, and Cyril of Jerusalem, but these do not share Gregory's reluctance to quote directly from scripture in the course of narrative summary. It seems that Gregory viewed summary of the biblical story rather than direct quotation from it as the best vehicle for teaching Christian doctrines to those who are not yet adequately prepared to receive and understand the Bible itself[20].

[14] See the citations and allusions noted in the apparatus of GNO III 4.5-82.

[15] GNO III 4.36.21-37.2.

[16] Luke 2:6; Luke 2:40, 52; Mark 2:16/Luke 24:43; John 4:6; Matt 8:24/Luke 8:23; Matt 26:38; John 11:35; Matt. 26:59; Matt. 27:27; Matt 27:38/par.; Matt 27:50/par.; Matt 27:57-60/par.

[17] GNO III 4.58.18-59.19; allusions are to Matt 1:18, 25; Luke 11:27; Luke 2:14, 3:22/par., 9:35/par.; Matt 9:1-8; Matt 8:5-13; Matt 9:18ff./par., Luke 7:11-17, and John 11:11-44; Matt 8:29/par.; Matt 8:23-27/par.; Matt 14:22-33/par.; Exod 14:19-29; Matt 4:2-4/par.; Matt 14:14 - 5:21/par. and 15:32-39/par.; Exod 16:13ff. and Num 11:4-9; John 6:1-13.

[18] GNO III 4.73.9-16; allusions are to Gen. 3:1-6, 4:1-8; Gen 6:5ff; Gen 19:1-29; Exod 5-11; Dan 4:19 [LXX] or Isa 37:23ff.; Matt 23:29-39; Matt 2:16-18.

[19] GNO III 4.81.11-19; allusions are to John 19:34; Luke 24:36?; John 20:19, 26; John 20:22; Matt 28:20; Acts 1:9.

[20] I develop this aspect of Gregory's use of scripture in the *Oratio* more fully in my forthcoming article 'Text of the Initiated: Scripture in Gregory of Nyssa's *Oratio Catechetica Magna*'.

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Fourth, the doctrinal content of the *Oratio* is essentially a commentary on the coherence of the Christian narrative as the most fitting portrayal of the being of God and the human condition. The initial section on theology proper develops the character of the triune God as the main character in the story vis-à-vis Jewish and Hellenistic characterizations of the divine[21]. The bulk of the *Oratio* explains the inner logic of the Christian story of creation, fall, and restoration[22]. Within that central section of the *Oratio*, Gregory portrays the means by which God effected the restoration of humanity as a drama in which God lures Satan to take the 'bait' of Christ's flesh as a ransom for captive humanity, a drama that concludes with the irony that the means by which Satan sought to defeat God not only proves to be the undoing of his schemes, but ultimately even secures his own restoration[23]. The narrative form of the doctrine taught in the *Oratio* ends with the intersection of the story of the triune God in creation and redemption with the stories of those who claim the divine story as their own. Participation in baptism and the Eucharist transforms the stories of the faithful[24], leading them into a life of the ongoing transformation of their character through faith and repentance[25].

Fifth, the *Oratio* also narrates the story of the Christian's progress in the spiritual life. It functions not only as a pattern for catechists in their teaching of the Church's story of the triune God, but also as a pattern for the spiritual progress of catechumens. Catechumens begin with an initial attraction to Christian faith that is accompanied by questions about the nature of the divine and an ignorance not only of specific details of scripture but also of the broad outlines of the biblical story. Gregory's pattern for catechesis begins with this stage of the catechumen's spiritual progress, utilizing appeals to reason and narrative summaries of various aspects of the biblical story and reserving direct appeals to scripture for later stages of spiritual progress. The *Oratio's* model for moving catechumens from attraction to the faith to increasing awareness of the coherence of the Christian story and from subsequent initiation into the Church to growth in the Christian life and the life of the age to come thus implicitly narrates the ideal stories of those who will experience this process.

Many aspects of what I have characterized as a 'narrative theology' in Gregory's *Oratio* are by no means unique to Gregory among patristic theologians. As Paul Blowers and others have observed, there is a common 'narrative character of early Christian faith' that makes it possible to discern elements of a narrative theology in virtually any expression of patristic thought[26]. The

[21] GNO III 4.8.10-15.15.
[22] GNO III 4.15.16-82.5.
[23] GNO III 4.57.10-67.21.
[24] GNO III 4.82.5-98.7.
[25] GNO III 4.98.8-106.18.
[26] P. Blowers, 'The *Regula Fidei* and the Narrative Character of Early Christian Faith', *Pro Ecclesia* 6 (1997), 199-228.

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doctrinal teaching modelled in the *Oratio* is narrative in form and content not because Gregory shaped it to be so, but because early Christian doctrine *was* narrative in character. Nevertheless, Gregory's *Oratio* serves as a noteworthy specific example of the role played by narrative in early Christian thought, noteworthy in part because of two distinctive contributions: a consciousness of narrative as a vehicle of doctrinal expression and a vocabulary articulating this consciousness, and a preference for narrative summary over direct quotation as a mode of biblical reference in the course of catechetical instruction.

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Gregory of Nyssa on Human Unity and Diversity

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Contemporary theologians in both the eastern and western churches have expressed considerable interest in the idea that the image of God in humankind is essentially communal, and that the Holy Trinity provides the pattern according to which human communities can best be structured. This concept is often associated with a belief that what makes people human is their personhood, and that a person is defined as combining a depth of irreducible uniqueness with intrinsic relatedness to others. Like the Godhead, humankind is thus characterized by unity and diversity. Besides addressing important theological issues within the Christian traditions, these ideas tie in with broader contemporary cultural concerns about the meaning of human diversity.

These ideas of personhood and a trinitarian *imago Dei* have often been ascribed to the Cappadocians, and to Gregory of Nyssa in particular, a notion that has been popular especially among systematic theologians who are not specialists in patristics. Gregory's letter to Ablabius *On Not Three Gods* is most often cited in this regard. However, recent studies of this text and related writings have challenged this interpretation. Lewis Ayres and Michel Barnes have argued that the *Ad Ablabium* is primarily concerned with the 'grammar' of theological discourse and the unity of divine will and have shown that it is at least as concerned to note divergences between divine and human community as it is to suggest parallels between them[1]. Lucien Turcescu has demonstrated how vastly the notion of individuation expressed here and in the *Ad Petrum* – a text otherwise known as Basil's *Epistle 38*, but usually ascribed to Gregory – differs from the theory of personhood advocated by John Zizioulas and those who share his views[2]. The *Ad Ablabium* states that the word ἄνθρωπος properly refers to the nature that all human beings have in common, whereas proper names like Luke or Stephen refer to particular people. 'The principle of the hypostases', it says, 'allows for differentiation through the properties observed in each ... but the nature is one'. 'Ο μὲν τῶν

[1] Lewis Ayres, 'On Not Three People: The Fundamental Themes of Gregory of Nyssa's Trinitarian Theology as Seen in *To Ablabius: On Not Three Gods*', in Sarah Coakley, ed., *Rethinking Gregory of Nyssa* (Oxford: Blackwell, 2003), 15-44; and Michel René Barnes, 'Divine Unity and the Divided Self: Gregory of Nyssa's Trinitarian Theology in its Psychological Context', in Coakley, 45-66.

[2] '"Person" versus "Individual", and Other Modern Misreadings of Gregory of Nyssa', in Coakley, 97-109.

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ὑποστάσεων λόγος διὰ τὰς ἐνθεωρουμένας ἰδιότητας ἑκάστῳ τὸν διαμερισμὸν ἐπιδέχεται ... ἡ δὲ φύσις μία ἐστίν ... (GNO 3.1, 40-1). As Turcescu has shown, here Gregory makes use of Aristotelian logic as Porphyry presents it in his *Isagoge*, an introductory handbook familiar to the Cappadocian and his contemporaries. This approach to individuation begins with natures, that is genera, known and defined by properties all members of the group, such as human beings, have in common. Within a genus, each individual is circumscribed, distinguished from others and made known by a particular set of properties not shared by other members of the group. Each human being may thus possess a unique subset of all possible individual human properties. Yet this is a far cry from what contemporary philosophers and theologians mean by personhood, which for them entails an unfathomable depth of uniqueness that cannot be reduced to a particular collection of properties. This concept of personhood is a commonplace today, but was unknown in the ancient world.

Since this is not how Gregory understands what is distinctive in a particular human being's identity, how does he understand it? His anthropological writings can surely tell us more than does the point of logic he deploys in a debate about the Trinity. For him, which kinds of human diversity are foundational and permanent, and which are ephemeral? And in what ways are human beings united with each other? My paper will make a modest attempt to address some of these questions, though it cannot take account of all the complexities of Gregory's anthropology and its diverse scholarly interpretations.

Given the profound dynamism of the human condition as he understands it, the static picture presented in the logical definitions of φύσις and ὑπόστασις in the *Ad Ablabium* and the *Ad Petrum* cannot fully explain his understanding of human unity and diversity. People change over time in many ways, so their properties change. Gregory recognizes that the body itself, and even the matter of which it is composed, change through the various stages of the life cycle[3], to say nothing of the resurrection, which will transform it radically in ways largely beyond our present imagining. Moreover, much of Gregory's writing aims to persuade people to change their moral qualities by turning from passions and practising virtues. A person's free choice plays a great role in this. For Gregory, human beings are very malleable, and they can choose many of the properties they will possess. Thus, they can take on themselves the image of a savage beast by imitating its character and activities, or they can imitate Christ and acquire the likeness of God.

As I showed in a paper presented at the Oxford Patristics Conference in 1987, for Gregory the human person functions as a kind of receptacle and can choose which properties to receive and keep within itself[4]. The key text is in

[3] *De mortuis*, GNO 9, 51-2.

[4] 'Receptacle Imagery in St. Gregory of Nyssa's Anthropology', *SP* XXII (1989), 23-7.

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the *De anima et resurrectione* and speaks of how this receptacle functions when one chooses to receive more and more divine life into oneself.

> A kind of vessels and free-willed receptacles of souls were fashioned by the Wisdom which constructed the universe, in order that there should be a container to receive good things, a container which would always become larger with the addition of what would be poured into it. For the participation in the divine good is such that it makes anyone into whom it enters greater and more receptive. As it is taken up it increases the power and magnitude of the recipient, so that the person who is nourished always grows and never ceases from growth. Since the fountain of good things flows unfailingly, the nature of the participants who use all the influx to add to their own magnitude (because nothing of what is received is superfluous or useless) becomes at the same time both more capable of attracting the better and more able to contain it. Each adds to the other, the one who is nourished gains greater power from the abundance of good things, and the nourishing supply rises in flood to match the increase of the one who is growing. Those whose growth is not cut off by any limit will surely continue to increase in this manner. (PG 46, 105A-C[5])

This passage describes the dynamic of the eternal progress for which Gregory is well known. In contrast, he says elsewhere that when one attempts to fill one's receptacle with passions and material things, it functions like a leaky jar that is never full no matter how much one pours into it[6]. That is, if we do not live as our creator intends, we will be trapped in futile labour and continual dissatisfaction.

This shows how one's properties can change, yet the same individual continues to exist throughout these changes; for example, Saul of Tarsus becomes the apostle Paul, but he remains the same human being. The word ὑπόστασις in its most literal sense means something like a receptacle, that which underlies and contains the properties present in it[7]. Although Gregory never defines it in this way, I would suggest that his usage presupposes such a meaning. To arrive at a full and balanced understanding of his theology, we must take into account his metaphors and analogies, which often convey rich and precise conceptual content, as well as his philosophical argumentation. In his writings these modes of expression complement each other as he endeavours to convey what he can of mysteries he knows largely surpass the capacities of human language.

[5] Catharine P. Roth, tr. *St. Gregory of Nyssa: On the Soul and the Resurrection* (Crestwood, NY: St. Vladimir's, 1993), 87-8, modified.

[6] *De Beatitudinibus* 4, GNO 7.2, 119; *De mortuis*, GNO 9, 59.

[7] Let me thank Alexander Golitzin, who made this observation in a private conversation in Berkeley, some time in the 1980s.

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Temporary Modes of Diversity

In western cultures today there is great concern about the diverse properties shared by some groups of people but not others, the kinds of things summed up in the phrase 'gender, race, and class'. In Gal 3:28, the apostle Paul notes that precisely these kinds of diversities are absent in a Christian's new baptismal identity. The Fathers also are wary of these kinds of diversity on the grounds that they could threaten the unity of the body of Christ. Early Christians did not see them as defining what is most essential to being human. In the ancient world, the category of race was not understood in the ways it is now, and Gregory appears to say little about it, though he does argue against Jewish and Graeco-Roman theological ideas. His position on gender is well known, and as I have discussed it elsewhere I will not focus on it here. However, in Gregory's anthropology there is an interesting parallel between the ways he understands gender and class, which we will now consider. He contrasts both these kinds of diversity with the common properties he regards as central to human identity. He defines what is distinctively human in terms of the image of God in Gen 1:26-27, a text he cites in many of his writings. A famous passage in *De opificio hominis* 16 provides a good starting point for our study. It is worth quoting at length.

> For as indeed a particular human being is enclosed by the size of his body, and the magnitude corresponding to the outward surface of the body is the measure of his subsistence (ὑποστάσεως), so, it seems to me, the whole plenitude of humanity was encompassed by the God of all through the power of foreknowledge, as if indeed in one body, and the text teaches this which says, 'And God created the human being, according to the image of God he created him' [Gen 1:27a]. For the image is not in part of the nature, nor is the grace in a certain entity observed in it, but such power extends equally to all the [human] race. A sign of this is that mind is established in all alike; all have the power of rational thought and deliberation, and all the other things through which the divine nature is imaged in that which has been created according to it. The human being manifested at the first creation of the world and the one that will come into being at the consummation of all are alike, equally bearing in themselves the divine image. Because of this, the whole [of humankind] was named as one human being, since to the power of God nothing is either past or future, but what is expected is encompassed equally with what is present by the energy that rules all. So the whole nature, extending from the first to the last, is, as it were, one image of the Existing One; the distinction between male and female was fashioned last [Gen 1:27b], added to what was formed. (PG 44, 185B-D)

Scholars such as David Balás, Reinhard Hübner, and Johannes Zachhuber have disagreed over what Gregory means here by the one human nature, whether it is the totality of all people from the beginning to the end of history, or whether it is a kind of form ontologically prior to human beings and immanent within all of them[8]. We cannot address this complex issue here.

[8] David L. Balás, '*Plenitudo Humanitatis*: The Unity of Human Nature in the Theology of Gregory of Nyssa', in Donald F. Winslow, ed., *Disciplina Nostra: Essays in Memory of Robert*

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Our concern with this text is that it shows how Gregory regards humankind throughout time, space, and the eschaton as a single whole whose unity is foundational and is constituted by the divine image, which all people possess equally and in the same way. For him, unity is prior to diversity. The emphasis on unity, alikeness, and equality in the context of protology and eschatology is important, and we will return to it below. Note how the text contrasts this with the gender distinction, which introduces diversity and disunity.

In a famous discussion of slavery, the *Fourth Homily on Ecclesiastes* addresses the issue of class similarly to the way gender is discussed in *De opificio hominis* 16. Both texts emphasize the same concept of human freedom. Gregory refers to Gen 1:26 repeatedly throughout the passage in *In Ecclesiasten* 4. He employs his theological anthropology to demonstrate the absurdity of owning slaves and uses pointed rhetoric to scold the owner directly.

'I acquired slaves and slave girls' [Eccl 2:7]. What are you saying? You condemn to slavery the human being, whose nature is free and self-ruling, and you legislate in opposition to God, overturning what is according to the law of nature. For upon the one who was created to be lord of the earth and appointed to rule the creation, upon this one you impose the yoke of slavery, as if he were resisting and fighting the divine precept. You have forgotten the limits of your authority, a rule limited to dominion over the non-rational animals. For scripture says, 'Let them rule birds and fish and quadrupeds and reptiles'. How can you bypass the slavery within your power and rise up against the one who is free by nature, numbering one of the same nature as yourself among the four-legged and legless beasts? (GNO 5, 335)

Though he may not have been an abolitionist in practice, it is important to note that Gregory regards his image theology as having ethical consequences. He notes in *De opificio hominis* 16 that the misery of people's present fallen condition contrasts sharply with the life expressive of divine likeness that will be fully actualized only in the eschaton. Yet in *In Ecclesiasten* 4 he stresses that human beings here and now possess the divine image, with all the dignity, equality, and authority that it entails, including those people most subject to the miseries caused by the fallenness of society. Gregory makes this even clearer in what follows, stating that this ultimate form of class difference divides the unity proper to humankind, just as the gender distinction is said to divide it in *De opificio hominis* 16. Again he speaks directly to the slave owner.

You have divided the nature itself, making some live as slaves and others as lords ... For God said, 'Let us make a human being according to our image and likeness'. Who sells and who buys the one who is in the likeness of God and rules all the earth and all that is on the earth, having been assigned the authority by God? (GNO 5, 336)

F. Evans (Cambridge, Mass.: Philadelphia Patristic Foundation, 1979), 115-31; Reinhard M. Hübner, *Die Einheit des Leibes Christi bei Gregor von Nyssa* (Leiden: Brill, 1974); Johannes Zachhuber, *Human Nature in Gregory of Nyssa: Philosophical Background and Theological Significance* (Leiden: Brill, 1999).

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The text goes on to say that the prospective slave owns and rules the earth and everything in it and is himself of greater value than all he owns, so no imaginable price could be sufficient to buy him. Gregory then cites Christ's words in Mt 16:26: 'For he who knows human nature says precisely that the whole world is not of sufficient value to be exchanged for the soul of a human being' (GNO 5, 337).

Gregory again uses the theology of the image to make an ethical point in the second homily *De pauperibus amandis*, where he defends the human dignity of homeless social outcasts who are disabled and disfigured by leprosy, as he reminds his audience of their duty to take care of them. In the middle of a lengthy description of such a person's miserable bodily condition and way of life, he makes the following observations.

> He is a human being, created according to the image of God, appointed to rule the earth, having within his power the service of the non-rational animals. In this misfortune he has indeed been changed to such an extent that from his appearance it is doubtful whether his visible form with the identifying marks it bears is clearly that of a human being or of some other animal[9].

Just as it is scandalous for the slave to have to play the role of a non-rational animal, it is an outrage that illness and mistreatment have blurred the distinction between a human being and a beast. In both cases one bearing the divine image is denied the respect intended by God. Divisions of class and social status have sundered the unity and solidarity intrinsic to the humanity shared by owners and slaves, by those secure in their houses and those wandering homeless in the countryside.

Following the texts we have cited, *In Ecclesiasten* 4 tells the master what he has in common with his slave. This is a useful list of the kinds of shared characteristics Gregory sees as uniting all human beings.

> For what has the authority [of ownership] added to what is yours by nature? Not time, not beauty, not honour, not furtherance in virtue. He is made of the same stuff as you, his life is of a like kind; you who are lord and the one subjected to lordship are to an equal extent dominated by the passions of soul and body: pain and good cheer, joy and sadness, grief and pleasure, anger and fear, sickness and death. Is there any difference in these matters between the slave and the lord? Do they not breathe the same air? Do they not alike see the sun? Do they not alike preserve their nature by eating food? Are they not the same in their use of digestive organs? Are not the two one dust after death? Is the judgement not one? Do they not share a common kingdom and a common gehenna? How then can you who have equality in everything have superiority in any particular, as you say, supposing yourself as a human being to be master of a human being? (GNO 5, 338)

[9] Arie van Heck, ed., *Gregorii Nysseni De pauperibus amandis orationes duo* (Leiden: Brill, 1964), 26.

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Besides sharing the divine image and the rationality it entails, for Gregory all humans share the same kinds of bodily and emotional experiences and weaknesses, the simple experiences of their common earthly environment, and, most importantly, the same prospects regarding death and the life beyond it. In the *De mortuis* he asserts that the following class differences will be absent in the life to come: 'slavery and lordship, poverty and wealth, nobility and ignobility, common lowliness and honourable sovereignty, and all such inequalities of status' (GNO 9, 35)[10].

It is noteworthy that a number of Greek patristic authors use lists of common characteristics similar to the one in *In Ecclesiasten* 4 to show how both genders are alike, sharing the same human nature and vocation[11]. It would be useful to consider further what sorts of relationships exist between the ways early Christian writers understand men and women and the ways they understand masters and slaves, since the roles of all these persons are interrelated in the world of the late antique household.

Eschatological Diversity

Study of theologians' views of eschatology is important when seeking to understand their concepts of anthropology. Besides showing how they think about God's plans for the future, it reveals which aspects of present human identity and existence they consider most important and valuable and which they consider peripheral and transitory. Thus, for Gregory the differences based on gender and class are less central to what it is to be human than intellect, freedom and the capacity for virtue and communion with God, properties that manifest the divine image and are shared by all human beings.

Since according to Gregory many of the diversifying properties most evident in this life do not continue into the next[12], what characteristics does he see

[10] At the Fourteenth Oxford Patristics Conference, in a paper entitled 'Moral and Ascetical Passages in Gregory of Nyssa, *Contra Eunomium*, Book I', Graham Gould noted that in *C. Eun.* 1, GNO 1, 178-9, Gregory observes that inequality is unnatural to human beings, hence the dominance of one person over others leads to political instability. After his presentation he kindly supplied me with this reference.

[11] Perhaps the most notable parallel is in Clement of Alexandria, *Paedagogus* 1.10.1 - 1.11.2 (SC 70, 128-30). See also Basil of Caesarea, *Homiliae de creatione hominis* 1.18 (SC 160, 213-17); John Chrysostom, *Homiliae in Genesin* 15 (PG 53, 120); and Theodoret of Cyrus, *Graecarum affectionum curatio* 5.54-57 (SC 57.1, 243-5).

[12] On Gregory's eschatology, see Jean Daniélou, 'L'apocatastase chez Saint Grégoire de Nysse', *RSR* 30 (1940), 328-47; Monique Alexandre, 'Protologie et eschatologie chez Grégoire de Nysse', in U. Bianchi and H. Crouzel, eds., *Arché e Telos: L'antropologia di Origene e di Gregorio di Nissa. Analisi storico-religiosa* (Milan: Università Cattolica del Sacro Cuore, 1981), 122-69; John R. Sachs, 'Apocatastasis in Patristic Theology', *TS* 54 (1993), 617-40; and Morwenna Ludlow, *Universal Salvation: Eschatology in the Thought of Gregory of Nyssa and Karl Rahner* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000), 1-111.

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as differentiating people from each other in the age to come, and by what features can they be recognized? He addresses these questions near the end of the *De mortuis*. The text begins by noting that now the shapes and colours of our visible forms change in accordance with the proportions of the material elements that compose our bodies, but in the next life it will be different.

> What shapes the form of each will not be these elements. Rather, the properties of vice and virtue, either in a certain mixture with each other, or in one way or another, produce the form to be imprinted. Indeed, something close to this occurs in the present life when the outward configuration of the face makes known the disposition hidden in the soul, from which we easily recognize what is ruled by sorrow and what has stood aloof in anger and what is let loose in desire and, on the contrary, the radiant, the gentle, what is adorned by the august distinguishing mark of prudence. So in accord with the inner life a particular disposition of the heart becomes a form, and the expression of the human being takes on the image of the passion lying within. Likewise, it seems to me, as the nature is changed toward the more divine, the human being is given form through his character, not being a certain thing and appearing as something else, but this very one is known as the one who is wise, just, meek, pure, loving, devout; or again in regard to all these qualities, either one has all the virtues or is adorned by only one; in one most are found, one has fewer than this [person] but has more than another. From these and other such qualities, the properties of those in accord with the better and those in accord with the opposite are contemplated, as if each is divided from the others into different kinds, until the last enemy is abolished. (GNO 9, 64-5)

Thus, according to this text the properties Gregory sees as individuating people in the next life are their virtues and vices. The virtues differ in character, though to the Cappadocian they differ from each other – and the people who possess them differ – primarily in quantitative terms. Some have one virtue, some have all of them, and others are somewhere in between. Notice that this state of moral diversity does not continue eternally, but only 'until the last enemy', namely evil, 'is abolished', a point to which we will return.

The eschatological ideas expressed in the *De mortuis* are also present elsewhere in Gregory's writings, notably at the end of his *In Canticum Canticorum*, one of his last works, which we will now cite. He believes that people remain free in the age to come and can make different moral choices that enable continued change in their character. In particular, he hopes that they will continue to grow in goodness and be purified of evil. The following passage shows how people arrive at different spiritual levels in this life, but it must also be understood as describing a dynamic process that continues beyond death.

> We have learned that there are many abodes with the Father [John 14:2] corresponding to the disposition toward the good in each [human being] and the withdrawal from what is worse, since a reward has been prepared for all. For one in the beginning immediately chooses what is better, while one from the depth of a life in accord with evil swims up to the truth through repentance. One has become better already through attentiveness and progress, while another has grown toward the better through the

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desire for good things. And one makes a moderate ascent to the heights, another moves past the middle, but there are some who also surpass these. Others overtake them, and beyond these others exert themselves in the race to what is above. And entirely according to the variety of differences in the free choice of each, God receives them favourably in their own rank, allotting to all the things of which they are worthy, gathering together the good rewards for the more exalted and measuring them out to those less so. (GNO 6, 459)

The Fathers and other theologians often express important aspects of their views of human diversity in their interpretations of John 14:2. This point merits further comparative study. Gregory understands the 'many abodes' to be different ranks in the heavenly life assigned on the basis of different levels of goodness. Notice how both human goodness and the divine goodness with which it is rewarded are portrayed in quantitative terms, as if they could be mapped as points on a line extending from zero at one end to the full stature of Christ at the other. The saints are then inevitably related to each other hierarchically, as possessing more or less holiness. The picture would be very different if he envisaged each of the virtues as unique and qualitatively different from the others, and the abodes with the Father as manifesting an irreducible and superabundant variety of facets of God's goodness. Yet this is not Gregory's final word on the subject. In a number of treatises he represents the eschaton as having two stages, of which this is the first.

Eschatological Unity

The second stage is the apocatastasis, which comes when all evil, which is ultimately finite, has come to an end and, what amounts to the same thing, all human beings have freely chosen to grow in goodness until they have reached the full stature of Christ. At this point the diversity caused by different levels of virtue no longer exists. People are not reduced to a least common denominator, but on the contrary they are all raised to the highest level, the complete likeness to Christ himself through participation by grace in divine life and goodness. In one text Gregory expresses this by saying that human beings' diverse amounts of contamination by evil diminish until all come down to the same level, where evil is zero and all alike are citizens of God's kingdom[13].

Gregory makes this point in the continuation of the passage cited above from the *De mortuis*. He has spoken of the different virtues by which people will be recognized in the age to come

until the last enemy is abolished, as the apostle says, and evil is expelled universally from all beings. Then one deiform beauty shines upon all of them, in which we were

[13] *In inscriptiones Psalmorum*, GNO 5, 174.

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formed in the beginning. And this is light and purity and incorruption and life and truth, and the like. For it is not unreasonable for children of day both to be light and to shine with light, and purity and incorruption will be found without change or division in those of the same [human] race, but one grace will illumine all, when having become sons of light they shine as the sun, according to the voice of the Lord that does not lie. But indeed all will be perfected into one, according to the promise of God's word, that they will have the same mind, and the same grace will be manifested to all, as each gives the same joy in turn to his neighbour, through which each also rejoices in seeing the beauty of the other and rejoices in turn that not one evil alters the form so as to be seen in its distinguishing marks. (GNO 9, 66)

Here and elsewhere, Gregory states that at the final stage of the eschaton all people will be one, and they will be united in their alikeness and equality with each other. This text expresses an important communal dimension of their fulfilment. It speaks of their joy in each other, an expression of their mutual knowledge and love. This shows that they remain persons in the sense that each retains a distinct identity, and they are not simply absorbed into the divine. Yet they are all the same in their complete likeness to Christ and their participation in his life. They each rejoice to find *Christ's* likeness in the other, not an unfathomable personal uniqueness. This mode of unity differs radically from the kind of unity in diversity established through mutual interrelatedness and interdependence that is a favourite concept among many contemporary theologians.

In other texts Gregory says that in the apocatastasis humans will share the mode of life and the activities of the angels, together with them praising God and fulfilling his purposes. In the *Oratio catechetica* he declares that even the devil will be saved and participate in the final consummation (GNO 3.4, 66-7). Thus, although he critiques the potentially cyclical character of cosmic history in Origen's system, his understanding of the final stage is very much like that of his Alexandrian predecessor. Angels, humans and demons will have in the end all returned to the good and become rational beings who are alike and are united in the praise of God. Gregory says different things in different places, as does Origen, and he does strongly affirm the resurrection body and eternal progress in God. Yet clearly Origen's speculations have made an important contribution to his eschatology.

As Gregory notes in *In illud tunc*, his treatise on 1 Cor 15:28, and in *In Canticum Canticorum* 15, in the eschaton it is Christ who unites people with each other. The whole of humankind becomes the body of Christ, and as his members people also become members of one another. Further, this ontological unity finds expression in a unity of will and activity. In the treatise *In illud tunc* he shows how this occurs, using the apostle Paul's experience as an example of what will be the future condition of all human beings.

For Paul says somewhere in his own words, 'I have been crucified with Christ, yet I live, but no longer I, for Christ lives in me' [Gal 2:20]. Therefore, if Paul no longer

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lives, who has been crucified to the world, but Christ lives in him, all that Paul does and says is rightly ascribed to Christ living in him. For indeed Paul's words are spoken by Christ when he says, 'Are you looking for proof of Christ speaking in me?' [2 Cor 13:3]. And Paul says that the good works of the Gospel are not his, but are referred to the grace of Christ dwelling in him. So if Christ living in him works and speaks these things, which follows from what has been said, Paul has rejected everything that formerly dominated him, when he was a blasphemer and persecutor and was insolent. He looked to the true good alone and made himself submissive and obedient to it. Once Paul's subjection to God has occurred, he has recourse to the one who lives in him, who also speaks and works the good things in Paul. The summation of all good things is subjection to God. The principle that applied to one [person] will also with good reason be harmoniously actualized in the whole human creation when, as the Lord says, the Gospel will come to the whole world [cf. Mt 28:19]. For when all reject the old humanity with its activities and desires and receive in themselves the Lord, of necessity the one who lives in them works the good deeds that they bring about. (GNO 3.2, 23-5)

Thus, in the final stage of the eschaton, all of humankind functions as one body comprised of distinct yet ontologically conjoined persons. One person, Christ, is the source of their ontological unity and also of the common will they all share. Like Paul having recourse to the one living in him, they each retain their freedom and cooperate in the actualization of the divine will as it unfolds and is accomplished in the activities of each of them. As Ayres and Barnes have noted, in the *Ad Ablabium* Gregory contrasts the unity of will and activity among the three divine persons with the diversity of human wills and activities even in people's collaborative works[14]. Yet they did not take account of the future transformations Gregory envisages in the mode of human existence. His position clearly suggests that in the eschaton the unity of human life and activity will mirror that of the Holy Trinity more closely than it does now. Just as the one divine will originates in the Father while the Son and Spirit freely share in this will and its actualization, eschatological humankind will share in Christ's will and its actualization. Yet perhaps some differences will remain, since although they will collaborate unanimously, all human beings may not all be performing the same actions; each may still be fulfilling a different part of God's will.

Further, for Gregory participation in the body of Christ is actually participation in the Trinity. Citing Johannine and Pauline texts, he says in *In Canticum Canticorum* 15 (GNO 6, 466-7) and *In illud tunc* (GNO 3.2, 20-3) that the eschatological unity of humankind is accomplished by the Holy Spirit, who unites all in Christ's body. Christ, in turn, brings all to the Father. This belief is not original with Gregory, but is a patristic commonplace. Yet this can be understood as increasing rather than diminishing its theological significance. This means that humankind united in the eschaton is, as it were, surrounded by

[14] See works cited in n. 1 above.

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the three divine persons and incorporated within their common life and activity. Following New Testament practice, this is the kind of language the Fathers use to speak of human participation in the life of the Trinity. It is within this dynamic and eschatological context that Gregory implicitly affirms human community as bearing the image and likeness of the Trinity, although he does not say this in the words used by modern theologians. Taken together, the corpus of his writings does not show him envisaging a divine threesome isolated from creation and a static, self-enclosed humankind and drawing an analogy or disanalogy between their modes of unity and diversity, although the logical argumentation of the *Ad Ablabium* and the *Ad Petrum* may be misread to suggest this.

However, in one respect his eschatological humans perhaps image the divine persons more than many modern theologians would like, namely in their complete likeness to each other. For Gregory, human diversity is transitory, and in the end it will disappear completely. His famous ideas about gender need to be seen in this broader context. Yet he does affirm some aspects of personhood as it is understood today. He acknowledges the distinct eternal existence of each human being as one endowed with intellect, perception, freedom, and love. Further, he recognizes the communal dimension of human identity. For him people are far from being self-enclosed or self-contained monads. A living receptacle endowed with freedom is by nature open to realities outside itself, which it can receive into itself, pour forth in love to others, or, if they are toxic, reject and push outside. In the eschaton, toward which human individuals and communities are called to grow little by little beginning in the present life, humankind does, at least by implication, bear the image of the Holy Trinity, though not in every respect. While Gregory's ideas are often highly suggestive and of relevance to contemporary discussions, it is essential to understand him in his own historical and theological context and not to make a simple equation between his anthropology and philosophical or theological positions current in our time.

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Gregory's Sophia: 'Christ, the Wisdom of God'

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Some thirty years ago Robert Wilken reminded us that, in relation to the role of wisdom itself, patristic scholarship has maintained a disproportionate interest in the influence of philosophical ideas on Christian thought; he noted that such a distinction did not apply to the ancients[1]. From this perspective, one cannot help but be struck by the division in work on Gregory of Nyssa between discussions of philosophical argumentation and the role of Wisdom, a theme receiving far less attention. The present report focuses on Sophia against the backdrop of philosophy in late antiquity, examining especially the controversy with the Arianizing Eunomius, since the issue came to a head with discussion of Prov. 8:22 where Wisdom proclaims, 'The Lord created me as the beginning of his ways, for his works'[2].

1. Gregory's Use of the Terms 'Philosophy' and 'Wisdom'

Cappadocian use of these terms presents a culmination of the position on Greek culture articulated by Justin Martyr, Clement of Alexandria, and Origen[3]. Unlike pagan philosophy (φιλοσοφία ἔξωθεν), Christian philosophy (ἡ καθ' ἡμᾶς φιλοσοφία) promises and also delivers more. The word φιλοσοφία represents culture in general (παιδεία), ethical guidelines, truth, and as ἡ ὑψηλὴ φιλοσοφία, a higher life of monastic contemplation modelled by Moses, Basil, or Macrina[4]. Used for Christian teaching, it gives insight on creation, especially on human nature restored in the image of God, in Christlikeness.

Exploring Gregory's use of the term 'wisdom', we discover three comparable areas of reference: creation, knowledge, and virtue. In numerous treatises, Gregory reflects on the creation as framed according to divine wisdom, using

[1] Robert L. Wilken, 'Wisdom and Philosophy in Early Christianity', in *Aspects of Wisdom*, ed. R.L. Wilken (Chicago: University of Notre Dame Press, 1975), 143-68, especially 143-4.

[2] The Septuagint text: κύριος ἔκτισέν με ἀρχὴν ὁδῶν αὐτοῦ εἰς ἔργα αὐτοῦ.

[3] The work of Anne-Marie Malingrey, *'Philosophia', Etude d'un groupe de mots dans la littérature grecque* (Paris: Klincksieck, 1961), provides a useful survey of the 'domestication' of the term φιλοσοφία for Christian thought.

[4] Cf. Malingrey, 210, 217, 234, 241, 247-8.

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the text, 'O Lord, how manifold are Thy works: in wisdom hast Thou made them all'[5]. Wisdom is also a human virtue reflecting the higher things of life[6]. And finally, he discusses wisdom as discernment of good and evil, as a spiritual ability assumed in the pursuit of good and avoidance of evil[7].

In terms of his own work, Gregory acknowledges the inadequacy of human wisdom to fully comprehend divine essence, saying that

> if any one should ask for some ... explanation of the Divine essence, we are not going to deny that in this kind of wisdom we are unlearned, acknowledging only ... that what is by nature infinite cannot possibly be comprehended in any conception expressed by words[8].

2. Application of the term 'wisdom' to Christ (as God) and Prov. 8:22

We narrow our investigation to examine Wisdom as it is applied to Christ. Representative treatises reveal that Gregory typically applies to Christ Old Testament metaphorical references to Wisdom as, for example, a 'tree of life'[9].

How, then, does Gregory explain Prov. 8:22, 'The Lord created me as the beginning of his ways, for his works', the text on which Arians based the creaturely character of Christ? Gregory's numerous discussions in the *Contra Eunomium* may be considered representative, developing Basil's and Athanasius' approach[10].

Gregory acknowledges acceptance of textual versions depending on the verb κτᾶσθαι, 'possessed', rather than κτίζειν, 'created', but says that either reading allows of an orthodox explanation, for the passage demands allegorical interpretation. And this he argues at length, presenting problems for a literal reading, especially the sequence of verbs 'created', 'set up', and 'begot',

[5] For such citation of Ps. 104:24 see, among others, *De Opificium Hominis* 1.2.

[6] *De Opif. Hom.* 16.11 refers to a human principle of all excellence, virtue, wisdom, and higher things, especially freedom from necessity.

[7] *De Opif. Hom.* 20.1 discusses the distinction between 'scientific' knowledge and knowledge as discernment.

[8] *Contra Eunomium* 3; 103. The text is edited by W. Jaeger in GNO I-II (1960), here II, p. 38 = PG 45, 601B. The quotation only slightly modifies the translation of the *Against Eunomius* by H.A.Wilson in *Gregory of Nyssa*, LNPF, ser. 2, vol. 5 (1892), 146.

[9] Cf. *De Opif. Hom.* 19.4. See also treatises like *Oratio Catechetica Magna* and *Ad Ablabium. Quod Non Sint Tres Dii.*

[10] The important passages are, first, *Contra Eunom.* 1.296-300 (GNO I, 114-15 = PG 45, 341C – 344C; LNPF, 63); secondly, *Refutatio Confessionis Eunomii* 110-113 (GNO II, 358-60 = PG 45, 516B – 517B; LNPF, 117-18 (there numbered as *Against Eunomius* 2.10)); and thirdly, *Contra Eunom.* 3.i.21-65 (GNO II, 10-27 = PG 45, 573A-589A (corresponding to 3.1.24-65 only); LNPF, 137-42). The third passage deals with the interpretation of Prov. 8:22 at much greater length than we find elsewhere in the work of Gregory. Cf. Athanasius *Orationes Contra Arianos*, 2.44-74; also *De Decret.* 13ff.

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for the text continues, 'He set me up (ἐθεμελίωσεν) from everlasting, in the beginning, before He made the earth, ... before the mountains were settled, before all the hills, He begets (γεννᾷ) me'. He concludes that to understand this text we must turn to Prov. 9:1, 'Wisdom has built herself a house'. Wisdom's house Gregory understands as a reference to the Lord's human body, the place prepared for him by the Virgin. The house therefore refers to the *commingling of humanity and divinity in the incarnation*[11].

How does Gregory argue this? He begins by positing an important principle, the fundamental separation between the divine, transcendent God and his creation[12]. In himself, 'in the fullness of the Divine bosom', God has nothing created; his power, wisdom, word, or truth cannot be said either to be created or imported. If, as Wisdom of God the Son were 'created', it would follow that God's wisdom is a thing imported, the result of making. But surely the Son, who is from the beginning, as God's Power, Truth, and Wisdom, is not to be classed among properties arising from without, anymore than one can conceive of God without his goodness or power! Since the Son is always in the Father, it is contradictory to speak of him, as Son (and as Wisdom) being 'created'. The crucial passage is given in book 3:

> For if the Wisdom of God is created (and Christ is the Power of God and the Wisdom of God), it would follow that God has His Wisdom as a thing imported, receiving afterwards, as the result of making, something which He had not at first. But surely He Who is in the bosom of the Father does not permit us to conceive the bosom of the Father as ever void of Himself ... He Who is conceived as being in the eternity of the Father's Godhead is always in Him, being Power, and Life, and Truth, and Wisdom, and the like[13].

Here we come to the heart of Gregory's argument. The term 'created' does not apply to what belongs inalienably to God. And Gregory argues that divine attributes like Power and Truth, Word and Wisdom, belong to God as uncreated divine Godhead; they belong to him from eternity. They are not part of

[11] Athanasius similarly connects Prov. 8:22 with Prov. 9:1 in *Contra Arianos* 2.44 (PG 26, 241B), where he also speaks of Prov. 8:22 as referring to the human body created, to the incarnation, to Christ's humanity. On Marcellus' earlier interpretation of the text in this way, οὐ τὴν ἀρχὴν τῆς θεότητος ... ἀλλὰ τὴν δευτέραν κατὰ σάρκα οἰκονομίαν, cf. E.P. Meijering, *Orthodoxy and Platonism in Athanasius, Synthesis or Antithesis?* (Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1968), 99.

[12] The comparable argument for Athanasius contrasts the being of God with his activity; only his eternal, unchangeable being takes priority to temporal actions associated with the economy: *Contra Arianos* 2.51 (PG 26, 256A). On this cf. Meijering, 101-2.

[13] The translation slightly modifies that of LNPF, 140. For the text see *Contra Eunom.* 3.i.49, in GNO II, 20-1 = PG 45, 581C-D: εἰ γὰρ κτιστὴ τοῦ θεοῦ ἡ σοφιά, Χριστὸς δὲ θεοῦ δύναμις καὶ θεοῦ σοφία, ἐπείσακτον ἔσχε πάντως ὁ θεὸς τὴν σοφίαν, ὕστερον ἐκ κατασκευῆς προσλαβὼν ὃ μὴ παρὰ τὴν πρώτην εἶχεν. ἀλλὰ μὴν ὁ ἐν τοῖς κόλποις ὢν τοῦ πατρὸς οὐδέποτε κενὸν ἑαυτοῦ δίδωσι νοεῖν τὸν πατρῷον κόλπον .... ὁ ἐν τῇ ἀϊδιότητι τῆς πατρικῆς θεότητος εἶναι νοούμενος ἀεὶ ἐν αὐτῷ ἐστι, δύναμις ὢν καὶ ζωὴ καὶ ἀλήθεια καὶ φῶς καὶ σοφία καὶ τὰ τοιαῦτα.

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created reality, and belong fully also to Christ as co-Creator. So Gregory concludes that if Proverbs speaks of Wisdom as 'created', it speaks not of the Wisdom with which God created everything. Nor can it mean creation from nothing. It is used in the sense of re-creation, a restoration of something already existing, as when the psalmist asks, 'Create in me a clean heart, O Lord'[14]. So he concludes that the words 'created me' refer to Christ's humanity, his incarnation.

To continue, Gregory asks how the wisdom which *establishes* the earth is also '*created* for the beginning of His works'. Here Gregory recognizes the work of salvation, the restoration of sinners. Just as Christ came, as a new and living way, taking on our humanity, so also the apostle Paul asks us to 'put on the Lord Jesus Christ', as a garment of salvation, the new man[15].

To sum up his position, then, we note that Christ was in the beginning both Word and God, as John's Gospel tells us (John 1:1-3), and was created when he became man. As true Wisdom he represents the power of creation, yet for us he became flesh, the new man, and the model for renewed humanity. Once we have put him on, as our salvation, he remoulds us in his own image.

3. Divine Attributes: Father and Son as Unbegotten and Begotten

Eunomius also applied the epithet 'Wisdom' to Christ, but insisted on the 'unbegotten' character of God as crucial to divine unity and simplicity; for him Christ was preeminently 'begotten'[16]. Though divine, above the rest of creation, his stature was below that of the Father. Proverbs 8:22 was used to accent this. Especially in the latter chapters of *Contra Eunomium* Bk. 1, Gregory supports Basil's refutation of Eunomius, arguing that 'unbegottenness' indicates not divine essence, but rather 'origin' or 'disposition'[17]. Gregory affirms that names for God, like Power, Wisdom and Light are to be applied equally to God, that is, to all three persons of the Godhead, and are not subject to degree[18]. And where Eunomius emphasized the distinction 'unbegotten' and

[14] For the quotation from Ps. 50:12, see also Athanasius, *Contra Arianos* 2.46 (PG 26, 244C-245A), who argues here that the verb κτίζειν may represent renewal of something already existing. Aside from the Psalm, Athanasius quotes Eph. 2:15 and 4:22-24 here. On this cf. Meijering, 99-100.

[15] Gregory refers to Eph. 4:22-24, and Col. 3:10.

[16] Gregory mentions Eunomius' use of the phrase 'living wisdom' for Christ, *Refutatio Confessionis Eunomii* 115 (GNO II, 360-1 = PG 45, 517D; LNPF, 118).

[17] Cf. Gregory's *Contra Eunom.* 3.i.66-102 (GNO II, 27-38 = PG 45, 589A-601A; LNPF, 6). For Basil's *Contra Eunomium* 1, cf. Basile de Césarée, *Contre Eunome*, ed. Bernard Sesboüé, vol. 1, SC 299 (Paris: Editions du Cerf, 1982), esp. I.15-16 (pp. 224-9). On this distinction see also Augustine, *De Trinitate*, 5.

[18] Gregory's use of the term 'wisdom' as a divine attribute calls for further discussion of divine attributes as such, but this would take us beyond the parameters of the present essay. At

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'begotten', Gregory prefers the personal names 'Father' and 'Son' as important correlatives. Even so, Gregory knows that with our human conceptions we cannot properly comprehend God, for it is impossible for the human mind to understand God's essence[19].

Thus, as an important response to the Eunomian challenge Gregory uses both kataphatic and apophatic approaches to explain God. Neither is adequate by itself, but Gregory has emphasized the apophatic since even with the terms 'Father' and 'Son' we must abstract much that characterizes normal relationships between a parent and child, particularly corporeality and passion.

4. Conclusions

We have briefly reviewed Gregory's use of the term 'wisdom' to examine implications for Christ as Sophia, the Wisdom of God, wishing to examine a link with the ascetic lifestyle as Christian philosophy. This paper has made only a small beginning on the topic, but a few conclusions may be drawn.

First, we recognize that even for Gregory 'wisdom' functions on three levels, those of (1) the transcendent divine, (2) incarnate divinity, and (3) the new humanity in Christ. As attribute of the divine Godhead, Wisdom is applicable equally to Father, Son, and Holy Spirit. Wisdom incarnate in the Son indicates our Lord Jesus Christ as the new man, in whose image the Christian is recreated. By putting on Christ, as the garment of salvation, wisdom is also begotten in the Christian.

In representative texts examined where Gregory refers to Christ as Sophia, I have found no overt link between his discussion of Christ the Wisdom of God and a Christian ascetic philosophy. Yet the link is implied in Gregory's discussion of the way of salvation, and restoration of the image of God. Among virtues characterizing the new man 'imaged' on Christ, Gregory emphasizes control of the passions in regaining that image. Just as Gregory

this point we simply note other passages in the *Contra Eunomium* helpful for understanding Gregory's approach to wisdom as used for God. In *Contra Eunom.* 1.233-237 (GNO I, 95-6 = PG 45, 321B-324A; LNPF, 57) Gregory affirms wisdom as a divine quality alongside goodness, power, and strength. God possesses Wisdom not as some incidental quality, but inalienably, rooted in his nature. Otherwise one could also conceive of degree in wisdom, implying a heterogeneous nature. Cf. *Refutatio Confessionis Eunomii* 124 (GNO II, 365 = PG 45, 524A; LNPF, 119), where there is reference to the adjective 'wise' representing God's transcendent power. Similarly, he cautions us in *Contra Eunom.* 3.iv.15 (GNO II, 139 = PG 45, 716B-C; LNPF, 184) that when Wisdom is attributed to Christ in this way, it is applied to the divine, not his human nature. In *Contra Eunom.* 3.vi.51-54 (GNO II, 203-5 = PG 45, 788C-789B; LNPF, 207) Gregory speaks of σοφία as a quality so closely related to the essence of both Father and Son that one cannot think of the Father without his wisdom. The normal logic of predication does not apply to such attributes, he affirms, since that would indicate composition.

[19] Cf. *Contra Eunom.* 3.i.103 (LNPF, 146), cited above at note 8.

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closely identifies human sin with the passions, the new life in Christ means control of the passions. Through his death and victory in the resurrection, Christ is our model also in this.

So I conclude that in connection with the issue of Christ as Sophia, whether as eternally begotten Son of God or as incarnate Son, Gregory's argumentation is much less 'philosophical' than 'biblical'. The reasons for discussion of Christ as Wisdom, or Light and Truth, rest on biblical exegesis, far more than on philosophical reasoning. While scholars today continue to focus on Gregory's philosophical theology, pursuing the discussion set in motion by Harnack a century ago,[20] I have been impressed by the depth of biblical understanding which Gregory brings to his task.

Secondly, in this research I anticipated Gregory moving away from use of the term 'Logos' to greater use of 'Sophia' for Christ, given the problematic subordinationist connotations for the term 'Logos'. We have reflected on Gregory's extensive use of 'Sophia' for Christ, but not because he uses the title 'Logos' less. Quite the contrary. Even a rudimentary search of the text with the help of a concordance shows that Gregory uses the terms 'logos' and 'sophia' in a ratio of about eight to one. When speaking of Christ, Gregory favours the terms *Son* of God and *Word* of God above others, using them almost equally.

My conclusions, thus, have turned out somewhat differently from what I anticipated. Of course, negative answers are also answers. If Gregory develops a Christian philosophy, it does not seem to have been part of Gregory's explicit agenda in the discussions with Eunomius. Appreciation for Origen is clearly a crucial factor in the continuing prominence of the term 'Logos', as it is for Gregory's use of the term 'Sophia'. However, with the pivotal role assigned to the theme of creation and to the 'image of God' for a Christian anthropology, Gregory is certainly charting important new directions for these discussions.

[20] R. Wilken alludes to such discussion in his essay, cited above (note 1).

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Basil of Caesarea and the Hellenization of the Gospel

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Basil of Caesarea takes his place among the many other fathers who assimilated Greek culture and learning – in a word, *paideia* – to Christianity. Basil artfully combines the Greek and Christian traditions, thereby making his own answer to Tertullian's astute question and explaining just what it is that Athens has to do with Jerusalem. How, though, should Basil's synthesis of Greek and Christian be judged and assessed?

Both ancients and moderns have in fact offered diverse accounts and judgements of the ancient Christian appropriation of Greek thought. These assessments follow a few patterns that can be variously named the 'corruption' theory, the 'displacement' theory, and the 'hybrid' theory. First, there are those who think that Christianity's involvement with things Greek entails corruption, either the Christian corruption of Hellenism, or vice versa. In ancient times, Celsus, Porphyry, and Julian, for example, rejected Christianity for defiling ancient culture. Along these lines, one cannot help but think of Gibbon's work on the Roman Empire and the role he assigned to Christianity in its demise. The empire had become weakened by the silly doctrinal squabbles of intolerant Christians. 'The flames of the Arian controversy,' Gibbon writes, 'consumed the vitals of the empire... [and] the Romans languished under the ignominious tyranny of eunuchs and bishops', who not only ruined the empire but also perverted Christianity itself[1].

More common, though, is the belief that Hellenism taints the Gospel. Edwin Hatch, who started modern scholarly debate over the Hellenization of Christianity in his 1888 Hibbert Lectures, and Adolf von Harnack represent this position[2]. As nineteenth-century liberal Protestants, they thought Christianity had more to do with conduct than belief, and they blamed the Greeks for the age-old emphasis on dogma.

Frances Young, in her *Biblical Exegesis and the Formation of Christian Culture*, presents a new way of looking at the relationship between Greek and

[1] Edward Gibbon, *The Decline and Fall of the Roman Empire*, ch. 21 and first sentence of ch. 22: in Great Books of the Western World, 2nd edn, 37 (Chicago: Encyclopaedia Britannica, 1990), 1:327 and 330.

[2] See Edwin Hatch, *The Influence of Greek Ideas and Usages upon the Christian Church*, The Hibbert Lectures, 1888, 6th edn (London: Williams and Norgate, 1897); repr. as *The Influence of Greek Ideas on Christianity* (New York: Harper and Row, 1966).

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Christian thought[3]. There was not a corruption, the one of the other, but rather a 'take over'. The bible displaced pagan texts as that which formed culture. The pagans, through the development of a particular style of education, had for a long time commented upon literature. The Fathers did likewise, but with another text, the bible. They drew moral and metaphysical truths from different stories and thereby established a Christian culture that replaced the pagan one.

For most of the Fathers themselves, however, and for some moderns, Christianity's encounter with Hellenism was not a corruption or a displacement, but an assimilation of the one to the other based upon an appeal to transcendent universal truth. The result of the assimilation is a hybrid of sorts, brought about not by the necessary laws of history or by those governing institutions, but by particular teachers. The emphasis here is on the particular problems faced by a certain Father at a certain time and how he brings coherence and unity to the disparate authorities or sources of truth that command his allegiance. The teaching of such a Father could be called syncretistic only if it were also incoherent and heterogeneous, only if it suffered falsity to accompany whatever truth it possesses.

What makes one model for viewing the interaction of Greek and Christian better than another? What makes one model more accurate than another? These questions lead directly to a consideration of presuppositions. The practitioners of the corruption model, for example, often presuppose that Greek thought contains little or no truth, and *a fortiori* that the efforts of the Greeks to arrive at truth, goodness, and beauty fall outside of the guidance of divine providence. That is to say that the mind, even the Greek one, unaided by divine revelation cannot but fail in its striving for truth. The assimilation model, on the other hand, operates with a different assumption, namely that the Greeks – or anyone else for that matter – can have arrived at truth, and if they do so, and if the Gospel is true, then the two are not only compatible, but able to be truly integrated.

The hybrid model has a further advantage over the corruption and displacement models. Both of the latter make a universal claim; they propose a way to understand every Father's appropriation of Greek thought. A universal claim, though, is a two-edged sword, and this case is no exception. While it allows for the comprehension of the entire patristic age – if the claim is in fact true – it does not accommodate the important differences among the Fathers in their way of dealing with Greek thought. The hybrid model has the opposite virtues and vices. It gains insight into the thought of one Father, but makes no claim on others, and even less, on the whole patristic age.

[3] See F.M. Young, *Biblical Exegesis and the Formation of Christian Culture* (New York: Cambridge University Press, 1997).

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Basil's work is best seen to represent neither a corruption of biblical truth nor a displacement of *paideia*, but an assimilation of scriptural teaching with what he judges to be true in Greek thought. This synthesis, moreover, can be viewed under at least two aspects – form and content. In respect to content, one could, for example, investigate Basil's ascetic programme and witness there a measure of borrowing from the Greek philosophical and ethical traditions, which had much to say about the way to ascend to God. Or one could consider Basil's Trinitarian thought and his doctrine of God, which very much evidence his assimilation of Greek thought; this has been much studied.

Aside from content, one could view Basil's synthesis also from the point of view of the literary forms that he borrows from the Greeks. This, in fact, is how Werner Jaeger treats Basil: he rejects the moral and religious content of Greek poetry, but praises its form[4]. Basil, of course, was not the first Christian to use Greek literary forms in the defence and promulgation of Christianity. Origen, both long before Basil and more than Basil, employed the full range of Greek scholarly genres.

I wish now to give a concrete example of Basil's appropriation of Greek literary form and to point out its significance. In the course of his education, Basil learned how to structure a work and craft an argument. This is crucial, I propose, for understanding Basil's use of the scriptures. That is to say, Basil employed a certain literary form in works like *Contra Eunomium* and *On the Holy Spirit*, and knowing this helps in the estimation of his interpretation of the scriptures. If one can discern how Basil organized his works, then one can determine which of his arguments is the most important or the strongest. Once the central arguments are discovered, the role that the scriptures play in these arguments can be analysed.

How, then, was Basil taught to structure an argument and prove a *thesis*? Though ancient education was not standardized in the way that modern education is, handbooks of rhetoric were composed throughout the centuries of Second Sophistic that gained a wide circulation. These handbooks contained *progymnasmata*, that is 'preliminary exercises', that enabled students to begin mastering the rhetorical forms that would aid them in writing and speaking[5]. Though there are differences among these handbooks, they all serve to teach through exercises a common rhetorical technique and method of arguing. Two

[4] See Werner Jaeger, *Early Christianity and Greek Paideia* (Cambridge, Mass.: Belknap Press, 1961), 81; 83–84.

[5] See George A. Kennedy, 'Introduction', in *Progymnasmata. Greek Textbooks of Prose Composition Introductory to the Study of Rhetoric: Writings by or Attributed to Theon, Hermogenes, Aphthonius, Nicolaus; Together with an Anonymous Prolegomenon to Aphthonius, Selections from the Commentary Attributed to John of Sardis, and Fragments of the Progymnasmata of Sopatros*, 2nd edn (Fort Collins, Col.: Chez l'auteur, 2000), vi. A version of this important collection was published by Kennedy as *Progymnasmata: Greek Textbooks of Prose Composition and Rhetoric* (Atlanta: Society of Biblical Literature and Leiden: Brill, 2003).

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rhetorical forms are of interest here: contradiction (*antirrhêsis*) or refutation (*anaskeuê*) and *thesis*. There was established in ancient education a method by which one undermined another's discourse. Ps.-Hermogenes advises the following way:

> You will refute by argument from what is unclear, implausible, impossible; from the inconsistent, also called the contrary; from what is inappropriate, and from what is not advantageous[6].

Theon advises much the same, but adds that the speaker ought to be turned against himself, that is, be demonstrated to hold the opposite of what he is arguing for in his discourse[7]. Basil uses these methods, for example, in his *Contra Eunomium*.

But Basil does more than simply refute Eunomius and attack his *Apology*; he is not satisfied to prove Eunomius wrong in his understanding of the Father and the Son. Rather, he supplies the correct understanding. In so doing, Basil is employing the rhetorical form of *thesis*. *Thesis*, by definition, views a topic generally and not specifically. It does not, to use Ps.-Hermogenes' example, investigate whether Pericles should marry, but whether anyone at all should marry[8]. *Thesis*, however, need not be deliberative or practical. The philosophers considered theoretical *theses*, 'for example, whether the sky is spherical, whether there are many worlds, whether the sun is made of fire,' and, Basil might add, whether the Son is similar to the Father[9]. *Thesis*, moreover, considers not a question on which people agree, but one that is debated[10]. Finally, *thesis* can involve arguments against one position as well as for another. To borrow Ps.-Hermogenes' example again, 'if we discuss whether one should engage in athletics rather than farm the land [the *thesis*] is double, for it is necessary to dissuade from one pursuit and exhort to the other'[11].

Basil, then, combines these rhetorical forms in *Contra Eunomium*, but even their combination has roots in ancient *paideia*. Indeed, the different rhetorical forms practised in the *progymnasmata* were not intended to remain distinct in discourses[12].

Basil's *Contra Eunomium* employs a simple but significant pattern in his use of contradiction, refutation, and *thesis*. First, Basil gives a direct quotation from Eunomius' *Apology*; then he argues against it using one or more of the above-mentioned methods; and finally he offers an alternative to Eunomius'

[6] Ps.-Hermogenes, *Progymn.* 5. Trans. Kennedy, *Progymnasmata*, 59.

[7] Theon, *Progymn.* 17. Trans. Kennedy, *Progymnasmata*, 53.

[8] See Ps.-Hermogenes, *Progymn.* 11. Trans. Kennedy, *Progymnasmata*, 65.

[9] Ibid. Trans.

[10] See ibid. Trans.

[11] Ibid. Trans. Kennedy, *Progymnasmata*, 65-6.

[12] Ps.-Hermogenes gives us a good example of this combination of refutation and thesis in his *On Invention*. See Kennedy, *A New History of Classical Rhetoric* (Princeton, N.J.: Princeton University Press, 1994), 211-15.

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explanation. Knowledge of this simple structure, repeated and varied by Basil throughout *Contra Eunomium*, allows one to understand and evaluate the role of scripture in his thought. In fact Basil will quote or allude to the scriptures at all stages of his argument, whether in his invective against Eunomius' character, in his refutation of Eunomius' arguments, or in the explanation of his own teaching. It is this last use that is most relevant for understanding the significance of scripture in Basil's *theses*.

Contra Eunomium, moreover, contains numerous *theses*, some more important than others, and Basil arranges his *theses* differently in different parts of the work. Sometimes he gives a central *thesis* first and then supporting ones; at other times he arranges supporting *theses* to climax in the central *thesis*. This flexibility of arrangement was consistent with Basil's education. Writing of theoretical *theses*, Theon comments that the student shall 'not keep to the same order here as in practical theses but shall compose in whatever way seems best to fit the proposed problem'[13]. Basil does exactly this; he arranges the *theses* to suit his overall argument against Eunomius, and insight into this arrangement of *theses* helps in understanding which scriptures are the most important for him.

The ways in which Basil's adoption of a particular literary form illumine his use of scripture must be left for future investigation. This much, however, can be said. First, Basil in fact adopted for his own Christian ends literary forms that had been worked out, defined, and taught in Greek schools for Greek purposes. Secondly, knowledge of these forms is indispensable for fully understanding Basil's arguments and for evaluating his use of scripture therein. Thirdly, Basil's adoption of Greek literary genres for Christian subject matter is just one among many ways in which he integrated his Greek patrimony with his Christian faith. In Basil's own words, we should act like bees in our approach to pagan literature. 'For these,' he says,

> neither approach all flowers equally, nor in truth do they attempt to carry off entire those upon which they alight, but taking only so much of them as is suitable for their work, they suffer the rest to go untouched. We ourselves too, if we are wise, having appropriated from this literature what is suitable to us and akin to the truth, will pass over the remainder. And just as in plucking the blooms from a rose-bed we avoid the thorns, so also in garnering from such writings whatever is useful, let us guard ourselves against what is harmful[14].

[13] Theon, *Progymn.* 11. Trans. Kennedy, *Progymnasmata*, 43.

[14] Basil, *To Young Men, On How they Might Derive Profit from Pagan Literature*, 4.8-9, in Saint Basil, *The Letters*, vol. 4, trans. Roy J. Deferrari, LCL (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1934), 391-3.

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A City by Any Other Name ...? Gregory of Nazianzus' Constantinople[1]

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As Plato explains in *The Republic*, a person defines and is defined by their interactions with and within their locus, in relationships, as citizens. It is personal, as well as communal. Two Worlds. 'City is soul writ large', in Allan Bloom's translation.

The idea of *city* as not only a locus, but a metaphor, is continued in the Christian poetic tradition across the ages. This tradition was especially dominant in the Eastern part of the Christian world during the fourth Century, and Gregory of Nazianzus (*c.*329-390) is perhaps its finest proponent. As a theologian, he was steeped in bible as an oral, as well as written, tradition, so that his metaphors and language are spontaneous biblical paraphrases. Where one encounters Christianity in all its forms, one encounters *city*[2]. Cities are portrayed in sacred and secular texts as wombs, birthing places, whores, Queens. And Gregory, as poet, sings of them.

Forever at odds with *city* as anything not seclusion, Gregory was repeatedly torn between his familial and ecclesiastical duties and his desires for the solitude of the villa, between the individual and the Church, the human and the Divine. Gregory of Nazianzus[3] was the first Christian autobiographical poet and one of the greatest academy-trained Greek poets of all time. In the Eastern Church his works are second only to the Bible in their popularity, all written during his retirement at his villa near Karbala (*c.*381-390)[4].

In his poem *Concerning Himself and the Bishops*, written as a didactic text to his colleagues in the episcopate, he advises, 'From cities, from the plaudits of the mob, from the whirl in which all public life is tossed, [the bishop] is a fugitive'[5].

[1] Dates throughout from *The Oxford Dictionary of the Christian Church*, 2nd edn F.L. Cross and E.A. Livingstone (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1974); *The HarperCollins Encyclopedia of Catholicism*, ed. Richard P. McBrien (New York: HarperCollins, 1995); Robert C. Walton, *Chronical and Background Charts of Church History* (Grand Rapids, Mich.: Zondervan, 1986).

[2] 'City' is used 1,000 times in the bible (as are 'Jesus' and 'Jerusalem').

[3] Also known as 'the Theologian' and 'the Christian Demosthenes'.

[4] The hillside villa was near Arianzus, near Nazianzus.

[5] Gregory of Nazianzus, *Three Poems*, tr. Denis Molaise Meehan, OSB, FC 75 (Washington: Catholic University of America Press, 1987), p. 67, lines 599-600.

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He views *city* in terms of Empire, as in Meeks' modern analysis[6], though he is also a staunch advocate of celibacy and living the Christian life within one's household, whatever its locus, as in Brown's descriptions[7]. For Gregory, people and their actions define *city*, as in Stark's modern analysis[8]. Often, those actions and people are in conflict.

Nazianzen's struggles with *city* began at home, his birthplace, at his family's estates at Arianzus, in Cappadocia[9]. Gregory canonized his entire family in his verses, turning them and himself into biblical heroes in Classical Greek forms within his extended biblical exegetical narratives. He revered and feared his severe father, Gregory the Elder (*c.*280-374), his ordaining bishop (*c.*362), in death as in life[10]. Nonna (d. 374), his saintly mother, had visions and had promised Gregory to the Church. Caesarius, Gregory's younger brother, a physician, inspired the elder brother to join him at the academy and become a remedy for the woes of his Church[11], but broke Gregory's heart by dying young in 368. Gorgonia (d. 369), his pagan older sister, was also beloved of Gregory[12].

When Gregory left home for his rigorous education in Athens, Alexandria, and the Caesareas of Cappadocia and Palestine, he grew to become a master rhetorician in Stoic and Neoplatonic styles and began to give form, through words, to the concepts of his Trinitarian theology. The academy equipped him to champion orthodoxy – not just belief but *right* belief – and fostered his Two Worlds mentality. This dialectical tendency continued between him and his

[6] Wayne A. Meeks, *The First Urban Christians* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1983).

[7] Peter Brown, *The Body and Society: Men, Women, and Sexual Renunciation in Early Christianity* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1988); *Society and the Holy in Late Antiquity* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1982).

[8] Rodney Stark, *The Rise of Christianity: How the Obscure, Marginal Jesus Movement Became the Dominant Religious Force in the Western World in a Few Centuries* (San Francisco: HarperSanFrancisco, 1997).

[9] Cappadocia lies at the heart of Asia Minor, where there is a crossing of ways leading to Byzantium, Africa, and Syria, at a triangle of cities – Nyssa, Nazianzus, and Caesarea – each 60 miles from the others, the homes of the wealthy landowners who became the Cappadocian Fathers: A.H.M. Jones, *The Cities of the Eastern Roman Provinces* (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1937); *Hammond Historical Atlas of the World* ([Maplewood, N.J.]: Hammond Incorporated, 1984); *Atlas of the Christian Church*, ed. Henry Chadwick and G.R. Evans, An Equinox Book (New York: Facts on File Publications, 1987).

[10] The son was betrayed and abandoned by his father through a forced ordination.

[11] Note the contrasting uses of φάρμακος by Ignatius of Antioch in his letters to the Ephesians (20.2) and Trallians (6.2).

[12] Biographical information from *ODCC*; Gregory of Nazianzus, *Autobiographical Poems*, tr. and ed. Carolinne White, Cambridge Medieval Classics 6 (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1996); Gregory of Nazianzus, *Poemata Arcana*, ed. C. Moreschini, tr. D.A. Sykes, Oxford Theological Monographs (Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1997); John A. McGuckin, *St. Gregory of Nazianzus, An Intellectual Biography* (Crestwood, N.Y.: St. Vladimir's Seminary Press, 2001).

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friends, including the Cappadocians[13], even his friend Basil 'The Great' of Caesarea (*c.*329-379)[14]. Gregory saw the decisions of the Council of Nicaea as the *only* way and fought for them with his whole body, unto physical and military altercations. It was the narrow way, through the eye of the needle, and he did not fancy himself the camel nor wish anyone under his care to be anything but right with God, in thought, orientation, and in the understanding and use of words (Matt 19:24, Mark 10:25, Luke 18:25).

Nazianzen dedicated himself to the perfection of the word for the good of God and the Church. Since the *Λόγος*, the second person of the Trinity, is the pre-eternal Word, in Gregory's Johannine cosmos, he shows that he is a holy man by writing, through *logos*, itself. This is essential to Gregory's sense and experience of his own Call, his salvation and ability to save others. It is the word as weapon and fortress, his sacred naming of himself, as Jacob became Israel after his angelic struggles (Gen. 32:25-29). And though Gregory is a great complainer in a romantic and rhetorical sense, he never complains that writing is at all difficult for him. Always, it is the remedy, always related to a *city* locus and her people.

Gregory praises and elevates many locales, such as Bethlehem and his own homelands, as small in size but great in stature, often with *city* as Queen, Virgin, mother. A funerary epigram as benediction, written in the voice of his bishop father to the elder's congregation, as warrant of Greogory's authority as son and heir, states in Trinitarian overtones,

Small is the pearl, but the queen of jewels;
small is Bethlehem, but yet the mother of Christ[15].

Similarly he writes on the death of his father's brother Amphilochus, who was known for his 'fiery oratory' in the courts of law and was, as such, a lover of Platonic order and sacred Law. This citizen was one who exalted earthly life and community through words and likewise elevated others, so Gregory exalts him via the sacrament of words, in his city's own anthropomorphized voice:

I, Diocaesarea, am a small city, but gave a great man ...
... boast of his native city, which his birth ennobled[16].

Yet of all cities, Gregory's bride of his soul is the first Christian city, Constantinople, and all other cities are, next to her, smaller stars in the constellation. Through his adventures there over a period equal to Jesus' ministry and just before Gregory's retirement, he describes his struggles and those of the

[13] Basil the Great, his younger brother Gregory of Nyssa, their sister Macrina, and Gregory of Nazianzus himself.

[14] At Basil's family estates in Annesi, they compiled the *Philokalia* of Origen.

[15] W.R. Paton (ed. and tr.), *The Greek Anthology*, vol. 2, LCL (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard University Press, 1917), epigram VIII.21 (pp. 410-11).

[16] Paton, epigram VIII.135 (pp. 458-9).

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post-Nicene church. For Gregory, it is *city*, this *city*, which looms largest, to which he was summoned as a bishop (379), and in which he was briefly consecrated and served as its Patriarch, to rule in tandem with the Emperor[17]. It is she who is his arena versus the Christological controversies of the Arians, the Alexandrians, the Sabellians, and his own bodily and spiritual health. She is his living icon of the Two Worlds (Matt 12:30, Luke 11:23), City of Man and City of God, through the Emperor and the Church.

Combining Byzantine traditions and the concept of Trinitarian unity of rule with the Greek sense of *polis*, Gregory's poetic vision treats the *city* and Church as one, empire and ecclesia joined. Constantinople is Gregory's embodiment of Platonic perfect order, as opposed to *Babel's* disorder. Gregory hopes in *On the Spirit* 'that we may glorify the clear-shining unity of rule, rather than finding pleasure in some Babel governance by a host of gods'[18]. When one calls, so does the other, and both are calls from God.

Constantine's city was the archetype for the Imperial self in all its Human/Divine congruence. Even Rome as a patriarchate pales in its dotage when compared to this new Queen, as well as to its former glory as Empire's seat and site of Paul's last mission and martyrdom. Rome had become spiritually poor when Gregory speaks of her even next to her successor, Nicaea[19], as the Queen's champion *city*. Constantinople had eclipsed even Jerusalem in influence and splendour, especially since the Romans reinterred Jerusalem's relics at Constantine's centre of the known world[20].

Constantinople became thus for Gregory and other orthodox Christians the New Rome, part of the Two Worlds, as there was the Father and the Son, with orthodox Antioch completing the Trinity as Holy Spirit. She became the crown of the Christian Empire, and the public spectacle that Constantinople was famous for was the manifestation of God's majesty on Earth, the material reaching up to Heaven and Divine reaching down to Creation. All this was a continuation of the Hebrew Temple and High Priesthood, in combination with the Roman ideas of might and temple cultus as legacy – God's *city*, sacred space. This view was blessed by the third canon of the Second Ecumenical Council, Constantinople I (381), and spoken of by Gregory in *Concerning His Own Life*:

You men, the shining eye of earth,
who inhabit the second world, as I see it,
clothed in the beauty of earth and sea,
the newly built Rome, the seat of new nobility,
the city of Constantine and a monument to his power ...[21].

[17] Theodosius I ('the Great'), who ruled from 379 to 395.

[18] Moreschini and Sykes, pp. 14-15.

[19] Thirty miles southeast of Constantinople, the site of the first Ecumenical Council in 325.

[20] Located at the apex of a triangle, with Antioch to the east and Rome to the west; see Chadwick and Evans, p. 33.

[21] Lines 12-20: White, pp. 10-11; Meehan, p. 77.

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Yet as a manifestation of God's continuous promise in two parts, the Old and New Testaments, the Nazianzen world is also configured in equal twos, supporting the Trinity, especially versus Arius and the Alexandrians, mirroring the coequality of Father and Son (plus Spirit):

Nature has given us not two suns,
but two Romes, beacons of the whole world,
one ancient power and one new ...
... but in their beauty they are equally balanced ...[22].

Nevertheless, for all of Gregory's devotion toward Constantinople as icon of God, it was the locus of some of the worst evils he had suffered during his lifetime, a paradox of earthly Heaven and Hell. Gregory had been summoned to take over the Church of the Apostles, as bishop, from the Arians who had held the city for a generation. He felt that, with his appointment, the orthodox Church within God's *city* had cleansed herself of its Arian leprosy, restored control. He spoke of the *city* as a wayward believer who had finally 'abandoned its insolent behaviour' And the cure had spread via correct beliefs, through him and the city's people, souls newly reconciled to God, through repentance. Constantinople became the source of all goodness, the font of God, and anything from outside was suspect[23].

When Gregory arrived at Constantinople, the Arian conflict reached its head. Theodosius had called the council (381) to settle the violent conflicts over which form of Christianity would be the one, true form. The conflicts intensified between clerical factions and peoples when Bishop Meletius of Antioch died during the council without a clear successor. This lack of unity amongst his colleagues and his flock contradicted Gregory's image of one Christendom embodied by and issuing forth from his Queen, in the unity of the Trinity[24]. Gregory remained focused on unified community.

Gregory's ten years at the academy, including Athens[25], had honed in him that sense of citizenship and community. He speaks of Athens, especially concerning himself and Basil, as a place of friendship, synthesis of life. He contrasts this with the lives of the other students:

[22] Lines 562-4, 1510: White, pp. 52-3, 120-1; Meehan, pp. 93, 119. The disruption to Constantinople and Gregory's own life emanating from Alexandria through Arius caused him to complain of 'that vain city, filled with every wickedness, irrational in its recklessness'.

[23] See White, pp. 112-13, lines 1402-3; Meehan p. 116, where the word Gregory uses for 'church' is ναός, with its connotations of Temple and Holy of Holies. See also White, pp. 62-3,lines 686-7; Meehan, p. 96 (*polis* contrasted with *oikos* ('house'), used of Gregory's small congregation) and White, pp. 116-119, lines 1460-9; Meehan, p. 117 (Gregory as martyr).

[24] Note the 22 books Augustine would write on *city* and God's 'New Jerusalem coming down from heaven' (Rev. 3:12), as opposed to the 'heavenly Jerusalem' of Heb. 12:22.

[25] Where he and Basil studied with the Armenian Christian Professor of Rhetoric/Sophist Prohaeresius.

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... how we lived
in fear of God, aware that first things are first:
how among the youth's elite, driven by recklessness ...
we led a life of such calm –
... we ourselves drew our friends on to higher things ...[26].

Despite conflicts in Cappadocia and love for Constantinople, Gregory always wanted to return home[27]. It is countryside as remedy for what the *city* could inflict upon him. Home is the place of blessedness, site of sacred *yizkor*, healed person. Home was personal versus communal – Constantinople as site of saved Humanity's continuity, healed community.

Yet Gregory would not allow himself to stay away whilst this world challenged the beauty of God's world. So he dove into the fray. Until the final eight yars of his life, Gregory worked with the people and with clergy as a citizen of Church and *city*. Thus he tells the Church's and his most difficult stories through his personal struggles within *city*, at the call of her people: 'It was their prayers and protestations that swayed me [to come to Constantinople]; to have resisted them would be unduly proud'[28]. His masterpieces help us to teach ourselves to be Christian citizens within our own cities, bridging the Two Worlds, living life to the fullest (John 10:10), making our cities transcendent, open to Divine *city* within them. In living in and working with our cities, as citizens we, like Gregory, can rise up, forever.

[26] White, pp. 24-7, lines 212-20; Meehan, p. 83.

[27] See Gregory's first bishopric, Sasima (contrasted with Athens), at a three-way crossroads, where one could possess 'in abundance only those evils with which cities are filled' (White, pp. 42-5, lines 439-46, 471; Meehan, pp. 89-90.

[28] *Concerning Himself and the Bishops*, lines 92-3; Meehan, p. 51.

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Sex/Gender in Gregory of Nyssa's Eschatology: Irrelevant or Non-Existent?

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For most of the past century, a common view has prevailed in modern scholarship[1] concerning the eschatological anthropology of Gregory of Nyssa, based particularly on his *De hominis opificio* and *De anima et resurrectione*, namely, that Gregory's eschatological anthropology includes the abolition not only of the state of marriage but more fundamentally of our current, physical, sexually-differentiated mode of existence[2], and is rooted in his protological anthropology, which excludes sexual differentiation from the *imago Dei* and, therefore, from God's original plan for humanity.

In the past few years, however, some scholars have challenged this consensus. The revisionist approach to Nyssene views on celibacy and marriage of Mark Hart[3] has been expanded by John Behr[4] to a radical new interpretation of Gregory's protological and eschatological anthropology with respect to sexual differentiation. The main features of this interpretation are (1) that Gregory sees human nature protologically as a composite of spiritual/rational and physical/irrational modes of being, with sexual differentiation as an integral component of the latter category, a component that is *not* contingent on humanity's Fall[5]; and (2) that Gregory therefore sees eschatological human nature as continuing to exist with the characteristic of sexual differentiation[6].

[1] E.g., Jean Daniélou, *Platonisme et théologie mystique* (Paris: Aubier/Éditions Montaigne, 1944), 55-7; *idem*, 'La résurrection des corps chez Grégoire de Nysse', *VC* 7 (1953), 163-4; Hans Urs von Balthasar, *Présence et pensée* (Paris: Beauchesne, 1952), 25-52; Verna E.F. Harrison, 'Male and Female in Cappadocian Theology', *JThSt*, n.s. 41 (1990), 441-71, at 465-71; Sarah Coakley, 'The Eschatological Body: Gender, Transformation, and God', *Modern Theology* 16 (2000), 61-73, especially 67-70.

[2] Even in his *De mortuis* 20, GNO 62-3, lines 24-27, Nyssa's discussion of the transformation of physical procreation into spiritual generation implies an abolition of sexual differentiation; otherwise, men would not possess this spiritual characteristic.

[3] Mark D. Hart, 'Reconciliation of Body and Soul: Gregory of Nyssa's Deeper Theology of Marriage', *TS* 51 (1990), 450-78; Mark D. Hart, 'Gregory of Nyssa's Ironic Praise of the Celibate Life', *Heythrop Journal* 33 (1992), 1-19.

[4] John Behr, 'The Rational Animal: A Rereading of Gregory of Nyssa's *De Hominis Opificio*', *JECS* 7 (1999), 219-47.

[5] Behr, 'Rational Animal', 234-8.

[6] Behr, 'Rational Animal', 244.

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Regardless of the merits of this interpretation, Behr's revisionist view illuminates the need to examine more closely an important nuance which is frequently under-explored in this area of study, namely, the distinction between the physical characteristic of sexual differentiation, which operates at the level of human *physis*, and what I will term the 'noetic' characteristic of gender, which may operate at the level of either *hypostasis* or *physis*. It is important not to conflate one with the other. It is equally important to recognize that the physical and the noetic may combine in different configurations, or that the noetic may change from one stage of human existence to another. Noetic gender will be touched upon only at the end; this article will concentrate on whether Gregory of Nyssa proposed an eschatological humanity that was still sexed, as the revisionists contend, or whether the earlier scholarly consensus of the abolition of human sexuality is correct.

At its root, the question of whether humanity will or will no longer exist physically as male and female concerns particularly the meaning for Gregory of the word *βίος*, 'mode of life'. Limiting his analysis to the *De hominis*, Behr interprets the term in a spiritual sense which affects physical *actions* but not physical *nature*. Therefore, he believes Gregory rejects sexual activity in the eschaton, but still includes the physical characteristic of sex and, presumably, a noetic gender consistent with the person's physical sex.

However, while Gregory certainly devotes a great deal of energy to an exposition of the spiritual and moral differences between postlapsarian and eschatological existence, he also explicitly notes that the physical manner of life will be different, at least in part, because the physical *hypostasis* will be different. Part of the problem here may be in trying to develop Nyssen's sexual eschatological anthropology by relying on one text, and that a text devoted primarily to humanity's *creation*, not resurrection. Even so, *De hominis opificio* does indicate Gregory's position regarding the physical mode of existence of eschatological humanity. This can be seen by taking into account two important points: (1) the relationship between prelapsarian and eschatological modes of existence, and (2) the relationship between sexual differentiation and other aspects of humanity's current, biological mode of existence.

With respect to the first point, it is crucial not to view the relationship for Gregory between prelapsarian and eschatological modes of existence as a tautological one, that is, not to reduce the resurrection state to a restoration of the 'original state' of Adam and Eve[7], because of the progressive teleology inherent in Nyssen's anthropology and soteriology[8]. Therefore, even when Gregory

[7] Fernand Floeri, 'Le sens de la "division des Sexes" chez Grégoire de Nysse', *RevSR* 27 (1953), 110 n. 1.

[8] Brian Daley, 'The Human Form Divine: Jesus' Risen Body and Ours, According to Gregory of Nyssa', paper presented at the Fourteenth International Conference on Patristic Studies and published in this volume; Vasiliki Limberis, '*kairos* and *chronos* in Gregory of Nyssa', in *SP* XXXII (1997), 141-4.

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talks about a return to humanity's original state, one must take into account the 'spiral' sense in which he understands return (*epistrophe* or *epaneleusis*).

This caution holds doubly true given that the 'original state' to which Gregory often refers may not be the prelapsarian life in Eden, which Behr and others often suppose, but rather God's 'original plan'. In chapter 16 of *De hominis opificio*, Nyssen divides his protology into two parts, distinguishing between the creation of humanity as a whole according to the *imago Dei* and without sexual differentiation (generic humanity) and the creation of human beings with the distinction of sexual differentiation (specific humanity, that is, particular persons)[9]. As Behr notes, it is true that Gregory sees sexual division as an aspect of our irrational nature of which we also take part[10]. However, one must not underestimate the significance of Gregory's argument that God added this division to human nature out of his foreknowledge of humanity's fall, in order to effect a means of procreation in our future, fallen state, and, consequently, Gregory's supposition, in chapter 17, that God had intended a different mode of procreation for humanity[11].

These two points cannot be divorced from one another. While Gregory indeed sees humanity as a microcosm participating in the physical, irrational life, and sexual differentiation is a part of this physical aspect of our nature, it does not follow that he believes sexual differentiation to be a necessary and eternal aspect of human existence. Not all aspects of humanity's postlapsarian, and even prelapsarian, physical existence are necessary to its fulfilling its mediatorial purpose. Some aspects of our physical existence are meant to be temporary, and sexual division falls into this non-essential category. Behr's model creates a new order of cause and consequence not borne out by the text, and is mute in response to the implicit question of whether God's original intention for humanity is ever fulfilled. Basically, this new order is an inversion of the straightforward argument in *De hominis opificio*. It replaces Gregory's argument that God created sexual division as a procreative contingency plan, because of his foreknowledge of the Fall, with a model that begins with sexual division as an intrinsic component of human nature, and procreation and marriage as the temporary and non-essential consequences which will be abolished in the eschaton.

The first problem here is that nowhere does Gregory state that God intends sexual differentiation as an essential part of human nature. In chapter 17, he recognizes the irrational, physical side of our composite, mediatorial nature as *inclusive* of sexual division, but does not argue that sexual differentiation is *normative* for human nature. The second problem, related to the first, is that nowhere in *De hominis opificio* does Gregory suggest that there is some inher-

[9] Gregory of Nyssa, *De hominis opificio* 16.8 (PG 44, 181B).
[10] *Ibid.*, 16.9 (PG 44, 181B-D).
[11] *Ibid.*, 17 (PG 44, 188A-189B).

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ent function of sexual differentiation beyond its procreative one. As mentioned a couple of sentences earlier, Gregory asserts only that sexual division serves as a reflection of humanity's composite nature, not that it therefore plays a necessary part in humanity's mediatorial vocation. Moreover, he quite explicitly states that the purpose of sexual division itself – not just marriage – was 'in order that the multitude of human souls might not be cut short by its fall from that mode by which the angels were increased and multiplied ...'[12]. For Gregory, at least in this text, marriage equals procreation equals sexual division. He does not treat questions of companionship or service to the Church as purposes of marriage, nor would one expect him to do so since those aspects of marriage are in any case not dependent on sexual differentiation.

Having discussed the relationship between prelapsarian and eschatological modes of existence, let us now turn to the question of the place of sexual division within the broader biological mode of life. Here, Gregory's thought becomes even clearer if the *De hominis* is taken together with his *De anima et resurrectione*. At the end of chapter 18 of *De hominis*, Gregory speculates that human beings will no longer be sustained by food and drink:

> ... as the resurrection holds forth to us a life equal with the angels, and with the angels there is no food, there is sufficient ground for believing that man, who will live in like fashion with the angels, will be released from such a function'[13].

This passage is significant since it echoes Gregory's argument in the previous chapter that there shall be no marriage in heaven because human beings will be equal to the angels.

Most scholars have read Gregory's interpretation of the Lucan passage, that is, Jesus' response to the Sadducees, as a proposal for the radical annulment of sexual differentiation[14]. His argument, which reflects the exegesis of other early church writers[15], is that we shall not marry *because* we shall be like the angels, not vice versa. That is, our nature shall be like the angelic nature in that regard. Since angels do not marry because they are non-sexed beings, it follows that Gregory assumes the same for eschatological human nature. His remarks regarding food and drink reflect the same presupposition. It is not that this different mode of existence is the result of simple moral choices, but that our physical nature will be ontologically changed in such a way that these aspects of our current existence will be abolished.

[12] *Ibid.*, 17 (PG 44, 189CD); English translation by H.A. Wilson, in NPNF, Series 2, vol. 9. 407.

[13] *De hominis opificio* 18 (PG 44, 196AB); English translation in NPNF, 408.

[14] E.g., Gerhart B. Ladner, 'The Philosophical Anthropology of Saint Gregory of Nyssa'. *DOP* 12 (1958), 85; Rosemary Radford Ruether, 'Misogynism and Virginal Feminism in the Fathers of the Church', in *Religion and Sexism; Images of Woman in the Jewish and Christian Traditions*, ed. Rosemary Radford Ruether (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1974), 154.

[15] See, for example, Clement of Alexandria, *Paedagogos*, I.4.10.3, SC 70, 128; John Chrysostom, *Homilies on Matthew*, Hom. 70 (PG 58, 658).

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This view is clear in chapter 10 of Gregory's *De anima*. The sexual actions which we now perform, as well as the other activities – eating, eliminating, growing, and growing old – which are part of our 'biological hypostasis', to use John Zizioulas' expression[16], will no longer occur precisely because they belong to the irrational skin which will be discarded in the resurrection[17]. Gregory's placement of sexual division within this biological ontology is significant. It is irrelevant that male and female exist prior to the Fall and the introduction of death and decay into human nature. Gregory believes that sexual division is taken, in anticipation, *from* that very nature. It would be unfaithful to the Cappadocian bishop's entire anthropology to divorce sexual differentiation from the other aspects of biological existence.

Finally, regarding the relationship between physical sex and noetic gender, a brief word is all that is necessary thanks to the illuminating writings of scholars such as Sarah Coakley and Nonna Verna Harrison[18]. Their work has amply demonstrated that, while Gregory may have envisioned the abolition of sexual division as a component of physical human nature in the eschaton, gender remained for him an important human characteristic, but as a soteriological characteristic he liberated it from the strictures of physical sex, that is, the garments of skin, calling on women to be 'male' in terms of spiritual strength in this life, and on men to be 'female' in terms of spiritual fecundity in the next. Thus, the best traits of both genders are to be cultivated by all human beings irrespective of sex[19]. In fact, the virtues of gender must be divorced from physical sex since otherwise they would become instincts, which – with the exception of the 'instinct' of erotic love for God[20] – for Gregory cannot be virtuous since they do not emanate from acts of free will[21].

In conclusion, then, a number of factors must be considered when attempting to tease out Gregory of Nyssa's eschatological views of human sex and gender. These include (1) the progressive, teleological relationship between Gregory's prelapsarian and eschatological anthropologies; (2) the nuances of

[16] John D. Zizioulas, *Being as Communion* (Crestwood, N.Y.: St. Vladimir's Seminary Press, 1985), 50-3. See also the discussion of the 'garments of skin' in Panayiotis Nellas, *Deification in Christ*, tr. Norman Russell (Crestwood, N.Y.: St. Vladimir's Seminary Press, 1987), 43-91, especially 71-85.

[17] *De anima* 10 (PG 46,: 149A); English translation in St. Gregory of Nyssa, *The Soul and the Resurrection*, tr. Catharine P. Roth (Crestwood, N.Y.: St. Vladimir's Seminary Press, 1993), 114.

[18] Coakley, 'Eschatological Body'; Harrison, 'Male and Female'; Harrison, 'Gender, Generation and Virginity in Cappadocian Theology', *JThSt* 47 (1996), 38-68.

[19] Coakley, 'Eschatological Body', 68.

[20] See, e.g., Martin Laird, 'Under Solomon's Tutelage: The Education of Desire in the *Homilies on the Song of Songs*', *Modern Theology* 18 (2002): 4 (special issue, *Re-Thinking Gregory of Nyssa*, ed. Sarah Coakley), 507-25; *Re-Thinking Gregory of Nyssa* republished Oxford: Blackwell Publishing, 2003.

[21] *De hominis opificio* 16.11 (PG 44, 184B).

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his two-part protology; (3) the place of sexual differentiation within the larger framework of Nyssen's understanding of postlapsarian, biological existence; and (4) the separation of noetic gender from physical sexual identity, both currently and especially eschatologically, with the concomitant soteriological freedom that implies. When all these factors are properly taken into account, it becomes clear that Gregory of Nyssa indeed envisions an ontological abolition of physical sexual differentiation in the resurrection while retaining the positive characteristics of a noetic sense of gender emancipated from the limitations of physical sex.

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Gregory of Nyssa and the Body: Do Recent Readings Ignore a Development in His Thought?

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Gregory of Nyssa is frequently studied for his writings on spirituality or mysticism, and in this respect he is often associated with a strand of Christianity which is world-denying and which also therefore has little value for the human body.

Thus, Peter Brown writes that 'Gregory mistrusted the material world'[1]. Likewise, Rosemary Radford Ruether stresses that for Gregory the image of God which humankind must recover was 'monistic' and therefore 'purely spiritual'[2]. Neither writer suggests that embodiment is *necessarily* evil nor fails to distinguish between the ideal and the fallen state of the human body. Nevertheless, both seemingly imply that, in Gregory's opinion, each individual's true self was to be found in the soul. Of course, other scholars have argued that he had a more positive attitude to the body, but the work of these two commentators in particular has had enormous influence, establishing a common pattern of reading Gregory as an ascetic with a very negative attitude to human embodiment.

Undoubtedly, Gregory was profoundly interested in the question of how the human soul yearns for God. He was also to some extent concerned with asceticism (by which I mean those practices by which one can discipline one's life so as to focus it on God). The question, then, is not whether Gregory was interested in asceticism, but whether the sort of asceticism which he advocated was world- or body-denying.

Central to the debate about Gregory's attitude to the body is his famous treatise *De virginitate*. Sometimes read as a defence of monastic life, and thus of literal virginity it is becoming increasingly common to see it as a more complex assertion of the paramount importance of the virginity of the soul. Whereas Gregory's comment that he wished that he had never been married was once taken at face value, some now read it as irony, taking more seriously

[1] Peter Brown, *The Body and Society: Men, Women and Sexual Renunciation in Early Christianity* (New York: Columbia University Press, 1988), p. 299.

[2] Rosemary Radford Ruether, 'Misogynism and Virginal Feminism in the Fathers of the Church', in Ruether (ed.), *Religion and Sexism* (New York: Simon and Schuster, 1974), p. 155.

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his claim that spiritual virginity is achievable within marriage, albeit with a great effort[3].

However, the question of whether Gregory endorsed the institution of marriage or not is a side-issue which detracts from the deeper theological problem of his attitude to embodiment. This is because marriage was for Gregory much more than a sexual relationship or a social institution. This is stressed by Peter Brown. Whilst acknowledging that in Gregory's opinion marriage, or rather sexual procreation, was established by God, Brown emphasizes the idea that it was only a second-best option, set in play due to God foreseeing the Fall. Ideally, human beings would have reproduced asexually like the angels; the consequences of the Fall, specifically mortality, meant that that was impossible, so to ensure that the human race generated the full number of individuals that God planned, God instituted sexual reproduction. Thus for Gregory marriage was inextricably tied up with mortality and the fallen experience of time, and presented the Christian with an array of challenging temptations connected with the misuse of sex, wealth, and social reputation. Brown rightly understands that marriage in Gregory's theology was thus not a mere facet of life, but a symbol or epitome of the whole condition of fallen human nature. Thus if Gregory *had* rejected marriage outright he would have been recommending that the soul should flee from the whole problematic condition of fallen life – hence Brown's claim that Gregory 'distrusted the material world'[4].

Other readers object that Gregory did not in fact reject marriage in *De virginitate*. Besides the argument from irony discussed above, one can also infer from Gregory's train of thought that the total renunciation of marriage would also be an opting-out of the divinely ordained plan for the bringing of the human race to its glorious consummation. We can thus conclude that for Gregory celibacy undertaken because of a distaste for marriage was merely selfish escapism and if advocated universally would be an obstruction to the fulfilment of the whole of the human race[5]. However, reading *De virginitate* as an

[3] See Mark D. Hart, 'Reconciliation of Body and Soul: Gregory of Nyssa's Deeper Theology of Marriage', *TS* 51 (1990), 450-78, and 'Gregory of Nyssa's Ironic Praise of the Celibate Life', *Heythrop Journal* 33 (1992), 1-19.

[4] Brown, *Body and Society*, p. 299.

[5] Brown's analysis contains a tension: on the one hand, 'the continuity of the human race through reproduction was accepted by [Gregory] as a sad but faithful echo of the abiding purpose of God' (*Body and Society*, p. 296), but on the other, 'only by the drastic step of abandoning marriage and childbirth was it possible to exorcise the anxiety caused by the sense of the inexorable passing of time' (p. 297). This tension could be resolved by reducing celibacy to a personal choice made for psychological reasons (a theory which does no justice to Gregory's theology of monasticism), or by postulating that Gregory either expected an imminent eschaton in the light of which it is better not to marry, or believed that a universal turn to celibacy would be a sign of the completeness of the human race and a herald of the end-times (possibly hinted at by Brown, p. 303). However, Gregory clearly anticipates the slow progress of time in which God achieves the expansion of humankind (see, e.g., Ton van Eijk, 'Marriage and virginity, death and immor-

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endorsement of marriage, at least for the spiritually strong, does nothing to resolve the central theological problem of Gregory's attitude to life in this fallen world. For even if Gregory *were* recommending a new goal of spiritual virginity within marriage, he did not exactly produce a whole hearted celebration of human sexuality nor even of everyday life[6].

Consequently, regardless of whether Gregory primarily defended physical or spiritual virginity, his flamboyant rhetoric still leaves an awkward question: if this life makes devotion to God so difficult, what is its point? Whilst it is clear that the body is not in itself evil nor a barrier to God, *De virginitate* suggests that the current anomalous condition of embodiment epitomized by marriage is so liable to evil distortion that it is a distraction from God.

Hence, *De virginitate* does provide evidence for claims about Gregory's negative attitude to embodiment. My argument is, however, that too much of the debate has centred on this text. My case is built on two assumptions. The first is that *De virginitate* is indeed an early work (apparently written when Basil was still alive) which, when compared to later writings, reveals a development in Gregory's anthropology. The second assumption is that this development is parallel to a similar development in Gregory's eschatology.

My argument is best illustrated by the contrast between the early treatise *De mortuis* and the later, and more famous, *De anima et resurrectione*[7]. *De mortuis* is based on the traditional *consolatio* form in which the writer persuades his audience that the deceased are far better off dead than alive. In order to make this point Gregory wrote of the soul yearning to leave the body which imprisons it and used other images which portray humans' earthly bodies very negatively. Interestingly, however, Gregory stressed that at the resurrection souls will be embodied, albeit, it seems, with a new pure body. The importance of some kind of eschatological materiality is reinforced by some of Gregory's most flamboyant descriptions of the physical geography of heaven. The problem with Gregory's train of thought, however, is that it leaves the reader

tality', in Jacques Fontaine and Charles Kannengiesser (eds), *Epektasis:Mélanges patristiques offerts au cardinal Jean Daniélou* (Paris: Beauchesne, 1972), pp. 231-3).

[6] The ideal husband is Isaac, who slept with Rebecca only until the birth of their children, and Gregory urges a husband to indulge sexual passion 'sparingly' and to 'keep it under restraint' (*De virginitate* 7.3-8: SC 119, ed. Michel Aubineau (1966), pp. 356-60; NPNF, Second series, vol. 5, tr. William Moore (1893), p. 353). The married life is described as a battle or a competition between the spirit and the flesh (8: SC 119, p. 360; NPNF, p. 353 and 20.3: SC 119, p. 496; NPNF, pp. 365-6), its balance endangered not only by sex, wealth and power, but also (somewhat more problematically) by the affectionate bonds between husband and wife and between parents and their children.

[7] For my reasons for assuming the comparative dating of these two works see Morwenna Ludlow, *Universal Salvation* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 2000), pp. 64-8; *De anima*'s treatment of the concept of desire also suggests it is a reworking of the more basic ideas in *De mortuis* (ibid., pp. 56-61). However, I recognize that the issue has not been resolved conclusively. See Brian Daley, 'The Human Form Divine: Jesus' Risen Body and Ours, according to Gregory of Nyssa', in this volume.

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of the treatise with a difficult question: *what is the point* of earthly embodiment if heavenly embodiment shows that there is a much better form of bodily life possible?[8] This neatly parallels the problem we found with *De virginitate*: *what is the point* of sexuality, marriage, and earthly life in general if it seems only to distract from the soul's ultimate goal – that is, God?

By sharp contrast with *De mortuis, De anima et resurrectione* has a detailed defence of the material identity of the earthly and resurrection bodies and tries to explain that the latter is a rearranged and thus transformed version of the former. This goes some way to explaining why the current body can be restricting and the heavenly one more accommodating. There is mention of the soul rising to God, which might sound like an emphasis on the purely spiritual union of God and the human, but on closer inspection it can be seen that this refers to an intermediate state between the death of the individual and the general resurrection, a state in which the soul is purified. This scheme is typical of Gregory's mature eschatology.

Consequently, if Gregory held that the resurrection is not some mysterious new materiality, but the perfection of the same materiality, could he have been so negative to our current embodied state as is sometimes claimed? A look at Gregory's wider theological concerns suggests he was not. Just as sexuality is a good (albeit second-best) means for God to achieve his purpose, so embodied earthly life as a whole, with its passions, distractions and impediments, is a good (albeit second-best) means for humankind to progress to its ordained eschatological destiny. Even in *De mortuis* Gregory stated that this life is a useful and necessary journey to fulfilment, the flower before the fruit[9]. In his later works, he claimed more positively that this life enables us to learn about God, and he stressed the embodied nature of the learning process: the physical universe teaches us about the creator God, and even the human body is a 'mirror of a mirror' which reflects the dignity of the soul created in the divine image[10]. The mediating role of human embodiment also extends to the praise of God, since the specific purpose of human creation is that God may be glorified by intellects *within* the earthly sphere[11]. In *De vita Moysis* and *De vita Macrinae*, although Moses and Macrina are symbols of the eschatological perfection of human persons, their *historical* lives are the necessary means to their own individual destinies. Most strikingly, Gregory suggested that children who die in infancy are, although sinless, *worse* off than people who live

[8] A question Gregory asks himself: *De mortuis*, ed. Gunterius Heil, *GNO* IX/1, (1967), pp. 48-9.

[9] For the journey and fruit/seed metaphors see *De mortuis*, GNO IX, pp. 49-53.

[10] *De hominis opificio* 2.1; 12.9.

[11] *De infantibus praematurе abreptis*, ed. Hadwiga Hörner, *GNO* III/2 (1987), pp. 78-9; NPNF, Second series, vol. 5, p. 375.

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longer, precisely because such infants have been denied the opportunity of maturing which this embodied earthly life offers[12].

Many other commentators have spotted the link Gregory made between anthropology and eschatology – that the eschaton is the restoration of human nature to its perfect original state – and have used his writings on eschatology as a key to unlock his views on what the ideal state of human nature is. However, little attention has been paid to the development in Gregory's eschatology, and this has resulted in three specific faults.

First, some of Gregory's statements about the disembodied intermediate state have been read as statements about humanity's final state, which has led to the mistaken conclusion that the first, ideal state of human nature was either totally disembodied or had a sort of ethereal embodiment so different from our current state as to raise questions about whether it can really be described as 'embodiment'.

The second problem is that Gregory asserted that in heaven there will be no sexual differentiation, no eating, none of the human desires that characterize current human living. All of these features were added to human nature when God provided humans with the means to survive in the fallen world. Thus again it is assumed that this ideal once and future state of humankind is so different from our current type of embodiment that Gregory did not really have a positive attitude to the present human body at all when he asserted the resurrection of the body.

Thirdly, it sometimes appears that Gregory thought that in the first creation humankind was an undifferentiated concept – 'human nature' – rather than a collection of real human beings. This suggests a lack of emphasis on the body, which has encouraged commentators to postulate the eschatological union of individual souls with God, even the final blending of all souls in a final, monistic synthesis. Yet an examination of most of Gregory's later eschatology shows the great importance of the *social* aspect of the resurrection. Although he highlighted the perfect union of heaven, he meant not a monistic union, but a harmony created from all parts and members of the created universe[13]. Gregory's assertion that human nature will be restored to its original state is hyperbole: humans will achieve the moral purity and other perfect qualities with which human nature was first created, but they will not literally return to the first state of creation, because God always planned that humankind would develop from an undifferentiated nature to perfect plurality.

To sum up, Gregory always asserted a resurrection of the body. His mature eschatology, however, affirmed it is the earthly body which will be transformed. Mentions of the soul alone ascending to God are references to the

[12] *De infantibus praematurae abreptis*, GNO III/2, 83-5; NPNF, p. 377.
[13] For detailed references, see Ludlow, *Universal Salvation*, pp. 73-6.

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intermediate, not the final, embodied and social state. Earthly life is a necessary preparation for the eschatological perfection of individuals and creation as a whole. Asceticism was thus for Gregory not so much a turning away from embodiment as learning to live how to live in the body. As a footnote to this conclusion, one could therefore surmise that Gregory saw monastic communities as symbolic of the eschaton, not because of any denial of embodiment, but because of their attempt literally to embody in advance the perfect society of heaven.

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Κοινωνία on Purpose? – Ecclesiology of Communion in the Letters of St Basil the Great

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St Basil is known as *the* Father of Eastern monasticism. While asceticism had formerly been practised almost exclusively by hermits[1], he introduced the element of organized cenobitic life to it.

The tendency to classify Basil as a '*monastic*' church father makes Klaus Koschorke speak of a growing dichotomy between the two models of church life, parish and monastery[2]. Yet is this really true? Did not the same principle of κοινωνία that guided Basil's monastic life and writings also rule his later activities as a bishop? Κοινωνία seems to have played a major role throughout his life. Therefore, the aim of this paper is twofold: first, to examine what κοινωνία means to Basil in a primarily non-monastic context. And secondly, to ask what impact κοινωνία has on his view of the church. The textual basis for this shall be mainly his letters[3], since they bear witness to his pastoral activities. There not only the term κοινωνία is to be paid attention to. The matter itself might be disguised by paraphrases and metaphors.

1. What Does Κοινωνία Mean to Basil?

1.1. *Three Main Metaphors and Four Levels of Κοινωνία*

A metaphor can often better express the different aspects of a term than a complicated explanation. Basil uses three metaphors to depict what κοινωνία means to him – garment[4], ship[5], and body[6] (which also implies Body of Christ).

[1] Cf. *Regulae Fusius Tractatae* and *Regulae Brevius Tractatae* and his life at the monastery of Annesos.

[2] K. Koschorke, *Spuren der alten Liebe. Studien zum Kirchenbegriff des Basilius von Caesarea* (Freiburg, Switzerland, 1991), p. 332: 'eine sich verschärfende *Diastase zwischen gemeindlichem und monastischem Kirchenmodell*'. In arguing thus, Koschorke fails to take into account *Ep.* 295. On its impact 'alla *koinonía* di tutte le chiese' see J.-R. Pouchet, 'La personalità di Basilio attraverso il suo epistolario', in S. Brock *et al.* (eds), *Basilio tra oriente e occidente* (Comunità di Bose, 2001), pp. 31-65, at p. 61.

[3] Cf. Saint Basile, *Lettres* I-III, ed. Y. Courtonne (Paris, 1957, 1963, 1966).

[4] Cf. *Ep.* 113.15-19 (II, pp. 16f.).

[5] Cf. *Ep.* 151.2.3 (II, p. 93).

[6] Cf. *Ep.* 97.12-14 (I, p. 210):Ἐπεὶ καὶ ἐξ αὐτῆς τῆς τοῦ σώματος κατασκευῆς τὸ ἀναγκαῖον τῆς κοινωνίας ὁ κύριος ἡμᾶς ἐδίδαξεν.

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He uses them in a twofold way – to describe successful and unsuccessful κοινωνία. 'Ship' for instance, can serve as a negative paradigm: the crew is exposed to the whims of the sea. In the tempest of heresy most of the ships (that is, the churches of the East) are threatened by shipwreck[7], while the churches of the West still fancy themselves in a safe harbour[8].

The metaphor of 'body' is transposed to four different levels of κοινωνία. Within the *parish* it can be applied to baptism, penitence, and, above all, to the Eucharist. In the *diocese* it describes the relationship between clerics and laypeople. *Between the dioceses* it accounts for the necessity of solidarity, and regarding the relation of the *Eastern churches to the West* it makes their calling for help more plausible.

The term κοινωνία is mostly associated with a complicated network of interchurch relationships and alliances. Yet this corresponds only to the third and fourth levels of Basil's use of κοινωνία. On these interchurch levels κοινωνία is maintained by letters of communion and mutual invitations to synods. Basil also tried to strengthen the practice of κοινωνία on the level of his diocese – as is shown by the way he dealt with his χωρεπίσκοποι and suffragan bishops. For instance, he celebrated local feasts and festivals of martyrs more magnificently than had been the case before his episcopate in order to have a forum for exchange with his clerics.

1.2. *Κοινωνία in the Parish*

But above all, Basil's parish work has been guided by his wish to establish κοινωνία. In Basil's notion baptism, penance and Eucharist are major hallmarks of communion.

1.2.1. Baptism – the Way to Enter into Κοινωνία

A rather obvious step to achieve unity and communion is to avoid something like a 'two-class' Christianity. In the course of time the status of being a catechumen had been prolonged to the whole of life[9]. There were many advantages, but few obligations. Basil mocks this way of sympathizing with Christianity as 'Today for me, tomorrow for God'[10].

For Basil baptism is the gate to Christian κοινωνία. But if baptism constitutes membership in the church, baptism and orthodoxy are necessarily linked.

[7] Cf. *Ep.* 70.9-11 (I, p. 165); *Ep.* 90.1.21-25 (II, p. 195); *Ep.* 242.1.2-8 (III, p. 65).

[8] Cf. *Ep.* 243.4.12 (III, p. 72).

[9] A prominent example in non-Christian literature is given by Lucian of Samosata in his Περὶ τῆς Περεγρίνου τελευτῆς 11–13, in *Luciani Opera* 3, ed. M.D. Macleod, Oxford Classical Texts (Oxford, 1980), pp. 188–205, at pp. 191f.

[10] Προτρεπτικὴ εἰς τὸ ἅγιον βάπτισμα (PG 31, 437B): Τὴν σήμερον ἐμοί, καὶ τὴν αὔριον τῷ Θεῷ. Cf. also ibid., 436A–B; 433B.

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And heretics are to be baptized again, if their creed, professed at their baptism, opposes or omits some of the articles of faith set up by Nicaea.

Basil seems to have been very strict on that point. Yet under certain circumstances he could admit even people to his κοινωνία who were renowned for being Arians. 'At Epiphany 372 Valens attended church at Caesarea with his court. Basil disappointed zealots who vainly hoped for a dramatic scene at which their bishop would refuse communion to the Arianizing emperor'[11]. For the sake of κοινωνία Basil contented himself with a mixture of being rigorous and being indulgent.

1.2.2. Penitence – a Way of Being Taken Back into Κοινωνία

From the second century onwards there existed the possibility of a *paenitentia secunda*, a second chance to gain forgiveness – apart from baptism. There was a system of public penitence, where the culprit was excluded from κοινωνία, especially the Eucharist, and gradually over many years brought back to full membership. Because of its awkwardness, this practice had almost been given up[12], when Basil started to revive it[13].

His idea is that the solidarity of all is such that, if one member commits a sin, this has its impact on the entire community[14]. Here κοινωνία stands for the party that suffers and that, at the same time, gives support[15].

Basil's interest is clearly concentrated on the community of the *faithful*. As Watkins puts it, 'While the punishment of even the wilful murder has come down to twenty years of penance, nothing short of the whole term of life will suffice for the apostate'[16]. On the other hand, the canons show an inexhaustible optimism: Any sin, no matter how grave, can be forgiven, for in the end it is God who forgives. And the Eucharist, as sacrament of communion with God and one's fellow Christians, proves that κοινωνία with the church has been regained.

1.2.3. Eucharist – the Way of Expressing Κοινωνία

Being admitted to the Eucharist was one of the most distinctive expressions of κοινωνία, 'and the taking part in it the activity *par excellence* of each of its

[11] H. Chadwick, *The Early Church*, Pelican History of the Church 1 (Harmondsworth, 1967), p. 149.

[12] Canonical punishment already had severe secular consequences, since all social intercourse with the offender was interrupted (cf. *Ep.* 288.11–14 (III, p. 158)).

[13] Cf. *Epp.* 188, 199, 217.

[14] Cf. J. Lecuyer, 'L'assemblée liturgique selon Saint Basile,' in R.E. Hoeckman (ed.), *Pluralisme et Oecuménisme en Recherches théologiques Mélanges offerts au R.P. Dockx, O.P.*, BETL 43 (Gembloux, 1976), 137-54, at 138: 'la solidarité de tous est telle que le péché d'un membre de l'Église a des repercussion sur toute la Communauté.'

[15] Cf. *Ep.* 217.84.2-4 (II, p. 216) and *Ep.* 188.2.10f. (II, p. 124).

[16] O.D. Watkins, *A History of Penance* I (London, 1920), p. 325.

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members'[17]. Ideally, the local community comprised all the faithful of a city. But faith differences were felt immediately: Basil complains that sometimes the orthodox part of a parish would be compelled to celebrate the Eucharist in the open air[18]. The boundary line between the different eucharistic communities could be drawn between different groups within the parish or between the congregation and its bishop[19]. The crucial question, therefore, is who can celebrate the Eucharist with whom? Basil works out some criteria for answering that question.

1.3. *The Criteria for Κοινωνία*

The Eucharist is the feature by which one can even from the outside discern who is in κοινωνία with whom. The limits of κοινωνία are not necessarily congruent with the limits of the church (universal or local). Basil concedes the possibility that the one faith can be expressed in different ways[20]. The indispensable basis of κοινωνία, however, is the Nicene Creed. Basil makes this condition very explicit in the document which Eustathius of Sebaste was to sign[21].

Apart from professing the orthodox creed, there is another criterion: to act against the canons, which is against the rules of κοινωνία, means to exclude oneself from that community. On the level of the parish that exclusion is temporary, and the sinner can be gradually rehabilitated. But the rehabilitation of a bishop, not canonically appointed, can only be achieved by his already well-established colleagues[22]. Thus clearly, orthodoxy (ὀρθοδοξία) and 'ὀρθοπρᾶξις' (acting according to the canonical regulations) are the *conditiones sine quibus non* of κοινωνία.

The schism at Antioch seems to have been such a catastrophe for Basil because it did not fit into this pattern. Κοινωνία was only possible with one party. Meletius had become bishop in a canonically not totally unblemished way. That left Basil with only one option – to suspect Paulinus of being a heretic[23], although he had formerly declared that in Antioch *orthodoxy* was split in itself[24].

Eucharistic communion is an ambiguous mark insofar as heterodox groups also set up their own eucharistic communities. Thus the problem of rivalry and contention arises. If there are different circles of κοινωνία, which is the legitimate one?

[17] B. Lowery, *Episcopal Collegiality According to Saint Basil the Great* (Excerpt of Diss., Rome, 1985), p. 19.

[18] Cf. *Ep.* 242.2.11-18 (III, p. 66f.).

[19] Cf. *Ep.* 90.2.7-10 (I, p. 196), *Ep.* 229 (III, pp. 33-5) and *Ep.* 230 (III, pp. 35-36).

[20] Cf. *Ep.* 251.4.3-7 (III, p. 92): Πίστις παρ' ἡμῖν οὐκ ἄλλη μὲν ἐν Σελευκείᾳ, ἄλλη δὲ ἐν Κωνσταντινουπόλει καὶ ἄλλη ἐν Ζήλοις καὶ ἐν Λαμψάκῳ ἄλλη καὶ ἐπὶ Ῥώμην ἑτέρα καὶ ἡ νῦν περιφερομένη διάφορος παρὰ τὰς προτέρας, ἀλλὰ μία καὶ ἡ αὐτή.

[21] Cf. *Ep.* 125 (II, pp. 30-4).

[22] Cf. *Ep.* 122 (II, p. 28).

[23] Cf. *Ep.* 263.5 (III, p. 125).

[24] Cf. *Ep.* 258.3.7 (III, p. 102).

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Basil tries to solve the problem by introducing a further criterion, the criterion of quantity. Those who are in communion with the majority of bishops can be sure of being members of the right κοινωνία-group. This criterion is, primarily, applicable to bishops; but the individual members of a parish as well feel themselves linked through their bishop to all the other members on his list of communion. Yet the criterion of quantity only works as long as the orthodox are the majority: Basil's nightmare was to be outnumbered by heretics. According to him, the Eastern churches were already in danger of that.

2. How Does Basil's Notion of Κοινωνία Influence His View of the Church?

For Basil κοινωνία is a basic category of *human life*. He calls man a κοινωνικὸν ζῷον – a being by nature sociable[25] – and sees the source of any human communion in the Trinity[26].

Moreover, κοινωνία represents a basic category of *church life*. It is a Christian duty; it aims at practical action and συγγυμνασία, common exercise in doing the will of God. It is not just the pursuit of a utopian or future reality. Basil's starting point is the sound and unblemished communion of which the New Testament speaks[27]. This ideal that formerly had been reality is to be achieved again. At the grass roots level there are various ways to exercise κοινωνία: Basil's centre for the sick and poor had taken the proportions of a 'city within the city', thus becoming a sign of enacted κοινωνία. By following Christ, one's own gifts are made fruitful for everyone in the parish. In this respect everyday life is even more relevant to κοινωνία than theological treatises[28].

Κοινωνία can be a very helpful *instrument* for managing the church, but its effect can also be ambiguous, for it borders on the one hand on personal friendship and on the other on unwanted interference.

How favourable personal friendship is to the development of κοινωνία is shown by the example of Amphilochius, Basil's friend who was bishop of Iconium and often sought his help. Both attitudes, personal friendship and κοινωνία, include taking some interest in and sympathizing with others.

[25] In the third rule of his *Longer Rules*, for instance, he calls the human being a κοινωνικὸν ζῷον – a being by nature sociable (PG 32, 181A–C).

[26] Cf. R. Pouchet, *Basile le Grand et son univers d'amis d'après sa correspondance. Une stratégie de communion* (Rome, 1992), p. 78: 'Pour Basile, la *koinônia* prend sa source dans le mystère trinitaire de Dieu.'

[27] For example, he points out Acts 4:32 in *Ep.* 128.3.11f.

[28] *Ep.* 150.4.8-10: ἡ περὶ τοῦ πῶς χρὴ ζῆν τὸν χριστιανὸν διδασκαλία οὐ τοσοῦτον δεῖται λόγου ὅσον τοῦ καθημερινοῦ ὑποδείγματος.

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On the other hand, κοινωνία could be mixed up with a juridically established right of intervention, which is felt to be unwanted officiousness. 'Values such as prestige and honour, the reaction they caused such as envy and pride: none of these were qualities designed to produce true co-operation and community'[29]. Κοινωνία rightly understood is characterized by a sound mixture of solidarity and autonomy.

This leads to structuring the field of κοινωνία in concentric circles. The inner circle consists of those between whom there exists personal relationship as well as κοινωνία. The next circle is formed by those who – although not being linked by personal friendship – nonetheless strive for mutual exchange and help. To the last circle belong those who distrust the manifestations of κοινωνία as attempts at interference, but still see themselves as members of the one church.

Basil does not seem to understand κοινωνία as an instrument of 'egalitarianism'. The κοινωνία of the triune God serves as a model for keeping the right balance between unity and diversity within the church. Unity of faith does not lead to a uniformity of the different churches[30]. And Basil also clearly opposes a wrongly understood connection between hierarchy and responsibility. To be the last one in a hierarchical order does not necessarily mean to be without responsibility. On the other hand, the responsiblity for κοινωνία obviously culminates in the bishop. The bishop is the link of his church to other churches. Without him the church cannot establish real κοινωνία. Therefore, κοινωνία does not mean the opposite of hierarchy. Hierarchy helps to structure κοινωνία.

3. Conclusion

From this brief sketch we may conclude that in his parish too Basil is deliberately guided by the same principle of κοινωνία that predominates in his monastic writings. He purposely enacts κοινωνία following certain guidelines that result from his idea of what κοινωνία means, first, to get involved with others without giving up truth, but rather holding fast to orthodoxy, and secondly, to maintain a balance between autonomy and solidarity. Κοινωνία aims at the life of the entire church.

[29] R. van Dam, 'Emperor, Bishops and Friends in Late Antique Cappadocia', *JThSt* NS 37 (1986), 53-76, at p. 67.

[30] Cf. E. Theodorou, 'Die Kirche als Communio sanctorum bei Basilius', in A. Rauch and P. Imhof (eds), *Basilius. Heiliger der Einen Kirche* (Munich, 1981), pp. 68-81, at p. 78: 'Vom ökumenischen Standpunkt aus ist es auch erwähnenswert, daß nach der Auffassung des heiligen Basilius die Unitas des Glaubens der Kirche nicht mit der Uniformitas und Einebnung der berechtigten Eigenart und Eigenständigkeit der einzelnen Kirchen gleichgesetzt werden darf.'

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Thus, with regard to the dichotomy between monastery and parish as well, we can conclude with Basil's own words: Εὐεργεσία δέ ἐστιν ἑνωθῆναι τὰ τέως διεσπασμένά[31] – it is charity to unite what has been divided for so long.

[31] *Ep.* 113.21 (II, p. 17).

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The *De Dis et Mundo* of Sallutios and the *Oratio Catechetica* of Gregory of Nyssa[1]

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I hope in what follows to offer a comparison between two works emanating from very different backgrounds. Yet it is only fair at the beginning to underline the fact that the two writings share much externally in common. Both were composed in the second half of the fourth century, probably within twenty years of each other. Both echo the religious sympathies of the reigning emperor, in the case of Sallutios those of Julian, in that of Gregory those of the Spanish emperor Theodosius the Great. Further, whereas the pagan was an important figure in the imperial management team, being Prefect of the East, Gregory also was something of a favourite with Theodosius and had been given the arduous privilege of delivering the funeral orations of his little daughter Pulcheria in 385 and of the emperor's wife, Placilla, a year later in 386.

Barely twenty years separate the two writings. *DDM* was probably composed on the eve of the infamous School Law of Julian between 22 March and 16 June 362, a law which had compelled Marius Victorinus to abandon his chair of rhetoric in Rome[2] and Prohaeresius his chair at Athens[3] rather than abandon their Christianity.

We cannot go far wrong if we date the *OC* to some time after 382[4]. In any event, therefore, the two works are fairly close in date. It is probably the case that much of Gregory's argument assumes some acquaintance with later Pla-

[1] Abbreviated as *DDM* and *OC*.

[2] Augustine, *Confessions* VIII.2.3.

[3] Eunapius, *Vitae Philosophorum* 493: 'In the reign of the Emperor Julian, Prohaeresius was shut out of the field of education, because he was reputed to be a Christian.'

[4] It is impossible to determine exactly the date of *OC*. The latest date proposed – shortly after 383 – was suggested by J.H. Srawley in his Cambridge edition of 1903, while the most recent edition of the text, by Raymond Winling (SC 453 (2000)), argues in favour of the probability of a date as early as 381, shortly before the Council of Constantinople. This latter proposal is partly based on the interesting and seductive argument that the *OC* makes no apparent use of the notions of either the infinity or the incomprehensibility of God, both of which occupy an important place in the replies of Gregory to Eunomius. That work dates at least as early as the Council of Constantinople, during which Jerome tells us that Gregory read it to himself and Gregory of Nazianzus. However, the reference in ch. 28 to 'previous writings on the subject' and, above all, the reference in ch. 38 to ἑτέροι πόνοι suggest the later date of Srawley. (Mühlenberg's edition (*GNO* III/4 (1996) offers no discussion of the date.)

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tonism; Sallutios, however – and this is characteristic of paganism in general – owes no ostensible debt to Christianity, except in one important area.

Julian's pagan reformation owed much to his desire to adopt and adapt those areas of Christian life and organisation to which he attributed the success of the Galilean. The whole catechetical instruction through which he, as a youth of fifteen, had passed prior to his own baptism must have made a lasting impression upon him, and in his programme of militant Hellenism the composition of *DDM* took a prominent part. Apart from the fact that Gregory's work was intended for the benefit of those instructing others in Christianity and that there is no evidence that such a system existed among the pagans, there does exist a certain surface similarity between the two works. But what of the contents?

The 1960 Budé edition of *DDM* by Gabriel Rochefort subdivides the text into twenty-one brief chapters, which are in their turn subdivided further into thirty-two smaller sections. This is not a convenient device of the editor, but appears to derive from the manuscript tradition. The whole work apparently derives at least in part from the discussions between Julian and his Prefect and was clearly envisaged as a statement of pagan beliefs against the seemingly unstoppable advance of Christianity.

It begins with insisting in a Platonic fashion on the importance of adopting a serious, moral spirit and carries on in the first section with a discussion of 'common notions', κοιναὶ ἔννοιαι – that is, of ideas which all reasonable people have on serious issues. This appeal we find also in Gregory of Nyssa, both in the *OC* 5 (p. 19.17 Mühlenberg) and elsewhere, above all in his *Contra Eunomium* II.11. Indeed it will soon become clear that much of Gregory's defence of the fittingness of the Incarnation, which occupies a very large portion of the *OC*, rests upon such commonly accepted notions. Chapter 1 then proceeds to list the basic characteristics of every god – goodness, freedom from passion, and superiority to change. On this point, at any rate, there is a striking similarity between what we find here and what we find in many Christian writers. Chapter 2 enlarges on these points by insisting both on the divine *apatheia*, its absence of body, and its or rather their superiority to the constrictions of space. The divine is without passion, body, or spatial extension. It was precisely this conviction, which was shared by most Christians, that made the fact of the Incarnation of God so difficult to come to terms with.

Chapter 3 now addresses an interesting and difficult point for a Platonist. Why is it that our ancestors, who possessed a natural knowledge of God deserted it and turned their attention to myths instead? The myths, Sallutios argues, attempt to imitate the gods themselves in all their variety and their activities or ἐνέργειαι, again a word common to the Christian account of God from Basil onwards. Myths also have the sovereign advantage of being more readily available to those whose minds are unused to or hostile to the more rarefied atmosphere of more abstract theology. Why then do these myths contain

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so much that is morally grotesque and unacceptable? Chapter 4 attempts to solve this objection by distinguishing four different types of myth, the theological, the physical the psychological and the earthly. The last class was a particular favourite with the Egyptians, who because of their ἀπαιδευσία identified Isis with the soil and Osiris with the wet and so on.

The nature of myths and the nature of the different types of gods occupy the next three chapters (4-6), at which Sallutios turns his attention to the nature of the world (7), to the mind and the soul and its immortality (8), and then on in 9 to providence, fate, and chance and in 10 to virtue and vice. Good and bad government are discussed in 11, and in 12 the origin and nature of evil. The answer given to the last problem is typical of both Christian and Hellenistic writers of the period – evil is unreal.

Chapters 13 and 14 also raise issues of concern to Christian theologians. How are eternity and becoming at all compatible, and how can the gods, who do not change, be said to be angry or to be helped? Chapter 15 asks the point of giving honour to the gods, who have no need of our help, while 16 argues that sacrifices and other devotions are of use to us but not to the gods. The eternity of the world, the cause and nature of atheism and the [deferred] punishment of sinners occupy the following chapters, 17-19, while the final two sections (20-21) deal with life after death, metempsychosis, and the happiness of the good.

A brief review of the contents of Gregory's *Catechetical Oration* illustrates the points of contact with and divergence from Sallutios. Above all we need to remember that Gregory is offering advice to catechists in order to help them to deal with objections on the part of intelligent pagans to Christianity and especially to the Incarnation of the Word. The treatise opens with a preface and four chapters devoted to theology properly so called, that is the immanent Trinity, which Gregory endeavours to prove steers a midway course between the polytheism of the Greeks and the strict monotheism of the Jews.

In chapter 5, however, he turns to the divine economy, that is the involvement of God with the world he made. Gregory begins by exploring the reason for the need of redemption in the first place and the nature of human freedom and the problem of evil. Here in chapter 5 (20.15ff.) his answer is strikingly similar to that offered by Sallutios in his twelfth chapter, entitled 'that evil has no real existence'.

But the majority of the rest of the work takes the form of separate answers to about twenty basic objections about the delay, nature, success, and justification of the Christian doctrine of redemption. How could it be true as it questions the basic ideas of the deity that all shared? It is for this reason that so much time is devoted to establishing the fittingness or θεοπρέπεια of the Incarnation. In other words, Gregory assumes at the opening of chapter 5 the same basic general ideas as Greeks, like Sallutios, and then endeavours to demonstrate that the various truths asserted about Christ do not contravene the

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underlying assumptions of the pagans. This means in effect that you do not have to lapse into unphilosophical fideism if you wish to be a loyal Christian. The basic aim of the work seen from this perspective is, therefore, apologetic.

Gregory makes it perfectly clear on several occasions what he understands under the general rubric of fittingness. It means, as he states at the end of the preface (8.3), that God must be assumed to be good, just, wise, and powerful, all these four being taken together. In all this he is echoing nearly to the letter the ideas of Origen[5]. He, like Gregory, is unwilling to appeal to the divine omnipotence in order to explain or justify the divine activity. This point is stated with great clarity by Gregory at the beginning of chapter 20, where he writes, 'Everybody agrees that we ought to believe that the divine is not only powerful, but also just, good, and wise.' The remainder of this chapter (53.10-55.3) is devoted to an insistence on this basic insight, that is of the inseparability of the four central divine attributes. The extraordinary frequency with which Gregory in this treatise employs the idea of divine fittingness with which to deal with the objections of the rationalists can be gauged by the number of times in which the actual term is employed[6]. On one of its last appearances, in chapter 32 (=81.9), he writes, talking about the cross, that 'all, even the non-believer, will admit that there is nothing here which departs from the notion of divine fittingness'.

The celebrated text from Matthew 19:26, 'God can do anything' or 'with God all things are possible', is not used in the *OC* or indeed, according to the Drobner index, anywhere else in Gregory's corpus in order to justify apparent breaks in his basic rule. Chapters 22 to 26 are primarily concerned to establish the justice of the redemption, against the idea that the redemption of man through the incarnation, cross, and resurrection was an example of the unjust use of the power of God. Here we see Gregory endeavouring to prove that, although the devil in virtue of the fall of man did possess rights over us, these were not infringed by the divine rescue operation, 'for he who once deceived man by the charm of pleasure, was himself deceived by the veil (of flesh) of the manhood, of Christ (26). Indeed this reduction of divine intervention to a minimum and the attendant exaltation of the idea of θεοπρέπεια is a marked feature of the whole treatise.

All this means that although *DDM*, hardly surprisingly, contains no treatment of the Incarnation or cross, many of the presuppositions underlying its approach are echoed by Gregory. The latter was writing after the accession of Theodosius, when Christianity was in the ascendant, and it is therefore interesting to see that even so Gregory thought it worthwhile to assuage criticism

[5] These appear both in his *On First Principles* II.5 and at *Contra Celsum* III.70.

[6] The frequent occurrences of divine fittingness in the *OC* can be found at the following places (chapter numbering from Srawley, page and line from Mühlenberg): preface (7.8); 2 (12.19); 8 (36.13); 9 (36.19 and 37.6); 10 (39.8); 14 (43.9); 15 (43.9), 45.8); 20 (54.2); 21 (57.4); 24 (62.21); 27 (69.11, 70.18); 28 (70.22); 32 (81.10).

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of the gospel by arguing that faith did not make impossible demands upon reason. His handbook was intended for precisely those converts from Hellenism who looked for something more from Christianity than a bare assertion of the gospel and creeds.

Sallutios, by contrast, though at the time of writing in 362 his party was in the dominant position, shows himself quite uninterested in meeting the Christians halfway. It would be difficult from his work to guess that there were such persons as Christians at all. In this attitude he is at one with the majority of non-Christian writers of the third and fourth centuries. Some of them like Libanius never mention Christians at all, except perhaps obliquely, though they must have known them quite well. Plotinus too maintains a sullen silence, while Porphyry and Julian show a pronounced hostility.

Apart from the differing themes addressed by the two catechisms, two other significant elements distinguish these two writings. Gregory is above all concerned, unlike Augustine in his *On Catechising the Simple*, to go as far as he can in answering the objections of intelligent non-Christians to the central teachings of the gospel, above all those concerned with the person of Christ. Indeed he goes so far in his endeavour to neutralise their objections that the very novelty of the Incarnation is greatly reduced. Sallutios on the other hand seems to know nothing of Christianity, though the reference to atheism in chapter 18 is an implied reference to the rejection of ancestral religion by, among others, Christians. And on this point it is worth recording that atheism was one of the main charges levelled by pagans against Christians from the middle of the second century, as we learn both from Justin in his *First Apology* 6 and from Athenagoras in his *Embassy* 4. In other words, though Gregory is happy to appeal to common ideas, Sallutios because of his contempt for atheism appeals neither to the bible nor the creed.

Secondly, the plain purposes of the two writings are quite distinct. Sallutios writes for the benefit of fellow Hellenists who wish to understand the structure and content of their belief. His work is in no sense missionary and seems to have no interest in making converts. In this it has more in common with Judaism than with Christianity. Gregory's work, by contrast, is catechist/convert oriented, above all in its endeavour to address precisely those difficulties that would occur to an intelligent person on the threshold of baptism. This serves to reinforce the simple point that the missionary zeal of the gospel before and after 312 had no counterpart in either Greek or Roman religion. Indeed *On the Gods and the World* may be a cryptic response to the more organised programme of the Galileans.

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La noción de asimilación del hombre a Dios en la tratadística basiliana

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La noción de 'asimilación a Dios' (ἡ ὁμοίωσις τῷ Θεῷ) es empleada por muchos escritores cristianos[1] para aludir a la divinización del hombre. Por ello, el análisis del modo en que el término 'asimilación a Dios' es utilizado por un autor permite conocer cómo concibe la divinización del hombre. Diversos estudiosos han llevado a cabo este análisis, ilustrando el pensamiento antropológico de los principales pensadores cristianos de la Antigüedad[2]. Aunque Basilio de Cesarea emplea este término varias veces en sus obras, ninguno de los estudios dedicados a su antropología[3] centra su atención en este punto. Estudiaremos la noción de asimilación a Dios en los dos tratados basilianos, el *Adversus Eunomium* y el *De Spiritu Sancto*, ya que la redacción de ambos escritos está separada por una decena de años, lo que permite conocer el pensamiento del Capadocio en dos momentos cronológicamente lejanos, y captar así eventuales diferencias o evoluciones; y, además, porque es posible contar con la edición crítica de ambas obras[4].

I. *Adversus Eunomium* I.27

Este tratado fue escrito por Basilio de Cesarea en el año 364[5] para refutar la *Apologia* del anomeo Eunomio de Cízico, que, con su escrito, había intentado

[1] Cfr. Ireneo de Lión, *Adversus haereses* V.6.1, y Orígenes, *De principiis* III.6.1.

[2] A.-G. Hamman, *L'homme image de Dieu* (Paris, 1987); S. Raponi, 'Il tema dell'immagine-somiglianza nell' antropologia dei Padri', en *Alla scuola dei Padri: tra cristologia, antropologia e comportamento morale* (Roma, 1998), pp. 69-195.

[3] M. Girardi, 'L'uomo *immagine somigliante di Dio* (*Gen* 1, 26-27) nell'esegesi dei Cappadoci', *Vet Chr* 38 (2001), 293-314; G. Maloney, 'St. Basil', en Maloney, *Man, the divine icon* (Pecos, N.M., 1973), pp. 109-23; J. Coman, 'Éléments d'anthropologie dans l'œuvre de saint Basile le Grand', *Kleronomia* 13 (1981), 37-55; K. Berther, *Der Mensch und seine Verwirklichung in den Homilien des Basilius von Cäsarea: Ein anthropologisch-ethischer Versuch* (Diss., Freiburg/Schweiz, 1974); Th. Spidlík, *La sophiologie de S. Basile*, OCA 162 (Roma, 1961).

[4] B. Sesboüé, *Basile de Césarée. Contre Eunome. Suivi de: Eunome. Apologie*, 2 vols, (SC 299, 305) (Paris, 1982-83); B. Pruche, *Basile de Césarée. Traité du Saint-Esprit*, *SC* 17 (Paris, 1946).

[5] Según J.R. Pouchet, *Basile le Grand et son univers d'amis d'après sa correspondance* (Roma, 1992), pp. 135-6, Basilio escribió el tratado entre el 363 y el 365.

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defender la rectitud de su pensamiento, ya que había sido expulsado a instancias del pueblo de la sede de Cízico, ocupada tan sólo unos meses antes, por los rasgos claramente arrianos de su predicación[6]. Este estudio de la teología trinitaria está dividido en tres partes, dedicadas respectivamente al Padre, al Hijo y al Espíritu Santo.

En esta obra, Basilio afirma:

> La bondad de Dios y Salvador nuestro Jesucristo induce a los hombres, en la medida en que son capaces de recibirla, *a la asimilación con el Dios del universo* (τῇ πρὸς τὸν Θεὸν τῶν ὅλων ὁμοιώσει) por medio de la solicitud y del ejercicio de las buenas obras, con las palabras: 'sed perfectos como vuestro Padre celestial'. Pero éste (scl. Eunomio), en la medida en que le resulta posible, priva al Unigénito de la familiaridad que tiene por naturaleza con quien lo ha engendrado[7].

En este pasaje, la validez de una afirmación es empleada para poner de evidencia la falsedad de una segunda afirmación, en virtud de una cierta oposición de esta segunda con aquella primera. Basilio afirma que Jesucristo llama al hombre a la asimilación con el Dios del universo por medio de la solicitud y del ejercicio de las buenas obras. E, inmediatamente después, añade que Eunomio pretende privar al Unigénito de la familiaridad con el Padre. La eficacia del procedimiento lógico es tan grande que Basilio no se preocupa por cerrar el razonamiento afirmando que, puesto que el hombre puede alcanzar la semejanza con Dios, es absurdo pensar que Cristo no la posea.

Basilio apoya su afirmación de que Jesucristo llama al hombre a la asimilación con Dios en el pasaje escriturístico en el que Cristo exhorta a quienes le escuchan a imitar la bondad misericordiosa de Dios Padre, de modo que, al igual que Dios reparte sus dones sobre todos los hombres, tanto si son justos como si no lo son, así también los hombres sean benévolos con todos los demás, sin tomar en consideración si merecen esa benevolencia o no[8]. La mención del pasaje bíblico es muy oportuna, ya que en él, Cristo compara la perfección que debe alcanzar el hombre con la que posee Dios, con las palabras: 'Sed perfectos como vuestro Padre celestial', lo cual equivale a llamar al hombre a la semejanza con Dios.

Basilio dirige a Eunomio en este pasaje la crítica de que priva al Unigénito de la familiaridad con el Padre que posee por naturaleza. Esta crítica es apropiada, ya que la doctrina característica de los anomeos era precisamente la afirmación de que el Hijo es no-semejante al Padre (ἀνόμοιος τῷ Πατρί)[9]. Basilio no habla de semejanza del *Verbo* con el Padre, sino de la familiaridad

[6] L. Abramowski, 'Eunomios', en *RACh* 6 (1996), 937, sitúa la ordenación de Eunomio como obispo de Cízico y su deposición en el año 360.

[7] *Adversus Eunomium* I.27, ll. 23-30 (ed. Sesboüé). La traducción es nuestra.

[8] Cfr. *Matth.* V, 43-48. El pasaje paralelo de *Luc.* VI, 36, dice: 'Sed misericordiosos, como vuestro Padre es misericordioso'.

[9] Cfr. *Apología* 12. M. Simonetti, *La crisi ariana nel IV secolo* (Roma, 1975), pp. 256-9, sintetiza el pensamiento de Eunomio.

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natural que existe entre el *Unigénito* y el Padre, términos que implican la 'familiaridad' (οἰκειότης).

Puede encontrarse un precedente de este pasaje en el *Contra Arianos* de Atanasio de Alejandría. En efecto, el modo en que Basilio argumenta constituye un eco del razonamiento con el que el pensador arriano Asterio, según transmite Atanasio, trataba de defender la típica idea arriana de que el Hijo tan sólo posee una divinidad imperfecta[10]. Asterio concretamente criticaba a quienes, a partir del pasaje 'El Padre y Yo somos una sola cosa', afirmaban que el Verbo es semejante y propio a la sustancia del Padre, ya que, razonaba Asterio, aunque la Escritura recoge la frase 'Que todos sean uno, como Tú, Padre, en mí, y Yo en ti', nadie deduce de ella que el hombre es semejante y propio de la sustancia de Dios, por lo que tampoco es lógica la conclusión precedente sobre la semejanza del Verbo con el Padre. Atanasio de Alejandría responde que el hombre llega a estar en el Padre por la presencia en él del Espíritu Santo, mientras que el Hijo está en el Padre como su resplandor, y explica que el Verbo es Hijo de Dios por naturaleza, mientras que los hombres son hijos de Dios por gracia.

Basilio razona de modo inverso a Asterio: mientras que el arriano niega la semejanza del Verbo con Dios, por medio de la negación de la semejanza entre el hombre y Dios, Basilio se apoya en la existencia de la semejanza del hombre con Dios, para demostrar que el Unigénito debe poseer familiaridad por naturaleza con el Padre. Este paralelo entre el *Adversus Eunomium* y los discursos *Contra Arianos* hace pensar que Basilio se inspiró en Atanasio a la hora de componer su obra[11].

En este pasaje, Basilio asegura también que la asimilación a Dios se obtiene 'por medio de la solicitud y del ejercicio de las buenas obras' (διὰ τῆς μελέτης καὶ τῆς ἀσκήσεως τῶν ἀγαθῶν ἔργων). Realizar buenas acciones, poniendo cuidado y esfuerzo en ellas, lleva a alcanzar la semejanza con Dios a la que el hombre es llamado. Basilio subraya unilateralmente la importancia del obrar humano en el logro de la divinización. Se intuye tras estas palabras el empeño ascético con el que Basilio vivía su vocación monástica[12].

[10] Cfr. Atanasio de Alejandría, *Contra Arianos* III.17.

[11] Tambien V.H. Drecoll, *Die Entwicklung der Trinitätslehre des Basilius von Cäsarea. Sein Weg vom Homöusianer zum Neonizäner*, FKDG 66 (Göttingen, 1996), pp. 119-29, sostiene que Basilio, al escribir los dos primeros libros del *Adversus Eunomium*, se inspiró en *Contra Arianos*.

[12] La palabra μελέτη aparece relacionada con la vida monástica en *Regulae fusius tractatae*: VI.1, VII.4, XV.2. También puede ser encontrada en las *Regulae brevius tractatae*: XVI, XXII, CXCVIII. La palabra ἄσκησις, a su vez, en *Regulae fusius tractatae* V.1, XV.4, XXVI, y en *Regulae brevius tractatae* XVIII. Pero Basilio, al hablar a todo el pueblo cristiano, emplea también ambos términos: μελέτη aparece en *Attende tibi ipsi* 3 (S.Y. Rudberg, *L'homélie de Basile de Césarée sur le mot 'Observe-toi-même'*, Acta Universitatis Stockholmiensis. Studia Graeca Stockholmiensa 2 (Stockholm, 1962), 28, 11), y ἄσκησις en *homilia VIII in psalmum XLIV*, 8 (PG 29, 405 A).

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También Orígenes consideraba que el hombre alcanzará la semejanza con Dios por medio de las obras[13], y, dado que Basilio leyó algunas obras del maestro alejandrino durante los años de su retiro en el Ponto, parece claro que su fuente de inspiración es ésta. Orígenes sitúa el logro de la semejanza en la consumación escatológica, detalle que Basilio no recoge.

La doctrina origeniana de que el fin del hombre es la semejanza con Dios se inspira en el *Teeteto* de Platón[14]. El texto platónico afirma que la semejanza con Dios es alcanzada 'en la medida en que es posible' (κατὰ δύνατον), matiz que Basilio conserva al decir 'en la medida en que somos capaces' (καθόσον ἐσμὲν χωρητικοί).

II. *De Spiritu Sancto* IX.23

Basilio escribió esta obra en el año 375[15] para refutar la idea de que el Espíritu Santo no es de naturaleza divina, sostenida por personajes como Eunomio de Cízico y Eustacio de Sebaste[16].

Basilio comienza la obra con una carta dirigida a Amfiloquio, obispo de Iconio, en la que le indica que las páginas sucesivas son la respuesta a una pregunta formulada tiempo atrás por él mismo. A lo largo del *De Spiritu Sancto*, Basilio justifica la fórmula doxológica que usaba en la liturgia 'Gloria al Padre, con el Hijo y el Espíritu Santo', por la que había recibido críticas, explica las ideas tradicionales sobre el Espíritu Santo, y muestra la continuidad que existe entre algunos autores cristianos precedentes y su propio pensamiento. Otro pasaje de forma epistolar cierra la obra.

Al inicio de la obra, Basilio alude a la noción de asimilación del hombre a Dios, para asegurar que el fin al que el hombre es llamado por Dios es precisamente esa asimilación, que se alcanza por medio del conocimiento[17].

[13] *De principiis* III.6.1. *Contra Celsum* IV.29-30, dado que une la doctrina de la asimilación del hombre a Dios con el texto de *Matth.* V, 48, puede también haber influido en *Adversus Eunomium* I.27, pues Basilio en este pasaje establece la misma relación.

[14] Cfr. *Theaetetus* 176 Af.

[15] Cfr. Pouchet, *Basile le Grand et son univers d'amis d'après sa correspondance*, pp. 430-2.

[16] H. Dörries, *De Spiritu Sancto. Der Beitrag des Basilius zum Abschluss des trinitarischen Dogmas* (Göttingen, 1956), pp. 81-9, muestra que muchas ideas sobre el Espíritu Santo que Basilio critica en su tratado, se encuentran entre las teorías que, en la *ep.* 125, atribuye a Eustacio. J.R. Pouchet, 'Le traité de Saint Basile sur le Saint-Esprit. Son milieu originel', *RechScRelig* 85 (1997), 329, sostiene que Eustacio era sólo uno de los adversarios de Basilio, junto al que habría que situar otros, como Eunomio de Cízico. Pouchet se basa en que el tema de la subnumeración, que Basilio critica en el *De Spiritu Sancto*, era típico de la teología de Eunomio. En cualquier caso, Basilio está interesado en resaltar la divinidad del Espíritu Santo.

[17] Cfr. *De Spiritu Sancto* I.2: 'No escuchar descuidadamente los discursos teológicos, sino intentar rastrear el sentido oculto en cada palabra y en cada sílaba, no es propio de los que son perezosos para la piedad, sino de los que conocen el objetivo de nuestra llamada, es decir, que se nos propone *asemejarnos a Dios en la medida en que es posible para la naturaleza del hombre*

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Mayor interés posee el segundo pasaje del tratado en el que Basilio habla de este argumento. A partir del libro IX del tratado, Basilio expone las ideas tradicionales sobre el Espíritu Santo, y trata de demostrar apoyado en ellas la naturaleza divina de éste. En este contexto, pronuncia las siguientes palabras sobre la transformación del alma operada por la iluminación del Espíritu Santo:

La familiarización del Espíritu con el alma, explica Basilio, no consiste en un acercamiento espacial – ¿cómo podrías, en efecto, acercarte corporalmente a quien es incorporal? –, sino en el alejamiento de las pasiones que sobrevienen en un segundo momento al alma, procedentes de su amor a la carne, y la hacen ajena a la familiaridad con Dios. El que se ha purificado de la fealdad, que había contraído con la maldad, y ha regresado a la belleza natural, y como que ha devuelto a la imagen real la primitiva forma por medio de la pureza, así es posible que éste únicamente se acerque al Paráclito. Este, como el sol, tomando posesión del ojo purificado, te mostrará en si mismo la Imagen del Invisible. En la gozosa visión de la Imagen, verás la belleza inefable del Arquetipo. Por medio de éste, el alzamiento de los corazones, la educación de los débiles, el perfeccionamiento de los que ya están adelantados. Este, iluminando a los que se han purificado de toda mancha, marca a los espirituales con la comunión con él mismo. Y como los cuerpos brillantes y transparentes, cuando un rayo de luz cae sobre ellos, se hacen ellos mismos resplandecientes, y derraman otro rayo desde su interior; de esa manera, las almas portadoras del Espíritu, iluminadas por Él, ellas mismas se hacen espirituales, y hacen llegar a otros la gracia. Entonces se produce la previsión de los acontecimientos futuros, la inteligencia de los misterios, la comprensión de las cosas ocultas, la distribución de los carismas, la ciudadanía celestial, la participación en los coros de los ángeles, la felicidad sin término, la permanencia en Dios, *la semejanza con Dios* (ἡ πρὸς Θεὸν ὁμοίωσις), el mayor de los deseos, hacerse dios[18].

Este pasaje describe un cierto itinerario espiritual del alma humana. Esta se encuentra inicialmente en una posición de alejamiento de Dios, cubierta de la fealdad producida por las pasiones y por la maldad. Posteriormente, atraviesa una etapa de purificación, al término de la cual la imagen real recupera la familiaridad con Dios, y muestra nuevamente la belleza en la que había sido creada. Por último, recibe la iluminación del Espíritu Santo, que permite conocer al Arquetipo por medio de su Imagen, y con la que llegan al alma una serie de bienes extraordinarios, el más elevado de los cuales es la asimilación a Dios, o, en otras palabras, el hacerse dios.

El medio por el cual se alcanza la asimilación a Dios es la iluminación del Espíritu Santo. Esto supone una novedad con respecto a *Adversus Eunomium* I, 27, donde la asimilación era alcanzada con la realización de las buenas obras. El protagonista activo de la asimilación ahora no es el hombre, sino

(ὁμοιωθῆναι Θεῷ κατὰ τὸ δυνατὸν ἀνθρώπου φύσει). *La asimilación no se da sin conocimiento* (ὁμοίωσις δέ, οὐκ ἄνευ γνώσεως); y *el conocimiento procede de las enseñanzas* (ἡ δὲ γνῶσις ἐκ διδαγμάτων). El discurso es el inicio de la enseñanza, y las partes del discurso son las sílabas y las palabras. De manera que no carece de sentido la investigación sobre las sílabas'.

[18] *De Spiritu Sancto* IX.23.

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Dios. Sin embargo, el hombre no es un sujeto meramente pasivo, ya que debe disponerse para recibir la iluminación, purificándose.

Basilio alude a la asimilación a Dios como a uno de los dones del Espíritu al hombre. Estos dones se caracterizan porque conceden al hombre la capacidad de hacer algo que excede sus posibilidades: el conocimiento del futuro; la inteligencia de los misterios, como la concedida a san Pablo para que comprendiera el misterio oculto por los siglos[19]; la comprensión de lo que está oculto; la distribución de los carismas, entre los que san Pablo enumera la 'glosolalia' o, el don de curación[20]. Parece claro que la 'asimilación' es un don que, como los anteriores, el hombre no puede alcanzar a no ser que el Espíritu se lo conceda.

La purificación es vista en cambio como algo que se halla al alcance de las fuerzas del hombre. Por medio de ella el hombre recupera la belleza natural, y restituye la 'imagen real' a su forma antigua.

El carácter extraordinario de los bienes que el Espíritu Santo concede al alma a la que ilumina pone de manifiesto que la divinización que se produce en esta alma es una transformación profunda, radical, e, indirectamente, que el Espíritu Santo pertenece a la esfera divina. Atanasio de Alejandría había explicado anteriormente que el Espíritu Santo es Dios porque diviniza al hombre, para defender la divinidad de la tercera Persona de la Trinidad frente a los ataques de unos personajes a los que denomina 'trópicos'[21]. Por tanto, parece que Basilio de Cesarea, al presentar la asimilación a Dios como un don sobrenatural otorgado por el Espíritu Santo, tiene en mente el deseo de defender la divinidad de la tercera Persona de la Trinidad.

Aunque diversos estudiosos opinaban que Basilio seguía en estas líneas las *Enneadas* de Plotino[22], los análisis más recientes han concluido que los parecidos de este pasaje con algunas líneas del filósofo neoplatónico son insuficientes para demostrar una dependencia directa[23].

Gregorio de Nisa escribió en el año 371 el tratado *De virginitate*, con el que deseaba contribuir a la difusión del ideal ascético de su hermano Basilio[24]. El Niseno describe en esa obra la iluminación del alma por el Espíritu Santo, y, en el curso de esa descripción se refiere a la necesidad previa de purificación, emplea la imagen del alma como cuerpo traslúcido, habla de la irrupción del Espíritu Santo en el alma como de iluminación que penetra en ese cuerpo y lo

[19] Cfr. *Eph.* III, 1-7.

[20] Cfr. 1 *Cor.* XII, 4-11.

[21] Cfr. *epistola I ad Serapionem* 24.

[22] P. Henry, *Études plotiniennes*, 1. *Les États du texte de Plotin* (Paris, 1938), 179, defiende esta dependencia.

[23] Cfr. J. Rist, 'Basil's "Neoplatonism": Its Background and Nature', in P.J. Fedwick (ed.), *Basil of Caesarea: Christian, Humanist, Ascetic*, 2 vols (Toronto, 1981), 1, 137-220: 201-202.

[24] M. Aubineau, *Grégoire de Nysse. Traité de la virginité*, SC 119 (Paris, 1966), Introduction, pp. 82-83.

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hace luminoso, de modo que puede revertir esa luz a su alrededor[25]. Todos estos rasgos son empleados también por Basilio en su obra. Puesto que esta obra fue escrita cuatro años antes que el *De Spiritu Sancto*, es posible que constituya una fuente de inspiración de Basilio.

III. Conclusiones

A lo largo de sus dos tratados, Basilio de Cesarea emplea en tres ocasiones la noción de asimilación del hombre a Dios. En los tres casos, el interés del Capadocio es fundamentar una verdad perteneciente al ámbito de la doctrina trinitaria: la mención del *Adversus Eunomium* sirve para defender la afirmación de que el Hijo es semejante al Padre; y la del *De Spiritu Sancto*, está dedicada a la demostración de la naturaleza divina del Espíritu Santo, a partir del análisis de la divinización que opera en las almas a las que ilumina.

Sin embargo, Basilio manifiesta también el modo en que entiende la asimilación a Dios. Así, en el *Adversus Eunomium* asegura que el hombre se asimila a Dios por medio de las buenas obras realizadas con empeño, mientras que en el *De Spiritu Sancto*, afirma que la asimilación a Dios es un don que el Espíritu Santo concede a las almas purificadas.

Las afirmaciones de Basilio deben entenderse a la luz de los interlocutores con los discute, es decir, de Eunomio, en el *Adversus Eunomium*, y de los detractores de la naturaleza divina del Espíritu Santo, en el *De Spiritu Sancto*.

[25] *De virginitate* XI.4, ll. 28-40.

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The Constitutive Elements of the Apophatic System of Gregory of Nyssa

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With this communication I wish to participate in the discussion concerning the significance of apophaticism in Gregory of Nyssa[1] by focusing on systematic and speculative aspects that attach to it. In what follows, I seek to clarify for the question, what is *apophasis* in Gregory as a systematic device, as a part of a speculative system that he aimed to construct in a coherent manner – as it is reflected in the argumentation of the Trinitarian context of *Contra Eunomium*[2]. In another words, my concern here is not the mystical ascent of the soul, but the argumentation that Gregory uses to support the Trinitarian confession and that is at once, somehow, *scientific* and *apophatic* in its character.

The exact, technical question I state, is this: what, very briefly, are the most necessary and fundamental speculative elements – I mean, distinguishable arguments – in Gregory that produce conceptions *making manifest* apophaticism in his thought[3]? What kind of speculative construction is established by these elements, and does it really make a *system* with connected constituents?

When one starts to examine apophaticism in Gregory from this point of view, two notions arise. First, although Gregory is familiar with the use of the *alpha privative* as a linguistic/epistemological technique[4] and certainly favours negative language when referring to God by abstractions[5], he does *not* develop

[1] Andrew Louth, in his balanced study *The Origins of the Christian Mystical Tradition* (Oxford, 1981), esp. 159, 180, 181, has rightly placed Gregory within the apophatic tradition with Philo and Pseudo-Dionysius. That Gregory's thought has to be characterized as *apophatic* is a thing we know from the fact that it performs what Deirdre Carabine has called 'the three-fold manifesto of *apophasis*' – that God is *ineffable*, *unnameable* and *unknowable* (*The Unknown God, Negative Theology in the Platonic Tradition: Plato to Eriugena* (Louvain, 1995), 9, 249). Raoul Mortley, too, confirms that Gregory 'arrives at the postulate of negative theology', but concludes that there 'is no *science of negation* in Gregory'. (*From Word to Silence*, 2 (Bonn, 1986), 144, 191). These remarks serve well as starting points for the following considerations.

[2] References to *Contra Eunomium Libri* I-III, ed. W. Jaeger (Leiden, 1960), in GNO I/II.

[3] See note 1 above. It is universally agreed that Gregory's thought manifests negative theology. It is harder, however, to define what *exactly* is referred to when the concept of *apophasis* is attached to his thought.

[4] *CE* II.142, 594. See also *An et res* (PG 46, 40).

[5] *CE* I.435, 683; *CE* II.142.

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or get involved with any *linguistic method* formally known as *apophasis*[6]: in the Christian context, this is a later contribution of Pseudo-Dionysius Areopagita. The linguistic method of *apophasis* thus cannot be conceived as a 'constitutive element' of his apophatic system. Second, *apophasis* as a systematic device in Gregory seems to function as a comprehensive *theoretical principle*, one that stands on an *exegetical* basis but has the Trinitarian debates as an important context of further systematic development, as more careful analysis is then addressed to all of its implications. The principle is *effective* in the scientific method used – namely, in Gregory's standard method of scientific reasoning, known as *akolouthia*[7] – or, viewed subjectively, *epinoia*[8] – to which the principle is attached as a certain epistemological 'directive'. The incomprehensibility of God's nature also represents one of the *dogmatic* principles to be taken into account when examining the Trinitarian doctrine and its logical constitution[9].

Basically what happens is this: Gregory presents it as a *biblical premise* that the essential nature of God cannot be known – it is a *theological truth* discovered by theologians like Abraham, David, Moses, Paul, and John[10]. It is to this premise that all scientific reasoning must fit as to a *philosophical axiom*, by the logical means of human reason, and with the further aid of the data of Revelation. Gregory's practical task is to show, by employing scientific method, *how* the more immediately evident and common principles of thought (*koinai ennoiai*) support the scriptural testimonies (*graphikais martyriais*) concerning the unknowability of God's essence[11]. This process of giving scientific evidence for God's essential unknowability – to be out to in further use in order to ground Trinitarian argumentation scientifically – actually produces what I here call the 'constitutive elements of the apophatic system' of Gregory.

The argumentative system arranged according to the apophatic axiom, has *to on* – including both *being* (*ousia*) and '*is-ness*' (*einai*) – as its inescapable category, since God, according his self-revelation is, for Gregory, Real Being – *He* who is[12]. God, as conceived by Gregory, is not *beyond being*[13], but

[6] As Mortley, 171-191 convincingly shows. Gregory, for his part, rather refuses to see any promising prospects in linguistic manoeuvres. See *CE* II.580, 587.

[7] For the theme and concept of *akolouthia* in connection with scientific thinking and methodology in Gregory, see the recent article by Hubertus Drobner, 'Gregory of Nyssa as philosopher', *Dionysius*, New Series 18 (2000) 69-103.

[8] For the theme and concept of *epinoia*, see Mortley, 151-3. In Gregory, for *epinoia* as a mental method in the sciences, in connection with logical sequence (*akolouthia*), see *CE* II.181-182.

[9] *CE* II.12.

[10] *CE* I.314; *CE* II.84-102, 119-124.

[11] *CE* II.11-12; *CE* I.217-221.

[12] In Ex 3:14 (*ego eimi*; *ego eimi ho on*). Gregory follows the exegetical tradition set forth by Philo (Carabine, 237). For one of the numerous illustrations of Gregory's firm conviction, see *CE* III.vi.3, 8. For the Platonic background of this idea, see Anthony Meredith, 'The Idea of God in Gregory of Nyssa', In H. Drobner and C. Klock (eds), *Studien zu Gregor von Nyssa und der christlichen Spätantike* (Leiden, 1990), 127-47.

[13] Another difference worth noticing between Gregory and Pseudo-Dionysius.

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beyond all *created* being – he *is* the ultimate reality of being. To discuss the being of God, then, is to discuss the reality and existence of a transcendent dynamic nature[14] – not just of some abstract essence that would exist separately in respect of its power, through the exercise of which its existence is known. Accordingly, one can find two major lines of argumentation in Gregory's apophatic system, intimately related but distinguishable – one addressed primarily to Gods *physis*, or *ousia*, and the other to his *dynamis*[15]. Further, one also finds two mediating argumentative settings that comment the both of the two major lines, connect them with the practical context of human, created existence, and give the system its common validity.

I find there are, then, altogether four speculative elements constituting an apophatic system in Gregory. The first element is an ontological argument concerning the division between created and uncreated[16], by which Gregory argues for a fundamental ontological difference between man and God with significant epistemological implications[17]. According to Gregory, the whole created order is bound in separation, difference, intervals, limitations and discontinuity in respect of time and space, that is, is in *diastema*[18] – or *is diastema* itself[19] – and always in a state of becoming, whereas there is no *diastema* or becoming in God; neither space nor time apply to the Creator of space and time. Man is *ktiston* and *diastematikon*, created and diastematic being, a mixed nature of intelligible and sensible, of spirit and corporeality, living according to his finite limits; God is *aktiston* and *adiastaton*, uncreated and undiastematic Being, and wholly spiritual, intelligible nature to which there is no limit. Human reason that operates according to its own diastematic constitution and conceives only things that are like itself cannot comprehend divine being and nature where there is no spatial or temporal extensions or limitations whatsoever, but which is to be understood in all respects as *apeiron*, infinite.

[14] See *CE* I.373-375, where (divine) *physis* and (uncreated) *dynamis* are treated as two equivalent terms in connection with the question of God's incomprehensibility as an 'unspoken principle' (*aphraston logon*) or 'first principle' (*arche*). For the idea of transcendent and connatural Power (in Gregory), see Michel René Barnes, *The Power of God, Dynamis in Gregory of Nyssás Trinitarian Theology* (Washington, 2000), 223ff., 260ff.

[15] For an illustration of this basic distinction in argumentation, see *CE* II.15; ... *kaí ousian kai dynamin kai aksian* ... The question of *rank* – or 'height' of being and honour – is actually discussed in relation to God's *ousia/physis* and *dynamis* (see *CE* I.161-190), and it receives its *special* emphasis in the argumentation of Eunomius; see *CE* II.52 and *CE* I.223-238.

[16] *CE* I.270-271, 295, 365-375; *CE* II.69-70

[17] On this subject, see Alden A. Mosshammer, 'The Created and Uncreated in Gregory of Nyssa', in L.F. Mateo-Seco and J.L Bastero (eds) *El 'Contra Eunomium I' en la produccion literaria de Gregorio de Nisa*, VI Cologuio internacional sobre Gregorio de Nisa, Colección Theológica 59 (Pamplona, 1988), 353-79.

[18] For the concept of *diastema*, see T. Paul Verghese, 'Diastema and Diastasis in Gregory of Nyssa, Introduction to a Concept and the posing of a Problem', in: H. Dörrie, M. Altenburger, and U. Schramm (eds): *Gregor von Nyssa und die Philosophie* (Leiden, 1976), 243-60.

[19] *In eccl.* (*GNO* V, 412, 14).

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The second element attaches directly to the first and leads the way to the third; it is Gregory's theory of language[20], the linguistic argument. Language is as inescapable a category for all theological discourse[21] as being is to all theological speculation. It is a necessary medium through which thoughts are expressed and communicated[22]. The expression of Christian faith, Trinitarian confession, is as bound to language as any other verbal or textual form of communication. It is thus absolutely necessary to define the actual indicative powers and limits of language in order to supply proper conceptions of the divine. It is basically to this question that Gregory has dedicated the second book of *Contra Eunomium*.

According to Gregory, language belongs to the created, diastematic order. Language, conceived as conventional and not ontic by Gregory[23], is not a God-given gift *as such*, with given concepts, but it is *based* on a God-given gift, *epinoia*, the faculty of abstract conception[24]. Language is essentially a human device and a man-made product; as man himself is a mixture of intellectual and corporeal nature, language is a medium fit to work in such a mixed reality, having its own natural constitution in corporeality. God, who is undiastematic, totally spiritual and intelligible, incorporeal nature, does not need language; nor can he be circumscribed according to his essential nature by the means of language[25]. Divine nature *is* utterly unnameable, indicated properly only by saying that it is above every name[26].

The names and attributes we apply to God must have another point of reference as they are still conceived of as being valid when talking about the divine. What we actually express by words, according to Gregory, are the *thoughts* that, again, are a mental construction of *experience*[27]. What gives us experience of God's being is his operation, an exercise of his power that meets us[28]. What men actually have named by using *epinoia* according to their shared experiences are the several energies of God[29] that constitute, sustain, and govern all created existence and make manifest God's power and the *existence* of powerful, operative divine nature beyond the creation. These things mark the actual limits of the indicative powers of language.

[20] For Gregory's theory of language, see Alden A. Mosshammer, 'Disclosing but not Disclosed, Gregory of Nyssa as Deconstructionist', in *Studien zu Gregor von Nyssa und der christlichen Spätantike*, ed. Hubertus R. Drobner, Supplements to Vigiliae christianae 12 (Leiden, 1990), 99-123, and Mortley (note 1).

[21] *CE* I.620-627; *CE* II.241-246, 255.

[22] *CE* II.47.

[23] *CE* II.125, 174, 252-261, 282-288, 395-402, 543-553. Again one fundamental divergence when compared to the Dionysian system.

[24] *CE* II.181-186.

[25] *CE* II.207-210, 390-393, 553

[26] Phil. 2:13. *CE* I.683.

[27] Definition of Mosshammer, 102. For Gregory's reflections, see *CE* II.168, 400-401, 572-580.

[28] *CE* II.102, 149.

[29] *CE* II.304, 583-587.

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The third element of Gregory's apophatic system, then, is an ousia-energeia distinction, used as an epistemological argument that gives the basic dynamics for the whole system. Gregory aims to show how the *ousia* and *energeia* of God are epistemologically related in their distinction and what kind of knowledge of God *is* possible. According to Gregory, the *ousia* and *energeia* of God coexist[30]; from the operation that we know, we can infer *that* there exists an operative essence. *What* that essence is, as essence, we cannot infer thereby[31]. In any event, when we speculate about God, it is in the *tension* of these two 'poles' of God's *is-ness* in relation to our life and all created existence[32].

When speculating on issues concerning the doctrine of the Church, one has to be aware of the (apophatic) principle that necessarily conditions these speculations. That principle is not immediately obvious for anyone, but one can learn it from the saints of the bible: the essence of God is beyond the reach of human reason and cannot be spoken of[33]. When, however, the focus is right, there remains a lot to learn about God, things that constitute proper knowledge and appropriate ways of speaking about him, without the illusion of having God's essence as a direct point of reference. The *energeiai* of God, according to which God is known, also make manifest his wisdom, goodness and power[34]. These are the things we are invited to explore with our mental faculties.

The fourth element of Gregory's apophatic system is, then, an argument concerning the goodness and power of God. This *argument from value* matches the *ontological* argument in finding its conclusion in the concept of infinity (*apeiron*). In Gregory's argumentation, goodness and power often constitute a pair to be introduced on the same occasion[35]. Evidently, good can also be conceived as an attribute embracing all the energies of God that make manifest God's power. It is equally true that God is to be conceived of as good and powerful *by nature*[36]: the essence of God's power and goodness is nothing other than the essence of God. Thus, although the ontological argument for the unknowability of God's nature is quite categorical in Gregory, this view *can*, however, *be challenged* by arguing that one can come to a knowledge of God's essence and *measure* it by contemplating his goodness and power – since they are understood as connatural and conceivable.

Gregory faces the challenge in the first book of *Contra Eunomium* by pointing out that the goodness and power of God must be *perfect* and *perfectly possessed* by God. They cannot be limited by any internal or external opposites making God 'more' or 'less' good and powerful; the goodness and power of

[30] *CE* I.207-211.
[31] *CE* II.71; *CE* I.207-211.
[32] *CE* II.148-154.
[33] *CE* II.97–105.
[34] *CE* II.78-81, 102-105.
[35] As for example, importantly, in the description of Abraham's assent, *CE* II.89.
[36] *CE* I.233-235, 276, 334-339; *CE* III.ix.6.

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God are unlimited (*aoriston*), and thus infinite (*apeiron*)[37]. Because they are infinite, they can never be circumscribed, and therefore comprehended, by discursive reason conclusively[38]. So one *can* advance in the knowledge of God by the way of contemplation to the extent that one participates in the perfection of God – but however much one learns, one always discovers that it is infinitely less than one desired to know[39]; it brings the contemplative mind no closer to any real comprehension of the essence of God[40]. One is still unable to define *what* God is according to his essential nature – and must turn to silence[41]. In another words: turn *away from speech* – which is the precise meaning of the word '*apophasis*'.

These four, to conclude – (1) a division between created and uncreated, (2) a theory of language, (3) an ousia-energeia distinction and (4) an argument concerning the goodness and power of God – are, I suggest, the elements that constitute a *system* that is to be called *apophatic* in Gregory. Philosophically, it is to be called *apophatic* because it relies on an axiom according to which the essential nature of God cannot be known; it is to called a *system* in the scientific sense, because the axiom becomes surrounded by scientific, universal, and *connected* arguments as to *how* it is so; and it is an *apophatic system*, because it produces conceptions that manifest apophaticism in Gregory. Finally, this apophatic system of Gregory is essentially a *theological* one by its motivation: it is to establish the basic starting points for understanding the inherent logic of the *Trinitarian confession* which must be accepted by faith – that alone, according to Gregory, is able to guide reason into proper conceptions about the divine.

[37] *CE* I.167-170.
[38] *CE* I.365-369.
[39] *CE* I.288-291.
[40] As Abraham experienced, *CE* II.89. See also *CE* I.364.
[41] *CE* I.314; *CE* II.105.

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La figure de Balaam chez les Cappadociens

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Si les chapitres 22-24 des Nombres tracent de Balaam un portrait ambigu où ressortent traits négatifs et aspects flatteurs, les traditions juives quasiment unanimes en font un personnage mauvais et pervers, magicien idolâtre, cupide, impie, insensé, menteur. Les traditions chrétiennes, pour leur part, semblent plus nuancées. Les textes du NT (Jude 11; 2 P 2, 15; Ap 2, 14) qui présentent un Balaam attiré par le salaire de l'injustice et l'appât du gain font écho à la légende noire du personnage évoquée par les textes juifs contemporains, mais, par la suite, un auteur comme Origène, en soulignant que Balaam annonce aux nations et à Israël la venue du Christ, montre le rôle positif qu'il joue dans l'économie du salut[1]. Comment cette grande figure vétéro-testamentaire est-elle perçue par les Pères Cappadociens? Ne font-ils que reprendre la tradition dont ils héritent ou l'infléchissent-ils?

Un constat s'impose d'abord: Balaam n'occupe pas une place égale dans l'œuvre des trois Cappadociens. Il apparaît une fois dans l'œuvre de Grégoire de Nazianze, trois fois dans celle de Basile si l'on y inclut le *Commentaire sur Isaïe* alors que six œuvres de Grégoire de Nysse le mentionnent et certaines assez longuement. Cela tient bien sûr à l'importance de la partie exégétique dans le corpus du Nysséen, mais également à son goût prononcé pour les grandes figures bibliques.

Grégoire de Nazianze évoque brièvement Balaam dans le *Contre Julien*[2]. S'il reconnaît en lui le magicien, l'astrologue non-israélite, le monde démoniaque hostile au Dieu véritable, il retient surtout du personnage le fait que, paradoxalement, malgré tous ses maléfices, il prophétise la vérité. Grégoire le compare à la pythonisse d'Endor qui fait apparaître Samuel et aux démons qui confessent Jésus malgré eux. Dans tous ces cas, c'est l'ennemi de la foi qui témoigne de sa vérité, ce qui a pour conséquence de la rendre davantage crédible. Le dernier Balaam de l'histoire, ultime avatar de cet être paradoxal, c'est l'empereur Julien qui, lui aussi, témoigne de la vérité malgré lui en faisant surgir des entrailles de victimes qu'il sacrifie une croix entourée d'une couronne. Intéressante actualisation de l'augure païen, devenu quasiment une

[1] Voir J.R. Baskin, 'Origen on Balaam: the dilemma of the unworthy prophet', *VC* 37 (1983), pp. 22-35.

[2] 4.54 (ed. J. Bernardi *SC* 309 (1983), p. 158).

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figure symbolique, contraint de révéler ce qu'il combat et cherche à faire disparaître, l'utilisation qu'en fait Grégoire de Nazianze révèle un être ambigu: le fonds du personnage est bien négatif, ce que renforce son identification à l'ennemi par excellence, Julien l'apostat, mais de lui sort la vérité.

Basile, quant à lui, mentionne Balaam dans la *Lettre* 210[3] qu'il adresse, après sa rupture avec Eustathe en 375, à des notables laïcs de Néo-Césarée et dans laquelle il dénonce l'erreur de leur évêque, Atarbios, qui l'accuse d'être un arianisant, un novateur dangereux et pousse les habitants de Néo-Césarée à le fuir[4]. Ici Balaam sert moins de repoussoir que de point de comparaison face à un homme en qui Basile reconnaît un faux prophète, un propagandiste illuminé. En héritier dévoyé de Grégoire le Thaumaturge, 'ce second Moïse'[5], Atarbios s'attribue le don de prophétie mais sans faire preuve de la conscience scrupuleuse de Balaam qui renonce à aller contre la volonté de Dieu et à maudire Israël. Lui a au moins le mérite de ne pas s'obstiner dans l'erreur. Il y a bien là un éloge de Balaam, mais il reste relatif: en examinant sa conduite, on peut lui reconnaître des qualités, mais celles-ci ne font qu'accuser le haut degré de perversion d'un pseudo-prophète pire que lui. Entre le mage païen et l'évêque chrétien, la différence est que l'un s'est résolu à exprimer la volonté de Dieu tandis que l'autre s'est soumis à 'l'esprit menteur' envoyé 'aux fils de la désobéissance'. Si l'un s'est presque converti, l'autre a fait le chemin inverse et a renié sa foi.

Mention est également faite de Balaam par Basile dans son *Homélie sur la naissance du Christ*[6]. Appartenant à la race des mages perses qui possèdent l'art de la divination et recourent aux incantations et aux antipathies naturelles, il est l'auteur de la quatrième parabole qui a révélé la naissance du Christ à ses descendants se souvenant de l'antique prophétie. Si ce sont eux, ses descendants, qui ont été jugé dignes d'adorer les premiers le nouveau-né, c'est que le témoignage des ennemis est toujours plus digne de foi. Montrant combien les mages suivent à la lettre la prophétie de leur ancêtre, Basile cite un verset de la troisième parabole ('Il s'est étendu et reposé comme le lion... ceux qui te bénissent se trouvent bénis') dont il propose une lecture allégorique d'inspiration origénienne: come le lion désigne la qualité royale, le repos étendu la passion et la bénédiction la divinité, les mages apportèrent à l'enfant l'or, la myrrhe et l'encens, c'est-à-dire les attributs du roi, du mort et de Dieu. Ici, le rôle éminent joué par les descendants de Balaam dans la célébration de la révélation chrétienne rejaillit évidemment sur celui qui apparaît sous l'aspect positif de prophète messianique.

[3] Éd. Courtonne, t. II (1961), p. 197.

[4] Voir R. Pouchet, *Basile le Grand et son univers d'amis d'après sa correspondance* (Rome, 1992), pp. 480-482.

[5] Basile, *Sur le Saint-Esprit* 29.

[6] PG 31, pp. 1469-72.

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Si, finalement, Basile, à la suite d'Origène, en trace un portrait plutôt flatteur, pour l'auteur du *Commentaire sur Isaïe*, Balaam est de façon traditionnelle 'un augure, instigateur de débauche et d'idolâtrie'[7], celui qui incite les Israélites à se prostituer avec les Madianites. Cependant, indication unique chez les Cappadociens, même si elle se trouve déjà chez Origène, il est mis sur le même plan que Caïphe[8]. L'un et l'autre, en effet, malgré leur indignité, ont été les porte-parole de Dieu. C'est ce que dit Jn 11, 51 de Caïphe: 'Ce n'est pas de lui-même qu'il prononça ces paroles ("votre avantage c'est qu'un seul homme meure pour le peuple"), mais, comme il était grand-prêtre cette année-là, il fit cette prophétie qu'il fallait que Jésus meure pour la nation.' L'auteur du traité fait le commentaire suivant: Balaam n'a d'autorité que comme devin[9] et Caïphe que comme grand prêtre, car il n'y a pas en eux d'âme pure ni d'esprit illuminé capable de voir Dieu et d'en tirer la puissance. C'est suivant le plan divin, l'économie (οἰκονομικῶς) que le Logos se trouve en eux, il n'opère pas selon leur mérite, mais selon le moment opportun[10]. La qualité de prophète de Balaam est réduite au strict minimum: homme sans principe moral ou charismatique propre, il ne doit son statut qu'à sa fonction de devin dont Dieu se sert pour faire passer son message. Le portrait est nettement plus sombre que chez Basile.

Dans le corpus nysséen, Balaam est plus présent et apparaît comme une figure beaucoup plus centrale. Tout d'abord, il reste dans deux traités un personnage démoniaque auquel Dieu n'a pu parler. Dans le *De Pythonissa*[11], ce n'est pas vraiment Dieu qui s'adresse à Balaam, mais un simulacre, de la même manière que c'est pas le véritable Samuel qui est évoqué par la sorcière, mais une fausse image qui a contrefait ses paroles:

> Lorsque Balaam dit: 'J'écouterai ce que dira en moi Dieu' et qu'ensuite, ayant appris qu'il était agréable à Dieu qu'il ne maudisse pas les Israélites, il n'est plus allé 'comme d'habitude à la rencontre des présages' (Nb 24, 1), celui qui manque d'attention pensera qu'ici aussi le vrai Dieu a parlé à Balaam, mais le raisonnement montre que l'Écriture a appelé ainsi celui que Balaam croit être Dieu, non celui qui est réellement Dieu.

Dans un des petits écrits trinitaires, l'*Ad Eustathium*[12], qui veut prouver la divinité de l'Esprit, l'exemple de Balaam qui interroge Dieu sert à montrer que l'appellation de Dieu peut servir à désigner des réalités inférieures et qu'elle ne surpasse donc en rien les autres appellations divines puisque mêmes les démons reçoivent ce nom dans l'Écriture. Ce ne peut être en effet le Dieu véritable –

[7] PG 30, 629 C.

[8] Cf. PG 30, 125 A.

[9] μάντις, cf. Jos 13, 22 où il est qualifié ainsi.

[10] Cf. Nb 23, 23: 'Il n'y a pas de divination en Israël, au moment opportun, à Jacob et à Israël, sera dit ce qu'accomplira Dieu.'

[11] Éd. H. Hörner, *GNO* III, 2 (1987), p. 106, 3 s.

[12] Éd. F. Mueller, *GNO* III, 1 (1958), p. 9, 17 s.

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c'est contre toute vraisemblance – qui apparaît à Balaam, 'une sorte d'augure et de devin qui s'était assimilé l'enseignement des démons grâce à sa curiosité augurale'. C'est exclusivement la dimenson négative du magicien, exclu par nature de toute relation avec Dieu, qui est ici soulignée. Pour Origène déjà, l'interlocuteur de Balaam n'est pas forcément le vrai Dieu[13].

En revanche, Grégoire se place d'abord dans le sillage de son frère quand il souligne dans son *Homélie sur la naissance du sauveur*[14], avec une insistance toute rhétorique, la valeur des paraboles prophétiques qui font des mages 'les hérauts de la grâce':

> Celui qui fait se lever le soleil sur les justes et les injustes, qui répand la pluie sur les méchants et les bons a porté le rayon de la connaissance et la rosée de l'esprit même sur les lèvres étrangères: ces témoigages issus d'adversaires affermissent en nous davantage la vérité. Tu entends l'augure Balaam saisi d'une inspiration plus grande (ἐπιπνοίᾳ κρείττονι) prophétiser devant les étrangers; tu vois les mages, ses descendants, observer, selon la prédiction de leur ancêtre, le lever de l'étoile nouvelle.

Malgré sa qualité d'augure et de magicien étranger, Balaam est bien ici un prophète inspiré par Dieu, saisi d'une inspiration plus grande que celle, probablement, des démons. Dans *la Vie de Moïse*, tout en étant présenté comme un être que l'assistance de certains démons rend redoutable, il devient celui qui, possédé par l'inspiration divine qui a remplacé l'action des démons, abandonne la mantique et profère des paroles vraiment prophétiques[15]. Sa transformation apparaît plus profonde que celle de l'ânesse, instrument des démons qui finit par énoncer l'invincibilité du peuple de Dieu[16]: de la même manière, la horde des démons, à l'approche de Jésus, clame sa puissance surnaturelle[17], épisode également rapproché de celui de Balaam par Grégoire de Nazianze.

Mais pour cela il a fallu forcer sa nature qui est d'user de son art pour le mal: sa magie qui n'attaque pas de front, mais procède par des détours, consiste à asservir les hommes aux illusions variées de cette vie, c'est-à-dire aux plaisirs, et à les faire succomber à des passions qui les transforment en animaux, telle Circé ensorcelant les marins d'Ulysse[18]. Balaam est ici pour Grégoire avant tout celui qui conseille à Balak, selon la tradition post-biblique (Philon, Josèphe), d'inciter les filles de Moab et de Madian à séduire les fils d'Israël. Grégoire propos une interprétation morale de l'épisode: si la puissance magique de la volupté triomphe dès son apparition d'hommes invaincus

[13] Cf. *HomNb* 14.1. Une exégèse proche se rencontre chez Eusèbe d'Émèse (fragment sur Nb 22, 8; Robert Devreesse, *Les anciens commentateurs grecs de l'Octateuque et des Rois (Fragments tirés des chaînes)*, Studi e Testi 201 (Città del Vaticano, 1959), p. 97, fr. A) selon qui Balaam interroge non pas Dieu, mais son démon habituel, et chez Apolinaire.

[14] Éd. F. Mann, *GNO* X, 2 (1996), p. 245, 3 s.

[15] *Vie de Moïse* I.73-74.

[16] *Id.*, II.291.

[17] Cf. Mc 1, 24; 5, 7.

[18] *Id.*, II.316.

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par les armes et dresse contre eux le trophée du déshonneur[19], la magie est inefficace contre ceux qui vivent dans la vertu, car ils n'offrent aucune prise à la critique[20]. Seule la vertu, telle celle de Moïse, parce qu'elle est invincible, peut en triompher, d'où l'invitation à vivre dans la vertu pour échapper à l'emprise de la magie de Balaam.

Dans son *Homélie sur son frère Basile*[21], Grégoire met en parallèle la vie de Moïse avec celle de son frère, nouveau Moïse. Entre autres points de comparaison, il montre que Basile a lui aussi défait les puissances démoniaques, qu'il a réduit à néant les complots magiques de beaucoup, comme Moïse, par sa prière, avait changé en bénédiction la malédiction de Balaam. Grâce à l'action de Moïse qui réussit à le convertir – il y a ici un infléchissement volontaire de la part de Grégoire car, dans le récit biblique, c'est Dieu par l'intermédiaire de l'ânesse qui opère cette conversion –, Balaam, qui offre ici son image la plus positive, devient l'exemple d'une transformation réussie: Basile à son tout a su déjouer par son charisme l'effet des mauvaises sorcelleries[22]. Le rôle de Moïse est nettement souligné dans son traité *Sur les titres ds psaumes*: 'Moïse transforma la magie de Balaam en piété, lui dont on rapporte (ἱστόρηται) que la fin fut plus élevée que la vie'[23]. Cette phrase, à elle seule, fait problème. La question est de savoir à qui se rapporte cette dernière proposition. Est-ce à Moïse? Ce serait l'unique relative introduite par le relatif au génitif qui viendrait interrompre la longue série des participes au nominatif précédés de l'article (quatorze occurrences au total). Il serait en outre étrange que l'allusion à la mort de Moïse survienne avant la mention de l'ascension du mont Nébo. C'est donc bien la fin de Balaam qui fut plus élevée que sa vie. Il pourrait s'agit d'une allusion à la fin de la vie de Balaam, période où il profère ses paraboles messianiques, mais le mot τελευτή évoque plutôt sa mort. Selon certaines sources donc, la mort de Balaam fut meilleure que sa vie. Peut-on identifier ces sources? La mort de Balaam est rapportée en Nb 31, 8: lors de la guerre de Madian, 'ils tuèrent Balaam fils de Beôr à coups de glaive avec leurs blessés à mort'. Auparavant, Balaam a émis le vœu que son âme puisse mourir parmi les âmes des justes et que sa descendance puisse devenir comme leur descendance (Nb 23, 10). Si Balaam est bien mort de la main des justes Israélites, donc parmi les âmes des justes, ces minces allusions n'indiquent pas que cette mort ait revêtu un caractère particulier, supérieur à sa vie: ce n'est donc pas du récit biblique que le Nysséen tire son renseignement. On trouve des indications dans la littérature légendaire juive. Si elles sont négatives, conformes à l'image général du personnage, elles ont l'intérêt de rapprocher la figure de Balaam de celle de Jésus, bien évidemment positive pour un chrétien.

[19] *Id.*, II.302.
[20] *Id.*, II.291 s.
[21] Éd. O. Lenolle, *GNO* X, 1 (1990), p. 129, 11 s.
[22] Voir M. Harl, *Le déchiffrement du sens* (Paris, 1993), p. 361, 366.
[23] *Sur les titres des psaumes* 14, 40 (éd. J. Reynard, *SC* 466 (2002)).

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Or dans ces textes la mort de Balaam présente plusieurs points de ressemblance avec celle de Jésus, notamment l'âge où elle s'est produite, trente-trois ans dans les deux cas. D'ailleurs, en *Sanhédrin* 106 b ainsi qu'en d'autres passages, Balaam aurait été utilisé comme pseudonyme de Jésus. Il s'agit là cependant d'une hypothèse récusée par L. Ginzberg[24]. Il est possible qe Grégoire ait eu connaissance de récits qui célébraient Balaam comme prophète messianique et faisaient un parallèle entre sa mort et celle de Jésus. Mais de telles traditions sont tardives, puisque le NT fait écho à la même vision négative que les textes rabbiniques.

Des trois Cappadociens, le Nysséen est clairement celui qui exploite le plus les multiples façettes du personnage et qui donne de lui l'image la plus riche et la plus positive. Mais chez lui aussi deux Balaam nettement distincts apparaissent: l'un inspiré par les démons, l'autre par Dieu, l'un magicien, l'autre prophète, sans que Grégoire ne semble soucieux, d'une œuvre à l'autre, de surmonter la contradiction. Être paradoxal, Balaam reste, durant sa vie, l'un et l'autre, penchant tantôt vers le mal, tantôt vers le bien et seule sa mort peut en définitive résoudre la contradiction.

[24] Cf. *The Legends of the Jews*, vol. VI (Philadelphia, 1959), notes 722 et 855. Voir Abraham Geiger, 'Bileam and Jesus', *Wissenschaftliche Zeitschrift für Jüdische Theologie* VI [1847], 31-37.

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The Date of Gangra and a Point of Comparison Between Basil's Small and Great Asketikon

Anna M. SILVAS, Armidale

Sometime in the mid-fourth century a synod of bishops convened in Gangra, the metropolis of Paphlagonia. The concluding document addressed the bishops of Armenia on what should be the Church's approach to certain exaggerations of ascetic enthusiasm, especially the disparagement of marriage. Clearly this was a perennially useful topic, since the canons of this local council found their way into the earliest strata of the canon law of the Church, both East and West. It is a point worth noting that most of the ancient collections place the canons of Gangra before those of the 'Dedication' Council of Antioch in 341.

Nevertheless, the dating of Gangra has been subject to some debate[1], because the opening salutation of its prefatory letter lists the thirteen participating bishops without their sees, which makes their identification something of a question[2]. Scholars such as Tillemont, Maran, Gwatkin, Leclercq, and Gribomont placed the Council in about 340. On this traditional view, the first-named bishop would be Eusebius of Nicomedia, then bishop of Constantinople, who died late in 341[3]; the Eulalius would be the very father of that Eustathius whose ascetic followers were censured by the council. It has been long noted that three of the signatories have the same names as bishops who attended the council of Sardica in 343, whose sees are known: Bithynicus of Zela in Pontus, Philetus of Juliopolis (western Galatia), and Proaeresius of Sinope on the Black Sea north of

[1] For discussion on the date of Gangra, see Mansi II, 1095-96, n. 1, Charles J. Hefele, *A History of the Councils of the Church*, vol. 2, tr. Henry Nutcombe Oxenham (Edinburgh: T. & T. Clarke, 1876), 325-39, at 337-9 (a very unsatisfactory account). On the 340 dating, see Jean Gribomont, 'Le Monachisme au IVe s. en Asie Mineure: de Gangres au Messalianisme', *Stu P* 64 (1957), 400-15, and 'Saint Basile et le Monachisme Enthousiaste', *Irenikon: Revue des Moines de Chevetogne* 53 (1980), 123-44. T.D. Barnes argues for a dating in the late 350s, in 'The Date of the Council of Gangra', *JTS* new ser. 40 (1989), 121-4.

[2] The letter begins: 'to the most honoured lords in Armenia, fellow ministers with us, Eusebius, Aelianus, Eugenius, Olympius, Bithynicus, Gregory, Philetus, Pappus, Eulalius, Hypatius, Proaeresius, Basil, Bassus, who have assembled in the holy synod at Gangra, greetings in the Lord'. A translation by Henry R. Percival also appears in "Nicene and Post-Nicene Fathers" series 2, vol. 14 (New York, 1900) 91-101, but was not consulted here.

[3] Eusebius 'died a short time after that Synod [of Antioch in October 341] was held' (Socrates, *HE* 2.12).

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Paphlagonia[4]. Though it has been suggested that the Gregory is Gregory the Elder, father of Gregory Nazianzen, this seems unlikely, since Nazianzus was well to the south in lower Cappadocia, whereas the geographic conspectus of the council seems to be the broad sweep of northern Anatolia.

There are, I believe, good and even new arguments that support the dating of Gangra to about 340/341, but they cannot all be pursued here. Within the limits of this communication, I confine myself to a statement of Fedwick, in his 1980 'Chronology'[5]. He argues that Gangra should be dated late, in the 360s or even the 370s, basing himself on a comparison of the successive editions of Basil's *Asketikon*. Fedwick alleged that evidence of the correctives of the Eustathians' excesses appears only in Basil's *Great Asketikon* from the 370s and not in the first edition, the *Small Asketikon*, dating from the mid to late 360s. In such a late scenario, the Eusebius might be thought to be Basil's predecessor in Caesarea.

However, my own comparison of the early edition of *Asketikon* and the later suggests that Basil was already tacitly implementing some of the Gangra correctives even in his first edition[6]. Consider the following instances.

1. As the concluding paragraph to the Gangra Preface deplores the fissiparous individualism of the enthusiasts, so too, the *Small Asketikon* targets individualism and all symptoms of self-pleasing (RBas 3.26 / LR 7); Basil inculcates an obedience diametrically opposed to the independent, if not to say arrogant manner of the enthusiasts (RBas 70.3 / SR 38). Basil in his earliest edition argues very strongly for the necessity of the cenobitic life, that is, the ordered life in communion and the imperatives that flow from it[7].

[4] Documented in a fragment of an otherwise lost work of St Hilary of Poitiers, *Against Valens and Ursacius*. See S. Hilarii Episcopi Pictaviensis *Opera*, Pars Quarta, ed. Alfred Feder S.I., CSEL 65 (Vienna: F. Tempsky and Leipzig: G. Freytag, 1916). The names occur in the subscriptions to the creed in Book 1 (= Fragmenta Historica A.IV.3): p. 75, (24) *Prohaeresius episcopus a Sinopa*; (29) *Bitinicus episcopus a Zelon*; and p. 76, (33) *Filetus episcopus a Iuliopoli*. For an English translation, see Lionel L. Wickham, *Hilary of Poitiers: Conflicts of Conscience and Law in the Fourth-century Church*, Translated Texts for Historians (Liverpool: Liverpool University Press, 1997), p. 39. Other names in this list of bishops may be remarked: p. 74, (2) *Olympius episcopus Doliceus*; (6) *Eulalius episcopus ab Amasias*; p. 75, (17) *Dianius episcopus a Caesarea*; (23) *Basilius episcopus ab Anquira*.

[5] P.J. Fedwick, 'A Chronology of the Life and Works of Basil of Caesarea', in Fedwick (ed.), *Basil of Caesarea, Christian, Humanist, Ascetic: A Sixteen-Hundredth Anniversary Symposium*, 2 vols (Toronto: Pontifical Institute of Medieval Studies, 1981), 1, 15, n. 81.

[6] Another assertion of Fedwick, in the same note, is that Basil's doctrine of the 'equality of sins' is found only in the *Great Asketikon* and not in the *Small Asketikon*. But see SR 4 (RBas 17). The Numbering of S(horter) R(ules) and L(onger) R(ules) is that of the *recensio vulgata* in PG 31; numbering of RBas is that of Rufinus' version (ed. K. Zelzer, CSEL 86 (1986)).

[7] Other examples of militancy against self-pleasing: the Gospel requires community life, RBas 3 (LR 7); one may not follow one's own unattested ideas about what is good, RBas 12 (SR 1); 'idiorrhythmic' tendencies are disallowed, RBas 30 (SR 86); one may not travel about without a mandate from the superior, RBas 80 (SR 120); one may not 'get back' at a superior by going on a hunger-strike, RBas 133 (SR 122); self-serving or ostentatious ascetic exaggerations are to be avoided because 'self-control' has reference above all to one's own will, RBas

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2. Gangra Preface 5 and Canons 6 and 7 had censured the Eutathians' tendency to assert their independence from local congregations, priests, and bishop and to commandeer the distribution of church funds to the poor. The *Small Asketikon* in turn promotes collaboration with local church authorities, teaching in RBas 31.4 (SR 187) that distributions of property are to be entrusted to 'those who preside over the local churches', that is, the local bishop or his deputy. Such is the similarity between the two texts there may even be verbal echoes[8].

3. One of the hyperascetics' tenddencies had been the loose association of men and women ascetics as shown, for example, by Glycerius and Aerius. The *Small Asketikon* envisages neither separate 'one-sex' communities nor 'mixed' communities where men and women ascetics live together indiscriminately. Instead, both sexes are brought together under the umbrella of a single ἀδελφότζς, but they live in separate houses and their meetings are subject to authorisation and witness (RBas 174 / SR 220).

As Gangra Preface 7 and Canons 13 and 17 had censured the adoption of male attire by women ascetics, so in the *Small Asketikon* the community observes a distinction between male and female dress (RBas 143.2 / SR 210) and, implicitly, RBas 11.27-30 (LR 22.3-40)[9].

4. Almost transparently answering the complaints addressed in Gangra, Canon 16, Basil teaches that children brought to the community must be received from their parents to the testimony of many witnesses (RBas 7.14 / LR 15.1), so as not to give a pretext to 'those of ill-will'.

5. RBas 144 (SR 50) echoes the misgivings of Gangra, Preface 4 and Canon 12, over the use by ascetics of exaggerated clothing, usually of an ostentatious meanness. In addition, Basil's care to speak only of the 'clothing fitting for a Christian' again displays an almost transparent sensitivity to Gangra's concerns on this point.

6. RBas 168 (SR 248) appears to be dealing with the temptation to *gnosis* or spiritual elitism. This was a standard feature of the Anatolian hyperascetics from the extreme Eusthathians of mid fourth century to the Messalians at century's end.

88, 89, 129 (SR 128, 129, 90); private fasting is entirely subordinated to the common life, RBas 181 (SR 137).

[8] It is very likely Basil took example from Macrina here (Gregory of Nyssa, *Vita Sanctae Macrinae*, ed. V. Woods Callahan, in GNO VIII/1 (1952), 345-414, at 393.15-18; tr. Virginia Woods Callahan, in *Gregory of Nyssa, Ascetical Works*, FC 58 (Washington: Catholic University of America Press, 1967), pp. 177-8), who had made this her practice as far back as the mid 350s. Reinforcing this disposition within the community are RBas 98, 99, 186 (SR 100, 87, 91): ministering to the poor belongs to those duly entrusted with the task.

[9] This had also been Macrina's practice (*Vita Sanctae Macrinae*, GNO VIII, 1, 403.5-6; tr. Woods Callahan, p. 184). A distinction of dress may also be inferred from Letter 2 (ed. and tr. Roy J. Deferrari, LCL, I (1926), I, 20-1), where Basil frowns on men wearing their belts high on the waist as γυναικῶδες, womanish or effeminate.

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7. Gangra, Preface 9 and Canon 2, dealt with the importance attached by the hyperascetics to distinctions between classes of foods. Basil certainly encountered Judaizers of whom this was true and perhaps Manichaeans as well. In RBas 181 (SR 137), he rules out such an attitude for Christians.

8. RBas 87 (SR 97) deals with another tendency of the enthusiasts – 'ascetic homelessness'. Basil takes a pastoral approach. These wanderers would be better won over to stability in the community, but, because of potential duplicity, careful discernment in their regard is necessary.

9. RBas 127 (SR 207) addresses another typical temptation of the hyperascetics – to consider themselves beyond the necessity of mundane work. Basil, on the contrary, could hardly insist more strongly than he does on the necessity of diligent work in the communities. Its basis, however, is not that of serving oneself, but of obeying the dominical and apostolic call to serve the needy; for one's own needs one must trust to the Lord's provision through the community.

10. The discourse of Gangra's epilogue (or 'Canon 21') should be noted – the emphasis on the scriptures, the sense of the one 'Church of God' and the necessity of being included in it, the avoidance of a specialized terminology for Christian ascetics. All of these aspects of Gangra's style are also characteristic of Basil's own discourse in the *Small Asketikon*.

Thus, I have isolated some ten points of comparison which demonstrate that Basil must have been at least implicitly aware of Gangra's censures of ascetic excesses even at the earliest stage of the *Small Asketikon*, from the mid 360s.

That Basil never mentions the council explicitly is not too difficult to explain if we accept the traditional identification of the first listed bishop as Eusebius of Nicomedia. For Basil, the memory, though not the doctrine, of Gangra would have been clouded by its being held under the auspices of this leading Arian bishop; for example, in Letter 263 he speaks of 'Eusebius of Constantinople, who indeed was second to no one in sponsoring the impious doctrine of Arius'[10].

It is true that other topics appear in the *Great Asketikon* that clearly relate to issues raised at Gangra, namely, cautions against the communities' accepting runaway slaves (LR 11), mutual consent of spouses required for the entrance of the married into monastic life (LR 12), chapels and feasts of the martyrs not to be spurned (LR 40), the Eucharist normally to be celebrated in a properly constituted church, not in private dwellings (SR 310), and so forth. But what the evidence above suggests is that these instances do not mean that the concerns of Gangra only appear for the first time in the *Great Asketikon*, but that the hyperascetic enthusiasm, spiritual elitism, and independence of the Church already met with in Grangra in the 340s and implicitly cautioned against in the *Small Asketikon* in the 360s went on recurring to the century's end, reaching

[10] Deferrari IV (1934), 94-5 (tr. modified).

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their apogee in the phenomenon of Messalianism. Throughout the 360s and 370s Basil laboured at the catechesis and genuine reform of the ascetic life, especially in his meetings with the superiors of the local communities.

The conclusion of this paper is that any argument for a late dating of Gangra based on a supposed distinction of the *Small Asketikon* and the *Great Asketikon* is not borne out by the evidence.

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L'aspetto antropologico 'della legge di natura' in Gregorio di Nazianzo

Norbert WIDOK, Opole

Gregorio di Nazianzo (†390) appartiene agli scrittori paleocristiani che facevano largo uso del tesoro lessicale della letteratura antica, introducendone, con abilità, parole in una riflessione teologica. Tra le molte parole presenti nelle opere del pensatore della Cappadocia, la parola φύσις merita attenzione. Questo termine svolgeva un grande ruolo nella lingua greca classica, soprattutto nella letteratura filosofica. Nei testi di Gregorio si ripete più di cinquecento volte, di cui circa quattrocentocinquanta applicazioni della stessa significano direttamente un aspetto teologico, essendo un termine adottato nell'ambito della cosmologia, antropologia, trinitaria, cristologia ed angelologia[1]. Il destinatario greco delle sue istruzioni si rendeva perfettamente conto del significato della parola φύσις quando si definiva con la medesima il mondo della natura. Comunque, questa è una realtà improntata da bellezza di forme e da armonia di elementi coesistenti, e che si distingue per perfezione e ordine interno.

Un confronto lessicale particolarmente interessante è quindi quello sulla presenza nelle opere del Cappadoce dell'abbinamento di φύσις con la parola che significa 'legge', dunque νόμος, oppure dei suoi equivalenti semantici: λόγος, τάξις e θεσμός. Gregorio si è servito undici volte delle espressioni di questo tipo, di cui proprio dieci applicate a diversi aspetti di concetto di uomo come di parte inseparabile della natura, oppure per la presentazione della natura umana in Cristo.

1. Νόμος φύσεως

La parola νόμος, nella lingua greca antica, apparteneva ai concetti fondamentali della riflessione di quel tempo, soprattutto filosofica. Nel corso dei secoli fu sottoposta a cambiamenti semantici[2]. Proviene dal verbo νέμω (asse-

[1] Un'analisi semantica precisa delle applicazioni della parola φύσις in Gregorio è stata fatta da N. Widok, *'Physis' w pismach Grzegorza z Nazjanzu. Studium z teologii patrystycznej* (Opole, 2001).

[2] Lo sviluppo semantico della parola νόμος a partire dai tempi più antichi con una particolare attenzione all' uso di questa parola nell' opera di Platone *Diritti* ha elaborato M. Maykowska, *Quaestiones Platonicae selectae* (Varsavia, 1949).

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gnare, tenere come propria parte) e prima significava una parte di vantaggi data nell'insieme e di obiettivi da realizzare: dunque un' assegnazione ottenuta diventava un diritto. Col passare del tempo νόμος perdeva gradualmente il significato passivo a vantaggio di quello attivo, e definì ciò che stabilisce le assegnazioni, cioè i diritti[3]. Nelle opere di Platone la parola νόμος è vicina semanticamente ai concetti di 'ordine' e 'assetto'[4]. In questo modo, il campo semantico stabilito della parola νόμος è diventato nella produzione letteraria degli scrittori greci un'espressione contraria a φύσις. L'antitesi νόμος – φύσις appariva nelle lettere insolitamente spesso, a partire da Ippocrate fino alla filosofia degli stoici[5]. Da qui si pone una domanda riguardante la creazione e l'uso dell'espressione νόμος φύσεως, nonostante che l'antitesi dei due significati delle parole su citate fosse così radicata nella mentalità dei pensatori greci. Risulta che questa espressione è apparsa solo cinque volte nella letteratura greca precristiana, però ogni volta richiedeva una spiegazione per quanto riguarda la correttezza dell'uso. È presente nelle lettere di Platone (due volte), Teofrasto, Ocello Lucano e Dionisio di Alicarnasso[6].

Per la prima volta l'espressione νόμος φύσεως è stata introdotta nella letteratura greca da Filone di Alessandria utilizzata circa trenta volte. Il nuovo concetto semantico di tale espressione consisteva nell'abbinare il concetto greco di φύσις come di potere universale con la fede ebraica nel potere universale della Legge Divina[7]. Le opere di Filone che influiscono in modo rilevante sullo sviluppo del pensiero cristiano, soprattutto della teologia alessandrina, sono diventate anche una fonte per trovare le definizioni e i termini così tanto necessari per spiegare la Rivelazione negli scrittori dei primi secoli. Gregorio utilizzava – come indicato – le espressioni già adattate e registrate dai predecessori.

Le parole chiavi, cioè νόμος e φύσις, unite nell'espressione νόμος φύσεως, si possono trovare nel testo in cui Gregorio incoraggia i suoi ascoltatori alla moderazione e al buon senso nei comportamenti interpersonali. Secondo lui possiamo raggiungere tale stato d'animo 'se sappiamo procedere come si deve e lodare la legge della natura'[8]. In questa istruzione Gregorio fa

[3] Ibidem, pp. 5-6.

[4] Ibidem, pp. 16-17.

[5] L'esame linguistico e fondamentale di quest' antitesi negli scrittori greci è diventato oggetto delle elaborazioni di alcuni autori: F. Heinimann, *Nomos und Physis. Herkunft und Bedeutung einer Antithese im griechischen Denken des 5. Jahrhunderts* (Basel, 1945); M. Pohlenz, 'Nomos und Physis', *Hermes* 81 (1953), 418-38; H.-M. Simon, *Die alte Stoa und ihr Naturbegriff. Ein Beitrag zur Philosophiegeschichte des Hellenismus* (Berlin, 1956), pp. 85-93; A.W.H. Adkins, *From the Many to the One. A Study of Personality and Views of Human Nature in the Context of Greek Society, Values and Beliefs* (London, 1970), pp. 110-26.

[6] H. Koester, 'Νόμος φύσεως. The Concept of Natural Law in Greek Thought', in J. Neusner (ed.), *Religions in Antiquity. Essays in Memory of Erwin Ramsdell Goodenough* (Leiden, 1970), p. 524.

[7] Ibidem, p. 522.

[8] *Oratio* 32.7 (SCh 318, p. 98, r. 4): ἐὰν εἰδῶμεν κόσμον καὶ ἐπαινῶμεν φύσεως νόμον.

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presente ai lettori le regole codificate nel loro temperamento spirituale dalle quali dovrebbero farsi guidare. Queste norme che caratterizzano l'esistenza umana sono così durevoli ed invariabili che, essendo regole che non si possono distruggere, diventano legge (νόμος). Allora, se νόμος si unisce con φύσις, ancora di più contribuisce a esporre il valore semantico di questa parola che esprime l'ordine regolare di vita di tutta la natura. Se poi riguarda persone, allora bisogna percepirlo in prospettiva etica.

L'espressione νόμος φύσεως viene utilizzata dallo studioso Cappadoce anche nel contesto dei comportamenti umani relativi all'acquisizione delle virtù. Ammira quelli che per motivi ascetici si nutrono di cenere con le lacrime evitando il pane e l'acqua. Commenta però il loro atteggiamento nel modo seguente: 'Mi sembra che loro superino le leggi della natura'[9]. La situazione descritta riguarda leggi della natura dell'uomo, cioè il consumare il cibo adeguato per mantenersi in vita. Questo è l'obbligo fondamentale della vita biologica espresso in questo brano tramite la parola νόμοι, che indica nello stesso tempo le regole dell'esistenza umana che non si possono distruggere. Le stesse sono contenute nel complesso delle regole esistenti nella natura, il che nel testo è stato indicato usando la parola φύσις. Il fatto che Gregorio si è servito dell'espressione νόμος φύσεως nel contesto dei comportamenti ascetici dell'uomo fa notare, senza dubbio, il suo rapporto con la natura circostante, di cui egli pure è una particella inseparabile.

Il seguente testo sottolinea le regole che legano l'umanità con la realtà: 'Eppure andremo nelle stesse ceneri! E se molto di più otteniamo in questi pochi giorni, come soltanto un po'più di male, ne saremo testimoni, oppure lo soffriremo da soli, oppure ancora persino lo compriremo, prima di rendere l'omaggio comune e necessario alla legge di natura'[10]. Il contenuto di questa riflessione è molto chiaro. Il corpo che contribuisce alla creazione dell'armonia psicofisica dell'uomo, dopo la sua morte viene sottoposto alle regole vigenti nel mondo della natura. I processi che si verificano e che comportano la sua decomposizione sono le regole risultanti dalla struttura essenziale della materia. Forza di questo genere è tale che nulla può resisterle, ossia è la legge (νόμος) esprimente il funzionamento fisico della natura (φύσις).

Lo stesso pensiero Gregorio di Nazianzo ha ripetuto in una delle lettere in cui ammira il destinatario, che durante la malattia fu in grado di 'lasciare il corpo alle sue sofferenze, perchè sia adesso, sia più tardi, il corpo andrà completamente a pezzi secondo la legge della natura'[11]. Anche in questo testo, tramite l'espressione νόμῳ φύσεως, l'autore si esprime in merito alla regola

[9] *Carmen* I.ii.19, 674 (PG 37, 729A): ἃ μοι δοκοῦσι καὶ φύσεως νικᾶν νόμους.

[10] *Oratio* 7.18 (SCh 405, p. 226, r. 31): λειτουργῆσαι τῷ τῆς φύσεως νόμῳ τὴν κοινὴν εἰσφορὰν καὶ ἀσάλευτον.

[11] *Epistula* 32.3, *Lettres*, ed. P. Gallay, t. I (Paris, 1964), p. 40: πάντως ἢ νῦν ἢ ὕστερον λυθησόμενον νόμῳ φύσεως.

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ontica (φύσις). Questa regola è così sicura ed irrevocabile che è stata chiamata legge (νόμος).

Nelle pagine delle sue opere, Gregorio solleva anche le questioni cristologiche. Parla dell'incarnazione di Cristo nel seguente modo: 'Si completa la figura di Melchisedek: quello che era senza madre, è senza padre, senza madre prima, senza padre dopo. Le leggi della natura vengono abolite'[12]. Nel testo citato il significato della parola φύσις si riferisce alle persone ed esprime il modo di mettere al mondo figli. Questo comportamento procreativo è invariabile, in quanto proprio esso costituisce la regola iscritta nel genere umano. Come nota l'oratore, questa regolarità evidente è stata scossa nel momento in cui Cristo è venuto al mondo, significando che Egli era prima senza madre, in riferimento alla Sua preesistenza, e dopo senza padre, prendendo in considerazione il modo della Sua concezione. Il comparire Cristo in questo modo nella realtà terrena andava oltre le regolarità osservabili, che nel su citato discorso sono state chiamate leggi (νόμοι).

La questione relativa all'incarnazione apparteneva alle priorità di insegnamento teologico di Gregorio. In uno dei suoi discorsi dimostra l'esistenza delle doppie realtà unite in Cristo dopo la Sua incarnazione. La loro differenza viene spiegata nel modo seguente: 'È stato mandato, ma come uomo, poichè aveva una doppia natura, in quanto secondo la legge della natura si stancava, aveva fame, sete, si spaventava e piangeva'[13]. In questo brano l'autore fa notare l'umanità di Cristo Incarnato, invocando i comportamenti 'del tutto'umani nella Sua attività pubblica. Citandoli, mette in rilievo la veridicità del piano umano nella figura di Cristo. Tale stato della condizione umana viene confermato da Gregorio con l'espressione νόμῳ φύσεως. La parola φύσις non si riferisce solo ed esclusivamente alla dimensione umana, ma alla natura intesa complessivamente, a cui partecipa l'umanità. Per questo motivo è una definizione che esprime le regole fisiche e biologiche, per mezzo delle quali si distingue la parte umana della natura. In modo simile a quanto sopra, anche in questo caso, tali comportamenti appartengono a modi fissi in cui l'uomo reagisce e che possiamo definire complessivamente usando il concetto di νόμος. Quando Gregorio si pronunciava in merito alla natura umana di Cristo Incarnato, pensava proprio a questo stato della condizione umana.

2. Νόμος καὶ τάξις φύσεως

Estremamente univoco nel suo contenuto è un discorso dell'autore indirizzato alle persone responsabili del consolidamento dei valori morali nella società:

[12] *Oratio* 38.2 (SCh 358, p. 106, r. 9): νόμοι φύσεως καταλύονται.

[13] *Oratio* 45.27 (PG 36, 660C): ἐπεὶ καὶ ἐκοπίασε, καὶ ἐπείνησε, καὶ ἐδίψησε, καὶ ἠγωνίασε, καὶ ἐδάκρυσε, νόμῳ φύσεως.

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La cosa migliore è un accordo e un'intesa comune tra i paesi e i popoli e le famiglie, nonchè le singole persone che seguono la legge e l'ordine della natura, che ha diviso e legato tutto e ad ogni essere ha conferito la forma di un mondo composto da molte forze naturali[14].

In questo testo φύσις si unisce con i verbi: διεῖλέ ('ha diviso'), συνέδησε ('ha legato'), πεποίηκε ('ha conferito'), che confermano il fatto che questa parola significa un' esistenza operante grazie al potere che sta nella medesima. Questo potere comporta che la natura dimostra la dinamicità creativa nei confronti dei suoi componenti, dei quali fa parte anche l'umanità. Le 'attività' elencate, che nel testo, in una certa misura, costituiscono la spiegazione della parola φύσις in quanto si riferiscono alla medesima, sono indirizzate ad ogni essere e creano un unico mondo (εἷς κόσμος) da molteplici elementi. È particolarmente importante la presenza dell'abbinamento delle parole φύσις e κόσμος. Da detto contesto risulta che κόσμος fa notare l'esistenza di un mondo ordinato, e φύσις la forza che crea in esso questo ordine, espresso con i verbi elencati che dimostrano la natura come un'esistenza avente potere proveniente da se stessa. Allora φύσις, essendo dotato del modo ordinato di procedere, è una personificazione di ogni regolarità. Gregorio non commenta precisamente questo pensiero, non suggerisce da dove viene questa regolarità ordinata inclusa nella parola φύσις. Comunque, in base a molti altri suoi interventi, risulta che essa è stata data dal Creatore. Per questo motivo, Gregorio raccomanda ai lettori di procedere secondo le regole ordinate, in quanto esse sono giuste e buone.

La questione più interessante è la comparsa in detto testo dell'espressione νόμῳ καὶ τάξει φύσεως, nella quale si possono intravedere le ripercussioni di un amalgama verbale introdotto da Filone. Il suo contenuto si riferisce, comunque, al potere che sta nella natura, conferitole dal Creatore. Sembra, però, che in questa espressione si tratti di uno spostamento dell'accento. Allora, se la parola φύσις significa 'natura' nel senso di una forza creativa che manifesta regole ordinate, la parola νόμος costituisce la sua definizione. La conferma di tale interpretazione è la presenza della seconda parola determinante, cioè τάξις, che significa l'ordine, la regolarità, la correttezza, ed è equivalente alla parola νόμος dal punto di vista grammaticale. In altre parole, i termini νόμος e τάξις esprimono le regole di andamento della natura (φύσις) come esistenza funzionante per se stessa. Se, però, queste regole riguardano le persone, quindi una parte del mondo creato, allora acquistano un carattere etico.

[14] *Oratio* 4.120 (SCh 309, p. 286, r. 7): νόμῳ καὶ τάξει φύσεως ἑπομένους ἢ πάντα διεῖλέ τε καὶ συνέδησε καὶ τὸ πᾶν τοῦτο κόσμον ἕνα ἐκ πλειόνων πεποίηκε.

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3. Νόμος καὶ λόγος φύσεως

Gregorio termina le riflessioni in merito al mistero dell'uomo con la seguente affermazione:

Potrei ancora raccontare molto per quanto riguarda le membra e le parti del corpo umano, e il loro completo adattamento reciproco tra sè, giacchè al fine dell'utilità, e contemporaneamente anche per la bellezza, si uniscono e distribuiscono, si pongono avanti e si ritirano, si armonizzano e si separano, all'unisono con la legge e il senso della natura'[15].

In questa descrizione, il funzionamento delle singole parti del corpo umano è stato definito usando un'altra espressione, vale a dire νόμῳ καὶ λόγῳ φύσεως. In tale espressione appare una nuova parola, λόγος, che nella lingua greca classica era una parola polisemica[16]. Sia φύσις sia λόγος, nelle opere degli autori del periodo precristiano, erano termini importanti per esprimere pensieri filosofici spesso molto complicati, costituendo nello stesso tempo due campi semantici indipendenti[17]. D'altra parte, il rapporto semantico di queste parole, che consiste nella loro dipendenza lessicale reciproca, proviene dalla filosofia stoica, nella quale si tendeva a stabilire una correlazione positiva tra esse, soprattutto quando entrambe, nello stesso tempo, si riferivano all'uomo. La formula stoica più conosciuta indica che il *logos* ordina il mondo delle divinità e delle persone: esso è la legge conforme alla natura (λόγος, ὅς ἐστι φύσει νόμος). In seguito, è stata creata una versione abbreviata, cioè λόγος φύσεως, che è stata adottata da Filone di Alessandria[18]. Inoltre Filone ha ripetuto dopo i filosofi stoici un' altra formulazione del pensiero contenuto in questa espressione: ὁ κόσμος φύσις λογική ('il cosmo è una natura razionale')[19]. In questo modo ha trasmesso tali espressioni direttamente agli autori paleocristiani. Se allora Gregorio di Nazianzo, in riferimento alle regole presenti nella natura, usa λόγος, afferma che le medesime sono giuste e razionali. Quindi, per mettere in rilievo le regole che sono percepite nella natura (φύσις), e concretamente nella vita biologica dell'uomo, Gregorio si è servito dei termini νόμος e λόγος a motivo della tradizione del loro uso.

Nel testo citato, entrambi i concetti, cioè νόμος e λόγος, hanno la stessa funzione semantica diventando sinonimi. In altre parole, il termine λόγος, utilizzato nello stesso contesto che presenta il testo, assume lo stesso ruolo

[15] *Oratio* 28.22 (SCh 250, p. 148, r. 28): νόμῳ καὶ λόγῳ φύσεως.

[16] Presenta ricchezza semantica della parola λόγος LSJ, pp. 1057-9.

[17] Esami semantici riguardanti questa questione tra l'altro sono stati svolti da A.L. Martorana, 'Il rapporto physis-logos in Senofane', *Sophia* (Padova) 37 (1969), p. 317-21; F. Wiplinger, *Physis und Logos. Zum Körperphänomen in seiner Bedeutung für den Ursprung der Metaphysik bei Aristoteles* (Wien, 1971).

[18] Processo di creazione di tale espressione viene descritto in modo più ampio da Koester, pp. 527-34.

[19] Vedi Simon, p. 96.

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semantico della parola νόμος. Per esempio, un altro brano del Cappadoce fa notare questo uso: 'Quando nasce il giorno, subito gli animali selvatici si ritirano in armonia, e l'uomo si sbriga per andare al lavoro. E così via, nell'ordine, uno cede all'altro secondo la legge razionale della natura'[20]. Il contenuto del passo conferma il pensiero di Gregorio, cioè che l'uomo costituisce una parte inseparabile della natura cooperando armoniosamente con tutti gli elementi del mondo creato. Questa coesistenza conforme e la creazione di una totalità integrale non sono casuali, ma risultano dalle regole che stanno nella natura. Volendo mostrarle il più precisamente, Gregorio ha deciso di servirsi delle parole che usava normalmente: τάξει νόμου καὶ λόγῳ φύσεως. Tutti i termini presenti in questa espressione erano già l'oggetto delle analisi lessicali. Comunque, nel brano appare inoltre un altro confronto, cioè τάξει νόμου, che per struttura verbale non differisce affatto dall'espressione successiva, cioè λόγῳ φύσεως. Allora Gregorio non ha identificato le parole νόμος e φύσις dal punto di vista del significato? Bisogna supporre che l'autore si è servito solo di una delle figure retoriche. Indipendentemente da questa questione retorica, la sua intenzione fondamentale è di mettere in rilievo, usando le parole τάξις, νόμος e λόγος, le norme ordinate che dimostrano bontà e forza, e che si riferiscono al modo esistere della natura insieme all'uomo, presente nella medesima, creando un' esistenza omogenea (φύσις).

Nel contesto, particolarmente interessante si presenta la parola λόγος nell'intervento del vescovo di Costantinopoli riguardante la provenienza del mondo da Dio. Afferma infatti che le cose a lui date od offerte bisogna trattarle 'come se appartenessero a Lui, e questo in base alla legge di natura e non a titolo di grazia'[21]. L'espressione che appare qui, λόγῳ φύσεως, fa notare un carattere del linguaggio giuridico. In riferimento alle esplicazioni in merito alla creazione del mondo da Dio, questa espressione prende un concreto riferimento. Se dunque Dio ha creato il mondo delle cose materiali, le stesse dovrebbero contenere alcuni Suoi tratti. Nel concetto di λόγος è stata formulata una di loro. La parola φύσις presente nel testo, usata in riferimento al mondo, fa notare le regole razionali del suo 'funzionamento'. La conseguenza di tale interpretazione è, quindi, far notare la fonte di provenienza del mondo della natura. Questo è l'unico luogo nella produzione letteraria di Gregorio in cui l'espressione 'legge di natura' si riferisce al rapporto tra Dio e il mondo.

4. Τάξις καὶ θεσμὸς φύσεως

L'uomo, come l'opera del Creatore, è molto spesso argomento delle riflessioni dell'autore Cappadoce. In riferimento all'idea di San Paolo riguardante

[20] *Oratio* 32.9 (SCh 318, p. 104, r. 12): καὶ ἀλλήλοις ὑποχωροῦμεν τάξει νόμου καὶ λόγῳ φύσεως.

[21] *Oratio* 30.9 (SCh 250, p. 242, r. 6): καὶ λόγῳ φύσεως, ἀλλ' οὐ χάριτος.

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l'importanza di tutte le parti del corpo umano (1 Cor 12,25), Gregorio conferma il suo significato e aggiunge che: 'le singole membra si prendono cura le une delle altre reciprocamente socondo l'ordine e la legge della natura, la quale allo stesso modo tutto ha congiunto insieme conservato'[22]. La riflessione del Nazianzeno costituisce un breve commento del testo biblico, nel quale egli si serve di una terminologia della scienza umanistica del suo tempo. Il potere convincente di tale commento è stato compreso nell'espressione τάξει καὶ θεσμῷ φύσεως. Questa volta φύσις si unisce con i termini τάξις e θεσμός. Il primo termine svolge la stessa funzione del precedente, dove significando l'ordine, la regolarità e la bontà, sostiene e completa semanticamente la parola νόμος. Il secondo invece, cioè θεσμός, che significa la legge divina, il diritto umano, la prescrizione, l'usanza, deve essere considerato come un sinonimo della parola νόμος. L'espressione θεσμός φύσεως è di provenienza stoica. Assunta da Filone di Alessandria è diventata adeguata all'espressione νόμος φύσεως. Entrambe sono invece definizioni della legge proveniente dal Creatore, che dirige il mondo creato secondo φύσεως νόμοις καὶ θεσμοῖς[23]. Infatti l'autore Cappadoce ha adottato questa espressione dalla tradizione lessicale greca per servirsene al fine di interpretare l'intervento di Paolo. Nel testo citato, egli indica un breve chiarimento per quanto riguarda il significato della parola θεσμός: una legge 'che allo stesso modo tutto ha congiunto insieme e conservato', dunque così come per la parola νόμος. Allora, sia la parola τάξις, sia l'espressione θεσμός, sono un'interpretazione delle regole e delle norme presenti nel funzionamento biologico dell'organismo umano che pure è una particella del mondo creato, cioè φύσις.

I testi sopra specificati appartengono agli interventi di Gregorio che mettono in rilievo il dinamismo del mondo della natura consistente nelle regole e norme invariabili di esistenza di ogni essere che si possono osservare. Tale senso è compreso nell'espressione che è oggi spesso usata, vale a dire 'legge di natura'. L'analisi dei testi di Gregorio che contengono questa espressione ha dimostrato che la medesima viene da lui usata come un tentativo di definire una forza creativa che sta nella natura. Le regole e le norme, che scaturiscono nelle attività di percezione del 'funzionamento' di tutta la natura, sono caratterizzate dalla costanza e dall'invariabilità, sono condizionate da un determinismo necessario. L'intreccio di tali condizionamenti viene definito proprio con la parola νόμος, che si può intendere come un'immagine o un rimando del termine invariabile φύσις.

Nelle opere dell'autore Cappadoce, il senso dell'espressione 'legge di natura' viene dato tramite l'abbinamento di alcune parole a φύσις nella fun-

[22] *Oratio* 6.8 (SCh 405, p. 142, r. 25): τάξει καὶ θεσμῷ φύσεως, τῷ δι' ἀλλήλων τὰ πάντα συνδήσαντι καὶ φυλάξαντι.

[23] Koester, pp. 530-3.

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zione di complemento del genitivo. Alle stesse appartengono i termini: νόμος, λόγος, τάξις e θεσμός. Dalle analisi fatte del contesto, risulta che si tratta dei sinonimi introdotti da Filone di Alessandria, il quale, successivamente, si è basato su riferimenti lessicali dei filosofi stoici. In modo particolare, comunque, bisogna mettere in rilievo che le espressioni usate da Gregorio, create da diversi abbinamenti di parole enumerate e tutte tradotte come 'legge di natura', si riferiscono all'uomo (con una sola eccezione: rapporto a Dio), al fine di presentare la sua dipendenza dalle regole seguite da tutta la natura. Due volte l'autore pensa all'elemento umano in Cristo incarnato. I suoi discorsi in merito dimostrano che il genere umano viene concepito come una parte inseparabile del mondo creato, nonostante molti privilegi concessigli dal Creatore. L'uso di questa espressione, al fine di indicare solo la dipendenza reciproca tra il genere umano e il resto della natura, non è casuale nei testi del Cappadoce, ma è intenzionale. Risulta, però, che oltre a νόμος φύσεως, nelle sue opere è presente l'espressione νόμος κτίσεως, cioè 'legge della creazione'[24].

I citati aspetti di contesto, verificatisi per motivo della presenza dell'espressione νόμος φύσεως nei discorsi di Gregorio, presentano il senso fisico, biologico ed etico in riferimento all'uomo come parte inseparabile della natura. Nel contesto delle considerazioni in merito al posto dell'uomo nella natura e delle relazioni reciproche che ne risultano, gli aspetti enumerati sono l'oggetto di numerosi studi della teologia contemporanea relativa alla creazione, nonchè dell'etica e della morale, in base alle premesse filosofiche (a partire dagli autori greci alla filosofia contemporanea)[25] o bibliche[26]. Gregorio di Nazianzo non è però trattato nelle materie di cui sopra.

[24] Vedi a titolo di esempio: *Oratio* 6.14 (SCh 405, p. 158, r. 8).

[25] Ecco alcuni di loro: H. Rommen, *Die ewige Wiederkehr des Naturrechts* (München, 1947²); F. Flückiger, *Geschichte des Naturrechts, I, Altertum und Frühmittelalter* (Zürich, 1954); J. Fuchs, *Lex Naturae. Zur Theologie des Naturrechts* (Düsseldorf, 1955); E. Zacher, *Der Begriff der Natur und das Naturrecht* (Berlin, 1973); A. Vierkandt, *Der geistig-sittliche Gehalt des neueren Naturrechts* (Wien-Leipzig, 1987); L. Honnefelder, 'Naturrecht und Geschichte. Historisch-systematische zum mittelalterlichen Naturrecht', in M. Heimbach-Steins (ed.), *Naturrecht im ethischen Diskurs* (Münster, 1990), pp. 1-27; W. Kluxen, 'Lex Naturae: The Lasting Significance of the Thomistic Solution to the Problem of Ethics', in Ch. Koyama (ed.), *Nature in Medieval Thought. Some Approaches East and West* (Leiden, 2000), pp. 95-110.

[26] Questi sono, tra l'altro, B. Schüller, *Die Herrschaft Christi und das weltliche Recht* (Rom, 1963); B.R. Schnackenburg, 'Die neutestamentliche Sittenlehre in ihrer Eigenart im Vergleich zu einer natürlichen Ethik', in J. Stelzenberger (ed.), *Moraltheologie und Bibel: Drei Vorträge beim Kongreß der deutschsprachigen Moraltheologen 23.-27. September 1963 in Freising* (Paderborn, 1964), pp. 39-69; F. Wieacker, *Zum heutigen Stand der Naturrechtsdiskussion* (Köln, 1965); B. Schüller, 'Zur theologischen Diskussion über die lex naturalis', ThPh 41 (1966), 481-503; K. Kremer, 'Christus – Grund und Erfüllung des natürlichen Sittengesetzes (*lex naturalis*)', TThZ 110 (2001), 253-66.

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Stoic Substance, Non-Existent Matter? Some Passages in Basil of Caesarea Reconsidered

Johannes ZACHHUBER, Berlin

This communication attempts to tie together some lose ends in recent research on Basil of Caesarea. I am not proposing the presentation of texts that have hitherto been totally unknown or neglected. On the contrary, I shall dwell mainly on two passages, both of which are fairly well known.

The first of the two is from Basil's *Against Eunomius*, his major contribution to the Trinitarian debate from his early career. It has been noted becouse of Basil's reference there to the common *usia* of all human beings as their 'material substratum', generating discussions about the supposedly Stoic background of Basil's concept of divine substance[1]. The other text stems from the first of his *Homilies on the Hexaëmeron*, his major work on cosmology. This passage has become a classic in the debate about the now celebrated Cappadocian doctrine that there is no matter[2].

Both seem to me to pose serious difficulties, and it will be my attempt to shed some light on those problems by bringing the two texts together, a task which has, as far as I am aware, not yet been undertaken. This would appear somewhat surprising, if only on account of the fact that both speak in rather similar terms about substance (*usia*), substratum (*hupokeimenon*), and matter (*hule*). What is more, however, their supposed upshot would seem to reveal a blatant incoherence: for if, as is sometimes claimed, Basil's *usia* is the Stoic *hupokeimenon*, then his other claim that such a substrate is non-existent must have really devastating consequences for important parts of his theology.

1. Let me turn first to the passage from the second book of Basil's anti-Eunomian treatise. The context is Basil's well-known diatribe against

[1] R.M. Hübner, 'Gregor von Nyssa als Verfasser der sog. ep. 38 des Basilius' in: J. Fontaine and Ch. Kannengiesser (eds), *Epektasis. Mélanges patristiques offerts au Cardinal Jean Daniélou* (Paris, 1972), 463-90; D. Balás, 'The Unity of Human Nature in Basil's and Gregory of Nyssa's Polemics against Eunomius', *SP* XIV (= 1976)), 275-81; Th. Böhm, 'Basilius: *Adversus Eunomium* II 4: Eine untypische Verwendung von οὐσία und ὑπόστασις?', *SP* XXXII (1997), 72-80.

[2] A.H. Armstrong, 'The Theory of the Non-Existence of Matter in Plotinus and the Cappadocians', *SP* V (= TV 80 (1962)), 427-9; R. Sorabji, *Time, Creation and the Continuum* (London, 1983), 290-4.

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Eunomius' claim that names indicate substances. Against this, Basil puts his own theory, according to which names do not (ever!) refer to substances, but to properties[3]. He gives the example of people, like Paul or Peter, and observes[4],

> So then when we hear 'Peter' we do not from the name think of his substance (by 'substance' I now mean the material substratum, which the name in no way signifies), but we are imprinted with the notion of the characteristics which are observed concerning him. For immediately from this utterance we think of the [son] of Jona, the man from Bethsaida, the brother of Andrew, the man called forth from the fishermen into the service of the apostolate [...]: none of which is the substance, if conceived as a substrate (*hupostasis*[5]).

As I said, this text has been noted mainly for its reference to human *usia* as the material substratum. Scholars were divided about its relevance. Some, like Balás and Hübner, proposed to accept this as Basil's regular understanding of *usia*, arguing on the basis of this and other, related passages for a Stoic concept of substance in Basil[6]. There appear to be, however, insurmountable difficulties with such an interpretation. Stoic *usia* is matter (as Basil himself says: ὑλικὸν ὑποκείμενον), a substrate devoid of any quality; it is whatever is left of a thing once any property is taken away from it. For Basil, divine substance does have properties; Basil's entire Trinitarian theory is built on the assumption that we need to distinguish between properties common to the three Persons (τὸ κοινόν) and properties shared by only one of them (τὸ ἴδιον)[7]: it would break down if Basil were serious about a Stoic account of *usia*.

The obvious alternative way, then, followed in principle already by Basil's brother Gregory of Nyssa, would be to dismiss his phrasing in our passage as an error (Gregory tacitly 'corrected' the formulation when he quoted it in his own *Contra Eunomium*, by the insertion of the negative *ou*[8]). I myself have previously dismissed these passages as singular *ad hominem* references without any bearing on Basil's understanding of divine substance[9].

[3] For the wider issue of Basil's semantic theory, cf. now D.G. Robertson, 'A Patristic Theory of Proper Names', *Archiv für Geschichte der Philosophie* 84 (2002), 1-19.

[4] Basil, *Adv. Eun.* II.4,9-18 (II.20 Sesboüé). ET: Robertson, 11.

[5] Basil's use of *hupostasis* here is difficult. As for the meaning I concur fully with Thomas Böhm (80). Given the general lack of a technical use of *hupostasis* in the *Adversus Eunomium* I find it, however, possible that Basil here uses the phrase synonymously with *hupokeimenon*, a use well attested elsewhere: cf. *PGL*, s.v. ὑπόστασις B.4.

[6] Balás, 279; Hübner, 476-84. A different view in, e.g., V.H. Drecoll, *Die Entwicklung der Trinitätslehre des Basilius von Cäsarea. Sein Weg vom Homöusianer zum Neunizäner* (Göttingen, 1996), 63-7.

[7] Cf., e.g., Basil, *epp.* 214.4; 236.6.

[8] Gregory of Nyssa, *CE* III/5.21-2 (GNO II, 167,22-168,4); cf. Balás, 275-8.

[9] J. Zachhuber, *Human Nature in Gregory of Nyssa. Theological Background and Theological Significance* (Leiden, 2000), 62.

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2. While I still hold that *usia* as the material substrate cannot be divine substance as we find it employed in Basil's Trinitarian thought, a comparison of the passage from the *Hexaëmeron* homilies will reveal that its relevance goes beyond an *ad hominem* reference. This text, from Basil's late years, not only shows quite distinctly that the concept of a nucleus of substance that is unknowable insofar as it is devoid of any property is part of Basil's thinking, but may help to integrate this view with Basil's accounts of divine substance in his Trinitarian texts. It is necessary, once again, to quote the relevant passage in full:

> In the same way we shall counsel ourselves with regard to [sc. the *usia* of] earth [the context is an exegesis of Gen 1:1]. We will not meddle about its *usia* proper (ἥτις ποτέ ἐστι), nor waste our thoughts searching for the substrate itself (αὐτὸ τὸ ὑποκείμενον), nor try to find some nature devoid of qualities, existing in such a way on its own account. For we are well aware that whatever is seen around it (περὶ αὐτήν) has been rendered fully by the account of being as completive of the *usia* (συμπληρωτικά τῆς οὐσίας). You arrive at nothing [therefore] if you try to take away by reason each of the qualities it possesses. If you take away black, cold, depth, density, the qualities associated with taste a substance possesses, or any other that may be seen around it, the substrate will be nothing[10].

The passage has been commented on mainly as one of the proof texts for the Cappadocians' by now famous theory of the non-existence of matter. Armstrong was the first – to my knowledge – to draw attention to this remarkable theory[11]; recently Richard Sorabji has contributed decisively to its clarification, especially with regard to Gregory of Nyssa[12]. Let us postpone this issue a little.

Basil's main intention here is to reject speculative interest in *usia*. More specifically, he argues that we should not treat of *usia* as it is by itself (ἥτις ποτέ ἐστι), a phrase that is apparently further explained by the subsequent references to 'the substrate itself' and 'some nature empty of qualities'. Instead, we are taught to focus on all the properties that are 'around' it, knowing that they fill up or complement the *usia* and are contained in the 'account of being' (ὁ τοῦ εἶναι λόγος). Basil's phrasing here is quite technical: τὰ συμπληρωτικὰ τῆς οὐσίας was the designation given by the Aristotelian commentators to the *differentiae*, those properties that belong to the essence of a particular being and are, therefore, part of the definition[13], for which again they often employed the phrase 'account of being'[14].

[10] Basil, *Hom in Hex* I.8 (15,3-12 Amand de Mendieta/Rudberg).

[11] Armstrong, 'The Theory of the Non-Existence of Matter'.

[12] Sorabji, *Time, Creation and the continunm*, 290-4.

[13] Cf. Porphyry, *In Cat* (95,22-33 Busse). Cf. A.C. Lloyd, *The Anatomy of Neoplatonism* (Oxford, 1990), 85 f.

[14] Cf. Zachhuber, 71-5.

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We are presented here, I should propose, with a two-tier theory of *usia*[15]. *Usia* (1), substance proper, is, apparently, an empty notion. It is what is left when all the properties have been taken away. Basil recommends his hearers not to spend their intellectual energies on this entity. *Usia* (2) is the real being of things, consisting of the former plus all their essential properties. Such a schema may have been derived from the average definition that calls

a living being an *usia* endowed with a soul and with sense-perception[16].

The reading that we may find most natural of such a definition is that the living being is a kind of *usia* characterised by the said properties. This, clearly, is *usia* (2). The same definition, however, might also be read as saying that the living being is something called '*usia*' plus those properties. This would be the mysterious *usia* (1) of which we neither learn anything by this definition, nor could we ever do so.

3. I should propose now that this analysis helps us put into context the earlier text from *Against Eunomius*. That they speak in similar terms about *usia* and *hupokeimenon* may seem obvious, but not quite exciting. Something more striking becomes apparent, however, once we recall that in the earlier text it had been Basil's intent to argue against Eunomius' contention that names refer to the substance of things. Against this view Basil had protested by drawing the distinction between *usia* and properties, claiming that only the latter are signified by names. We can easily identify the same conceptual framework standing behind both arguments although the consequences may not necessarily be identical. It would appear that in the *Adversus Eunomium* text Basil has pretended to read a definition like the one that says

a living being is an *usia* endowed with a soul and with sense-perception

as speaking of *usia* (1) plus properties. He there either ignored or wished to ignore what I termed *usia* (2) in his later text. But the basic idea of a distinction between a kind of *usia*, on the one hand, and the properties that are 'around' it and signified by name and definition, on the other, is the same in both.

That Basil may have found such a view attractive becomes evident as soon as we recall that one of the cornerstones of Eunomius' thought was the notion that the divine (as any) *usia* was captured by one (and only one) particular name (in the case of God, the unbegotten)[17]. Against this, Basil urged that the *usia* of God was unknowable by the very definition of our thinking minds[18].

[15] For a similar view, cf. Porphyry *ap.* Simplicius, *In Cat* (48,11-16 Kalbfleisch).
[16] Cf., e.g., Porphyry, *Isagoge* (10,6 Busse).
[17] Eunomius, *Apol.* 8 (40,16-42,18 Vaggione).
[18] Basil, *Adv. Eun.* I.12-14.

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At the same time, the comparison of the two texts makes it quite clear that, while the concept of *usia* as a material substrate, as Basil employed it in his *Against Eunomius*, may have facilitated his argument there by drawing a distinction between properties that are known, can be spoken, and are the basis for our conception of things, on the one hand, and a thing's substance, on the other, it can have been of no great help for Basil's Trinitarian theory. The latter obviously draws on *usia* (2), that is, on substance as the collection of common properties.

4. If the comparison has thus helped to gauge Basil's use of *usia* (1) in his *Adversus Eunomium*, it appears to reveal a real problem with regard to the text from the *Hexaëmeron* homilies. Basil there seems to say that this *usia* (1) is 'nothing'. Does this mean, as Armstrong surmised, a theory of the non-existence of matter, that is, *usia* (1)? Assuming that my findings with regard to the *Adversus Eunomium* are basically correct, Basil in this case would seem guilty of severe inconsistency. Alternatively, a development in his thought could be contemplated, or we might even speculate that he here wished to make a distinction between earthly substance, that is, matter in the strict sense of the word, and the inscrutable divine substance beyond all its properties. After all, Basil is referring explicitly to the *usia* of the earth.

A development, however, is quite unlikely as Basil had embarked on a very similar argument already in his *Adversus Eunomium*[19]. Without employing the phrasing that has here made the later text interesting, the similarities between the two passages suggest, to my mind, the same conceptual background. By the same token it seems unlikely that Basil should be credited with a principal difference between non-existent 'earthly' matter and divine *usia* that would be simply beyond knowledge. For in his anti-Eunomian writing his reference to our ignorance of the substance of the earth serves as an illustration for the claim that divine substance cannot be grasped.

I should, then, conclude that Basil probably did not espouse a theory of the non-existence of matter[20]. In my view it is perfectly likely that all he wished to express in the present passage was his conviction that the search for the underlying substance was not worthwhile, a vain undertaking that would lead to nothing. It appears not impossible, however, that Gregory of Nyssa was the first to think otherwise. He might then have felt it incumbent on him to work out and defend what he saw hinted in his brother's text[21].

[19] Basil, *Adv. Eun.* I.12,30-13,24 (I.214-218 Sesboüé).

[20] This leaves open the possibility that we have in *Hom in Hex* I.18 an unwitting echo of a text like Origen's *Princ* IV.4.7 (357,29-328,5 Koetschau).

[21] Cf. Gregory, *Apol in Hex*, PG 44, 69 B-C; *An et res*, PG 46, 124 C-D.

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Ultimately, Basil had a limited interest in a concept of *usia* as a substrate devoid of qualities. This was not 'his' notion of substance, but his adoption of this concept should guard us against the assumption that he may have argued for its inexistence.

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XII. Chrysostom

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Two Platonic Images in the Rhetoric of John Chrysostom: 'The Wings of Love' and 'the Charioteer of the Soul'

Constantine Bosinis, Athens

Introduction

In this paper I will deal with the influence of ancient Greek philosophy and, in particular, Platonism on John Chrysostom. I would like to focus especially on the dialogue *Phaedros,* where, as in the *Symposion,* Plato discusses love (ἔρως) and its benevolent influence on the life of man. *Phaedros* resonates more clearly in works of Chrysostom such as the exordium of his homily *Dicta postquam reliquiae martyrum,* where he repeats verbatim the philosophical axiom of Plato on the higher status of madness (μανία) induced by love in comparison with sanity (σωφροσύνη)[1]. Moreover, two well-known images from *Phaedros,* interwoven with the motif of Platonic love, occur quite often in his homilies. The first is the wings which grow upon the soul and raise it from the sensible world to the supra-sensible one, once the love for divine beauty within it has been set aflame, and the second concerns the comparison of the soul with a chariot, which the νοῦς governs as a charioteer, taking the reins of two horses which represent θυμός and the ἐπιθυμία[2]. The way in which Chrysostom assimilates these two Platonic images in his rhetoric is briefly analysed in the following pages.

The Wings of Love

Even if we could here cite an unlimited number of passages, we would not be able to exhaust the breadth of the figurative image of the 'wings of love' in John Chrysostom; traces of it can be found interspersed all over his voluminous work. 'Μέχρι πότε τῇ γῇ προσηλώμεθα; μέχρι τίνος οὐκ ἀναβλέπομεν εἰς τὸν οὐρανόν;' asks John from the ambo, while interpreting the Epistle to the Philippians[3]. Chrysostom's whole rhetoric is an appeal to

[1] Cf. *Phaedr.* 244aff. and *Hom. dict. postq. reliqu. martyr.* 1 (PG 63, 467). See further *In Gen., Hom.* LV. 3 (PG 54, 482); *De prof. Evang.* 8 (PG 51, 317).

[2] Both images are developed in the framework of Socrates' palinode in honour of the god Eros in *Phaedr.* 246a-256d.

[3] *In Ep. ad Phil., Hom.* X. 4 (PG 62, 260).

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the listeners to break the bonds that keep them tied up down on earth and fly away into the heavens. The phrase τῇ γῇ προσηλώμεθα or similar ones, such as χαμαὶ συρόμεθα, χαμαὶ κύπτομεν, περὶ τὸν βόρβορον ἐγκαλινδούμεθα, and so forth, by which John deplores the loose morals of the faithful, convey to us the idea – even if it is not explicitly expressed – that the soul is unable to spread its wings and fly away to its natural environment, heaven. As in the case of Plato, John also believes that man's yielding to animal instincts and desires of the flesh results in burdening the soul and, consequently, in the loss of its wings, which are specifically identified with its upper part, the νοῦς or the διάνοια[4]. And it is, no doubt, a surprise, to see how a Church Father who lays special emphasis on the pedagogical value of 'fear' and has no hesitation in terrifying his audience with hair-raising descriptions of hell extols divine love in his homilies as the peak of the moral life of the faithful: Ποθήσωμεν, παρακαλῶ, γνησίως τὸν Θεὸν, μὴ φόβῳ γεέννης, ἀλλ' ἐπιθυμίᾳ βασιλείας, he once says, apostrophizing his listeners. Τί γὰρ, εἰπέ μοι, τοῦ τὸν Χριστὸν ἰδεῖν ἴσον; Οὐδὲν οὐκ ἔστι. Τί δὲ τοῦ ἀπολαῦσαι τῶν ἀγαθῶν ἐκείνων ἴσον; Οὐκ ἔστιν οὐδέν[5].

Yet, desire for the heavenly Kingdom contains an element of self-interest as well and cannot by itself exhaust the whole spectrum of feelings which the love for God brings about within man's soul. Love for the Divine is a passion – just like love between a man and a woman – which, in its impulse, carries the soul along with it and makes it lose interest in everything in the world except for one thing: how it can be together with the person it is in love with. Such a passion, according to John, had captured the soul of the Apostle Paul, who endured with gladness every grief, persecution, or hardship throughout his missionary work, without having ever counted the benefit which he could have had by exchanging them for the joys of the Kingdom of Heaven.

Τὸ γὰρ ἁπάντων μεῖζον εἶχεν ἐν ἑαυτῷ, τὸν τοῦ Χριστοῦ ἔρωτα [John says], καὶ μετὰ τούτου πάντων ἑαυτὸν μακαριώτερον εἶναι ἐνόμισε ... κόλασις γὰρ ἐκείνῳ μία, τὸ τῆς ἀγάπης ταύτης ἀποτυχεῖν. Τοῦτο αὐτῷ γέεννα ... ὥσπερ καὶ ἀπόλαυσις, τὸ ταύτης ἐπιτυχεῖν[6].

In a stereotypical way, Paul is depicted in the Chrysostomic homilies as a 'warm' or 'manic lover' of Christ[7]. Together with him a series of eminent

[4] Cf. *Phaedr.* 246d-e, 248c, and *De stat., Hom.* XI. 4 (PG 49, 125); *Exp. in Ps.* IV. 6 (PG 55, 47-8); *De comp., Lib.* I. 7 (PG 47, 404); *In Matth., Hom.* LXXXIX. 3 (PG 58, 785) and *Hom.* XXXIX. 3 (PG 57, 432).

[5] *In Ep. I ad Tim., Hom.* XV. 4 (PG 62, 584). In this sense, that the 'desire for the Kingdom' comes before 'fear of *gehenna*', John also interprets the saying from Christ's Sermon on the Mount: 'Seek first the Kingdom of God, and all these things will be given you as well' (Mt 6:33). See *In Gen., Hom.* XXIV. 8 (PG 53, 216).

[6] *In S. Ap. Paul., Or.* II (PG 50, 480; SC 300, 4-5, 148-50).

[7] See evidences in M.M. Mitchell, *The Heavenly Trumpet, John Chrysostom and the Art of Pauline Interpretation* (Tübingen, 2000), p. 160 n. 135.

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personalities from the early Church and ancient Israel are also recruited by John in order to give shape to the ideal of divine love which he projects through his preaching to the faithful[8].

Besides strong passion or madness (μανία), the love which pervades Chrysostom's conception of Christian life in his homilies approaches platonic love in one more characteristic point: it is awakened within the soul by the attraction that the divine beauty exerts upon it. John refers quite often to the beauty of God, trying to document its biblical origin. 'Lord, show us the Father and it is enough for us'. This phrase of Philip from his dialogue with Jesus in John's Gospel (14:8) is explained in a singular manner by the Church Father: Philip expresses his longing to see God's beauty, exactly as Moses did, when he addressed Yahweh, saying 'show me your face', in the long past days of Exodus (Ex 33:13)[9]. The beauty of God penetrates completely, according to Chrysostom, the history of the divine Economy; it is revealed in the divine manifestations to the prophets, as in Isaiah's vision of the throne of the Lord (Is 6:2-5) or the appearance of the heavenly messenger to Daniel (Dan 10:1-7)[10]. Special emphasis is also laid by Chrysostom on the invincible power of God's beauty. The amazement which it causes to the soul when it faces it for the first time is portrayed clearly, according to the Father, in the reaction of Peter during the Transfiguration of the Lord. 'Suddenly Peter', he writes in one of his early ascetical works, 'threw everything out of his soul', as he saw Jesus in front of him shining in his divine glory. No more did he long for any else, but only the pleasure of this spectacle, as the phrase 'it is good for us to be here' (Mk 9:5 and parallels) asserts[11]. Paul's apocalyptic visions, too, even his conversion on the way to Damascus, are connected by John with the ecstatic experience of the contemplation of the divine beauty, which results in a dramatic change in one's life[12].

Chrysostom's numerous references to love (ἔρως) and divine beauty (κάλλος) certify his dependence on the *Phaedros*. From the same treatise, of course, the Father also borrows the image of wings which grow upon the soul and raise it up to the celestial world. He associates this metaphor of Plato with

[8] *In Gen., Hom.* XXIII. 3 (PG 53, 199): Noah; *Exp. in Ps.* XLI. 4 (PG 55, 160): Moses and XLI. 6 (PG 55, 164-5): David; *In Ep. ad Rom., Hom.* V. 7 (PG 60, 431-2): Peter; *In illud, Dilig. Deum omn. coop. in bon.* 3 (PG 51, 168-9): Silas; *In Ep. ad Rom., Hom.* IX. 4 (PG 60, 474): the Apostles in general. Regarding Paul and other biblical personalities as models of virtue, setting an example for imitation in Chrysostom's rhetoric, see M. M. Mitchell, ibid., pp. 43ff.

[9] *Exp. in Ps.* XLI. 6 (PG 55, 160).

[10] Ibid. and *Ad Theod. laps.* I. 14 (PG 47, 297; SC 117, 166-8).

[11] *Ad Theod. laps.* I. 11 (PG 47, 292; SC 117, 144). On the adverb ἐξαίφνης, which Chrysostom uses in the above passage, cf. Plato, *Symp.* 210e; Porphyry, *De vit. Plot.* 23.

[12] *De comp., Lib.* I. 7 (PG 47, 405). Although John does not have the temperament of a mystical theologian, his homilies often remind us of the theology of Origen and Gregory of Nyssa. In relation to the latter two Fathers, see A. Louth, *The Origins of the Christian Mystical Tradition, From Plato to Denys* (Oxford, 1981), pp. 52ff.

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various aspects of Christian worship. When he wants, for example, to stress to his listeners how important it is for them to read the bible, he likens it to spiritual food which nourishes the soul and makes its wings stronger[13]. Fasting, as well as prayer, almsgiving, and the imitation of the saints, are a trigger reminding Chrysostom of the same image from the *Phaedros*[14]. Of course, the way in which he uses this imagery is, to a great extent, fragmentary. Often he merely outlines it roughly, without giving additional explanation which might distract his congregation from the particular subject which he is dealing with in his preaching. Yet, all the various and fragmentary testimonies on the use of the figurative *topos* of the wings which we can collect from John's texts come together coherently and gain their deeper meaning when they are placed within the framework which we have sketched out in the course of our analysis – that is, the love for God and his unspoken mysterious beauty. Even beyond the study of the bible, fasting, praying or any other aspect of Christian worship there lies, according to the Church Father, the deepest desire of man to unite with the Divine; this desire urges him to leave everything behind him and mock any difficulty he comes across in order to open the wings of his soul and fly to heaven[15]. The Platonic origin of John's thought is especially evident at this point. Yet, in place of the abstract and transcendental Ideas of Plato, the incarnate Logos of God is the one who awakens love in the soul, according to the Church Father. Furthermore, the close connection of the *topos* of the wings with the worship of the Church lends to it an intensely ecclesiological dimension and seals its Christian character.

The Charioteer of the Soul

Plato, as is well known, divides the soul into three parts: θυμός, that is, man's feelings; ἐπιθυμία, his lowest animal instincts; and, finally, νοῦς, his rationality. The relationship among the three parts is illustrated by Plato in the *Phaedros* through a figurative image: the soul, he says, is like a chariot. The two horses which draw it are the θυμός and the ἐπιθυμία, while the charioteer that drives it is the νοῦς[16]. In addition, each of the two horses has different characteristics: the first one, which represents θυμός, is noble, obedient and

[13] *In Gen., Hom.* XXIX. 2 (PG 53, 262).

[14] *In Gen., Hom.* I. 4 (PG 53, 25) and *Hom.* X. 2 (PG 53, 83): fasting; *De Ann., Serm.* IV. 5 (PG 54, 666); *Exp. in Ps.* IV. 2 (PG 55, 41-2) and *Exp. in Ps.* CXXIX. 1 (PG 55, 373-4); *In Ep. ad Hebr., Hom.* XXII. 3 (PG 63, 158-9): prayer and repentance; *Exp. in Ps.* XLVIII. 4 (PG 55, 518): almsgiving; *De poen., Hom.* II. 5 (PG 49, 291); *Hom. in mart.* (PG 50, 663): imitation of the saints.

[15] *In Ep. ad Rom., Hom.* IX. 4 (PG 60, 474). Cf. *In Matth., Hom.* VI. 5 (PG 57, 68); *Exp. in Ps.* IX. 2 (PG 55, 124) and *Exp. in Ps.* XLI. 4 (PG 55, 165).

[16] See above, n. 2.

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gives way willingly to its driver's commands; the second one, on the contrary, which corresponds to ἐπιθυμία, is vicious, stubborn, and wild. Plato depicts in the *Phaedros* the charioteer's attempt to tame and break it in. He flogs it continuously and jerks the bit between its teeth until its jaws get drenched with blood – a very clear reference to man's difficulty in mastering his passions (especially his sexuality) through rationality[17].

The image of the charioteer of the soul is transferred unchanged in Chrysostom's rhetoric. Like Plato he uses the image in order to point out (a) the superiority of the νοῦς over against the other two parts of the soul and (b) the necessity of their being subjugated to its power[18]. Certainly, Chrysostom is not absolutely consistent in the way he uses the image of the charioteer. When he speaks about the untamed power of carnal desire, he is in keeping with the *Phaedros*. He likens it, exactly as Plato does, to a wild horse which does not obey the charioteer and pulls the chariot of the soul along with its frenzied galloping[19]. Yet, on the other hand, he also exploits the Platonic image in the framework of his polemic against other passions of the soul. In each case, he alters it so that it can serve the special purpose of his preaching. In one of his homilies, for example, he brings up the negative consequences that anger (ὀργή) can cause. Castigating the behaviour of a master in a Christian family who in a rage curses and threats his servant, John describes how in this case the charioteer has tumbled down from his chariot and is helpless on the ground underneath the horses' hooves[20]. Yet, the originality with which John uses the metaphor of the charioteer is not exhausted by such examples; the Church Father makes additional changes to the Platonic image, giving a strong Christian character to it.

According to Christianity, salvation presupposes the activation of all of man's powers; however, it also presupposes the grace of God, which supports man in his efforts. Chrysostom does not deviate from this norm. He shares with Paul the belief that love, faith, mildness, abstinence, and every other virtue constitute a fruit of the Holy Spirit (Gal 5:22-23), which, on the day of Pentecost, was diffused through the whole world and which indwells each of the faithful through baptism. This theological principle is interwoven in the preaching of Chrysostom with the influences that have come to him from ancient Greek philosophy. Ἀρετὴ γὰρ σαρκὸς τὸ ὑποτετάχθαι τῇ ψυχῇ,

[17] *Phaedr.* 253cff.

[18] See characteristically *In Ep. ad Eph., Hom.* XVII. 3 (PG 62, 120); *Contr. lud. et theatr.* 1 (PG 56, 265).

[19] *In Ep. I ad Cor., Hom.* XXXVII. 3 (PG 61, 320); *In Ep. ad Tit., Hom.* V. 2 (PG 62, 689); *De stat., Hom.* I. 4 (PG 49, 21). Cf. *In Gen., Hom.* XXII. 3 (PG 53, 189); *De poen., Hom.* II. 2 (PG 49, 286) and *Hom.* VI. 2 (PG 49, 316).

[20] *In Act., Hom.* XV. 5 (PG 60, 126). See also *In illud, Vid. Domin., Hom.* V. 1 (PG 56, 130): ἀπόνοια; *In Act., Hom.* XXVII. 3 (PG 60, 209-10): τρυφή; *In Gen., Hom.* XXIII. 5 (PG 53, 204): ὀργή, φθόνος, βασκανία, λύσσα χρημάτων, etc.

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κακία δὲ τὸ ἄρχειν ψυχῆς, he says in one of his homilies, reminding us of the Platonic demand for the subjugation of the lowest animal instincts to the power of reason[21]; he clarifies it, indeed, as usual, with the image of the charioteer. The next sentences of the homily, though, has a surprise in store for us:

Ἀλλ' οὐδὲ ἡνίοχος δείκνυται ἄνευ ἐπιστήμης· καὶ γὰρ καὶ αὐτὸς ἐκείνων [that is, τῶν ἵππων] δεινότερα ἄνευ ἐπιστήμης ἐργάζεται. Ὥστε πανταχόθεν ἐφεστάναι χρή· τὸ πνεῦμα, τοῦτο ἐφεστὸς, τὸν ἡνίοχον ἰσχυρότερον ποιεῖ· τοῦτο καὶ τὴν ψυχὴν καὶ τὸ σῶμα καλλωπίζει[22].

The mastery and skilfulness of the charioteer in handling the reins of the chariot is a detail which does not exist in the *Phaedros*. Chrysostom adds this detail to show that man, in spite of his rational ability, must be illuminated by the Holy Spirit in order to achieve moral perfection. Interpreting Paul's words in Rom 8:14, he goes a little further: dramatically changing the Platonic image, he identifies the charioteer with the Holy Spirit, which, taking the reins, guides the soul and the body of man[23]. The image of the *Phaedros*, as we see, changes into an expressive device for the illustration of fundamental truths of the Christian faith[24].

To conclude, the complete assimilation of the two metaphorical images from the *Phaedros* in the theology of John brings naturally to mind the term 'Christian neoclassicism', which Werner Jaeger used some decades ago about the Cappadocian Fathers of the fourth century[25].

[21] *In Ep. ad Eph., Hom.* V. 4 (PG 62, 41). In Chrysostom's homilies the term ψυχή is often identical with its upper part, namely, the rational.

[22] Ibid.

[23] *In Ep. ad Rom., Hom.* XIV. 2 (*PG* 60, 525).

[24] It is also worth mentioning that John often turns to the Platonic image, to criticize heretics and austere ascetic circles of his time. Against their dualistic views, he juxtaposes the metaphor of the charioteer in order to prove that the *νοῦς* and not the flesh is the reason that man is corrupted and drawn to perdition. See, e.g., *In Ep. ad Rom., Hom.* V. 1 (PG 60, 421); *In Ep. I ad Cor., Hom.* XVII. 4 (PG 61, 144).

[25] W. Jaeger, *Early Christianity and Greek Paideia* (Cambridge MA, 1962), p. 75.

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La figure d'Anne, mère de Samuel, dans l'œuvre de Jean Chrysostome[1]

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Anne, mère de Samuel, est évoquée à une vingtaine de reprises dans l'œuvre de Jean Chrysostome. Le prédicateur lui consacre même une série de cinq homélies, qui constituent une sorte de commentaire suivi des chapitres du *Premier Livre des Règnes* qui la concernent.

Anne est souvent évoquée, les commentateurs l'ont remarqué[2], comme un modèle de l'éducation parfaite à donner aux enfants. Mais elle est aussi, et même bien davantage, évoquée comme modèle de prière. Enfin, sa résistance à la colère face aux insultes et aux sarcasmes de sa rivale font d'elle un modèle de 'philosophie'. S'additionnant, ces trois qualités essentielles donnent une sorte d''épaisseur de vertu', pourrait-on dire, au personnage, si bien que Chrysostome se réfère à elle dès lors qu'il veut donner un exemple général de vertu, quitte à lui prêter quelquefois des qualités qui ne sont pas nécessairement les siennes[3].

Pour donner un aperçu du traitement de la figure, je souhaiterais dans mon exposé présenter Anne par rapport à trois autres figures, plus ou moins explicitement opposées par Jean Chrysostome à la mère de Samuel.

I. Anthousa

La première est implicite, mais non moins présente, dans le discours de Chrysostome. Il s'agit d'Anthousa, la mère du prédicateur, qui, s'il faut en croire le *Dialogue sur le Sacerdoce*, avait convaincu son fils de ne pas partir avec Basile pour mener avec lui une vie d'ascète afin de ne pas la laisser seule.

[1] Je remercie Philippe Le Moigne pour sa relecture précise et amicale de cet article.

[2] Aimé Puech, *Un Réformateur de la Société Chrétienne au IV siècle, Saint Jean Chrysostome et les moeurs de son temps* (Paris: Hachette, 1891), p. 128; L. Meyer, *Saint Jean Chrysostome, maître de perfection chrétienne* (Paris: Beauchesne, 1933), p. 305; A. Moulard, *Saint Jean Chrysostome, le défenseur du mariage et l'apôtre de la virginité,* (Paris: Gabalda, 1923), p. 162 et 231.

[3] Cf. par ex. *Homélie 14 sur la Première Epître à Timothée*, PG 62, 573, 4-6, où Anne est plus ou moins présentée comme le modèle des veuves. Cf. C. Broc, 'Jean Chrysostome lecteur de la Septante: la figure d'Anne', à paraître.

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Jeune veuve en effet, elle avait renoncé à un second mariage pour se consacrer à l'éducation de son fils:

'Mais en échange de tous ces sacrifices, je ne te demande qu'une seule faveur, c'est de ne pas me précipiter dans un second veuvage et de ne pas rallumer une douleur maintenant apaisée. Attends patiemment ma fin'[4].

Dans le discours 3 du traité *Contre les Adversaires de la vie monastique*, Chrysostome présente d'Anne la figure inverse, celle de la mère qui, dès lors qu'elle a porté son fils au Temple, ne lui demande plus jamais de pénétrer dans la maison paternelle. L'image s'appuie sur 1 *Règnes* 2, 19, où il est dit que chaque année, Anne portait à son fils un petit manteau qu'elle lui avait tissé:

Et quand il n'eut plus besoin <du lait maternel>, elle le prit et le consacra aussitôt à Dieu, et elle ne lui demanda plus jamais de franchir le seuil de la maison paternelle, mais il habitait tout le temps dans le Temple de Dieu. Et quand elle désirait le voir, comme il est normal pour une mère, elle n'appelait pas l'enfant à elle, mais c'est elle qui montait vers lui avec son père, dans la pensée qu'elle se tenait désormais à l'écart de quelqu'un qui était consacré[5].

Et que Samuel soit devenu un grand prophète est présenté dans la suite du texte comme une conséquence immédiate du renoncement d'Anne à garder son enfant auprès d'elle.

Dans *la Deuxième Homélie sur Anne*, on voit comment, en annonçant que Samuel ne 'boira ni vin ni boisson enivrante', Anne subordonne son souci légitime de mère veillant à la santé de son enfant à la confiance en celui à qui elle le remet:

Elle ne s'est pas dit à elle-même: 'Et s'il est de santé délicate et que boire de l'eau lui fasse du mal? Et s'il tombe malade? Et s'il meurt en proie à une mauvaise maladie?' Mais elle se dit en elle-même que celui dont elle l'avait reçu pourrait aussi s'occuper de sa santé...[6]

Ainsi, non seulement Anne ne s'est pas opposée à la vocation religieuse de son fils, mais c'est elle qui l'a encouragée, ou même totalement suscitée. Sans durcir l'opposition, on peut dire qu'Anne représente une contre-figure de la mère de Chrysostome, qui, malgré l'éducation chrétienne qu'elle donna à son fils, montre dans le *Dialogue sur le Sacerdoce* les limites auxquelles son sacrifice n'avait pu se résoudre. Anne est allée plus loin qu'elle.

[4] *Dialogue sur le Sacerdoce*, I.2, 75-79, SC 272 (1980), p. 70-71, trad. A.-M. Malingrey.
[5] *Contre les adversaires de la vie monastique*, PG 47, 383, 31-38.
[6] PG 54, 641, 26-31.

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II. Eve

La deuxième figure à laquelle Anne est, cette fois-ci, explicitement comparée est celle d'Eve. Par ses qualités multiples, Anne montre qu'il est possible d'être vertueuse en étant femme, et ainsi, de balayer l'antique accusation. Dans la *Quatrième homélie sur Anne*, dans un passage merveilleusement suggestif, Chrysostome s'exclame:

Je ne peux pas m'enlever cette femme de l'esprit, tant j'admire la belle forme de son âme (τὴν εὐμορφίαν τῆς ψυχῆς), et la beauté de sa pensée. J'aime ses yeux qui pleurent dans la prière (...), et ses lèvres, et sa bouche, qui n'est pas rougie par du maquillage, mais embellie par l'action de grâce envers Dieu; je l'admire d'avoir fait preuve de philosophie, et je l'admire plus encore d'avoir fait preuve de philosophie en étant femme, une femme, que beaucoup ont souvent accusée: *C'est de la femme*, dit l'Ecriture, *qu'a commencé le péché, et c'est à cause d'elle que nous mourons tous*[7], et encore: *Toute méchanceté est peu comparée à la méchanceté de la femme*[8], et Paul: *Ce n'est pas Adam qui a été trompé, mais la femme* (...)[9]. Si je l'admire, c'est surtout parce qu'elle a balayé ces reproches, qu'elle a repoussé l'accusation, et qu'en étant du sexe calomnié et accusé, elle a effacé tous ces blâmes, en nous enseignant par les actes que les autres ne sont pas devenues telles[10] par nature, mais par suite de leur volonté et de leur propre négligence, et que dans ce sexe il est possible d'atteindre au faîte de la vertu[11].

A la suite de cette sorte de blason de la vertu, Anne apparaît comme l'une de ces femmes, au même titre que les matriarches Sarah, Rachel et Rebecca[12], dont l'action amène à reconsidérer la nature féminine, et relativise, voire annule, la portée du péché d'Eve[13]. Si Chrysostome cite ici l'Ecriture, en l'occurrence *l'Ecclésiaste* et la *Première Epître à Timothée*, il omet de dire au passage qu'il fait lui-même partie de ces πολλοί qui 'ont accusé' 'la' femme. Cette mise en valeur de la volonté, προαίρεσις, au détriment de la nature, φύσις, à laquelle se prête ici la figure d'Anne, conduira ailleurs Chrysostome à la conclusion explicite que finalement, le masculin et le féminin ne sont pas tant une question de nature que de volonté, ce qui ne fait d'ailleurs que déplacer la question de la valorisation du masculin et de la dépréciation

[7] Eccl 25, 33

[8] Eccl 25, 26

[9] 1 Tim 2, 14.

[10] On peut s'interroger sur la remarquable imprécision de l'expression τοιαῦται γεγόνασιν. Sont-elles devenues 'dignes de mériter ces reproches?'; 'telles qu'elles sont?'; voire 'femmes' (cf. *infra*, note 14)?

[11] *Homélie 4 sur Anne*, PG 54, 663, 3-24.

[12] *Homélie 13 sur l'Epître aux Ephésiens*, PG 62, 99, 17-21. Cf. C. Broc, *Les figures féminines du Nouveau Testament dans l'œuvre de Jean Chrysostome*, à paraître aux Etudes Augustiniennes.

[13] C'est le seul cas, dans les textes évoquant Anne, où la question de la nature féminine est ainsi posée.

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du féminin[14]. En attendant, on voit que c'est ici une figure vétéro-testamentaire, Anne, qui est opposée à Eve, en d'autres termes, que la contestation de la condamnation de la femme se fait ici avant l'avènement de la grâce néo-testamentaire.

III. Marie

Ainsi opposée à Eve, on pouvait s'attendre, en effet, à ce que la figure d'Anne soit rapprochée de celle de Marie, et les formules mêmes du type 'elle a balayé ces reproches', 'elle a repoussé l'accusation', 'elle a effacé tous ces blâmes' – sembleraient suggérer le rapprochement. Or, malgré la forte valorisation de la figure d'Anne – ou peut-être à cause d'elle –, c'est une confrontation qui n'a pas lieu chez Chrysostome, et j'articulerai ici encore mes remarques en trois points.

1) Disposant manifestement du texte du cantique d'Anne, dont il commente les deux premiers versets avant de l'abandonner[15], et dont il cite le cinquième, Chrysostome ne fait jamais le rapprochement avec le Magnificat[16], qu'il ne commente d'ailleurs pas non plus[17]. Certes, il n'a pas commenté l'Evangile selon saint Luc de façon systématique, et sans doute le texte de cet Evangile lui est-il moins présent à l'esprit que ceux de Matthieu ou de Jean. Mais ce silence est tout de même surprenant face à deux textes, le *Cantique d'Anne* et le *Cantique de Marie*, qui auraient pu, par exemple, inspirer également les préoccupations sociales du prédicateur. Il y a là une occasion manquée de rapprochement relativement étonnante.

2) On rencontre, appliquées à Anne, des formules que l'on aurait pu attendre pour Marie. En effet, Chrysostome souligne la naissance extraordinaire de Samuel, obtenu par Anne malgré sa stérilité, à force de prières. Or, non seulement il ne fait pas le rapprochement avec la naissance particulière du Christ, mais encore, c'est à propos d'Anne que l'on rencontre chez Chrysostome la formule 'ses entrailles étaient sanctifiées', qu'il n'emploie jamais à propos de Marie. Le passage se trouve dans la *Première Homélie sur Anne*:

[14] Cf. *De studio praesentium*, §2, PG 63, 487, 23-31: 'Car la différence n'est pas entre l'esclave et l'homme libre, entre le riche et le pauvre, entre la femme et l'homme, mais elle est dans les dispositions d'esprit, entre le zèle et la paresse, le vice et la vertu. Ainsi je peux appeler riche le pauvre, et pauvre le riche, femme un homme, et homme une femme, ignorant le sage, et sage l'ignorant, non que je mélange la nature des choses, mais parce que j'introduis le meilleur critère capable de rectifier toute chose'.

[15] Dans l'*Homélie 3* (PG 54, 657, 46-47), le cantique est escamoté par la formule 'quand elle eut dit cela et qu'elle eut prié...'

[16] Lc 1, 46-55.

[17] On rencontre seulement une probable réminiscence du texte dans *l'Homélie Postquam reliquiae martyrum*, PG 63, 471, 13.

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Dès son plus jeune âge, et dès sa naissance, elle le fit marcher dans la voie de la sainteté, abandonnant tout à Dieu, et avant sa naissance, son ventre était sanctifié puisqu'il contenait un prophète, qu'il allait donner le jour à un prêtre, et qu'il portait une offrande, une offrande vivante[18].

L'emploi quasi naturel de ce verbe ἁγιάζω à propos d'Anne rend plus significative encore l'absence de ce terme ou d'expressions apparentées à propos de Marie, et renforce l'idée d'un refus conscient de la part de Jean Chrysostome de s'engager dans des réflexions trop précises sur la maternité de Marie, qu'il laisse à 'ceux qui s'agitent et se mêlent de questions indiscrètes' – οἱ περιεργαζόμενοι καὶ πολυπραγμονοῦντες.

Qu'il vient donc de nous et de notre substance, et du sein virginal, ces arguments et beaucoup d'autres le rendent évident; mais le 'comment', cela n'est plus évident. Ne va donc pas chercher toi aussi, mais accepte ce qui est révélé, et ne te mêle pas de ce qui est passé sous silence (μὴ περιεργάζου τὸ σιγηθέν)[19].

3) On sait comment Jean Chrysostome, lorsqu'il commente les *Noces de Cana*, fait de Marie demandant à Jésus un miracle l'exemple des parents abusifs qui cherchent à accroître leur prestige au détriment de la vocation religieuse de leur enfant[20]. De ce point de vue, et sans que la comparaison soit faite explicitement par Chrysostome, Anne et Marie sont deux figures antithétiques, l'une se déplaçant au Temple par respect pour son fils consacré, l'autre, selon la présentation de Chrysostome, contrariant 'l'heure' de Jésus pour le seul plaisir de susciter l'admiration de l'assistance. Si l'on peut, dans les deux cas, voir se dessiner en filigrane la figure d'Anthussa comme figure maternelle contrariant la vocation religieuse de son enfant, c'est Marie qui représenterait la mère de Chrysostome, tandis qu'Anne en représente le dépassement. Si la comparaison était faite explicitement par Chrysostome entre les deux figures d'éducatrices que sont Anne et Marie, elle se ferait donc en faveur de la mère de Samuel. Peut-être peut-on même y voir la raison pour laquelle les deux figures ne sont jamais évoquées ensemble dans la prédication de Chrysostome.

Conclusion

Il ne s'agit pas ici de faire d'Anne une sorte de figure détournée de Marie, au détriment de cette dernière. Mais on peut dire en tout cas qu'Anne n'est pas une figure 'orientée' vers celle de Marie. Dans l'Homélie *Peccata fratrum non evulganda*, Chrysostome évoque les exemples de femmes stériles qui, devenues mères par la puissance de Dieu, pouvaient préparer à l'enfantement virginal de

[18] PG 54, 641, 32-36.
[19] *Homélie 4 sur Matthieu* 3, PG 57, 43, 33-38.
[20] Cf. *Homélies XXI et XXII sur saint Jean*, surtout PG 59, 130, 43-60.

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Marie[21]. Or, il cite Sarah, Rachel et Rébecca, mais il ne cite pas Anne. Modèle parfait d'éducation de son enfant, nouvelle Eve au ventre sanctifié par la gestation d'un prophète, Anne concentre effectivement autour d'elle un certain type de discours que Chrysostome ne tient pas – ou peu – à propos de Marie. Si le fait nous étonne rétrospectivement, nous ne devons pas oublier qu'en cette deuxième moitié de quatrième siècle[22], le discours marial commence tout juste son véritable essor. Chrysostome ne s'engage pas aussi résolument que d'autres[23] dans cette direction, et peut-être est-ce cette liberté par rapport à la figure mariale qui lui permet de donner cette importance à la mère de Samuel. Il y a là quelque chose d'intéressant à entendre ainsi un discours d'Eglise sur 'la question de la femme', qui ne soit pas encore capté par la figure, certes exemplaire, mais tout de même bien complexe, de la mère du Sauveur.

[21] PG 51, 361, 6-17. Le passage explique pourquoi, alors qu'il avait à sa disposition les exemples de Rachel, de Sara et de Rébecca, Gabriel se contente de donner à Marie l'exemple d'Elisabeth.

[22] Malgré les premiers éléments donnés par Justin et Irénée, ou encore Origène et Athanase. Cf. Domiciano Fernandez, 'La spiritualité mariale chez les Pères de l'Eglise' *DSp* 10 (1980), col. 423-440.

[23] Basile et les deux Grégoire en particulier.

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Pedagogical Methods in John Chrysostom's Preaching*

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'Orality and literacy', despite their apparent opposition, can coexist and complement each other. In antiquity, the practice of reading texts aloud inevitably bound the spoken and the written word together. Likewise, rhetorical training that was meant to distinguish the educated elite from the masses was also designed to capture the attention of listeners. These two issues are important factors in the study of the social context of sermons in Late Antiquity. Here, I will discuss how rhetorical speaking and written texts were used by John Chrysostom to convey religious knowledge to his congregation in Antioch. His pedagogical methods illustrate both the diverse nature of his audience and his priorities in his instruction of lay Christians.

The congregation's mood during the church service affected the preacher and his delivery style. In one sermon, Chrysostom described his teaching strategy:

> To keep you from spitting up what you are given, I have not tipped the cup of instruction for you all at once, but I have chopped it up for you over many days, providing you a rest on these intervening days from the labour of listening, in order that what is laid down may stick firmly in your heart's understanding[1].

When laypeople showed special interest, they could inspire their preacher to elaborate on the subject of his sermon or even to delve into additional subjects. In the same way, their boredom could cause him to lose his inspiration[2].

With this in mind, Chrysostom employed a varied array of rhetorical devices meant to keep his listeners' attention. When he commented systemtically on scripture, he began almost every sermon with a short recapitulation of the previous one. Chrysostom also remarked on the structure of his sermons:

* Quotations in this article are based on the following translations: *Homilies on Genesis*, trans. Robert Hill, Fathers of the Church, vols. 74, 82, and 87 (Washington, D.C.: Catholic University Press, 1986-92); *On Wealth and Poverty* (Translations of the nine sermons *On Lazarus*), trans. Catharine Roth (Crestwood, NY: 1984); *A Select Library of Nicene and Post Nicene Fathers*, ed. Philip Schaff, Series 1, vols. 9 and 12 (Peabody, Mass.: Hendrickson Publishers, 1994).

[1] *De Lazaro* 3.1 (PG 48, 991).

[2] *Hom. in Genes.* 2.7.8 (PG 53, 251); *Hom. in Matt.* 1.7 (PG 57, 22); *De Stat.* 9.1 (PG 49, 103); *Hom. in Genes.* 45.1 (PG 54, 414). On Chrysostom's sensitivity to his congregation's mood, see Wendy Mayer, 'John Chrysostom: Extraordinary Preacher, Ordinary Audience', in *Preacher and Audience: Studies in Early Christian and Byzantine Homilectics*, ed., Pauline Allen and Mary Cunningham (Leiden: Brill, 1998), 105-37 at 132.

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if he found himself on a tangent and decided to return to the main topic, he told his audience precisely what he was doing. Sometimes, repetition of key phrases and ideas is meant to stamp the subject or even exact words into the minds of the listenners. When preaching on Genesis, Chrysostom directly addressed Cain, on the verge of murder: 'Cain, what are you doing? Don't you know who you're talking to?'[3] He bombarded Cain with twenty-seven, almost consecutive, rhetorical questions. Elsewhere, he repeated short biblical quotations up to seven times within a few minutes for a similar effect[4].

Not surprisingly, the Antiochene congregation included people with different levels of knowledge, ability, and interest. Some attended church more regularly, while some were able to read scriptures on their own[5]. Chrysostom responded to this range of people by

> preparing every kind of discourse for you, since every kind of sickness is likely to exist in such a large assembly, and our task is not to heal only one wound, but many wounds of different types. Because of this, it is necessary that the medicine of the instruction be manifold[6].

Sometimes, this meant that the more capable members of the congregation were expected to remain patient while he explained a concept to the others. During a sermon on Lazarus, some listeners recognized the story from the first line, 'There was a rich man'. Chrysostom praised them, but requested them to slow down for the sake of others. He pointed out that the Church was composed, like physical body, from higher and lower parts, from eyes down to the feet[7]. All parts were connected and had to cooperate with the others: 'If you are swift, if you are well prepared for listening, but you have a brother who does not follow what is said, let your eye descend to the heel. Let it feel sympathy...'[8].

Not everyone, though, was expected to be able to understand all the details. Occasionally, subjects too complex for the general audience became the homework for the 'more diligent' (φιλοπόνοι) to pursue separately. For example, the relationship among the four elements and between hot and cold[9], the structure and function of different parts of the body[10], and grammatical issues were tangential enough to the sermon to be left to experts. In the latter case, Chrysostom claimed that people's interest would be inspired more by their own study of the problem than if he solved it for them[11]. The preacher's recog-

[3] *Hom. in Genes.* 19.1 (PG 53, 159-60).

[4] *Hom. in Genes.* 24.3 (PG 53, 209).

[5] See Pauline Allen's remarks on Chrysostom's references to literary, access to books, and private readings of scriptures in 'The Homilist and the congregation: a case study of John Chrysostom's Homilies on Hebrews', *Aug* 36 (1996), 397-421.

[6] *De stat.* 14.4 (PG 49, 149).

[7] *De Lazaro* 6.4 (PG 48, 1032).

[8] *De Lazaro* 6.4 (PG 48, 1032).

[9] *De stat.* 10.5 (PG 49, 117).

[10] *De stat.* 11.3 (PG 49, 124).

[11] *Hom. in Genes.* 26.4 (PG 53, 234).

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nition of the 'more advanced' lay Christians and his requests for their patience indicate that he wished to reach all of his listeners. In other words, his concern for communicating with the uneducated did not stem from a lack of alternatives.

Chrysostom had high hopes for his audience's enthusiasm and capacity for learning. He advised laypeople to spend an entire day reviewing the content of a sermon and to read the next section of scripture in order to prepare for the following lesson[12]. Laypeople were expected to go home after the sermon and discuss together as families, with their bibles in hand[13]. Pre-empting possible excuses, Chrysostom assured them that if they had no teacher to help them read, God would be their instructor[14].

These references to literacy, access to texts, and the leisure to read them suggest that the preacher, in these cases, addressed only the more priviliged individuals in the congregation. The sermons, however, indicate that Chrysostom expected a wider range of people to be capable of reading. After instructing his listeners to read scripture, Chrysostom echoed some of their excuses for not doing so: they could not leave the courthouse, their municipal responsibilities, or their families. They considered reading to be the business of the monks living in the mountains[15]. Chrysostom pointed to the example of the scholarly Ethiopian eunuch in the Acts of the Apostles, who was always reading scripture despite travelling with a military party. The preacher held this figure up as an example to soldiers, women, and people in general who did not have occupations particularly conducive to reading and study[16].

Not all of the lay Christians who could read found it to be an easy task. They were the ones Chrysostom heard muttering, 'I don't understand the contents, I can't grasp the full sense of the words, why should I go to this trouble all to no purpose by reading without having someone capable of guiding me?'[17] Taking note of the people who did not read fluently, Chrysostom still told them all to read, whether or not they completely understood what they were reading[18]. These statements indicate that the issue at stake, at least in some cases, was the will to read scriptures, not the ability to read at all[19]. Also,

[12] *Hom. in Matt.* 1.6 (PG 57, 21); *De Lazaro* 3.1 (PG 48, 991).
[13] *Hom. in Matt.* 5.1 (PG 57, 55); *Hom. in Genes.* 6.6 (PG 53, 61).
[14] *Hom. in Genes.* 35.1 (PG 53, 321); *Hom. in Matt.* 72.4 (PG 57, 672).
[15] *De Lazaro* 3.1 (PG 48, 992).
[16] *Hom. in Genes.* 35.2 (PG 53, 323).
[17] *Hom. in Genes.* 35.1 (PG 53, 322).
[18] *Hom. in Genes.* 35.2 (PG 53, 323).
[19] Numerous studies indicate that functional literacy was accessible to a wide range of people in this period. Robert Browning, 'Literacy in the Byzantine World', *Byzantine and Modern Greek Studies* 4 (1978), 39-54; Harry Gamble, *Books and Readers in the Early Church: A History of Early Christian Texts* (New Haven: Yale University Press, 1995), 5; *Literacy in the Roman World*, ed., Mary Beard *et al.*, Journal of Roman Archaeology Supplementary Series 3 (Ann Arbor: Journal of Roman Archaeology, 1991); *Literacy and Power in the Ancient World*, ed. Alan Bowman and Greg Woolf (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1994).

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his tone of persuasion – he was speaking to people who did not enjoy reading – points to an audience without intellectual pretensions. In this context, religious duties were a matter of will rather than culture, even when they required skills and interests that traditionally divided the elite from the rest.

Even with the most optimistic estimation of literacy, not all lay Christians were able to read, but everyone could utilize their memories. Chrysostom's instruction in Christian doctrine and behaviour depended on reliable memories. The first goal for an ambitious Christian was the memorization and subsequent contemplation of scripture[20]. Memories could be durable and vivid: 'when we come across virtues of good people through listening and store them up in the recesses of our mind, we are able to enjoy their fragrance for all time, if we want'[21]. More accessible than written texts, memories repeating through one's mind could be ever present.

Chrysostom attempted to make his sermons memorable. In many cases, he stopped himself from speaking longer because too much material in one sitting would only confuse his listeners. In a sermon on Genesis, he explained why the previous sermon concluded abruptly:

> Since our speech was drawn out at great length, we wrapped it up quickly, so as not to bury your memory with its length ... we wanted to say as much as you were able to remember and leave here having profited from it ... we consider that we have received a reward sufficient in itself, if we see your progress in grasping the words precisely, and if you store them in the recesses of your mind, stirring them up and ruminating on them constantly[22].

He also observed that people simply got bored if he talked too long: they might stare at the ceiling, or complain about the physical discomfort of standing through long sermons. Chrysostom knew this and responded to their needs, while resenting their willingness to stand in the rain and cold for the games[23].

The preacher wanted his listeners to take home general beliefs and behaviours, but also expected them to remember specific stories from the bible that illustrated these concepts. The bible itself was structured in a way to aid memorization: it was meant 'to rivet the sacred truths in our mind by the repetition in the teaching'[24]. Since they could not learn everything at once, the laity would ideally make a 'kind of a chain' out of the pieces of information they received each day, and would eventually know the scripture in its entirety[25]. At other times, Chrysostom was less ambitious about what he expected them to remember. The repetition of key phrases along with a direct statement at the

[20] *De Poen.* 8.3 (PG 49, 340); *Huit catéchèses baptismales* 1 (SC 50, ed. A. Wenger (1957), 1.22, 1-2).

[21] *Hom. in Genes.* 43.1 (PG 54, 395).

[22] *Hom. in Genes.* 28.1 (PG 53, 252).

[23] *Hom. in Genes.* 6.2 (PG 53, 56).

[24] *Hom. in Genes.* 6.5 (PG 53, 60); *Hom. in Genes.* 20.5 (PG 53, 173).

[25] *Hom. in Matt.* 5.1 (PG 57, 56).

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end of a sermon emphasized to the audience precisely what to remember, if they could remember only one simple thing[26].

In some cases, Chrysostom attempted to impress the lesson of the day visually upon his listeners' memories. The sufferings of well-developed biblical characters especially lent themselves to visualization. One day he sent them home imagining the warm blood dripping from the severed head of John the Baptist[27]. On a different day, Chrysostom told the men and women of his congregation to inscribe in their minds an image of Job and his wife's sufferings[28]. In a sermon on Lazarus, he advised them, 'Paint this parable, both the rich and the poor – the rich on the walls of your houses, the poor on the walls of your hearts ... it will be a school for you and the first lesson of all philosophy'[29]. Elsewhere, he recommended that the walls of houses and hearts should be inscribed with the 'flying sickle' (Zech. 5:1-3), so that laypeople would see it soaring toward them whenever they stepped out of line[30].

Chrysostom ultimately wished for the members of his congregations to learn enough to become teachers themselves. He urged them to remember biblical stories and the words of his sermons in order to be able to repeat them to others outside of church[31]. He encouraged husbands and wives to 'philosophize' at home and instruct their children[32]. He also envisioned a wider network of teachers and followers: 'You should be teachers and guides of others; friends should instruct and lead on their neighbours, servants their fellow servants, and youths those of their own age'[33]. If laypeople repeated stories and doctrinal arguments outside of church, they would reinforce their own knowledge and have the chance of reaching the ears of people who did not attend church[34].

Chrysostom had no qualms about encouraging people to read and discuss scriptures independently, or to attempt theological disputations with pagans, Jews, and Christians from other sects. To prepare them for this, he taught rhetorical methods as well as a body of information in his sermons: 'Our contest is with enemies, and so we must practice the *reductio ad absurdum* which Paul also often uses'[35]. In another instance, Chrysostom told them to dispute

[26] *De Lazaro* 2.6 (PG 48, 991-2).
[27] *De stat.* 14.1 (PG 49, 144).
[28] *Hom. in I Cor.* 28.5 (PG 61, 239-40).
[29] *De Lazaro* 4.2 (PG 48, 1008).
[30] *De stat.* 9.5 (PG 49, 110). He advises this as an aid to break the habit of swearing.
[31] *Hom. in Genes.* 28.1 (PG 53, 252); *De stat.* 14.6 (PG 49, 151-2).
[32] *De stat.* 5.7 (PG 49, 80).
[33] *De stat.* 16.6 (PG 49, 170).
[34] *Hom. in I Cor.* 5.6 (PG 61, 46).
[35] *Hom. in I Cor.* 39.4 (PG 61, 337). On disputations, see Richard Lim, *Public Disputation, Power and Social Order in Late Antiquity* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1995). On the Christian adoption of the intellectual tradititon, especially the art of rhetoric, see Averil Cameron, *Christianity and the Rhetoric of Empire: the Development of Christian Discourse* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1991), 120-54.

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with pagans and to work out their arguments in advance. He suggested that they start by asking pagans to explain how twelve humble men had triumphed over the world[36]. Later in the same series of sermons, Chrysostom boasted, '[Greeks] are confounded when they see an artisan and the sort of person one meets in the market who is more of a philosopher than themselves'[37].

Chrysostom's approach to teaching doctrine and behaviour reveals that he spoke to a range of people and had high expectations of them. This is not surprising, because religious knowledge, in contrast to traditional *paideia*, was not so much a matter of careers or high culture as it was a condition for salvation.

[36] *Hom. in I Cor.* 3.4-5 (PG 61, 28); *Hom. in Genes.* 6.6 (PG 53, 60).
[37] *Hom. in I Cor.* 5.2 (PG 61, 40).

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What Does It Mean to Say that John Chrysostom Was a Monk?

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There is a widespread and persistent assumption that, whatever other role he adopted, John Chrysostom was at heart, and for the majority of his life, a monk[1]. And yet, if we set aside for the moment John's own writings on the subject, it is noteworthy that the sources that might suggest this is the case are extremely brief regarding this point, and few in number. When it comes to this assumption, then, we must ask ourselves how solid is its foundation?

The major source is the partisan defence of John by his close colleague Palladius. Palladius tells us in Chapter five of the *Dialogue* that, as a young man in Antioch, following his appointment as lector under Bishop Meletius, John took himself off to the mountains surrounding the city, where he apprenticed himself to an old ascetic. After four years, he retired to a cave for a further two years, where he practised sleep deprivation and stasis and concentrated on learning the scriptures. It was only when his kidney function and overall health were threatened as a result of that lifestyle, that he returned to the embrace of the church[2]. By contrast, Ps-Martyrius embarks on his discussion of John's career prior to Constantinople with the vague comment, 'When he transferred to the wondrous life of the monks ...', adding little more than that John became experienced at that time in the reading and knowledge of the scriptures, and that this took place prior to his baptism[3]. Ps-Martyrius thus appears to be referring to a period of monastic *askesis* distinct from that described by Palladius, and more in line with a third

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[1] At its most evident in J.N.D. Kelly, *Golden Mouth. The Story of John Chrysostom: Ascetic, Preacher, Bishop* (London, 1995), esp. 35 ('he remained a monk at heart ... [and] continued ... to practise his routine of monastic austerities'); and in the recent study by Claudia Tiersch, *Johannes Chrysostomos in Konstantinopel (398-404).Weltsicht und Wirken eines Bischofs in der Hauptstadt des Oströmischen Reiches* (Tübingen, 2002): 'Ungebrochen war jedoch die Faszination die die Lebensweise der syrischen Mönche auf ihn ausgeübt hatte. Er behielt ... selbst die monastische Lebensweise bis zum Ende seines Lebens bei ...' (60).

[2] Ed. A.-M. Malingrey and P. Leclercq, SC 341, 108,16-110,33.

[3] Ps-Martyrius, *Vita* 20-26 (Parisinus graecus 1519 (= P) 457a-458b).

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source[4]. Socrates refers to a phase in which John attended the ascetical school or *asketerion* of Diodore and Carterius in Antioch. According to him[5], this training took place shortly after John completed his rhetorical training and was about to embark on a secular administrative career, and thus perhaps prior to the period mentioned by Palladius.

Taken together, these three sources suggest a progressively more intense immersion by the young John in ascetic discipline, which was then abruptly broken off after some eight or more years had elapsed. Given the brevity of the information supplied by these sources and that all three refer exclusively to the period before John entered the priesthood – a period in which none of the three is interested for its own sake, except as an introduction to the main events – at least two questions immediately arise. Firstly, how reliable is the picture they draw of an intense and increasingly in-depth interest in the ascetic life on the part of the young John? Is it possible that the length of time involved and/or the nature of John's engagement with asceticism have been exaggerated? And secondly, given the widespread influence of Palladius' account in particular upon Chrysostomian scholarship, how valid is Palladius' implied assertion that John would not have abandoned monastic life in the mountains outside Antioch had he not been forced to do so? Both questions are apposite when we consider that it is unlikely that any of the three sources knew the details of John's earlier Antiochene years personally, and in light of recent challenges to Palladius' implied claims shortly afterwards in the same chapter with regard to the manner in which John was removed from Antioch and taken to Constantinople to begin his career as bishop[6].

The point of this paper is not to deny that the young John had personal experience of some form of organised monastic life. That much, it seems from his own writings[7], must be accepted. In attempting to show that in terms of the way they depict these years none of the three sources can be taken at face value, however, the intent here is to take the first steps towards a broader range of questions, which are the subject of a more extensive study[8]: for instance, does Palladius obscure the fact that John was already thinking of moving back to Antioch? Was the termination of his tenure in monastic circles in fact self-imposed? What models did John have available to him, both of the relationship between urban life and asceticism and of that between the priesthood and

[4] Since Ps-Martyrius goes on to say that God could not allow such a choice vessel to be hidden in the wilderness, and so brought him to the attention of the current bishop, which led to John's ordination as deacon (*Vita* 27-28 (P 459a)), it is possible that Ps-Martyrius has either deliberately or carelessly glossed over different stages in John's ascetic development.

[5] Socr., *HE* 6.3.2-7; cf. Soz., *HE* 8.2.5-7.

[6] W. Mayer, 'Antioch: Examining the Episcopate of John Chrysostom from Another Angle', *JEH* forthcoming.

[7] See *Ad Demetrium de compunctione* 1.6 (PG 47, 403,28-38).

[8] This paper details the programme of investigation for a chapter on Chrysostom's 'monasticism' in my forthcoming book, *John – Priest of Antioch, Bishop of Constantinople.*

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the ascetic life? How diverse were these models? How did John himself perceive the ascetic life? What reflections exist in his writings of the two widely differing ascetic lifestyles that he allegedly personally experienced? How do his own reflections on asceticism shed light on what we can reconstruct of his lifestyle after ordination, both in Antioch and, later, in Constantinople? In short, what does it mean to say that John Chrysostom was a monk? Is this claim even valid? To answer these more major questions is to make one's way slowly inside the mind of both John and the citizens of Antioch. If we can answer them, we will be able to assess whether, in his own eyes, John Chrysostom was indeed always a 'monk' or whether he no longer viewed himself in these terms after he returned from the Antiochene mountains and 'wilderness' to the city.

To return to the question of the reliability of the sources regarding John's forays into asceticism, it is important to point out that all three sources in general exhibit scanty knowledge of John's life prior to Constantinople. Ps-Martyrius speaks of it in somewhat elevated, but imprecise terms[9]. Socrates (whom Sozomen essentially follows) skims through John's secular and spiritual educations, mentions his appointment as lector, then ordinations as deacon and subsequently, presbyter, before going on to outline in brief John's character and habits – the whole peppered with a number of factual errors[10]. Palladius briefly mentions his family and secular education, his baptism by Meletius and appointment as lector, outlines his years as an ascetic in the mountains, and then briefly skims over his years as deacon and as presbyter. With regard to the basic facts, Palladius appears the most reliable. Unlike Socrates, he offers plausible names for the bishops who ordain John as deacon and as presbyter and offers precise figures for the number of years that John spent in his various phases. These do not fall outside of what can be reconstructed of his pre-Constantinopolitan life[11].

Even if we accept that the basic facts may be correct in his case, however, this does not mean that Palladius has not arrayed them in a particular light. Palladius is noticeably at pains to impress upon his listeners that the choice to leave the monastic life in the mountains was not John's, but was forced upon him by his deteriorating health[12]. It is also significant that he devotes a comparatively large amount of space to John's monastic years (some eighteen

[9] *Vita* 20-35 (P 457a-461b): John practices monasticism, learns the scriptures, comes to the attention of the bishop, becomes deacon, then later presbyter.

[10] Socr., *HE* 6.3.8, wrongly identifies John's friend Basil as Basil the Great, claims that John was appointed lector by Zeno, and at 6.3.12 says he was later ordained presbyter by Evagrius. The claim at 6.3.11, too, that John separated himself from the Meletian side of the Antiochene schism for three years after Meletius' death seems unlikely, given John's obvious attachment to that side of the schism, unless it can be explained in terms of John's grief over Meletius' death.

[11] On this point see Kelly, *Golden Mouth*, 296-8, who speculates that Palladius derived this information from John himself.

[12] *Dial.* 5 (SC 341, 110,30-3).

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lines in the Malingrey edition), when the rest of John's experiences (his secular education, his lectorship, diaconate, and presbyterate) are rapidly glossed over[13]. It would seem that there is a double agenda here. Firstly, Palladius needs to explain away the accusation brought at the Synod of the Oak regarding John's eating habits[14]. That this is a major issue for him becomes clear later in the *Dialogue*, where he devotes an entire chapter to the subject[15]. By claiming that John's constitution was damaged by extreme ascetic practice, Palladius inserts early into his defence the most acceptable and indeed laudable reason for John's solitude while eating, and his poor hospitality. Secondly, Palladius is also at pains, later in Chapter 5, to portray John's ascension to the throne of Constantinople as an event in which he was the reluctant victim and himself played no active part. As argued elsewhere, it is extremely unlikely that John was as uninvolved as Palladius makes him appear[16]. In the case of his monastic interlude, too, then, it is important to question the impression Palladius carefully crafts that John played no active role in the decision to return to Antioch. Significantly, this same passivity in regard to the termination of John's life as a monk is found in the spin put on events by Ps-Martyrius. There God, rather than John's health, makes it impossible for him to stay in the wilderness[17]. In both instances, I would argue, presenting John as the innocent victim of either circumstance or the manipulations of others is an important device in crafting John's story into apologetic hagiography.

To return again to the issue of reliability, if Socrates' account of John's early experiences is particularly susceptible to error, then the details of his time at the *asketerion* may or may not be accurate. At the same time, if the accounts of John's time as a monk provided by Ps-Martyrius and Palladius have been doctored to present a particular case, then these too must be taken with a grain of salt and their claims read with a certain amount of scepticism. The key question then becomes, did John voluntarily quit a withdrawn ascetic life to return to active service in the church and the life of the city? If he did, then the implications of this for the view that he remained at heart and, to a degree in practice, a monk must be reconsidered. Other considerations challenge this view, too, and demand a larger and more extensive study of the issue. Chief among these is John's reaction to exile, a time when he was provided with precisely the physical and social isolation and deprivation that, if our view of the character of asceticism in Syria and in Antioch, in particular,

[13] The rest of his early years is summed up in twenty-five lines (SC 341, 104,1-108,15; 110,34-112,43).

[14] Charge 25 brought by John (SC 342, 106,51-2), Charge 3 brought by Isaac (SC 342, 108,91-2).

[15] Palladius, *Dial.* 12.

[16] See n. 6 above.

[17] See n. 4 above.

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is accurate[18], ought to have been no hardship for a person with this inclination and training. And yet, his correspondence from this period dwells precisely upon the lack of social contact, the physical discomforts, and the lack of services as major negatives. The point is that, even if he was unable to tolerate the lifestyle any longer in the flesh, as Palladius suggests, there is no evidence here that his spirit was willing either. Rather, John's deliberate suppression within his letters of his local pastoral activities in Armenia in favour of an intense focus on his rehabilitation to the episcopate and on events relating to the see of Constantinople and its dependents, suggests that the role of bishop held a key position in his mind and that he considered it was this, rather than the role of monk, that at this point in his life defined him.

To sum up, until we understand better how Syrian asceticism and Antiochene church life influenced his understanding of the ascetic life and its relation to ordained ministry, especially the episcopate, through studies in particular of his role models back in Antioch, both ascetic and ecclesiastical[19], we will remain far from grasping truly what it means to say that John Chryostom was a 'monk'. Within the broader context of improving our understanding of the concept 'monk-bishop', of the relationship between ascetic virtue and the *polis* in late antiquty and between asceticism as an interior virtue and its external expression, this question, it seems to me, is fundamental.

[18] Another key question. For a challenge to the prevailing views, see W. Mayer, 'Monasticism at Antioch and Constantinople in the Late Fourth Century. A case of exclusivity or diversity?', in P. Allen *et al.* (eds), *Prayer and Spirituality in the Early Church*, 1 (Brisbane, 1998), 275-88.

[19] E.g, Diodore and Carterius, the monks Aphraat and Macedonius, the bishops Eustathius, Meletius, and Flavian. The recent brief study by Martin Illert, *Johannes Chrysostomus und das antiochenish-syrische Mönchtum. Studien zu Theologie, Rhetorik und Kirchenpolitik im antiochenischen Schrifttum des Johannes Chrysostomus*, (Zürich and Freiburg i. Br., 2000), is also an important starting point.

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John Chrysostom's Treatises on 'Spiritual Marriage'

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1. Introduction

In early Christianity, women and men who lived together in 'spiritual marriage' followed a Christian way of life: they lived in a relationship which Bailey defined as 'the cohabitation of the sexes under the condition of strict continence'[1]. Blake Leyerle addresses the problem of the term to use to describe a relationship 'in which a man and a woman, or a man and several women, all under the vows of sexual continence, shared a house'[2]. She concludes that from the beginning of the debate about this relationship in the early Church until the present time there has been no adequate name for it. In studies of early Christianity the term 'spiritual marriage' is usually used. Meanwhile medievalists use the term 'spiritual marriage' for what in early Christian studies would be called 'chaste marriage' – the non-consummated relationship of a legally married couple[3]. When Hans Achelis[4] at the beginning of the twentieth century started to investigate this kind of relationship by focusing on different sources related to the topic, he used the Latin term *subintroductae*, which designates – in a negative way – the women living in this manner. Since Achelis' studies, the sources for and the phenomenon of 'spiritual marriage' itself have increasingly become the focus of research[5].

[1] Derrick Sherwin Bailey, *Sexual Relation in Christian Thought* (New York, 1959), 33 cited in Elizabeth Clark, *Jerome, Chrysostom and Friends. Essays and Translations* (New York, 1979), 162.

[2] Blake Leyerle, *Theatrical Shows and Ascetic Lives. John Chrysostom's Attack on Spiritual Marriage* (Berkeley/Los Angeles/London, 2001), 76.

[3] Leyerle, 77. On chaste marriage, see Dyan Elliot, *Spiritual Marriage: Sexual Abstinence in Medieval Wedlock* (Princeton, 1993).

[4] Hans Achelis, *Virgines Subintroductae. Ein Beitrag zum VII. Kapitel des I. Korintherbriefs* (Leipzig, 1902).

[5] Elizabeth Clark, 'John Chrysostom and the Subintroductae', *CH* 46 (1977), 171-85; Susanna Elm, 'Formen des Zusammenlebens männlicher und weiblicher Asketen im östlichen Mittelmeerraum während des vierten Jahrhunderts nach Christus', in: Kaspar Elm and Michel Parisse, eds., *Doppelklöster und andere Formen der Symbiose männlicher und weiblicher Religiosen im Mittelalter*, Berliner Historische Studien 18 (Berlin, 1992), 13-24; Anne Jensen, tr. O.C. Dean, *God's Self-Confident Daughters. Early Christianity and the Liberation of Women* (Louisville, 1994), 20-1 and 44-8; Susanna Elm, *Virgins of God. The Making of Ascetism in Late Antiquity* (Oxford, 1994), 48-51; J.N.D. Kelly, *Goldenmouth. The Story of John Chrysostom – Ascetic, Preacher, Bishop* (Ithaca, 1995), 48-51; Leyerle, *Theatrical Shows and Ascetic Lives.*

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John Chrysostom's two treatises 'Instruction and Refutation Directed Against Those Men Cohabiting With Virgins' and 'On the Necessity of Guarding Virginity'[6] are significant and detailed documents concerning 'spiritual marriage' in early Christianity. The precise dating of the texts is uncertain. Socrates dated them to Chrysostom's time as a deacon in Antioch, and Palladius to the time when Chrysostom became bishop in Constantinople. The information we obtain from these two ancient historians points to another option: both may be right, and the treatises may have been published twice[7].

2. 'Spiritual Marriage' as a Variety of Close Relationship Between Women and Men of Different Social Status

According to Chrysostom's treatises, women and men who lived in 'Spiritual Marriage' transgressed within their relationship traditional boundaries of social status, economic wealth, and political power. Chrysostom calls this 'third option' between marriage and prostitution συνοικεῖν. When Chrysostom refers to the women involved in spiritual marriages in his text, he mostly describes them as 'virgins'. Normally he does not mention the social status of the men[8]. There are, however, two exceptions: the first is that he describes a scene in the domicile of a monk (ἀνδρὸς μονάζοντος)[9], while the second points to men with a high social status:

> It may be, if you please, that the housemate is not some man of the common variety nor one of the rejects, but is among those who have considerable power in the church because of the brilliance of his family line and his power of speech. (*Quod reg.* 7.33-36: Clark, 229)

[6] Text and translations of Johannes Chrysostomus, *Adversus eos qui apud se habent subintroductas virgines* and *Quod regulares feminae viris cohabitare non debeant*:
Greek and French tr.: *Les cohabitations suspectes* and *Comment observer la virginité*, ed. Jean Dumortier (Paris, 1955).
English tr.: 'Instruction and Refutation Directed Against Those Men Cohabiting With Virgins', 'On the Necessity of Guarding Virginity', in Clark, *Jerome, Chrysostom and Friends*, 158-248.
German tr.: 'Gegen jene Mönche, welche Jungfrauen in's Haus aufnehmen und als Schwestern bei sich wohnen lassen', und 'Daß gottgeweihte Jungfrauen nicht mit Männern zusammen leben sollen', in Jakob Fluck, ed., *Die ascetischen Schriften des heiligen Johannes Chrysostomus* (Freiburg, 1864), 115-74.
For discussion on the original title, see Jean Dumortier, 'La date des deux traités de Saint Jean Chrysostome aux moines et aux vierges', *MSR* 6 (1949), 250; Neil Adkin, 'The Date of St. John Chrysostom's Treatises on 'Subintroductae'', *RBen* 102 (1992), 257; Kelly, 49; Leyerle, 78-9.

[7] Dumortier, 247-52; Adkin, 255-66; Leyerle, 213 ff.; Kelly, 48-9.

[8] Leyerle, 78-9.

[9] *Adv. eos* 9.70-71: Clark, 192. For discussion on the question whether the men were priests or not, see Leyerle, 92-3.

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Chrysostom also explains that the women and men involved in 'spiritual marriage' have different financial resources[10], for example, he talks about rich and poor virgins:

'Yes,' he says, 'but what if she wrestles with extreme poverty? As far as the rich virgins went, your points were well-taken'. (*Adv. eos* 7.27-29: Clark, 183[11])

From these examples we can conclude that the term 'spiritual marriage' includes a wide range of relationships.

3. John Chrysostom's Polemic Against Women and Men Who 'Live Together' (συνοικεῖν)

John Chrysostom is on the whole highly critical of women and men who lived together, and he devalues all parties involved. He argues that it is wrong for ascetic women and men to live together and share a house. He wants to convince his audience that it is necessary for the women and men involved to reject their close relationship. He says that he does not want to judge these women and men; his aim is rather to act as a physician who convinces, persuades, and heals. In this, John Chrysostom's text is a polemical text. This is evident linguistically because he takes quotations from his opponents and uses them as a component of his polemic, and he defames his opponents. He devalues the women and men who live together by showing them as ridiculous, endangered, and weaklings. He depicts men dealing with typical female activities[12]. He refers to them as slaves of women[13] and describes them as victims of female tyranny. He exposes them to ridicule by saying,

He [Christ] has not furnished us with spiritual weapons so that we take upon ourselves the service of girls worth only three obols, that we turn our attention to matters which concern wool and weaving and other such tasks, that we sit alongside women as they spin and weave, that we spend all day having our souls stamped with women's habits and speech. (*Adv. eos* 10.73-79: Clark, 195)

He devalues the women as dressy and vain, and says that they pay too much attention to their appearance[14]. He also accuses them of taking pride 'in this harsh tyranny' of men[15]. Women and men who live together are from his point of view too concerned with worldly affairs. He criticises the fact that men in some cases instruct women to be interested in economic wealth and

[10] On the social status of the couples, see Leyerle, 89-91.
[11] Similarly 'But the man who lives with a poor woman...' (*Adv. eos* 10.24-27: Clark, 193).
[12] *Adv. eos* 9.74-90: Clark, 192.
[13] *Adv. eos* 10.70-72: Clark, 195.
[14] *Adv. eos* 11.54-57: Clark, 198.
[15] *Adv. eos* 11.77-78: Clark, 198.

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prosperity: in such a case the woman and the man are dealing with financial resources although, for neither of them, does this suit their calling in life. Concerning the women he says,

If she wants to have business to attend to, why does she play with things which are not to be trifled with? For when a virgin does such things, the game she plays does not give pleasure but results in death. (*Adv. eos* 7.14-19: Clark, 183)

He accuses the men of being eunuchs[16] who are responsible for the house, and he says that they, instead of being ascetic, have taken on the roles of managers, governors, and lawyers[17].

4. John Chrysostom's View of Ideal Ways of Living Together and Their Legitimation

Chrysostom favours traditional ways of life and uses religiously legitimated norms and laws to authorise these ways. He accuses those who live together of defying these laws:

God does not wish us to free ourselves from practical concerns in this manner; instead he wants us to despise possessions, to be detached from all the things of this life. You, however, do not permit this nor do you concede that God's law should prevail. (*Adv. eos* 6.72-75: Clark, 182)

He also says that it would be better for women to live in a legal marriage and have a husband who is responsible for them economically[18], although real ascetic life should always take precedence over marriage. He pleads for traditional gender roles: the roles and behaviour of women are connected to the house and the duties of the house, while the main duties of men are to deal with public life and to dominate women:

... since even from the beginning the man was assigned to civic affairs and it was her lot to guard the house and manage all its arrangements. (*Quod reg.* 7.7-10: Clark, 228)

From his point of view, the task of ascetic women and men is to reject the earthly world, to fight against demons and to be strong fighters for Christ: 'Christ wants us to be stalwart soldiers and athletes' (*Adv. eos* 10.72-73: Clark, 195)[19]. He begins his second treatise by lamenting the betrayal of

[16] *Adv. eos* 6.44: Clark, 181. On the social role of eunuchs, see Keth Hopkins, 'Eunuchs in the Late Roman Empire', *Cambridge Philological Proceedings* 9 (1962), 62-80, and Peter Guyot, *Eunuchen als Sklaven und Freigelassene in der griechisch-römischen Antike*, Beiträge zur Geschichte und Politik 14, (Stuttgart, 1980).

[17] Cf. *Adv. eos* 6.14-21: Clark, 180, and Leyerle, 95.

[18] 'How much better would it have been for her to marry and live with a man who could attend to the management of these matters...' (*Adv. eos* 6.54-57: Clark, 181, and *Quod reg.* 4.20-21: Clark, 219).

[19] See Leyerle, 75.

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virginity by those who were called on to be the army of Christ[20]. He compares virgins in the company of men with prostitutes[21]. As virgins, women should not enter the public sphere. The following citation shows his idealised picture of virgins[22]:

... so the virgin too ought to throw everyone who sees her into wonder and terror at her holiness. For when she walks, it is as though through a desert, and when she sits in church in deepest silence, her eyes see none of those in attendance, neither men nor women, but only the Bridegroom, as if he were present and visible, and having conversed with him in prayer, she retires to her house and hears his voice alone through the scriptures. (*Quod reg.* 9.68-75: Clark, 237)

For an ideal virgin, luxury is forbidden, because she should focus totally on her soul. Such a life is the only real adornment. He also argues that it would be better for women to live together with women and for men to live together with men, because of the same needs each sex has[23].

5. Chrysostom's View of the Motivation for 'Living Together'

In Chrysotom's discussion, men who live together with women are motivated by a 'bleak and wretched pleasure' (*Quod reg.* 7.16: Clark, 229), and women live together with men because of their love of vanity[24]. Chrysostom supposes that it is impossible for men to live in such a close relationship without any sexual undertones:

But I do wish our accusers could also persuade us on this point: that a young man bursting with vigor can cohabit with a girl, sit side by side with her, eat with her, talk with her all day long (not to mention all the rest – untimely laughter, merriment, sweet talk, and so forth, which is perhaps not nice to speak about), have the house, the table, the salt in common, share everything very frankly, and yet not be seized by any human sentiment, but remain pure of evil desire and pleasure. (*Adv. eos* 3.6-15: Clark, 170f.)

This text is clearly misogynist. Chrysostom says that nobody would live together with a woman were it not for her erotic attraction, and thus he reduces women to their sexual attractiveness[25]:

Thus even from the beginning God endowed women with this strength [love and lust], knowing that she would be totally despicable unless she were provided with this power, that no man would choose to live with her if he were innocent of desire. (*Adv. eos* 5.67-71: Clark, 179)

[20] *Quod reg.* 1.28-34: Clark, 210.
[21] On language and the sexualised figure of the female prostitute, see Leyerle, 73-4 and 152.
[22] Elm, *Virgins of God*, 165, and Leyerle, 171-2.
[23] Chrysostom argues that it would be better for a man to live with a man in *Adv. eos* 9.46-69: Clark, 191-2, and for a woman to live with a woman in *Quod reg.* 4.88-98: Clark, 221f.
[24] *Quod reg.* 7.15: Clark, 229.
[25] Leyerle, 117.

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6. Conclusion

In his treatises, John Chrysostom gives us a deep insight into the variety of relationships of women and men who lived together in 'spiritual marriage' in early Christianity. Although he criticises women and men who have chosen 'this third way of life' and pleads for traditional ways of life, his text reveals to us how traditional roles of women and men who lived together were redefined. Furthermore, we discover their disagreements with traditional attitudes and models of behaviour, and their rejection of traditional hierarchical distinctions through the transgression of gender roles[26].

[26] Leyerle, 97-9. For her comparision with the theater, see 121ff.

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Painful Preaching: John Chrysostom and the Philosophical Tradition of Guiding Souls

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In Plato's *Phaedrus*, a preliminary definition of rhetoric is given by Socrates: 'As a whole, the rhetorical art is a kind of guidance of souls by means of words (ψυχαγωγία τις διὰ λόγων) ...'[1] For centuries, Greek and Roman philosophical schools discussed psychagogy or spiritual guidance, the way in which the philosopher could most effectively use rhetoric to care for and guide students in a particular way of life. Certain features of classical psychagogy, such as the use of harsh rhetoric in guiding souls, shape John Chrysostom's exegesis and homiletical methods. If his preaching is to be understood in its context, the philosophical tradition of psychagogy must be taken into account.

According to Plato's description of psychagogy, adaptation is critically important if a person is to guide souls persuasively. In order to adapt well, a spiritual guide must have a thorough knowledge of various kinds of souls as well as the way in which different types of speech affect each kind of soul[2]. A guide must also adapt to particular circumstances, discerning, for example, when to speak and when to be silent[3]. But adaptation does not mean that the speaker should simply say what seems right to the crowd. Plato makes clear that the orator must not cater to the opinions of others[4]. A spiritual guide is not a flatterer who aims only for pleasing spectators. Instead, aiming for the good and beneficial, a guide is a frank counsellor who assumes that what is pleasant is not always beneficial; pain sometimes is[5].

A frank spiritual guide adapts his speech to different souls by using a mixed method of exhortation. A mixture of harshness and gentleness is a basic formal

[1] *Phaedrus* 261a-b; see also 271c. For Gorgias, the rhetor is a ψυχαγωγός who uses everything at his disposal to lead souls in a kind of poetic incantation. Cf. Elizabeth Asmis, 'Psychagogy in Plato's *Phaedrus*', *Illinois Classical Studies* 11.1-2 (1986): 153-72; Charles P. Segal, 'Gorgias and the Psychology of the Logos', *HSCP* 66 (1962), 99ff.; Mario Untersteiner, *The Sophists*, tr. Kathleen Freeman (New York: Philosophical Library, 1954), pp. 119f.

[2] *Phaedrus* 270b-272a (LCL 36, 548-55).

[3] *Phaedrus* 271d-272b; 277b-c (LCL 36, 552-5; 570-1).

[4] *Phaedrus* 260a-262c (LCL 36, 512-23).

[5] *Sophist* 222d-223a (LCL 123, 286-9); *Phaedrus* 240b (LCL 36, 452-3); *Gorgias* 461b-466a; 500b-503a; 520c-522e; 525b-c (LCL 166, 306-23; 442-53; 508-19; 524-5); *Republic* 404c-d (LCL 237, 266-9).

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structure of persuasive psychagogic discourse. Already in Homer, one can see the practice of speaking 'with gentle words at times, at others harsh'[6]. Plato speaks of the venerable pedagogical method of fathers, an 'admonitory kind of education', which sometimes shows anger at the errors of children and sometimes more gently exhorts them[7]. Reproaches and curses may, at times, effect more improvement than praise or blessing. The language of parents, schoolmasters, or magistrates should not be simplistically used to judge the character or consistency of the speaker. Isocrates indicates that the speaker's intentions and the character of those addressed should be considered:

> Do not think that it is their natural dispositions alone which make rulers harsh or gentle, but the character of the citizens as well; for many before now have been compelled by the depravity of their subjects to rule more harshly than they wished[8].

The psychagogic themes sounded during the Greek classical age were widespread in Graeco-Roman society. Cynics, Stoics, Platonists, Peripatetics, Epicureans, and Pythagoreans were all, in some form or shape, striving to reform souls. Classic psychagogic methods for attaining this goal were commonly employed by these diverse Hellenistic philosophical schools. Consider Epicurean and Stoic use of the mixed method of exhortation, for example. Philodemus' work *On Frank Criticism* (Περὶ Παρρησίας) is essentially an Epicurean handbook on psychagogic theory and practice[9]. It discusses at length how different types of souls in a community should guide one another through various types and degrees of harsh and gentle παρρησία. The Stoic Epictetus, a philosopher to whom Chrysostom explicitly refers in his corpus, also advocates a mixed method of exhortation. A philosopher's frank speech, he argues, serves the truth and is not afraid to censure a friend[10]. In fact, the greater the sickness of a friend, the harsher the method of healing required[11]. 'The school of the philosopher is surgery,' Epictetus insists. If you are not healthy when you enter, 'you should not depart from it in pleasure, but in pain'[12].

Philosophical methods of guidance also influenced the earliest expressions of Christianity. Such methods are already exhibited by the Apostle Paul, who debated with both Epicurean and Stoic philosophers (Acts 17:18)[13]. In

[6] *Iliad* 12.267 (LCL 170, 576-7).

[7] *Sophist* 229e-230a (LCL 123, 312-15); see also *Laws* 791d-793a (LCL 192, 14-19).

[8] *Nicocles or the Cyprians* 55 (LCL 209, 108-9); see also Isocrates' discourses on moral education: *On the Peace* 72 (LCL 229, 50-3); *To Philip* 1.22 (LCL 373, 396-7); *To Demonicus* 3-6; 30-31; 45-46 (LCL 209, 4-7; 20-3; 30-3); *To Nicocles* 28, 42-43, 48-53 (LCL 209, 54-7; 62-9).

[9] Clarence Glad, 'Introduction', in *Philodemus: On Frank Criticism: Introduction, Translation, and Notes*, tr. David Konstan, Diskin Clay, *et al.* (Atlanta, GA: Scholars Press, 1998), p. 2.

[10] *Discourses* 3.22.77-97 (LCL 218, 158-65).

[11] *Discourses* 2.15.14 (LCL 131, 318-19).

[12] *Discourses* 3.23.30 (LCL 218, 180).

[13] See Abraham J. Malherbe, *Paul and the Thessalonians: The Philosophic Tradition of Pastoral Care* (Philadelphia: Fortress, 1987); Clarence Glad, *Paul and Philodemus: Adaptability in Epicurean and Early Christian Psychagogy* (New York: E.J. Brill, 1995).

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succeeding centuries, as the Christian tradition defined itself as the true φιλοσοφία[14], it transformed the figure of the classical philosopher as spiritual guide into the person of the clerical spiritual guide[15]. Recent studies have accented psychagogic theory and methods in Clement, Gregory the Theologian, and Augustine[16].

Chrysostom's theology and homiletical methods also make use of the classical tradition of spiritual guidance. His theology portrays God as the Divine Teacher who employs the rhetorical art to guide souls toward salvation. God's methods of revelation throughout redemptive history are thoroughly psychagogic[17]. In Chrysostom's estimation, the Apostle Paul imitates God's method. Preaching on the harsh language in the epistle to the Galatians, Chrysostom defends Paul's words on the basis of biblical precedent: 'Why wonder if rebuke and abuse are praiseworthy, seeing that slaughter, deceit, and guile found favour in the Old Testament and the New?'[18] Moreover, Christ himself spoke both gently and sternly to his disciples: shortly after he blesses Peter for his confession (Matt. 16:17), Christ rebukes him, calling him Satan (Matt. 16:23)[19]. Similarly, Paul both calls the Galatians 'foolish' (3:1) and soothes them by expressing his maternal longing for them (4:19). Chrysostom concludes: 'Since Paul learned this method by walking in the footsteps of his teacher, he varied his discourse according to the need of his learners, at one time cutting and cauterizing, at another applying a gentle medicine'[20].

Chrysostom sees this mixed method of exhortation everywhere: his common refrain is 'because Paul had attacked them sharply, he refreshes them

[14] For discussion and references, see Anne-Marie Malingrey, *'Philosophia': Étude d' un groupe de mots dans la littérature grecque des Présocratiques au IVe siècle après J.C.* (Paris: Klincksieck, 1961); and J. Leclercq, 'Pour l'histoire de l'expression "philosophic chrétienne"', *MSR* 9 (1952), 221-6. Pagans also perceived Christianity in terms of classical philosophy and rhetoric: e.g., Lucian refers to Christians as 'worshipping that crucified sophist [σοφιστήν]' (*De morte Peregrini* 13 (LCL 302, 14)).

[15] Ilsetraut Hadot, 'The Spiritual Guide', in *Classical Mediterranean Spirituality: Egyptian, Greek, and Roman*, ed. A.H. Armstrong (New York: Crossroad, 1986), p. 455; Abraham J. Malherbe, 'Hellenistic Moralists and the New Testament', *ANRW* 2, *Principat*, 26.1 (1992), 304.

[16] Judith Kovacs, 'Divine Pedagogy and the Gnostic Teacher according to Clement of Alexandria', *JECS* 9.1 (2001), 3-25; Robert Wilken, 'Alexandria: A School for Training in Virtue', in *Schools of Thought in the Christian Tradition*, ed. Patrick Henry (Philadelphia: Fortress, 1984), pp. 15-30; Christopher A. Beeley, 'Gregory of Nazianzus: Trinitarian Theology, Spirituality and Pastoral Theory' (unpublished Ph.D. dissertation: University of Notre Dame, 2002); Paul R. Kolbet, 'The Cure of Souls: St. Augustine's Reception and Transformation of Classical Psychagogy' (unpublished Ph.D. dissertation: University of Notre Dame, 2002).

[17] See chapters 1-4 of my thesis, 'The Adaptability of Divine Pedagogy: *Sunkatabasis* in the Theology and Rhetoric of John Chrysostom' (unpublished Ph.D. dissertation: University of Notre Dame, 1999).

[18] *De laud. Paul.* 5 (SC 300, 258).

[19] Chrysostom provides Matt. 15:16 and John 4:27 as additional examples (*In epist. ad Gal. comm.* 1 (PG 61, 612)).

[20] *In epist. ad Gal. comm.* 1 (PG 61, 612).

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again'[21]. As the Apostle writes, he anticipates the degree to which his listeners will be proud or humble, slothful or despairing, weak or strong in faith[22]. In order to adapt to the state of his listeners' souls, he rhetorically moves back and forth along a gentle–harsh continuum. Chrysostom, carefully tracing the ebb and flow of Paul's harshness in each verse or even single word[23], shows how listeners are increasingly guided toward a Christian way of life[24].

Two characteristics of Chrysostom's rhetorical analysis of Paul should be noted. First, Chrysostom portrays Paul as frustrated that some of his students lack progress and convinced that harshness is necessary if gentleness does not reform a person[25]. Second, Chrysostom praises Paul's apparent deception whereby the apostle controls the emotions of his listeners: Paul 'utters angry words, not that he himself felt this way but in order to correct them'[26]. Paul appears to his listeners not as he is, but in the way the weak are able to receive him most profitably. Paul's true feelings of love are concealed so that his pupils can progress. Therefore, his severity is actually an expression of love[27]. Paul employs benevolent harshness. By wounding, he heals.

Since Paul, according to Chrysostom, is the perfect model of a priest[28], every priest should imitate the Apostle's oscillation between gentleness and severity. Because a priest must minister to a wide variety of people, Chrysostom concludes in his work *On the Priesthood*:

[21] *In epist. i ad Cor.* 10.3 (PG 61, 83). Or 'he frames his rebuke in combination with praise. For this is always a part of Paul's wisdom, to mix painful things with kind ones ... He achieves two things: he does not overstrain them nor allow them to fall back' (*In epist. ad Heb.* 8.4 (PG 63, 71); cf. *In epist. ii ad Cor.* 18.1 (PG 61, 525)). Cf. Frances Young's comments on Paul's oscillation between severity and tenderness ('John Chrysostom on 1 and 2 Corinthians', *SP* (1986), 349-52; also, Young, *Biblical Exegesis and the Formation of Christian Culture* (Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1997), pp. 254-5).

[22] *In epist. ad Heb.* 8.5 (PG 63, 71) is typical: 'Observe, I beseech you, Paul's great wisdom, how he always acts according to the conditions of the souls before him ...'

[23] E.g., Chrysostom often demonstrates how Paul, in a single verse, can simultaneously shore up the obedient and pull down the proud (*In epist. i ad Cor.* 26.2 (PG 61, 213)). Even in Paul's use of a little word such as ἡμῶν in 1 Cor. 4:8, Chrysostom can detect great anger (*In epist. i ad Cor.* 12.4 (PG 61, 98)).

[24] In addition to tracing Paul's severity verse by verse, Chrysostom indicates that the ordering of topics in a letter is determined, at least in part, by the degree of harshness which each topic requires and which the psyche of his listeners can bear. 1 Corinthians 7, for example, is a 'relief from more unpleasant subjects', and the most serious offence (heresy regarding the resurrection) is saved until last (*In epist. i ad Cor.* 19.1; 26.1-2 (PG 61, 151; 211-13)).

[25] *In epist. ad Heb.* 8.4 (PG 63, 70) on 5:11-14; *In epist. i ad Cor.* 3.1 (PG 61, 23) on 1 Cor. 3:2.

[26] *In epist. i ad Cor.* 14.2 (PG 61, 115).

[27] E.g. 'Do you see how he shows in himself simultaneously his severity and his care over them'? (*In epist. i ad Cor.* 12.4 (PG 61, 98)). Commenting on 1 Cor. 4:21, 'Shall I come with a rod or in love?', Chrysostom exclaims, 'Coming with a rod is surely an instance of love' (*In epist. i ad Cor.* 14.4 (PG 61, 117)).

[28] *De Sacerd.* 6.5 (SC 272, 322); see also *In Gen.* 11.13 (PG 53, 95).

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[The priest] must be many-sided. I say many-sided – not a charlatan, a flatterer, or a hypocrite; but absolutely open and frank of speech [ἐλευθερίας καὶ παρρησίας], knowing to adapt appropriately when the situation requires, and to be both kindly and severe. It is impossible to treat all his people in one way, any more than it would be right for the doctors to deal with all their patients alike or a helmsman to know only one way of battling with the winds. This ship of ours is beset with continual storms ... Great adaptation and great severity are both needed. And all these different methods look to one goal: the glory of God and the edification of the Church[29].

If one reads Chrysostom as he reads Paul, a mixed method of rhetoric seems virtually omnipresent in the exhortation sections of his homilies. Gentleness and harshness are used to steer people between the pits of despair and sloth; he encourages the former and frightens the latter. When addressing the despairing, for example, Chrysostom insists that vices can be easily overcome, even within a matter of days; to the slothful and overconfident, however, he acts as if virtue is nearly impossible to attain if one allows onself to fall into sin[30].

Since his goal is reform, Chrysostom claims that his severity is a loving remedy. Even when his rhetoric of abuse assaults spiritual marriage, Anomoeans, or Judaizers, he expresses his desire not simply to warn believers away from errors of doctrine or life, but also to win back those who have strayed from the church[31]. Chrysostom indicates that, as in the case of Paul, his harshness is a mask that conceals his love. He appears to the recalcitrant not as he is, but in a way which is profitable to them. Once harshness has had its desired beneficial effect, the mask can be removed: 'As long as there was need of harsh expressions, Paul refrained from drawing the curtain ... but when the time came for a gentler process, he stripped off the mask'[32].

Chrysostom's severity is prominent throughout his preaching. Although there is indeed political awareness and savvy behind some of his harshness[33], his refusal to be a more gentle, accommodating preacher on certain occasions can also be seen as leading to his exile and death[34]. Does political naïveté and/or personality alone fully explain such harshness?[35] Perhaps not. Chrysostom

[29] 6.4 (SC 272., 320); see also *In epist. ad Tit.* 3 (PG 62, 678).

[30] E.g., *In epist. i ad Cor.* 11.8-9 (PG 61, 93).

[31] See the final passages of *Adv. eos gui subintroductas*; *Quod reg. feminas*; each homily of *Contra Anom.* 1-10; *Adv. Jud.* 1, 2, 4.

[32] *In epist. i ad Cor.* 12.1 (PG 61, 95). Regarding the theatrical nature of harshness, see Blake Leyerle, *Theatrical Shows and Ascetic Lives: John Chrysostom's Attack on Spiritual Marriage* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 2001), p. 194.

[33] See, for example, Leyerle's discussion of Chrysostom's angry rhetoric against spiritual marriage (*Theatrical Shows*, esp. pp. 192-205).

[34] Cf. Socrates, *Hist. eccles.* 6.18; Sozomen, *Hist. eccles.* 8.20; and Palladius, *Dial. de vita Chrys.* 8-11.

[35] On Chrysostom's propensity to anger and irritability, see his *De sacerd.* 3.10.141-45 (SC 272, 176); Socrates, *Hist. eccles.* 6.3 and 21 (PG 67, 669 and 725).

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should also be understood within the tradition of classical psychagogy which advocates that the more recalcitrant students are, the greater the proportion of harshness required[36]. Although gentleness is the primary tone of correction initially[37], according to Chrysostom, accommodation has its limits. In a homily written during the last decade of his life, Chrysostom vows to excommunicate listeners who have been continually instructed in spiritual philosophy (φιλοσοφίαν πνευματικήν), but whose proud, avaricious way of life is unchanged. Then he postures his listeners as objecting to his harshness and arguing that he should accommodate to weak people. Chrysostom rejoins, 'To what point? Till when? Once and twice and three times, but not perpetually. Behold, I charge you again and protest after the pattern of the blessed Paul, "that if I come again I will not spare" [2 Cor. 13:2]'[38]. This threat may be hollow, nothing more than another rhetorical ploy calculated to scare his listeners into obedience. However, Chrysostom may be serious. Sometimes radically harsh measures must not be spared, even if the cost to the speaker is considerable. Christ was killed because he spoke the truth, Chrysostom notes[39]. He also praises Paul for his willingness to speak the truth boldly even though suffering would inevitably result. Chrysostom himself seems willing to face exile for speaking frankly.

If, as Isocrates suggests, we do not judge a speaker simply according to language used, but also take into account the speaker's intentions and the audience's character, then Chrysostom's prickly stubbornness may be seen as stemming less from poor political sensibility than from his conviction that it is in the best interest of his listeners not to accommodate to weakness forever. Although some of his words are difficult to bear even with 1600 years of distance, understanding Chrysostom in the context of classical psychagogy is to investigate him on his own terms[40]. It situates his homilies in their native philosophical context so that their features are illumined by the hermeneutical and homiletical criteria that informed their original composition.

[36] See the recent research by Wendy Mayer and Pauline Allen on the nature of Chrysostom's audience: Mayer, 'John Chrysostom: Extraordinary Preacher, Ordinary Audience', in *Preacher and Audience. Studies in Early Christian and Byzantine Hamiletics*, ed. Mary B. Cunningham and Pauline Allen (Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1998), pp. 105-37; Mayer, 'Who Came to Hear John Chrysostom Preach? Recovering a Late Fourth-Century Preacher's Audience', *ETL* 76.1 (2000): 73-87; Allen, 'John Chrysostom's Homilies on I and II Thessalonians: The Preacher and His Audience', *SP* XXXI (1997), 3-21.

[37] *In epist. i ad Cor.* 11.9 (PG 61, 94-6); *De inani gloria et de educandis liberis* 30 and 52 (ed. A.M. Malingrey, SC 188 (1972); not in PG).

[38] *In epist. ad Col.* 7 (PG 62, 350-51).

[39] Foreknowing such a reaction, God did not send Christ earlier but instead revealed the truth in a veiled form for an extended period of time. *In epist. ad Col.* 4 (PG 62, 327).

[40] See Robert Wilken's masterful interpretation of the difficult *Adv. Jud.* in their historical context (*John Chrysostom and the Jews: Rhetoric and Reality in the Late Fourth Century* (Berkeley: University of California Press, 1983)) and his wise conclusions on p. 163.

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The Concept of Honour/Shame in Chrysostom's Commentary on Matthew

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1. Introduction

Recently many studies have shown that honour and shame were core values in the Mediterranean world in general and in the bible as well[1]. These values shaped the lives of peoples in the ancient world, including the lives of Jesus and his disciples[2]. Modern scholars who take the historical-critical approach seriously have come to realize how important it is to read ancient documents according to their appropriate cultural context, which necessarily includes appreciation of honour and shame as core social values[3]. Scholars therefore attempt to read the New Testament in terms of prevalent social values[4].

These social values also shaped the lives of the ancient theologians. Chrysostom, for example, had first-hand knowledge of these values. As a matter of fact, Chrysostom says that 'the soul has a shame implanted in us' (*hom.* lxxxvi.3). It is therefore a pity that modern scholars who study the ancient social system poised on honour and shame base their statements on classical sources only. They very seldom consult the patristic writings[5]. In this paper it will be shown how important these values were for John Chrysostom. Honour and shame were key concepts in his exegesis of the Scriptures. The aim of this article is therefore to show to what extent Chrysostom employed social values

[1] B.J. Malina, *The New Testament World. Insights from Cultural Anthropology* (Kentucky: Westminster John Knox Press, 2001), 27ff.; J.J. Pilch and B.J. Malina, *Handbook of Biblical Social Values* (Peabody: Hendrickson Publishers, 1998 [1993]), 106-7; B.J. Malina, *The Social World of Jesus and the Gospels* (New York: Routledge, 1996).

[2] J.H. Neyrey, *Honor and Shame in the Gospel of Matthew* (Kentucky: Westminster John Knox Press, 1998), 3.

[3] Neyrey, 4.

[4] Neyrey; B.J. Malina and R.L. Rohrbaugh, *A Social-scientific Commentary on the Synoptic Gospels* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1993); Malina and Rohrbaugh, *A Social-scientific Commentary on the Gospel of John* (Minneapolis: Fortress Press, 1998).

[5] The only exception is Botha, who has written extensively on the social values in the writings of Ephrem the Syrian; see P.J. Botha, 'Polarity and Divine Economy in Ephrem the Syrian's Hymn De Crucifixione V', *Acta Patristica et Byzantica* 9 (1998), 23-34; Botha, 'Honour and Shame as Pivotal Values in Ephrem the Syrian's Vision of Paradise', *Acta Patristica et Byzantica* 10 (1999), 49-65; Botha, 'Social Values and Textual Strategy in Ephrem the Syrian's Sixth Hymn on the Fast', *Acta Patristica et Byzantica* 11 (2000), 22-32.

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such as honour and shame as exegetical keys in his reading of the Gospel of Matthew.

2. Definitions

Pilch and Malina[6] define honour as

a claim to worth that is publicly acknowledged .... Shame, as the opposite of honour, is a claim to worth that is publicly denied and repudiated. To 'be shamed' is always negative; it means to be denied or to be diminished in honor. On the other hand, to 'have shame' is always positive; it means to be concerned about one's honor.

In contrast, shameless people do not care what others think of them. They disregard the code of expected behaviour. Shameless people were always held in contempt by the ancients, since they did not participate in the game of reputation[7]. To praise someone means to assign honour to the person. To blame someone means that you strip the person of honour.

3. Honour and Shame in Antioch

Chrysostom's ninety homilies on Matthew represent the oldest complete commentary on this Gospel that has survived from the patristic age[8]. Chrysostom probably delivered these sermons in Antioch, because in homily vii.7 he says to his congregation: 'Our city first crowned itself with the name of Christian'. This is probably a reference to Acts II.26 ('The disciples were called Christians first at Antioch'). These sermons were delivered about 390[9]. Chrysostom's exhortations reveal the customs and manners of his time. It is also clear from his works that social values such as honour and shame played an important role in his society.

Pilch and Malina[10] say that honour is a value embodied by adult males, while (positive) shame is a value embodied by adult females. For a male 'to lose honour' is to be shamed. This involves a loss of repute and worth in the eyes of others. This concept is also found in homily vii of Chrysostom. Chrysostom says that a male is ashamed to have a woman as a teacher (*hom.* vii.7). Yet he wants to send the males in his congregation to their wives to be

[6] Pilch and Malina, 106-7.

[7] Neyrey, 30.

[8] J. Quasten, *Patrology*, vol. 3, *The Golden Age of Greek Patristic Literature* (Utrecht: Spectrum Publishers, 1975 [1960]), 437.

[9] D.R. Bueno, *Obras de San Juan Crisóstomo. I. Homilias sobre S. Mateo (1-45)* BAC 141 (Madrid: Biblioteca de autores Cristianos, 1955), xv; Quasten, 437.

[10] Pilch and Malina, 107.

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taught by them because they are watching naked women in theatres and public pools. He says that this will be a shameful experience for them, but the scriptures send us even to irrational beings such as ants to become their disciples (cf. *hom.* vii.7). Chrysostom says that even irrational animals are more honourable than the males in his congregation (*hom.* vii.7).

4. Honour and Shame as Key Concepts in Chrysostom's Exegesis

We will now look at Chrysostom's comments on four narratives from the Gospel of Matthew as examples of his employment of social values in his exegetical treatment thereof.

4.1 A Woman Anoints Jesus at Bethany (Mt. 26:6-13)

Chrysostom says that while all the people came to Jesus to be healed, this woman came to honour him, and she received amendment of her soul. Modern scholars[11] have shown that one's head was the body part which enjoyed the most honour, while one's feet had the least honour. This is explicitly stated by Chrysostom as well. He also says that one's head is the most honourable member of the whole body (*hom.* lxxx.1). Chrysostom then adds that this woman was prepared to lay the most honourable member of her body at Christ's feet (*hom.* lxxx.1). This shows to what extent this woman was prepared to give honour to Christ.

But, according to Chrysostom, Christ also honoured her when he said that 'what she has done, will be spoken of all over in the world'. Immediately after this account, Matthew tells us about Judas' agreement to betray Jesus. Chrysostom says that it was because of the honour which women (who were harlots) showed to Jesus that Judas decided to betray Jesus (*hom.* lxxx.3).

4.2 The Canaanite Woman's Faith (Mt. 15:21-28)

Chrysostom says that Matthew explicitly states that she was a Canaanite woman because 'that would call to mind those wicked nations' (*hom.* lii.1). That would highlight her marvellous act and would make her more honourable. When Jesus turned down her request and said that he was sent only to the lost sheep of Israel, she 'made herself shameless with a goodly shamelessness' (*hom.* lii.2). Chrysostom says that earlier this woman did not venture so much as to come in sight, because we read that the disciples said, 'She cries after us'). But now she displayed shamelessness, though she was full of shame.

[11] Malina, *Handbook*; 1993; Neyrey, 65-6; R.L. Rohrbaugh, *The Social Sciences and New Testament Interpretation* (Peabody: Hendrickson Publishers, 1996).

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Chrysostom also emphasizes the humility of the woman and her willingness to honour other people. When Jesus answered, 'It isn't right to take the children's food and throw it to the dogs', he in truth compared the Jews to 'children'. But in her answer to Jesus this woman called them 'masters', because she said, 'Even the dogs eat the leftovers that fall from their masters' table'. (*hom.* lii.3). It was not difficult for this Canaanite woman to honour others, even though the words of Christ could be regarded as an insult. But Chrysostom makes it clear that in truth Jesus did not insult her. He merely wanted to reveal the treasure laid up in her.

4.3 Judas' Betrayal of Jesus (Mt. 26:17-25)

Judas' betrayal of Jesus is also interpreted in terms of honour and shame. In the first place, Chrysostom says that Judas' decision to be present at the Last Supper and to partake of the meal is proof of his shamelessness (*hom.* lxxxi.1; *hom.* lxxxii.1). According to Chrysostom, some theologians interpret Judas' conduct as bold in not honouring Jesus and daring to dip his bread in the dish with his. Chrysostom wants to differ from these scholars. He says that 'this act has something more in it'. He then argues that Christ continued to dip his bread with Judas because he wanted to shame Judas the more (*hom.* lxxxi.1).

But Judas' shamelessness became even more apparent when he said to the Lord, 'Is it I, Lord?' He dared to ask this question while he knew that Jesus referred to him. Chrysostom says that since good people are worthy of double honour (cf. 1 Tim. 5:17), so the worthless deserve twofold punishment, because they became wicked, when they might have become good (*hom.* lxxxi.2). Even the words of the Lord that 'he has eagerly desired to eat this Passover' with his disciples did not move or shame Judas. Neither was Judas shamed when Jesus said, 'It is the one to whom I will give this piece of bread when I have dipped it in the dish'.

Chrysostom ascribes Judas's betrayal to covetousness. Therefore Judas should be blamed for what he did. To be naked was a shame, but to be clothed with covetousness is much more shameful than nakedness (*hom.* lxxxi.iv).

Modern studies have shown that in antiquity meals were a form of social communication[12]. The meals of the Judaeans indicate their distinctive group affiliation[13]. It is therefore understandable why Chrysostom says that Judas displayed his shamelessness by attending the Last Supper despite his decision to betray Jesus. Yet Jesus nevertheless honoured him by allowing him to partake of the meal. But the honour which Jesus bestowed upon Judas did not help him to become better (*hom.* lxxxii.1).

When Matthew describes Judas' betrayal of Jesus, he nevertheless refers to Judas as 'one of the twelve'. According to Chrysostom, it shows that Matthew

[12] Pilch and Malina, 81ff.
[13] Rohrbaugh, 170.

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was not ashamed to mention this (*hom.* lxxxiii.2). The sign of the kiss with which Judas betrayed Jesus was another shameful act. Jesus' willingness to kiss him was an indication of his meekness, and this too should have shamed Judas. When Jesus asked Judas, 'Are you betraying the Son of Man with a kiss?', he tried to ask him whether even the form of the betrayal did not shame him.

4.4 The Resurrection of Jesus (Mt. 27-28)

When the women went to the tomb on the Sunday morning, the angel told them that he knew that 'they were looking for Jesus, who was crucified'. Chrysostom says that the angel was not ashamed of referring to Jesus as the 'Crucified One', since this is 'the chief of the blessings'.

When Jesus appeared to these women, they clasped his feet (the most dishonourable part of the body). Chrysostom says that we would wish to be like these women in clasping Jesus' feet, but when Jesus returns in glory, we would have the opportunity to clasp even his sacred head (the most honourable part of the body, *hom.* lxxxix.3). We must also bear in mind that women were associated with shame, not with honour. But Chrysostom says that Christ overturned this. He says that when Jesus sent these women to his disciples with the good news of his resurrection, he 'brought honour, as I have often said, to that sex which was most dishonoured' (*hom.* lxxxix.3).

Peter ran to the tomb and saw strips of linen lying by themselves. This is proof to Chrysostom that the body was not stolen (*hom.* xc. 2). He says that myrrh was a drug that adheres to the body and cleaves to the clothes. It was therefore not easy to take the clothes off the corpse. A thief would not want to lose time in stripping the body and carry a naked body away, because that would dishonour the corpse.

Yet soldiers were paid money to start a rumour that the disciples had stolen the body of Jesus. Chrysostom says that these soldiers were shameless when they told this story. But he is not surprised that they yielded to the temptation, since money prevailed even over Judas, who was a disciple of Jesus. But Chrysostom finds it noteworthy that Matthew was not too ashamed to tell the readers of his Gospel that such a report prevailed against the disciples. This is proof of their love of truth (*hom.* xc. 2).

5. A Social Value System Which Is Turned Upside Down

Originally anthropologists talked about honour and shame as core values in the Mediterranean world, yet they focused on Iraq, Turkey, Greece, Spain, and Morocco. Neyrey[14] admits that there are historically minded scholars who take

[14] Neyrey, 8.

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issue with this generalization. These scholars call for more nuanced studies of individual areas. Rohrbaugh[15] says that what was honourable could vary from region to region, and even from village to village. It also varied considerably among elite and non-elite sectors of the society.

But this paper wants to emphasize that the values in a Christian community also differed from values in a secular community. Modern scholars who write about social values in antiquity often fail to point out to what extent these prevalent social values were overturned in a Christian community. Believers did not have the same value system that unbelievers did. This can clearly be seen when we read Chrysostom's homilies. In the secular world wealth caused someone to be honoured in his or her community. But Chrysostom praises poverty (*hom.* xc.4). He says that Peter too was not ashamed of poverty, and even glories in it, when he says, 'Silver and gold have I none'. Chrysostom also says that if one despises the things of the world, one will become more honourable than all the world (*hom.* iv.20). The reason is, of course, that God will then honour such a person. Elsewhere (*hom.* lxxxiii.4) he says that 'foolish men regard poverty as a disgrace'. He then adds that believers should rather feel ashamed when one sees that someone is taking care of outward things. Nicely adorned houses resemble the theatres which were not pleasing to God. Chrysostom therefore argues that no one should be ashamed of a humble house, since Christ is willing to dwell in such a house.

Chrysostom also overturned other aspects of social values. We know, for example, that being born into an honourable family made one honourable since the family was the repository of the honour of past illustrious ancestors[16]. However, Chrysostom argues that Jesus' birth has taught us not to be ashamed of our ancestors' sins, but to seek after virtue (*hom.* iii.3). Sinners who have come to Christ do not even have to be disgraced by their former sinful lives. The wickedness of our ancestors will no longer have power to bring shame to us (*hom.* iii.3). Chrysostom says that this is the reason why Matthew included Ruth in Jesus' genealogy. David was not ashamed of Ruth. This leads Chrysostom to say that 'he shines forth the more, who not being of worthy ancestors, has yet become excellent' (*hom.* iii.5).

In *hom.* lxxxvii.4 Chrysostom discusses at length the whole issue of honour and shame, and how this whole value system should be overturned by believers. He then explains that believers should have complete disregard for what the world regards as honour and shame. He says that one should rather lead a righteous life and seek God's honour. The honour or dishonour which people bestow upon us has no meaning at all. No one on earth can put us to shame. Chrysostom says that if someone who is righteous and worthy of honour is being called an adulterer, a thief, a murderer, or a violator of tombs, it does not

[15] Rohrbaugh, 9.
[16] Malina, 32.

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disgrace him, even though many people may share this opinion. That righteous person is still not disgraced, while those people who hold this opinion are the ones who bring shame upon themselves.

Chrysostom then illustrates this principle with a very striking example. He says that if someone thinks that the sun is dark, he is not disgracing the sun, but he is only bringing shame upon himself 'by accounting one who is not such to be such' (*hom.* lxxxvii.4). Chrysostom therefore argues that one should not pay too much attention to the honours and dishonours of the world. The judgements of unbelievers are not trustworthy. We should rather focus on the honour which God will bestow upon us.

Modern scholars who read the New Testament in terms of pivotal values of antiquity should therefore bear in mind that social values function differently in a community of believers. This can clearly be seen when we read Chrysostom's homilies on the Gospel of Matthew. Chrysostom frequently refers to a Christian value system which differed radically from that of the secular world. One may ask why the believers in Chrysostom's church were prepared to adhere to a different value system. The social values of the ancient world can easily provide an answer to this question. We know that honour basically has to do with social perception: what do people think of this person?[17] But Chrysostom says that one should also bear in mind who are the people who are ascribing honour to yourself. Applause from the populace has no worth. To yearn after such honour brings shame and dishonour. We should rather 'seek honour that comes from God alone'. He also says 'If we praise ourselves, God will no more praise us' (*hom.* iii.6).

6. Conclusions

To read an ancient text such as the bible according to its appropriate cultural context is definitely not an optional enterprise. It should be an integral part of our analysis of any ancient text. But this exegetical approach to a text is not as new as some of us might have thought. As a matter of fact, it is clear from the above that social values such as honour and shame played an important role in Chrysostom's exegesis of the Gospel of Matthew. The writings of the ancient theologians can indeed serve as valuable sources for our understanding of the social values of the ancient world.

[17] Neyrey, 5.

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